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1 Samuel 1:1–8

1 Samuel

1 Samuel 1:1–8

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 1:1–8 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:1–8 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The book of 1 Samuel tells the true story of Israel during the time when the Israelites changed from judges leading them to kings leading them. The Bible describes the period of time when judges ruled Israel as a time when the people did not all agree on the right way to live. Instead, "everyone did what was right in his own eyes." The first part of the first book of Samuel tells how Samuel was born and how Yahweh called Samuel to serve Yahweh, to judge Israel, and to appoint Israel's first king. At this time, the ark of God, the symbol of Yahweh's presence with his people, was still in a region of Israel that people called Shiloh.

The storyteller says, "There was a certain man." This is the way the Israelites would often begin a true story about a real person who lived in the past. This man was from Ramathaim, or Ramathaim-Zophim, which shows that Ramathaim, sometimes called Ramah, was in Zuph. Zuph was the region of hills where the Ephraimites lived. Ramathaim means "two heights" or "two hills." Some versions say the man was an "Ephrathite." This could mean the man was descended from the tribe of Ephraim or that he was from the city of Bethlehem. Most versions say the man was descended from the tribe of Ephraim, one of the 12 tribes of Israel. In the book of 1 Chronicles, the Bible lists Elkanah as a descendant of Levi. Since the Levite tribe of Israel did not receive any land, the Levites lived in the lands of other tribes. Elkanah might have lived in the area of the Ephraimites even if he was a Levite.

Stop here and share a story about a real person from your community who lived in the past but is no longer living. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a map of Ramathaim and the region of Zuph. Pause this audio here.

The man is a Zuphite, which means he is from the region of Zuph. Some sources say the name Elkanah means "God has created a son," while others say it means "God bought." Because Elkanah was a real person, the author also gives the names of Elkanah's ancestors, Jeroham, Elihu, and Tohu, going back to Elkanah's clan leader, Zuph. Some of these names are a little different in other parts of the Bible. The people called the area Zuph after their clan leader, Zuph.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your community keep a record of the names of their ancestors? How do you name the different areas of your language group? Pause this audio here.

Elkanah had two wives. When God created the first man and woman, God also created the pattern for marriage to be between one man and one woman. Even though the Israelites knew that marriage should be between one man and one woman, sometimes men would marry more than one woman if the man was wealthy. One of Elkanah's wives was called Hannah, which means "grace" or "favor with God," and the other wife was called

Peninnah, which might mean “Pearl” or “Coral.” Some translations call Peninnah the second wife. Peninnah had children, but Hannah did not. In this part of the world at this time, it was very important for men to have sons, because only sons could inherit the man’s property. It was more common for a man to marry a second wife if the first wife could not have children.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who can marry each other in your community? How many people can be married to each other? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who can inherit a man’s property in your community? Tell a story about a woman who was not able to have children. Pause this audio here.

Now, this man, Elkanah, used to go up every year from his home city, Ramathaim, to Shiloh. [When the author says Elkanah went “up,” it is because Shiloh was on higher ground than Ramathaim]{.mark}. Elkanah went up to Shiloh each year in order to worship Yahweh. When someone worshipped in that time, the person would usually get down on their knees and touch their forehead to the ground to show honor and respect to Yahweh. The person would also offer sacrifices and eat a feast. Elkanah feasted with his whole family, including Elkanah’s wives and children. The Israelites held several feasts each year, but this story does not say which feast Elkanah’s family celebrated at this time. The Israelites kept the tabernacle and the ark of Yahweh in Shiloh at this time in their history. Eli’s sons, Hophni and Phinehas, were acting as priests for Yahweh in Shiloh. Elkanah worshipped “Yahweh Almighty” or “Yahweh of hosts,” which can also mean “Yahweh of Armies.” This title might refer to Yahweh’s great power or to Yahweh’s authority over everything that people can see and also what they cannot see, both on earth and in heaven.

Stop here and share a story about a special feast your community has every year. Pause this audio here.

The author does not say what type of sacrifice Elkanah made to Yahweh. When the Israelites sacrificed a peace offering to Yahweh, Yahweh allowed the Israelites to eat some of the meat. On the day when Elkanah sacrificed to Yahweh, Elkanah would give pieces of the meat to his wife Peninnah and to all her sons and daughters. Elkanah gave Hannah something different. Most translations say Elkanah gave Hannah a double portion. This could mean Elkanah gave Hannah two pieces of meat, or a large, special, or honorable piece of meat. Elkanah did this because he loved Hannah, although Yahweh had closed Hannah’s womb. People probably did not expect Elkanah to give Hannah a double or special portion since Hannah did not have children.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your community show special honor to some people during a feast? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says Elkanah gave Hannah a double portion because Elkanah loved Hannah even though Yahweh had closed Hannah’s womb, or did not allow her to have children. This is the way the Israelites spoke about a woman who was not able to have children. The Israelites believed it was Yahweh who gave the ability to have children or not. If Yahweh gave that ability, the Israelites said Yahweh “opened the womb,” and if he did not, they said Yahweh “closed the womb.” Even though Hannah cannot give Elkanah any heirs, Elkanah shows Hannah how much he loves her by giving Hannah a double or special portion of meat.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why are some women not able to have children? How do women who cannot have children feel about not being able to have children? How do other people treat those women or feel about them? Pause this audio here.

The author says Hannah’s rival, Peninnah, used to provoke or bother Hannah. A rival is someone who is competing with another person for the same thing or competing to be better at some type of activity. Peninnah is competing with Hannah to bear Elkanah’s children, and Peninnah is winning. Peninnah provoked Hannah to “irritate” Hannah or to make her angry or ashamed, because Yahweh had closed Hannah’s womb. Even though everyone believed Yahweh was the one who closed a woman’s womb, women still felt ashamed when they could not have children.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do wives of the same husband get along with each other in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a woman who competes with another woman. Pause this audio here.

Peninnah did not provoke Hannah only one time. Peninnah continued to provoke Hannah every year when they went to Shiloh, up to the house of Yahweh. Each year, when Peninnah would provoke Hannah, Hannah would weep and not eat any food.

Stop here and share a story about someone who teased another person over and over in order to hurt that person and make them feel ashamed. Pause this audio here.

This passage says that Elkanah and his family went to the "house" of Yahweh, but it was probably not a house at this time. The ark of Yahweh was probably in the tabernacle, or tent of meeting, which was a special tent. But people called this tent the "house" of Yahweh.

Stop here and look at a picture of the tabernacle. Pause this audio here.

Elkanah, Hannah's husband, would ask her, "Hannah, why do you weep? And why do you not eat? And why is your heart sad? Am I not more to you than 10 sons?" Elkanah is not really asking questions here. Elkanah knows that Hannah is weeping and not eating because Peninnah is provoking her. Elkanah knows Hannah's heart is sad because Yahweh has not given her any children. For the Israelites, the heart was the most inward part of a person, or the center of the person's thoughts and desires. The question, "Am I not more to you than 10 sons?" probably means, "Am I not more valuable to you than many sons?" Elkanah does not mean 10 as a specific number, but as a large number. Maybe Elkanah thinks he is more valuable than many sons because Elkanah loves Hannah so much, or because Elkanah can do more for Hannah than many sons could do. Elkanah is not asking a question but is trying to comfort Hannah that Elkanah's love for Hannah is more valuable than having many sons.

Stop here and share a story about a family with many children. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: What is the most valuable relationship that a woman can have in your culture? Would it be more valuable for a woman in your community to have a husband who loves her very much or to have many children?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: The person telling the story introduces Elkanah with a list of Elkanah's ancestors and the place where Elkanah lived at the time of this true story.

In the second scene: Elkanah takes his family up to Shiloh to worship Yahweh. Elkanah gives his wife Hannah a special portion of the sacrificed meat because Elkanah loves Hannah even though Yahweh has closed her womb. Elkanah's other wife, Peninnah, taunts, or teases Hannah and tries to make her feel ashamed. Hannah becomes so sad that she cannot even eat. Elkanah tries to comfort Hannah by asking her if Elkanah is not better than many sons.

The characters in this passage are:

- Elkanah
- Jeroham
- Elihu
- Tohu
- Zuph
- Hannah
- Peninnah
- Hophni
- Phinehas
- And Peninnah's children

1 Samuel 1:1–8

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage begins with the words, "There was a certain man," which makes it clear that the story that follows is a true story about a real man who lived in the past. Then we hear a list of Elkanah's ancestors and the place where Elkanah lived. These details also show that Elkanah was a real person. It is important to start this story in whatever way your language uses to tell true stories.

Stop here and share a story about a famous or important person in your history. How do you show that the story is a true story about an important person who lived in the past? Pause this audio here.

Even though Zuph is "in the hill country of Ephraim," other parts of the Bible say Elkanah is descended from the tribe of Levi, not Ephraim. Since Yahweh did not give the descendants of Levi their own land, the Levites lived among other tribes. So it is possible that Elkanah is a Levite who lives in the area of the tribe of Ephraim. However, you should translate this as it is.

When the author introduces Elkanah's wives, most translations say that "one wife" was called Hannah and one was called Peninnah, but some translations say that the "first" wife was called Hannah and the second was called Peninnah. It is not certain that Hannah was Elkanah's first wife, but the author also says that Peninnah had children and Hannah did not. So Elkanah probably married Peninnah when he realized Hannah could not have children. The storyteller does not say how many children Peninnah had, except that she had more than one.

Elkanah used to go up to Shiloh every year. The journey from Ramathaim-Zophim to Shiloh would have been uphill. Elkanah went to Shiloh to worship and sacrifice to Yahweh of hosts. Worship for the Israelites included getting down on their knees and touching their foreheads to the ground to show respect and honor to Yahweh. Yahweh was not only the God of the Israelites. Yahweh is the one true God of everything on earth and in heaven.

Stop here and describe how you would travel to another town that is on higher ground than your town. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you describe a journey that people make every year? Pause this audio here.

The author mentions Eli in this passage, but we do not see Eli act in this story. Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, are the priests who serve Yahweh.

The author does not mention what type of sacrifice Elkanah made to Yahweh, but it was probably a peace offering since Yahweh allowed Elkanah's family to eat a portion of the offering. When a worshiper made a peace offering, Yahweh permitted the priest and the worshiper's family to eat a portion of the meat the worshiper offered. Meat was a special food for the people at this time. The storyteller does not say who Elkanah served first, but it says Elkanah gave portions to Peninnah and each of her children. Now the storyteller clearly shows that Elkanah did something different for Hannah than what he did for Peninnah. Elkanah gave a double or special portion to Hannah because Elkanah loved Hannah even though Yahweh had closed her womb, or did not allow her to have children. This is the way the Israelites spoke about a woman who was not able to have children. The Israelites believed it was Yahweh who gave the ability to have children or not. If Yahweh gave that ability, the Israelites said Yahweh "opened the womb," and if he did not, the Israelites said Yahweh "closed the womb." Even though Hannah cannot give Elkanah any heirs, Elkanah shows Hannah how much he loves her by giving her a double or special portion of meat.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: How will you talk about Yahweh closing Hannah's womb? Pause this audio here.

After the storyteller tells how Elkanah divided the meat among his family, the storyteller says that Hannah's rival used to tease Hannah because she could not have children. The person telling the story no longer uses Peninnah's name, but calls her Hannah's rival. Peninnah did not tease Hannah only one time. Peninnah teased Hannah every year when they went to Shiloh for the feast. Peninnah's teasing made Hannah so sad, and bothered Hannah so much, that Hannah would not eat any food.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you name characters in your true stories? When do you stop saying a character's name in a story and instead use a description of the person? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 1:1–8

Every year, Elkanah tries to comfort Hannah by asking her several questions. Elkanah's questions are not really questions that he expects Hannah to answer. Elkanah is just trying to tell Hannah that he loves her, even though Hannah has not given Elkanah any children. Elkanah thinks his love for Hannah should be a greater comfort to her than having many sons.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of things do people in your community say or do to encourage others and convince those people that the person loves them? How will you translate Elkanah's encouragement to Hannah? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When you tell a true story, how do you talk about something that happens over and over, like the journey Elkanah's family takes each year, the yearly sacrifice, and the yearly trouble between Hannah and Peninnah in this story? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Elkanah
- Jeroham
- Elihu
- Tohu
- Zuph
- Hannah
- Peninnah
- Hophni
- Phinehas
- And Peninnah's children

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The author introduces Samuel's father, Elkanah, by saying, "There was a certain man," and by telling the names of Elkanah's ancestors.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Elkanah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am proud that I come from a long line of important men from an important tribe; or
- I feel confident because I have a long history in this place. People know my family; or
- I feel responsible to keep the good name that I inherited from my ancestors.

Continue the drama.

Elkanah had two wives. People called one wife Hannah and the other wife Peninnah. Peninnah had children, but Hannah did not.

Elkanah used to go up to Shiloh every year to worship Yahweh and to sacrifice to Yahweh. Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, were priests at Shiloh. Since Elkanah made this journey with his family every year, you might want to act it out in a way that shows the journey happening year after year. You could show this by having the children get older each time, or you could add a new child each time.

On the day when Elkanah sacrificed, he would give portions to Peninnah and her sons and daughters. But to Hannah, Elkanah gave a double portion, because Elkanah loved Hannah even though Yahweh had closed her womb.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Elkanah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love Hannah very much, even though Yahweh has closed Hannah's womb; or
- I want to show Hannah that she is special to me, even though Hannah has not given me any sons.

Ask the person playing Peninnah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am jealous that Elkanah gives Hannah a better portion of food than he gives me, even though I have given Elkanah sons and daughters, while Hannah has not; or
- I am embarrassed that Elkanah is showing everyone how much he loves Hannah by giving Hannah a better portion than he gives me.

Continue the drama.

Hannah's rival, Peninnah, used to taunt, or tease her because Yahweh stopped Hannah from having children. Peninnah did this every year when they went up to the house of Yahweh. Hannah was so upset by Peninnah's teasing that Hannah wept and would not eat any food.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Peninnah is right—Yahweh has closed my womb, and I am so sad about it! or
- I am thankful that Elkanah gives me a special portion of food, but it is nothing compared to the gift of having a son. I would rather have children like Peninnah.

Continue the drama.

Elkanah asks Hannah, "Hannah, why do you weep? And why do you not eat? And why is your heart sad? Am I not more to you than 10 sons?"

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Elkanah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not know what else to do to show Hannah how much I love her! Yahweh has not allowed me to give Hannah the thing she wants most; or
- I wish Hannah could see how much I love her and be comforted so she would no longer feel sad about not having sons.

Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Elkanah cannot understand my sadness about not having any sons.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

1 Samuel 1:1–8

The passage describes the man as an "**Ephrathite**." People used this term to describe either a person who was from Bethlehem or someone who descended from Ephraim. In this case, the storyteller probably uses the term to say that Elkanah descended from Ephraim. But in other parts of the Bible, we hear that Elkanah descended from Levi. Even though Elkanah was descended from Levi, Elkanah was living in the land of the tribe of Ephraim, so that is probably why the storyteller uses this term to describe Elkanah as an Ephraimite.

Each year, Elkanah would go up from his city, Ramathaim, to the city of Shiloh to worship Yahweh and sacrifice to Yahweh. Worship means to give Yahweh honor and to be amazed by how powerful, good, and loving Yahweh is. People in the Bible often worshiped Yahweh by bowing down to Yahweh. A sacrifice is a gift to God. There are different kinds of sacrifices, but the one Elkanah gave was a sacrifice of an animal to worship God. It was a sacrifice that Yahweh allowed Elkanah to eat a portion of.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **worship**. Look up worship in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sacrifice**. Look up sacrifice in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Elkanah takes his family to Shiloh every year to worship "Yahweh of hosts." The word hosts could refer to the armies of Israel, angelic beings, or heavenly bodies, such as stars. This title emphasizes that Yahweh is the ruler who has all power. Yahweh is not only the ruler over a certain region, but Yahweh is the ruler of everything on earth and in heaven.

Stop here and review the word or phrase you have used for Yahweh. Look up **Yahweh of hosts** in the Master Glossary for more information. Which word or phrase will you use for "Yahweh of hosts" or Yahweh of heaven's armies? Pause this audio here.

Elkanah and his family went to the "house of Yahweh" to worship. "House of Yahweh" is any place where the Israelites worshipped Yahweh throughout their history, whether the tabernacle or the temple that Solomon later built. In this case, the house of Yahweh refers to the tabernacle, or tent of meeting, where Yahweh met with the Israelites before they built the temple. At this time, the tabernacle, or "house of Yahweh," was located in Shiloh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **house of Yahweh**. Look up "house of God" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hannah's rival, Peninnah, used to "provoke" Hannah. This means that Peninnah caused Hannah to suffer. Some translations say "taunt" or "torment." The storyteller uses this word twice in this passage. Use the same word for provoke in both places. Several translations add a description, such as "provoked her grievously," "bitterly," or "severely." You might want to add a description for the word you choose, too.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **provoke**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Each year, when Peninnah provoked Hannah, Hannah would "weep" and would not eat any food. The word weep is like the word cry, but it shows that the person is feeling a lot of sorrow and grief, like the sorrow and grief of losing a child.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **weep**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 1:1–8

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (647 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 1:9–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 1:9–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:9–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:9–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story is about what happened during one special feast that Elkanah's family celebrated in Shiloh. After the family finished eating and drinking the meal, Hannah stood up. The family had finished their meal, but Hannah did not eat anything.

1 Samuel 1:9–18

Eli the priest was sitting on the seat or chair by the doorpost of Yahweh's temple or house. A chair was a sign of honor in this culture because most people sat on the floor. It is likely that only the priest used this chair. At this time, Yahweh's temple was the tabernacle, a special tent. The doorpost might have been a post at the entrance to the tent, or the Israelites might have built some kind of structure around the tabernacle at Shiloh.

Stop here and look at a picture of the tabernacle as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do you have people sit if you want to honor them? Pause this audio here.

Hannah was deeply distressed. Elkanah had tried to comfort Hannah, but Hannah went to Yahweh for comfort. Hannah prayed and wept bitterly before Yahweh. Hannah vowed, or promised, and said, "O Yahweh of hosts." This is the same title the storyteller used earlier for Yahweh that emphasizes Yahweh's power over everything on earth and in heaven. Hannah says, "If you will look on the affliction of your servant." "Your servant" refers to Hannah. The Israelites would speak about themselves like another person when they wanted to show they were humble. Hannah also shows she is humble before Yahweh by calling herself Yahweh's servant.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture show they are humble when they speak to someone that people honor more than them? Share a story of a time when a humble person asked an important leader for help. Pause this audio here.

Hannah asks Yahweh to "look on her affliction," to remember Hannah and not forget her, and to give Hannah a son. Hannah vows that if Yahweh will give her a son, Hannah will give that son back to Yahweh all the days of her son's life. As proof that Hannah has dedicated Hannah's son to Yahweh, Hannah will make sure no razor ever touches her son's head. This means Hannah will make sure no one ever cuts her son's hair. It is unusual that Hannah offers to give her son to Yahweh. It would be more common for a woman who finally received a son to keep that son close to her. Hannah is being like Abraham in this way, because Abraham was also willing to give up Abraham's son, Isaac, to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you ask someone with power and authority over you to think about your suffering and help you? Pause this audio here.

The vow Hannah makes is similar to one called a Nazirite vow. The author does not say that this is a Nazirite vow, but Hannah's story is similar to the story of Samson's mother. Samson was a Nazirite, and that is why no one was supposed to cut Samson's hair. The Nazarite vow also meant that the person would not eat or drink anything from the grapevine, including wine, and would not go near dead bodies. Hannah only mentions not cutting her son's hair, but it is possible that Hannah used one part of the vow to represent the whole vow. People usually made the Nazarite vow for only a period of time, but Hannah makes this vow for "all the days" of her son's life.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of promises do people in your culture make to God? Share a story about a time someone made a promise to God. Pause this audio here.

Hannah continues praying "before Yahweh," which means that Hannah is praying again and again in Yahweh's presence. Eli is close enough that he can see that Hannah is moving her lips. Hannah prays in her heart and only her lips move. In Israelite culture, the heart is the center of a person's thoughts and desires. So this means Hannah is praying silently or inwardly. The custom at the time was for people to pray aloud. Since Hannah's lips are moving, but she is not making any sound, Eli thinks Hannah is drunk.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you know when someone is drunk? Pause this audio here.

Eli begins the conversation with Hannah because Eli is a man and a priest. Eli asks Hannah, "How long will you go on being drunk?" Eli is not really asking Hannah a question. Eli assumes Hannah is drunk, so this is Eli's way of telling Hannah to stop being drunk. Eli also tells Hannah to put her wine far away from her, which is another way to tell Hannah to stop getting drunk.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture think about wine and strong drink? Pause this audio here.

Hannah answers Eli, "No, my lord." Hannah is showing Eli respect by calling him lord, but Hannah is still challenging what Eli said even though he is a priest with spiritual authority over Hannah. Hannah tells Eli that Hannah is a woman troubled in her spirit. Hannah has not been drinking any wine or other strong drink. Hannah

1 Samuel 1:9–18

says she has been pouring out her soul before Yahweh. In other words, Hannah is telling Yahweh all her sorrows and desires. Hannah is in Yahweh's presence where Hannah knows Yahweh can hear her. Yahweh does not actually need to be near a person to hear that person. Hannah knows this, and this is why Hannah prayed silently, in her heart. But Hannah is emphasizing her closeness to Yahweh as she prays at Yahweh's tent.

Hannah tells Eli not to think of his servant as a worthless woman. Again, Hannah is speaking about herself as if she speaks about another person. Hannah does this to show Eli respect. In this culture, people would have considered a drunk woman to be worthless, harmful, or evil, especially if she was drunk at the tent of Yahweh. But Hannah has not been drunk in Yahweh's presence. Hannah has been begging Yahweh for help because Hannah is so troubled.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If a man or woman in your culture was drunk in front of the community or in a place of worship, how would your leaders respond? Pause this audio here.

When Eli hears Hannah defend herself, Eli responds and says, "Go in peace, and may the God of Israel give you what you have asked him for." In this culture, peace meant more than just not being troubled. Peace meant to have a full life with Yahweh's blessings. Eli says "the God of Israel" while Hannah says "Yahweh of Hosts." Both of these are titles for Yahweh. The God of Israel means Yahweh, the God whom Israel serves and worships. Eli might just be wishing for something that is not certain. Since Eli is a priest, Eli might be doing more than wishing that Yahweh answers Hannah's prayer. Eli might be saying Yahweh will certainly answer Hannah's prayer.

Hannah replies to Eli, "Let your servant find favor in your eyes." Hannah is again showing respect by speaking of herself as Eli's servant. Hannah wants Eli to favor her, or to treat Hannah kindly.

Then the woman, Hannah, went away and ate food and her face was no longer sad. Earlier, Hannah would not eat any food, but now Hannah eats food. Earlier, Hannah was weeping bitterly and appeared drunk because she was so sad, but now Hannah's face does not look sad. Hannah is not feeling better because she ate food. Hannah is feeling better because Eli's blessing makes Hannah confident that Yahweh has listened to Hannah's prayer.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:9–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Elkanah's family finishes eating their sacrificial feast, and Hannah stands up and leaves.

In the second scene: Hannah stands in Yahweh's presence near the entrance to Yahweh's tent. Eli is sitting in his seat close enough to see Hannah move her lips while Hannah prays silently again and again. Hannah is very upset and does not say her words aloud. Eli can only see Hannah move her lips and cannot hear her words, so Eli thinks Hannah is drunk in Yahweh's presence. Eli scolds Hannah and tells her to stop getting drunk.

Hannah replies that she has not been drinking any wine or strong drink. Instead, Hannah is very sad and miserable and has been silently telling Yahweh all her troubles. Eli tells Hannah to go in peace, and may Yahweh give Hannah what she has asked Yahweh for.

In the third scene: Hannah humbly asks Eli to treat her kindly, and Hannah leaves Yahweh's tent and eats food. Hannah's face does not look sad anymore.

The characters in this passage are:

- Elkanah's family
- Hannah
- Eli
- And Yahweh, though no one can see Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

1 Samuel 1:9–18

At the beginning of this story, Hannah gets up at the end of the family meal. People commonly use the phrase "eating and drinking" to refer to having a meal, but this phrase does not mean that Hannah ate. In the previous story, the storyteller says that Hannah would be so upset that Hannah would not eat any food. Hannah has not been eating, but the rest of Elkanah's family, including Peninnah and all her children, did eat the meal. Hannah stands up. That is all the storyteller tells us, but in the next scene, Hannah is in or near Yahweh's tent. So we know that Hannah stood up and left the area where they ate their meal, and Hannah walked over to Yahweh's tent.

At Yahweh's tent, Eli is sitting on the seat beside the doorpost of Yahweh's tent. It is not clear what the doorpost would have been since Yahweh's house was a tent at this time. It is possible that the Israelites built a more solid structure at the entrance of the tent or around the tent.

Eli's seat was special, because most people sat on the ground. The seat showed that Eli had an honored position in his community because Eli was a priest. Hannah is standing and praying silently to Yahweh of hosts. Hannah looks very sad. Hannah moves her lips, but Hannah is not saying any words aloud. Hannah is weeping bitterly as she moves her lips, so she might be making weeping sounds even though she is not saying her words aloud. Hannah is praying over and over again, asking Yahweh to look at Hannah, remember Hannah, and not forget Hannah, but to give Hannah a son. The phrases "look on," "remember," and "not forget" are each different ways of asking God to think about Hannah's sorrow and help her. Hannah makes a vow or promise to Yahweh that if Yahweh will give Hannah a son, Hannah will give her son to Yahweh for all the days of her son's life. Hannah also says she will not let anyone cut her son's hair. Several times in this passage, Hannah talks about herself as "your servant" in order to show humility to Yahweh. Hannah is speaking about herself as if she were speaking about another person.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you beg a deity for help? What kinds of words do you use? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this idea of "your servant" so that your audience knows Hannah is speaking about herself? Pause this audio here.

Eli did not hear any of those words. No one else would have heard Hannah's words either, because Hannah prayed in her heart. It is not clear where Hannah is standing, but Hannah is somewhere near Yahweh's tent. We know this because Eli can see Hannah move her lips from where Eli sits beside the entrance to the tent.

The whole time Hannah is praying, Eli is sitting in his seat nearby and watching Hannah. Eli can see Hannah move her lips, but he cannot hear her words, so Eli thinks Hannah is drunk because he thinks she has drunk too much alcohol. Eli scolds Hannah by asking her how long she will continue to be drunk and by telling Hannah to put away her wine.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe that Eli thought Hannah was drunk. Pause this audio here.

Hannah tells Eli not to think of her or treat her as a "worthless woman." Worthless means to have no worth or value. In this case, a worthless woman could also mean someone who is harmful or evil.

Hannah replies to Eli with proper respect by saying "my lord" or "my master." Hannah is showing Eli respect by calling him lord, but Hannah is still challenging what Eli said, even though Eli is a priest with spiritual authority over her. Hannah tells Eli she has not been drinking wine or any other strong drink. Hannah is not drunk, but is very miserable. Hannah has been praying to Yahweh about all her troubles. Hannah tells Eli not to think of Hannah as a wicked woman. Hannah has not been dishonoring Yahweh. Hannah has been praying to Yahweh out of her grief and sorrow. Hannah uses special language about pouring out her soul. Hannah says she has been pouring out her soul before Yahweh. In other words, Hannah is telling Yahweh all her sorrows and desires. Hannah does not mean that she is actually pouring out her soul, because we cannot see, touch, or pour out a soul. Hannah is using special language to say that Hannah is telling Yahweh all her sorrows and longings. Hannah says she is pouring those sorrows and longings out "before" Yahweh, which means Hannah is in Yahweh's presence, where she knows Yahweh can hear Hannah. Yahweh does not actually need to be near a person to hear that person. Hannah knows this, which is why she prayed silently, in her heart. But Hannah is emphasizing her closeness to Yahweh as she prays at Yahweh's tent.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Think about a time when you shared everything you were thinking and feeling with someone. Now, think about how you talk about the inner part of a person—their thoughts, feelings,

1 Samuel 1:9–18

and plans. How would you describe how Hannah pours out her soul and shares all her thoughts and feelings with Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

When Eli hears what Hannah has really been doing, Eli tells Hannah to "Go in peace." Eli is doing more than just telling Hannah not to feel so sad anymore. Eli is wishing Hannah a full life of Yahweh's blessings. Eli says, "May the God of Israel grant what you have asked of him." Since Eli is a priest, Eli might be doing more than just wishing and hoping Yahweh will give Hannah the son Hannah has asked for. Eli might be telling Hannah that Yahweh will certainly give Hannah the son she has asked Yahweh for.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you bless someone or wish them well when you tell them goodbye? Pause this audio here.

Hannah replies, "May your servant find favor in your eyes." This means Hannah is hoping Eli will be kind to Hannah.

After Hannah's conversation with Eli, Hannah returns to the place where Elkanah's family ate the sacrificial meal. Hannah eats food, and Hannah's face is not sad anymore. This is a big change from the last passage, where Hannah was too sad to eat, and everyone could see by looking at Hannah's face that she was very sad.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you say that someone is not sad anymore? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:9–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Elkanah's family
- Hannah
- Eli
- And Yahweh, though no one can see Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Hannah was deeply distressed. Hannah prayed to Yahweh and wept bitterly. And Hannah vowed to Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so weary of the way Peninnah torments me! or
- The only one who can help me is Yahweh, who has closed my womb; or
- I need Yahweh to have mercy on me. I cannot bear feeling so sad any longer!

1 Samuel 1:9–18

Continue the drama. As Hannah continued praying before Yahweh, Eli watched Hannah move her mouth. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Something is wrong with this woman. This woman's face looks so strange; or
- I see that woman move her mouth, but why do I not hear any words coming out of it? or
- That woman is so wicked to come to Yahweh's tent when she has been drinking too much! That woman is dishonoring Yahweh and his place of worship!

Continue the drama. And Eli said to Hannah, "How long will you go on being drunk? Put your wine away from you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is terrible—the priest thinks I am drunk! or
- I do not want the priest to think I have been dishonoring Yahweh! or
- I hope I can make the priest understand that I have really been honoring Yahweh by praying to Yahweh in my distress.

Continue the drama. Hannah answered Eli, "No, my lord. I am a woman who is deeply troubled. I have not been drinking wine or other strong drink. I was pouring out my soul to Yahweh." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This woman does not sound drunk. This woman is respectful and speaks well; or
- I believe this woman. I have mistaken this woman's deep distress for drunkenness, but I was wrong; or
- This woman is clearly very sad. I do not know what this woman asked Yahweh for, but it must be something very important.

Continue the drama. Then Eli answered, "Go in peace, and may the God of Israel grant you what you have asked of him." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so relieved that the priest believes me! or
- What a wonderful blessing! I feel excited that I can have peace and Yahweh's blessings after all these years of shame and sadness! or
- Eli is the priest, so his words are a great comfort. Surely Yahweh has heard my prayer!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:9–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

After Elkanah's family had finished **eating and drinking**, Hannah stood up. People in the Bible often use the phrase "eat and drink" to refer to having a meal. In this case, Elkanah's family ate the meal, but Hannah did not because Peninnah's teasing made Hannah feel too sad to eat.

Eli sat in the **seat** near the entrance to Yahweh's temple or tent. Only honored people sat in seats. Most people sat on the ground, so this seat shows that Eli, a priest, was honored above other people.

Stop here and look at a picture of the kind of seat a priest would have sat in. Pause this audio here.

Eli was sitting by **Yahweh's temple**, or house. Use the same word for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for more information about Yahweh. In this passage, the storyteller used the words "big house, or palace," for temple. Remember that this is actually the tabernacle, or tent of meeting. You may use a phrase for "Yahweh's house," or "Yahweh's tabernacle."

Stop here and discuss what phrase you will use for **Yahweh's temple**, or house. For more information, see tabernacle or house of God in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Hannah makes a **vow** to Yahweh that Hannah will give her son to Yahweh and that no razor will touch her son's hair. A vow is a solemn promise, a binding oath, that people make to Yahweh, usually in return for Yahweh's favor or blessing. People made different types of vows to Yahweh. A woman was allowed to keep her vow if her

1 Samuel 1:9–18

husband did not forbid her. Hannah's vow is probably a Nazirite vow. When Hannah says, "no razor will touch his hair," Hannah means she will not let anyone cut her son's hair. A Nazirite vow also included not eating or drinking anything that people made from grapes, and not going near a dead body. Hannah only mentions not letting anyone cut her son's hair, but she might have used one part of the Nazirite vow to represent the whole Nazirite vow.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **vow**. Look up vow in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hannah speaks to Yahweh and calls him "O **Yahweh of hosts**." This is a title for Yahweh that emphasizes his great power over everything, both on earth and in heaven. Use the same word or phrase for "Yahweh of hosts" as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information about Yahweh of hosts.

Hannah says, "If you will indeed look on the affliction of your servant and remember me and not forget your servant." By calling herself "your servant," Hannah is being humble before Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word you will use for **servant**. See the Master Glossary for more information about servant, and use the same word that you have used in other parts of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

Hannah was **praying** in her **heart** because Hannah was pouring out her **soul** to Yahweh. The soul is the innermost part of a person's body that continues to live even after a person dies. People referred to the heart as the place where a person's thoughts and desires happen. In this case, it also means that Hannah was praying silently rather than praying aloud. People commonly prayed aloud at this time. For more information, look up soul, pray, and heart in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **praying in her heart** and **pouring out her soul**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Eli took Hannah to be a drunken woman. This means that Eli thought Hannah was **drunk**. A drunk person was someone who had drunk too much of a fermented or strong drink, so that they acted strangely. It was never good to be drunk, but especially not when praying to Yahweh at his tent.

Hannah says she has not had any **wine** or **strong drink**. Wine is a drink that people made by fermenting grapes. In this culture, people made strong drinks by fermenting grains or fruits. Both wine and strong drinks could make a person drunk if they drank too much of them. For more information on wine, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look at a picture of grapes on a grape vine, and discuss how you will translate **wine** or **strong drink**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Eli wishes for Hannah to "go in peace." Eli is doing more than just telling Hannah not to feel so sad anymore. Eli is wishing Hannah a full life of Yahweh's blessings.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word you will use for **peace**. See the Master Glossary for more information about peace, and translate peace in the same way you have in previous books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

Since Eli is a priest, Eli might be doing more than just wishing that **the God of Israel** will give Hannah what she asked God for. Eli might be saying that the God of Israel will certainly give Hannah what she asked for. "The God of Israel" is a title for Yahweh that means the God whom Israel serves and worships. Use the same term for "the God of Israel" each time you use it. For more information, look up God and Israel in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 1:9–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (723 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

1 Samuel 1:19–28

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 1:19–28 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:19–28 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:19–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Early the next morning, after Hannah asked Yahweh for a son and Eli blessed Hannah, Elkanah's family got up from their beds and worshiped Yahweh by bowing low before Yahweh. Then, after Elkanah's family worshiped before Yahweh, the family went back from Shiloh to their home in Ramah.

1 Samuel 1:19–28

Stop here and look at a map of Shiloh and Ramah as a group. Pause this audio here.

Then Elkanah knew, or had sexual relations with, Hannah, Elkanah's wife. And Yahweh remembered Hannah and treated her kindly. Yahweh kept his promise to Hannah just like Eli said Yahweh would.

Stop here and share a story about a time when God or a powerful person kept his promise. Pause this audio here.

After Elkanah's family returned from Shiloh, and before they took their yearly journey again, Hannah gave birth to a son. Hannah named her son Samuel because Hannah asked Yahweh for this son.

A year passed, and then Elkanah went up with his family to offer the yearly sacrifice to Yahweh and keep his vow. When Yahweh gave the Israelites his law, Yahweh said that a husband could decide whether or not his wife kept a vow she made to Yahweh. Elkanah allowed Hannah to keep her vow to Yahweh. It might be her vow Elkahah is keeping here, or it might be another vow that Elkanah made himself.

But Hannah did not go up to Shiloh this time as she usually did. Hannah told Elkanah that she would wait to take Samuel to Shiloh after she had weaned Samuel. Then Hannah would take Samuel to the tabernacle in Shiloh and present him to Yahweh. And Samuel would live at the tabernacle for the rest of his life until he died. At this time, an Israelite mother would usually wean her baby after three years.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When does a mother wean her child in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and share a story about a time when someone in your culture dedicated their child to God. Why did that person dedicate their child? What did it mean for the child when the parent dedicated the child? Pause this audio here.

Elkanah, Hannah's husband, replies to Hannah, "Do what seems best to you." Elkanah's main concern is that Yahweh will confirm Yahweh's word. Elkanah gives Hannah permission to wait, but Elkanah wants Hannah to keep her vow to Yahweh just as Yahweh has kept his word to remember Hannah and give her a son.

After Hannah weans her son, Hannah takes Samuel up to Yahweh's tabernacle in Shiloh with her, even though Samuel is still a young boy. Elkanah goes with Hannah, though the storyteller does not mention Elkanah here. Hannah and Elkanah bring items for a sacrifice with them, too. This sacrifice was typical for someone who was keeping a vow or promise to Yahweh.

Hannah and Elkanah bring a three-year-old bull, an ephah of flour, and a skin of wine. An ephah was a special basket that people used for measuring grain and other items. An ephah could usually hold up to about 13 kilograms. In this culture and time, people usually stored wine in bags that people made from animal skins, but sometimes people stored wine in jars that people made from clay. The most important thing the Israelites would have noticed about the flour and wine offerings Hannah and Elkanah brought is that they were very large amounts. The words for "three-year-old bull" could also mean "three bulls." People would not typically bring three bulls, but the amount of flour and wine is three times as much as people usually brought, so it is possible that Hannah and Elkanah also brought three bulls. However, most translations say a "three-year-old bull."

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a bull, an ephah of flour, and a skin of wine. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: What do you use to measure grains? How do you store water or other liquids that you drink? Pause this audio here.

The size of the offerings shows that Elkanah is wealthy. Since Samuel might be as young as three years old, Hannah and Elkanah might have given an extra-large offering because the priests would be caring for Samuel for a long time. Or maybe the offering was so large because this is a very special dedication. Yahweh had closed Hannah's womb for many years before giving her this son. Also, this is Elkanah's first son with his wife, Hannah, whom Elkanah loves very much.

After Hannah and Elkanah bring the offerings to the tabernacle in Shiloh, they slaughter the bull, and they bring the boy to Eli. Hannah greets Eli as her lord, or master, to show him honor. And Hannah says to Eli, "As surely as you live, my lord." Hannah calls Eli "my lord" again to show him respect. The phrase "as surely as you live" was a common oath. Hannah reminds Eli that she is the woman who stood beside him and prayed to Yahweh. Hannah uses an oath to emphasize that she is the same woman, even though that might surprise Eli.

1 Samuel 1:19–28

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When someone in your community says something that other people find hard to believe, how does that person emphasize that they are telling the truth? Pause this audio here.

Hannah makes this offering and brings her child to Eli because Yahweh answered Hannah's prayer. Hannah tells Eli she has lent Samuel to Yahweh. Hannah is giving Samuel to God forever. Samuel belongs to Yahweh for Samuel's whole life. Then Elkanah worshiped Yahweh.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:19–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: The very next morning, Elkanah, Peninnah and their children, and Hannah get out of bed and go to worship Yahweh at his tabernacle in Shiloh. Then the family travels back to their home in Ramah.

In the second scene: Elkanah knows his wife Hannah, and Hannah gives birth to a son. Hannah names this son Samuel because Hannah asked Yahweh for this son.

In the third scene: A year after Hannah prayed to Yahweh for a son, Elkanah and his family prepare to go to Shiloh again to offer sacrifices and to keep Elkanah's vow. Hannah tells Elkanah she wants to wait to go to Shiloh with him until after Hannah has weaned Samuel. Elkanah gives Hannah permission to stay and wait until she has weaned Samuel. Elkanah's main concern is that Yahweh's will is done.

In the fourth scene: Hannah, Samuel, and Elkanah travel to Shiloh with a three-year-old bull, an ephah of flour, and a skin of wine as offerings for keeping their vow. After Hannah and Elkanah slaughter the bull, they bring Samuel to Eli. Hannah reminds Eli that she is the same woman who had stood near Eli and prayed to Yahweh several years before this. Hannah explains that Samuel is the child she asked Yahweh for, so Hannah is giving Samuel to Yahweh to live at the tabernacle for the rest of his life until Samuel dies. Then Elkanah worships Yahweh there.

The characters in this passage are:

- Elkanah
- Hannah
- Peninnah
- Peninnah's children
- Samuel
- And Eli

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage begins where the last passage ended. In the last passage, Hannah asked Yahweh for a son, and then Hannah went back to where Elkanah and the rest of the family had eaten their feast together. This passage begins the next morning after Elkanah's whole family slept through the night. The whole family includes Peninnah and her children. All of the people in Elkanah's family get up from their beds and go to the tabernacle to worship Yahweh. The family members probably bowed low with their foreheads to the ground to worship Yahweh. Then the family traveled back to their home in Ramah.

The next part of the story takes place at the family's home in Ramah. The next action happens in private, so you will want to find a way to show what happened without acting it out. Elkanah knew Hannah, his wife, and Yahweh remembered Hannah. Some translations say Elkanah "lay with" Hannah or "slept with" Hannah. These are all different ways of politely saying that Elkanah had sexual intercourse with Hannah. This phrase was a way people could speak publicly about the private act between a husband and wife. The word "remembered" means that Yahweh treated Hannah kindly and kept his promise to Hannah. This probably means that when Eli said, "May the God of Israel grant you what you have prayed for," Eli was speaking Yahweh's promise to Hannah that Yahweh would give Hannah the son she asked for. You will want to think of a way for your audience to

understand what happened without having the actors perform that part or without making your objects do the action.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your community speak politely about the private act that a husband and wife do together in order to make a child? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember the story you told in the last step about God or a person keeping a promise. How did you talk about God remembering what God had said and keeping his promise? Pause this audio here.

After that, Hannah conceived and gave birth to a son. The phrase "conceived and gave birth" is the way the Israelites spoke about a woman having a baby. This might also be something you choose not to act out or show with objects in front of the audience. After giving birth, Hannah explains that she named her son Samuel because she asked Yahweh for this son. The passage does not say who Hannah was speaking to when she said this, but perhaps Hannah was speaking to her family.

Stop here and share a story about a woman having a baby. Pay attention to the words you use to say that she had a baby. Pause this audio here.

The name Samuel has several possible meanings: "Name of Yahweh," "Offspring or child of Yahweh," or "Yahweh heard." Samuel was Elkanah's child, not Yahweh's child. So if Samuel's name means "child of Yahweh," it is because Hannah knows Yahweh gave her Samuel, not because Samuel is literally the child of Yahweh. In Hebrew, the name Samuel sounds like the Hebrew word for "to ask." The name Samuel also sounds similar to Saul, whose story the storyteller will tell later in the book of 1 Samuel. Samuel and Saul may sound alike, but they are very different men.

The scene switches to show Elkanah, Peninnah, and their children preparing for their yearly journey to Shiloh again. But Hannah does not go up to Shiloh with the family this time. Hannah tells Elkanah she wants to wait to bring Samuel up to Shiloh after Hannah has weaned Samuel. Then Hannah will bring Samuel to Yahweh's tabernacle in Shiloh, and Samuel will live there for the rest of his life.

Elkanah gives Hannah permission to stay and wait until she has weaned Samuel. Elkanah says, "Only may Yahweh keep his word." Elkanah shows that his main concern is that Yahweh keep his word, or promise. It is not clear if Elkanah is talking about Yahweh keeping his promise or Hannah keeping her promise, so some translations say, "May Yahweh confirm your promise," meaning Hannah's word or vow to Yahweh. People who translate the passage this way think Elkanah is talking about Hannah's promise since Yahweh has already kept his promise. Although the story does not tell this next part, you might want to show Elkanah and the rest of the family leaving while Hannah stays home, and then show the family returning again later. At this point in the story, Samuel is a baby.

Then the storyteller comes back to Hannah after some time has passed. The storyteller says, "After Hannah weaned the boy," so it has probably been about three years since Elkanah went to Shiloh without Hannah. Now, Samuel is a young child. Hannah, Elkanah, and Samuel travel from Ramah up to Shiloh with a three-year-old bull, an ephah of flour, and a skin of wine. An ephah of flour may have been around 13 kilograms. These are the typical sacrifices an Israelite would make to Yahweh when he or she was keeping a vow to Yahweh. Elkanah and Hannah brought much more of each item than people usually brought for such a sacrifice. This shows that Elkanah is wealthy and also that this vow is very special to Elkanah and Hannah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you speak about the time when a mother stops nursing her child or stops giving the child milk from her breasts? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says, "They slaughtered the bull," but it is not really clear who sacrificed the bull. This might refer to Elkanah and Hannah or to the priests. Then Elkanah and Hannah bring Samuel to Eli. Hannah reminds Eli that she is the same woman who stood near him and prayed to Yahweh several years ago. Hannah uses an oath to show that she is telling the truth, even though it might surprise Eli to hear that she is the same woman.

Hannah tells Eli, "I prayed for this child, and Yahweh has given me what I asked of him." Hannah's words are almost the exact same words Eli used when he blessed Hannah several years before. Eli had said to Hannah,

1 Samuel 1:19–28

"May Yahweh give what you have asked of him," so Hannah is emphasizing that her son, this child, is Yahweh's answer to the prayer Hannah prayed that day several years ago.

"So now" shows that Hannah is making this offering and lending her child to Eli because Yahweh answered Hannah's prayer. The word "lent" usually means to give something for just a time and then receive it back, but here Hannah is not expecting to receive Samuel back. Samuel will belong to Yahweh for the rest of Samuel's life until he dies. Most translations then say, "and he worshiped Yahweh there." But it seems likely that Elkanah, Hannah, and Samuel all worshiped there with Eli at this time, so some translations say, "they worshiped Yahweh there." Again, they probably bowed very low with their foreheads to the ground to worship Yahweh.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:19–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Elkanah
- Hannah
- Peninnah
- Peninnah's children
- Samuel
- And Eli

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Early the next morning, Elkanah's whole family got up from their beds and went to Yahweh's tabernacle to bow low and worship Yahweh. Then the family went back to their home at Ramah.

Elkanah slept with Hannah, and Yahweh remembered Hannah. And in due time, Hannah gave birth to a son. Hannah named her son Samuel because she said, "I asked Yahweh for him." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I can hardly believe my great joy! Yahweh answered my prayer for a son! or
- My many years of deep sadness have ended! Yahweh listened to my prayer and gave me the son I asked for! or
- Yahweh has removed my shame. Finally, I have given Elkanah a son, and Peninnah cannot tease me.

Continue the drama. When it was time for Elkanah to take his family to Shiloh again for their yearly sacrifice to Yahweh, Hannah told Elkanah she wanted to wait to go to Shiloh until after she had weaned Samuel. Then Hannah would take Samuel and present him to Yahweh, and Samuel would live at Yahweh's tabernacle for Samuel's whole life.

1 Samuel 1:19–28

"Do what seems best to you," Elkanah, Hannah's husband, told her. "Stay here until you have weaned him; only may Yahweh confirm his word." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Elkanah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Hannah's request makes sense because it would be hard to leave a nursing baby at the tabernacle; or
- I agree with Hannah, but I want to be sure we keep our vow, because Yahweh kept his promise to give Hannah a son; or
- The most important thing to me is that we give Samuel to Yahweh.

Continue the drama. So Hannah stayed home and nursed Samuel until she had weaned Samuel. After Hannah had weaned him, Hannah took young Samuel, along with a sacrifice, to Yahweh's tabernacle in Shiloh. Hannah and Elkanah brought a three-year-old bull, an ephah of flour, and a skin of wine for their sacrifice. After they sacrificed the bull, Hannah and Elkanah brought Samuel to Eli. Hannah said, "As surely as you live, my lord, I am the woman who stood here beside you praying to Yahweh. For this child I prayed, and Yahweh has given me what I asked him for." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Eli must be so amazed to see me here with a child this time! or
- The last time I was here, I was so sad, but now I am so happy to be here with the child Yahweh gave me! or
- Yahweh has been so good to me! This child is proof that Yahweh remembered me.

Continue the drama. As she had promised, Hannah gave Samuel to Yahweh for the rest of Samuel's life. And Hannah, Elkanah, Samuel, and Eli worshiped Yahweh together at Yahweh's tabernacle.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 1:19–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Elkanah and his household got up early the next morning and **worshiped** Yahweh. You may say that Elkanah and his household bowed down to Yahweh, which was a way of worshipping him, or you may use a word for worship that you have used previously. See the Master Glossary for more information about worship.

"And **Yahweh** remembered her." When the Israelites spoke of Yahweh remembering someone, people usually meant that Yahweh did something to help that person. This was especially true when the person had struggled for a long period of time, as Hannah had struggled for a long time with not having any children. Use the same word for Yahweh that you used in previous passages. Yahweh is in the Master Glossary.

Elkanah "went up with his house" or household to Yahweh's **tabernacle**, or **house**, in Shiloh. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh's house or tabernacle as you have used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on house of God or tabernacle. The term "house" or "household" referred to a man's family, because it referred to everyone who lived in that man's house. A household could include more family than just a man's wife and children. A man might also have his parents or his son's families and others living in his house as well.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **household**. Look up household in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Elkanah went to offer up his yearly **sacrifice** to Yahweh and "to keep his **vow**." A vow is a promise to God. If a married Israelite woman made a vow, her husband could let her keep the vow or not. Use the same words for sacrifice and vow as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up sacrifice and vow in the Master Glossary.

When Hannah and Elkanah brought Samuel to Yahweh's tabernacle in Shiloh, they brought an offering of "a three-year-old bull, an **ephah** of flour, and a skin of **wine**." This was the typical offering for someone who was keeping a vow to Yahweh, except that Hannah and Elkanah brought a very large amount of each item. For more information, look up wine and ephah in the Master Glossary.

1 Samuel 1:19–28

Stop here and look at a picture of a bull, an ephah of flour, and a skin of wine as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **ephah** and **skin of wine**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hannah also calls Eli "**my lord**," which was how people showed respect when speaking to someone they honored. Use the same word or phrase for "my lord" as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up the word lord in the Master Glossary.

Hannah tells Eli that she is the woman who was **praying** for a child years ago. When Hannah prayed, she talked with Yahweh. Use the same word for praying as you did in previous passages. For more information about pray, refer to the Master Glossary.

Hannah tells Eli she has "lent" her son to Yahweh. The word "lent" usually means to give something for only a period of time, expecting to receive it back later. In this case, Hannah is not lending Samuel for only a period of time. Hannah says, "for as long as he lives." Hannah is giving Samuel to Yahweh for the rest of Samuel's life until he dies. Some translations say "I give" or "I am dedicating" to show that Hannah does not expect to ever have Samuel back again.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use to say that Hannah **lent** her son to Yahweh. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 1:19–28

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (790 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.1 MB)

- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 Samuel 2:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 2:1–11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:1–11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

NOTE: This passage is a song, which is Hebrew poetry. We recommend that your team complete the "Introduction to Poetry Module 1" before continuing with "Step 2: Setting the Stage." Stop here, if needed, and review the translation decisions your team has made regarding the translation of poetry. Pause this audio here.

Hannah and Elkanah have just brought young Samuel to Eli. Elkanah and Hannah worshipped Yahweh in the tabernacle, and then Hannah prayed to Yahweh. People often call this prayer "Hannah's Song" because Hannah uses beautiful, poetic language. This prayer is similar to songs the Israelites used to sing when they celebrated their victory over their enemies. Israelites often made prayers to give thanks after God heard their prayers and helped them. Hannah thanks Yahweh for more than the birth of Hannah's son. Hannah also thanks Yahweh for the way he changes people's circumstances with Yahweh's mighty power. Later, in the New Testament, Jesus's mother Mary sings a similar song-prayer after the angel Gabriel tells Mary she will have a son.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when someone wrote a song to celebrate something very good that happened to them or to your community. Whom did the songwriter address the song to? How is a celebration song different than other songs? Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: What do prayers sound like in your language? Pause this audio here.

Hannah prays and says that her heart rejoices in Yahweh. In the Bible, the heart is the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. Hannah says her horn is lifted up to Yahweh. People used horns to symbolize power, strength, and pride. Yahweh has lifted Hannah from the shame of being barren to the dignity of having a son, and Hannah praises Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some things that your culture uses as symbols of strength and power? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a horn. Pause this audio here.

Hannah says her mouth boasts, or speaks boldly, over her enemies, because Hannah rejoices that Yahweh rescued her. Then Hannah emphasizes that Yahweh is completely different than anyone else. Three times, in three different ways, Hannah says there is no one like Yahweh. There is no one who is holy like Yahweh. There is no one who is beside Yahweh, or equal to him. And there is no one who is a rock like the Israelites' God. The Israelites often compared God to a rock. The Israelites meant that Yahweh is a strong protector.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some things that people in your culture compare to God? What are symbols of protection in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Next, Hannah speaks to the rest of her community about how they should behave toward their unique and holy God. The community should not talk proudly or let arrogant words come from their mouths, because Yahweh judges people's actions.

Hannah moves from talking about the Israelites' actions to talking about Yahweh's actions. Hannah gives seven examples to show that Yahweh changes human circumstances. Yahweh can change people's lives in a way that no one understands. Hannah does not say who is doing the action, but Hannah is speaking about Yahweh, and everyone listening knows that. In Hannah's first example, Yahweh breaks the bows of strong men. People often used bows and arrows as weapons in Israel at this time. Yahweh can make strong men weak. Yahweh can cause the weapons that men depend on to fail. On the other hand, Yahweh arms weak men with strength. Even when these men have no weapons to depend on, Yahweh can cause weak men to defeat their enemies.

Stop here and tell a story of a time when God changed human circumstances, either by making a strong person weak or a weak person strong when no one expected it to happen. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of bows and arrows. Pause this audio here.

In her second example, Hannah says that people who used to have plenty of food are now hungry. These people are asking other people to hire them to do work so the hungry people can get enough bread. Bread was a very important food for the Israelites, so they often used bread as a symbol of food in general. But those who were hungry are no longer hungry.

The barren woman who could not have children has given birth to seven children, but the woman who already had many children is childless. Being hungry is similar to being barren, and being full is similar to having children. For the Israelites, the number seven was a symbol of the perfect amount. Yahweh causes the barren woman to have an ideal family, and Yahweh causes the woman who already had children to have no children. This is the situation that most closely matches what Yahweh has done for Hannah, but Hannah is praising Yahweh for more than what he has done for her. Hannah is praising Yahweh for the way he reverses situations for many of his people.

In the next part of her song-prayer, Hannah talks about Yahweh's character. Yahweh kills and brings to life. Yahweh brings people to Sheol, and Yahweh raises people up. Yahweh does not kill people the same way men kill other men, but Yahweh has all power, so Yahweh is the one who causes people to die and who causes people to live. The Israelites considered Sheol as the dark place beneath the earth where both good and evil people from all nations went when they died. The Israelites also considered Sheol the place where Yahweh judged people for the actions people did during their lives. Yahweh has total power over both life and death.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call the place where people go after they die? What is that place like? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says two similar things in the same way again: Yahweh changes people who are poor or low to people who are rich or high. Again, Yahweh is the one who reverses people's fortunes.

Hannah talks again about how Yahweh can reverse people's fortunes. Hannah says Yahweh raises the poor up from the dust and lifts the needy from the ash heap. Poor and needy are the same thing, because those who are poor have many needs. The dust and the ash heap are both low and dirty places. Because Yahweh chooses who is rich and who is poor, Yahweh can also change who is rich and who is poor. Yahweh makes the poor sit with princes and inherit places of honor. Yahweh owns the whole earth, and Yahweh sets the world in order. Yahweh can also change that order whenever Yahweh wants to, so that those who are poor and needy become rich and honored.

Stop here and share a story about a time when a very poor person became the respected friend of an important leader. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh will guard the lives of those who are faithful to him, but Yahweh will cut off the wicked in darkness. No one will succeed because of their own strength. Yahweh is not only the God of Israel. Yahweh is God of the whole world. Yahweh has power over those who are faithful to him and those who are Yahweh's enemies. The people around Israel worshipped false gods. Those people thought their gods only had power over certain people,

places, or things, such as a god of only one people group, a god of rain, or a god of a certain hill. The Israelites knew that their God was the one true God who ruled over all people, places, and things.

Yahweh will completely destroy his enemies. Yahweh will judge everyone on earth. Yahweh will make his king, his anointed one, strong. Israel did not yet have a king when Hannah prayed these words. Hannah's prayer looks forward to King David and David's descendants, which includes Jesus. In the Old Testament, when God set someone aside for a special job like being king, God would instruct someone else to anoint that person, or pour oil over that person's head, as a symbol of the Holy Spirit of God. To anoint that person showed that the person had special authority from God to do their job.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture set someone aside to do special work for God? Pause this audio here.

After Hannah's song-prayer, Elkanah and Hannah went home to Ramah, and the boy, Samuel, stayed in Shiloh and served Yahweh under the authority of Eli the priest.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Hannah praises Yahweh for saving Hannah and causing her to boast over her enemies.

In the second scene: Hannah tells the Israelites to be humble because Yahweh knows everything the Israelites do and because Yahweh will judge the Israelites.

In the third scene: Hannah gives examples of how Yahweh reverses people's fortunes as he chooses.

In the fourth scene: Hannah says Yahweh will guard those who are faithful to Yahweh, but Yahweh will destroy his enemies. Yahweh will make his anointed one, the king of Israel, strong.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hannah
- Yahweh
- Elkanah
- Eli
- Samuel
- The Israelites
- Strong people who are full, rich, powerful, and have children
- Weak people who are hungry, poor, powerless, and barren
- Faithful people
- God's enemies
- And God's anointed one, the king

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Stop here and review as a group: We recommend that your team complete the "Introduction to Poetry Modules 2 & 3" before continuing with "Step 3: Defining the Scenes." If your team has completed the introduction to poetry, remind one another of the special ways that poets use language. What are the most common ways that poets use language in Hebrew poems? Pause this audio here.

In this story, Hannah prays immediately after she brings young Samuel to serve Eli at the tabernacle in Shiloh. People often call Hannah's prayer a song because it has rhythm and beautiful language like a song. It is possible that Hannah prayed this prayer at the tabernacle in Shiloh, but Hannah might have prayed it after she went home. Hannah's prayer is similar to other hymns in which people thank Yahweh because Hannah emphasizes that Yahweh has the right to rule over all the earth. Hannah uses a common feature of Hebrew poems where

people say the same thing in two or three similar ways. Hannah also repeats important words, one after the other. It is possible that Hannah did not create this prayer herself but was reciting a prayer that the people of Israel all knew. The Israelites used to sing songs like this when they defeated their enemies in battle. Songs like this have a rhythm that is like a drumbeat or a clap-clap-clap sound.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do your victory songs sound? Pause this audio here.

Hannah prays out loud. Hannah focuses on several important truths about Yahweh. Yahweh is holy, so Yahweh has the right to rule all of creation. Yahweh reverses human fortunes, bringing high people low and low people high. Hannah ends by talking about the king, even though Israel does not yet have a king. Hannah begins by speaking about herself, but quickly switches to speaking about people in general. Sometimes Hannah speaks directly to Yahweh in her prayer. Other times, Hannah speaks about Yahweh to the people who hear Hannah's prayer.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how would you switch from talking to Yahweh and then talking to people in the middle of your prayers? Pause this audio here.

Sometimes in Hebrew poetry, people use one part of something to represent the whole thing. Hannah's heart, horn, and mouth represent Hannah. These things include everything Hannah thinks, does, and says. In the Bible, people use the heart as special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. Horns were symbols of power and strength. Hannah does not literally lift up a horn with her hands. Hannah is saying Yahweh has changed Hannah from being sad to rejoicing, and from being weak to being strong. Yahweh could do that because Yahweh has power over everything.

Stop here and look at a picture of a horn. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, in which part of the body do people think, feel, and make decisions? Pause this audio here.

Because Yahweh has saved Hannah, Hannah boasts over her enemies. Hannah's mouth does not speak by itself. Hannah uses her mouth to boast. When the Israelites talked about boasting over their enemies, they said their mouths were open wide over their enemies. Hannah was not boasting about herself. Hannah was boasting about what Yahweh did to help her.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember when you learned about poetry and you discussed whether you wanted to follow the Hebrew pattern for poetry or your culture's pattern for poetry. If you want to follow the Hebrew pattern, you will want to find two or three similar ways to say that Hannah rejoiced because of what Yahweh had done and that Hannah praised Yahweh. If you want to follow your culture's pattern for poetry, how will you translate these lines? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and share a story about someone who was very strong. How do you speak about that person's strength? What symbols do you have for being strong? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and share a story about a time when your language group had a victory over your enemies. Pay attention to the words you use. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, will it be okay to speak about a heart rejoicing or a mouth boasting? Since these parts represent Hannah as a whole person, you could also choose to say that Hannah rejoices in Yahweh and Hannah boasts over her enemies. Pause this audio here.

Hannah emphasizes how different Yahweh is when she says three times that there is no one like Yahweh: no one is holy like Yahweh, no one is beside Yahweh or equal to Yahweh, and no one is a rock like Yahweh, Israel's God. Yahweh is holy, unique, and mighty.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Hebrew poetry repeated an important idea three times in order to emphasize it. How do you emphasize an important idea in your language? Pause this audio here.

Hannah speaks about the rest of the community using parallelism. Parallelism means Hannah says the same thing in two or three similar ways. The people should not talk proudly or let arrogance come from their mouths because Yahweh knows everything, and Yahweh weighs people's actions. "Talk" and "mouth" are similar to each other, and "proudly" and "arrogance" are similar to each other. The Israelites often said that Yahweh weighed

1 Samuel 2:1–11

people's actions on a scale as a way to talk about Yahweh judging whether the things that someone did were good or bad.

Stop here and look at a picture of a scale. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you speak about God judging whether something that a person did was right or wrong? Pause this audio here.

Hannah goes on to talk about seven ways that Yahweh changes people's fortunes. Hannah compares strong and weak people, full and hungry people, barren and fertile women, dead and living people, sick and well people, poor and rich people, and humble and honored people.

Hannah uses special language to say that Yahweh makes strong men weak. Bows were weapons of war, and strong men relied on bows. Yahweh causes the weapons that strong men rely on to be useless to those men. On the other hand, Yahweh makes weak men strong. Yahweh puts strength on weak men like a piece of clothing for the men to wear.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some weapons that men in your culture rely upon in battle or when hunting? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh causes people who had stomachs full of food to become so hungry that they offer to work for other people so they can buy a piece of bread. On the other hand, Yahweh gives people who were hungry plenty to eat.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you know that someone is extremely hungry? What would that person do? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh causes the barren women who could not have children to have seven children. The Israelites considered seven the perfect number, so Yahweh gives the barren woman the ideal family. On the other hand, Yahweh causes the woman who had many children to lose all of her children and to be lonely and sad. The poet is using different ideas to show the same meaning. To be hungry is similar to being barren, and to be full is similar to having children.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you describe a woman who has the perfect number of children? Pause this audio here.

When Hannah says Yahweh kills, Hannah does not mean that Yahweh kills the way men kill other men. Yahweh does not have a body. But Yahweh has control over all of creation, so Yahweh is the one who causes people to die. Yahweh is also the one who causes people to live. This might be talking about Yahweh causing some sick people to die of their sickness while Yahweh heals other people so that those people keep living. Hannah says the same thing in a second way: Yahweh brings people down to Sheol, the place where dead people go, and Yahweh raises people to life.

Hannah says Yahweh makes people poor. Yahweh also makes people rich. Hannah focuses on how Yahweh changes people's circumstances. Yahweh can make people who used to be rich poor and people who used to be poor rich. Yahweh brings people low and humbles those people, and Yahweh lifts people up and honors those people. These are opposite things, and it is Yahweh who does both.

Yahweh raises the poor and needy from the dust and the ash heap. The ash heap was a place where people put garbage or manure. Both the dust and the ash heap represent miserable conditions. "To sit with princes" and "inherit a seat of honor" are special language for Yahweh taking poor people who sat in the dust and giving those people honorable and important positions in the community. A seat of honor was like a throne. A seat of honor was a special seat that people saved for people of high honor or authority, and these seats placed people higher than the other people who sat around them. The Israelites and other people who lived during this time believed that the Earth was flat and that pillars supported the Earth. Hannah says Yahweh is the one who owns the pillars that support the world, and Yahweh is the one who set the world on the pillars. Yahweh makes the world stable.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are the most miserable places in your community? What do you call the places where you put your garbage or pile up the manure of your animals? Where do the poorest people of your community sit? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a seat of honor together. How will you talk about a throne, or a seat of honor? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is your culture's traditional belief about what keeps the world stable? Do you want to use traditional special language in this part of Hannah's song-poem, or do you want to change this part to speak about what we understand about the Earth now? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of pillars as a group. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh always guards the feet of his faithful ones, but Yahweh makes wicked people silent in death. Feet here represent the whole bodies of Yahweh's faithful people. The Israelites often used one part of something to represent the whole thing. Yahweh's faithful people are those who obey Yahweh. The wicked are the evil people who disobey Yahweh. Hannah is using the picture of warriors whose feet were slipping, but Yahweh causes these people to walk securely so their enemies cannot defeat them. Yahweh makes Yahweh's enemies silent in death. Yahweh does these things to show that people cannot win victories using their own strength.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: How do you speak about causing someone else to be silent because you have overpowered that person? Pause this audio here.

Hannah makes several statements about what Yahweh will do, but these statements are also Hannah's prayer to Yahweh, asking him to do these things. Hannah uses special language to talk about Yahweh defeating Yahweh's enemies. Yahweh will break Yahweh's enemies to pieces, shatter them, and thunder against them from heaven. For the Israelites, thunder was a symbol of God's powerful judgment. One title the Israelites had for God was "The Most High," because God has the most power and authority, and God dwells in the highest place in heaven. The "ends of the Earth" was a way of speaking about every part of the Earth. Yahweh will judge all the people in the whole world. Yahweh will set apart a man to be the people's king, and Yahweh will make that man strong.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you speak about all the people in the whole world? Pause this audio here.

After Hannah finishes her song-prayer, Hannah and Elkanah go home to Ramah, but Samuel stays in Shiloh and serves Yahweh by helping Eli the priest.

When Hannah talks about Yahweh reversing people's fortunes, Hannah uses several different examples of people: weak people, strong people, poor people, rich people, barren women, women with many children, faithful people, and wicked people. You might want to choose one person who represents all strong people and another person who represents all weak people, and then do this same thing for each type of person Hannah talks about. You will probably want to have some children as well, so you can show that Yahweh gives children to the barren woman and takes children away from the woman who already had children.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hannah
- Yahweh
- Elkanah
- Eli
- Samuel
- The Israelites
- Strong people who are full, rich, powerful, and have children
- Weak people who are hungry, poor, powerless, and barren

1 Samuel 2:1–11

- Faithful people
- God's enemies
- And God's anointed one, the king

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Hannah prayed and said, "My heart rejoices in Yahweh! Yahweh has made me strong. My mouth speaks boldly over my enemies. I rejoice because you rescued me." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy! Yahweh has been so good to me! or
- Peninnah used to speak boldly against me, but Yahweh has changed my fortune, and now I speak boldly against Peninnah; or
- Yahweh took away my shame by giving me the son I asked for!

Continue the drama. "No one is holy like Yahweh! There is no one equal to Yahweh! No one is a rock like our God!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Our God is the only true God; or
- God is perfect in a way that no one else is; or
- No one protects us the way God protects us.

Continue the drama. "Stop acting so proud and haughty! Do not speak arrogant words, because Yahweh knows everything and Yahweh judges everything people do." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Hannah is right! We must be humble before God; or
- It is scary to remember that God knows everything I think, say, and do! or
- God will judge me for my sin someday. I must humble myself before God so that God will have mercy on me.

Continue the drama. "Yahweh breaks the bows of the strong men, but Yahweh gives strength to weak men." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing a strong man, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I must remember that my strength comes from God; or
- If I am proud, God might take away my strength and make me weak; or
- It is true that it is not my bow or my muscles that make me strong, but it is God. I should be humble so God will not make me weak.

Ask the person playing the weak man, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Even though it looks like the strong man will certainly defeat me, God is able to make the strong man weak; or
- I do not need to be afraid of my enemies' strength. God is much stronger than my enemies; or
- If I stay humble before God, God might make me strong enough to defeat my enemies.

Continue the drama. Now repeat those same steps for each kind of reversal of fortunes that Hannah mentioned. Each time, the answers may be a little different, but the strong people should see that God is stronger than they are, and the weak people should be comforted that God can change their circumstances.

1 Samuel 2:1–11

"Yahweh will destroy those who fight against Yahweh. Yahweh will shatter those people. Yahweh's wrath will be like thunder against those people from heaven. Yahweh will judge everyone on Earth. Yahweh will set a man apart and make that man a strong king." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh's enemy, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am terrified! or
- I do not care. I will keep fighting against Yahweh; or
- I will surrender. Yahweh is stronger than me.

Ask the person playing an Israelite, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes it looks like our enemies will defeat us, but God fights for us; or
- I am so relieved that God will not let our enemies win when they fight us, because we are God's people; or
- I am excited that God will give us a strong king!

Continue the drama. Then Elkanah and Hannah went home to Ramah, but the boy Samuel stayed in Shiloh and served Yahweh by helping Eli the priest. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad to leave my little boy, but God was so good to me, so I am happy to keep my promise; or
- I am so thankful that God has removed my shame! or
- I am thankful to serve God because God is so good and strong and perfect in all that God does.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Hannah says that her **heart** rejoices in Yahweh's deliverance, or salvation. Hannah's heart is where Hannah's feelings and thoughts are. Hannah's heart is the inner part of herself. Use the same word for heart that you have used in previous passages. Heart is in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **salvation**. Look up salvation in the Master Glossary. Some versions say victory here, but in any case, Hannah rejoices because Yahweh has saved her, or rescued Hannah from her circumstances. Pause this audio here.

"There is none holy like Yahweh." Holy means God is completely good, pure, powerful, and majestic. Holy means that God is whole, complete, and unchangeable. God alone is God. Yahweh is the name God gave himself. God is the one who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being. Use the same words for God and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. God and Yahweh are in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss what word you will use for **holy**. Look up holy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

"The barren woman has given birth to seven children." The Israelites considered seven to be the perfect, complete number.

Stop here and discuss how you describe women who are barren or unable to have children in your language. Pause this audio here.

"Yahweh brings down to Sheol and raises up." Sheol is the word the Israelites used for the place of the dead. The Israelites believed Sheol was under the earth, so the Israelites talked about going down to Sheol.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Sheol**. Look up Sheol in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

"Yahweh will guard the feet of his faithful ones." Faithful ones are those to whom God has pledged his covenant love or those who obey God. Those who love God and have faith in him also obey God.

1 Samuel 2:1–11

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **faithful ones**. Look up faith in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

“Yahweh will thunder against his enemies from heaven.” The word heaven sometimes means the visible sky where birds fly and we can see clouds or stars at night. Most of the time, though, “heaven” refers to the place where God lives with his angels.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **heaven**. Look up heaven in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

“Yahweh will exalt the horn of his anointed one.” To exalt means to lift up. Horns were symbols of strength and dignity. To anoint someone meant to pour sweet-smelling oil over someone. In the Old Testament, before God gave someone a special task, God would instruct someone else to pour oil over that person’s head. Usually, a priest would anoint the man God chose to be king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **anoint**, **king**, and **priest**. Look up anoint, king, and priest in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 2:1–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (725 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (9.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 2:12–26

1 Samuel 2:12–26

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 2:12–26 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:12–26 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:12–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The storyteller ended the last story by saying that Samuel served Yahweh in the presence of Eli. In this story, the storyteller compares Samuel's service with Eli's sons' service. The storyteller says Eli's sons were "worthless" or "wicked" men because they did not respect or honor Yahweh as their ruler.

The storyteller gives examples of the ways Eli's sons showed contempt for Yahweh or did not respect Yahweh. When this story talks about the custom or practice of the priests with the Israelite people, the storyteller is probably referring to the custom or practice of Eli's sons. The storyteller goes on to describe two customs of Eli's sons that are different than what Yahweh commanded for the priests.

When Yahweh, through Moses, told the Israelites how to offer sacrifices many years before, Yahweh said to first burn the fat as an offering to Yahweh. After that, the worshiper was to give the priest the breast and the right thigh of the sacrificed animal. Then the worshiper would normally boil the rest of the sacrifice. It seems that during this time in Israel's history, priests took more than their share of the meat. Eli's sons, the priests at this time, also did not obey those commands. When any man offered a sacrifice and then boiled the meat, Eli's sons would send one of their servants to the man with a fork in his hand. The servant would plunge this three-pronged fork into the kettle, cauldron, or big pot of meat while it was still boiling. The servant would take whatever piece of meat the fork brought out of the pot and give it to Eli's sons. Eli's sons treated everyone who sacrificed at Shiloh this way. Yahweh had instructed the Israelites about which parts of the animal the priests could eat, but Eli's sons were choosing their portions for themselves and asking for more! Then, worst of all, Eli's sons wanted meat even before the people burned the fat. This means that Eli's sons were taking part of the sacrifice that was for Yahweh only.

Stop here and look at a picture of a three-pronged fork. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a kettle or pot as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and share a story about a good religious leader and a bad religious leader. How do you know which leaders are good and bad? What do those leaders say and do? Pause this audio here.

Eli's sons sinned in other ways, too. Yahweh had instructed the priests to remove and burn the fat of the sacrifices as an offering to Yahweh, but Eli's sons were sending their servants to take Yahweh's fat portion for themselves. If the worshiper argued with the servant and said the priests must burn the fat first, the servant would say no. The servant would threaten to fight with the worshiper if the worshiper did not give the servant the meat right away. The Israelites were trying to obey Yahweh, but Eli's sons would not let them.

Yahweh considered the sins of Eli's sons very terrible. Eli's sons were disrespecting the offerings the people made to Yahweh by not obeying Yahweh's commands about the offerings.

1 Samuel 2:12–26

Stop here and share a story about a time when someone did not show proper respect for an important leader in your community. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller switches his focus back to Samuel. At this time, Samuel was a boy serving Yahweh while wearing a linen ephod. The linen ephod was the special robe the priests wore, which people made from linen. Linen is a white fabric that people make from a grain. Linen is comfortable to wear in hot places. The ephod was a special robe that priests wore, so it was unusual to see a boy wearing the ephod. The next sentence says that Samuel's mother used to make Samuel a little robe and bring it to him each year when she went up with her husband to offer the annual sacrifice. The word "little" emphasizes that Samuel was young and small to be wearing an ephod. Samuel was like a little priest.

Stop here and look at a picture of a linen ephod as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: How do young people in your culture learn the roles of religious leaders? Pause this audio here.

Each year, when Hannah and Elkanah came to Shiloh to offer their annual sacrifice and to bring Samuel a little robe, Eli would ask Yahweh to bless Elkanah by giving Elkanah more children with Hannah. And Yahweh caused Hannah to conceive and give birth to three more sons and two daughters. While Hannah continued to have more children over time, Samuel grew while serving Yahweh in Shiloh.

The storyteller changes the focus back to Eli again. Eli was very old, and Eli kept hearing bad reports about his sons from the people of Yahweh. The storyteller also adds another way that Eli's sons sinned: Eli's sons slept with, or lay with, the women who served at the entrance to the tabernacle of Yahweh. This means Eli's sons had sexual relations with the women. Eli asks his sons why they are doing such wicked things, but Eli is not really asking a question. Eli is telling his sons that they should not be doing such things.

Eli tells his sons that if a person sins against another person, Yahweh will mediate for that person, or make peace between the people. But if someone sins against Yahweh, no one will make peace for that person. Eli is warning his sons that they are sinning against Yahweh, and that Eli's sons should be afraid to continue sinning against Yahweh, because no one will mediate for them.

Stop here and share a story about a time when someone helped bring peace between two people or two groups who were arguing or fighting. Pause this audio here.

But Eli's sons would not listen to Eli, because Yahweh's plan was to put Eli's sons to death.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the things God wants and plans for people? Talk about a time when it seemed like God wanted something bad for someone. Why do you think God wanted that thing? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller changes the story's focus to Samuel again. Even though Samuel is still young, Samuel is different than Eli's sons. Eli's sons would not listen to their father and stop sinning. Samuel continued to grow physically and in favor with Yahweh and also with men. Both Yahweh and the people, including women, were more and more pleased with Samuel as Samuel grew older.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:12–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The person telling the story says that Eli's sons, the priests, were worthless or wicked men who did not know Yahweh. The person who tells the story gives an example of one way Eli's sons were wicked. When any man offered a sacrifice, Eli's sons would rob Yahweh by taking meat that Yahweh did not allow the sons to have. While the meat was still boiling, the servant would plunge his fork into the kettle and pull out whatever meat the fork went into. Then the servant would give that meat to the priest.

1 Samuel 2:12–26

In the second scene: The person telling the story gives a second example of a way Eli's sons were wicked. When a man would bring his sacrifice to be burned, Eli's sons would order the man to give the sons the fat portion that belonged to Yahweh. If the man argued, the servant would demand, "Give it to me now, or I will take it from you using force."

In the third scene: The person telling the story says that Yahweh considered the sin of Eli's sons to be very great, because the sons treated the people's offerings to Yahweh with contempt.

In the fourth scene: The storyteller switches to focus on Samuel. Samuel was serving Yahweh in the tabernacle, and Samuel was a boy wearing a linen ephod. Samuel's mother used to make him a new little robe and bring it to Samuel each year when she would travel to Shiloh with her husband to offer the yearly sacrifice. Eli would bless Elkanah and Hannah. Yahweh gave Hannah three more sons and two daughters to take the place of the son Hannah gave to Yahweh.

In the fifth scene: Eli hears the bad reports that Yahweh's people are spreading about Eli's sons. Eli warns his sons to stop sinning against Yahweh. But Eli's sons will not listen because Yahweh plans to kill the sons.

In the sixth scene: The storyteller changes focus again by saying, "Now the boy Samuel continued to grow both in stature and in favor with Yahweh and also with men."

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh, though no one can see Yahweh
- Eli's son Hophni
- Eli's son Phinehas
- Eli
- Samuel
- Elkanah
- Hannah
- The servants of the priests
- And other Israelites

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The storyteller switches the story's focus back and forth several times to show the difference between Samuel and Eli's sons. You might want to have one person narrate the story while other people act the story out.

The first scene begins with a word that shows us that the storyteller is changing the story's focus from the previous passage, where the storyteller talked about Samuel. Here, the story shifts to talk about Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, who were worthless or wicked men. Hannah talked about herself in the same way when she previously asked Eli not to think of Hannah as a worthless or wicked woman. Eli's sons did not know Yahweh, which means they did not respect Yahweh. Eli's sons knew Yahweh's commands, but they did not obey those commands. The sons acted as if they did not know that Yahweh was their ruler.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When you have a story that keeps switching its focus from one person or scene to another in order to compare the two people, how do you show that the focus of the story is changing? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you speak about someone showing proper respect for a deity? How will you translate the idea of Eli's sons not "knowing" Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

The first scene gives one example of how Eli's sons acted wickedly. The storyteller says, "The custom of the priests," and goes on to describe the custom. A custom is a standard way that people do something. Since the storyteller says Eli's sons were wicked and then describes a custom that was not obedient to Yahweh, the storyteller is probably saying this was Hophni and Phinehas' custom only, not the custom of all priests at the time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the standard, accepted way that a priest does his duties at a place of worship? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 2:12–26

The wicked custom was that a priest's servant would come up to the kettle where a man was boiling his sacrifice in a large pot of water. The servant would plunge a three-pronged fork into the boiling water and pull out whatever piece of meat the fork stabbed. Then the servant would give that piece of meat to the priest.

Stop here and look at a picture of a three-pronged fork as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a kettle or pot. Pause this audio here.

It is not clear from the story where Hophni or Phinehas would be when the servant would go to get the meat. Both Hophni and Phinehas did this wicked thing of sending their servants to take the meat from the pot. Hophni and Phinehas might have been sitting nearby to watch the servant do what they commanded him to do, or Hophni and Phinehas might have been somewhere else. Wherever Eli's sons were, their servant would bring the sons the meat.

The storyteller begins the second scene with a word that shows that it describes another way Eli's sons acted wickedly. The sons would send their servant to demand that the worshiper give the servant meat for the priest right away, before the priest burned the fat as an offering to Yahweh. When the servant says, "I will take it by force," his words are angry, and the servant is threatening to fight with the worshiper if the worshiper does not give him meat right away.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about one person threatening to fight with another person if that other person does not give what the person demands? Pause this audio here.

The third scene begins with a word that shows that the sins of Eli's sons were very great against Yahweh. The sons' actions showed that they treated the offerings to Yahweh with contempt or disrespect. The sons did not obey Yahweh's instructions about which portion of meat they could eat, how the meat should be cooked, or when the sons should take their portion of meat. Some translations think the "men" who disrespected Yahweh's offering were the Israelite men, so Eli's sons were causing the Israelites to disrespect Yahweh's offerings. But most translations say it was Eli's sons who treated the offerings with disrespect.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The story strongly said that the sons did not respect Yahweh's instructions. How would you say that in your culture? Pause this audio here.

The beginning of the fourth scene uses a word that shows a quick switch to focus on Samuel. The word for boy also means young man. This is the same word the storyteller used to describe Eli's sons. These words show that the storyteller is comparing Samuel to Eli's sons. Samuel is still a boy, but Samuel is wearing a linen ephod, which is the same kind of robe that the priests wore. Samuel is like a little priest, serving before Yahweh. Samuel is different than Eli's sons, because Samuel is showing Yahweh respect.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: What special items do your priests wear to show that they are priests? What would happen if someone who was not a priest wore these special items? Pause this audio here.

The story stays focused on Samuel by talking about Samuel's parents, but the setting switches back and forth between Samuel's parents' home and Shiloh. Every year, while Hannah was at her home, Hannah made a new little robe for Samuel. Every year, Hannah would bring the new robe to Samuel when she traveled to Shiloh with Elkanah to make their yearly sacrifice. Every year, when Hannah and Elkanah came to Shiloh, Eli would bless Hannah and Elkanah by saying, "May Yahweh give you more children to take the place of the one you prayed for and gave to Yahweh."

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Remember when, in previous stories, you discussed how you talk about events that happen over and over again. How did you decide to talk about such events? Pause this audio here.

At home, Yahweh did bless Elkanah and Hannah with more children together. Some translations say that Yahweh visited Hannah to show that it was Yahweh who caused Hannah to conceive and give birth to three more sons and two daughters. The story only uses the phrase conceive and give birth one time, but Hannah probably conceived and gave birth to each child separately over a period of time. Hannah probably gave birth six times, including Samuel's birth. While Hannah and Elkanah continued to have more children at home, Samuel stayed in Shiloh and grew while serving Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about a woman giving birth? How will you show that each child was born at a different time rather than all at the same time? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 2:12–26

The fifth scene begins with a word that again shows a change in focus. Eli is very old. Eli hears the Israelites talking about the wicked things Eli's sons are doing. Some translations say Eli heard, and others say Eli kept hearing. Eli probably heard bad reports about his sons more than once, over a period of time. It is not clear how long Eli had been hearing the bad reports, but Eli heard the reports from more than one person. It is not clear if anyone told Eli directly what his sons were doing or if people just talked to each other close enough that Eli could hear them. The phrases "slept with" and "lay with" are polite ways of saying Eli's sons were having sexual intercourse with the women who served at the entrance of Yahweh's tabernacle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember when you discussed how your culture talks politely about the private act between a husband and a wife that they do to make a child. What word or phrase did you use? Would you use the same word or phrase to describe that act when it happens between a man and a woman who are not married? Pause this audio here.

Eli asks his sons why they are doing such wicked things. Eli does not expect the sons to answer his question. Eli says, "No, my sons; it is not a good report the people of Yahweh are spreading." Eli is warning his sons that they should stop doing such wicked things.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: How would a father tell his son that the son is doing something wrong when the son already knows he is doing something wrong? Discuss as a group how you will translate Eli's question. Pause this audio here.

Eli says if someone sins against a man, Yahweh will mediate for that person. The word man here refers to a person, either a man or a woman. The idea is that something might or might not happen, but in this case, a person will certainly sin against another person at some time in his life. The words "mediate" and "intercede" mean to come between two people or two groups in order to help the groups make peace with one another.

Eli asks his sons, "If someone sins against Yahweh, who can intercede for him?" Eli does not expect the sons to answer his question. Eli is warning his sons that they are sinning against Yahweh, and the sons should be afraid to continue sinning against Yahweh, because no one will mediate for the sons. But Eli's sons would not listen to him because Yahweh planned to kill the sons. In other words, Eli's sons would not obey Eli and stop sinning. The reason Eli's sons would not listen is that Yahweh planned to kill the sons. Some texts say that Yahweh planned to "put them to death." Yahweh does not have a body, so this does not mean Yahweh planned to physically kill the sons with Yahweh's hands or with weapons. It means that in a mysterious way, Yahweh plans to do something that causes the sons to die.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate the difference between what happens when a man sins against another man compared to what happens when he sins against Yahweh. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember the story you shared earlier about someone who helped bring peace between two people or groups who were fighting or arguing. What word do you use to describe a person who brings peace that way? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the things God desires and plans? Pause this audio here.

In the sixth scene, the storyteller uses a word to again switch the focus to the boy Samuel. The word boy could refer to a young man of any age between birth and just before the young man got married. We do not know Samuel's exact age, but we know Samuel was still young. This is the same phrase that refers to Eli's sons in order to show the difference between Samuel and Eli's sons. Samuel continued to grow in stature and in favor with Yahweh and with men. Stature can refer to physical size, to the way people like you, or to having wealth or power. Samuel was not becoming wealthy or powerful, so stature probably refers to Samuel's size and the way people thought about him. Samul continued to get older, taller, and heavier. Samuel also grew in favor with Yahweh and with men. Both Yahweh and the people, including women, were more and more pleased with Samuel as Samuel grew older.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When you tell a true story, how do you show your listeners that you are changing the focus from one event or person to another event or person? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 2:12–26

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about someone whom others like and treat well? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:12–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has 6 scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh, though no one can see Yahweh
- Eli's son Hophni
- Eli's son Phinehas
- Eli
- Samuel
- Elkanah
- Hannah
- The servants of the priests
- And other Israelites

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Eli's sons were worthless men who did not know God. They did things that priests were not supposed to do.

Eli's sons would send their servants with a three-pronged fork to pull meat out of the pot while it was boiling. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing an Israelite, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like

- I am angry that this servant is taking meat that should not belong to the priest, or
- I am afraid. This servant is forcing me to disobey Yahweh with my offering, or
- I feel helpless to obey Yahweh because I do not want to fight with the priest's servant.

Continue the drama. The priest's servant would tell the worshiper to give him meat before they burned the fat. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing a priest's servant, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like

- I like being a servant of the priest, because it gives me power, or
- I like how scared this man looks when I tell him to give me the meat, or
- I want this man to be afraid that I will fight him.

Continue the drama. The sin of Eli's sons was very great against Yahweh, because they treated the offerings to Yahweh in a way that showed they did not respect Yahweh at all. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hophni or Phinehas, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like

1 Samuel 2:12–26

- I am the priest, so I should get any piece of meat I want. I think Yahweh's rules are bad or
- Yahweh cannot tell me what to do. I have power too. or
- I am more important than these regular men. They must do as I tell them since I am the priest.

Continue the drama. Samuel was serving Yahweh, a boy wearing a linen ephod. Each year his mother would make a new little robe for him and bring it to him when she traveled to Shiloh with Elkanah to offer their yearly sacrifice.

Each year, Eli blessed Elkanah and Hannah and prayed that Yahweh would give them more children to take the place of the child they had given to Yahweh. Yahweh gave Hannah three more sons and two daughters. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hannah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like

- I remember when I feared that Yahweh would never give me children, and Peninnah used to taunt me, or
- I only asked Yahweh for one child, but he has given me three more sons and two daughters, or
- Yahweh has been so good to me! My shame is removed and I have many children. I am glad I gave Samuel to Yahweh, because Yahweh is so generous to me!

Continue the drama. When Eli was very old, he kept hearing Yahweh's people spreading a bad report about his sons.

Eli warned his sons to stop being wicked, but his sons would not listen because Yahweh planned to kill them. But Samuel continued to grow in stature and in favor with Yahweh and with other men. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like

- I have given Hophni and Phinehas many chances and many years to repent of their sin, but they continue to sin against me, or
- Hophni and Phinehas are sinning against me and against the people. Since they will not repent, I will not allow them to continue living and serving as priests, or
- Samuel shows me the proper respect. He serves me well and he treats the people well. I am very pleased with him.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:12–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Eli's sons were **worthless** men who did not know **Yahweh**. Use the same word or phrase for worthless as you used in the previous passage about Hannah. The word "**know**" here means that Eli's sons did not respect and obey Yahweh as they should have. Use the same word for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages, and remember that Yahweh is in the Master Glossary.

Whenever people made a **sacrifice**, the **priests** would take some of the meat. Use the same words or phrases that you used for sacrifice and priests as you used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for more information about sacrifice and priest.

The priests would send "one of their young men," or **servants**, to stab and take a piece of meat from the pot where it was boiling. Although the original language uses the term for young men, we know that these young men served the priests. If you use a word for servant, use the same word or phrase for servant as you have used previously, and see the Master Glossary for more information about servant.

The sin of Eli's sons was very great. When people sin, they disobey Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sin**. If you have already translated sin in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Look up sin in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause the audio here.

Samuel was a little boy wearing a linen ephod. An ephod was an item of clothing that priests usually wore, so Samuel was like a little priest ministering before Yahweh. Linen is a white fabric that people make from a grain. Linen is comfortable to wear in hot, dry places.

1 Samuel 2:12–26

Stop here and look at a picture of a linen ephod as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **linen ephod**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. For more information, look up the word ephod in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Hannah **conceived** and **gave birth** to three sons and two daughters. The word conceived refers to the moment when a new life begins in the mother's womb. Gave birth refers to the way the mother pushes a baby out of her body. Use the same words or phrases for conceived and gave birth as you used in the previous passage when Hannah conceived and gave birth to Samuel.

Eli asks his sons, "Why do you do such things?" Eli's sons were also sleeping with, or lying with, the women who served at the entrance of Yahweh's tent of meeting, or **tabernacle**. Use the same word for tabernacle that you used in previous passages. For more information, look up tabernacle in the Master Glossary.

Eli said that his sons were doing **wicked** things. Use the same word or phrase for wicked as you have used in previous stories, and see the Master Glossary for more information about wickedness.

Eli scolded his sons and said, "If a man sins against another man, Yahweh will mediate, or intercede, for him." All people sin against other people at some point in their lives. The words **mediate** and **intercede** mean that a person comes between two people or two groups in order to help them have peace with each other.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use to translate this idea that when a person sins against another person, Yahweh will help them make peace with each other. Pause this audio here.

Eli's sons were sinning against Yahweh, but Samuel was growing both in **stature** and in **favor** with Yahweh and with the people who knew Samuel. Stature probably refers to Samuel's physical growth in age, height, and weight. Favor refers to the way Yahweh and the people who knew Samuel became more and more pleased with Samuel as he grew older. The Bible uses the same phrase to describe Jesus in the Gospel of Luke. If you have already translated the book of Luke, use the same words or phrases you used for stature and favor in that book.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 2:12–26

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (688 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (10.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 Samuel 2:27–36

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 2:27–36 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:27–36 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:27–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous section, Yahweh planned that Hophni and Phinehas would refuse to obey their father, Eli, because Yahweh planned to kill Hophni and Phinehas. This section tells more about what will happen to Eli and his sons. A prophet, or man of God, comes to bring Yahweh's message to Eli.

Yahweh uses questions to remind Eli that Yahweh had made himself known to Eli's ancestors. Yahweh did this while Eli's ancestors were still slaves who belonged to Pharaoh, the king of Egypt. Yahweh chose Eli's ancestor Aaron from all the tribes of Israel to be Yahweh's priest. Aaron was to do all of the priest's work. This included going up to Yahweh's altar to offer sacrifices on the altar. Aaron was also to burn incense, which was a mix of sweet-smelling spices. And Aaron was to wear an ephod. The high priest's ephod was more special than the one little Samuel wore. People made this ephod of colored threads, and the ephod had a part that went over the shoulders and chest, into which people set valuable jewels. The priest had to wear or carry this ephod when the priest served in the most holy part of Yahweh's house. This ephod held the urim and thummim, the holy lots that the priest used to determine Yahweh's will. This was a very important item of clothing for the high priest.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are the duties of a priest or special religious leader in your community? What kinds of clothes do priests wear to show that they are set apart for service to God? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh tells Eli that Yahweh gave Eli's ancestors part of all of Yahweh's meat offerings that the Israelites made with fire. In this way, Yahweh provided food for the priests. Yahweh uses a question to accuse Eli and Eli's sons of disrespecting or hating Yahweh's sacrifices and offerings that Yahweh commanded for the place where Yahweh lives. Eli honored his sons more than Eli honored Yahweh because Eli and his sons made themselves fat by eating the best meat of all the offerings of Yahweh's people. In the previous story, we saw that it was Eli's sons who were doing this, but since Eli is their father and Yahweh's priest, Yahweh blames Eli for his sons' disobedience.

1 Samuel 2:27–36

When Yahweh gave the Israelites his law, the first command was to worship Yahweh, and after that, the Israelites were to honor each other. Eli disobeyed Yahweh's command by honoring his sons first.

Stop here and share a story about a time when someone punished a father who did not stop that father's children from sinning. Pause this audio here.

The prophet continues speaking Yahweh's words to Eli. Yahweh had promised that Eli's family and the rest of Eli's ancestors' family would serve Yahweh forever. But now Yahweh is changing his promise. Yahweh will not allow all of Aaron's descendants to serve Yahweh as priests, but only those who honor Yahweh. Yahweh will honor those who honor Yahweh, but Yahweh will shame those who do not respect Yahweh. Since Eli has not respected Yahweh, Yahweh will dishonor Eli.

The prophet warns Eli that Yahweh will judge Eli soon. Yahweh says he will cut off, or destroy, the strength of Eli's father's household. The young men of Eli's family will die while they are still young and strong. Eli will weep so much that Eli will not be able to see. Eli will watch with envy as Yahweh does good things for the rest of the Israelites but not for Eli's family. Some translations say Eli will see bad things happen to the place where Yahweh lives, the tabernacle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do people consider a terrible curse in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says that any of Eli's descendants whom Yahweh allows to serve as priest, Yahweh will also allow to live. Many years after this story, Eli's descendant Abiathar escapes when King Saul kills the other priests of Nob and removes Abiathar from being a priest. Any of Eli's descendants who live will weep and grieve, and men will violently kill the rest of Eli's male descendants before they reach old age. Eli will not live to see all of Eli's descendants die, so Yahweh gives Eli a sign that this curse will happen: men will kill Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, on the same day.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Share a story about a time when an unusual event let you know that something important was going to happen. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says he will raise up a faithful priest to serve Yahweh, and Yahweh will establish this priest's house, or descendants, to be priests forever. Unlike Hophni and Phineas, the priest Yahweh raises up will act according to what is in Yahweh's heart and mind, or all that Yahweh plans and desires. Yahweh will give this new priest male descendants, so that this priest and his family will serve Yahweh's chosen king as priests forever. Most people think this refers to Zadok, whose family served Yahweh's kings from the time of David until Israel's enemies destroyed the temple. Zadok descended from Aaron through Aaron's son Eleazar. Eli descended from Aaron through his son Ithamar. Yahweh is not talking about Samuel when he talks about this priest. Yahweh made Samuel a prophet, not a priest.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In Israelite culture, a priest would anoint or pour oil on a man to set that man apart for special work, especially the work of a king. How does a religious leader in your culture set someone apart to do special work? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says that everyone who is left in Eli's house will come to the faithful priest and beg the priest to give them a job among the priests so they can have food to eat. Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, acted as if Yahweh was not generous enough by taking food that belonged to Yahweh and making themselves fat. Hophni and Phinehas' descendants will see that Yahweh is generous to the priests and will wish they could serve as priests, but Yahweh will not let them.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:27–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

1 Samuel 2:27–36

In the first scene: A prophet speaks Yahweh's words to Eli. Yahweh reminds Eli of the promise Yahweh made to Eli's ancestors when the Israelites were slaves to Pharaoh in Egypt. Yahweh gave Eli's ancestors special work to do, and Yahweh fed them from portions of the Israelites' offerings to Yahweh.

In the second scene: Yahweh continues speaking to Eli through the prophet. Yahweh shows his anger and says Yahweh will now change his promise because of Eli's sin. Yahweh will cause people to violently kill Eli's descendants while they are still young men. Yahweh gives Eli a sign that this judgment is coming: both of Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, will be killed on the same day.

In the third scene: Yahweh continues speaking to Eli through the prophet. Yahweh says he will raise up a faithful priest to serve him, and Eli's descendants will beg that priest to give them work to do so they can have food to eat.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- A man of God
- Eli
- Hophni
- Phinehas
- Eli's descendants
- And the faithful priest

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The storyteller begins this section with a word that shows that the focus is changing from Samuel back to Eli. A man of God comes to Eli to tell him Yahweh's words. Storytellers sometimes use the phrase "man of God" to describe a prophet. A prophet is a man Yahweh sends with Yahweh's message. The storyteller does not tell us where Eli was when the prophet came to Eli. When the prophet says, "Thus says Yahweh," the prophet is using a typical phrase that Israelite prophets used. The things the prophet says after that phrase are the words of Yahweh himself. The prophet speaks the words, but they are not the prophet's words, so the prophet speaks them as if Yahweh himself is speaking, saying things like "I" and "my." Yahweh asks a question, but it is not a question Yahweh wants Eli to answer. Yahweh is reminding Eli that Yahweh revealed himself to Eli's father's house many years ago when they were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt. Yahweh is not talking about Eli's father, but about Eli's ancestor Aaron. The term "father" could be used for any man who came before Eli in Eli's family line. Pharaoh was the title for the king in Egypt. Pharaoh was not the king's name.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show the change in focus from Samuel to Eli at the beginning of this section? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Although the man who came to Eli was a prophet, the storyteller simply calls this man a "man of God." How will you say that? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does a prophet show which of his words are his own and which are the words the prophet is speaking for a deity? How will you translate the statement the man of God makes to introduce the words that Yahweh says? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh uses more questions to remind Eli that Yahweh chose Aaron from all the tribes of Israel to be Yahweh's priest. Now Yahweh describes again the important things that a priest does. A priest goes up to his altar and offers sacrifices on it, burns incense, and wears an ephod. The ephod was important because it carried the holy lots, the urim and thummim, that helped the priest to know the will of Yahweh. This shows that part of the priest's work was to find out the will of Yahweh for the people. Yahweh says the priest goes up to his altar, because the altar at that time had steps for the priest to climb. The Israelites would give the animal as an offering, but the priests would burn the offering on the altar. Yahweh gave Eli's ancestors a portion of all the offerings made with fire. In this way, Yahweh provided food for the priests.

The 12 tribes of Israel were the extended families of Israel's sons. The tribes all spoke the same language. Aaron's family was not a whole tribe of Levi, but one family from Levi's tribe.

1 Samuel 2:27–36

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call a man who is someone's ancestor from many generations ago? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you refer to the large, extended families that each descended from one father? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of an altar as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of incense as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a priest's ephod as a group. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh accuses Eli and Eli's sons of despising, or scorning, Yahweh's animal sacrifices and the other offerings that Yahweh commanded his people to make at Yahweh's tabernacle, where Yahweh lived. Eli and Eli's sons have made themselves fat by eating the first, or best, pieces of meat and by eating the fat that should have belonged to Yahweh. Yahweh blames Eli because it was Eli's sons who were doing this. Because Eli was Yahweh's priest, Eli should have stopped his sons' wicked behavior. Yahweh uses a question to tell Eli he was wrong to honor his sons more than he honored Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the things people offer to God? Do you have different words for different types of things people offer, such as animals or grains? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone treated something that had special honor as if it had no value at all. Pay attention to the words you use. Pause this audio here.

The man of God now shows that Yahweh, the God of Israel, is about to say something very important: Even though Yahweh promised that Eli's house and the rest of Eli's father's house would always serve Yahweh as priests, Yahweh will change his promise because of Eli's sins and Eli's sons' sins. Yahweh says, "Far be it from me!" to show that Yahweh is very angry and he will not continue with that promise. Then Yahweh uses a special word to emphasize that Yahweh is making a change in the promise. Yahweh will not honor all of Aaron's descendants, but only those who honor Yahweh. Yahweh will shame any of Aaron's descendants who do not respect Yahweh. Yahweh uses several different words that all mean not to respect someone. The Israelites often said something two or three different ways to emphasize what they were saying. Yahweh wants to emphasize that Eli has dishonored Yahweh, so Yahweh will dishonor Eli.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The Israelites used the word house or household to refer to a whole family. How do you refer to a whole family, including parents, children, grandparents, and other family members? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The phrase "Far be it from me!" appears several times in the book of 1 Samuel. Tell a story about how someone in your culture would express anger and a complete change from something they said or promised in the past. Pay attention to the words you use to show that anger and change of mind. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you emphasize that what you are about to say is an important change from what you said before? Pause this audio here.

The man of God says, "Behold the days are coming," which was a typical way for prophets to announce that Yahweh would send judgment or punishment soon. Yahweh tells Eli that Yahweh will cut off or destroy the strength of Eli's father's household. All the members of Eli's family will die before they reach old age.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Share a story about a time when a prophet warned someone that God was going to judge that person soon. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: how do people in your culture describe their ancestors from long ago and their distant descendants many years from now? Pause this audio here.

Some translations say that Eli will look with envy as Yahweh does good to the rest of Israel but not to Eli's family. Other translations say that Eli will see bad things happen to Yahweh's dwelling, the tabernacle. In any case, Eli will be sad because of the bad things Eli sees happening.

1 Samuel 2:27–36

Most translations say it is Eli who will weep, even though Eli will not live to see all of his descendants die. Other translations say it is Eli's descendants who will weep. Yahweh says that any of Eli's descendants whom Yahweh does not "cut off" from serving him as priest, Yahweh will allow to live. The phrase "cut off" that Yahweh used can mean to destroy, separate, or send away from a place. Abiathar was the last descendant of Eli to serve as priest. Solomon did not kill Abiathar, but he did remove Abiathar from serving as priest and sent Abiathar to live in another town.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when a leader sent someone away from a place or killed that person to punish him for something. Pay attention to the words you use to describe the leader sending the person away permanently. Pause this audio here.

When Yahweh says "you will weep your eyes out," or "go blind with weeping," and your heart or soul will grieve, it does not mean that Eli's eyes will actually fall out or that Eli will actually go blind. This is special language to show that Eli will weep so much that Eli will not be able to see, because Eli will be very sad all the time. Eli will weep because all of his other descendants will be "killed by the sword." This is an expression the Israelites used to talk about any violent killing, even if a man used a weapon other than a sword to do that killing. Eli might also weep because he sees bad things happen to the place where Yahweh lives, the tabernacle. While Yahweh punishes Eli's family, Yahweh will still do good to Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about someone who weeps often because they are very sad, such as a person whose child dies from a terrible accident? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when one man violently killed another man. Pay attention to the words you use to describe the killing. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says he will give Eli a sign. A sign proves that what a prophet said is true. Eli would not live long enough to see all of Eli's descendants die, so Yahweh gives Eli a sign that all of these things would happen. The sign is that someone would kill Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, on the same day. When someone kills Eli's sons on the same day, that will prove to Eli that Yahweh will also stop Eli's descendants from serving at his altar and will not allow those descendants to live until they are old.

Stop here and remember the story you told about a time when an unusual event led you to believe that something important was going to happen. How did you talk about that event? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says that Yahweh will raise up, or choose, a priest for himself who will be faithful. This priest will do all that is in Yahweh's heart and mind. In Israelite culture, the heart referred to the inner person or a person's will. The mind referred to a person's soul or that person's desires. Yahweh will also make sure the new priest has a long line of descendants who will serve Yahweh as priests. This priest will always serve Yahweh's anointed one. Anointed one usually refers to the king Yahweh chooses to rule over Israel. The priest Zadok is listed as a descendant of Aaron in the book of Chronicles, and he lived to serve Yahweh's anointed king.

The storyteller begins the final section with language that shows the difference between Eli's descendants and the faithful priest whom Yahweh chooses for himself. The prophet speaks for Yahweh, and Yahweh says the words Eli's descendants will say. Eli's descendants will bow down low to show they are humble. Everyone left in Eli's priestly family will be so poor that they will beg the new priest for even the smallest wages and for food. Eli's descendants will say, "Please give us jobs among the priests so that we may have bread to eat." For the Israelites, bread was such an important part of their diet that they often used bread as a symbol for all food. Hophni and Phinehas made themselves fat by taking offerings that belonged to Yahweh. Hophni and Phinehas' descendants will be hungry.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the most common and important food in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some common things people in your culture beg for? How do they beg? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:27–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- A man of God
- Eli
- Hophni
- Phinehas
- Eli's descendants
- And the faithful priest

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

One of Yahweh's prophets came to Eli and said, "This is what Yahweh says: Did I not reveal myself to your ancestor's family when they were slaves of the Pharaoh in Egypt? I called him out of all the tribes of Israel and chose him to serve me as priest. I also gave his family food from all the Israelites' food offerings. Why have you disrespected my sacrifices and offerings that I commanded at my place of worship? You have honored your sons more than me by making yourselves fat with the best part of my people's offerings." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so ashamed! or
- I regret my sin! Why did I disrespect Yahweh when he was so generous to my family? or
- Yahweh is right! I have honored my sons more than Yahweh, even though Yahweh deserved my honor. I have no answer for these questions.

Ask the person playing the man of God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am nervous to speak this message to Yahweh's priest; or
- I hope Eli will not be angry with me, but I must give him Yahweh's message even though it is a hard message; or
- If this is Yahweh's message to his priest, I must be very careful to honor Yahweh, too. No one is above Yahweh. No one can dishonor Yahweh and avoid his punishment.

Continue the drama. Yahweh, the God of Israel, declared, "I promised that your family would serve before me forever, but not any longer! Those who honor me, I will honor. Those who dishonor me, I will dishonor. Very soon, I will destroy your family's strength so that none of your family will reach old age. You will see bad things happen in my place of worship, even though I will do good to Israel. Any man of your descendants whom I do not remove from serving me as priest will be sad and weep so much that he cannot see. Other men will violently kill all of your descendants. This is the sign that everything I have said will happen: your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, will both be killed on the same day." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is a terrible punishment! or
- My family will be so ashamed! Everyone will know that Yahweh is angry with me; or

1 Samuel 2:27–36

- I regret that my descendants will suffer so much because I sinned this way!

Continue the drama. Then I will raise up a faithful priest to serve me. This priest will obey all of my plans and desires. I will make sure this priest has a long line of descendants. This priest will serve my anointed one, the king I choose for Israel, forever. Anyone who is left in your family will bow low to the ground and beg this priest for a piece of silver or a loaf of bread. Your descendants will say to this priest, "Please give us work among the priests so we can have food to eat." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I wish now that I had honored Yahweh as a faithful priest; or
- I see now that Yahweh was generous to let us serve as priests and eat from the Israelites' offerings; or
- I am so humiliated that my descendants will be beggars. Yahweh is shaming my family, and we deserve this shame.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 2:27–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

A man of God is a prophet. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. For more information about the general term for God, look up God in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **man of God** or **prophet**. Look up prophet in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The man of God speaks for **Yahweh**. For more information about God's personal name, look up Yahweh in the Master Glossary. If you have already translated Yahweh, use the same word in all the places where Yahweh is used. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh chose Eli's father's house. Sometimes, **father** means the man who created a child with the child's mother. Other times, father can refer to any man among a person's ancestors, including that person's grandfather, and so on.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember when you discussed what you call a man who is someone's ancestor from many generations ago. What word did you use? Use the same word in all the places where father means someone's ancestor. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh chose Eli's father's **house**. Sometimes a house refers to a building in which a family lives. In this case, house refers to a family, including the long line of the family's descendants, because often generations of a family would live in the same house. Use the same word or phrase that you used for house in previous passages when it meant family and descendants. For more information, look up household in the Master Glossary.

This passage also uses the word **dwelling**, which is a place where someone lives. Yahweh said he commanded sacrifices and offerings for his dwelling, the place where Yahweh lived. The people knew Yahweh was referring to the tabernacle. For more information about Yahweh's dwelling, look up tabernacle in the Master Glossary.

Yahweh chose Eli's family from among all the tribes of Israel when they were slaves of the Pharaoh of Egypt. "Tribes" refers to all the extended families descended from one man. The tribes of Israel all spoke the same language. Pharaoh was the word for king in Egypt. Pharaoh was a title, not a name.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember when you discussed how you refer to large, extended families who all descend from one man. What word did you use? Use the same word in all the places where the storyteller uses the word for **tribes**. If you have translated the word tribe in a previous book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you like to translate the word **pharaoh**? For more information, look up pharaoh in the Master Glossary. If you have already translated pharaoh in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 2:27–36

Eli's ancestors were Yahweh's priests. A priest is someone who works in Yahweh's dwelling or place of worship. This person is between God and the people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **priest**. Look up priest in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The priest would go up to Yahweh's altar. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for altar. Look up **altar** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of an altar as a group. Pause this audio here.

The priest would burn incense, a perfume people made with sweet-smelling spices and gums. People usually burned incense for a deity.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **incense**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of incense as a group. Pause this audio here.

A priest would wear an ephod when he served before Yahweh in Yahweh's dwelling. A priest's ephod was a piece of clothing that people made from colored fabric, with a special piece that went over the shoulders and chest with jewels in it. Only high priests wore this.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **ephod**. Look up ephod in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a high priest's ephod as a group. Pause this audio here.

Eli and his sons scorned Yahweh's offerings. Scorn probably means to trample on something. Eli and his sons did not literally trample on Yahweh's offerings. This is special language that compares the men's disrespect for Yahweh's offerings to the way an animal might carelessly walk on top of something it should not step on. For more information, look up **sacrifices** and **offerings** in the Master Glossary. The words sacrifices and offerings often appear together in the Old Testament to refer to the whole Israelite sacrificial system. Use the same words or phrases for sacrifices and offerings that you used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember the story you told about someone treating something that had special honor as if it had no value. What words did you use? How will you translate the idea of **scorn**? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh gave Eli a sign that this prophecy would happen. A sign is something unusual that is happening for a special reason.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sign**. Look up sign in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh would raise up a faithful priest who would do all that was in Yahweh's "heart and mind," or soul. In the Bible, the heart is special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. Look up heart in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the whole phrase **heart and mind**. Look up mind in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh's faithful priest would serve Yahweh's anointed one. To anoint someone means to pour sweet-smelling oil over that person. Before Yahweh gave someone a special task, Yahweh would instruct someone else to pour oil over that person's head. In this case, Yahweh's anointed one is the person Yahweh chose to be Israel's king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **anointed one**. Look up anoint in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 2:27–36

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (665 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (992 KB)

1 Samuel 3:1–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 3:1–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:1–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 3:1–14

6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Yahweh spoke to Eli through a messenger. In this passage, God speaks directly to Samuel, who is serving Yahweh by assisting Eli. This passage says the word of Yahweh was rare at this time in Israel's history. Also, Yahweh did not often give visions to his prophets at this time. A vision was when a person saw something from God that other people did not see, or heard something from God that other people did not hear. A vision was different than a dream because the person was awake when they had a vision. Both the word of Yahweh and visions were messages from Yahweh. These details let us know how unusual it was that Yahweh spoke to Samuel.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when someone heard God speaking to that person or saw a vision from God. How common is it for God to speak to people in your community or give people visions? Pause this audio here.

One night, the priest Eli is lying down in his own place where Eli usually sleeps at night. Eli can barely see because Eli's sight is becoming very weak. The lamp of God has not yet gone out, so this means that it is still nighttime, before the sun rises. Yahweh had instructed Yahweh's priests to set up a sacred lamp in the tabernacle. One of the priest's jobs was to keep the lamp burning all night long. While the people of Israel sleep at night, Yahweh always stays awake. Eli's bad eyesight might explain why Samuel later comes to Eli when Yahweh calls Samuel. Perhaps Samuel is used to Eli calling to Samuel for help because of Eli's bad eyesight.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the lamp of God burning in the tabernacle. Pause this audio here.

Samuel is sleeping in Yahweh's tabernacle, near the ark of God. The ark of God was in a special part of the tabernacle, behind a curtain. Only the priest could go into the part of the tabernacle where the priests kept the ark of God. The ark of God was a special box that people made of a wood called acacia and covered inside and outside with gold. The ark of God held special items inside it to remind the Israelites of God's covenant with the Israelites. The Israelites believed God lived in the space above the ark, so the ark was a symbol of God's presence.

Stop here and look at a picture of the ark of God as a group. Pause this audio here.

Then Yahweh calls to Samuel, and Samuel says, "Here I am!" Samuel runs to Eli and says, "Here I am, because you called me." But Eli says, "I did not call you. Lie down on your bed again." So Samuel goes and lies down.

And Yahweh calls again, "Samuel!" Samuel gets up from his bed and goes to Eli and says, "Here I am, because you called me." But Eli says, "I did not call you, my son. Lie down again."

Samuel does not yet know Yahweh because Yahweh has not yet shown Yahweh's word, or will, to Samuel. In other words, Yahweh has never before given Samuel a personal message. This explains why Samuel keeps going to Eli, because Samuel thinks it is Eli who is calling Samuel. It also shows that Yahweh is now going to speak to Samuel.

Yahweh calls Samuel again a third time. Samuel gets up from his bed, goes to Eli, and says, "Here I am, because you called me." After the third time, Eli realizes that Yahweh is the one calling the boy, so Eli says to Samuel, "Go, lie down, and if he calls you, say 'Speak, Yahweh. Your servant is listening to you.'" This was the proper and humble way for a prophet to reply when Yahweh gave a message. So Samuel goes and lies down in his place.

Yahweh comes and stands, calling like he had the other times, "Samuel! Samuel!" In other parts of the Bible, when Yahweh calls people twice, Yahweh has an important and urgent message for that person, and Yahweh has a special job for that person to do. Often, when Yahweh calls a man's name twice, Yahweh also appears to the man in a visible way, like the time Yahweh appeared to Moses in the burning bush. With Samuel, Yahweh calls twice and also comes and stands near Samuel. Samuel does what Eli instructed and says, "Speak, because your servant is listening."

Stop here and share a story about a time when God spoke to someone and revealed himself to that person. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 3:1–14

Then Yahweh tells Samuel to listen carefully to what Yahweh says next. Yahweh tells Samuel that Yahweh plans to do something shocking soon. This thing will cause everyone who hears about it to be very surprised.

Yahweh prepares Samuel to be Yahweh's messenger, or prophet, by telling Samuel what Yahweh plans to do in Israel. Before this, Samuel did not know Yahweh, because Yahweh had not yet given Samuel a personal message. Now, Yahweh is showing Samuel his word, or Yahweh's will. This is something special Yahweh does for his messengers. Yahweh speaks to Yahweh's messengers directly.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: How do you know when someone is God's messenger? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh tells Samuel that Yahweh plans to do everything he had threatened to do against Eli and Eli's family —every detail of that plan. When people hear what Yahweh does, people will be shocked. Yahweh had told Eli before that Yahweh would soon punish Eli's family line forever because Eli knew about the sins Eli's sons did, and Eli did not stop them. Eli's sons dishonored Yahweh and made Yahweh seem less powerful and important than Yahweh is. Yahweh had already told the Israelites that Yahweh would punish this sin with death.

Yahweh tells Eli that Yahweh is going to keep the oath, or promise, he made to Eli's family. Eli's family will never be able to make a sacrifice or offering that will make it possible for Yahweh to forgive their sins. When Yahweh gave the Israelites his law about how the Israelites should live, Yahweh told the Israelites how priests could make sacrifices and offerings for their own sins. However, Hophni and Phinehas's sins are terrible. Hophni and Phinehas had continually shown such disrespect for Yahweh's sacrifices and offerings that Yahweh would no longer allow Hophni and Phinehas to make sacrifices and offerings in order to cover for or atone for their sins.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How can people in your culture be forgiven when they do something wrong? Share a story about a time when someone did something so bad for so long that no one would forgive that person.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The narrator reminds the audience that Samuel was serving Yahweh as Eli's assistant. At this time in Israel's history, Yahweh rarely spoke to his prophets or gave them visions. One night Eli and Samuel were both sleeping in the tabernacle area and the lamp of God was still burning.

In the second scene: God calls to Samuel. Then Samuel runs to Eli and says, "Here I am, because you called me." But Eli says that Eli did not call Samuel. Eli tells Samuel to go back to bed.

In the third scene: God calls to Samuel again, and Samuel goes to Eli again and says, "Here I am, because you called me." But Eli says he did not call Samuel and tells Samuel to go back to bed again.

In the fourth scene: God calls Samuel a third time. Samuel goes to Eli again, and this time Eli realizes it is God who calls Samuel. Eli tells Samuel that the next time the voice calls to Samuel, Samuel should reply, "Speak, Yahweh, for your servant is listening to you." And Eli tells Samuel to go back to bed.

In the fifth scene: God calls a fourth time and reveals himself to Samuel. God repeats Samuel's name two times, "Samuel! Samuel!" Samuel responds the way Eli told him to. Yahweh tells Samuel about his plans to punish Eli's family because Hophni and Phinehas sinned against Yahweh, and Eli knew about it and did not stop them. Yahweh says everyone who hears about it will be shocked, but there is nothing Eli's family can do now in order to be forgiven.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Yahweh

1 Samuel 3:1–14

- And Eli

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage shifts focus from Eli back to Samuel. The storyteller reminds us that the boy Samuel was serving Yahweh as Eli's assistant. Samuel was probably about 10 to 15 years old. The word of Yahweh was rare in those days, and people did not often have visions of Yahweh. The word of Yahweh refers to Yahweh's message through Yahweh's prophets. This helps us understand how unusual it is that Yahweh speaks to Samuel and gives Samuel a message.

Stop here and share a story about a very unusual thing that really happened. What words or phrases did you use to let your listener know that your story was unusual and true? Pause this audio here.

Eli was sleeping in his usual place when this story begins. The tabernacle had places like rooms in its courtyard where the priests and Levites would sleep when they served in the tabernacle. Eli's eyes were becoming dim or blind. Eli could barely see anymore. The lamp of God was still burning, so we know that it was still nighttime, before the sun rose.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you speak about someone whose eyes are beginning to see less and less, so that he is almost blind? Pause this audio here.

Samuel was also lying down in Yahweh's tabernacle, which was the tent where Yahweh lived at this time. Samuel was probably in one of the rooms in the courtyard where priests and Levites slept. Samuel was near the ark of God, but not in the same room as the ark of God, because only the high priest could go near the ark of God. One of the priest's jobs was to keep the lamp burning all night, and Samuel would have helped Eli with this job.

Yahweh called Samuel, and Samuel said, "Here I am!" Samuel ran to Eli and said, "Here I am, because you called me." But Eli said, "I did not call you. Go lie down in your bed again." So Samuel went and lay down.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would someone in your culture respond if they heard an honorable person calling to them? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh called again, "Samuel!" Samuel went to Eli and said, "Here I am, because you called me." Notice that this time, Samuel did not run to Eli but simply went to him. Eli said, "I did not call you, my son. Lie down on your bed again." Samuel was not actually Eli's son, but Eli called Samuel "son" as a way to show tenderness to Samuel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would someone in your culture speak to a child whom he loved like his own child but who is not actually that person's child? Pause this audio here.

Here, the person telling the story interrupts the story to give us more information. The storyteller says Samuel did not yet know Yahweh because Yahweh had not revealed himself or his will to Samuel personally. In the original language, this does not mean that Samuel did not know who Yahweh was, but that Yahweh had never given Samuel a personal message before. At the beginning of the story, the storyteller already mentioned that Yahweh did not speak to his prophets often or give them visions often at this time in Israel's history. Now, we hear this added information to show that Yahweh had never before spoken directly to Samuel. This is probably why Samuel did not know it was Yahweh calling to Samuel. It also tells us that Samuel was soon going to know Yahweh, because Yahweh was going to reveal himself to Samuel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some reasons why a person might choose to give important information out of order when telling a story? How does giving the information in that order make the story better? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh called Samuel again a third time. This is the third time we see this pattern repeated in the story. This time Eli responds differently from the way he did the first two times. Eli has a new understanding of what is happening. In the Bible, when something happens three times, that shows it is important. Maybe this is why Eli now realizes who is calling Samuel. So Eli tells Samuel that when the voice calls Samuel again, Samuel should reply, "Speak, Yahweh, because your servant is listening to you." Eli is not telling Samuel to command Yahweh to speak, but to make a humble request for Yahweh to speak to Samuel. In the culture at this time, people would sometimes speak about themselves as if they were someone else, such as calling themselves "your servant" in order to show respect.

1 Samuel 3:1–14

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is the proper way for a prophet to reply to a message from God? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture refer to themselves when they speak to someone whom people highly honor and respect? Pause this audio here.

The next time Yahweh came, Yahweh stood and called again, "Samuel! Samuel!" This is the first time Yahweh not only called but also stood. Yahweh does not have a body, so Yahweh does not literally stand, but this probably means Yahweh not only spoke words to Samuel but also showed himself to Samuel in a visible way. Yahweh does not have a physical body, so it is not clear how he appeared to Samuel.

Yahweh calls Samuel's name two times, which shows it was a special type of calling. Yahweh also called the names of Abraham, Jacob, and Moses two times in earlier stories in the Bible. Samuel says almost exactly what Eli told him to say, but Samuel does not say Yahweh's name. Instead, Samuel just says, "Speak, for your servant is listening to you." It is not clear why Samuel does not say Yahweh's name as Eli has instructed.

Then Yahweh uses language that shows he wanted Samuel to listen carefully to what Yahweh said next. Yahweh told Samuel he planned to do something shocking soon. Yahweh uses special language about tingling ears to show that the people who hear about what Yahweh does will be very surprised. Yahweh uses this same expression in two other places in the Bible where Yahweh tells the Israelites he is going to punish people, and the ears of those who hear about it will tingle. This means the people will not only be surprised but also very afraid.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture tell someone to listen carefully to what they say next? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture talk about something they plan to do very soon when they do not want to say exactly what day or time they plan to do it? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and share a story about a time when something very terrible happened to an honored leader, and how people reacted when they heard about that thing. What language did you use to show how surprised the people were when they heard about it? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says he is going to judge or punish Eli's house or family exactly as Yahweh told Eli he would when he spoke to Eli earlier through the man of God. The language Yahweh uses means Yahweh will do everything he threatened. Yahweh says he told Eli he was going to judge Eli's family forever because Eli knew his sons dishonored Yahweh and made him seem less powerful and important than he is. When the men did that, they brought Yahweh's curse upon themselves. Eli should have done more than just tell his sons they were sinning. Eli should have stopped his sons.

Stop here and share a story about a time when someone dishonored an honorable person and made that person seem less powerful and important than he was. What language did you use to talk about the way that person treated the honorable person badly? Pause this audio here.

Because Eli knew about his sons' sin and did not stop his sons, Yahweh makes an oath or promise to Eli's family that Yahweh will not cover or wipe away their sins against Yahweh. There will never be an offering or sacrifice that Eli's family can make to cause Yahweh to forgive their sins now. Eli's family did not treat Yahweh's sacrifices and offerings with the honor they deserved, and now Eli's family will not be able to make any sacrifices or offerings to atone for, or cover or remove, their own guilt.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

1 Samuel 3:1–14

- Samuel
- Yahweh
- And Eli

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Then Yahweh called Samuel, and Samuel said, "Here I am!" And Samuel ran to Eli and said, "Here I am, because you called me." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Eli must need my help because Eli's eyesight is so weak; or
- I wonder why Eli needs my help in the middle of the night? or
- I hope Eli is okay. Eli is a very old man now.

Continue the drama. Then Yahweh called again, "Samuel!" and Samuel got up and went to Eli and said, "Here I am, because you called me." But Eli said, "I did not call, my son. Lie down in your bed again." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Samuel is such a good boy to come quickly when he thinks I have called him; or
- I wonder why Samuel keeps thinking I am calling him. Samuel must be sleeping badly; or
- This is the second time tonight that Samuel thought I was calling him. The poor child is acting strangely.

Continue the drama. Yahweh called Samuel a third time. And Samuel got up and went to Eli and said, "Here I am, because you called me." Then Eli realized it was Yahweh who was calling the boy, so Eli told Samuel, "Go lie down in your bed again, and if he calls you again, say, 'Speak Yahweh, for your servant is listening to you.'" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is the third time someone has called Samuel. This must be a special calling; or
- Yahweh often does special things three times, so it must be Yahweh calling Samuel; or
- If Yahweh is speaking to Samuel, I must teach Samuel how to respond like a prophet.

Continue the drama. Yahweh came and stood. And Yahweh called like he had the other times, "Samuel! Samuel!" And Samuel said, "Speak, for your servant is listening to you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I cannot believe Yahweh is speaking to me and appearing to me! or
- I am so amazed that I cannot even say his name! or
- I have been serving Yahweh my whole life, but this is the first time Yahweh has spoken to me! What will Yahweh say to me?

Continue the drama. Yahweh said to Eli that Yahweh would punish Eli's family forever. Yahweh would do this because Eli knew his sons were dishonoring Yahweh, and Eli did not stop them. Yahweh promises that nothing will cause Yahweh to cover up or wipe away the sins Eli's family has committed. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is time to punish Eli's family as I said I would when I spoke to Eli through my messenger; or
- Eli and his sons might have thought they could keep sinning without being punished, but they were wrong; or
- Eli and his sons have sinned so terribly that I will not show them any mercy.

1 Samuel 3:1–14

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Now the boy Samuel served Yahweh by assisting Eli. The word the storyteller uses here refers to a boy around 10 to 15 years of age.

Stop here and discuss as a group which word you will use for **boy**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In those days, the word of **Yahweh** was rare. The word of Yahweh is a message from Yahweh. People did not receive many visions. A vision was when a person saw something from God that other people did not see, or heard something from God that other people did not hear. Use the same word for Yahweh as you have used in previous passages, and remember that Yahweh is in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate **word of Yahweh** and **vision**. For more information about a vision, refer to the Master Glossary. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The lamp of God had not yet gone out, and Samuel was lying down in the temple of Yahweh near the ark of God. The lamp of God was a sacred lamp, holy and dedicated to God. The priest made sure this lamp had enough oil to keep burning through the night every night. The lamp of God stood inside the tabernacle, before the curtain that separated the holy place from the most holy place, where the priests kept the ark of God.

Stop here and review what phrase you have used for **lamp of God** in the book of Exodus. If you have already translated this phrase, use the same word that you have used there. Remember that God is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of the lamp of God as a group. Pause this audio here.

The story tells us that Samuel was lying down in the temple of Yahweh, but people had not yet built the temple at the time of this story. The word for temple here also refers to a palace or someone's special house, so sometimes the Israelites called the tabernacle the temple. Some translations say that Samuel was lying in the "house of Yahweh." Samuel was actually lying in the tabernacle or tent where Yahweh lived and where people worshiped Yahweh. Samuel was probably lying in a part of the courtyard of the tabernacle where there were spaces for the priests and Levites to sleep when they served Yahweh in the tabernacle. For more information, refer to tabernacle or temple in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate **temple**, **house of Yahweh**, or **tabernacle of Yahweh**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The ark of God was a chest that people made from the wood of the acacia tree. The chest was covered inside and outside with gold. The chest held the tablets of the law that God gave to Moses; a pot of the manna, or special food, that God gave the Israelites while they wandered in the desert; and Aaron's rod that had budded. The ark of God was meant to remind the Israelites that God had promised to be with them. People sometimes called the ark of God "the ark of the covenant."

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **ark of God**. Look up "Ark of the Covenant" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Eli told Samuel to go and lie down, and if the voice called to Samuel again, Samuel should say, "Speak, Yahweh, for your **servant** is listening." A servant is a man or woman who works for another person. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages. Servant is in the Master Glossary.

1 Samuel 3:1–14

Yahweh told Samuel that Yahweh was going to judge Eli's family forever because of the **sin** Eli knew about. Sin is an act of rebellion against God. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you used in previous passages. Sin is in the Master Glossary.

Yahweh said that Eli's sons were bringing **curses** on themselves, which means that Yahweh would punish Eli's sons because they were **blaspheming** or disrespecting God. You may either say that Eli's sons were bringing curses on themselves or that they were blaspheming God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what you will say about what Eli's sons were doing. Refer to the Master Glossary for information about blasphemy and about curse. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh told Samuel that the guilt of Eli's house would never be atoned for by making sacrifices or giving offerings. Atone means to cover over and reconcile or restore a relationship with God when the relationship has been broken because someone sinned or because someone was impure.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **atone**. Look up atonement in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A **sacrifice** is a gift to God. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifice as you used in previous passages. Sacrifice is in the Master Glossary. The phrase "sacrifices and offerings" is often used together in the Old Testament to refer to the whole Israelite sacrificial system.

An **offering** is a gift or sacrifice that people offer in a ritual to God, usually in the temple or on a special altar. Use the same word or phrase for offering as you used in previous passages. Offering is in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 3:1–14

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (645 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.6 MB)

- Embodying the Text (2.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (967 KB)

1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage begins hours after the previous story. Yahweh gave Samuel a vision sometime during the night, and now it is morning. Samuel and Eli are still in Yahweh's house, the tabernacle.

Samuel lies in his bed until morning. The passage does not say whether Samuel goes back to sleep or not. The passage only says that Samuel lies in his bed. When it is morning, Samuel opens the doors of the tabernacle, as Samuel probably did every morning as one of his jobs for Eli. The tabernacle was a tent, but the Israelites might have built doors in front of the entrance to the tabernacle after they settled in Shiloh. This was the first thing Samuel did on that morning. Samuel was afraid to tell Eli about the vision Yahweh had given Samuel.

Stop here and look at a picture of the tabernacle together as a group. Pause this audio here.

Eli really wants to know what Yahweh said to Samuel, even though Samuel is afraid to tell Eli. In the previous story, Eli was the one who finally realized it was Yahweh calling Samuel and who told Samuel how to reply. Now that it is morning, Eli still remembers that Yahweh spoke to Samuel. As soon as Samuel opens the doors, Eli calls Samuel.

Eli asks Samuel what Yahweh told Samuel. Eli seems to already know that Samuel is afraid to tell Eli. But Eli shows how serious Eli is by adding that Samuel should not hide Yahweh's words from Eli. Eli uses an oath, or a curse, by asking God to punish Samuel if Samuel does not tell Eli the whole truth.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some oaths or curses that people in your culture use to make someone obey that person? Pause this audio here.

So Samuel tells Eli everything. Samuel does not hide anything from Eli. After Samuel tells Eli everything, Eli replies humbly that he accepts Yahweh's plan because Yahweh has the right to do what Yahweh thinks is best.

And Samuel grows, both physically and spiritually. Remember, Samuel is probably between the ages of 10 and 15 years old when Yahweh first speaks to Samuel, so Samuel continues to grow physically, but he also continues to grow spiritually. Yahweh is with Samuel. This shows that Samuel is a true believer. Yahweh does everything he spoke through Samuel. Everyone in the whole country of Israel knows that Samuel is Yahweh's true and faithful prophet, or Yahweh's messenger to the Israelites. Everyone in Israel, from Dan to Beersheba, refers to all the Israelites, because those towns were at the northern and southern boundaries of Israel. The emphasis is on all the people of Israel, not on the land itself.

1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a

Stop here and look at a map of Israel together as a group. Pause this audio here.

The expression “Yahweh was with Samuel” is a phrase we commonly see in the Old Testament. This phrase means that Yahweh blessed Samuel. Yahweh protected Samuel, guided him, and caused him to succeed. The storyteller uses special language to say that Yahweh caused Samuel to speak Yahweh’s words faithfully to the Israelites. All the Israelites could see that Samuel was Yahweh’s trusted prophet because every message Samuel spoke for God was true.

In the previous story, the storyteller began by saying that Yahweh’s word was rare in Israel. In this story, the storyteller ends by saying Yahweh spoke to Samuel over and over again.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel gets out of his bed in the morning after Yahweh spoke to him. Samuel opens the doors of the tabernacle, as Samuel probably did every morning. Samuel is afraid to tell Eli what Yahweh said to Samuel in the nighttime.

In the second scene: As soon as Samuel opens the doors, Eli calls Samuel to come to Eli. Samuel comes to Eli and answers respectfully. Eli gently asks Samuel to tell Eli what Yahweh said to Samuel. But Eli also makes an oath where he calls on Yahweh to punish Samuel if Samuel does not tell Eli every word that Yahweh spoke to Samuel. Samuel tells Eli everything Yahweh said to Samuel, and Eli humbly accepts Yahweh’s plan.

In the third scene: Samuel continues to grow both physically and spiritually. Yahweh does everything Yahweh says he will do through Samuel. All the Israelites know that Samuel is Yahweh’s true prophet. Yahweh continues to appear to Samuel in Shiloh by speaking Yahweh’s word to Samuel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- Eli
- And all the Israelites

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage’s setting:

Samuel lies down in his bed after Yahweh spoke to him. In the morning, Samuel opens the doors of Yahweh’s house, the tabernacle. The tabernacle was a tent, but the Israelites might have built wooden doors in front of the entrance after they settled in Shiloh because the Israelites did not move the tent anymore.

In the next part, the storyteller begins with language that shows the difference between Samuel being afraid to speak to Eli about his vision from Yahweh and Eli wanting Samuel to tell Eli. A vision was when a person saw something from God or heard something from God that other people did not see or hear. Even if God only spoke words, people still called it a vision.

But Eli calls Samuel. It is possible Eli is still in his room in the courtyard of the tabernacle when Eli calls Samuel. Eli uses the phrase “my son” even though Samuel is not Eli’s son. Eli does this to show affection for Samuel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember in the previous story when you talked about how someone in your culture would refer to a child whom he loved like his own son, but who is not his own son. What word or phrase did you use? Pause this audio here.

Samuel comes to Eli and answers him respectfully. Samuel and Eli probably continue their conversation in Eli’s room in the courtyard of the tabernacle. Eli asks Samuel what Yahweh said to Samuel during the night. Eli seems to already know that Samuel is afraid to tell Eli, because Eli uses language that makes his request more gentle.

1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a

Eli tells Samuel not to hide Yahweh's words from Eli. Eli even makes an oath, or curse, that calls for Yahweh to punish Samuel if Samuel hides any of Yahweh's words from Eli. So Samuel tells Eli everything. Samuel does not hide anything from Eli. The Israelites used this pattern of first saying something in a positive way, like "Samuel told Eli everything," and then repeating the idea in a negative way, like "Samuel did not hide anything." The Israelites did this to emphasize that what they were saying was important.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture emphasize something they say in a true story? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate Eli's oath that called on God to punish Samuel if Samuel did not tell Eli everything Yahweh had said to Samuel. Pause this audio here.

Eli humbly accepts that Samuel's words are from Yahweh. Eli uses the special language, "good in his own eyes," to say that Yahweh has the right to do what Yahweh thinks is best.

The next passage talks about a much longer period of time, beginning from the time of this conversation and continuing through many years of Samuel's life. Samuel grew to become a man and Yahweh was with Samuel. Samuel was probably between the ages of 10 and 15 years old when Yahweh first spoke to Samuel. It might be good to have a younger person play the part of Samuel at the beginning of the story and then have an adult play the part of Samuel at this point in the story.

Yahweh continued to appear at Shiloh. Yahweh revealed himself to Samuel at Shiloh by his own word. This means that Yahweh himself spoke to Samuel directly. Samuel's words, which were Yahweh's words, went out to all of the Israelites. These are three ways to say that Samuel was a true prophet of Yahweh who spoke Yahweh's true words to the Israelites. The Israelites often repeated important things three times to show that those things were important. The storyteller uses special language when he says, "None of Samuel's words fell to the ground." This means that Yahweh made sure that nothing Samuel spoke on Yahweh's behalf was false.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture refer to someone who speaks God's messages to the people? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Share a story about a prophet who said that something would happen, and then that thing did happen just as the prophet said it would. Pay attention to the language you use to talk about the prophet's words. How would you emphasize that none of the prophet's words were false? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh continued to appear to Samuel in Shiloh over and over again. The storyteller does not say exactly how many times Yahweh appeared, but this means Yahweh appeared many times. Yahweh made himself known to Samuel through the things Yahweh said to Samuel when he visited Samuel. It is not clear if Samuel could see Yahweh during these visits or if Yahweh only spoke to Samuel. Through Yahweh's messages to Samuel, Samuel learned to know Yahweh. Samuel spoke Yahweh's messages to all the Israelites, and the Israelites believed the messages.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- Eli
- And all the Israelites

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Samuel lay down until morning and then opened the doors of Yahweh's house. It was probably the entrance doors of the tabernacle that Samuel opened. Eli probably heard Samuel open the doors while Eli was still in Eli's own room. Eli called to Samuel and said, "Samuel, my son." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am afraid to face Eli; or
- How can I tell Eli what Yahweh said without making Eli angry at me? or
- Maybe I can avoid telling Eli what Yahweh said last night.

Continue the drama. Samuel answered, "Here I am." Eli asked, "What did Yahweh say to you? Do not hide it from me. May God deal with you, be it ever so severely, if you hide from me anything he told you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Did Yahweh talk to Samuel about me? or
- I am ashamed to think that Yahweh might have told Samuel about my sin; or
- I hope Yahweh will not add even more to my punishment than Yahweh already told me about.

Continue the drama. So Samuel told Eli everything. Samuel did not hide anything from Eli. Then Eli said, "He is Yahweh; let him do what is good in his eyes." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I deserve Yahweh's punishment for my sin; or
- Yahweh has the right to do what he knows is best; or
- I am no match for Yahweh's wisdom or strength.

Continue the drama. Yahweh was with Samuel as he grew up, and Yahweh let none of Samuel's words fall to the ground. All Israel from Dan to Beersheba recognized that Samuel was a prophet of Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing an Israelite, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Every time Samuel says he is speaking Yahweh's words, the words turn out to be true; or
- If Samuel says something will happen, it always does; or
- Yahweh is clearly speaking through Samuel, because Samuel could not know all those things on his own.

Continue the drama. Yahweh continued to appear at Shiloh, and there Yahweh revealed himself to Samuel through his word. And Samuel's word came to all Israel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel opened the doors of the house of **Yahweh**. During the time when Samuel was judge, Yahweh lived in the tabernacle, so people called this place "the house of Yahweh" or "the house of **God**," even though it was a tent. Later, the Israelites built the temple as the house of Yahweh. Yahweh is the name God gave himself. Yahweh is God, the creator of all things and the most powerful spiritual being. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh and God as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up Yahweh and God in the Master Glossary.

For more information, look up **house of God** and **tabernacle** in the Master Glossary, and use the same phrase for “house of Yahweh” as you have used in previous passages.

Samuel was afraid to tell Eli the **vision**. A vision is when God speaks words to a person or shows a person something that other people do not hear or see. Use the same word or phrase for vision as you used in previous passages. For more information on vision, refer to the Master Glossary.

All the people of **Israel** from Dan to Beersheba knew that Samuel was established as a **prophet** of Yahweh. Israel is the territory where the Israelites lived. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Use the same words or phrases for prophet and Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh revealed himself to Samuel through his **word**, or his message. Use the same word or phrase for “word” as you have used in previous passages, and look up word in the Master Glossary for more information if necessary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 3:15–4:1a

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (732 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (952 KB)

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 4:1b-11 and put it in your hearts.

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:1b-11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:1b-11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Yahweh revealed himself to Samuel at Shiloh and established Samuel as a prophet throughout Israel. Yahweh also told Samuel that Yahweh would judge the house of Eli.

In this story, Yahweh begins to fulfill Yahweh's promise to judge Eli and Eli's family. The storyteller ended the last story by saying that the word of Samuel came to all Israel. This means that all the Israelites knew and accepted that Yahweh would speak to them through Samuel, Yahweh's prophet. It is possible that the beginning of this story is part of the conclusion of the last story, because it shows that the people of Israel have accepted Samuel as a prophet of Yahweh. However, this story also shows that although the people recognized the word of Samuel, the Israelites went out to battle without asking Yahweh's will through his prophet Samuel.

We do not know the reason that the Israelites went to battle or war against the Philistines. To go out to battle is a military phrase that means the army marched out.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when your community went to war. Which members of your community went to fight in the war? Why did your community have this war, and how did the leaders make the decision to fight? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites made their camp at Ebenezer and their enemies, the Philistines, made their camp at Aphek. This is where the two armies settled before they began the battle, but this is not where the armies fought the battle.

Stop here and look at a map of Ebenezer and Aphek as a group. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines were a warrior tribe of people who came many years before by boats and settled in the coast of the land of Canaan. The Philistines were enemies of the Israelites and fought many battles with them. The Philistines arranged themselves in lines to fight against the Israelites.

When the battle began, the Philistines defeated the Israelites and killed about 4,000 men in the field of battle. Four thousand is not the exact number of Israelites. These soldiers did not run away but died in the field while they were fighting.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When your warriors go to war, how do your leaders organize the warriors to fight? Pause this audio here.

The remaining Israelites who did not die in battle returned to their camp at Ebenezer. The elders or leaders of the Israelites asked why Yahweh had defeated Israel before the Philistines that day. The elders asked that question because the elders believed that it was Yahweh who caused the Philistines to defeat Israel. The elders of Israel were the leaders of the clans of Israel. The elders were generally old men, but it was not necessary to be old to be an elder.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who in your community do you view as elders or leaders? What types of leaders do you have for different groups of people? For example, who are your leaders for families, clans, and villages? Pause audio here.

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

The elders made the decision that they should take the ark of Yahweh's covenant from Shiloh and bring it to Ebenezer so that it may save the Israelites from the hand of their enemies, or the control and power of the Philistines. At this time, the Philistines were ruling over the Israelites. This means that the Israelites served the Philistines by following their orders and paying them taxes. It is possible that the elders were thinking that Yahweh would save the Israelites if they brought the ark to the battle because the ark was a visible sign of Yahweh's presence. It is also possible that the elders believed that the ark itself would save them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group. What does your community do to ask God to give you victory in a battle or war? How do you react when your enemy has defeated you? Pause audio here.

The ark was a rectangular chest that Yahweh had asked Moses to make of acacia wood. The ark contained the tablets that Yahweh wrote his law on and gave to Moses, a pot of manna, and Aaron's rod that had budded. The Israelites believed that Yahweh literally lived in the space directly above the ark, so the ark came to symbolize Yahweh's presence.

Stop here and look at a picture of the ark as a group. Discuss this question as a group: Tell about an object, ritual, or person in your community that is a sign of God's presence. In what ways can people rely on the object, ritual, or person rather than on God? Pause this audio here.

For this reason, the army sent messengers to Shiloh to bring the ark. Shiloh is a town in the hill country of Ephraim. Shiloh is where the Israelites set up the tabernacle before Yahweh divided the land of Canaan among the tribes of Israel. The distance from Ebenezer to Shiloh is approximately 30 kilometers or 20 miles.

Stop here and look at a map of the journey from Ebenezer to Shiloh as a group and a picture of the people carrying the ark. Pause this audio here.

The messengers brought back "the ark of the covenant of Yahweh of hosts, who is enthroned above the cherubim." This is one of Yahweh's full titles. Yahweh of hosts means that Yahweh is the leader of heaven's armies. This title refers to the Israelites' belief that Yahweh literally sat between the carved cherubim on the top or lid of the ark like a king sits on a throne. Cherubim were intelligent, powerful winged creatures that protected Yahweh's things. Cherubim often symbolize Yahweh's presence.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What makes the sacred objects in your community sacred? If the deity lives in the sacred object, where does the deity live in the object? How do the object and the deity connect to each other? Pause the audio here.

Hophni and Phineas, Eli the priest's two sons, also came to the army camp with the ark of Yahweh's covenant. It is likely that the reason that Hophni and Phineas came was because they were in charge of guarding and taking care of the ark.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who are the people responsible for looking after your community's sacred things? Pause audio here.

When the people carried the ark of Yahweh's covenant into the camp, all the warriors of Israel in the camp shouted a great shout of joy. The shout was so great that it shook the ground all around the warriors.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories of when something has happened during a war that has caused your warriors to feel very courageous. How did the warriors react to the thing that gave the warriors courage? Pause this audio here.

When the Philistines heard Israel's warriors shouting, the Philistines became confused. The Philistines asked each other what the great shout that they heard from the Hebrews' camp meant. At this time, the name Hebrew probably meant anyone who did not originally live in the land of Canaan. When the Philistines call the Israelites Hebrews, the Philistines are insulting the Israelites. When the Philistines found out that the Israelites had brought the ark of Yahweh's covenant into their camp, the Philistines were afraid. The Philistines spoke among themselves and said that gods have come into the camp of the Israelites. The Philistines worshiped many gods and probably thought that the Israelites also worshiped many gods. The Philistines became scared and distressed and said that they were in big trouble because nothing like this had ever happened to the Philistines before. The Philistines were in anguish and said that they were doomed! This means the Philistines thought that the gods that had come into the camp of the Israelites would completely destroy the Philistines. The Philistines asked

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

who would save them from the power of these mighty gods that had struck the Egyptians with many blows in the wilderness. The Philistines used this question to show how helpless the Philistines felt. This shows that the Philistines were not very clear on the details of how Yahweh had delivered the Israelites from Egypt. The Philistines were wrong when they said that the gods of the Israelites struck the Egyptians with many plagues in the wilderness. It was Yahweh, not other gods, who struck the Egyptians with many plagues. And Yahweh struck the Egyptians in Egypt, not in the wilderness.

Stop here and talk about a time when your community went to war and your community believed that your enemies' gods defeated you. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines encouraged one another and said, "Let us act like men and be brave because if we do not fight, the Hebrews will defeat us and they will make us their servants just like they have been our servants." The Philistines did not want to be brought under the power and control of the Israelites.

For this reason, the Philistines fought bravely and defeated the Israelites. The Israelite warriors who survived fled to their tents. This means that the warriors escaped the battle and returned home because the enemy had defeated the Israelites. There was a great slaughter that day. The Philistines killed 30,000 Israelite warriors. The Philistines also took the ark of God and killed Hophni and Phineas, Eli's two sons.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What would your people think and do if an enemy defeated you and took away your sacred objects?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:1b-11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Israel's warriors march out to war against the Philistine warriors, and the Philistines defeat the Israelites.

In the second scene: Israel's remaining warriors return to the camp and tell Israel's elders about the defeat. The elders decide to send messengers to Shiloh to bring the ark of Yahweh's covenant.

In the third scene: The messengers bring the ark from Shiloh to the Israelites' camp at Ebenezer. Eli's sons accompany the ark of the covenant. The people arrive with the ark, and the Israelite warriors who are in the camp shout with very much joy.

In the fourth scene: The Philistines fear much when they hear the Israelites shouting. The Philistines encourage one another to fight courageously so that the Israelites will not defeat the Philistines and make the Philistines slaves.

In the fifth scene: The Philistines fight courageously and defeat the Israelites. The Philistines kill 30,000 Israelite warriors and take the ark of God. The Philistines also kill Hophni and Phinehas, Eli's two sons.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelite warriors
- The Philistine warriors
- Israel's elders
- The messengers, the men that the army sent to bring the ark of the covenant
- And Hophni and Phinehas

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the story's setting:

In the first scene, Israel's warriors went out to war against the Philistines. This means that Israel's warriors came together from their different homes and traveled to the battlefield in an organized way. The battlefield is the land where people fight battles in a war. It is likely that the Israelites followed the instructions of leader-warriors.

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

The Israelite warriors made their war camp at Ebenezer, and the Philistines made their war camp at Aphek. A war camp is a place to settle near the battlefield. Warriors make the final preparations for battle in the war camp. The Philistines sent out their warriors from their war camp to fight against the Israelites. The Philistine warriors took up their positions in organized battle lines against the Israelites. When the warriors began the battle, the Philistines killed 4,000 Israelite warriors from the battle lines and defeated Israel. It is important to remember that these events took place in a military setting. If your language has a word or phrase for orderly battle lines that people use in war, you should use that here.

Stop here and do this activity as a group. Choose one member of the group to be the leader of the fighting men, and have the rest of the group play the role of fighting men. Imagine that you are about to fight an enemy. The leader should organize the rest of the group in fighting formation and give these people instructions on how to fight. Try to organize your fighting men in lines and have them face each other so you can see how the Israelites and Philistines lined up in battle. The leader should use military words as much as possible. The rest of the group may suggest better or more appropriate military words. Repeat this activity with the most suitable military words. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, after the Philistines defeated the Israelites, the Israelite warriors who were not killed returned to their war camp at Ebenezer and told their elders what had happened. Israel's elders could not understand why Yahweh had not helped Israel defeat the Philistines. The elders asked why Yahweh himself had defeated Israel that day before the Philistines. The elders did not expect anyone to answer this question. This question means that the elders believed that Yahweh had not been on Israel's side when Israel fought the war against the Philistines. Israel's elders decided to send messengers to Shiloh to bring the ark of Yahweh's covenant to the battle. The elders probably believed that the reason Yahweh had defeated Israel was that Israel had not brought the ark with them to the war. The elders believed that if the warriors of Israel carried the ark with them into the war, Israel would defeat the Philistines. It is unclear whether the elders believed that Yahweh would save Israel from the hand, or power, of their enemies or whether the elders thought that the ark itself would save Israel. If possible, translate this in a way that keeps this uncertain. But if it is not possible, then it is better to translate it in a way that shows that the elders thought that the ark would save Israel. The hand, or power, of Israel's enemies refers to the control that the Philistines had over Israel.

In the third scene, the messengers who went to Shiloh brought back the ark of the covenant of "Yahweh, who is master of armies and has his throne between the two cherubim." This is Yahweh's full name. Yahweh of armies refers to Yahweh as the leader of the armies of Israel or of the armies of angels. You could translate this title as Yahweh, the all-powerful. That Yahweh has his throne between the two cherubim refers to the two winged creatures that Yahweh asked Moses to make on the cover of the ark of the covenant. The Israelites thought that the top of the ark represented the throne of Yahweh.

Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phineas, also went from Shiloh to Ebenezer with the ark. This is probably because Hophni and Phineas were responsible for the ark. It is likely that Hophni and Phineas were the ones who carried the ark.

When the men brought the ark into the Israelites' camp, all the Israelite warriors who were there shouted a great shout of joy. The sound of the men's shout was so loud that it shook the ground in the place where they were.

In the fourth scene, the Philistine warriors heard the great shout that the Israelite warriors made. The Philistines were greatly troubled and asked one another what the great shout in the Hebrew camp meant. By calling the Israelites Hebrews, the Philistines showed that they felt disgust toward the Israelites because, at this time, people used the name Hebrew to mean foreigner. In your translation, you should not change the name Hebrew to Israelites. You should keep it as Hebrew or express it as closely as possible in your own language.

Stop here and tell stories about a time when foreign tribes or people that your community despises came close to your community. How does your community talk about these people? What kinds of words do people in your community use to describe those people to show how they despise them? Pause the audio here.

The Philistines learned that the Israelites had brought the ark into their camp. So the Philistines were very afraid and said that the gods of the Israelites had come into their camp. And the Philistines said that a great disaster had come upon them because something like this had never happened to the Philistines before. This shows that the Philistines were afraid for themselves and felt threatened by the Israelites. The Philistines asked who would

rescue the Philistines from the power of these mighty gods who had come into the camp of the Israelites. When the Philistines said that they were in big trouble and that they were doomed, the Philistines used two kinds of expressions that people use when they are terribly afraid of disaster or destruction by their enemy.

Stop here and tell stories of times when great disasters have happened to your people. What phrases do you use to express this kind of fear and feeling of doom? Pause audio here.

The Philistines said that these were the same Israelite gods who had struck the Egyptians with many plagues in the wilderness. When translating what the Philistines said, remember that the Philistines believed in many gods and probably thought that the Israelites also believed in many gods.

The Philistines encouraged one another to be strong and act like men so that the Philistines would not become slaves of the Israelites as the Israelites had been to the Philistines. It is likely that the leaders of the Philistine army are the ones who stood up to encourage the Philistines not to be afraid but to be men and fight. When the Philistines told each other to be men and fight, they meant that men, unlike women or children, are brave and successful in battle.

Stop here and discuss as a group how your community encourages your warriors to fight courageously when the warriors are too afraid to fight their enemy. What phrases do you use to encourage people to be brave? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the Philistine warriors reacted to this encouragement and fought the Israelites. The Philistines defeated the Israelites, and the Israelites who survived fled, every man to his own tent. This means that the Israelites who survived gave up fighting. The Philistines killed 30,000 Israelite warriors that day. The Philistines also took the ark of God and killed Hophni and Phineas, Eli's two sons.

Stop here and tell stories about a time when your enemies defeated you in a war. How did your community respond when the enemy defeated your warriors? How did the enemy that defeated you treat you after they defeated you? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:1b-11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelite warriors
- The Philistine warriors
- Israel's elders
- The messengers, the men that the army sent to bring the ark of the covenant
- And Hophni and Phinehas

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Israel's warriors went out to war against the Philistines. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the warriors of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are tired of serving the Philistines. We do not want to follow the Philistines' orders anymore. The Philistines charge us taxes and control our lives; or
- We can defeat the Philistines. Our leaders are sure of it. Our leaders have made a good war plan, and we will surely win.

Continue the drama. The Israelites encamped at Ebenezer, and the Philistines encamped at Aphek. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistine warriors, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The Israelites will regret coming out to war against us. The Israelites have forgotten that we are a very strong nation; or
- These Israelites have forgotten that we rule over them. We must punish the Israelites severely so that they will not think to fight us again.

Continue the drama. The Philistines arranged themselves in battle lines against the Israelites. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistine warriors, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are a skillful and experienced army. Look at how we arrange ourselves; or
- These Israelites are no match for us.

Continue the drama. When the battle began, the Philistine warriors defeated the Israelite warriors and killed 4,000 of them on the battlefield. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite warriors, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Oh, how terrible these Philistine warriors are. We cannot beat the Philistines. The Philistines have killed many of our brothers who have fought bravely; or

Ask the person playing Philistine warriors, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel victorious! We are fighting well and are destroying the Israelites; or
- The Israelites' bodies are all over the battlefield. The Israelites keep fighting but cannot defeat us; or
- We are a superior army. Our warriors fight better than the Israelites' warriors.

Continue the drama. In the second scene, the Israelite warriors who survived the battle returned to their camp at Ebenezer and told the leaders of the Israelites how the battle had gone. The elders of Israel said, "Why has Yahweh defeated us today before the Philistines?" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the elders of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is terrible. So many of our warriors have been killed. What is the reason? We were sure that we would be victorious, but our enemy has defeated us; or
- We must have displeased Yahweh in some way. This is why Yahweh has caused us to be defeated; or
- We must find what has caused Yahweh not to be on our side. We must make Yahweh happy.

Continue the drama. The elders of Israel decided that they should bring the ark of the covenant of Yahweh from Shiloh and bring it to the war so that it might save the Israelites from the hand of the enemy. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the elders of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is the ark! That is where we went wrong. We did not carry the ark with us as our fathers used to. That is the reason we lost the battle; or
- The ark always went before the warriors of Israel in every battle, and the Israelite warriors defeated their enemies. We made a big mistake in leaving the ark of the covenant of Yahweh.

Continue the drama. In the third scene, the army sent messengers to Shiloh and brought the ark of the covenant of Yahweh of hosts who is enthroned above the cherubim. Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phineas, also came with

the ark of Yahweh's covenant. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Desperate! We need the ark or we will all die. Eli will understand that;

Ask the person playing Hophni and Phineas, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We have heard the terrible news regarding the war. This news is very sad; or
- Our father is too old to go with the ark. We shall go with the ark to guard and look after it. This is our duty.

Continue the drama. When the men carried the ark into the camp of the Israelites at Ebenezer, the warriors of Israel shouted and cheered for joy. The warriors made such a great shout that the ground where they stood shook. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the warriors of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are very happy. Our hearts are greatly encouraged. The ark is like a mighty warrior coming into the camp.

Continue the drama. In the fourth scene, the Philistine warriors heard the noise of the great shout that the warriors of Israel made. The Philistine warriors were confused and terrified by the shout and asked each other what the sound meant. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistine warriors, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We heard a mighty shout coming out of the camp of the Hebrews. It sounded like the shout of a victorious army, but we have just defeated the Israelites. What could it be that would cause the Israelites to make such a great shout; or
- What makes these dirty Hebrews, who have just suffered a terrible loss, so excited? What kind of people are these foreigners?"

Continue the drama. In the fifth scene, the Philistines found out that the Israelites had carried the ark into their camp. The Philistines became very afraid and said that gods had come into the Israelites' camp. The Philistines said that this meant a great disaster had come upon them because the Philistines had never in their history experienced something like this before. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel great fear. Our courage has gone. We are in great danger because we have heard that the Israelites have brought gods into their camp. This is terrible news for us. We shall surely be defeated; or
- We have never had to fight against gods before. The Israelites made a great shout because they know that now they will destroy us. The Israelites have the power of the gods. What can we do? or
- Our end has come. We shall be destroyed. This is a great sorrow for us. We feel no hope.

Continue the drama. The Philistines said that they were doomed because the gods that had come into the camp of the Israelites were the same gods who had struck the Egyptians with plagues in the wilderness. The Philistines asked who would save them from the hand of these gods. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We can fight human armies, but how can we fight these gods? Can our swords fight against plagues? What shall we do? Who will fight for us and save us from these gods? or
- We are doomed. These gods will destroy us like they destroyed the Egyptians because we have no one on our side to fight against these gods.

Continue the drama. The Philistines encouraged each other to be strong and to be men and fight. The Philistines said that if they did not fight, then the Israelites would make the Philistines serve the Israelites, just as the Israelites served the Philistines before. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We must stand strong. We must be brave. We cannot give up now. If we are too afraid to fight because of these gods, then the Israelites will certainly defeat us and rule over us; or
- Every Philistine warrior must be brave and be a man. We must not lose hope.

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

Continue the drama. In the fifth scene, the Philistine warriors fought courageously and defeated the Israelites. The Philistines killed 30,000 fighting men of Israel. The rest of the warriors of Israel who were not killed fled from the battle, and each man returned to his own tent. The Philistines captured the ark and killed Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phineas. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the warriors of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The ark did not help us. The elders of Israel were wrong. What hope is there? We cannot continue fighting; or

Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are a mighty army. The Philistine warriors have fought with gods and have conquered them.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:1b-11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Israel went out to battle against the Philistines. The Philistines were a nation of people who came by boat and settled in parts of the land of Canaan before the Israelites came to Canaan. The Philistines became the Israelites' enemies and fought many battles with the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Philistines**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When the battle began, the Philistines defeated the Israelites and killed 4,000 Israelite warriors. The remaining Israelite warriors who were not killed returned to the camp and told the elders what had happened. An elder is a person with authority in the community. An elder was usually the head of a family or a group of families. A group of elders would meet together to make decisions about the affairs in the community. When you are translating this word, be careful that you do not use a word that just means "old people." An elder was not necessarily an old person, though an elder would not be a very young person either.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **elders**. Look up elder in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The elders decided that people needed to bring the ark of God from Shiloh to the war. The "ark of God" refers to the oblong chest that God asked Moses to make from acacia wood. The ark was 115x69x69 centimeters and people covered the ark inside and outside with gold. The ark contained the tablets that Yahweh gave to Moses with the law on them, a pot of manna, and Aaron's rod that had budded.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the general term for **God**, and for the **ark of God**. Look up the ark of the covenant in the Master Glossary for more information. In this story, the storyteller calls the ark by three different names: the "ark of God," the "ark of the covenant of Yahweh," and the "ark of Yahweh." Pause this audio here.

So the elders sent messengers to Shiloh to bring the ark of the covenant of Yahweh of hosts, who dwells between the cherubim. "Yahweh of hosts who dwells between the cherubim" is one of Yahweh's full titles, and you should translate this title in one sentence.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Yahweh of hosts who dwells between the cherubim**. Look up Yahweh of hosts in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Cherubim were some sort of intelligent, powerful angelic beings. Cherubim guard sacred places. Cherubim often symbolize Yahweh's presence. Cherubim have the body of a lion, the wings of a bird, and the face of a human.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cherubim**. Look up cherubim in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

When people carried the ark of Yahweh's covenant into the Israelite camp, the Israelite warriors who were there shouted a great shout. When the Philistines heard the shout, the Philistines asked what the noise in the camp of the Hebrews was. "Hebrew" is the name of the people group who are Abraham's descendants, but it is also the name of the language that this people group spoke. The descendants of Abraham often referred to themselves as Hebrews when they were talking with foreigners. When an Israelite wanted to distinguish himself from a person of another ethnic group, he called himself a "Hebrew." Also, when a foreigner wanted to distinguish himself from an Israelite, the foreigner called that Israelite a "Hebrew." When the Philistines called the Israelites Hebrews, the Philistines meant it as an insulting name. Translators should not use the word Israelite where the storyteller uses the word Hebrew.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Hebrews**. Look up Hebrews in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When the Philistines found out that the Israelites had brought the ark of Yahweh's covenant into their camp, the Philistines said that these were the gods that struck the Egyptians with plagues in the wilderness. Plagues refer to afflictions that Yahweh sent on the people. Yahweh judged Egypt with many different plagues.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **gods** and **plagues**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Wilderness refers to a lonely, barren place without water. Almost no trees or bushes grow in the wilderness. The ground is dry and rocky, and wild animals roam around in the wilderness. People do not live in the wilderness.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wilderness**. Look up wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 4:1b–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (824 KB)

- Setting the Stage (7.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 Samuel 4:12–22

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 4:12–22 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:12–22 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:12–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, the Philistines killed many Israelite warriors and defeated the Israelites in battle. The Philistines also killed Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phineas, and the Philistines took the ark of Yahweh's covenant.

In this story, a certain man from the tribe of Benjamin escaped from the battle where the two armies fought. On that same day, that man ran to Shiloh. The distance from Ebenezer to Shiloh is about 30 kilometers. It was common for messengers to run great distances to deliver news. The man had torn his clothes and put dirt on his head. This is how the Israelites showed their sorrow.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of things do people in your culture do when they feel deep sorrow? Pause this audio here.

At the time when the man entered Shiloh, Eli the priest was sitting on his seat watching the road. Shiloh is the town where the Israelites set up the tabernacle before the time when Israel's tribes divided into two separate kingdoms. Eli was sitting on his seat by the roadside at the city gate, which refers to a door or opening in the wall that goes around the city. It is likely that Eli was sitting here so that he could listen to hear the warriors of Israel returning because he was worried for the ark.

Stop here and look at a picture of a city gate as a group. Pause this audio here.

Eli was blind and could not see, but Eli was waiting nervously. Eli's heart trembled for the ark. This means that Eli was anxious about the ark because the Israelite warriors had taken it with them to battle. Eli was not watching with his eyes because Eli was blind. Eli was waiting with a worried and trembling heart because Eli was afraid that the ark was not safe.

The man from the tribe of Benjamin entered the city and began to tell the people in the city what had happened to the Israelite army in the war against the Philistines. All the people cried out in horror when the people heard the report.

1 Samuel 4:12–22

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell about a time when someone told your community very bad news. How did the people react? For example, how would your community react to the death of the most important person in their community? Pause this audio here.

Eli heard the sound of the people in the city crying. Eli called out and asked why the people were making so much noise. Just then, the man hurried and told Eli the news.

The storyteller interrupts the action of the story with more information about Eli. The storyteller tells us that Eli was 98 years old, and Eli's eyes were fixed so that they could not see. This means that Eli was blind. We know that the rest of the people could see how the Benjamite man had torn his clothes and put dust on his head. But because Eli was old and blind, Eli would not understand what was happening. The storyteller may also tell us that Eli is very old to help us understand why Eli dies suddenly.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories about old people in your community who died suddenly when no one expected them to die. Pause this audio here.

The Benjamite man told Eli that he was the man who had come from the battle. Because Eli was blind and could not see the man's torn clothes or the dust on the man's head, Eli would not have immediately known that the Israelites had lost the battle. The man repeated that he was the man who had fled from the battle line that same day. This does not mean that the man ran away from the battle. This means that the man ran to Shiloh after the battle was over and the Philistines had defeated the Israelites. Eli asked the man what had happened. Eli called the man Eli's son. This is probably because Eli felt very anxious and afraid of the news Eli was about to hear. It is also possible that the man found it difficult to tell Eli the tragic news, and Eli wanted to encourage the man to speak.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone brought terrible news to your community. Who did the person who brought the bad news speak to, and how did that person speak? Pause audio here.

The man told Eli the news in three parts. The man told Eli that Israel's army had run away from the Philistines and had suffered a great defeat. This means that the Philistines had defeated Israel and killed many of their warriors. The man said that the Philistines had also killed Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phineas. The man also told Eli that the Philistines had even taken the ark of God. As soon as the man told Eli that the Philistines had taken the ark, Eli fell backwards from his seat, which was by the side of the city gate.

Because Eli was an old and heavy man, when Eli fell backwards, the bones of Eli's neck broke and Eli died. Eli had judged Israel for 40 years. This means that the period of Eli being Israel's judge had come to an end. Forty years represents a generation. It is possible that the number 40 is not an exact number for the years that Eli judged Israel. Judges were the leaders of the people of Israel. Yahweh gave the people of Israel many judges at different times. The judges guided the people of Israel and sometimes saved the Israelites from their enemies. A judge acted like a chief or great elder of the community.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who settles disputes between people in your community? What other roles does this person have, and how does your community select this person? What happens when a judge, or someone like a judge, dies? Pause this audio here.

At that same time, Eli's daughter-in-law, the wife of Eli's son Phineas, was pregnant and near her time to give birth. Phineas' wife heard that the Philistines had captured the ark of God's covenant and killed her father-in-law, Eli, and her husband, Phineas. When Phineas' wife heard this news, the pains of giving birth overwhelmed her, and she bowed and gave birth to a baby. Israelite women gave birth by bowing or kneeling down on their knees.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do women in your culture give birth? Who helps the women give birth? What would happen to a woman who gave birth in the middle of the night or in a situation where she could not reach medical professionals? Pause audio here.

Eli's daughter-in-law had a difficult delivery of her baby, but the women who helped her give birth tried to encourage her and comfort her by telling her that she had given birth to a son. The birth of a son usually made the Israelite families greatly rejoice.

1 Samuel 4:12–22

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What happens when a son is born in your community, rather than a daughter? Who names the newborn child, and when and how do they name the child? Pause this audio here.

The other women wanted this announcement to help Phineas' wife be strong and recover. But Phineas' wife did not answer the other women or pay any attention to their words of comfort. This means that Phineas' wife did not recover her strength but rather that she died in childbirth. As Phineas' wife was dying, she named the boy that she had given birth to Ichabod. It was usual for a mother to name her child as soon as it was born. It was also normal for the mother to give the child a name that reflected the circumstances of the child's birth. Ichabod means "no glory." Phineas' wife called the child Ichabod because she said that the glory had gone from Israel. Phineas' wife's last words show the sorrow that she felt because the Philistines had captured the ark of Yahweh and killed her father-in-law and husband. Phineas' wife said that the glory had gone from Israel because the Philistines had taken the ark of Yahweh's covenant. Phineas' wife probably meant that Yahweh himself, or Yahweh's glory and majesty, had left Israel and gone to live in the Philistines' country with the ark. Phineas' wife probably thought this way because Yahweh's glory lived above the ark.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the most sacred object in your community? What would people in your community think if your enemy took this object?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:12–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: A certain Benjamite man survives the battle and runs from the place where the Israelites fought the battle to Shiloh to tell the news to Eli the priest and the people of Shiloh.

In the second scene: The man enters Shiloh and begins to tell the news of the battle to the people in the city. When the people hear the news, the people cry loudly.

In the third scene: Eli hears the people crying. Eli calls out and asks why people are making this noise. The man runs and tells Eli that the Philistines defeated Israel, killed Eli's two sons, and even took the ark of Yahweh's covenant. When Eli hears the news about the ark, Eli falls back on his chair and dies.

In the fourth scene: Eli's daughter-in-law is pregnant and about to give birth. When the woman hears the news, her birth pains come to her and overwhelm her. The woman gives birth to a boy, names the boy Ichabod, and then dies.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Benjamite messenger
- The people of Shiloh
- Eli
- Eli's daughter-in-law, the wife of Phineas
- The women who helped Phineas' wife give birth
- The Philistine army
- The Israelite army
- Hophni
- Phinehas
- And Ichabod

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the same day that the Philistines defeated Israel, a certain Benjamite man escaped and ran from the battle line to Shiloh. Shiloh is a town located within the hill country of Ephraim. This was where the Israelites set up the tabernacle before the time when Israel's tribes divided into two separate kingdoms. That the man ran from the battle line does not mean that he did not fight. This means that after the Philistines had

killed the other Israelites in the battle, this man was still alive, so the man ran away from the battlefield. Battle line is a military word that refers to the place where the armies fought the battle.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone escaped a war or a dangerous situation and returned to tell the news. Pause the audio here.

The messenger is from the tribe of Benjamin. The storyteller probably tells us that the messenger is a Benjamite because Yahweh will take the leadership of Israel from Eli and then later give it to Saul, who is a Benjamite. The Benjamite man had torn his clothes and put dirt on his head. An Israelite would do this to show their sorrow when a great disaster had happened. If the idea of the man with torn clothes and dirt on his head does not communicate sorrow in your culture, it might be good to add that he did it to show his great sorrow.

When the man arrived, Eli was sitting on his seat by the side of the road at the city gate. Eli was watching the road because his heart trembled for the ark of Yahweh. This does not mean that Eli was watching with his eyes. It means that Eli was waiting anxiously because Eli was afraid that something bad had happened to the ark. When the Israelites talk of feeling strong emotions, they talk as if the people feel the emotions in their heart. Other cultures and people groups may speak of feeling their strong emotion in other parts of their bodies, such as the kidneys.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, which part of the body do people see as the place where people feel strong emotions? Talk about a time when you were very afraid and anxious to hear news about something. Pay attention to the words you use to describe your feelings. Pause this audio here.

Now the storyteller switches the focus of the story from the messenger to Eli. At the same time the man arrived, Eli was sitting by the side of the road at the city gate. However, the man tells the news to the people in the city before he tells it to Eli. This may be because the man entered the city by a different gate from the one Eli was sitting at. Or maybe the man just passed by Eli without talking to Eli.

In the second scene, the man entered the city and began to tell the news to the people the man met. The man did not speak to everyone in the city together but told the news to the people as he went through the city. It is likely that the man shouted the news sorrowfully as he made his way through the city.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Choose one person to be a messenger with news about the results of a war that your warriors are fighting in. Let the rest of the group play various members of the community, and let them be busy in their daily routine. Spread the group members around an area so that they are not all in one place. This area will be the city. Then make the messenger come into the city hurriedly. Let the messenger show grief and sorrow the way your community shows grief and sorrow. The messenger should announce the bad news to the first person the messenger sees, and that person should react to the news in the way that your community reacts to a great disaster. That person's reaction should draw the attention of the other members of the community, one by one, and each person should respond until the news has spread to the entire city. Pause audio here.

This news caused the whole city to cry out. This means that all of the people in the city shouted in horror, sadness, and fear.

In the third scene, Eli heard the noise the people made and called out and asked what the noise was. Eli was already worried and anxious about the ark. When Eli heard the noise in the city, the noise probably increased the fear and anxiety that the blind man already felt. Just as Eli called out and asked what the noise was, the man hurried and told Eli the news. The man did not come to Eli because Eli called. Instead, the man happened to come to the place where Eli was seated just at the right time.

Stop here and discuss a time when people in your community mourned or felt great sadness. What words or phrases do you use to describe how people behaved and the noise people made? Pause audio here.

The storyteller slows down the action of the story by adding information about Eli's age and eyesight. Eli was 98 years old, and his eyes were fixed so that he could not see. Eli had probably become blind because of his great old age. If it is more natural in your language, you could put this information about Eli at the beginning of this story when the storyteller first introduces Eli sitting on his seat watching the road. The Benjamite man told Eli that the Benjamite was the man who had come from the battle line. The Benjamite man repeated his words to

1 Samuel 4:12–22

Eli and added that he had fled from the battle line that same day. The Benjamite man probably did this because he realized that the blind Eli could not tell that the messenger had come with bad news. When Eli understood that the man had come from the battle line, where Eli's sons had taken the ark, Eli asked the man what had happened. Eli called the man "son," probably because Eli felt distressed in his heart by the news he expected to hear regarding the ark. It is also likely that Eli felt the man hesitate to tell Eli the bad news, so Eli may have called the man "son" to encourage the man to speak.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Choose one person to play the role of Eli and another to play the role of the messenger. Let the person playing the messenger hesitate to deliver the news to Eli, and have Eli encourage the man to speak. Pay attention to the word that the person playing Eli uses for "son." The rest of the group may suggest a more appropriate word in your language. Pause audio here.

The messenger delivered the news to Eli in three parts. Each part of the news is more important than the last and adds to the great impact of the last part of the news. The messenger told Eli that Israel had fled before the Philistines and had suffered many losses. This means that the Philistines had defeated Israel and had also killed many of Israel's warriors. The messenger told Eli that the Philistines had killed Hophni and Phineas and even captured the ark of Yahweh's covenant. As soon as Eli heard that the Philistines had captured the ark, Eli fell backward on his chair towards the side of the gate. This shows that Eli was more concerned about the ark of Yahweh than the defeat of Israel or the death of Eli's sons. Because Eli was an old and heavy man, when Eli fell back on his chair, the bones in Eli's neck broke, and Eli died.

Eli had judged Israel for 40 years. Forty years is a general number of years for one generation. It is possible that the exact number of years that Eli led Israel was more or less than 40.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have one person be a messenger with this three-part message or a similar three-part message. Let this person deliver the news to another person with the rest of the group watching. The rest of the group should pay attention to the words that this person uses to join the parts of the message. When this person finishes speaking, the rest of the group should suggest phrases the person can use to show that the news goes from bad to worse. At the same time, the person receiving the news should listen intently and show a reaction to the first and second parts of the news. When the messenger tells the last part of the message, the receiver should react by showing great shock or horror and falling backwards as if someone had hit them and caused them to die. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, Eli's daughter-in-law was at the same time pregnant and ready to give birth. This means that Eli's daughter-in-law was close to her day of giving birth, not that she was at that moment in the process of giving birth. Although the storyteller switches the focus of the story from Eli to his daughter-in-law, the storyteller still emphasizes her connection to Eli. Another way of bringing out this connection with Eli would be to call her the wife of Eli's son Phineas.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss the way your community refers to pregnant women. What do you call a woman who is very close to giving birth? Pause the audio here.

Eli's daughter-in-law heard the news that the ark of Yahweh's covenant had been captured and that her father-in-law and her husband were dead. Immediately, when Eli's daughter-in-law heard this news, the pains of labor came to her and overwhelmed her. This means that although Eli's daughter-in-law was close to the day of giving birth, the shock of hearing the news actually caused her labor pains. So Eli's daughter-in-law knelt down and gave birth. This is the way that Israelite women gave birth.

Stop here and tell a story about a woman giving birth. Pay attention to the phrases you use to describe her giving birth. Pause the audio here,

When Eli's daughter-in-law was about to die, the women who helped her tried to comfort her by telling her that she had given birth to a son. But Eli's daughter-in-law did not pay attention to the women or receive their comfort.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What phrases would women in your community use to encourage a woman who is dying in childbirth to strengthen herself? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 4:12–22

Eli's daughter-in-law called the boy Ichabod, which means "no glory." Eli's daughter-in-law said she called the boy this name because the glory had departed Israel. The Israelites believed that Yahweh's glory, or Yahweh himself, lived above the ark of the covenant. Because the ark had left Israel, the Israelites would feel like Yahweh himself had left them and gone into the land of the Philistines. Eli's daughter-in-law spoke these words because the Philistines had captured the ark and taken it out of Israel, and because both her father-in-law and her husband were dead.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is a sign in your community that God is with you? Pause audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:12–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Benjamite messenger
- The people of Shiloh
- Eli
- Eli's daughter-in-law, the wife of Phineas
- The women who helped Phineas' wife give birth
- The Philistine army
- The Israelite army
- Hophni
- Phinehas
- And Ichabod

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, a certain Benjamite man escaped and ran from the battle line to Shiloh. The man had torn his clothes and put dirt on his head. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing The Benjamite messenger, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel great sorrow, grief, and anguish. This is a great disaster. Our enemy has defeated us; or
- This is the worst day for our nation. Our enemies have taken Yahweh's throne. Yahweh's presence is gone with the ark; or
- What shall be done for us now? I must run to Shiloh and tell Eli the priest. Surely Eli will know what to do.

Continue the drama. When the man arrived, right at that moment Eli was seated on his seat beside the road waiting anxiously. Eli's heart was anxious about the ark of God. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

1 Samuel 4:12–22

- My heart is in great trouble. I have no peace. I am very worried about the ark. I keep listening to hear the army return, but I hear nothing; or
- The ark is Yahweh's dwelling place. The ark is where I meet Yahweh. Without the ark, how can we worship Yahweh? or
- What will happen to Yahweh's covenant with the people of Israel if we lose the ark? Why did I let the people take the ark to this war? Why did I not refuse the elders' request?

Continue the drama. In the second scene, the man entered the city of Shiloh and began to tell the people there the news about the war. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Benjamite messenger, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel panic, fear, and anguish. I am confused and heartbroken. I do not know what to do.

Continue the drama. When the people in the city heard the news, the whole city cried out. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Shiloh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is a disaster. A very great disaster has happened to us today; or
- This is the death of the people of Israel. Without the ark of the covenant of Yahweh, Yahweh will not dwell with us. We are all alone. Our enemy has conquered us now. What hope is there anymore?

Continue the drama. In the third scene, Eli heard the sound of the people's cry and called out and asked what the noise meant. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel frightened; or
- What is happening? Is someone attacking us? Has the army returned? Who will tell me what is going on? or
- I need help! I need someone to explain what is happening. I cannot see. This noise I hear does not sound good.

Continue the drama. Just then, the Benjamite man hurried and told Eli the news. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Benjamite messenger, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Here is Eli! What will he do when he hears? Now that I see the priest of Israel, my heart is even more broken for the loss of the ark. What a great evil has happened in Israel today. I pray Eli knows what to do. Maybe Eli can pray to Yahweh and get the ark back.

Continue the drama. Eli was 98 years old, and Eli's eyes had set so that he could not see. The Benjamite messenger told Eli that the messenger had just fled from the battle that same day. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very scared. I hear the noise, but I cannot see. I am unable to tell what is happening; or
- I feel very vulnerable. I cannot move as easily as I used to when I was younger, and I cannot see. I need a young man to lead me by the hand. If I were able, I would have gone to Ebenezer myself.

Ask the person playing the Benjamite, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These are the most heartbreaking words I have ever spoken in my life; or
- I am afraid to tell this old man the horrible thing that has happened to our nation today. How do you share such horrible news?

Continue the drama. Eli asked the Benjamite what had happened. The Benjamite messenger told Eli that the Philistines had defeated Israel and killed many of their warriors, and that Eli's two sons were dead and that the Philistines had even taken the ark of Yahweh's covenant. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The Philistines have defeated Israel and killed many warriors in battle. My heart is heavy with fear for the ark; or
- Oh no! The ark! We are doomed! Israel is destroyed! Our end has come. Without the ark, what are we? What am I? I have failed Yahweh by letting the ark go to war without asking Yahweh.

Continue the drama. When Eli heard that the Philistines had taken the ark, Eli fell backwards on his chair by the city gate and broke his neck and died because he was an old and heavy man. Eli had judged Israel for 40 years.

1 Samuel 4:12–22

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Benjamite, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I have killed the priest. The news I have delivered has surely killed the priest; or
- This day is the worst day that has ever been. The ark is gone, and the priest is dead. Who will help us now?

Ask the person playing the people of Shiloh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Who shall lead us now? Who will tell us what we must do? or
- Who will take Eli’s place? Eli’s sons are also dead. And even if Eli’s sons had not died, how could they lead us without the ark? Where would they meet with Yahweh?

Continue the drama. In the fourth scene, Eli’s daughter-in-law was pregnant near her time to give birth. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli’s daughter-in-law, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy. Any day now, I will have my baby. I pray that my baby is a boy. My husband will be very happy; or
- I pray for a safe birth and that the baby will be born healthy. I also pray that my husband will return from Ebenezer. My husband will be so happy when the child is born. I pray that the child is a boy.

Continue the drama. When Eli’s daughter-in-law heard the news that people had captured the ark of Yahweh’s covenant and that her father-in-law and her husband were dead, the pains of giving birth came to her, and she gave birth. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eli’s daughter-in-law, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I cannot breathe. The shock I feel is too great. My life is over. Israel is finished; or
- My heart is broken by this news. How can such terrible things happen in one day?

Continue the drama. When Eli’s daughter-in-law was at the point of death, the women who helped her tried to comfort her by telling her that she had given birth to a son. But Eli’s daughter-in-law did not respond or pay any attention. Eli’s daughter-in-law named the boy Ichabod because she said that the glory had departed from Israel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the women who helped Eli’s daughter-in-law give birth, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This is so sad. Our hearts are broken for her and for her son and for the house of Eli; or
- Yahweh is no longer with us. Israel is left alone; or
- Yahweh is now in the land of the Philistines with the ark. We are all alone.

Continue the drama. Eli’s daughter-in-law spoke these words because the Philistines had captured the ark of God, and because her father-in-law and her husband had died. Eli’s daughter-in-law said the glory had departed because the ark of Yahweh’s covenant had been captured.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 4:12–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

That same day, a **Benjamite** ran from the battle line and went to Shiloh. A Benjamite refers to someone who is from the tribe of Benjamin, one of the 12 sons of Jacob. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Battle line is a military term that refers to the place where two armies meet for battle. This is where the armies actually do the fighting. If your language uses military terms, it is better to use them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **battle line**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 4:12–22

The Benjamite man had torn his clothes and put dust on his head. The people of Israel tore their clothes when they felt great sorrow. The people of Israel also put dust on their heads to publicly show that they were mourning. If this custom of the people of Israel is difficult to understand in your language, you may want to say the reason in your translation. For example, you could say, “to show his grief, he had torn his clothes and put dirt on his head.”

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **torn his clothes** and **put dust on his head**. Pause this audio here.

When the man arrived, Eli was sitting on his seat by the side of the road, watching, because Eli’s heart trembled for the ark of Yahweh. “Watching” means that Eli was waiting anxiously. Use a word that is natural in your language to describe a blind person waiting nervously and listening in order to find out whether the thing he is worried about has happened.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **watching**. Pause this audio here.

That Eli’s “heart trembled” is a phrase that means that Eli was feeling anxious, scared, or worried. If your culture considers another part of the body to be the place of emotion, it is okay to use that part instead of heart.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for Eli’s **heart trembling**. The word “heart” is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Eli was 98 years old, and his “eyes were set” so that he could not see. This means that Eli was blind. The lenses of Eli’s eyes were clouded so that Eli could not see through them.

Stop here and discuss the words and phrases you use in your language to say that a person is blind and unable to see. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **eyes were set**. Pause audio here.

The man told Eli that he had fled from the battle line that same day. The man told Eli the news that the Philistines had defeated Israel, killed both of Eli’s sons, and even taken the **ark of God**. The people do not call Yahweh by his name in this phrase. The people call Yahweh by a name that means that Yahweh is the most powerful spiritual being who created the universe. The Israelites believed that Yahweh literally lived in the space directly above the ark, so the ark came to symbolize Yahweh’s presence. Use the same word for God and “ark of God” that you used in previous passages. Both God and “ark of God” are in the Master Glossary.

As soon as the man mentioned the ark of Yahweh, Eli fell back on his chair by the side of the city gate. Because Eli was old and heavy, when Eli fell, the bones of Eli’s neck broke and he died. Eli had judged Israel for 40 years.

Look up **judge** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Eli’s daughter-in-law, the wife of Eli’s son Phineas, was pregnant and about to give birth. When Eli’s daughter-in-law heard the news regarding the ark and her father-in-law and husband, her labor pains overcame her, and she gave birth. As she was dying, Eli’s daughter-in-law named the boy that she had given birth to Ichabod, which means “no glory.” Eli’s daughter-in-law said the glory had departed from Israel. Eli’s daughter-in-law was referring to the ark of God that the Philistines had taken and the death of her husband and father-in-law. Glory refers to the power and splendor of Yahweh. It can also refer to Yahweh’s presence.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **glory**. Look up glory in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 4:12–22

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (838 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1013 KB)

1 Samuel 5:1–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 5:1–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 5:1–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 5:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, the storyteller told us what happened in Israel after the battle. A certain Benjamite man ran from the battle line and went to Shiloh. This man told the people in the city and the priest Eli how the Philistines had defeated Israel in battle, killed Eli's sons, and taken the ark of God. When Eli heard the news about the ark, Eli fell backwards on his chair and died.

In this story, we hear what the Philistines did after the battle. The storyteller uses the general title for God most of the time. The story starts at the end of the battle. After the Philistines captured the ark of God, the Philistines

1 Samuel 5:1–12

took the ark with them from Ebenezer to Ashdod. The Philistines probably believed that they were taking the God of the Israelites. In wars, the winners usually took the gods of their enemies to show that they had completely defeated the enemy and the enemy's gods.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What things do you do in battle to show that you have been victorious over your enemies and their gods? Pause this audio here.

The land of the Philistines was made up of five cities that had united politically, commercially, and militarily. Each of the five cities had its own ruler. Ashdod was one of these five Philistine cities. Ashdod was about 56 kilometers from Ebenezer, where the armies fought the battle.

Stop here and look at a map of Philistia as a group. Consider the distance from Ebenezer to each of the five cities of the Philistines and discuss why you think they chose to take the ark to Ashdod. How are the people of your tribe, culture, and language spread out throughout the country you live in? Pause this audio here.

When the Philistines arrived in Ashdod, they carried the ark of God into the temple of Dagon, the Philistines' chief god. Dagon's temple was the place where the Philistines worshiped Dagon and placed Dagon's idol or image. Many different nations and people groups worshiped Dagon. The Philistines probably worshiped Dagon as a god of seed, plants, and crops, whereas other nations worshiped Dagon for different reasons. The Philistines worshiped many gods, but Dagon was their main god. In cultures where people worship many gods, people usually honor one of the gods more than the rest.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If your ancestors worshiped more than one god, tell of the kind of sacrifices that your ancestors gave to these gods. If your ancestors did not worship more than one god, talk about a neighboring community that did. Which of these gods do you think received the greatest honor or worship, and why? Pause this audio here.

The Philistines placed the ark of God beside the statue of Dagon. A statue is an image or figure of solid material like wood, metal, or stone. People make an image of a god and worship that image as if it were that god. Such an image could look like a person, or like an animal, or just have any different shape. Dagon's image probably had a human body, with a head and hands, but the tail of a fish.

Stop here and look at an illustration of the image of Dagon. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe the images of the gods that your community or communities around you worship, and where people worship and keep these images. Pause audio here.

It was normal at this time for two nations that were fighting one another to believe that the gods that they each worshiped were also fighting each other. The Philistines took the ark of God and set it beside their god Dagon to show that Dagon had defeated the God of the Israelites. It is also possible that the Philistines put the ark of God next to Dagon as an offering to Dagon because they believed that Dagon had helped them to defeat the Israelites. The Philistines likely believed that Dagon would now control the God of Israel just as the Philistines controlled the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when your community honored God for giving victory in war. What does your community think of the gods of your enemies who have defeated you in battle? And what does your community think of the gods of the enemies that you have defeated? Pause this audio here.

The people of Ashdod woke up early the next morning, went into the temple of Dagon, and found that the idol of Dagon had fallen on its face before the ark of Yahweh. This means that Dagon was in a posture of worship before the ark of Yahweh. So some of the Philistines lifted Dagon up and put him back in his place. Yet when the Philistines came back in again early the next morning, the Philistines found that Dagon had again fallen on his face before the ark of Yahweh and also that his head and his hands had broken off and were lying at the threshold or entrance of the temple. Only the main part of the body or the trunk of Dagon remained unbroken. During war, the winners would sometimes cut off the heads and hands of their enemies to show their victory. Perhaps Yahweh is showing that Yahweh has victory over the Philistine god Dagon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What gestures do you use to show honor and respect to older or greater people in your culture? Tell stories of times when gods have fought each other. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

Because of what happened, the Philistines started a new custom. This custom was that none of the Philistine priests or any Philistine who went into the temple of Dagon walked on the threshold. People respected the threshold because it separated the world from the sacred place inside the temple. But now the people showed the threshold even more respect. Because Dagon's head and hands had fallen there, people no longer wanted to step on the threshold.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some places that people restrict in your culture, and why do they restrict them? Pause this audio here.

The hand of Yahweh was heavy upon the people of the city of Ashdod and its villages. In other words, Yahweh used his power to harm the people of Ashdod by giving them tumors. Tumors are swellings or growths on the skin. This is likely a disease that rats spread widely and quickly among people. This disease causes ugly and painful swellings on the skin and kills many people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell about a time when a fast-spreading, deadly disease affected your community. Where did your people say it came from, and why did it come? Pause this audio here.

When the people of Ashdod realized what was happening, the people said that the ark of the God had to leave their city because the God of the Israelites was punishing the people and their god Dagon. Although the Philistines did not worship Yahweh or believe that Yahweh was the only true God, the Philistines knew that Yahweh had genuine power because they said Yahweh was punishing them and their god. So the Philistines called together their five rulers and asked the rulers what they should do with the ark of the God of the Israelites. The rulers told the people to bring the ark to another of the five main cities, Gath. Gath was 19 kilometers to the east of Ashdod.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who governs the people of your tribe, culture, and language in the places they live around the country? What happens when there is an issue that affects all of the people? Pause audio here.

After some of the Philistines had brought the ark to Gath, the hand, or power, of Yahweh was against that city and caused a great panic or chaos and confusion there. Yahweh used his power to punish the people of Gath as he had in Ashdod. Yahweh attacked all the people of Gath, both young people and old people, with an outbreak of tumors.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When your community was affected by the fast-spreading and deadly disease, how did the people feel and behave? Pause audio here.

So the people of Gath sent the ark of Yahweh to Ekron, another of the five Philistine cities. Ekron was about 19 kilometers to the northeast of Ashdod. Of all the cities of the Philistines, Ekron was the closest to the land of the Israelites. But as the people of Gath were carrying the ark of God into the city of Ekron, the people of Ekron protested. The people of Ekron said that the people of Gath were bringing the ark of the God of the Israelites into their city to kill them. The people of Ekron thought that the ark itself would kill them. The people of Ekron called together the leaders of the cities of the Philistines and told the leaders to tell some men to take the ark of the God of Israel back to its own place. The people said that if they did not return the ark to its own country, the ark would kill them and their people. The people said this because there was a deadly panic throughout the city, because Yahweh was attacking them severely. The people were very afraid of dying because Yahweh had killed many people there. It is likely that Yahweh attacked the city of Ekron more severely than Ashdod and Gath because the Philistines were responding to Yahweh's previous attacks by trying to keep the ark rather than returning to the Israelites. The cry of the city went up to heaven. This means that the people of Ekron prayed desperately for help. It is likely that the people prayed to their own gods.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when you think God punished your community. What did the punishment look like, and what did you do about the punishment?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 5:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The Philistines took the ark that they had captured from the Israelites and brought it with them from Ebenezer to one of their five cities, Ashdod. The Philistines carried the ark into the temple of Dagon and set it up beside the idol of Dagon.

In the second scene: When the people of Ashdod rose up early the next morning, the people found the idol of Dagon had fallen on its face before the ark of Yahweh. So they took Dagon and put him back in his place.

In the third scene: The following morning, the people of Ashdod rose up early and found Dagon fallen on his face before the ark of Yahweh. Dagon's head and hands had been cut off and were lying on the threshold of Dagon's temple.

In the fourth scene: Yahweh attacked the people of Ashdod and its villages by punishing the people with tumors. When the people of Ashdod realized what was happening, the people said that the ark of the God of the Israelites could not remain in Ashdod because the hand of the God of the Israelites was powerful against them and their god Dagon. So the people sent and gathered the rulers of the cities of the Philistines and asked the rulers what they should do.

In the fifth scene: The rulers of the cities of the Philistines decided to send the ark of the God of Israel to Gath, another Philistine city. When the people brought the ark to Gath, the hand of Yahweh was powerful against the people of Gath, and the people of Gath panicked. Yahweh attacked the people of Gath, both young and old, with tumors.

In the sixth scene: The people of Gath sent the ark to Ekron, but the people of Ekron protested against the other people bringing the ark into their city. The people of Ekron were afraid that the ark would kill them. So the people of Ekron called together the rulers of the cities of the Philistines and told them to send the ark away, back to Israel. A great panic had filled the hearts of the people of Ekron because the people were attacked with tumors, and many people had died there. The people wept and prayed for help.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Dagon
- The Philistine warriors
- The people of Ashdod
- The people of Gath
- The people of Ekron
- The rulers of the cities of the Philistines
- And the priests of Dagon

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story takes place after the battle that the Philistines and the Israelites fought against each other at Ebenezer. The setting of the story is in the land of the Philistines. In the first scene, after the Philistines captured the ark, the Philistines carried the ark of God with them from Ebenezer to Ashdod. The Philistines referred to the ark as the "ark of God" rather than the ark of Yahweh. The Philistines probably said this because they did not know the name Yahweh, the personal name for the Israelites' God. Therefore, the Philistines used a more general name for God. The more general name for God refers to the creator or a powerful spiritual being.

The Philistines carried the ark of God into the temple of Dagon, the Philistines' main god, and set the ark beside the statue of Dagon. Throughout this story, the storyteller talks about the statue of Dagon as if it were a real, living being, even though it is just a statue.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you speak of a non-living object as if it is alive? Pause audio here.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

The second scene begins the next morning. The people of Ashdod rose up early in the morning and went into the temple of Dagon. When the people looked inside, there was Dagon fallen on his face before the ark of Yahweh. The phrase “there was Dagon” calls attention to the scene and shows that the Philistines were surprised and alarmed to find Dagon on his face before the ark of Yahweh. Remember that there was no one in the temple overnight and that the Philistines found Dagon in a posture of adoration before Yahweh. Therefore, the Philistines were very surprised by this sight.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Imagine that you are busy with your daily tasks. One member of the group sees something amazing or terrifying. That person wants to alert the rest of the group. Make that person stand at a small distance and shout out to the rest of the group, calling their attention to the surprising thing. Pay attention to the words or phrases the person uses to call the people’s attention to the surprising thing. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller uses the personal name Yahweh to tell us that Dagon has fallen on his face before Yahweh. The storyteller is probably reminding us that the war between the Philistines and the Israelites is really about war between Yahweh, the God of the Israelites, and Dagon, the god of the Philistines.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when your tribe came into contact with another group of people. Tell how your worship customs and God have come into conflict with those people’s worship customs and God. Pause this audio here.

Some of the Philistines took Dagon and put him back in his place. This means that the people picked up the statue of Dagon, stood it upright, and placed it back on its platform or stand.

The third scene contrasts what the people of Ashdod did the previous night with what they found the following morning. The previous day, the people had picked up Dagon’s statue and placed it back on its platform. But when the people went into Dagon’s temple early the following morning, the people found that Dagon had again fallen on his face on the ground before Yahweh. Just like when it first happened, this surprised the Philistines because no human being was in the temple during the night. The Philistines were even more alarmed because they also found that someone had cut off Dagon’s head and hands, and the head and hands were lying on the threshold or entrance of the temple. Only the main part of Dagon’s body remained unbroken. It was probably Yahweh himself who cut off these parts of Dagon’s body. This is why the priests of the Philistines or any other person who enters the temple of Dagon in Ashdod does not step on the threshold. The storyteller then gives us the added information that the Philistines continue to avoid stepping on the threshold even to the time the storyteller writes this book of 1 Samuel.

Stop here and give an example of a taboo or restriction in your culture. How and where did people start that taboo or restriction? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, Yahweh’s hand was heavy upon the people of Ashdod and its villages. The “hand of Yahweh” is special language that shows that Yahweh used his hand, or his power, to punish the people who lived in Ashdod and the villages that surrounded it. Yahweh punished the people with unpleasant and painful swellings on the skin.

When the people of Ashdod saw what was happening, the people said that the ark of the God of Israel could not stay with them and must leave their city because his hand was heavy upon them and their god Dagon. This means that the people of Ashdod came to realize that the God of Israel was punishing them for taking the ark. The storyteller does not say how the people came to this realization. When the Philistines spoke of the ark, they called it the ark of the God whom the Israelites worshiped. The Philistines did not believe that the God of the Israelites was the only true God. But the Philistines did recognise that the Israelites’ God had power because he was punishing them and their god Dagon. The Philistines did not believe that Dagon was the only god. The Philistines believed that there were different gods in different countries and that each god was powerful in his own country. This is why the Philistines call Yahweh “the God of Israel.” The Philistines believe that Yahweh is a god, but not a god of the land of the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you refer to the creator of the world when you speak with other communities who do not worship the same God as you do? Pause audio here.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

So the people of Ashdod called together all the rulers of the Philistines and asked them to advise the people on what they should do with the ark of the God of Israel. The rulers of the Philistines were probably the kings or governors of the Philistines' five cities.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when your community called together all the rulers or leaders of your people. Pause audio here.

In the fifth scene, the rulers of the Philistines said that they should move the ark from Ashdod to Gath. Gath is another one of the five Philistine cities. The rulers did not say who would move the ark. So some of the men moved the ark of the God of Israel to Gath. But after the men brought the ark to Gath, the hand of Yahweh was hard against that city. This means Yahweh began to punish the people of Gath. This caused great panic, or great confusion and chaos. Yahweh attacked the people of that city—both the old people and the young people—with tumors. This is special language to say that Yahweh punished all the people who lived in Gath by causing tumors to break out or grow suddenly on their bodies.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Choose one person to play the role of Yahweh and divide the rest into two groups. Make these groups sit apart. One group will represent the people of Ashdod, and the other will represent the people of Gath. Choose an object to represent the ark and give it to the people of Ashdod. When the people of Ashdod have the ark, have the person who plays Yahweh wave his hands over the people of Ashdod as if he is punishing the people. The people should react by crying as if they suffer physically. The people of Ashdod should give the ark to the people of Gath and move away from those people. When this happens, the people of Ashdod should stop suffering and begin to return to their normal lives because the person playing Yahweh has turned from them. Then the person who plays Yahweh should begin to afflict the people of Gath. But the people of Gath should suffer even more than the people of Ashdod. Pause the audio here.

In the sixth scene, the people of Gath sent the ark to Ekron. Ekron is another Philistine city. The storyteller does not tell us how the people of Gath decided to send the ark to Ekron, but we know the people sent the ark there to stop their own suffering. But as the people of Gath were bringing the ark into the city of Ekron, the people of Ekron cried out in protest. This means that the people of Ekron did not want the people of Gath to bring the ark. The people of Ekron said that the people of Gath had brought the ark into Ekron so that the ark or the God of Israel would kill the people of Ekron. The people of Ekron were angry with the people of Gath. The people of Ekron accused the people of Gath of bringing death to their city. The people of Ekron said this because they believed that the ark or the God of Israel would kill them.

Stop here as a group and talk about a time when someone in your community did something that other people thought was wrong or evil. Perhaps people thought this action would make God angry with the whole community. Pay attention to how you talk about the way the community reacted to the person who brought the evil thing into the community. Pause this audio here.

So the people of Ekron called together all the rulers of the Philistines. The people told the rulers to tell some men to return the ark to its own place. This means that the people wanted the ark to be returned to where it belonged, in the land of Israel. The people of Ekron said that the ark must be returned to its own place because the people believed that if the ark remained in their land, it would kill all of the people. A deadly panic had filled the city, and the hand of the God of Israel was heavy upon them. This means the people were afraid they would die because Yahweh was punishing the people severely with the outbreak of tumors. Many people died, and Yahweh punished those who survived with tumors so that the outcry of the city went up to heaven. This means that the Philistines cried out for help from heaven, where they believed their gods lived.

Stop here and discuss what your community did during the time they thought their God was punishing them. How did people ask God to stop punishing them? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 5:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Dagon
- The Philistine warriors
- The people of Ashdod
- The people of Gath
- The people of Ekron
- The rulers of the cities of the Philistines
- And the priests of Dagon

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, the Philistine warriors capture the ark and carry it with them from Ebenezer, where the men fought the battle, to Ashdod, one of their five main cities. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistine warriors, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are victorious! or
- We are so happy to celebrate our god Dagon’s victory! or
- The Israelites’ God shall serve our god and be his slave just as the Israelites are our slaves.

Continue the drama. The people of Ashdod carried the ark into the temple of Dagon and set it up beside Dagon. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Ashdod, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This is a great day of giving honor and glory to our god Dagon. Dagon has given us victory over the Israelites; or
- We are very pleased with the results of the war. Our warriors fought bravely and have come out victorious.

Continue the drama. In the second scene, the people of Ashdod rose up early the next morning and went into the temple of Dagon. When the people went in and looked inside, the people found that Dagon had fallen face-down on the ground before the ark of Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Ashdod, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We feel horrified and alarmed. How could such a terrible thing have happened? Who did this? What does this mean? or
- We must catch and punish whoever did this; or
- Let’s pick Dagon up and put him back in his place. We must be careful that this does not happen again. What a shameful thing it would be if our enemies heard that this happened.

Continue the drama. So the people took Dagon and put him back on his platform. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am Yahweh. There is no God beside me. I do not serve and bow to anyone; or
- Dagon is not a god. The Philistines make an image of their own imagination and fall down to it to worship it. This is foolish; or
- Let the Philistines look and see that Yahweh alone is powerful.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

Continue the drama. In the third scene, when the people of Ashdod woke up early the following morning and came into the temple of Dagon, the people found Dagon fallen on his face before the ark of Yahweh. Dagon's head and hands had been cut off and were lying on the threshold of Dagon's temple. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Ashdod, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What a horror! This is worse than yesterday. We are very afraid; or
- What are these signs that the God of Israel is performing? Will Israel's God destroy our god? or
- How is it possible that the God of Israel can do such things here in our land? What will happen if Israel's God remains here? Will Israel's God not completely destroy Dagon?

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Will the Philistines not learn? Dagon is not a God. Dagon has hands but cannot save himself. Dagon's ears do not hear, and Dagon's mouth cannot speak. Dagon must be carried everywhere by those who worship him; or
- The Philistines think I only have power in the land of Israel, but I am Yahweh. The whole world is mine.

Continue the drama. Dagon's head and hands had been cut off and were lying on the threshold of Dagon's temple. Only the trunk of Dagon was left to him. This is the reason that the priest of Dagon and all who enter the temple of Dagon do not step on the threshold of Dagon in Ashdod to this day. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest of Dagon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The threshold is holy ground. The threshold was made holy by the head and hands of Dagon. Therefore, we do not walk on the threshold; or
- To walk on the threshold would be the same as stepping on Dagon himself.

Continue the drama. In the fourth scene, Yahweh attacked the people of Ashdod and its villages by afflicting them with tumors. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am not happy with these people. These people have taken my ark. The people are proud and believe that they are stronger than I am; or
- I have tried to show these people who I am by afflicting their false God, but they will not listen; or
- I will afflict these people until they hear me and turn.

Ask the person playing the people of Ashdod, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel afraid. There is an outbreak in the city. Painful swellings of the skin have spread throughout the community. Oh, how painful and ugly! or
- We are in great suffering. There is no one to comfort us. All of us are afflicted by these tumors; or
- This must be the God of the Israelites. First, he afflicted Dagon, and now he afflicts us.

Continue the drama. When the people of Ashdod realized what was happening, the people said that the ark of the God of the Israelites could not remain in Ashdod. The people said this because the hand of the God of the Israelites was hard against the people and their god Dagon. So the people sent and gathered the rulers of the cities of the Philistines and asked the rules what they should do. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Ashdod, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Our life was good before people brought the ark here. Since this ark has come into Ashdod, we have seen many strange things. First, Dagon was attacked and broken, and now we are tormented by these tumors; or
- This ark cannot stay here! or
- It is the ark that has caused problems both to us and to Dagon, our god.

Continue the drama. In the fifth scene, the rulers of the cities of the Philistines decided to send the ark of the God of Israel to Gath, another Philistine city. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the rulers of the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The people of Ashdod are very angry and scared. The people will not allow the ark to stay here any longer. We must do something; or
- Let's move the ark to another place. Perhaps it would be better if the ark went to Gath. Maybe the God of Israel will have no power there.

Continue the drama. When the people brought the ark to Gath, the hand of Yahweh was hard against the people of Gath and caused a great panic. Yahweh attacked the people of Gath, both young and old, with tumors. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These people refuse to learn that I am powerful in all the earth. I am not a God of stone. I am the living God. No one can control me. Any person who tries to control me will suffer my punishment.

Ask the person playing the people of Gath, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Oh no, what is happening? We are so terrified. A great disaster has come upon us. No one is safe from this disease; or
- These tumors have come upon us from the day that the ark entered our city. Just like it happened in Ashdod, it has happened to us; or
- The whole city is in chaos. We are so afraid. Our children are dying from the tumors. We have no one to help us. This ark must leave Gath. It is the only way to end this plague.

Continue the drama. In the sixth scene the people of Gath sent the ark to Ekron. As the people of Gath were carrying the Ark into Ekron, the people of Ekron protested against the ark coming into their city. The people of Ekron said that the people of Gath were bringing the ark of the God of Israel so that the ark could kill the people of Ekron. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Ekron, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We heard how Israel's God attacked the people in Ashdod and Gath when they brought the ark into their cities. Now the people of Gath bring the ark to us. No! We shall not have the ark. The people of Gath know that what happened to them will happen to us, and they do not care; or
- We do not want to die. We want to have nothing to do with this ark. Why would the people of Gath bring the ark here? Surely the people of Gath hate us and mean to bring death to our city; or
- We must do something immediately.

Continue the drama. So the people of Ekron called together the rulers of the cities of the Philistines and told the rulers to send the ark away back to Israel. The people of Ekron were afraid that the ark would kill them. A great panic had filled the heart of the people of Ekron because many people had died there. Those who did not die were attacked with tumors. The people of Ekron wept and prayed for help. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Ekron, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are so afraid. Death is everywhere. Every home mourns; or
- So many people have died, and the rest have tumors. There are no strong people left. The whole city prays for the end of this plague. Everyone prays to his own God; or
- I wish people had never brought the ark here. Oh God, help us!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 5:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

When the **Philistines** captured the **ark of God**, they brought it from Ebenezer to Ashdod. Use the same words or phrases for Philistine, the general word for God, and "ark of God" as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for God and ark of the covenant, if needed.

The Philistines brought the ark into the temple of Dagon and set it up beside Dagon. Temple refers to a place where people worship their god. The Philistines kept a statue of their god Dagon in his temple. You can translate this as the house of Dagon because it is where Dagon lived.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **temple**. Look up temple in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

Dagon refers to an image or idol that the Philistines had made to represent Dagon. People would have made this idol out of solid material such as wood, metal, or stone. Dagon is a proper name, so it is best to keep the same name or pronounce it in your language.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Dagon**. Because Dagon is an idol, look up idol in the Master Glossary for more information if you will include the term idol in your translation. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines found Dagon fallen with his face to the ground before **Yahweh**. The Philistines put Dagon back in his place, but the next morning they found that he had again fallen with his face to the ground before the ark of Yahweh, and his head and hands had been cut off and were lying by the threshold. Yahweh is a name that God gave himself. This name means something like "I am," or "I am who I am." The name Yahweh was a very personal name for God that showed the close relationship that God had with the people of Israel. Look up Yahweh in the Master Glossary for more information, and translate Yahweh in the same way you have in previous passages.

Threshold refers to the bottom of a doorway or entrance to a building. People cross the threshold when they enter a house or room, in this case, the temple of Dagon.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **threshold**. Stop here and look at a picture of a threshold as a group. Pause this audio here.

Because of this, the **priests** of Dagon or anyone entering the temple of Dagon do not walk on the threshold of the temple to this day. Look up priest in the Master Glossary if needed for more information, and translate priest in the same way you have in previous passages.

The hand of Yahweh was heavy against the people of Ashdod, and Yahweh terrified and afflicted the people with tumors. Tumors are swellings or growths on the skin. Rats likely spread these tumors.

Stop here and look at a picture of tumors as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **tumors**. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines gathered together all the rulers of the Philistines. Rulers are governors or kings. The Philistines had five main cities, and each city had its own ruler. These rulers made decisions together. You can translate this word as kings, princes, or governors.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **rulers**. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines sent up their cry to **heaven**. The word heaven refers to the place where God lives with his angels. The Philistines probably believed that their gods lived in heaven. Look up heaven in the Master Glossary for more information, and translate heaven in the same way you have in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 5:1–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (835 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (7.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (994 KB)

1 Samuel 6:1–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 6:1–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:1–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Yahweh attacked the Philistines and their gods in all the Philistine cities wherever they took the ark. After Yahweh killed many Philistines with painful tumors, the Philistines who lived in Ekron asked their rulers to return the ark of Israel's God back to the land of Israel.

In this story, the Philistines return Yahweh's ark back to the land of Israel. The Philistines had kept the ark in their land for seven months. The Philistines called together the priests and diviners, their religious experts. Diviners are people who communicate with spirits and gods. Diviners use rituals to predict the future, interpret dreams and events, or tell fortunes. It was common for pagan societies to use diviners to make decisions, but Yahweh had told the Israelites never to do it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone predicted the future. Who was that person, and how was the person able to do it? What did the person predict, and did the thing they predicted actually happen? Pause this audio here.

The Philistines asked their priests and diviners what they should do with the ark of Yahweh and how they should send it back to its place in Israel. The Philistines were probably asking about the ritual they should follow when

1 Samuel 6:1–18

they sent the ark back. For the Philistines to decide to send the ark back to Israel means that the Philistines accepted that Yahweh had defeated the Philistines and their gods.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What does your community do to make peace with God when they think that God is angry with them? Pause audio here.

The Philistines' priests and diviners answered and said that the Philistines should not send the ark of Israel's God empty-handed or without a gift. The priests and diviners told the Philistines to send the ark back to the God of Israel with a payment or offering for their guilt. This is probably because they thought that the Philistines had made the God of Israel angry by taking his ark. The priests and diviners were not completely sure that Yahweh had caused the tumors and deaths. So the priests and diviners said that if the Philistines were healed of their tumors after they had returned the ark with a gift, then the Philistines would know that it was the God of Israel who had been punishing them for taking his ark.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when something unnatural happened in your community. Who did people say caused the thing to happen? Pause this audio here.

The Philistines asked the priests and diviners what kind of payment they should send to the God of Israel. The priests and diviners told the people that they should send five gold models of the tumors and five gold models of rats. The priests and diviners said this because they were five rulers of five Philistine cities, and they had all been punished with the same punishment of tumors. The Philistines also had to send five models of the rats that were destroying all their crops on their farms or in their fields. The Philistines hoped that if they gave glory and honor to the God of Israel, God would lift his heavy hand from them or end the punishment. In that culture, people honored the power of a god that healed by making a model of an illness or the part of the body that was sick. Then people offered that model to the god.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of what the gold tumors and rats might have looked like. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the different kinds of gifts that people offer to gods in your community when they are in danger or great trouble. How do people know what to offer and the number of offerings to give? Pause this audio here.

The priests and diviners encouraged the Philistines not to harden their hearts or be stubborn like the Egyptians and the Egyptian king, the Pharaoh. The priests and diviners reminded the people of what happened to the Egyptians when Yahweh sent Moses to tell Pharaoh to let the Israelites leave Egypt. When Pharaoh refused to listen, the God of the Israelites humiliated the Egyptians and Pharaoh and punished them harshly until they let the people of Israel leave Egypt. Therefore, the priests and diviners advised the Philistines to prepare a new cart or vehicle and two milk cows, or cows that had recently given birth. The Philistines were to choose cows that had never pulled a cart before. Then the Philistines should take away the cows' baby calves from them and put the calves in the house or pen. After that, the Philistines should yoke or tie the cows to the new cart. People used cows to plow or pull carts by attaching them to a cart with a yoke or wooden bar on their neck. The Philistines probably chose cows that had never pulled a cart because they considered those cows to be suitable to offer to Yahweh, because they were clean and pure. Milk cows would not naturally abandon their calves. By taking away the calves, the people probably thought that the cows would choose to go to their calves when people released them. It is likely that diviners thought that the only reason why these milk cows would abandon their calves would be if Yahweh made them go where Yahweh wanted.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a team of cows that people yoked to a cart. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group. Talk about how your community uses animals for different purposes, like to do work, to eat, to give as gifts, such as a dowry, or to make sacrifices. How do you choose an animal for a sacrifice? Pause this audio here.

The priests and diviners told the Philistines to place the ark of Yahweh on the cart and to place another box or chest that contained the gold tumors and gold rats for the guilt offering beside the ark. The Philistines were to let the milk cows pull the cart whichever direction the cows wanted to go. The Philistines were not to interfere, but they were to keep watching the cart. The priests and diviners said that if the cows carried the ark towards the ark's territory, Beth Shemesh, it would show that Yahweh had been the one who brought the great disaster

on the Philistines. But if the cows did not go toward Beth Shemesh, the Philistines would know that an accident or chance had caused the great disaster, not Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when the priests or diviners of your community had to choose between two or more options to determine the cause of a problem in your community. How did the priests and diviners test to see which of the options was the cause of the problem? Pause this audio here.

The Philistines did everything that the priest and diviners had told them. The Philistines tied the two cows to the new cart and shut the cows' calves in the barn. The Philistines placed the ark of Yahweh on the cart along with the other chest that contained the gold tumors and gold rats. When the Philistines let the cows go, the cows went straight towards Beth Shemesh, and kept to the road, not turning left or right, even though the cows were lowing or calling for their calves all the way. The cows were probably lowing because they wanted to go back to their calves, but they did not turn back because Yahweh was leading the cows. The five rulers of the Philistines followed the cows and watched the cows all the way to the border of Beth Shemesh.

The Israelites of Beth Shemesh were busy harvesting their wheat in the valley, or the lowland between two hills.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of people harvesting wheat with a sickle. Pause this audio here.

When the people looked up from their work and saw the ark, the people were very happy to see that the ark had returned to Israel. The cows pulled the cart to the field of a man from Beth Shemesh named Joshua and stopped by a large rock that was there. All this happened without any humans interfering. Some Levites or men from the tribe of Levi who were there took the ark of Yahweh and the chest with the gold models off the cart and placed them on the rock.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of Levites carrying the ark. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some religious activities in your community that only a few select people or groups are allowed to do, and why? Pause this audio here.

A few other Israelites chopped up the cart and made a fire. These people killed the cows and burned them as burnt sacrifices to Yahweh. Burnt sacrifice is a specific type of offering where the priests burned the entire animal on the altar. Usually, the priests used only male cows for burnt sacrifice. The priests probably used the large rock as an altar to sacrifice on. After that, the priests offered other animals as extra burnt sacrifices and made other types of sacrifices to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are the various sacrifices that you offer in your community? What are the reasons that you make these sacrifices, and what animals do you offer? Pause this audio here.

When the five rulers of the Philistines who had followed the cart to the border of Beth Shemesh saw what had happened, they returned to Ekron the same day. The Philistines had offered five gold tumors to Yahweh for their guilt or wrongdoing. Each gold tumor represented one of their five cities: Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron. The Philistines also offered Yahweh gold rats equal to the number of cities that belonged to the five Philistine rulers. The Philistines offered gold rats for all of their walled cities and open villages.

The great stone in Joshua's field, the man from Beth Shemesh, on which the people placed the ark of Yahweh, is a witness or reminder to this day. The storyteller probably wants to remind us that the great stone was still on Joshua's field when he wrote this story. This stone reminded the people who saw it that Yahweh defeated the Philistines and their gods.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

1 Samuel 6:1–18

In the first scene: The Philistines called together their priests and diviners and asked them what they should do with the ark of Yahweh. The priests and diviners told the people to send the ark back with a guilt offering on a new cart pulled by two milk cows that had never pulled a cart before. The priests and diviners told the people to leave the cows to pull the cart in whichever direction the cows wanted to go, without interfering, but to follow the cows and watch where they went. The priests and diviners said that if the cows pulled the cart toward Beth Shemesh in Israel, the people would know that it was Yahweh who had been punishing them with tumors.

In the second scene: The Philistines prepared the guilt offerings, the cart, and the cows just as the priests and diviners had advised them. The cows went straight on the road without turning to the right or to the left, even though the cows lowed, or called, for their calves as they went. The five Philistine rulers followed the cows to the border of Beth Shemesh.

In the third scene: The people of Israel who lived in Beth Shemesh were busy harvesting their wheat in the valley. When the people looked up from their work and saw the ark, they rejoiced to see it return to the land of Israel. The cows carried the ark to the field of a man named Joshua and stopped next to a large rock that was there.

In the fourth scene: Some Levites who were there took the ark of Yahweh and the chest that contained the guilt offerings and placed them on the large rock. The people made a fire with the wood of the cart and killed the cows and burned them as a burnt offering to Yahweh. After that, the people offered other sacrifices and rejoiced together. The five Philistine rulers saw what happened and returned home that same day.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- The Philistines
- The five rulers of the Philistines
- The Philistine priests and diviners
- The Israelites of Beth Shemesh
- Joshua (the Israelite from Beth Shemesh)
- And the Levites of Beth Shemesh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller tells us that the ark of Yahweh has been in the land of the Philistines for seven months since they captured it in battle. The storyteller probably does this to show us that Yahweh caused the Philistines to suffer enough to make them want to return the ark. At this point in the story, the ark is in Ekron. The Philistines called together their priests and diviners. The Philistines asked the priest and diviners what they should do with the ark of Yahweh and how they should send it back to its place or land. The Philistines already knew that they should send the ark back to Israel, but they wanted the priests and diviners to tell them the way to transport it and the rituals that they should do when they sent it back.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the person in your community who uses rituals or ceremonies to communicate with spirits. Pay attention to the name you call that person. Pause audio here.

The priests and diviners answered the people and said that if they sent the ark of Yahweh back, they should not send it empty-handed or without an offering for their guilt or wrongdoing. The people believed that it was likely that the God of Israel was angry with them because they had taken the ark, and they needed to pay for their guilt. The priests and diviners told the Philistines that they should send a payment for their guilt to the God of Israel. Then, if the people were healed, they would know that the God of Israel had not lifted his hand from them and had kept punishing them because they had kept his ark. Then the Philistines asked the priests and diviners what kind of guilt offering they should send to the God of Israel. The priests and diviners answered and said that the people should send five gold tumors and five gold rats, the same as the number of their cities and rulers, and because the same punishment or sickness had struck the Philistines and their five rulers. The priests and diviners told the Philistines that they must make the God of Israel gold images or representations of their tumors and gold copies of the rats that were destroying their land. The images would be a payment or gift to honor or acknowledge the God of Israel. They hoped that Israel's God would lighten his hand or stop punishing the people and all their land and gods. It was common in the non-Israelite communities to honor or acknowledge

the power of a god who punished or healed you with a gift. It does not mean that the Philistines wanted to worship Yahweh, but that they accepted that Yahweh had used his power to punish them. It is important not to confuse this guilt offering with the guilt offering that the Israelites gave to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about people in your community who have done something wrong and have had to make a payment to God for the thing they did wrong. Pay attention to the words and phrases that you use when referring to the payment. Pause this audio here.

The priest and diviners asked the Philistines two questions to encourage them to follow their advice. The priests and diviners told the Philistines not to harden their hearts or to be stubborn like the Egyptians and Pharaoh, the Egyptian king, had been when Yahweh said to let the Israelites leave Egypt. When someone hardens their heart, they refuse to listen and they act stubbornly. The Philistine priests reminded the Philistines how the God of Israel had been very harsh with the Egyptians until the Egyptians let the people of Israel go.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about someone who has been very disobedient and has refused to listen even after many warnings. Describe how someone punishes that person very harshly. Use strong words, but do not sound cruel or unjust. Pay attention to the words and phrases that you use to describe the punishment. Pause this audio here.

For this reason, the priests and diviners told the Philistines to get and prepare a new cart that had not been used before, and to choose two milk cows that had recently given birth to calves but that had never been tied to a yoke before. It is likely that the priests were the ones who gave this direction because the priests would be concerned with the purity of the cows and cart that they would send to Yahweh. The priests told the Philistines to take the calves away from the two milk cows and put them in their barn or house, and then tie the two milk cows to the new cart. Then the Philistines should place the ark of Yahweh on the cart and another box next to the ark. The priests told the Philistines to put the gold tumors and rats that they would be sending as their guilt offering in the box that was next to the ark. Then the priests told the people to allow the cows to pull the cart in whichever direction the cows wanted to go, but to keep watching which way the cows went. If the cows went toward Beth Shemesh in the territory of Israel, the ark's home, then it would mean that Yahweh had brought the suffering of tumors on the Philistines. But if the cows did not go toward Beth Shemesh, it would mean that an accident had caused the suffering, and it was not the hand of Yahweh. The priests probably gave this direction because it is a way of deciding whether Yahweh had been the one punishing the people or not.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe the various skin diseases that affect people in your community, especially any that cause swelling or that rats spread. Pay attention to the names you give to these diseases. Tell stories of when rats have destroyed crops in the field. Pay attention to what you call these kinds of rats. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the Philistines did all that their priests and diviners had told them. The Philistines chose two cows like the ones that the priests and diviners had advised. They tied the cows to a new cart and put their calves in the barn.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Choose one member of the group to play the role of the priests and diviners. This person should give the instructions that the priests and diviners gave the Philistines to the rest of the group. The group should pay attention to the words and phrases the members of the group use. Focus especially on the words and phrases for the two milk cows and their calves, the action of tying or yoking the cows to the cart, and the golden items that the people put in the box. The group should suggest better words and phrases to the person playing the role of the Philistine priests and diviners. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines placed the ark of Yahweh on the cart together with the chest that contained the gold tumors and gold rats. It is likely that the Philistines had learned not to touch the ark because Yahweh would kill anyone who touched it. Therefore, it is important not to confuse the ark and the box containing the guilt offerings. The cows went by themselves straight toward Beth Shemesh. Even though the cows were mooing, lowing, or calling for their calves all the way as they went, the cows stayed on the road that goes to Beth Shemesh and did not turn off the road to the right or to the left. This is special language that shows that the cows went straight ahead without turning back to look for their calves.

1 Samuel 6:1–18

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a typical road of the time. Tell a story about a time when someone went from one place to another without stopping or changing their mind. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to describe how the person traveled. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you took a calf from its mother. How did the cow react? Talk about the different sounds that a cow makes. Pay attention to the word or phrase you use for a cow calling for its calf. Pause this audio here.

The five Philistine rulers followed the cows to the edge of the fields of the villages that surrounded Beth Shemesh.

In the third scene, the people of Beth Shemesh were busy in their fields harvesting wheat. The people grew their wheat in the fertile valley or the low-lying land between two hills.

When the people looked up from their work and saw the ark, they rejoiced and were happy to see it return to Israel. The people probably felt that Yahweh himself had returned to Israel after spending seven months in the land of the Philistines. The cows pulled the cart into the field of a man named Joshua who was from Beth Shemesh. They stopped the cart next to a large rock in Joshua's field.

In the fourth scene, some Levites took down the ark and the box with the guilt offerings from the cart and placed them on the large rock. The Levites were there because Beth Shemesh was one of the cities of Israel where Levites lived. Although no one was allowed to touch the ark, Yahweh had given the people from the tribe of Levi the work of transporting it. After the Levites had taken down the ark and the chest with the guilt offerings from the cart, the people of Beth Shemesh chopped up the wood of the cart and made a fire with it. The priests killed the cows and burnt them completely as a burnt sacrifice to Yahweh. A burnt offering involves the burning of the whole animal except its hide or skin. The priests probably did this to rededicate or renew their relationship with Yahweh. The priests did this because they probably believed that Yahweh had left them when the Philistines captured the ark, but now Yahweh had returned. That same day, the people of Beth Shemesh also offered other burnt sacrifices in addition to the two cows and made other sacrifices to Yahweh. The people probably offered other kinds of animals, like sheep or goats, as extra burnt sacrifices. The burnt offerings were probably for dedicating themselves back to serving Yahweh, whilst the other sacrifices were to show their joy and restored relationship with Yahweh. The other offerings were also different from the burnt sacrifices because the people did not burn them entirely. The people probably ate some of the meat of the other sacrifices and rejoiced together.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Earlier, you talked about the different kinds of gifts that people offer to gods in your community and their reasons. How do people make sure that they do not offer the wrong sacrifice for a particular need or reason? Pause this audio here.

The five Philistine rulers witnessed all that the people of Beth Shemesh had done, and then they returned home to Ekron that same day.

Now the storyteller gives us a summary of what the Philistines sent to Yahweh. These are the gifts that the Philistines sent to Yahweh. The Philistines sent five gold tumors for their guilt. The Philistines sent one gold tumor for each of their five cities: Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron. The Philistines also offered Yahweh gold rats equal to the number of cities that belonged to the five Philistine rulers. The Philistines offered a gold rat for each of their towns, whether they were walled towns or open villages, because several villages usually surrounded walled towns. It is likely that the total number of towns was more than five, which would mean that they offered more than the five rats that their priests and diviners had advised. This could be because the rats had spread across all the land of the Philistines, whereas the tumors had only affected the people who lived in the cities where people had brought the ark.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the towns and villages that make up your community. Compare your town with another town to see which has more villages. How do you know which town a village is part of? Pause this audio here.

The large stone in the field of Joshua, the man from Beth Shemesh, on which they placed the ark of Yahweh, remained as a reminder and a witness of what had happened even in the days that this story was written.

1 Samuel 6:1–18

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some physical things in your community that your people built so that they can remind everyone of some past events? Pay attention to how you describe these things. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- The Philistines
- The five rulers of the Philistines
- The Philistine priests and diviners
- The Israelites of Beth Shemesh
- Joshua, the Israelite from Beth Shemesh
- And the Levites of Beth Shemesh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, the ark of Yahweh has been in the land of the Philistines for seven months. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am angry with the Philistines; or
- I will continue to punish the Philistines until they return my ark to Israel.

Ask the person playing the Philistines, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- No more! We have had enough of this punishment. We will be completely destroyed by these tumors if this does not stop; or
- So many of our people have died, and more die every day. As long as the ark remains in Ekron, we will keep dying; or
- The ark must leave! The ark cannot stay here any longer. We must return the ark to its own country; or
- This is because of the ark of Israel’s God. Wherever we take this ark, the people of that city get tumors, and these rats are all over the country. This ark must leave our territory. Seven months of suffering is long enough.

Continue the drama. The Philistines called together their priests and diviners and asked them what they should do with the ark of Yahweh and how the Philistines should send the ark back to its place. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We need help. We have called our religious experts to teach us how we must treat the ark. We are very afraid of making mistakes and suffering more than we are already suffering; or

- Our priests and diviners know how to communicate with the gods and the spirits. Maybe our priests and diviners will be able to tell us what we can do to make Israel's God stop being angry with us; or
- We just want this suffering to stop. The God of Israel has defeated our gods. Our gods have not been able to save us or themselves from Israel's God.

Ask the person playing the priests and diviners, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Perhaps the people of Ekron and our rulers are right to want to send the ark back. We do not all agree. Some of us think an accident has caused all of this, but some believe Israel's God has done it; or
- We do not know why this has happened, so we should test and see why this has happened to us.

Continue the drama. The priests and diviners told the Philistines that they should send Israel's God a payment for their guilt. If Israel's God healed the Philistines, then the Philistines would know that the God of Israel had not kept punishing them because they kept his ark. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest and diviners, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- If the God of Israel has done this to us, then that means that he is angry with us because we have wronged him by taking his ark. Therefore, we must send gifts with the ark; or
- We must admit our guilt. Maybe then Israel's God will stop punishing us. We must make a payment to Israel's God. We must show this God that we understand that he has done this to us.

Continue the drama. The Philistines asked the priests and diviners what kind of guilt offering they should send to the God of Israel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What the priests and diviners have said is very wise. Maybe it will work, and then this terrible suffering will stop; or
- I am worried! What shall we send the God of Israel? We do not know this God. How can we know what to send him? What if the thing we send Israel's God only makes him more angry? or
- We are so worried and afraid. We want our lives to go back to normal.

Continue the drama. The priests and diviners answered the people and said that the Philistines should send five gold tumors and five gold rats, the same number as their cities and rulers. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest and diviners, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Maybe when the God of Israel receives these gifts, he will stop being angry with us.

Ask the person playing the rulers of the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are not sure whether this will work; or
- It is a very expensive gift that the priests and diviners are suggesting. What if the God of Israel did not do this to us? We will have given the God of Israel a present for nothing. The Israelites will laugh at us and our gods, and they will think that their God defeated our gods; or
- Why should we pay the God of Israel? If Israel's God was the one doing this to us, why were we able to capture the ark in the war? Our god Dagon defeated Israel's God.

Continue the drama. The priests and diviners told the Philistines not to harden their hearts or be stubborn as the Egyptians and Pharaoh who refused to listen to the God of Israel when he told them to let his people go. The priests and diviners reminded the Philistines how the God of Israel had been very harsh with the Egyptians until they let the people of Israel go. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priests and diviners, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We fear that the suffering will only increase as long as the ark stays in our territory. It is a hard thing to do, but we must do it. We cannot be proud and be stubborn against the God of the Israelites. Otherwise, Israel's God will punish us more severely; or
- The God of Israel dealt with the Egyptians very severely when they refused to do what he wanted. We are afraid that Israel's God will do the same thing to us; or

- We are worried that the people and our rulers are not taking us seriously enough. Maybe they think that they can still keep the ark in Philistine territory.

Ask the person playing the five rulers of the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We do not want to admit that the God of the Israelites had defeated us and our gods, but we are very afraid. If the God of the Israelites has done this to us, then we had better listen to the priests and diviners and return the ark. Otherwise, the God of Israel might do to us a worse thing than he did to the Egyptians; or
- The God of the Israelites destroyed Pharaoh and Egypt also. We heard the news of what the God of the Israelites did, and we do not want that to happen to us.

Continue the drama. Therefore, the priests and diviners told the Philistines to prepare a new cart that no one had used before. The Philistines were also to choose two milk cows that had recently given birth to calves but that had never been tied to a yoke before. The priests and diviners told the people to take the calves away from the two milk cows, to put the calves in their barn, and then to tie the two milk cows to the new cart. Then, the people must place the ark of Yahweh on the cart and another chest that contained the gifts next to the ark. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest and diviners, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We must be very careful not to insult the God of the Israelites. We must use a new cart that has not been used for any other purpose before. If we send a cart we have previously used, it may be that this God will consider it unclean and be even more angry with us. The cows also must be cows that no one has ever used to do any of our work—cows that will please this God and be acceptable to him; or
- We must make a different box to put the guilt offerings in and place it on the cart with the ark. We must be very careful how we deal with the ark. If we try to open it, it might kill us.

Continue the drama. The priests and diviners told the Philistines to let the cows pull the cart in whichever direction the cows wanted to go, but to keep watching the cart and see where it went. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest and diviners, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We must test and see whether this was an accident or whether the God of Israel has brought this great disaster on us, because we are not sure. We do not want to give the ark back to the Israelites and admit defeat if it was an accident that caused all our suffering.

Continue the drama. In the second scene, the Philistines did all that their priests and diviners had told them. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We have done everything exactly as the priests and diviners told us. We feel hopeful that their plan will work, but we will only know once we have let the cows go; or
- We really want this to work. We want to be healed and for these tumors to go away. We are tired of suffering. We want these rats to go away from our farms; or
- We are afraid and worried about what will happen if the cows do not go toward Beth Shemesh. How will we be healed?

Continue the drama. The Philistines chose two cows like the ones the priests and diviners had asked them to choose and tied these cows to a new cart. Then the Philistines placed the ark on the cart together with the chest that contained the gold tumors and gold rats. Then the cows went by themselves straight toward Beth Shemesh. The cows stayed on the road that goes to Beth Shemesh and did not turn off the road to the right or to the left, even though they were lowing all the way as they went. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that my ark is returning to Israel. I will direct the cows to the place I want them to take it; or
- I have punished the Philistines for as long as they have kept the ark so that they may know that I am not like their gods of stone.

Continue the drama. The five Philistine rulers followed the cows up the border or the fields of the villages that surround Beth Shemesh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the five rulers of the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel amazed! We have never seen anything like this. These cows are crying for their calves, and yet the cows do not turn back to go to the calves. The cows saw that we put their calves in the barn, and yet when we let them go, they went away from the calves in the direction of Beth Shemesh; or
- How is this possible? This must be the hand of the God of Israel. Israel's God must be taking his ark home. This is a powerful God; or
- The priests and diviners were right. Now we know that we have angered the God of Israel by taking his ark. If only Israel's God will accept our guilt offerings and heal us and our land.

Continue the drama. In the third scene, the people of Beth Shemesh, who were busy in their fields harvesting the wheat, looked up from their work and saw the ark coming. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Beth Shemesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What a wonderful day! The cows are pulling the ark to us without any man directing them. What a strange and amazing thing; or
- This must be the hand of Yahweh. Who else could do this? Why would the Philistines give us back the ark? or
- We must stop our work and sacrifice to our God Yahweh for this great thing he has done. Yahweh has returned to his people.

Continue the drama. The cows pulled the cart into the field of a man named Joshua, who was from Beth Shemesh. The cows stopped the cart next to a large rock that was in Joshua's field. Some Levites who were there took down the ark of Yahweh and the chest with the guilt offerings from the cart and placed them on a large rock in Joshua's field. Then the people of Beth Shemesh chopped up the wood of the cart and made a fire with the wood. The people killed the cows and burnt them completely on the wood as a burnt sacrifice to Yahweh. The people of Beth Shemesh also offered other burnt sacrifices in addition to the two cows and made other sacrifices to Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is a great day of rejoicing and praising Yahweh. Yahweh has returned the ark to his people. Yahweh's presence is back in Israel; or
- We must be careful to follow the instructions that Moses gave regarding the ark. Only adult men from the tribe of Levi can handle the ark; or
- Let's sacrifice to Yahweh and dedicate ourselves and the people of Israel to serving Yahweh.

Ask the person playing the people of Beth Shemesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are full of joy. Our God lives with us again. Our God is close to us; or
- We will sing and shout and send messages to our brothers and sisters all over the land of Israel about this great thing that has happened today.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy and pleased to see my people rejoicing in me; or
- My people's sacrifices are pleasing and acceptable to me; or
- I will live again with my people! I am very happy!

Continue the drama. The five Philistine rulers witnessed all that the people of Beth Shemesh had done, and then the rulers returned home to Ekron that same day. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the five Philistine rulers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The people of Israel have celebrated joyfully whilst their God has defeated us. It is a sad day for us and all the Philistines, but we hope that the suffering will end and that we will be healed; or
- This God of Israel is a terrific God. We do not want to fight him again.

Continue the drama. These are the gifts that the Philistines sent to Yahweh. The Philistines sent five gold tumors for their guilt, one for each of their five cities: Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron. The Philistines also

offered Yahweh gold rats equal to the number of cities that belonged to the five Philistine rulers. The people sent a gold rat for each town that belonged to the five rulers, whether they were walled towns or open villages.

The large stone that was in the field of Joshua, the man from Beth Shemesh, on which they placed the ark of Yahweh, remained as a reminder and a witness of what had happened even in the days that this story was written. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Joshua from Beth Shemesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is the most amazing thing. Yahweh has done great things and has made my farm a place of memorial; or
- Praise the name of Yahweh, for he is great and powerful. Yahweh is stronger than all our enemies.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The Philistines had kept the **ark** of **Yahweh** in their territory or land for seven months. Use the same words or phrases for ark and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for Yahweh and "ark of the covenant," if needed.

The Philistines called together their priests and diviners. Priests are people who are between God and the people. It is important to remember that these Philistine priests are not the same as the priests of Yahweh. Diviners are people who communicate with gods and spirits. Diviners use various rituals to tell the future, interpret dreams, and even to make decisions.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **priests and diviners**. Look up priest and divination in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The priests and diviners told the Philistines that if they sent the ark of the **God** of Israel back, they should send it with a guilt offering. Use the same general word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for God, if needed. The kind of guilt offering that the Philistines offered was not the same as the guilt offering that an Israelite would offer to Yahweh. The Philistines offered a payment which showed that they acknowledged and accepted that the God of Israel had used his power to punish the Philistines. The Philistines would have offered this kind of gift to any god whom they thought had power over them, but the Israelites would never have offered a guilt offering to anyone except Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for this kind of **guilt offering**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The priests and diviners told the Philistines to make images of the tumors that they had on their bodies and the rats that were destroying their land in order to give **glory** to the God of Israel. To give glory is to honor and recognize God's power. Use the same word or phrase for glory as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for glory, if needed.

The priest and diviners said that if the Philistines gave glory to the God of Israel, perhaps he would lift his hand from the Philistines' gods and their land. Gods of other nations are not the same as the one true God, Yahweh. Sometimes people use wood or metal to make statues or pillars to represent their gods. These were called idols.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **gods**. Look up gods in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Israel is the name of the country where the Israelites lived. Sometimes the word Israel refers to all the descendants of Abraham together. It then means the same as the Israelites, or as the people of Israel. When the Philistines say "the God of Israel," they are referring to Yahweh, the God of the Israelites. It is also possible that the Philistines meant the God of the land of Israel. Use the same word that you used for Israel in previous passages. Look up Israel or Israelite in the Master Glossary for more information.

The priests and diviners told the Philistines to prepare a new cart and two milk cows and then to yoke the cows to the cart. A cart is a wooden vehicle that people used to carry things or people, and a milk cow is a cow that has recently given birth and therefore is producing milk for its calf. A yoke is a wooden collar with two openings that people use to tie two animals together. Then the animals can walk together to pull a plow or a cart. The yoke helps the animals to walk in step with each other so that they can pull their load smoothly. For this to work, the animals have to be about the same size.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **yoke**. Look up yoke in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The priests and diviners told the people to place the ark of Yahweh on the cart and a box that contained the golden tumors and rats beside it.

The people of Beth Shemesh were in their fields harvesting their wheat. The people rejoiced when they looked up and saw the ark. The people chopped up the wood of the cart and made a fire on which they offered the two cows as a burnt offering to Yahweh. A burnt offering is an offering that is meant to renew a person's relationship with Yahweh. The people kill and chop up the animal, and then burn it completely. The people do not eat any of the animal.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **burnt offering**. Look up burnt offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Before the people chopped up the wood of the cart, the Levites who were there had already taken down the ark of Yahweh and the box that contained the guilt offerings and placed them on the large rock that was in Joshua's field. Levites are people who belong to the tribe of Levi, one of the 12 tribes of Israel. Those Levites who were descendants of Aaron became priests. Other Levites who were not descendants of Aaron were also important, because they helped the priests in their duties. The Levites had the important job of carrying the ark whenever it needed to be moved. The Levites also helped the priests take care of the tabernacle, and later, the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Levites**. Look up Levites in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The large stone that was in the field of Joshua, the man from Beth Shemesh, on which they placed the ark of Yahweh, remained as a reminder and a witness of what had happened even in the days that this story was written. The word witness here does not mean a person in court. A witness describes a structure that is supposed to remind people of past events. You could translate it as a "stone that helps people remember or testify to certain events."

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **witness**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 6:1–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (796 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (9.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (11.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 6:19–7:2 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:19–7:2 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:19–7:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, the Philistines listened to the words of their priests and diviners and returned the ark of Yahweh to the land of Israel. The people of Beth Shemesh rejoiced when they saw the cows pulling the ark on the cart into their land. After the Levites took down the ark and the gifts that the Philistines had sent with it, the people made sacrifices to Yahweh.

This story is about what happened to the people of Beth Shemesh after the cows brought the ark into their town. Yahweh struck or killed some of the people of Beth Shemesh because they looked into the ark of Yahweh. Yahweh had commanded that no one was to look into the ark. Yahweh said that he would kill anyone who looked inside the ark, because the ark was holy. It is likely that the people who looked into the ark wanted to see the tablets of the law, the pot of manna, and the rod of Aaron, which the Israelites kept inside the ark. Maybe the people wanted to make sure that the Philistines had not taken these things out or replaced them with other things.

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the most holy object in your community? What kinds of things can someone do that would be considered disrespectful to this object, and what would God, your gods, spirits, or ancestors do to that person? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh killed 70 men of Beth Shemesh because they had looked into the ark. The people of Beth Shemesh mourned or cried with sorrow because Yahweh had punished them severely or struck them with a heavy blow.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when great joy and celebration suddenly became very sad. What happened to cause the sadness? Pause this audio here.

When the people of Beth Shemesh saw how Yahweh had punished them, the people said that there is no one who is able to stand before Yahweh, because Yahweh is a holy God. The people were afraid of Yahweh and felt that no one was safe in Yahweh's presence. The people did not want the ark to stay in Beth Shemesh because they believed the ark was Yahweh's throne. The people believed that because Yahweh was so holy, Yahweh would kill the people because they were not clean. The people asked each other if there was anyone they could send the ark to. The people asked this question because they realized that no one was holy and probably wondered who could take the ark with them and survive.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Where do you keep the most holy object in your community? What kinds of people are allowed to come near the object? Pause this audio here.

So the people decided to ask the people who lived in Kiriath Jearim to take the ark. The people sent messengers to Kiriath Jearim and told the people there that the Philistines had returned the ark of Yahweh. The people asked the people of Kiriath Jearim to come down to Beth Shemesh and take the ark with them to Kiriath Jearim. Kiriath Jearim was a town of Israel that was 15 kilometers away from Beth Shemesh.

Stop here and look at a map of the journey from Beth Shemesh to Kirjath Jearim as a group. Pause this audio here.

The men of Kiriath Jearim listened to the people's request and came down from their town to Beth Shemesh and took or carried the ark of Yahweh. We do not know how the people transported the ark. The people brought the ark to Kiriath Jearim and put it in the house of a certain man whose name was Abinadab. Abinadab's house was on a nearby hill.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when people in your village or town sent a message to people in another village or town and called them to come help you. Pause this audio here.

The people chose one of Abinadab's sons, whose name was Eleazar. The people dedicated or appointed Eleazar to perform the priestly work of guarding or taking care of the ark of Yahweh. It is likely that Abinadab and his sons were from the tribe of Levi because only the Levites were allowed to perform the work of guarding the ark.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of things do religious leaders or priests do in your culture? How do you appoint certain leaders to do certain tasks? Pause this audio here.

About 20 years went by from the day the people brought the ark into Kiriath Jearim, and all the people of Israel cried out to Yahweh for help. The people were probably asking Yahweh to save them from the Philistines, who ruled the Israelites. The ark remained in Kiriath Jearim for more than 20 years. The storyteller probably wants to show us that for 20 years the Israelites did not worship Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when your community felt that their God or gods had left them. What made the people feel like that, and how did they behave?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:19–7:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

In the first scene: Yahweh punished 70 men of Beth Shemesh with death because the men looked into the ark of Yahweh. The people of Beth Shemesh mourned because Yahweh had caused them great harm. The people said that there was no one who would be able to stand in the presence of Yahweh because of Yahweh's holiness. The people asked each other if there was anyone they could send the ark to in order that Yahweh might leave their town.

In the second scene: The people of Beth Shemesh sent messengers to the people of Kiriath Jearim and told them that the Philistines had returned the ark of Yahweh. The people asked the people of Kiriath Jearim to come down and get the ark and take it with them to Kiriath Jearim.

In the third scene: The people of Kiriath Jearim came down and took the ark of Yahweh and carried it with them to Kiriath Jearim. The people brought the ark to the house of a certain man named Abinadab whose house was on a nearby hill. The people chose one of Abinadab's sons, whose name was Eleazer, and appointed him to look after the ark of Yahweh.

In the fourth scene: The ark remained in Kiriath Jearim for 20 years, and all the people of Israel cried out to Yahweh for help.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- The 70 men of Beth Shemesh who saw the ark of Yahweh
- The rest of the people of Beth Shemesh
- The messengers whom the people of Beth Shemesh sent to Kiriath Jearim
- The people of Kiriath Jearim
- The men of Kiriath Jearim whom the people sent to get the ark
- Abinadab
- Eleazer
- And all the people of Israel

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Yahweh struck down some of the men of Beth Shemesh. "Yahweh struck down" was a usual way of saying that Yahweh killed people because he was punishing those people. Yahweh killed 70 men of Beth Shemesh because some of the people looked into the ark of Yahweh. The people probably touched the ark to open it so that they could look inside. It may also be possible that all the people did was stare at the ark with too much curiosity. Yahweh had strictly forbidden anyone from touching the ark. Yahweh had also told Moses to warn the priests who worked in the tabernacle not to go into the holy place to look at the holy things, even for a moment, or they would die. It is not clear whether the men who died were the same people who looked into the ark. It is also possible that more than 70 men looked into the ark. It is also not clear whether Yahweh killed seventy men or fifty thousand and seventy men. The language makes both possible, but it is unlikely that the town of Beth Shemesh would have had fifty thousand and seventy men. Therefore, it is most likely that Yahweh killed 70 men.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: One by one, tell each other about events that you have attended in the past. Choose events that many people attend, such as marriage ceremonies, funerals, or other such gatherings. The person narrating should tell the group how many people they think attended the event and how they know. Pause this audio here.

The people of Beth Shemesh mourned or were sorrowful because Yahweh had caused the people great harm or struck them with a great blow. This is a way of saying that Yahweh punished the people of Beth Shemesh by killing some of the people. It does not mean that Yahweh literally struck the people hard. The people of Beth Shemesh asked whether there was anyone who could bear to be in the presence of Yahweh, because Yahweh is a holy God. The people were not asking a question that they expected anyone to answer. The people were expressing that they did not think anyone could be in Yahweh's presence. It is possible that when the people say, "Yahweh, this holy God," the people are comparing Yahweh to other pagan gods that they may have been worshiping. The people were afraid of the holiness or purity of Yahweh and his power, and the people believed that Yahweh's holiness would kill them all because the people were not pure. Therefore, the people wondered and

asked each other whether there was anyone to whom they could send the ark so that Yahweh would leave the people. It is likely that the people discussed this question as a community, with their leaders, like the Philistines had done in the previous story.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about God's qualities or character. Pay attention to how you describe God's purity, or how he is holy, in your language. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the people of Beth Shemesh decided to send messengers to the people who lived in Kiriath Jearim. Kiriath Jearim was a town of Israel. In the message, the people Beth Shemesh informed the people of Kiriath Jearim that the Philistines had returned the ark of Yahweh. The people asked the people of Kiriath Jearim to come down to Beth Shemesh and take the ark with them to Kiriath Jearim. We are not told why the people of Beth Shemesh chose the people of Kiriath Jearim or why they did not send the ark to Shiloh, where it had previously stayed in the tabernacle. The people probably believed that Yahweh had rejected Shiloh. It is also possible that the tabernacle at Shiloh had already been destroyed. The people probably chose Kiriath Jearim because it was the nearest large town on the road from Beth Shemesh to Shiloh.

In the third scene, the people of Kiriath Jearim came down from Kiriath Jearim to Beth Shemesh. Beth Shemesh was a town in a valley, so the people of Kiriath Jearim would have traveled downwards or descended to get to Beth Shemesh. The people of Kiriath Jearim picked up the ark of Yahweh and brought it to Kiriath Jearim. We do not know how the people transported the ark. It is possible that the people brought some Levite men with them from Kiriath Jearim. Yahweh only allowed Levite men to carry the ark. The men brought the ark to Kiriath Jearim and put it in the house of a certain man named Abinadab. Abinadab's house was on a nearby hill, either inside the city of Kiriath Jearim or very near to that city. The people consecrated or dedicated and appointed one of Abinadab's sons, whose name was Eleazer, for the work of guarding the ark. Eleazer would now be able to stand in front of the ark of Yahweh without dying because he was holy or set apart for Yahweh.

In the fourth scene, all the people of Israel were sorrowful and wept for Yahweh all the days that the ark remained in Kiriath Jearim. From the day that the people brought the ark into Kiriath Jearim, many days, about 20 years, passed. The ark continued to remain at Kiriath Jearim until the days of King David, so the storyteller is not saying that people took the ark out of Kiriath Jearim after 20 years. The storyteller is probably explaining to us the spiritual condition of the people of Israel because he tells us that the house or nation of Israel cried out to Yahweh for help. The Philistines still ruled the nation of Israel this whole time, so the Israelites were probably crying out and seeking Yahweh to help them be free from the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who needed help, but no one gave that person help. Talk about how this person felt as he begged and continued asking for help and complaining about his situation. Pay attention to the words you use when you describe how the person cries for help. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:19–7:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- The 70 men of Beth Shemesh who saw the ark of Yahweh
- The rest of the people of Beth Shemesh
- The messengers whom the people of Beth Shemesh sent to Kiriath Jearim
- The people of Kiriath Jearim
- The men of Kiriath Jearim whom the people sent to get the ark
- Abinadab
- Eleazer

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

- And all the people of Israel

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, Yahweh killed 70 men of Beth Shemesh because some of the people looked in the ark of Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the 70 men of Beth Shemesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Wow! This ark is amazing. Look how the gold shines. This is the purest gold we have ever seen; or
- We have heard many stories about the ark from our fathers and our grandfathers. We heard how this ark saved them in war and destroyed their enemies, and now it is here in our town, and our eyes see it; or
- I wonder what the ark looks like inside. Everyone wants to see it. Everyone has stopped their work and is pushing to look at it.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry with the people. The people treat my holy ark like a common object; or
- These people forget my words to Moses. The people must not touch or foolishly stare at any of my holy things. The ark is not a plaything. The people must make a separation between me and them, because I am holy and the people are sinful. The people must remember that I am holy and powerful. The people must come to me with the highest respect.

Continue the drama. Yahweh killed 70 of the people, and the people of Beth Shemesh mourned because Yahweh had struck them with a great blow. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Beth Shemesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Oh no! What a terrible disaster has happened to us. So many people have died in an instant; or
- Our joy has turned into sorrow. We have lost our brothers and fathers. Every household mourns. So many deaths.

Continue the drama. The people of Beth Shemesh asked if there was anyone who could bear to be in the presence of Yahweh because Yahweh is a holy God. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Beth Shemesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are too afraid of Yahweh. Yahweh is dangerous. Yahweh will kill us all. Yahweh is not like any other God. We do not want Yahweh to stay here; or
- Yahweh's holiness is terrifying. Is there any way we can be safe near Yahweh? or
- Is there anyone who is acceptable to be in Yahweh's presence? Will Yahweh not kill all the people?

Continue the drama. The people asked each other whether there was anyone to whom they could send the ark so that Yahweh would leave them. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Beth Shemesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The ark cannot stay here. If it remains in Beth Shemesh, all the people will die. But will any town in Israel allow us to bring the ark to them? or
- Maybe we can send the ark to Shiloh. But how can we send the ark there? Many say that Yahweh rejected Shiloh. Will we not make Yahweh even angrier if we send the ark there? Oh, what shall we do? or

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

- Maybe we can send the ark to Kiriath Jearim. The people there will know what to do with the ark. Kiriath Jearim is a big town on the way to Shiloh. Let us ask the people there if they will come and take the ark. It is better there than here with us.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is sad. My people would rather get rid of my presence than consider how they might cleanse themselves so that I would not destroy them; or
- My people's hearts are far from me. The people do not realize that I am able to purify them and bless them and that my presence with them would be good for them if only they would respect me and honor me; or
- But my people are right in one thing. I am a holy God, and no one can stand before me in their sin.

Continue the drama. In the second scene, the people of Beth Shemesh decided to send messengers to the people who lived in Kiriath Jearim. They told the people of Kiriath Jearim that the Philistines had returned the ark of Yahweh and they asked the people to come down to Beth Shemesh and take the ark with them to Kiriath Jearim. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- People have sent us with an urgent message. We must run and deliver it. If we run, we can get there in two hours. Our town depends on us. We do not want anyone else to die; or
- Maybe we should not tell them about all the people that the ark has killed in our town. We do not want to scare them from coming to take it. We will be very careful about how many details we give them about the things that have happened in Beth Shemesh; or
- Hopefully, the people of Kiriath Jearim will agree to come back with us and take the ark. If we keep running hard, we can return with them to Beth Shemesh before the end of the day.

Ask the person playing the people of Kiriath Jearim, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We have received messengers from Beth Shemesh today. The people brought an urgent message. The Philistines have returned the ark of Yahweh, and the people of Beth Shemesh have asked us to come and take it from them to Kiriath Jearim; or
- It is probably best that the ark comes to Kiriath Jearim. Beth Shemesh is close to the country of the Philistines. The Philistines might attack again and capture it. It is probably best if we bring it to us and hide it here; or
- This is an urgent matter. We have sent some of our men back with the messengers that came from Beth Shemesh to go and bring the ark immediately.

Continue the drama. In the third scene, the people of Kiriath Jearim came down from Kiriath Jearim to Beth Shemesh. The people took up the ark of Yahweh and brought it to Kiriath Jearim. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the men of Kiriath Jearim, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What a wonderful thing has happened. The ark is back in Israel's territory. We are very happy and glad that we are going to get it; or
- We must make sure that we follow the laws that Moses gave us about transporting the ark, and we must take it back with us at once; or
- We pray that we will make it back to Kiriath Jearim safely and that we will have no problems on the journey. It would be a great disaster and shame to us if anything happened to the ark.

Continue the drama. The people brought the ark to Kiriath Jearim and put it in the house of a certain man named Abinadab. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the men of Kiriath Jearim, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We will bring the ark to the house of Abinadab. It is the safest place in our town. It is on a hill, which means that you can see any enemy approaching. There is also enough room in Abinadab's home; or
- Abinadab is a Levite, and he has sons who can guard the ark. Yahweh said only Levites are allowed to do the job of guarding the ark; or

Ask the person playing Abinadab, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What a great honor. I am very happy today; or

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

- The ark of Yahweh is the most important thing in all of Israel. How blessed I am that it will be in my house while people make plans for it. It might only be here for a short time, but I am happy that they have chosen my house; or
- We must be very careful to honor Yahweh and make sure we do not lose the ark again.

Continue the drama. The people consecrated or dedicated one of Abinadab's sons, whose name was Eleazer, for the work of guarding the ark. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Kiriath Jearim, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We need someone to guard the ark well, or we will die; or
- We are also making sacrifices as Moses commanded us so that Yahweh will not be angry.

Ask the person playing Eleazer, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very emotional and overwhelmed. This is the best day of my life; or
- This is holy work, and the person doing it must be holy; or
- Yahweh commanded through Moses this anointing of all who would come into his presence."

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased with the people of Kiriath Jearim. These people are careful to follow my instructions; or
- These people have treated my ark with respect and have honored my word; or
- These people have done well to anoint Eleazer. I will bless Eleazer and his father's house.

Continue the drama. And all the people in the nation of Israel cried out to Yahweh for help. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the nation of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Our lives are so difficult. We are slaves to the Philistines; or
- We feel like Yahweh has abandoned us. We cry out to Yahweh for help; or
- Oh, when will Yahweh come and rescue us?

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The people need to learn to honor me; or
- I must teach the people to worship me alone; or
- I will not help the people until they put away all their false gods and worship me with all their hearts.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 6:19–7:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Yahweh struck some of the men of Beth Shemesh. Yahweh struck the men because they looked into the **ark of Yahweh**. Use the same words or phrases for ark and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. If needed, look up "ark of the covenant" and Yahweh in the Master Glossary.

Yahweh struck **70** men. Some translations have "seventy and fifty thousand men." This number is difficult because the population of Beth Shemesh was less than 50,070 people. It is probably better to follow what most translations say and use the number 70.

The people of Beth Shemesh asked, "Who is able to stand before Yahweh, this holy **God**?" Yahweh is holy because Yahweh is completely good, pure, powerful, and majestic. Holy means that God is whole, complete, and unchangeable. But most of all, holy means God is God! Use the same general word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages, and look up God in the Master Glossary, if needed.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **holy**. Look up holy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people of Beth Shemesh sent messengers to **Kiriath Jearim** and asked the people to come and take the ark of Yahweh. The men of Kiriath Jearim took the ark of Yahweh and put it in the house of a man named **Abinadab**.

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

Stop here and discuss how you will represent these names to make them easy to understand in your language. Pause this audio here.

The people consecrated Abinadab's son Eleazer to guard and keep the ark of Yahweh. To consecrate someone is to dedicate them as holy and set apart for God. We call any person holy whom people dedicate to God. That means that the person is set apart for God's special purposes. That person is no longer common or ordinary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **consecrate**. Look up consecrate in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

From that day, a long time passed, 20 years, and the house of Israel lamented after Yahweh. The house of Israel refers to all the people in the land of Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **house of Israel**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When someone laments, they show that they are very sad. Maybe you lament when someone you love dies, but in this case, lament is the kind of sadness that someone feels when they are crying for help. Lament also means that the people were seeking Yahweh earnestly. The people complained to Yahweh about their situation and begged Yahweh to save them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **lament**. Look up lament in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 6:19–7:2

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (862 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.5 MB)

- Embodying the Text (7.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1010 KB)

1 Samuel 7:3–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 7:3–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 7:3–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 7:3–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, the men of Kiriath Jearim came to Beth Shemesh and carried the ark of Yahweh from there to their own town. The men brought the ark to Abinadab's house and anointed Abinadab's son Eleazer to guard the ark. The ark remained in Kiriath Jearim for a long time, and for 20 years all the people of Israel were mourning and seeking Yahweh.

This story is about what happened when Samuel heard that the people of Israel were seeking Yahweh. Samuel told the people that if they truly wanted to return to Yahweh, then the people needed to reject or turn away from all of the false gods and be committed to Yahweh and worship Yahweh only. The people of Israel had been worshiping many false gods. It is likely that the people had been going to the temples of the nations that were around them and even bringing the statues of the gods of those nations, like the Ashtoreths, into the Israelites' own homes. The first commandment that Yahweh had commanded the people of Israel in the days of Moses was not to serve or worship any other gods. Samuel said that Yahweh would save the Israelites from the power of the Philistines if the Israelites returned to and obeyed Yahweh only.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when some people in your community stopped doing the worship practices of your ancestors. What caused the people to do so, and what new worship practices did people start doing? Pause this audio here.

The people of Israel listened to Samuel and returned to Yahweh. The people rejected the worship practices of the other nations and got rid of the statutes of the Baals and Ashtoreths. Baal and Ashtoreth were the main male and female gods of the Canaanites. People thought of Baal and Ashtoreth as partners. Many communities worshiped Baal and Ashtoreth in different ways and by different names.

Stop here and look at a picture of the statues of Baal and Ashtoreth as a group. Pause this audio here.

The people of Israel rejected or turned away from all the false gods and returned to Yahweh to worship and serve Yahweh only.

Samuel sent a message to all the people of Israel and told them to gather together at Mizpah so that Samuel could pray to Yahweh for the people. When the people had gathered at Mizpah, they drew water, probably from a well, and poured it before Yahweh. This ritual was probably part of an offering or sacrifice that the people made to Yahweh. The people may also have poured the water as a sign that the people were rejecting Baal, because

1 Samuel 7:3–17

some people considered Baal the provider of rain. The people also fasted on that day and confessed that they had sinned against Yahweh. Fasting or going without food for some time was a religious practice that people did to pray to their god and show that they had turned away from their disobedience.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some of the rituals your community uses to show God that you are sorry? Imagine the people in your community who had turned away from your way of worship. If those people wanted to return to that worship, how would they do that? Pause this audio here.

It was on this day that Samuel the prophet began to act as a judge or leader of the Israelite people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who is the great leader or chief of your people? What are his or her responsibilities? When did this leader begin to be the leader of your people? Pause this audio here.

Someone told the Philistines that the Israelites had gathered together at Mizpah. The Philistine rulers marched out with their army against the Israelites. When the Israelites heard about it, they were afraid that the Philistines would kill the Israelites. The Israelites asked Samuel to pray and beg Yahweh, their God, to rescue them from the power of the Philistines. So Samuel took a young lamb that was still young enough to drink its mother's milk. Samuel cut the lamb up and burned it entirely as a burnt offering to Yahweh. Yahweh had instructed Israel that they could offer a calf, lamb, or baby goat as a burnt offering from the time it was eight days old. Levites offered these burnt offerings to Yahweh on behalf of a person or the nation to say sorry for sin. Samuel may have been a Levite. In any case, Samuel acted like one now.

Stop here and look at a picture of a young lamb as a group. Pause this audio here.

Samuel prayed and begged Yahweh to save the Israelites from the Philistines, and Yahweh heard and accepted Samuel's request.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when your people were in great danger and cried out to God for help. Who spoke to God for the people, and how did he or she do it? Describe any rituals that the person did. Pause this audio here.

This is how Yahweh answered Samuel's prayer: As Samuel was offering the sacrifice, the Philistine army had been approaching the Israelites and had gotten near enough to attack the Israelites. Yahweh sent the sound of a loud thunder against the Philistines and defeated them in the presence of the Israelites. The people of Israel believed that thunder was Yahweh's voice. People believed that Dagon, the Philistines' god, and the Baals controlled the skies. It is likely that Yahweh sent thunder to show that it was Yahweh who controlled the skies. Yahweh's thunder caused the Philistine army to feel great panic. As the Philistines were running away, the men of Israel ran after the Philistines and killed many Philistine men. The Israelites continued chasing and killing the Philistines until they reached a place below Beth Kar.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when your fighters or the fighters of another community lost a battle and ran away in panic. How many fighters died when they ran away in panic, compared to how many fighters died when they drew back all together from the fight? Pause this audio here.

Samuel took a stone and set it up between Mizpa and Shen. People often set up stones where something important happened to remind them of that event. Samuel named the stone Ebenezer, which means "stone of help," because Samuel said that Yahweh had helped Israel up to this point. Samuel likely wanted the people of Israel and their children to remember what Yahweh had done for them so that they would not return to worship false gods.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In what ways does your community keep memory of important events and pass that memory down to later generations? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh defeated the Philistines and made them weaker than the Israelites. The Philistines stopped entering Israel's territory to attack the Israelites.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of the division of the territory of the Israelites and Philistines. Pause this audio here.

For the rest of the time that Samuel was alive, Yahweh was against the Philistines so that they did not enter the land of Israel to take it. The cities between the two large cities of Ekron and Gath that the Philistines had taken

1 Samuel 7:3–17

from Israel became Israel's territory again. Israel also took back the land that was around those cities from the control of the Philistines. The Amorites, a large and powerful tribe of people who lived in the land of Canaan, also stopped fighting the Israelites at that time and made peace with the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when your people took back their own land or property, such as livestock, from your enemies in battle. Or tell about a time when your people took your enemies' land or property because you won a battle. Pause this audio here.

Samuel continued to be the leader of the people of Israel for the rest of his life. Every year, Samuel went to three important Israelite cities to judge the people of Israel. It is likely that Samuel listened to the people's problems and gave them solutions and leadership. It is also likely that Samuel gave justice to people who were in legal disputes after Samuel heard those people's cases.

Discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when people in your community had a legal dispute. Describe one major dispute among the people. What leader settled those people's legal case, and why did the people in the dispute listen to the leader's decision? Pause this audio here.

Samuel traveled to Bethel, Gilgal, and Mizpah. But Samuel always returned to Ramah, his hometown, where Samuel also judged the people.

Stop here and look at a map of Samuel's route as a group. Pause this audio here.

Samuel also built an altar to Yahweh in Ramah. People usually used stone to build altars. People made sacrifices on these altars. The Philistines had probably already destroyed the tabernacle at Shiloh, where the Israelites used to go to sacrifice to Yahweh when Eli was alive. Samuel likely led the people in offering sacrifices, which would mean that Samuel did the job of a priest.

Stop here and look at a picture of a stone altar as a group.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 7:3–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has nine scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel told the Israelites that if they truly wanted to return to Yahweh, the people needed to reject and turn away from all of the false gods. The people needed to be committed to Yahweh and worship Yahweh alone. Samuel told the people that Yahweh would save the Israelites from the power of the Philistines if the Israelites did these things.

In the second scene: The people listened to Samuel and returned to Yahweh.

In the third scene: Samuel sent a message to all of Israel and told the people to gather at Mizpah so that Samuel could pray to Yahweh for the people.

In the fourth scene: The people gathered at Mizpah. The people drew water and poured it out before Yahweh. The people fasted that day and confessed their sin.

In the fifth scene: The rulers of the Philistines heard that the Israelites had gathered together at Mizpah, and the Philistines came up to attack the Israelites.

In the sixth scene: The Israelites were afraid when they heard that the Philistines were coming to attack them. The Israelites asked Samuel to cry out to Yahweh to save them. While Samuel was offering a sacrifice to Yahweh, the Philistines came close to attack. But Yahweh sent thunder to scare the Philistines, and Yahweh defeated the Philistines that day.

In the seventh scene: Samuel took a stone and set up a memorial between Mizpah and Shen to remind the people what Yahweh had done for the Israelites.

1 Samuel 7:3–17

In the eighth scene: The Philistines stopped entering Israel's territory to fight against Israel because Yahweh had defeated the Philistines. Israel recovered the cities and lands between Ekron and Gath that the Philistines had taken from the Israelites. The Amorites also made peace with Israel.

In the ninth scene: Samuel continued to judge Israel's people all the days of Samuel's life. Every year, Samuel went around in a circle from Bethel to Gilgal to Mizpah, and Samuel judged the people of Israel in each place. Samuel also judged the people in Ramah, Samuel's hometown. Samuel built an altar to Yahweh in Ramah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- The people of Israel
- The Baals and Ashtoreths—all the false gods that the Israelites had been worshiping
- The rulers of the Philistines
- The Philistines
- And the Amorites

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The word that opens the first scene shows that Samuel is responding to the previous story. In the previous story, the ark remained in Kiriath Jearim for a long time, and the people of Israel lamented or looked for Yahweh. In the first scene of this story, Samuel responded to the people's lament by telling the house or nation of Israel that if the people were truly returning to Yahweh with all their heart, the people should get rid of their foreign gods. Samuel is telling the Israelites that they need to stop disobeying. The people need to turn back to Yahweh. Samuel says that the Israelites must be sincere and be totally committed to Yahweh. But Samuel uses the special language "with all their heart" because the Israelites believe the heart is the part of the body that shows emotion and commitment.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What special language do you have in your community to speak about someone who does something earnestly and sincerely? In your language, which part of the body do you speak of as being the center of commitment, emotion, or determination? Pause audio here.

Samuel told the people that they should completely put away, get rid of, or turn from worshiping the foreign gods that the nations around them worshiped, including the Ashtaroth. Ashtaroth was a very popular female god of the Canaanites. Samuel told the Israelites that if the Israelites directed or turned their attention to Yahweh and served and worshiped Yahweh only, Yahweh would save the Israelites from the power of the Philistines. The Israelites were supposed to serve Yahweh with sacrifices, rituals, special days, pilgrimages, and temple ceremonies. But the Israelites had stopped doing these things for Yahweh and had instead been doing them for the Baals and Ashtoreths. Samuel is telling the Israelites that they need to stop doing those things and commit themselves completely to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In what ways do your community and the communities around you serve or worship God? Pay attention to the words you use for worship and serve. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the people listened to Samuel. The people put away their many idols or statues and served Yahweh only. The storyteller refers to the Baal and Ashtaroth as being many. This could mean that the people had many idols of the same two gods, or it could also mean that the Israelites had many kinds of male and female gods.

In the third scene, Samuel told all the people of Israel to gather at Mizpah so that Samuel could pray to Yahweh for the people. Samuel wanted to pray for the people so that Yahweh would bring the people back into a peaceful relationship with Yahweh. This would happen if Yahweh forgave the people for worshiping other gods. It is unlikely that every man, woman, and child in Israel came to Mizpah. It is more likely that Samuel meant all adult men. Mizpah means watchtower or lookout. People probably called more than one place in Israel "Mizpah." This Mizpah was in the territory of Benjamin, 13 kilometers north of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of Mizpah as a group. Pause audio here.

1 Samuel 7:3–17

In the fourth scene, the people gathered at Mizpah. When the people had gathered at Mizpah, the people drew water from a well or a pit and poured it out before Yahweh. The people may have poured out water "before Yahweh" as a ritual that was part of a particular sacrifice or offering. It may also be possible that the people were simply denying themselves drinking water. The people may also have wanted to show that they were pouring out, or giving, their sorrow and wrongdoing to Yahweh. The people also fasted or went without food all that day and confessed that they had sinned against Yahweh. The people confessed together for the sin of the whole nation. The people may have also confessed individual sins. Yahweh had promised the people of Israel in the days of Moses that Yahweh would forgive the people whenever they returned to Yahweh and put away their idols and confessed their sin. Yahweh cared about what the people believed and felt about Yahweh. The people needed to sincerely repent. The rituals were outward signs of what was happening in the people's hearts or thoughts. Samuel was the one who was judging or leading the people. A judge in those days led the people to return to Yahweh and to fight their enemies. Samuel also prayed for the nation and set up memorials.

In the fifth scene, as the people of Israel confessed their sin in Mizpah, someone told the Philistines that the Israelites had gathered at Mizpah. The rulers of the Philistines marched out with their men and came to attack the Israelites. People commonly began war with religious rituals, so the rulers of the Philistines probably thought that the Israelites were preparing themselves to attack the Philistines.

In the sixth scene, someone told the Israelites that the Philistines were coming to attack the Israelites. The Israelites were afraid that the Philistines would defeat and kill the Israelites. So the Israelites asked Samuel to keep crying out and urgently beg Yahweh to save the Israelites from the power of the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when your people prayed to God to save them from certain death. How did your people sound when they prayed? Pay attention to the words you use for the type of praying that the people did. Pause this audio here.

Samuel responded to the Israelites' request by taking a young or baby lamb and sacrificing it to Yahweh as a burnt offering. The Israelites usually offered a burnt offering to ask Yahweh to forgive the Israelites for their sins. It is likely that Samuel killed and chopped up the animal before he burned the animal completely. Samuel prayed earnestly to Yahweh and asked Yahweh to save the Israelites from the power of the Philistines just as the people of Israel had requested.

Yahweh heard and answered Samuel's prayer in this way. As Samuel had been offering the burnt offering, the Philistines had been approaching the people of Israel to attack the people of Israel. It is likely that at the time that Samuel was sacrificing and praying, the Philistines were close enough to the Israelites to attack them and begin a battle. Yahweh sent a loud thunder against the Philistines and confused the Philistines. It is likely that the sound that the Philistines heard was a loud thunder. The Israelites believed that thunder was Yahweh's voice.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the sound of loud thunder in your language. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh defeated the Philistines, and the Israelites saw Yahweh do it. The Philistines believed that their god Dagon was in charge of storms. It is possible that Yahweh sent thunder against the Philistines to show the Philistines and the Israelites that only Yahweh had power in the skies. The Philistines began to run away. When the Israelites saw this, the Israelites chased the Philistines and continued killing many of the Philistines. The Israelites chased the Philistines all the way to the place people called Beth Kar.

In the seventh scene, after the Israelites had chased off the Philistines and killed many of them, Samuel set up a stone between Mizpah and Shen to help the Israelites remember the victory. Samuel called the stone Ebenezer or "stone of help" because Samuel said that up to that point, it was Yahweh who had helped the Israelites.

In the eighth scene, the Philistines stopped coming into the land of Israel to make war on Israel, because Yahweh had conquered the Philistines. It is likely that the Philistines would have come into the land of Israel for other reasons, but they did not come again with their army to harass Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories about an enemy tribe or community that invaded your lands to fight with you or steal from you. Discuss a time when you were able to defeat that tribe or community. If you have never defeated those people, imagine the day that you will. Tell how those people stopped fighting you. Pay attention to the words you use for how the enemy stopped wanting to fight you. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 7:3–17

For the rest of the days that Samuel remained alive, the hand or power of Yahweh was against the Philistines to stop the Philistines from defeating Israel. The Israelites use the special language "hand of Yahweh" to talk about Yahweh's power.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What special language do you use in your community to talk about the way someone powerfully defeats that person's enemy? Pause this audio here.

The big cities of Ekron and Gath remained under the Philistines' control, but the Israelites retook all the cities between Ekron and Gath that the Philistines had previously taken from the Israelites. Israel also delivered or saved the lands around those cities from the Philistines' control. The Amorites, who lived in the land of Canaan, also stopped attacking the Israelites.

In the ninth scene, Samuel acted as the leader of the people of Israel for all the days of his life. Samuel would travel around the country in a circle each year. Samuel would go from Bethel to Gilgal and then to Mizpah. In each of these towns, Samuel would listen to the Israelites' problems or disputes, and Samuel would give the people justice by telling them what would be pleasing to Yahweh in each case. Samuel would always return to his house in Samuel's ancestral hometown, Ramah. The people of Israel would also come to Ramah to get justice from Samuel. Samuel also built an altar to sacrifice to Yahweh in Ramah. It is likely that the people of Israel brought their sacrifices to Ramah, where Samuel would also be the religious leader. Samuel was a prophet, but in this story, Samuel also became a judge and did the job of a priest by leading the people in offering sacrifices.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 7:3–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has nine scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- The people of Israel
- The Baals and Ashtoreths, all the false gods that the Israelites had been worshiping
- The rulers of the Philistines
- The Philistines
- And the Amorites

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, Samuel told the people of Israel that if they were returning to Yahweh with all their heart, they should get rid of their foreign gods and serve Yahweh alone. Then Yahweh would save the Israelites from the hand of the Philistines. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

1 Samuel 7:3–17

- I have been patient with these rebellious children. The people have left me and followed deaf and mute idols. The people bow down to the Baals and Ashtoreths; or
- I have allowed the Israelites to suffer so that they might turn away from their evil ways. I have not listened to the Israelites' cries because of their evil ways. But I am ready to listen now if the Israelites will listen to my words that I give to Samuel; or
- I did not completely forsake my people Israel because I am faithful and have loved them with an everlasting love.

Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have heard that the Israelite people want to return to Yahweh; or
- This news is very good. My heart is glad, and I thank Yahweh for turning the hearts of the people back to Yahweh. I have prayed for Israel for many years, and finally Yahweh has heard. I thank Yahweh that he did not completely destroy the Israelites. Yahweh is a merciful God who is slow to get angry. Yahweh will have mercy on the Israelites if they listen to Yahweh; or
- The Israelites must reject all their false idols and worship Yahweh alone. Yahweh is a jealous God and will not tolerate any other god beside Yahweh. The Israelites cannot serve Yahweh together with Baal and Ashtoreth.

Continue the drama. In the second scene, the Israelite people listened to Samuel and got rid of their Baals and Ashtoreths. The people served Yahweh alone. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel terrible. Our sin is great. We are very miserable. Our days pass by in tears. We left Yahweh and followed the ways of the foreign nations. We went to those nations' temples and sacrificed to their Gods. We broke Yahweh's first commandment, and we have suffered these many years for doing that. The Philistines continue to oppress us. Our life is difficult and we have found no help from Baal or Ashtoreth; or
- Oh that Yahweh would forgive us. We have learned that Yahweh is a powerful God, the only true God, and the God of our fathers; or
- Each of us has thrown away the idols that he kept in his house. We want to bow down to Yahweh only. We want to be Yahweh's people and Yahweh will be our God.

Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy. The people are sincere in their desire to return to Yahweh; or
- The nation needs to become clean again. We must confess before Yahweh our great sin and offer the right sacrifices. This is the ritual for restoring our relationship with Yahweh.

Continue the drama. In the third scene, Samuel sent a message to all of Israel and told the people to gather at Mizpah so that Samuel could pray to Yahweh for the people. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel like it is very important that I must gather the people so that we can confess our sins to Yahweh and ask for Yahweh's forgiveness and help.

Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Samuel will be a priest for us. Samuel will offer the right sacrifices and cry out to Yahweh for us; or
- We abandoned Yahweh, but now we are returning and Samuel will lead the way; or
- Yahweh will listen to Yahweh's prophet Samuel.

Continue the drama. In the fourth scene, the people gathered at Mizpah. The people drew water and poured it out before Yahweh. The people fasted that day and confessed their sin. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are sad. We have behaved in an evil way. We have insulted Yahweh's goodness; or
- We really want Yahweh to come back; or
- Only Yahweh can provide food and water. Baal and Ashteroth cannot provide these things.

Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

1 Samuel 7:3–17

- This is a good day. The nation is returning to Yahweh; or
- Though the people feel sad, this is a day to rejoice because we are finally returning to Yahweh; or
- We return to Yahweh with these rituals to show Yahweh how we are following him again.

Continue the drama. In the fifth scene, as the people of Israel were confessing their sin, someone told the Philistines that the Israelites had gathered at Mizpah. The rulers of the Philistines marched out with their men and came to attack the Israelites. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the rulers of the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are very concerned. Why have the Israelites gathered together? Do the Israelites intend to attack us? We are angry and will not allow this to continue. We will teach the Israelites a lesson; or
- We will gather our men quickly and attack the Israelites immediately. We must punish the Israelites so severely that the Israelites will never try this again; or
- The Israelites are still making sacrifices to their gods. Do the Israelites think that their gods are stronger than our gods?

Continue the drama. In the sixth scene, the Israelites heard that the Philistines were coming to attack the Israelites. The Israelites were afraid that the Philistines would kill the Israelites. The Israelites asked Samuel to beg Yahweh to save the Israelites. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are very afraid. We are not prepared for battle; or
- Only Yahweh can help us.

Continue the drama. So Samuel took a young lamb and sacrificed the lamb as a burnt offering. Samuel cried out to Yahweh to save the Israelites. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so sad that our sins have caused this; or
- The lamb I sacrifice must be perfect. This is how we make peace with Yahweh; or
- I am praying earnestly to Yahweh to forgive us and save us. And the people are praying too.

Continue the drama. Yahweh heard and answered Samuel because, whilst Samuel was still offering the sacrifice, the Philistines came to attack the Israelites. Yahweh made a noise like loud thunder and confused the Philistines. There was a great panic amongst the Philistines so that they began to run away. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased with my people, Israel. The Israelites' sacrifice is acceptable to me. The smoke of the Israelites' sacrifice rises to me as a pleasing aroma. I will accept Samuel's prayer for the Israelites, and I will show the Israelites that I have heard by defeating their enemy; or
- The Israelites' hearts are sincere. I have forgiven the Israelites' evil ways. I am not angry with the Israelites. I will save my children from disaster.

Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so afraid because the gods of the Israelites attack us; or
- Our military leaders have left us! or
- So many of our people are dead. The confusion and chaos make us even weaker. We have lost all our strength and confidence.

Continue the drama. The Israelites chased the Philistines, who were escaping, and killed many of the Philistines. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Praise Yahweh our God! or
- Yahweh has given us victory. We are full of courage now that Yahweh has heard our cry and acted for us. Let us all chase our enemy and kill the Philistines.

Continue the drama. In the seventh scene, Samuel took a stone and set it up between Mizpah and Shen to remind the people of what Yahweh had done for them. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

1 Samuel 7:3–17

- I feel joy and happiness. This stone will help us remember this memory forever; or
- The people forget easily, and they turn away from Yahweh and go after foreign gods. If the people do forget, this stone will remind the people about the slavery they suffered under the Philistines and how Yahweh delivered the Israelites.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- If the people remember who I am and what I have done for them, the people will be faithful to me; or
- I am so happy that my people are free. It does not please me for my people to be in bondage.

Continue the drama. In the eighth scene, the Philistines stopped entering Israel's territory to fight against Israel because Yahweh had defeated the Philistines. Israel recovered the cities between Ekron and Gath that the Philistines had taken from the Israelites. Israel also took back the lands around those cities. The Amorites also made peace with Israel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistine rulers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We will not attack Israel anymore. The power of Israel's God terrifies us; or
- The Philistine warriors would not listen to us anyway. None of them wants to fight against Israel anymore.

Ask the person playing the Amorites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We heard what the God of the Israelites did to the Philistines, and we became very scared. We live very close to the Israelites and do not want to be at war with the Israelites.

Continue the drama. In the ninth scene, Samuel continued to judge the Israelites people all the days of his life. Samuel went around in a circle from Bethel to Gilgal to Mizpah. Samuel judged the people of Israel in those places. Samuel also judged the people in Ramah, Samuel's hometown. Samuel also built an altar to Yahweh in Ramah. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that the people do not worship idols anymore; or

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy. My people worship only me. I have given my people peace with their enemies, and my people increase in the land. I will keep blessing my people because I love them; or
- Samuel has been faithful to me. Samuel has followed me with his whole heart and has led my people well; or
- I will punish my people's enemies who come to attack them because my people are pleasing to me. My people listen to my word that I give to Samuel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 7:3–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel told the house of Israel that if they were returning to Yahweh, the people should put away the foreign gods and Ashtaroth and direct their hearts to Yahweh and serve Yahweh only. "House of Israel" refers to the nation of Israel, which is all of Jacob's descendants together. House of Israel means the same as Israelites or "people of Israel."

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **house of Israel**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. For more information, look up Israel in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **Yahweh** as you used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for more information about Yahweh. Foreign gods and Ashtaroth are gods of other nations. Gods of other nations are not the same as the one true God, Yahweh. Yahweh told the people of Israel not to worship or follow any other god but Yahweh. Sometimes people used wood or metal to make statues or pillars to represent their gods. People called these things idols. "Foreign gods" is a general phrase that includes any god of another country or community. Ashtoroth was a female fertility goddess of Cannan.

1 Samuel 7:3–17

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foreign gods and Ashtaroth**. Look up gods in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Serve is another word for worship. When you serve someone, you live and work for that person. Samuel told Israel to serve or worship Yahweh by bowing down, sacrificing, praying, and being obedient to Yahweh only. To do that, the Israelites would have to stop serving the foreign gods.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **serve**. If you decide to use the idea of worship in this passage, look up worship in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

The people put away the Baals and Ashtaroth and served Yahweh only. Baal was a male fertility god of the Canaanites. The Canaanites considered Baal to be the husband of Ashtaroth. When the storyteller refers to the Baal and Ashtaroth as many instead of individuals, this could refer to the many idols people made to represent Baal and Ashtaroth or to the many other male and female gods of the surrounding nations.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Baal** and **Ashtaroth**. Look up Baal in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel gathered all Israel at Mizpah and drew water and poured it out before Yahweh. The people fasted all that day. When someone is fasting, that person is not eating or drinking anything for a certain amount of time. Sometimes people fasted because they wanted to ask Yahweh to forgive their sins. In that case, fasting was a sign of humility. Sometimes people were fasting because they needed Yahweh to help them, or they wanted Yahweh to tell them what to do. Fasting was then a way to show Yahweh how serious the problem was. People in many cultures know the practice of fasting. When you translate the word fasting, be careful that the word in your language does not mean fasting in honor of a particular god or religion, or for one particular purpose. You may need to use a different word or phrase that explains the biblical practice of fasting.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **fasting**. Look up fasting in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel **judged** the people of Israel. Yahweh gave the people of Israel men and sometimes women whom people called judges to lead the people and decide their cases for them. Samuel was a prophet, but Samuel also became a judge. Samuel led the Israelite people in offering sacrifices and prayer. Samuel also led the people in war and set up memorials. Use the same word or phrase for judge as you used in previous passages. For more information on judges, refer to the Master Glossary.

When the Philistines heard that the Israelites had gathered at Mizpah, the Philistine rulers marched their armies out to attack the Israelites. The Israelites were afraid when they heard that the Philistines were coming to attack the Israelites. The Israelites asked Samuel to beg Yahweh to save the Israelites. Samuel took a suckling lamb and offered it to Yahweh as a burnt offering. Samuel cried to Yahweh to save Israel, and Yahweh answered. A suckling lamb is a lamb that is still young enough to drink its mother's milk.

Stop here and look at a picture of a suckling lamb as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **suckling lamb**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A **burnt offering** is a form of sacrifice that people bring to God. When a person brings God a burnt offering, that person kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar, which is a special place that people make for bringing gifts to God. Samuel was probably telling Yahweh that the Israelite people would be completely devoted to Yahweh, just as they completely burned the animal. Use the same word or phrase for burnt offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

After Yahweh had defeated the Philistines, Samuel set up a stone between Mizpah and Shen. Samuel called the stone **Ebenezer**, which means "stone of help," to remind the Israelite people that Yahweh had helped them up to that point. It is important to connect the name Ebenezer with its meaning because this is why Samuel used the

1 Samuel 7:3–17

name. You can use the name Ebenezer and give the meaning, or you can say the name Ebenezer in the closest-sounding way in your language. Use the same word or phrase for Ebenezer as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines stopped entering the land of Israel to fight, and the Israelites recovered the land that the Philistines had taken from the Israelites. The Amorites also made peace with Israel. When nations live in harmony with each other without fighting, those nations are living in peace.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **peace**. Look up peace in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel judged Israel for the rest of Samuel's life. Samuel would go around the Israel cities of Bethel, Gilgal, and Mizpeh every year and judge the people there. But Samuel would always return to his home in Ramah, where Samuel built an altar to Yahweh. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. An altar is like a table or a platform that people make of earth or large stones. People placed gifts for God on this table. Often, this meant that people then burned the gift. The gift could be an animal, food items, or sweet-smelling spices.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **altar**. Look up altar in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 7:3–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (807 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (8.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.5 MB)

- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 Samuel 8:1–9

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 8:1–9 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:1–9 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Samuel has been leading the Israelites for many years and is now growing old. Instead of new judges to replace Samuel, the Israelites want a king like the nations around them. The Israelites are really rejecting Yahweh, because Yahweh chooses the judges. But Yahweh tells Samuel to appoint or choose a king. First, though, Samuel must warn the people about how a king will act. This is an important moment for Israel, when kings begin to lead, instead of judges.

As Samuel grows older, Samuel appoints or chooses his sons to be judges. Judges are people who help solve disagreements and lead the Israelites. Samuel may have wanted his sons to help him lead and maybe continue to lead after Samuel dies. This is the first time a judge chooses the next judge. Normally, God chooses each judge. Samuel's two sons are Joel and Abijah, and these men are judges in the south of Israel in a town people call Beersheba. This is far from where Samuel lives in the town of Ramah.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group and find the towns of Beersheba and Ramah. Pause this audio here.

But Samuel's sons are not good judges. The storyteller uses the special language of walking to describe how Joel and Abijah act. Samuel acts in a fair and just way, which is like walking on good, straight paths. Samuel's sons do not follow Samuel's example or walk on those good, straight paths. Instead, Samuel's sons turn and get off the good paths to do wrong and unfair things. Because Samuel's sons are greedy for money, Joel and Abijah accept bribes or gifts of money from people to make wrong and bad judgments. Joel and Abijah prevent justice or do not treat people fairly according to Yahweh's laws.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, describe a leader who acts in a fair and just way. Then describe a leader who does not act in a fair and just way. Discuss what kind of phrases or comparisons you would use to compare those two leaders. Pause this audio here.

Since the Israelites are unhappy with their leaders, the Israelite elders ask Samuel for a new leader for all the Israelites. An elder was the head of a large family or clan. These elders would meet together to make decisions about the community. The elders come to Samuel at Ramah to speak with Samuel. Samuel is getting old, the elders say, which probably means that the elders are worried Samuel will not be able to lead the people for much longer. The elders do not want Samuel's sons to take Samuel's place because the sons do not act fairly like Samuel does. For the Israelites' new leader, the elders ask for a king to lead them. The Israelites want to be like the other nations that have kings.

1 Samuel 8:1–9

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss the different kinds of leaders in your cultures, such as leaders of family groups, cities, tribes, or nations. What words do you use for these different leaders? Which leaders are more important or have more authority than the other leaders? Who chooses the new leaders? Pause this audio here.

Samuel is not happy that the people asked for a king. The storyteller says that the people's request was evil in Samuel's eyes. This means that Samuel thinks that this is a bad or evil request. Samuel knows that Yahweh has chosen Israel to be Yahweh's people and to be different than the other nations. But now, Israel wants to be like the other nations that have a king. In this time, kings had all of the power and authority, more than the judges who followed Yahweh's guidance. Also, a king would rule for life and then pass on his authority to one of his sons. With a king to lead them, the Israelites will not have to wait for Yahweh to appoint the next judge. Because Samuel is worried about this request, Samuel prays to Yahweh to ask what to do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you saw something bad or evil that made you unhappy or upset. Discuss as a group what words or phrases you use to describe how you feel about something that is bad or evil. What words or phrases do you use to show you are unhappy with something? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh speaks to Samuel and tells Samuel to choose a king for the people. Yahweh explains that when the people ask Samuel to give them a new leader to replace Samuel, the people are not just rejecting Samuel as their leader. The people are actually rejecting Yahweh as their king, since Yahweh chooses the judges, including Samuel. With this request, the elders are saying that Yahweh is not a good enough king and that a human king and his sons will do a better job.

Yahweh says that the Israelites have been rejecting Yahweh for a long time. From when Yahweh brought the Israelites out of Egypt up until that day, the Israelites abandoned Yahweh to worship other false gods. And now, the Israelites are treating Samuel in the same way by rejecting Samuel's leadership. Again, Yahweh tells Samuel to do what the elders want, but to first explain what a king will be like. Samuel must solemnly warn the people about what a king will do when he rules over the people. Then the Israelites can see how different a human king is from Yahweh.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel appoints Samuel's sons to be judges. But Samuel's sons are dishonest and accept gifts of money to make wrong judgments.

In the second scene: The Israelite elders come to Samuel and ask Samuel to appoint a king to lead the Israelites so the Israelites will be like the other nations.

In the third scene: Samuel prays to Yahweh about the elders' request. Yahweh tells Samuel to choose a king. Yahweh explains that the people are really rejecting Yahweh as their king and leader, just like the people have been doing since they left Egypt. Yahweh tells Samuel to warn the people how the king will act.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Samuel's sons, Joel and Abijah
- The elders of Israel
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

1 Samuel 8:1–9

The first scene in this story probably begins many years after the victory in the last passage. Samuel is old, old enough to have two adult sons. Samuel appoints his sons or gives his sons authority to lead. Samuel may have needed help to lead the Israelites, or maybe Samuel was preparing for when he could not lead anymore. Samuel lives in the town of Ramah in the center of Israel and, according to the last passage, Samuel sometimes travels to nearby towns. Samuel's sons go down to the town of Beersheba, in the south of Israel, and judge there. Because Samuel's sons are greedy for money, Samuel's sons accept money secretly to make wrong judgments. Samuel is not nearby to stop or correct Samuel's sons.

The second scene happens some time after the first. Samuel's sons have been judging long enough for the people to see how bad the sons are. So the elders go to Ramah to speak with Samuel. The elders begin to speak to Samuel with a word that means, "Pay attention! We are about to say something important!"

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what words or phrases do you use to get someone's attention when you want to talk about something important? Pause this audio here.

The elders mention two problems. First, Samuel is old, so Samuel will not be able to lead the Israelites for much longer. Also, Samuel's sons are not good leaders, so the elders do not want the sons to lead the Israelites after Samuel dies. The elders tell Samuel that the way to solve these problems is to pick a new leader, a king! The Israelites have seen the kings of other nations, and the elders want to have a king too. Samuel is not pleased with this request.

In the third scene, Samuel talks to Yahweh, and Yahweh tells Samuel what to do. Yahweh tells Samuel to listen to the elders' request. This means that Samuel should do what the elders ask. Yahweh says that the Israelites are treating Samuel in the same way that the Israelites have treated Yahweh. The people are rejecting Samuel as their leader while Samuel is still alive. The Israelites are asking for a different kind of leader, which the Israelites think will be better than a judge. In the same way, the Israelites have also been rejecting Yahweh ever since Yahweh brought the Israelites out of Egypt. To this day, the Israelites keep worshiping other gods. The Israelites think these gods will be better than Yahweh.

Yahweh explains that the Israelites are really rejecting Yahweh again, not just Samuel, when they ask for a new leader. Yahweh has been choosing the judges and leaders of Israel. This means that Yahweh was the king, or top leader of Israel. With this request, the elders are saying that Yahweh is not a good enough king and that a human king will do a better job.

Again, Yahweh tells Samuel to listen and do what the people ask. But before Samuel anoints a king, Samuel should warn the people what a king will do. Samuel should speak clearly and seriously. This means that Samuel should speak in a formal way to show how important this information is. The king will declare that he has certain privileges or that certain actions are right for the king to do as king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of times when people speak in a solemn or formal and serious way, such as during a ceremony. Discuss how you would describe that kind of speaking. Pause this audio here.

Now stop and discuss roles or jobs in your culture that come with certain duties and privileges, like a husband or business owner. Discuss how and why people get those roles, and the privileges, too. Discuss what words or phrases you would use to describe how these people take or use these privileges. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh already warned the Israelites about the danger of kings when Yahweh gave the Israelites his law. Yahweh is reminding the Israelites that this is an important choice, and Yahweh is showing the Israelites how a human king will lead them differently than Yahweh does.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

1 Samuel 8:1–9

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Samuel's sons, Joel and Abijah
- The elders of Israel
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

When Samuel became an old man, Samuel appointed his sons to be judges in Israel. Samuel's oldest son was Joel, and Samuel's second son was Abijah. Joel and Abijah acted as judges in the town of Beersheba. But Samuel's sons did not follow Samuel's good example. Samuel's sons were only interested in making money, so they accepted bribes to make wrong judgments. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to lead the people well, but as I get older, I become more tired and cannot listen to everyone's problems! I need some help! or
- I trust my sons. As my sons grew up, Joel and Abijah saw how I judged and led the Israelites. Surely Joel and Abijah will lead in the same way; or
- I am worried for the Israelites. When I die, the Israelites will need a new leader! I will go ahead and choose some new leaders, so that the Israelites will not have trouble after I die.

Ask the person playing Joel and Abijah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have seen the way my father acts as a judge, but that does not seem like the best way to me. I am sure I know more than my father does. It is a good thing we do not live near our father, so our father cannot correct or catch us; or
- I do not want to have to work too hard to get money! If I take these bribes that people give me, then I will be able to live well and comfortably! or
- I am excited to have this new job as a judge! I do not really care about doing what is right or helping other people. I just want to be important and rich!

Continue the drama. So all the elders of Israel went together to Ramah to talk with Samuel. The elders said to Samuel, "Look, you are old now, but your sons do not follow your good example. So now choose a king to lead us, so that we will have a king like all the other nations."

But Samuel did not think that the elders' request for a king was good. Samuel prayed to Yahweh and told Yahweh what the people had asked for. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the elders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Samuel's sons are not good judges! I am tired of having judges. I want a new kind of leader; or
- I see other nations have strong kings who make the nations wealthy and powerful! I want what those nations have! or
- I do not like waiting around for Yahweh to pick a new judge. When we do not have a judge, other nations fight against us and win! I would rather have a strong king who can protect us all the time!

Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

1 Samuel 8:1–9

- Now I am even more worried about the Israelites! The Israelites want to be like the nations that do not worship Yahweh and do terrible, evil things! or
- I am offended! These Israelites are saying that they do not want me or my family to lead them! or
- I know that Yahweh is really our leader, not me, so I will ask Yahweh what to do about this. I know Yahweh will give me the right words to tell the people.

Continue the drama. Yahweh said to Samuel, "Do as the people have asked. You think the people are just rejecting you, but really, they are rejecting me as their king. Ever since I rescued the Israelites out of Egypt, these people have rejected me by turning away from me and worshiping other gods. In the same way, the people are rejecting you as their leader. So now do what the people say, but be sure to give them a clear warning and tell the people what their kings will do." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that my people do not want me to lead them. I have protected and saved my people when no human could, but the people still want a human king; or
- I want my people to choose to follow me, so I will give the people a choice. I want the people to understand how a human king will not be as good a leader as I am; or
- Even though the Israelites have rejected me again and again, I am patient with them, because I love them. I have taken care of the Israelites even when they chose other gods. However, things will change if the people pick a human king.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel **appoints** his sons to be judges for Israel. To appoint means to assign a job or role to someone and give that person authority to act in a certain way. Use the same word or phrase for appoint as you used in previous passages.

Judges were leaders who helped settle arguments or disputes and sometimes led the Israelites in battle. God chose all the judges except Samuel's sons.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **judge**. Look up judge in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Israel is the name of the country where the Israelites lived. Sometimes the word Israel refers to all of Abraham's descendants together. It then means the same as Israelites or "people of Israel." For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

Samuel's sons accept bribes or gifts of money to stop or prevent justice. Justice is when someone treats someone else fairly according to the law. Joel and Abijah make wrong, unjust judgments that do not follow God's laws.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **justice**. Look up justice in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Because these new leaders are not just, the Israelite **elders** go to speak to Samuel. In this time, an elder was usually the head of a large family or a clan who had authority in the community. A group of elders would meet together to make decisions about the work in the community. For more information on elder, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for elder as you used in previous passages.

The elders ask Samuel to appoint a **king** like the other nations have. A king was someone who ruled over a city or territory. A king normally ruled for his entire life and passed on his authority to one of the king's sons. Kings had more authority and power than judges. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

A nation is a group of people who belong together, who live in the same country, and who have the same ruler.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **nation**. Look up nation in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Because Samuel is unhappy that the people made this request, Samuel **prays** to Yahweh. To pray means to communicate with or speak to God. For more information on pray, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for pray as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh is God's proper name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh says that the Israelites keep worshiping other **gods**. These are false gods. For more information on gods, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for gods as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 8:1–9

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (734 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 Samuel 8:10–22

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 8:10–22 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:10–22 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

1 Samuel 8:10–22

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:10–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

After Samuel talks with Yahweh about the people's request for a king, Samuel speaks to the elders again. Samuel explains what life with a king would be like. Samuel is trying to warn the elders that their request was not a good one because kings will take many things from the people. However, the Israelites do not listen and insist that they still want a king. When Samuel talks to Yahweh again, Yahweh says to do what the people want and choose a human king.

First, Samuel repeats everything Yahweh has said to the people. Then Samuel explains to the people what a king will have the right to do. Samuel is probably speaking to the elders Samuel talked to in the last section. Samuel says these are the rights of kings or that kings have the authority to do these things.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture's history, how have kings or top rulers behaved? How did people expect the rulers to behave? Why do people expect these things? Pause this audio here.

A king will take the Israelites' sons and daughters and make them serve the king. The king could pay these people or make them work without payment. Either way, the king forces the people to serve whether they want to or not.

A king will take the Israelites' sons and make the sons work in the king's army. The king will make some of the people's sons drive the king's chariots. Chariots were wagon-like vehicles with two wheels. Horses pulled the chariots, and two men, one driver and one warrior, rode the chariot into battle.

Stop here and look at a picture of a chariot as a group. Pause this audio here.

A king will make some of the Israelites' sons serve with the king's horses, riding the horses into battle. Other sons will have to run in front of the king's chariot as runners. In that time, a group of men ran ahead of the king's chariots to clear the way and protect the king. A king will also make the Israelites' sons serve as commanders or military leaders. These commanders would be in charge of a group of soldiers, from 50 men to 1,000 men. These were standard-sized groups, so sometimes people just called these groups a "thousand" or a "fifty."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are the armies or military groups like? How do the leaders organize the soldiers? Who is in charge of the soldiers? Pause this audio here.

A king will also make the Israelites' sons plow or prepare the king's ground for planting crops, then reap or gather the crops for the king's harvest. Other sons will have to make the soldiers' weapons and the equipment for horses in the king's army.

A king will not only take the people's sons for his work, but the king will also take the Israelites' daughters. The king will make these women serve the king as perfumers, who mix ointments and spices for perfume and maybe medicine. Other daughters will have to cook food and bake bread for the king.

A king will also take the Israelites' land and possessions. A king will take the Israelites' best land: their fertile fields where they grow grains, like wheat. The king will take the people's vineyards, the gardens of vines where the people grow grapes. The king will take the people's olive orchards, which are groups of trees that grow olives. A king will take the most fertile fields, the vineyards that grow the largest grapes, and the olive orchards

where the trees grow the most olives. The king will give this land to his own officials and attendants, or trusted servants, probably to keep and reward their loyalty.

Stop here and look at a picture of a vineyard and an olive orchard as a group. Pause this audio here.

A king will then take a tax or portion of the food that the Israelites grow in the fields they have left. The king will take a tenth of their grain and vintage, which are grapes. Out of every ten things the people produce, the king will take one. Then the king will give that food to his important officials and trusted servants. Kings in the nations around Israel normally did this as well.

A king will also take the Israelites' servants, both men and women, so the servants must serve the king instead. A king will also take the Israelites' best donkeys for the king's use. Donkeys were important animals that carried heavy loads and pulled farming equipment.

Stop here and look at a picture of a donkey as a group. Pause this audio here.

Some versions say that the king will take their best young men to serve the king. Other versions say the king will take the people's best cattle. The king is definitely taking both the people's young men and their animals, but the best word to use here is probably cattle. A king will also take a tenth of the flocks of sheep and goats.

Stop here and look at pictures of cattle, goats, and sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the kinds of things rulers in your history have done compared with the kinds of things Samuel says the kings could do. Talk about what things they took or used. Why do you think they did these things? Pause this audio here.

In the end, the Israelites will become the king's slaves. Soon, the Israelites' enemies will not oppress the Israelites anymore, like in the time of the judges. But instead, the Israelites' own king will oppress them! When that time comes, the Israelites will cry out or protest loudly to Yahweh because of their suffering. The Israelites will ask Yahweh for relief because of their king. However, Yahweh will not answer the Israelites when they ask. The Israelites will have to live with the results of their choice.

When Samuel finishes saying all this, the Israelite elders reject Samuel's advice. The elders say, "No! We do not believe you! This will not actually happen!" Again, the elders say that they want to be like other nations. The elders want a king to lead and judge for them. The elders do not want Yahweh to lead them in Yahweh's battles, like Yahweh has done before. Instead, the people want a king to lead them to fight in their own battles.

After Samuel listens to all the people have to say, Samuel tells Yahweh what the people have decided. Again, Yahweh says to listen to the people and do what they ask. Samuel should appoint a king to rule the Israelites. Because Samuel will now begin to search for a king, Samuel tells the Israelite elders to return to their hometowns.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:10–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel describes what kings do. Kings take people's sons and daughters and make those sons and daughters work for the king. Kings take people's best land, produce, animals, and servants. Eventually, the Israelites will become their king's slaves.

In the second scene: The Israelites do not listen to Samuel's warning. Again, the Israelites declare that they want to be like other nations. The Israelites want a king to lead them and fight the Israelites' battles.

In the third scene: Samuel speaks to Yahweh, who tells Samuel to appoint a king. Samuel tells the people to return home.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Yahweh
- The Israelite elders
- The kings who will rule Israel
- The Israelites' sons
- The Israelites' daughters
- The king's officials and attendants
- And the Israelites' servants

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Samuel repeats Yahweh's words to the Israelite elders, then warns them about what a king will have the right to do. Samuel describes a king's actions because the Israelites have never had a king. The Israelite leaders in the past have not acted like a king. Other nations' kings do these things. And now, since the Israelites want to be like other nations, Israel's kings will do similar things. While one king may do all of these things, Samuel is not necessarily describing a certain king. Samuel is warning the Israelites that these are things kings normally do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, describe the duties or actions of a kind of job or role, such as a farmer or a mother. Pay attention to how you show that you are talking about the normal actions of anyone who has that role or job, and not just one specific person. Pause this audio here.

Samuel then lists everything a king will take. The king would probably send his servants and soldiers to take these things from the Israelites. First, Samuel says a king will take the Israelites' sons and daughters and then make them serve the king. These sons and daughters would probably be at least young men and women. Samuel is probably talking about both these elders' children and their future descendants as well.

Samuel first talks about how a king will take the Israelites' sons for the king's army. The Israelites' sons will drive chariots, ride horses, run ahead of the king's chariot to protect the king, lead groups of soldiers, and make equipment for the soldiers. Other sons will have to prepare the king's land for planting food, then gather the food for the king. A king will also take the Israelites' daughters and have them make perfumes, food, and bread for the king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when a leader of a group, like a head of a company or a leader in a community, decided what work people should do. Pay attention to the way that you explain that the leader chose what work the people would do. Pause this audio here.

Next, Samuel explains how a king will take the Israelites' possessions and use them as the king wants. A king will take the land that is best for growing food. The king will take fields and vineyards and olive groves. The Israelites would have spent time preparing their fields, and several years growing their grape vines and olive trees. A king will give this land to his officials and attendants as gifts or payment. A king will also take a portion, one tenth, of people's crops, of their grain and grapes. Again, the king will give these to his attendants and officials, who did not spend time growing these foods.

Then Samuel describes how a king will take the people and animals who serve the Israelites. A king will take the Israelites' servants, both men and women, along with their donkeys. Some versions say the king will also take the people's young men, while some say the king will take their cattle. The king is definitely taking the people's sons and male servants, and the king is also taking their animals. The king will take a tenth of the people's flocks, or groups of sheep and goats.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, think of a dangerous activity or job. Take some time to think about the reasons that activity is dangerous or bad. Try to come up with a list of why the activity is dangerous or bad, and then share your lists with each other and pretend you are trying to convince the others not to do this activity. Afterwards, discuss the way you all arranged your lists and what methods you used to convince the others. Pause this audio here.

In the end, Samuel says, a king will take so much from the Israelites that the king will own even the Israelites. When that time comes, the Israelites will call out for help, for relief. But when the Israelites call out, Yahweh

1 Samuel 8:10–22

will not answer their call. The Israelites have chosen these kings who oppress them. The Israelites chose these kings instead of Yahweh to protect them. So the Israelites will have to deal with the results of their choice.

In the second scene, the Israelites respond to Samuel's warning. The Israelites say, "No!" The Israelites do not believe this will happen, so they do not listen to Samuel's warning. Again, the Israelites say that they want a king. The Israelites want a king because they want to be like other nations. Those nations' kings are always ready to fight when the people want to fight, unlike the judges that Yahweh chooses when Yahweh decides the people should fight. The people do not like waiting for Yahweh's guidance and choices.

In the third scene, when Samuel has listened to everything the people have to say, Samuel talks to Yahweh about the people's response. Now that Samuel has warned the people, Yahweh tells Samuel to begin the process of finding and appointing a king. So then Samuel tells the people to go back to their hometowns, and Samuel probably tells the people that Samuel will now go and choose a king.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:10–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Yahweh
- The Israelite elders
- The kings who will rule Israel
- The Israelites' sons
- The Israelites' daughters
- The king's officials and attendants
- And the Israelites' servants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses. As Samuel tells the people what kings do, the actors can act out what Samuel describes.

Samuel spoke with the people who were asking for a king. Samuel explained to the people exactly what Yahweh had said. Samuel warned the people, "If you have a king, this is how the king will treat you: The king will take your sons and make them serve the king. The king will make some of your sons drive his chariots and others ride his horses in the king's army. Your sons will have to run in front of the king's chariots to honor and protect the king. The king will make some of your sons officers in charge of 50 or 1,000 soldiers. The king will make others prepare his fields and gather his harvests. Also, the king will appoint some of your sons to make weapons for his soldiers to use, and to make equipment for his chariots. The king will take many of your daughters too, and command them to make perfumes, to cook, and to bake for the king." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite sons and daughters, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

1 Samuel 8:10–22

- I do not want to do this job that the king is making me do! I would rather be doing other work, but I cannot leave. The king is powerful and will make us work; or
- Because the king saw how good I am at my job, the king made me come work for him. I would rather work in my hometown. I am sad because I miss my family and friends; or
- I am excited to live near the king and work for him, but I am also worried because I am not sure what my life will be like there.

Continue the drama. Samuel continued speaking and said, "The king will take your best fields, vineyards, and orchards of olive trees. Then the king will give these things to the king's officials. The king will take a tenth of your grain and grapes and give it to his officers and servants. Also, the king will take some of your servants, both men and women, and make them do the king's work. The king will take your best cattle and donkeys for himself. Not only that, but the king will also take a tenth of your flocks of sheep and goats. So in the end, you yourselves will become slaves to your king. When all this happens, you will call out to Yahweh to free you from your king whom you chose. However, when you do, Yahweh will not do as you ask." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am worried for the people of Israel. The people do not understand how much their lives will change if they have a king. I hope the people will listen to what I am saying; or
- I am sad that the people are rejecting Yahweh and his judges. The people keep doing this over and over again! or
- I want the Israelites to understand how the kings will hurt not just these people, but also these people's children and descendants by taking away their belongings, land, and freedom!

Continue the drama. But the Israelite people refused to pay attention to Samuel. The people replied, "No, we will not listen to you! We want a king who will rule over us. If we have a king, our nation will be like the other nations. We will have a king who will judge us and lead us into battle and fight for us." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not think Samuel is telling the truth. The other nations have kings, and those nations beat us in battle. So I think that nations with kings become stronger; or
- We are the leaders of the tribes. We are wise and have experienced many things. I do not think Samuel knows more than all of us. Samuel has not lived with a king! And Samuel's last decision, to appoint his sons as judges, was bad! I trust my own judgment more; or
- I am tired of waiting for Yahweh to send us a leader when it is time to fight. I want our leaders to always be ready to defend us or to attack if another group is weak! Then we can win new land and wealth, and then keep it!

Continue the drama. When Samuel heard everything the people said, Samuel repeated it to Yahweh. Yahweh replied, "Appoint a king over them just as they have asked."

Samuel then told the Israelite people to go back to their hometowns because Samuel had agreed to their request. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have given the people a choice, and even though they chose poorly, I will let the people have their own way. Like a parent who sees their children making the wrong choice, I feel sad for my people; or
- Though Israel has rejected me, I will not abandon Israel, but things will change. The Israelites will turn to their human kings for help, but those kings will not be able to help the Israelites like I can.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 8:10–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel repeats to the Israelites what **Yahweh** has said. Yahweh is God's proper name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

1 Samuel 8:10–22

Then Samuel warns the Israelites about how **kings** act. A king was someone who ruled over a city or territory. A king normally ruled for life and passed on his authority to one of the king's sons. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

A king will take the Israelites' sons and **appoint** those sons to many roles. To appoint means to assign a job or role to someone and give that person authority to act in a certain way. Use the same word or phrase for appoint as you used in previous passages.

A king will make the Israelites' sons drive the king's chariots. Chariots were wagon-like vehicles with two wheels. Horses pulled the chariots, and two men, one driver and one warrior, rode the chariot into battle. The warrior would fight the enemy while standing in the chariot.

Stop here and look at a picture of a chariot again as a group, as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **chariot**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A king will take the people's daughters and make the women serve as perfumers. Perfumers mix spices and oils to make good-smelling scents and healing ointments.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **perfumers**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king will take the Israelites' best vineyards and olive groves. A vineyard is a garden where people grow fruit called grapes on a tree called a grapevine. Olive groves were gardens where people grew fruit called olives on trees. If you planted these trees and grapevines from a seed, they would need to grow for several years before they grew olives or grapes. Both grapes and olives were important crops for the Israelites.

Stop here and look at a picture of a vineyard and an olive orchard again as a group, as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **vineyard** and **olive grove**. Look up vineyard in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king will give this land to his officials and attendants. Some versions say "servants" instead of attendants, but these were probably assistants, trusted people who served the king in important jobs. Later, Samuel says that the king will take the Israelites' male and female servants and that eventually, the Israelites will become the king's slaves. A servant, or a slave, is a man or a woman who works for another person. People pay servants for their work, but people do not pay slaves. In the Bible, authors often used the same word for servant or slave. Most servants did not have a choice about serving the master's family, so these people were like slaves. The Israelites probably had servants that they paid, as well as slaves that they did not pay. However, in the end, the Israelites will definitely be their king's unpaid slaves.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for the king's **attendants** and for the Israelites' **servants** and **slaves**. Although these are all the same word in this story, they probably have slightly different meanings. You may want to use different words for the three. Look up servant in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king will take a portion of the Israelites' flocks. A flock is a group of sheep or goats.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **flock**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Despite Samuel's warning, the people again say they want a king so that the Israelites can be like other **nations**. A nation is a group of people who belong together, who live in the same country, and who have the same ruler. For more information on nation, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for nation as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 8:10–22

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (755 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

1 Samuel 9:1–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 9:1–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:1–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

1 Samuel 9:1–14

Pause this audio here.

A new character enters this story. Saul, a strong and tall man from a respected family, goes searching for his father's lost donkeys. When Saul is about to give up, his servant convinces Saul to ask a man of God for help. This man of God is Samuel, who is looking for a new king.

The section begins by introducing Saul's father, Kish. Kish is from the tribe of Benjamin and is a man of good standing, which means that Kish is wealthy or powerful and that other people respect him. Kish is the son of Abiel, Abiel is the son of Zeror, Zeror is the son of Bekorath, and Bekorath is the son of Aphiah. All of these people are also descendants of Benjamin.

Kish's son, Saul, is an impressive man. No other man in Israel is like Saul. Some versions say that Saul is a handsome young man. At that time, Saul had a son old enough to be a soldier. But compared with Kish, Saul is "a young man." Saul is strong, healthy, and is also tall. Saul is head and shoulders taller than anyone else, which means that no other man in Israel is taller than Saul's shoulders.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Pretend you are introducing an important person, someone you respect, to the group. Explain this person's family line and the person's reputation or place in the community. Then discuss as a group the ways that you normally talk about a person's family and reputation when you are introducing a person. Pause this audio here.

Now Saul's family has a problem. Some of Kish's female donkeys have wandered off, as donkeys often do. Donkeys were important animals because they carried heavy loads and pulled the equipment people used for farming. So Kish asks Saul to go and look for the donkeys and to take a servant with Saul.

Stop here and look at a picture of a donkey as a group. Pause this audio here.

Saul and the servant search for several days as they travel through the tribe of Benjamin's territory and the hill country of Ephraim, which is nearby. It is not clear where Shalishah and Shaalim were, but they were probably regions in Ephraim. However, the donkeys are not in any of those areas.

Stop here and look at a map of the territory of Benjamin and Ephraim as a group. Pause this audio here.

Finally, when Saul and the servant reach the district or region of Zuph, Saul suggests that they stop searching. Saul and the servant have been traveling for about three days, and Saul does not want to worry his father. If Saul and the servant do not come back soon, Kish may worry that Saul is lost or hurt.

The servant suggests a different plan. The servant knows that in a nearby town is a man of God, or a man who serves God. People respected this man because everything this man said would happen did happen. This showed that God was with this man of God. The servant suggests going to the man of God and asking the man where to look for the donkeys.

Saul finds a problem with the servant's plan, though. Saul asks what he and the servant have to give to the man of God. It was normal at that time to give a gift to a man of God, or to anyone with whom you wished to have good relations. But Saul and his servant have eaten all the food in their sacks, and the men have no gift to give. Saul then asks the servant if there is anything they have to give as a gift.

The servant has a solution: he has a quarter of a shekel of silver. A shekel is not a coin, but a certain weight that people used to trade. This quarter shekel is about three grams, and would have been a week's payment for a working man. This is not a big gift, but it is an acceptable gift. The servant offers to give the silver to the man of God so that the man will tell Saul and the servant where to look for the donkeys.

Now the storyteller stops to explain one of the words Saul is about to say. In Saul's time, when people needed to ask for God's guidance, people would often say, "Let us go to the seer." A seer is a person who has a special relationship with God. God gives that person messages about the future to share with the people. The storyteller says that today, in the storyteller's time, people use the word "prophet" instead of "seer." A prophet also shares messages about the future that God gives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are some words or phrases that your grandparents or other older people say that you would say differently? As an activity, discuss how you would explain to your grandparents the new way that people talk. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 9:1–14

The story continues as Saul responds to the servant. Saul says that this is a good plan and that the men should go to the town where the man of God is. This town may be the man of God's hometown, or the man of God may just be visiting this place. This town was on a hill. Towns were often on hills where it was easier for people to defend the town.

As Saul and his servant are walking up the hill towards the town, the men meet some young women. These women are going down the hill to draw water or lift water up from a well or spring in a jar or bucket. Women would fetch water every day, and normally, the women went in the evening when it was cooler. Saul and his servant ask the women if the seer is here in the town.

The young women answer that the seer is here and that the two men should hurry to find the seer. The seer or man of God has just come to this town today because the people are presenting a sacrifice or offering at a high place. High places were places of worship, often on hills and sometimes with shrines or other buildings. While people did worship false gods at high places, this place is probably an official place to worship Yahweh, since the man of God is there.

Stop here and look at a picture of a high place as a group. Pause this audio here.

The young women say that Saul and his servant will easily be able to find the seer when the men enter the town. The seer is about to go to the high place to eat. When people offered an animal as a sacrifice, the people would sometimes offer some parts to burn and then cook and eat the rest. The people who are already at the high place will not eat until the seer comes. The seer must ask God to bless the sacrifice and the food before the guests at the sacrifice can eat. The women urge Saul and his servant to go now, and the women assure the men that the men will definitely find the seer.

So Saul and his servant continue walking up the hill towards the town. As the men enter the town, they can see Samuel, who is the man of God, walking towards them on his way to the high place.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller introduces Saul's father, Kish, and his family line. Then the storyteller describes Saul.

In the second scene: Because some of Kish's donkeys wander off, Kish sends Saul and a servant to go and look for the donkeys. Saul and the servant search several regions but do not find the donkeys.

In the third scene: When Saul suggests that the men stop searching, the servant suggests asking a man of God for guidance. Saul says they do not have a gift to bring, but the servant says he has some silver to give as a gift. Saul agrees to go and meet the man of God.

In the fourth scene: As Saul and the servant approach the town, the men ask some young women if the seer is in the town. The young women say that the seer has just arrived for a sacrifice and that the two men should hurry. As Saul and the servant enter the town, Samuel, the man of God, comes towards the men.

The characters in this passage are:

- Kish
- Saul
- The servant
- The man of God, or seer, who is Samuel
- The young women
- And the people at the sacrifice

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

1 Samuel 9:1–14

The last section ends when Samuel agrees to search for a king. Now, instead of describing Samuel's search, the story introduces another man, Saul, who is searching for something else. This new character's story is a bit of a surprise, which builds some suspense in the story. Eventually, Saul meets up with Samuel, and we see how the stories and the two men's searches connect.

The first scene introduces Saul and his family. Saul is the son of Kish, a wealthy man from the tribe of Benjamin, whom people respect. Kish is the son of Abiel, who is the son of Zeror, the son of Bekorath, the son of Aphiah. All these men were Benjamites as well. Saul is taller and looks more impressive and handsome than anyone else in Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what words or phrases would you use to describe a powerful man whom people respect? What words or phrases would you use to describe an impressive, tall man? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate the list of Saul's ancestors. In your culture, what order do you list ancestors—from the oldest to the present or from the present back to the oldest? Pause this audio here.

The second scene introduces a problem: Kish's donkeys have wandered off. So Kish sends Saul and a servant to look for the donkeys. The two men go northwest into the tribe of Ephraim's territory and search in two areas. The men look in Shalishah, but the donkeys are not there. The men look in Shaalim, but the donkeys are not there. The men search in the territory of the tribe of Benjamin, but the donkeys are not there. For each place the men look, the storyteller repeats that the men cannot find the donkeys.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, tell a story about a time when you lost something and searched in many different places for it. Pay attention to the way you show that this was a long and hard search. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Saul and the servant come to the region of Zuph. The men are probably back in Benjamite territory and close to a town. Saul suggests that the men stop looking for the donkeys. If the men do not go home soon, Saul says that his father will stop worrying about the donkeys and instead worry about Saul and the servant.

But the servant replies, "Look! We are near a town where a man of God is." People often used the title "man of God" for a prophet. The servant suggests that the men ask the man of God where the donkeys are. The storyteller does not reveal who the man of God is at this point. It is possible that Saul and the servant do not know the man of God's name. The audience, however, would quickly realize that this man of God is Samuel, and they would remember that Samuel is looking for a man to appoint as king. Maybe Saul, this impressive man, will be the king!

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Tell a story about a time when you met someone exciting in an unexpected way. Do not immediately explain who the person is as you tell your story. See if your listeners can guess who the person is before you tell them at the end of your story. Pause this audio here.

However, Saul points out another problem: The men do not have a gift to give the man of God. The servant again says, "Look!" The servant has a quarter shekel of silver that the men can give! Saul agrees that seeing the man of God is a good plan, so the men go towards the nearby town.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Both times when the servant speaks, the servant begins with a word that means, "Pay attention! I have something to say or show to you!" In your culture, what words or phrases do you use to get someone's attention when you want to talk about something or show something to that person? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Saul and the servant meet some young women coming out of the town. Towns were often on hills or high ground near a spring or well of water. It was the women's job to fill their jars and buckets with water for their families, and the women often went in the evening when it was cooler. In the original language, "young women" can mean young unmarried girls as well as young married women, so this was probably a group of women of several different ages.

Saul and his servant are walking up the hill of the town, not yet at the top, as some young women are walking down the hill. The men ask the young women if the seer is in the town. The storyteller explains that the word "seer" means the same thing as "prophet," which is the word that people would use in the storyteller's time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember what you discussed about explaining new words in step two, and discuss how you will translate this explanation for the word “seer” in your translation. Discuss where you want to include this explanation. Pause this audio here.

The young women repeat themselves and sound disorganized. Probably several young women all talked at once, each one giving part of the answer. The young women do not say Samuel’s name. Instead, the women say that “he,” the seer, is ahead of Saul and the servant. The young women probably passed Samuel as they were coming out of town, then reached Saul first because they were moving faster than Samuel. The young women say that the seer arrived today to bless the sacrifice at the high place. The high place was probably on another hill outside of the town. People are already waiting for the seer at the high place. When people offered an animal as a sacrifice, they would sometimes offer some parts for the priest to burn and eat the rest. Once the seer blesses the food, the people can then eat it. The young women tell Saul to hurry because the seer is about to walk outside the town to the high place to bless the sacrifice. Saul and his servant should be able to find Samuel easily when they enter the town.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have one person ask the group a question about how to do something. Then have everyone in the group give an answer or part of the answer. Have the first person repeat or explain the answers that the group has said. Pay attention to the ways that this person makes the group’s answer more connected, or shows that several people were talking. Pause this audio here.

So Saul and the servant walk to the town at the top of the hill. The town probably had a wall around it with at least one gate. The gateway or entrance to a town was a place where people commonly met. As Saul and the servant enter the town, the men meet Samuel, who is walking out of the town at the same place.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Kish
- Saul
- The servant
- The man of God, or seer, who is Samuel
- The young women
- And the people at the sacrifice

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

There was a man whose name was Kish, who was a member of the tribe of Benjamin. Kish was wealthy and important. Kish was the son of Abiel, who was the son of Zeror, who was the son of Bekorath. These men were

1 Samuel 9:1–14

all descendants of Aphiah, whose ancestor was Benjamin. Kish had a son named Saul. Saul was an impressive young man who looked more handsome than all the other Israelites. No other Israelite was taller than Saul's shoulder.

Saul's father, Kish, had some donkeys, but one day some of the donkeys wandered off. So Kish said to his son, Saul, "Go search for the donkeys. One of our servants can go with you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Kish, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am upset that some of our donkeys are gone. These are useful animals, and if we do not find the donkeys, it will take time and money to replace them; or
- I trust my son Saul. I know Saul is capable of searching for these animals. I think Saul will be the best person to send; or
- I care for my son and want him to have some help. Since I am a wealthy man, I can send a servant with Saul. The servant can help Saul look and help with the journey. The servant can also help lead the donkeys back when the men find the donkeys.

Continue the drama. So Saul and the servant left to look for the donkeys. First, Saul and the servant searched through the hilly part of Ephraim. The men searched in the area around Shalishah, but they could not find the donkeys. The men searched in the land of Shaalim, but they did not find the donkeys there either. Then the men traveled through the land of Benjamin, but they did not find the donkeys there.

When the men arrived at the region of Zuph, Saul said to his servant, "We must return home now, or my father will start worrying about us instead of the donkeys." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am tired of searching. We have been responsible and looked in all the places the donkeys might have gone, but we cannot look forever. I need to make a decision about when to go home; or
- I know my father cares about the donkeys, but I also know he cares about me, his son, and the people who work for him, like this servant. I do not want to cause my father to worry by being gone for so long; or
- I am surprised that we have not been able to find the donkeys! The donkeys must have run far and fast!

Continue the drama. But the servant replied, "Listen. A man of God lives in this nearby town. The people honor this man greatly because when he says something will happen, it happens. It might be good if we went to see the man of God. Perhaps the man can tell us where we can find the donkeys."

Saul said to his servant, "But what can we give this man if we go to see him? We have eaten all our food, so our sacks are empty. We have no suitable present to give to the man of God. Do we have anything at all?" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I respect this servant, so I will listen to his idea. My father trusts this servant, since he sent the servant with me. The servant has also shown that he is a good servant by searching with me for days; or
- It would be rude to show up without a gift, and I do not want to dishonor a man of God, especially one who people respect so much; or
- I do want to go and see the man of God. It would be helpful to get some advice, since we have not found the donkeys! Maybe the servant remembers some item we have that we can give as a gift.

Continue the drama. The servant replied to Saul again: "Look, I have here a small piece of silver. I can give that to the man of God. Then the man will tell us where to find the donkeys." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the servant, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to honor my master and his son by doing everything I can to help find the donkeys! I will even give up this silver to help! or
- I am also tired of searching for the donkeys and want to see if there is a better or smarter way for us to take; or
- I remember hearing about this man of God and how God is with him. Everything this man says will happen actually happens! I am excited to meet this man of God!

Continue the drama. In Saul's time, when someone wanted to ask God something, the person used to say, "Let us go and ask the seer." People used to say "seer," but people in our time would use the word "prophet" instead.

Saul said to his servant, "All right then. We will go there now."

1 Samuel 9:1–14

So Saul and the servant started on their way to the town where the man of God was. As the men went up the hill towards the town, they met some young women who were just leaving the town. These young women were going to the well to get some water. The men asked the young women, “Is the seer in the town here?”

The young women answered, “Yes, he is. The seer is in the town ahead of you. Hurry up and go into the town. The seer arrived in our town today in order to lead the people as they offer their sacrifice at the high place. When you enter the town, you will see the seer, since he has not yet left the town to go up to the high place to eat the sacrificial meal. The people at the high place are waiting for the seer there, and they will not begin to eat until he comes and first prays over the sacrifice. Then the guests will eat. So if you want to see the seer, you need to go now.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the young women, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are excited to have a man of God in our town. Everyone has been talking about this man, so we know exactly why he is here and what he is doing; or
- These two men are asking in a polite way, so we will answer. We will let the men know what is happening in town today and assure them they can find the seer.

Continue the drama. So Saul and his servant went up to the town. As they entered the town, the men saw Samuel coming toward them on his way to the high place.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Kish is a **Benjamite**, which means he is a member of the tribe of Benjamin. Use the same word for Benjamite as you have used in previous passages.

Saul is so impressive that there is no one like Saul in **Israel**. Israel is the name of the country where the Israelites lived. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

Kish tells Saul to go look for the lost donkeys and to take a **servant** with Saul. A servant is a man or a woman who works for another person. A servant can work in their master’s house or fields. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages.

Donkeys were important animals that carried heavy loads and pulled farming equipment. These donkeys were female donkeys. Use the same word for female donkeys as you have used in previous passages.

The servant says he has a quarter shekel of silver to give to the man of God. A shekel is a unit of measurement for weight. One shekel is about 11.4 grams, so a quarter shekel would be about 3 grams. Israelites used weights, or shekels of precious metal, for money before they used coins.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **shekel**. Look up shekel in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

“Man of God” is another title for a prophet or seer. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. This message can be an instruction from God about something that needs to be done or about something that is going to happen in the future. A seer means someone who can see visions or see what other people cannot see. A prophet is a seer because he can see, or understand, God more clearly than other people and knows things that other people cannot know. This happens because God gives the prophet this understanding. People also called a prophet a man of God because the prophet serves God. This title uses the general word for God, not God’s personal name, Yahweh. In Saul’s time, people would use the word “seer,” while people in the storyteller’s time would use the word “prophet.”

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **man of God**, **prophet**, and **seer**. Look up prophet and God in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 9:1–14

The seer, Samuel, is in the town to lead the people as they offer a **sacrifice**. A sacrifice is a gift to God. People gave sacrifices to thank God for something, worship God, confirm their relationship with God, or ask forgiveness for something they had done wrong. For some sacrifices, a priest would kill an animal and then burn the animal. Sometimes, the priest would burn certain parts of the animal, and then the people would cook and eat the rest of the animal. For more information on sacrifice, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifice as you used in previous passages.

The people are waiting for Samuel at the high place. A high place was a place of worship, sacrifice, and prayer. People would often make these high places on a hill or higher area of land, sometimes with shrines or other buildings or just an altar outside. Sometimes, these were good or official places to worship God, but usually, people worshiped idols there. This high place was probably an official or good place for worshiping God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **high place**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people are waiting for Samuel to **bless** the sacrifice. When people bless something, like food, this means that the people are thanking God for that thing. For more information on bless, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for bless as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 9:1–14

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (745 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 9:15–27

1 Samuel 9:15–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 9:15–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:15–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:15–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Yahweh promises to send a man for Samuel to anoint as king. Then Yahweh reveals that this man is Saul. Though the people want to replace Yahweh, Yahweh is still in charge, and Yahweh still chooses the new king. When Samuel and Saul meet, Samuel invites Saul to the sacrifice meal and speaks of how important Saul is to Israel. The next morning, as Saul is about to leave, Samuel says that Samuel has a message from God to share with Saul.

The day before Saul came to the town in the region of Zuph, Yahweh spoke privately and directly to Samuel. Yahweh revealed that he would send a man to Samuel. This man would be from the land or tribe of Benjamin. Yahweh says to anoint this man as ruler over Israel. To anoint means to pour oil over someone's head to show that God has set that person aside for a certain task. Earlier, the people had asked for a king, a word which in the original language meant head ruler. But Yahweh tells Samuel to anoint this man as the leader Yahweh has chosen, perhaps like a military commander.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss the words you have in your language for various leaders or rulers. What words do you use for a leader who leads everyone else? What words or phrases do you use for someone who is the second most important or powerful, who leads almost everyone, but still follows someone's instructions? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh says that this leader will save the Israelites from the hand of the Philistines. People often used the word "hand" to mean "power." This leader will save the Israelites from the Philistines, who have been attacking the Israelites. Yahweh is sending this leader because Yahweh can see the danger the Israelites are in and can hear the Israelites when they pray and call out for help.

So when Saul arrives in town and Samuel sees Saul, Yahweh again speaks to Samuel privately. No one except Samuel hears what Yahweh says. Yahweh says that this is the man Yahweh promised yesterday to send. This man, Saul, will govern the people. While before, the Israelite people each did what they thought was right, Saul will now watch over the people and make them follow God's laws.

Saul walks up to Samuel at the entrance or gateway of the town. Then Saul asks Samuel a question. Saul does not know that Samuel is the man of God Saul is looking for, so Saul asks Samuel where the seer is staying. This town could be the town Samuel lives in, or it could be a town Samuel often visits, with a house Samuel often stays at.

Samuel responds that he is the seer. Samuel invites Saul to a meal and offers to give Saul the help Saul needs. God has revealed to Samuel that Saul has a question or problem with which he needs help. Samuel promises to tell Saul later what is in his heart, which means Samuel will explain the things Saul is thinking or wondering about.

1 Samuel 9:15–27

Samuel then shows that he really does hear from God. Samuel does this by talking about the missing donkeys before Saul even mentions them. Samuel reassures Saul that someone has found the donkeys, so Saul does not have to look for the donkeys any longer. Saul has time to eat and talk with Samuel.

Samuel then says that all of Israel hopes for Saul and his family. The people have been wanting and waiting for a king. Samuel is suggesting that Saul will be this king that Israel longs for.

Saul is surprised and says that he does not understand how this can be. Saul responds with questions, but Saul is not expecting Samuel to answer these questions. Instead, Saul asks these questions to emphasize that Saul is not from one of the larger or more important tribes of Israel. Saul also says that he comes from the least important family in the tribe of Benjamin. Though Saul's father is a respected person, Saul's humble answer is polite. Although Saul probably did not fully understand what Samuel had said to him, Saul may have understood that Samuel was predicting great things for Saul. However, Saul does not understand how these great things will happen.

However, Samuel, who knows that Saul is God's choice, does not respond to Saul's questions at the time. Instead, Samuel leads Saul and Saul's servant to the high place and into a hall, or a large room where people eat. About 30 guests are already sitting in this room. Samuel shows how important Saul is by giving Saul and Saul's servant the most honorable seats in the room.

Earlier, Samuel had told the cook to set aside a thigh, or the leg of the animal, and now Samuel asks the cook to bring this thigh out. So the cook brings out the thigh, along with the fat on the thigh. This is a very good piece of meat on the animal! The cook gives the thigh to Saul, and Samuel tells Saul to eat it. Samuel already planned to save this piece of meat for Saul when Samuel was inviting the other guests. Samuel did this even before he invited Saul! So Saul ate with Samuel that evening.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about a time when you were hosting or helping at a celebration meal, such as a wedding, where there were guests that you wanted to honor. How did you show that those guests were important? What did you do for those guests? Where did those guests sit? What food did you give those guests? Pause this audio here.

After the feast, everyone comes down from the high place and returns to the town. Then Samuel takes Saul up on the roof of Samuel's house. Since the roofs of the houses in Israel were flat, the roof was a good place to talk privately. People also used roofs as a place for sleeping since it was cooler outside on the roof with the breeze. Some versions say that Samuel talks with Saul on the roof. Some say that Samuel makes a bed for Saul on the roof. Both of these things probably happen.

Stop here and look at a picture of a house with a flat roof as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When you have guests stay the night at your house, where do you give the guests a space to sleep? Why do you give the guests this space? Pause this audio here.

When the sun comes up the next morning, Samuel says that when Saul is ready to go, Samuel will walk with Saul for a little way on Saul's journey. This was the normal, polite behavior of a host to a guest.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you do to say goodbye when a guest leaves your house? Why do you do this? What are some things that many people in your culture do, and which are ones that just you do? Pause this audio here.

So Saul gets ready and starts to walk to the edge of the town, along with his servant and Samuel. While they are still in the town, Samuel tells Saul to instruct Saul's servant to keep walking ahead of them. While the servant continues walking, Samuel stops Saul so that Samuel can privately tell Saul a message from God.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:15–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

1 Samuel 9:15–27

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh promises that tomorrow, Yahweh will send a man for Samuel to anoint as ruler over Israel. Yahweh chooses this man to save the people from the Philistines because Yahweh heard the Israelites' cries for help.

In the second scene: When Samuel sees Saul the next day, Yahweh says that this is the man Yahweh said he would send.

In the third scene: Saul asks Samuel where the seer is staying. Samuel replies that he is the seer and invites Saul to eat with Samuel. Samuel assures Saul about the donkeys and hints at something great for Saul's future. Saul politely responds that he does not understand why Samuel says this to Saul.

In the fourth scene: Samuel and Saul go to the high place, and Samuel gives Saul and Saul's servant the best seats. Samuel also tells the cook to give Saul the best piece of meat. The men eat together, talk together, and then Saul spends the night at Samuel's house.

In the fifth scene: In the morning, Samuel walks with Saul and Saul's servant to the edge of the town. Samuel tells Saul to instruct the servant to keep on going. While the servant continues walking, Samuel stops with Saul to tell Saul a message from God.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- Saul
- The Philistines
- The servant
- The guests at the feast
- And the cook

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

After showing how Samuel and Saul's stories connect, the storyteller now explains something that had happened the day before. The first scene happens the day before Saul enters the town. This scene shows how Yahweh has planned Samuel and Saul's meeting. Yahweh speaks to Samuel privately and says that Yahweh has heard the Israelites when they asked for help. Yahweh has seen the way the Philistines, the Israelites' enemies, are attacking and hurting the Israelites. So Yahweh has chosen a man to rule over Israel and save them from the Philistines. Yahweh will send this man to Samuel at the same time tomorrow. Samuel should anoint this man, or pour oil on this man's head, to show that the man will be Israel's ruler.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone told you how something would happen, then later it happened just like the person said it would. Tell the story twice, and each time, pick a different point in the story to explain the time that the other person told you about the event. Discuss what effect the different versions have on the listeners, even though they are still hearing the same story. Pause this audio here.

The second scene starts the next day, as Saul is entering the town with his servant. The town might have had a wall around it with a gate through which people came and went. When Samuel, who is standing in the gate and is about to walk out of the town, sees Saul, Yahweh speaks again. No one except Samuel hears what Yahweh says. Yahweh says that Saul is the man that Yahweh talked about yesterday. This man, Saul, will govern the Israelites.

In the third scene, Saul walks towards Samuel, who is standing "in the gate" or in the entrance part of the town. Saul asks Samuel where the seer's house is. Saul had never met Samuel and did not know Samuel was the seer Saul was looking for. Samuel answers that Samuel is the seer, so Saul does not have to look anywhere else. Samuel tells Saul to go ahead of Samuel to the high place, or the place of worship outside of town. In that time, letting another person walk in front of you could show that you respected or honored that person.

Samuel tells Saul that Saul should eat with Samuel, and then on the morning of the next day, Samuel will tell Saul what is in Saul's heart or explain anything that is confusing or important to Saul.

1 Samuel 9:15–27

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you describe the things a person is thinking and wondering about—things that are important to the person and that they think about often or over a long time? Pause this audio here.

Samuel says that someone has found the missing donkeys, so Saul does not have to keep searching. Samuel then hints that great things will happen to Saul, saying that all the people of Israel hope for Saul and his family to help or lead the people.

Saul politely replies that he does not understand how this can be. Saul humbly says that he is not important because Saul is not from one of the larger or more important tribes or families of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is the polite way to respond when someone compliments you? How do you respond when someone says that good or important things will happen to you? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, Samuel brings Saul and Saul's servant to the high place or place of worship. This high place would be on a hill outside the town. When people sacrificed animals, the people sometimes had to eat some of the meat near the place of sacrifice. So these places of worship often had a hall or large room nearby where many people could sit and eat. There were 30 people or guests already sitting in this hall. Samuel gives Saul and Saul's servant the best seats in the room.

It is not clear if the sacrifice happened after Samuel and Saul arrived in the hall or before Saul even arrived in town. But at some point after the sacrifice, the cook started cooking the meat, and Samuel asked the cook to save one particular piece of meat for a special guest.

Now, the cook and anyone who helped the cook were probably bringing out the food to the guests. Samuel tells the cook to bring out the special piece of meat. We are not sure what kind of animal this meat was from. This was the thigh of an animal, which was a very good piece of meat. This is probably a cooked piece of meat, since Samuel then tells Saul to eat this meat that they have saved for Saul. Samuel says that he planned to save this piece for Saul before the sacrifice, when Samuel was inviting the other guests. So Saul eats with Samuel and the other guests.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Pretend you are having the other people in the group over for a meal, and you made some very good food for each person. Describe how you planned for and prepared this food for the people before they arrived. Pause this audio here.

Saul also stays the night at a house with Samuel. This could be Samuel's house, or the house Samuel stays at when he is in this town. Samuel may have prepared a bed of soft things, like a wool mattress and blankets, on a mat or light wooden frame for Saul on the flat roof of the house. Samuel and Saul probably talk some before Saul goes to sleep.

Scene five begins the next morning, when the sun comes up and everyone is waking up. Samuel, who is on the ground or in the house, calls up to Saul, who is on the roof. Saul should get ready, and Samuel will then walk with Saul for a little while to send Saul on his way. So Saul gets ready to travel again and comes down from the roof. Saul and his servant then walk towards the edge of town with Samuel. Before the men reach the edge of town or the town walls, Samuel tells Saul to instruct his servant to keep walking. Saul does, and the servant keeps walking while Samuel and Saul stop. Samuel will now give Saul a message from God.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:15–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh

1 Samuel 9:15–27

- Samuel
- Saul
- The Philistines
- The servant
- The guests at the feast
- And the cook

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The day before Saul arrived, Yahweh had spoken to Samuel and said, “Tomorrow, about the time that it is now, I will send a man to you from the territory of Benjamin. Pour oil on this man’s head to show that I have chosen him to be the leader of my people, Israel. This man will rescue my people from the power of the Philistines. I have seen how my people are suffering, and I have heard how they are crying out for help.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- My people want to replace me with another ruler, but I know that a human king will not be as good or powerful as me. While this makes me sad, I am patient with my people, and I will help them find a human ruler. This ruler will not be more powerful than me, though; or
- I care about my people, and it makes me sad to see other nations attacking them. I can see that my people need help, and I will help them, even though they have not served me like they should; or
- It is an important task to choose a new king for the people. I will help Samuel and bring a man to him, so that Samuel does not have to travel and search for a long time.

Ask the person playing Samuel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am always amazed when Yahweh, my God, speaks directly to me. What an honor it is to hear his voice and serve him! or
- I am so thankful that Yahweh is helping me choose a new king. I know all the people will have different opinions on who would be the best king, so I am glad that Yahweh is guiding me to the right person; or
- I wonder what this man will be like. I wonder if this man will be a soldier, since he will make the Philistines stop attacking us. I really do hope this man will lead the Israelites well.

Continue the drama. When Samuel saw Saul, Yahweh said to Samuel, “This is the man I told you about. This man will rule over my people.”

There at the gateway, Saul approached Samuel and asked, “Can you tell me where the seer lives?”

Samuel replied, “I am the seer. Go ahead of me to the hill where the sacrifices are made, for today you will both eat with me. Tomorrow morning, I will answer all your questions and then send you home. Do not be concerned about your donkeys that wandered off three days ago. Your father has got the donkeys back. The people of Israel look to you and your father’s family, Saul, hoping that you will lead them.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Every time Yahweh says he will do something, he does it! And every time I am amazed by the way Yahweh works and allows me to be a part of his work; or
- Yahweh has also shown me that this man is worried about several things, like the missing donkeys. I know Yahweh will give me the words to speak to comfort and give good advice to this man; or

1 Samuel 9:15–27

- I am glad I get the chance to talk to this man who will be our new ruler. I can see what this man is like and maybe give him some advice from the time I have spent leading Israel.

Continue the drama. Saul answered Samuel, "But I am only a member of the tribe of Benjamin. Our tribe is the smallest of all the tribes in Israel. And my family is the least important of all the families in the tribe of Benjamin. I am surprised that you are saying this to me." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am surprised that the first man I talked to was the seer! I am also surprised that the seer already knew about the missing donkeys! This man must really serve God, since he knows this! or
- I am also surprised and confused by what the seer has said to me. Why would the Israelites want me to lead them? People respect my father and his family, but just the people who know us, not all of the Israelites! or
- I am responding in a humble way because I want to be polite, but I am honored that the seer has said this to me. I also feel a little excited. Maybe the seer means that I will do important things for my people!

Continue the drama. When the men had climbed the hill to the place of worship, Samuel took Saul and Saul's servant into a large room where about 30 guests were sitting. Samuel gave Saul and Saul's servant the most honorable seats of all.

Samuel said to the cook, "Bring here the piece of meat I told you to set aside."

So the cook brought the thigh covered with fat and put it in front of Saul. Samuel said, "Here, we put this aside for you. Go ahead and eat it. I was saving it for you even before I invited these others." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the guests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We all respect Samuel and know how important he is, because Samuel serves God. If Samuel is giving this other man the most honorable seat, this man must be very important! or
- It looks like Samuel might have set up this sacrifice and meal in order to celebrate and thank God for this man. I wonder who this man is and what he will do!

Continue the drama. So Saul and Samuel feasted together that evening. After the feast, everyone came down from the hill and returned to the town. Then Samuel took Saul up on the roof of Samuel's house, and they talked together there. The men got up as the sun was rising, and Samuel called up to Saul, who was on the roof, "Come on, let us go. I will send you on your way."

Saul got ready, and he and Samuel went out of the house together. As they were approaching the edge of the town, Samuel said to Saul, "Tell your servant to go on in front of us." Saul did so, and the servant went on ahead.

Then Samuel said to Saul, "Stay here for a while so that I can tell you the message that God has told me to tell you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the servant, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Many amazing things have happened to me and my master, Saul. The seer, whom everyone respects, has honored us, eaten with us, and even let us stay with him! or
- I wonder what Samuel and Saul are talking about while I walk ahead. It must be something very important; or
- I am glad that Samuel has told us that someone else has found the donkeys. Now we can stop searching and return home!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 9:15–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Before Saul arrives in town, **Yahweh** speaks to Samuel. Yahweh is God's proper name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh tells Samuel to **anoint** the man Yahweh is sending. To anoint someone means to pour sweet-smelling oil over someone. Before Yahweh gave someone a special task, Yahweh would instruct someone else to pour oil over

1 Samuel 9:15–27

that person's head to show that Yahweh had set this person apart for a special purpose. For more information on anoint, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for anoint as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh says this man will be a ruler, or chosen leader. In the original language, this is not the same word as king, which is what the Israelites asked for. This means that Yahweh will still be the highest ruler, and this man will be second to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **ruler**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

This chosen leader will rule over Yahweh's people, **Israel**. Sometimes the word Israel refers to all the descendants of Jacob together. It then means the same as Israelites or "people of Israel." For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

Saul asks Samuel where the **seer** lives. A seer is someone who can see visions or see what other people cannot see. People also call these people prophets. For more information on seer, refer to prophet in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for seer as you used in previous passages.

Saul tells Samuel that Saul is from the least important clan, or family group, in the tribe of Benjamin. A clan is a large group of people made up of many families. A clan is smaller than an entire tribe, but larger than one household.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **clan**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel tells Saul to go up to the **high place**. A high place was a place of worship, sacrifice, and prayer. People would often make these high places on a hill or higher area of land, sometimes with shrines or other buildings, like a big room where people would eat. This high place was probably an official or good place for worshiping God. Use the same word or phrase for high place as you used in previous passages.

Samuel gives Saul and Saul's **servant** the best or most honorable seats. A servant is a man or a woman who works for another person. A servant can work in their master's house or fields. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages.

When Saul is leaving town, Samuel says he has a **word** or message from **God** to give to Saul. This is the more general word for God, not God's personal name, Yahweh. For more information on word and God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for word and God as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 9:15–27

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (805 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 10:1–16

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 10:1–16 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:1–16 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Samuel anoints Saul because Yahweh has chosen Saul to rule over Israel. Samuel describes three events that will happen to Saul. These events are signs that God is with Saul. Samuel tells Saul that when they meet up again, Samuel will give more instructions. Saul travels home and everything happens as Samuel said it would, but Saul does not tell anyone what Samuel has told Saul about being Israel's ruler.

After Saul's servant walks on ahead of Samuel and Saul, Samuel tells Saul Yahweh's message: Yahweh has chosen Saul to rule over Israel. To show this, Samuel anoints Saul by pouring a little oil out of a flask, or small clay jar, over Saul's head.

Stop here and look at a picture of a clay jar as a group. Pause this audio here.

Samuel kisses Saul, probably on the cheek, as a sign of affection or respect. Samuel says that Yahweh is anointing or choosing Saul as ruler over Yahweh's inheritance. An inheritance is something that belongs to someone by right. Both the land and the people of Israel belong to Yahweh, who has chosen Saul to rule over them. Samuel phrases his statement like a question to emphasize that it is definitely Yahweh who chooses.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are some actions that you do to show respect to someone, like an elder or a leader? Discuss kissing in your culture. When is it acceptable or polite to kiss? Which people do it and with whom? Pause this audio here.

Some versions say a few more things after Samuel says that Yahweh has chosen Saul. In these extra statements, Samuel says that Saul will rule over Yahweh's people and save the people from the hand or power of their

1 Samuel 10:1–16

enemies. Then Samuel says, “Here are the things that will show that Yahweh has chosen you to be the ruler of his people.” These statements repeat or emphasize information that we already know. If the translation you are listening to includes these extra sentences, you may keep them.

Samuel then describes three events that will happen. First, when Saul continues to travel, Saul will meet two men by Rachel’s tomb or burial place, which is at Zelzah, on the border of the tribe of Benjamin’s land. Rachel was the wife of Jacob, whose name is also Israel. Jacob and Rachel were the Israelites’ ancestors. These two men near the tomb will tell Saul that someone has found the missing donkeys and returned them to Kish. Since Saul has not returned home yet, Kish is now worried about Saul. Kish is wondering what Kish should do to find his son.

When Saul travels on to the big tree at Tabor, the second event will happen. This big tree may be a terebinth tree. Trees were often landmarks, meeting places, and sacred places.

Stop here and look at a picture of a terebinth tree as a group. Pause this audio here.

Saul will see three men who are going to the town of Bethel to worship God. Bethel was an important holy place and for many years had an altar for sacrifice. These men will be carrying three young goats, three loaves of bread, and an animal skin or leather pouch full of wine, all of which may have been gifts for God. These men will greet Saul and offer to give Saul two loaves of bread. Saul should accept the bread from these men.

The third event will happen when Saul is approaching the town or hill that people call Gibeah of God. This town or hill was near a Philistine outpost, which is a camp of soldiers. As Saul is walking towards Gibeah, a group of prophets and musicians will be coming from the high place, or place of worship. The musicians will be playing lyres, which are string instruments, and timbrels, which are small hand drums that people made out of animal skins. The musicians will also be playing flutes, also called pipes, and harps, another string instrument with thicker strings and a louder sound than the lyre.

Stop here and look at pictures of a lyre, timbrel, pipes, and harp as a group. Discuss what instruments you have in your culture that are similar to these. What are some times when musicians play instruments in a procession, or as they walk in front of people? Why do the musicians do this? Pause this audio here.

The prophets will be prophesying. These prophets were a little different than Samuel, who told people instructions and messages from God. These prophets would follow a certain ritual, like listening to someone play a musical instrument while the prophets began to praise and worship Yahweh and to speak words that Yahweh’s Spirit gave to the prophets.

When Saul meets these prophets, the Spirit of Yahweh will suddenly take control of Saul, and Saul will also prophesy. Yahweh’s Spirit will change Saul into a different person, or a different sort of man, and give Saul new abilities for his new role as Israel’s leader.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how would you describe what prophets or seers do? What are the different kinds of prophets in your culture? How do other people react to prophets? Pause this audio here.

Once all these events or signs happen, Saul should do whatever his hand finds to do. Samuel is urging Saul to act confidently and do what Saul thinks is right because God will be with Saul. This means that God protects Saul and gives Saul success.

Samuel then instructs Saul to eventually meet Samuel at the town of Gilgal. Samuel promises to come there to sacrifice burnt offerings and fellowship offerings. Burnt offerings were gifts of animals that people burned on an altar to give to God. Fellowship or peace offerings were gifts people gave to maintain a good relationship with God. However, when Saul arrives at Gilgal, he will have to wait seven days for Samuel to arrive. When Samuel comes, Samuel will sacrifice the offerings and tell Saul what to do.

When Samuel finishes speaking and Saul turns to leave, God changes Saul’s heart. In the original language, people used the word “heart” to describe the deepest part of a person, where people thought, felt, and understood things. God changes the way Saul thinks, giving Saul a new understanding.

Then, as Saul travels, all the signs happen just as Samuel said they would. The third sign makes some people at Gibeah, Saul’s home, surprised. When Saul meets the prophets and God’s Spirit takes control of Saul, people

1 Samuel 10:1–16

who know Saul see him prophesying and are amazed. The people ask each other what has happened to Saul, the son of Kish. The people ask, "Is Saul also among the prophets?" and wonder if Saul is also a prophet now. One man asks who the prophets' father is. Father was another name for a leader, and groups of prophets often had a leader. This man could be asking who the head prophet is who allows Saul to prophesy with this group.

The saying, "Is Saul also among the prophets?" became a proverb or a famous saying. Many people used this proverb in the time of the storyteller, so the storyteller did not need to explain the proverb. However, the proverb is not as clear to us. People probably said this proverb to express surprise when a person did something they had never done before that people did not expect.

When Saul stops prophesying, Saul goes to the high place or place of worship, where he speaks with his uncle. Saul's uncle asks where Saul and Saul's servant have been. Saul answers that they were looking for the donkeys, and that when the men could not find the animals, they went to ask Samuel for help. Saul's uncle wants to know what Samuel said, but Saul does not tell his uncle everything. Saul replies that Samuel told them that someone had found the donkeys, but Saul does not mention anything about how Yahweh has chosen Saul to be the ruler or king of Israel.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel anoints Saul and describes three events or signs that Saul will see. Saul will meet men who will tell Saul about the missing donkeys. Saul will meet men who will give him two loaves of bread. Finally, Saul will meet a group of prophets, and Yahweh's Spirit will cause Saul to join the prophets as they prophesy. Samuel finishes by instructing Saul to eventually meet Samuel at Gilgal.

In the second scene: When Saul leaves Samuel, God changes Saul's heart. All three signs happen. When Saul joins the prophets, the people who know Saul are surprised and ask if he is one of the prophets now.

In the third scene: When Saul stops prophesying, Saul goes up to a high place where he meets his uncle. Saul's uncle asks where Saul and the servant have been. Saul tells his uncle that they went to Samuel and that Samuel told the men what happened to the donkeys.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Saul
- Yahweh
- The two men, who know what happened to the donkeys
- Kish, Saul's father
- The three men with the goats, bread, and wine
- The group of prophets and musicians
- The people who know Saul
- The servant
- And Saul's uncle

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the last section, Saul, Saul's servant, and Samuel were walking towards the edge of the town. Saul sent the servant ahead so that Samuel could tell Saul a message from God in private. God has spoken to Samuel and told him to anoint Saul. God has also revealed certain events to Samuel that will show that God will help and protect Saul. This section has the general title for God more often than Yahweh, so pay attention to when the storyteller uses each word.

1 Samuel 10:1–16

Now, in this first scene, Samuel and Saul are standing in the town, probably away from other people, so that no one will hear the message or see Samuel anoint Saul. Samuel brings out a flask or small jar from a bag he was carrying or from a pocket in his clothes. This was probably a clay jar, and the oil was probably olive oil. Samuel pours a little of the oil on Saul's head to anoint Saul. Then Samuel kisses Saul, probably on the cheek, as a sign of affection and honor. Samuel then speaks the message from God. Samuel explains that Yahweh has chosen Saul to be the ruler of Israel. When Samuel anoints Saul, Samuel is doing it as Yahweh's representative, so Yahweh is anointing Saul to be the ruler. Remember, Samuel uses the word for leader instead of king when he describes what Saul will be.

Then Samuel describes three things that God has said will happen to Saul. These events will be signs or proof that God is with Saul. First, after Saul leaves Samuel and begins to travel, Saul will come to the place where people buried Rachel. Samuel says that this place is at Zelzah near the border of the land of Benjamin. It is not clear where Zelzah or Rachel's burial place is, though there is a traditional location for Rachel's tomb. This and the other locations Samuel mentions were probably on the main or normal route between Saul's home and the town Saul is in now.

Stop here and look at a map of central Israel as a group. Find the border of Benjamin on the map. Pause this audio here.

When Saul is near the burial place, Saul will see two men. These two men probably knew Saul and Saul's father and might have been looking for Saul. These two men will tell Saul what happened to the donkeys. The men will also say that Saul's father is worried about Saul, since Saul has not returned home yet.

Saul will continue to travel, and when he reaches the big tree at Tabor, Saul will see another sign. Saul will see and talk to three men who are going to Bethel to worship God. It is not clear where the big tree at Tabor is, but it is on the way to Bethel.

Stop here and look at a map of central Israel as a group. Find Bethel on the map. Pause this audio here.

One of the men will be carrying three young goats. The second man will be carrying three round loaves of bread. The third man will be carrying a skin, or a leather pouch full of wine. The three men will greet Saul and ask if Saul wants some bread to eat. The men will offer to give Saul two loaves, probably one loaf each for Saul and Saul's servant. Samuel tells Saul to accept the bread.

The third sign will happen as Saul approaches Gibeah of God. This could be referring to the high place around Gibeah, where people worship God, or to the town of Gibeah, which is probably the same Gibeah as Saul's hometown. Nearby the town is the Philistine outpost. The Philistines were Israel's enemies and had built a camp, maybe with some buildings, probably to threaten the Israelites or control the roads.

Stop here and look at a map of central Israel as a group. Find the town of Gibeah on the map. Pause this audio here.

Also, near the town is a hill with a high place or place of worship at the top. A group of prophets and musicians will be walking down the hill, probably towards Saul. The prophets will be prophesying, or loudly and joyfully speaking the words Yahweh's Spirit gives the prophets, while the musicians are playing their instruments. All of the instruments will be small enough that the musicians can carry and play the instruments at the same time. We do not know exactly what the prophets will be saying.

Yahweh's Spirit will come to Saul and cause Saul to also start prophesying. Samuel says that Yahweh's spirit will change Saul so that Saul will be like a new person, ready to serve Yahweh.

When all this happens, Samuel says, Saul will know that God is with Saul to help him. Because God will be with Saul, Saul will be successful in whatever he does, so Saul should then act confidently. God will give Saul opportunities to prove himself as God's chosen ruler.

Samuel's final instruction is for a meeting at Gilgal. Gilgal is a town in central Israel and one of the towns Samuel visits every year. We do not know how soon Saul should go to Gilgal. Samuel may have been about to start his annual visit, so Saul's visit to Gilgal may be within a few weeks or months. When Saul arrives in Gilgal, he should wait for seven days for Samuel. When Samuel arrives, Samuel will then lead or help with the sacrifices, as well as tell Saul what to do next.

Stop here and look at a map of central Israel as a group. Find the town of Gilgal on the map. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 10:1–16

The second scene begins when Samuel finishes speaking and Saul travels home. When Saul turns to leave Samuel, God changes Saul's heart or changes Saul to be a different sort of man. God prepares Saul to be Israel's ruler.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about a time someone went away to learn something new, like at school or for a job, then came back with new skills or abilities. How would you describe how the person had changed when they came back? Pause this audio here.

God also causes all three signs to happen just as Samuel described. However, the storyteller only describes the third sign, since other people saw that sign and talked about it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone explained how something would happen, like a wedding or a ceremony, before you went and saw it happen. Describe what the person said, then how the event happened. Pay attention to the times that you choose to explain exactly how the event happened, and times that you just give a brief explanation or summary, since you have already described what the person has said. Pause this audio here.

When Saul is prophesying with the group of prophets near the high place by Gibeah, other people are nearby and can see Saul and the prophets. People who know Saul are amazed to see him with the prophets. The people ask each other if anyone knows what has happened to Saul to make him act like this. A man who lived there in Gibeah also wonders who the father or the leader of the prophets is. The storyteller mentions that people's question, "Is Saul also one of the prophets?" is now a famous saying in the storyteller's time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of proverbs or famous sayings in your culture and discuss how those things became famous or why people say them. Pay attention to the way you chose to explain certain phrases and which phrases you chose not to explain because other people would know them. Pause this audio here.

The third scene begins when Saul finishes prophesying. Saul and his servant walk up the hill to the high place, or the place of worship, that is just outside of Gibeah. Saul most likely meets his uncle at the high place. This was probably Saul's father's brother, and he may have been waiting for Saul there or came there to find Saul. Saul's uncle asks Saul and the servant where they have been. Saul answers that he and the servant were looking for the donkeys, and when they could not find the animals, they went to Samuel for help. Saul's uncle politely asks what Samuel said. Saul only repeats what Samuel said about the donkeys and does not mention anything about being Israel's new king.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Saul
- Yahweh
- The two men, who know what happened to the donkeys
- Kish, Saul's father
- The three men with the goats, bread, and wine
- The group of prophets and musicians
- The people who know Saul
- The servant
- And Saul's uncle

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

1 Samuel 10:1–16

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Then Samuel took a bottle and poured some oil from the bottle onto Saul's head. Samuel then kissed Saul and said, "Yahweh has certainly chosen you to be the leader over Israel. After you leave me today, you will travel on to Zelzah at the edge of the land that belongs to the tribe of Benjamin, near Rachel's burial place. There you will meet two men. The men will tell you that someone has found the donkeys you were looking for. So now, your father is no longer concerned about the donkeys. Instead, your father is worried about you and is wondering what he should do to find you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Kish, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that I have the donkeys back, but my son is more important to me than these donkeys, so now I am hoping that he will return safely; or
- My son does not know that the donkeys are no longer missing. I do not want my son to keep searching forever! I know Saul has been looking all over for the donkeys, so I do not know where he is, and I do not know how I will find him.

Continue the drama. Samuel then said, "As you go on your way, after a while you will reach the large tree at Tabor. There you will meet three men who will be on their way to Bethel to worship God. The first man will be carrying three young goats. The second man will be carrying three round loaves of bread, and the last will have a leather pouch filled with wine. The men will greet you politely and offer you two loaves of the bread. You should accept the bread from the men.

"Then go on to Gibeah of God. There is a Philistine camp nearby. When you come near the town, you will meet a group of prophets returning from the high place of worship. Musicians will walk in front of these prophets, playing various kinds of stringed instruments, drums, and pipes. The prophets will be speaking words that Yahweh's Spirit gives them. Then the Spirit of Yahweh will suddenly take control of you, too. You will join the prophets in what they are doing and will become a new person. When these things happen, be confident, because God is with you to help you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know that ruling Israel will be a hard task. I have seen how the Israelites do not listen! I will prepare Saul for this new role, and I will be there to help Saul; or
- I like to fill people with my Spirit, so that they are full of joy and praise. I want Saul to feel that joy and reassurance from me; or
- I am sure Saul is amazed and wondering if he can really be king. I will give Saul signs to show him that I am in control and that I have really spoken to Samuel about this.

Continue the drama. Finally, Samuel said, "Go ahead of me down to Gilgal. I will come down later and meet you there in order to offer burnt sacrifices to God as well as peace offerings. But do not do anything until seven days have passed and I have come to tell you what you should do." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know Yahweh cares for us, and I can see how Yahweh is reassuring Saul with these signs. When Saul sees these things happen, just as Yahweh said they would, Saul can know that Yahweh is powerful and is helping Saul, giving Saul reassurance, food, and God's own Spirit; or
- I am thankful that Yahweh has chosen the new king for the Israelites. When I chose new leaders for Israel, I did not make a good choice. I would not want to choose poorly again! or

1 Samuel 10:1–16

- I hope Saul will listen to my instructions and believe my words, because they are from Yahweh and Yahweh's way is best.

Continue the drama. As Saul turned aside to leave Samuel, God changed Saul's nature for a new, better one. Then, after Saul went on his way, everything that Samuel had told Saul happened that day just as Samuel had said it would. When Saul and his servant arrived at Gibeah, some prophets met Saul. Then the Spirit of God suddenly took control of Saul, and Saul joined the prophets' activities. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I can see clearly how God's Spirit is with me, and I am amazed! I have to tell people about how amazing Yahweh is, and praise Yahweh! or
- I feel a little overwhelmed by these signs I have seen and the new role Yahweh has given me. I am glad Yahweh is with me to help me! or
- I feel and think differently now. After I left Samuel, I felt something change in me. Before, I would have never thought I could lead Israel, but now I can feel Yahweh leading me to be Yahweh's ruler.

Continue the drama. When all the people who knew Saul saw him prophesying along with the prophets, the people exclaimed to each other, "What has happened to Saul, the son of Kish? It is hard to believe Saul is one of the prophets!"

But one of the local people said, "Who is the father of those other prophets?" So people's exclamation about Saul became a famous saying. People often said, "Has Saul really become a prophet?" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people who know Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We have known Saul since he was a boy, and we have never seen Saul do anything like this! Something must have happened to Saul while he was away; or
- I do not understand how people prophesy, and it is a little strange to me. I wonder if anyone can become a prophet; or
- I cannot believe that Saul is prophesying. Maybe Saul is just caught up in the excitement and music and does not know what he is saying. I wonder who is leading these prophets and is allowing Saul to join them.

Continue the drama. After Saul finished prophesying, Saul went to the high place. Saul's uncle asked Saul and the servant, "Where have you both been?"

Saul answered his uncle, "We were searching for the donkeys. But when we realized we could not find them, we went to ask Samuel for advice."

Saul's uncle asked, "What did Samuel say to you?"

Saul answered, "Samuel told us not to worry, because someone had found the donkeys." But Saul did not tell his uncle what Samuel had said about Saul becoming king. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul's uncle, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- People were saying strange things about Saul. People said Saul was prophesying, but Saul seems normal now. I wonder what happened earlier; or
- I am glad Saul is home. I was worried about Saul, too. I wonder where Saul was looking for the donkeys; or
- I am impressed that Saul got to speak with Samuel, our leader. Maybe Samuel told Saul some wise advice or a message from God!

Ask the person playing the servant, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Many strange and surprising things have happened to us today. I wonder if those things have something to do with what Samuel said to Saul when I could not hear them; or
- Saul seems different now. When we left Samuel, something about Saul changed. Maybe Samuel told Saul something about Saul's future. I hope it is good! or
- I am glad our journey is over. I am a little frustrated that we searched in the wrong places, but at least we got to meet the man of God on our trip.

1 Samuel 10:1–16

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel says that **Yahweh** is the one who chose Saul, so Samuel is anointing Saul on Yahweh's behalf. Yahweh is God's personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

To **anoint** someone means to pour sweet-smelling oil over someone. This shows that God had set this person apart for a special purpose. For more information on anoint, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for anoint as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh has chosen Saul as **ruler** over Yahweh's inheritance. In the original language, this word for ruler or chosen leader is not the same word as king, which is what the Israelites asked for. Use the same word or phrase for ruler as you used in previous passages.

An inheritance is something that belongs to someone by right. Inheritance generally refers to something that a person has the right to receive when his father dies. But in this context, inheritance refers to the land and people of Israel, which belonged to Yahweh, who had the right to rule and lead Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **inheritance**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel says that Saul will meet two men near Rachel's grave, or tomb. A grave is the general name for a place where people bury a dead person. A tomb is the name for a specific type of place where people bury a dead person. In the Bible, a tomb could be a natural cave in a rock, or it could be a hole that people cut out of rock. Although the storyteller uses the general word for grave in this story, you can use the word for tomb, because tombs were the normal way to bury people during Old Testament times in Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **grave** or **tomb**. Look up grave and tomb in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

These men will tell Saul that someone has found the missing **donkeys**. Donkeys were important animals that carried heavy loads and pulled farming equipment. These donkeys were female donkeys. Use the same word or phrase for donkey as you used in previous passages.

Samuel says that Saul will meet three men who are going to **God** at Bethel. This is the more general word for God, not God's personal name, Yahweh. Pay attention to where the storyteller uses the word God or Yahweh. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

One of those three men will have a skin or leather bag full of **wine**. Wine is a drink that people make from fermented grape juice. For more information on wine, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for wine as you used in previous passages.

Saul goes near a Philistine outpost or **army camp**.

Stop here and discuss as a group what you will call a group of soldiers who camp all together in order to protect an area or prepare for battle. Pause this audio here.

Samuel says that Saul will also meet a group of prophets who will be prophesying. A prophet is someone who speaks the words that God gives to that person. Some prophets, like Samuel, tell people instructions and messages from God. Some prophets, like this group of prophets, speak the words God's Spirit gives them to worship and praise God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **prophet** and **prophesying** here. Look up prophet and prophecy in the Master Glossary for more information. Look at how you have already translated the word prophet. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 10:1–16

These prophets would be coming down from the **high place**. A high place was a place of worship, sacrifice, and prayer. People would make these high places on a hill or elevated area. This high place was probably an official or good place for worshiping God. Use the same word or phrase for high place as you used in previous passages.

A group of people playing instruments will be walking in front of the prophets. These people will be playing on lyres, timbrels, flutes, and harps. Lyres are instruments with strings stretched across a frame. People plucked or stroked the strings to play them. Timbrels, or tambourines, are small hand drums that people made out of animal skins. Flutes, or pipes, are instruments that people made of wood, ivory, or bone. These instruments made a soft, nasal sound when the player blew on them. Harps are another kind of string instrument with thicker strings and a louder sound than the lyre.

Stop here and look at the pictures of a lyre, timbrel, pipe, and harp again as a group, as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **lyres**, **timbrels**, **pipes**, and **harps**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Spirit of Yahweh will come to Saul and Saul will start prophesying. The Spirit of Yahweh is the Holy Spirit. The Spirit of Yahweh is the power that comes from Yahweh. This power creates, gives life, performs miracles, and changes people. When the Spirit of Yahweh comes over a person, that person receives a special power or ability. This can mean physical strength, special wisdom, or a clear understanding of what God wants.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **the Spirit of Yahweh**. Though not in the Old Testament, this is another term for the Holy Spirit, so look up Holy Spirit in the Master Glossary for more information. Do not translate this as the Holy Spirit, but translate “Spirit of Yahweh” in the same way that you have translated it in previous passages in the Old Testament. Pause this audio here.

Samuel tells Saul to go to Gilgal, and Samuel will join Saul there to sacrifice burnt offerings and fellowship offerings. To sacrifice means to give a gift to God. For more information on sacrifice, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifice as you used in previous passages.

A **burnt offering** is a kind of sacrifice that people bring to God. When a person brings God a burnt offering, he kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar, which is a special place meant for bringing gifts to God. For more information on burnt offering, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for burnt offering as you used in previous passages.

A **fellowship offering**, also called a peace offering, is an offering that people brought to God to restore peace with someone else. For more information on peace or fellowship offerings, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for peace or fellowship offering as you used in previous passages.

Saul and his **servant** travel home together after Samuel finishes speaking. A servant is a man or a woman who works for another person. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages.

God changes Saul’s **heart**. In Saul’s culture, people used the heart to talk about the place where their emotions, feelings, and decisions happen. God changed the way that Saul thought and acted. Use the same word for heart that you have used previously, and see the Master Glossary for more information about heart, if needed.

God made all the **signs** happen that God said would happen. Signs are unusual things that God makes happen in order to warn people or to prove to them that something God said would happen will happen. Use the same word or phrase for sign as you have used in previous passages, and see sign in the Master Glossary for more information.

The people say, “Is Saul also one of the prophets?” and people repeat their exclamation until it becomes a proverb in the storyteller’s time. A proverb is a short saying that is easy to remember and that people pass on to other people. These sayings give advice about right behavior, describe what usually happens in a situation, or express a common feeling.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **proverb**. Look up proverb in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul does not tell anyone, including his uncle, how Samuel has anointed Saul to rule Israel, or about the kingship. The kingship is the role or position of a king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kingship**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 10:1–16

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (758 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (7.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 10:17–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 10:17–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:17–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1 Samuel 10:17–27

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:17–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Yahweh has already given signs to Saul to prove that Yahweh has chosen Saul to rule Israel. Now Yahweh will show the Israelites that Yahweh has chosen Saul. When the Israelites gather together, in front of all the people, Yahweh chooses Saul's tribe, clan, and family, and then Saul himself. Some people accept and follow Saul, but some do not believe Saul is the right person to rule.

At the beginning of this story, Samuel sends out messages to tell all the people of Israel to come to Mizpah and gather before Yahweh. The town of Mizpah was a location where the Israelites gathered for sacred or special gatherings. There was an altar at Mizpah. To gather before Yahweh means to come together or meet together in a place where Yahweh's Spirit is. The Israelites could gather before Yahweh at the tabernacle, or in front of an altar, like at Mizpah.

Samuel begins by announcing that Yahweh, the God of Israel, has said these things. Then Samuel tells the Israelites what Yahweh has said. Yahweh says that Yahweh is the one who rescued the Israelites from the Egyptians and brought the Israelites out of Egypt. Ever since that time, Yahweh has also saved the Israelites from the kings and other nations who have attacked the Israelites. Yahweh is reminding the Israelites of what the Israelites already know.

Now Samuel starts speaking Samuel's own words. Samuel says that even though God has saved the people from difficult and dangerous situations, the people have rejected or refused to honor God. The people have said to Yahweh, "No, we do not want you as our king." The people have demanded that Samuel appoint or choose a king for the people.

Since Yahweh has agreed to give the people a ruler, Samuel tells the Israelites to present themselves, or come forward in the presence of Yahweh, so that Yahweh can show the Israelites whom he has chosen to be the king. Each person should stand with their family. All the families should stand in a clan or a group of families. All the clans should stand together with the other clans in their tribe. Each tribe should stand apart from the other tribes. Saul belonged to Kish's family, in Matri's clan, in the tribe of Benjamin.

Yahweh will choose the new ruler by lot. Casting lots was a way people used to discover God's will. There were several ways to do this, so it is not clear exactly what happened in this story. People sometimes shook stones in a small container in such a way as to cast or shake out a stone. Each stone could have a symbol on the stone with either the word "Yes" or "No" to answer the person's question. Yahweh would cause the stone with Yahweh's answer to come out.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the stones for casting lots. Pause this audio here.

First, each of the tribes came forward. Yahweh chose the tribe of Benjamin. Then the clans in the tribe of Benjamin came forward, and Yahweh chose the clan of Matri. Then the families in the clan of Matri came forward. Finally, Yahweh showed that Yahweh chose Saul from the family of Kish. Kish was Saul's father.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your people's history, what have been some of the ways that a person becomes king or leader? Who chooses the leader? What ceremonies do you have to show this? Pause this audio here.

However, Saul is not standing with his family. When some people look for Saul, the people cannot find Saul. So the people ask Yahweh if Saul was even at Mizpah. Yahweh answers that Saul is here and that Saul is hiding in the baggage or stacks of supplies. Some people run over to the supplies, where they find Saul and bring him out to the people. Then everyone could see how tall Saul was. No one was taller than Saul's shoulder!

1 Samuel 10:17–27

Then Samuel declares to all the people that this is the man that Yahweh has chosen. Samuel phrases this statement like a question, asking if the people can see Saul, but Samuel knows they can see Saul. Samuel is telling the people to look at Saul and understand that Yahweh has chosen Saul. Samuel says that there is no one in Israel who is like Saul. The people respond by shouting, "May the king live for a long time!" to show that they understand and are excited. The people are wishing God's blessing on the king so that the king will live a very long time.

So Samuel then explains the king's duties and rights, or the things that a king has authority to do. These may be the same things that Samuel has already told the people about kings earlier. Samuel may also be repeating what Yahweh has said about kings in Yahweh's law. Samuel writes down these things to record or officially show that Saul and the people have heard and agree to these things. Samuel writes these things on a scroll, which is a long strip of papyrus or parchment. After Samuel finishes writing it on the scroll, Samuel puts the scroll before Yahweh. This means that Samuel puts the scroll in a holy place in the presence of Yahweh. This could be there at Mizpah or with the ark of the covenant in Kiriath Jearim.

Stop here and look at a picture of a scroll as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: When you begin a new job or project with other people, how do you discuss everyone's roles or duties? When do you do this? How do you make sure everyone agrees and will do what each person says they will do? Pause this audio here.

Then Samuel tells all the people, including Saul, to go back to their homes. When Saul goes back to Gibeah, some men go with Saul. God touches or changes the hearts of valiant or brave men. In the original language, people used the word heart to describe the deepest part of a person, where people thought, felt, and understood things. So God inspired these men to follow Saul and to want to protect and serve Saul.

However, not everyone was happy about Yahweh's choice. Some men, who are troublemakers or disrespectful people, said that Saul would not be able to save the Israelites from their enemies. These men did not honor Saul, and they did not give Saul any gifts. People often brought gifts to kings to show respect, especially when a new king began to rule. When Saul hears what the troublemakers are saying about him, Saul does not defend himself, say bad things about the men, or punish them. Saul waits patiently and does not try to take revenge.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:17–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel tells the Israelites to come to Mizpah so Samuel can tell them what Yahweh has said. Samuel says that Israel has rejected their God by asking for a king. But, since Yahweh has agreed to give the Israelites a ruler, Samuel tells them to come forward in orderly groups so that Yahweh can show the people who Yahweh has chosen.

In the second scene: The tribes, clans, and families come forward, and Yahweh chooses the tribe of Benjamin, Mitri's clan, and Kish's family. However, when Yahweh shows that he has chosen Saul, Saul is not standing with Saul's family.

In the third scene: People look for Saul, and when they cannot find Saul, they ask Yahweh if Saul is here. Yahweh says that Saul is hiding in the baggage. The people find Saul and bring him out to the people, where everyone can see how tall Saul is.

In the fourth scene: Samuel says that no one is like Saul, the man Yahweh has chosen. The people shout, "May the king live for a long time!" Samuel then explains the duties of a king and writes the duties all down on a scroll, which Samuel puts in a holy place.

In the fifth scene: Samuel tells all the people, including Saul, to return home. Everybody goes home. Some brave men follow Saul. Some men do not respect or honor Saul. Saul does not say anything about the disrespectful men.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- The people of Israel
- Yahweh, the God of Israel
- The tribe of Benjamin
- The clan of Matri, which is a clan within the tribe of Benjamin
- The family of Kish, which is a family within the clan of Matri
- Saul
- The men who accept and follow Saul
- And the disrespectful people who do not accept Saul

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Samuel tells the people of Israel to gather at Mizpah. Samuel probably sends out messages to all the people. This probably took several days or even weeks for everyone to gather. Mizpah was a town in the center of Israel, so Mizpah was a good gathering place.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find Mizpah on the map. Pause this audio here.

There was also an altar there at Mizpah, where Yahweh would meet with the people when they brought Yahweh gifts and asked for guidance. So when the people gathered there, near the altar, the people were before Yahweh, or at the place where Yahweh would come to meet with the people. The people are probably outside of the town of Mizpah, and there are probably people in the crowd who will repeat what Samuel is going to say so everyone can hear Samuel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when people are going to make a big decision for their people group, where do they gather together to talk? What makes this place a good or important place to gather? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh spoke to Samuel before the gathering and told Samuel what to say to the Israelites. Samuel begins by saying, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says." In this time, messengers were supposed to repeat the message exactly as the original speaker said it, so they would start their messages like this: "Yahweh says, 'I am the one who rescued you and brought you out of Egypt.'"

When Yahweh says "you," Yahweh means "your people" or "your ancestors." Yahweh saved the Israelites' ancestors from the hand or the power of the Egyptians. Yahweh has also saved the Israelites and their ancestors from all the kings and other nations who have attacked and mistreated the Israelites.

Stop here and as an activity, tell a brief overview of your people's history up until now. Pretend you are telling this history to other members of your people. Pay attention to when you say "you," "your people," or "your ancestors." Pause this audio here.

Now Samuel begins speaking his own words. Samuel says that this day, or in this present time, the Israelites are rejecting their God. Though God has saved the Israelites from their troubles and difficult situations, the Israelites have said that Yahweh is not a good enough king. The Israelites think a human king will be better, so they have asked Samuel to appoint a king. Since Yahweh has agreed to do what they ask, Samuel will now show them the man that Yahweh has chosen. Samuel tells the people to organize themselves and come forward in the presence of Yahweh.

In the second scene, the people stand in groups. All the people stand with their families. All the families stand in clans or family groups. Then all the clans stand with the other clans in their tribes. All the tribes stand separate from each other.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss what words you use in your language for various family groups, such as family, clan, or tribe. As an activity, introduce yourselves to each other and share what family groups you come from using the words you have discussed. Pause this audio here.

Each of the tribes comes forward as Samuel casts lots and asks Yahweh if this was the group Yahweh had chosen. Since Yahweh was choosing a man for their new leader, it may have been just the men in each group. It is possible that each group actually came and stood in front of Samuel, or that Samuel wrote down the names of each group

and presented them to Yahweh in some way. Yahweh would then reply with a "Yes" if this was the group Yahweh chose and a "No" if it was not. Either way, this still probably took some time to do.

Yahweh chooses the tribe of Benjamin. Then, when the clans step forward, Yahweh chooses Mitri's clan. When the families and then the men in the families come forward, Yahweh chooses Kish's family. Then Yahweh shows that Saul is Yahweh's choice. However, Saul is not standing with Saul's family.

In the third scene, the people start looking for Saul. When the people cannot find Saul, the people ask Yahweh if Saul has come to Mizpah yet. The people think Saul may still be traveling or at home. To ask Yahweh this question, the people may have asked Samuel to ask Yahweh. Yahweh responds with a word that means "Look! There he is!" Yahweh says Saul is hiding amongst the piles of supplies, which may be the food and traveling gear that the people brought with them.

Some of the people run over to the supplies and find Saul. The people bring Saul out to stand amongst the other people. Now the people can see how tall Saul is. No one is taller than Saul's shoulder!

In the fourth scene, Samuel tells the people that this is the man Yahweh has chosen and that no one in Israel is like Saul. Remember in the last section, Yahweh prepared and changed Saul to be ready to rule Israel. Saul impresses the people when the people see Saul. The people are excited and shout, "May the king live for a long time!" This is probably not all of the people, since later we learn that some people do not approve of Saul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your people's history, how would people show that they were excited to pick or see a new ruler? What kind of respectful or excited phrases would the people say? Pause this audio here.

Because the people have responded like this, Samuel explains the rights and authority of the king, so that everyone will know how to act. To show that everyone has officially heard and agreed to these things, Samuel writes the things down in a scroll. Samuel puts this scroll before Yahweh, which means at a holy place where Yahweh's presence is. This could be at the altar at Mizpah or with the ark of the covenant at the town of Kiriath Jearim. If Samuel puts the scroll with the ark, Samuel will probably travel to put the scroll there when Samuel and everyone else leave Mizpah.

In the fifth scene, Samuel tells everyone to return home, and the people show how they feel about Saul. God inspires some brave men, probably fighting men, to go to Gibeah with Saul when he returns home. These men are showing that they are loyal to Saul and ready to serve Saul. However, some other people are not happy with Yahweh's choice of ruler. These people are disrespectful to Saul. These people ask, "How can this man save us?" These people are not expecting anyone to answer this question. These people are saying that they do not believe that Saul is able to save or lead Israel. These people do not give Saul the traditional gifts for a king like other people probably do. However, Saul does not say anything about these people's disrespectful actions.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:17–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- The people of Israel
- Yahweh, the God of Israel
- The tribe of Benjamin
- The clan of Matri, which is a clan within the tribe of Benjamin
- The family of Kish, which is a family within the clan of Matri
- Saul
- The men who accept and follow Saul

- And the disrespectful people who do not accept Saul

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Some time later, Samuel sent messages to the people of Israel and told them to come to Mizpah to hear what Yahweh had to say to the people. When the people arrived, Samuel said to them, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says to you: 'Long ago I led your people, Israel, out of Egypt and freed you from Egyptian authority. I have rescued your people from all the other enemy kings that were mistreating you.' But in these recent days, you have refused to follow your God, the one who rescues you from all your troubles and sufferings. You have demanded a man to be your king. So gather before Yahweh and stand in groups according to your tribes and clans." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am still not happy that the Israelites have disrespected Yahweh like this, but I trust Yahweh and will do what he tells me to; or
- I am glad that Yahweh is giving me the words to say and showing me how to choose Israel's ruler. I wouldn't know the best way to do these things by myself! or
- I hope the people will understand that they still need to obey Yahweh, even though they have a human king. Maybe this ceremony, where the people see Yahweh choose the ruler, will help them remember that Yahweh is still their God.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Even though the Israelites have rejected me, I still care for the people and want to make their lives better. So I will choose the new ruler in a peaceful way, so that the different tribes do not fight over who will rule; or
- I know my people are quick to forget that they can trust me, so I will remind them of how reliable I am and how I always rescue my people from their enemies.

Continue the drama. Samuel told each tribe of Israel to approach Yahweh, and Yahweh chose the tribe of Benjamin. Then Samuel instructed each clan from the tribe of Benjamin to come before Yahweh. The clans came before Yahweh, and Yahweh showed that Matri's clan was the one Yahweh had chosen. Finally, Yahweh showed that he had chosen Kish's son Saul. But when some of the people looked for Saul, they could not find Saul anywhere.

So the people asked Yahweh another question: "Has this man, Saul, come here yet?"

And Yahweh replied, "Yes, Saul has come and is hiding among the baggage."

The people hurried to get Saul. When Saul came out and stood among the people, everyone could see that Saul was taller than any of them. No one was taller than Saul's shoulders. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want to look too proud, like I expected that Yahweh would choose me. So I will hide back here for a while; or
- I have felt how God's Spirit has prepared me to be king, but I am still a little nervous about ruling all these people, especially now that I see them all! or
- God has already shown me that I will rule the people, but I am glad that he is showing everyone else, so that no one will try to fight over who will rule. Surely everyone will listen to Yahweh!

1 Samuel 10:17–27

Continue the drama. Then Samuel said to all the people, “Here is the man Yahweh has chosen to be your king. No other person is like this man.”

Then the people exclaimed, “May the king live a long life!” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This man, Saul, is so tall and impressive! Saul looks like a king! Yahweh has chosen a good man to be our king! or
- This is such an exciting day! Now that we have a king, all the other nations will see that we are just as important as they are! or
- I am from the tribe of Benjamin, and I am proud that Yahweh chose a man from my tribe!

Continue the drama. So Samuel explained to the people the rights and duties of a king. Samuel wrote these things down in a scroll and placed the scroll in a special place before Yahweh. After that, Samuel told the people that they could all go home. Saul also went to his home in Gibeah. God led some brave men to go with Saul, and they went. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the brave men, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Now that I have seen Saul, I think that he is a good leader. I think that it would be worth leaving my home to go serve and protect Saul; or
- I feel different from how I felt earlier today. I feel loyalty and love for this king. I want to do what this king tells me to do; or
- I wonder what serving a king will be like. I am excited to have adventures and do good things for our people.

Continue the drama. But there were some others, troublemakers, who said, “This man Saul could never save us from our enemies.” These people did not honor or respect Saul and refused to bring him a gift. But Saul did not say anything about these people. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the disrespectful people, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I think that a different man would be a better king—someone from my tribe or maybe even me! Why does Saul get to rule everyone? or
- I have never heard of this man, Saul! Saul has never led us into battle, and I have never seen him settle disputes. I do not think Saul has the skills to be king; or
- I do not trust Yahweh or his way of picking a king. I think I know better what a good king looks like.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 10:17–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel tells the people of Israel to gather before **Yahweh**. Yahweh is God’s proper name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Samuel repeats the words that Yahweh, Israel’s **God**, has said. This is the more general word for God. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. This word for God appears several times in the passage, so pay attention to how you translate the names or words for God. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh says that he rescued **Israel** from the Egyptians and from the other kingdoms that wanted to oppress the Israelites. Sometimes the word Israel refers to all the descendants of Abraham together. It then means the same as Israelites or “people of Israel.” For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

Kingdoms are areas of land that a king rules over.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kingdom**. See the Master Glossary for more information about kingdom, and translate this in the same way that you have in previous passages in the Bible. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites have rejected God and demanded a man to be their **king**. A king was someone who ruled over a city or territory. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

The people presented themselves as **tribes** and **clans**. Use the same words for tribes and clans as you have used in previous passages.

Samuel writes down the rights and duties of a king on a scroll, which is a long strip of papyrus or parchment. Papyrus is a thin sheet that people make from the fibers of a certain plant, and people make parchment from the skin of an animal. On both ends of the scroll, people attached a narrow wooden handle, like a round stick. When people were reading from a scroll, they would unroll one side of the scroll and roll up the other end around the stick.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **scroll**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 10:17–27

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (780 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 11:1–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 11:1–15 and put it in your hearts.

1 Samuel 11:1–15

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 11:1–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 11:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

While the people know that Yahweh has chosen Saul to be their king, Saul does not start leading until the Israelites are in danger. Another people group, the Ammonites, is threatening the Israelite town of Jabesh Gilead. When Saul hears about these threats, Saul gathers the Israelite men together and attacks the Ammonites. Saul shows that God is with Saul as he leads the Israelites to win the battle. The people see this and celebrate. The people confirm again that Saul is their king.

This story begins some time after Yahweh chose Saul as king. King Nahash leads the Ammonite army to attack Jabesh Gilead, or the Israelite town called Jabesh, which was in the region of Gilead. Jabesh is located on the east side of the Jordan River in the land where the half-tribe of Manasseh lived. The Ammonites lived in the same area, to the east of the Jordan River. The Ammonites often fought with the Israelites. The Ammonite army besieged the town or set up camps around the Israelite town so that none of the people could get out, and no one could bring food in.

The people of the town send a message out to the Ammonite king Nahash. The people ask Nahash for a treaty or an agreement. The people will agree to serve the Ammonites, or accept Nahash as their king, if the Ammonites stop attacking. In Israel at that time, it was probably normal for towns to be independent enough to make their own treaty, as Saul was not yet governing and making decisions as king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do your people or leaders make agreements with other people groups and nations? Who has the authority to suggest or confirm these agreements? Pause this audio here.

Nahash says his army will stop attacking the town if they first gouge or cut out everyone's right eye. This would shame or dishonor all of the people of Israel because they could not save the Israelite people of Jabesh from the Ammonites.

The elders or leaders of Jabesh ask the Ammonites to wait one week so the people can send out messengers for help. If no Israelites come to help, then the people of the town will surrender and walk away from the town. The people will leave the town empty and unguarded so the Ammonite soldiers can enter it. Then Nahash can treat the people however he wants.

Nahash agrees to this plan, probably because Nahash does not think anyone will rescue the people of the town. The other nations probably still think that the Israelites are divided and do not have a king.

The people of the town send out messengers who travel to Gibeah, where Saul lives. The messengers describe the attack and treaty to the people of Gibeah, who begin to weep loudly. The people of Gibeah are worried and scared for the people of Jabesh. As the people are weeping loudly, Saul comes back from working in the fields. Saul is walking behind his oxen. Oxen are cattle that can pull a plow.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of an ox. Pause this audio here.

When Saul sees the people weeping, Saul asks the people what is causing them to weep. The people of Gibeah tell Saul what they have heard. Then God's Spirit comes to Saul in power. This means that God's Spirit comes

1 Samuel 11:1–15

to Saul and controls Saul. Now, Saul will have God's power for what Saul will do. Saul becomes angry at the Ammonites. Saul's anger is so strong that it is like a burning fire.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who was so angry that it seemed like someone else was controlling that person. What words or phrases do you use to describe this person in your story? Pause this audio here.

Saul sends out a message to the Israelites in a shocking way. Saul kills two oxen, cuts them up, and sends pieces of the oxen with messengers throughout Israel. Saul tells the messengers to say, "If you do not follow Saul and Samuel to battle, then your oxen will be like this one, cut into pieces." Saul mentions Samuel because Samuel still has authority in Israel. Yahweh causes the people to fear Saul, so the people quickly come together as one army and act in a united way. Saul gathers all the fighting men at the town of Bezek. Besek is on the west side of the Jordan River. Bezek is opposite the town of Jabesh, which is on the east side of the Jordan River. Saul counts the fighting men. Saul has 300,000 men from "Israel," which is what people called northern Israel. Saul also has 30,000 men from Judah, or southern Israel.

Saul and the army tell the messengers to take a message to the Israelite people of Jabesh. The messengers should say that the Israelite army will rescue Jabesh tomorrow by the time the sun is hot, which means midday. When the messengers repeat this to the people of Jabesh, the people are very happy and relieved. The people of Jabesh tell Nahash and his troops that tomorrow, the people will come out of the town to the Ammonites, and the Ammonites can do what they want to the people. The people of Jabesh were purposely vague when they said that they would come out. The people were probably trying to deceive the Ammonites so that the army would not expect an attack.

The next day, Saul prepares to attack. For the Israelites, a day was from sundown to sundown, so it is evening when Saul divides his men into three groups. This would give Saul's troops more options and safety when they attack. The army travels overnight from Bezek to Jabesh Gilead, and the army arrives at the last watch of the night. A watch was a measurement of time. The night had three watches, and the last watch was early morning before dawn. Saul and his army surprise the Ammonite army by attacking at this time. The Israelites slaughter, or kill, their enemies until the heat of the day, or midday, just like the messengers said. The Ammonites lose so badly that there are not many Ammonite soldiers still alive at the end of the battle. The Ammonite soldiers who are still alive run away. Each of the soldiers is on his own. No one is leading the soldiers in orderly groups.

Saul leads the fighting men so well, and the people are so enthusiastic about their new leader, that the people ask Samuel about the Israelite men who had disrespected Saul earlier. We heard about those men in the previous story. The people insist that those men come forward so that the people can kill the men. However, Saul says that the people will not kill any other Israelites today. Yahweh has just rescued the Israelites, so the Israelites should be celebrating, not punishing people.

Samuel suggests a better way to show that the people approve of Saul. The Israelites should all go to Gilgal and there renew or confirm the kingship, to show that the Israelites all accept Saul as their king. So all the people go to Gilgal and the people confirm Saul as king in Yahweh's presence. Yahweh's presence is a sacred or holy place, where Yahweh is present and listening in a special way. This is the final step or ceremony to make Saul king. Before, Yahweh had shown that Yahweh chose Saul by telling Samuel and by choosing Saul by lot in front of all of Israel. Now that Saul has shown that he will be a good king, the people have a celebration to emphasize that all of Israel has now agreed that Saul is the king of Israel. The people also offer peace or fellowship offerings to God. People often gave these offerings at celebrations to thank or praise God for what he has done. The people eat a portion of those offerings and celebrate joyfully together.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is the process people use to pick or appoint a new leader? What steps or ceremonies do you have? How long does the process take? Where do these ceremonies happen?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 11:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 11:1–15

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

In the first scene: Nahash and his army camp around the Israelite town of Jabesh in the region of Gilead. When the people of the town ask for a treaty, Nahash says he will only make a treaty if Nahash can cut out the people's right eyes. The elders of the town ask for time to see if anyone will help. Nahash agrees.

In the second scene: The messengers leave Jabesh and arrive in Gibeah. When the messengers explain what is happening at Jabesh, the people of Gibeah weep loudly. Saul returns to town and asks what is wrong. The people tell Saul the news. God's Spirit comes to Saul. Saul cuts up his oxen and sends out messengers with pieces of the oxen to tell the Israelites to gather together to fight.

In the third scene: When the people of Israel hear the message, God causes the people to gather quickly to form an army at Bezek. Saul and the army send the messengers from Jabesh Gilead back to their town to tell the people there that the army will rescue the people.

In the fourth scene: The messengers repeat their message to the people of Jabesh Gilead. The people rejoice and send a message to Nahash and his army.

In the fifth scene: Saul and his army travel overnight to attack the Ammonites in the morning. Saul's army wins when they kill and scatter the Ammonite army.

In the sixth scene: The people are so impressed by Saul that they want to kill anyone who does not approve of Saul. Saul, however, stops the people from killing anyone. Samuel tells everyone to gather at Gilgal to renew the kingship.

In the seventh scene: At Gilgal, the people declare that Saul is king in a holy place where Yahweh meets the people. The people offer fellowship offerings and celebrate together.

The characters in this passage are:

- Nahash
- Ammonite army
- People of Jabesh Gilead
- Messengers from Jabesh Gilead to Israel
- People of Gibeah
- Saul
- Messengers from Saul to Israel
- People of Israel, including the men who can fight
- And Samuel

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Nahash and his Ammonite army come to attack the Israelite town of Jabesh, which is in the area called Gilead. Jabesh is on the east side of the Jordan River. This was near the territory that belonged to the Ammonites. We know from later passages that Nahash is the king of the Ammonites. Nahash may have led his army through the Israelite land and fought anyone in his way, or Nahash may have just avoided other towns to attack Jabesh specifically.

Stop here and look at a map of central Israel as a group. Find the region of Gilead, as well as the Ammonites' land. Pause this audio here.

The people of Jabesh see the Ammonite army surrounding their town. The Ammonite army is probably much larger than the number of fighting men in Jabesh. The people of Jabesh ask for an agreement to stop fighting. The people probably send messengers to Nahash, who then sends back a message for his answer. Nahash says he will only agree to a treaty if the people let Nahash's army cut out everyone's right eye. Nahash could mean just the men, or maybe everyone in the town. Nahash wants to shame Israel and show that the Israelites are not strong enough to stop Nahash.

1 Samuel 11:1–15

The Israelite elders, respected men who lead the town, ask for time to make their decision. The elders want to send out messengers throughout Israel to ask for help. If no one comes to rescue Jabesh, then the people will agree to a treaty where they lose their right eyes. Though the storyteller does not mention it in the passage, Nahash must have agreed, because the messengers would have to walk through Nahash's camp to leave. The people of Jabesh may have sent out several messengers to quickly spread the news of this attack.

In the second scene, the messengers arrive in Gibeah, Saul's hometown. The messengers may have come straight to Gibeah because Saul lived there, and the messengers were looking for their new leader. When the messengers arrive, Saul is not in the town. The messengers probably go to a meeting place in the town, like the market or at the entrance gates. Then the messengers start to tell everyone what is happening in Jabesh. Everyone who hears the news is worried and sad, and the people start to weep loudly.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of central Israel. Find the town of Gibeah on the map. Pause this audio here.

Saul is returning with his oxen from the fields where Saul has been working. Saul sees the people who are weeping. Saul asks why the people are weeping, and the people answer and again tell the news about Jabesh.

When Saul hears what the people are saying, God's Spirit comes to Saul and fills Saul with power. Saul becomes angry at the Ammonites. Saul is angry that the Ammonites would attack Saul's fellow Israelites. Saul's anger is so strong that the storyteller compares it to a burning fire, which is hard to put out or stop.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do you think the storyteller compares Saul's anger to a burning fire? What words or phrases do you use to describe when someone is very angry? Pause this audio here.

Saul kills and cuts up two oxen in order to send pieces with messengers around Israel. The messengers will show the pieces of the cut-up oxen and repeat Saul's message to the Israelites. The messengers will say that if anyone does not follow Saul and Samuel into battle, then those people's oxen will be like these cut-up oxen.

In the third scene, when the people of Israel hear the messages, God causes people to fear Saul so that they will obey immediately. The men of Israel quickly travel to Bezek, which is probably a town on the west side of the Jordan River, near a good river crossing. Three hundred thousand men come from the north, and 30,000 men come from the south. Samuel probably comes to Bezek too, to travel with the army.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: God causes the people to fear Saul, or to have a deep respect for and awe of Saul. Talk about someone you respect so much that you are almost afraid of that person. What kind of things does that person do? What kinds of descriptions do you use? Discuss what words or phrases you will use to show this deep respect. Pause this audio here.

Now that the army has gathered and is ready to go help Jabesh, Saul and his men send the messengers back to Jabesh. The messengers should tell the people of Jabesh that the army will come to rescue them before noon tomorrow.

In the fourth scene, the messengers arrive back in Jabesh and repeat this message to the people there. The people are very happy and very relieved that someone is coming to help them. The people send a message to the Ammonites, but the people do not tell the Ammonites about Saul's army. Instead, the people say they will come out of their town tomorrow, and then the Ammonites can do what they want. The Ammonites will probably assume that this means the people are surrendering.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss situations in your language and culture where you pick certain words or phrases carefully so that the words have several meanings, like for poetry. For example, if you want to send someone a message to tell them you are coming, but you do not want to tell the person when you are coming or why you are coming, what words or phrases would you use in your message? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, Saul and his men prepare for battle. Day began at sundown and ended at the next sundown for the Israelites, so the messengers return to Jabesh in the daylight on one day, and then that evening the army prepares to leave. Saul divides his men into three groups, and then the men travel to Jabesh. The men arrive during the last watch of the night, which means early the next day, before the sun has risen. Saul and the Israelite fighting men will be able to surprise the Ammonites by attacking at this time.

When the Israelites attack the Ammonites' camp, the Ammonites are not ready to fight, but are probably still sleeping. The people of Jabesh may have come out of their city, like they said they would. However, the people

1 Samuel 11:1–15

would not have come out to surrender, but to help fight the Ammonites. The Israelite army wins this battle. The Israelites kill the Ammonite soldiers until the sun is high, or until midday. Only a few Ammonites are left. These Ammonites are afraid and have no leaders to organize them, so each Ammonite runs away alone.

The sixth scene happens the same day as the battle. The Israelites ask Samuel for the names of the people who had earlier questioned whether Saul could really save the people. Although the people say this like a question, the people are really reminding Samuel and each other about these men in a disapproving way. The people insist that those men come forward so that the people can kill those men.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of an annoying or bad problem that several people in the group know about or have encountered, like bad weather or rough roads. Remind each other of these things, and pay attention to the way you bring these things up, how you phrase your reminders to each other. Pause this audio here.

Saul, however, stops the people. Saul says that the people will not kill anyone today because today, Yahweh has rescued Israel. Because Yahweh has led Saul to rescue Israel, Samuel suggests that the people celebrate. The people can all go to Gilgal, where the Israelites often gathered, to be in the place where Yahweh comes to meet with the Israelites. Then the people can once more proclaim that Saul is their king.

Stop here and look at a map of central Israel as a group. Find the town of Gilgal on the map. Pause this audio here.

So in the seventh scene, the people gather at Gilgal. It may have taken a day or two for everyone to gather together, as families may have joined the fighting men there. In the place where Yahweh meets with the Israelites, the people officially made Saul their king. It is not clear exactly what the people do, but they may give Saul special items to show that Saul is king. Then the people declare together that they all accept Saul as their king.

The people also sacrifice peace or fellowship offerings to Yahweh. When people sacrifice these offerings, they give a portion to Yahweh and then eat the rest together. So Saul and all the Israelites celebrate, eat, and thank Yahweh for their victory and their new king.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 11:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Nahash
- Ammonite army
- People of Jabesh Gilead
- Messengers from Jabesh Gilead to Israel
- People of Gibeah
- Saul
- Messengers from Saul to Israel
- People of Israel, including the men who can fight
- And Samuel

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

1 Samuel 11:1–15

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Nahash the Ammonite led his soldiers to the town of Jabesh in Gilead and surrounded the town. So the people of Jabesh sent Nahash a message that said, "If you promise not to kill us, we will become your subjects and allow you to rule over us."

But Nahash sent back this reply: "I will not make this agreement with you unless you agree to let us blind all of you in the right eye. In this way, I will humiliate all the people of Israel."

The elders of Jabesh sent this answer to Nahash: "First, wait seven days. We will send messengers to all of Israel for help. If nobody comes to help us, then we will surrender to you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Nahash, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to expand my land and take the good things in Jabesh. Then my people will see what a powerful king I am; or
- I do not like the Israelites. I want to shame the Israelites by taking one of their towns. I do not care if I have to fight and kill everyone, or just cut out their eyes. Either way, I win and show how weak the Israelites are; or
- I have heard how Israel does not have a king. There is no one to gather the Israelites into an army to fight me. I am not worried about these messengers.

Ask the person playing the people of Jabesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- When I looked outside our town and saw the army surrounding us, I was terrified! These soldiers are ready to kill all of us! or
- I hope the other Israelites will come quickly to help us! Maybe our new king, Saul, can gather men fast enough to come rescue us; or
- We have taken care of ourselves for so many years that we even make our own treaties and agreements. While the other Israelites are our people, we are not very united. I worry that no one will come, because they are scared of the Ammonites or do not want to help us.

Continue the drama. When the messengers from Jabesh reached Saul's town of Gibeah and told the people there what the Ammonites had demanded, all the people of Gibeah started to cry loudly.

Right at that time, Saul was driving his two oxen home from the fields. When Saul heard the people crying, Saul asked some of the people there, "What is the problem? Why are the people crying?"

So the people told Saul the news that the men from Jabesh had brought. When Saul heard the news, the Spirit of God entered Saul with power, and Saul became very angry. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Gibeah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The people of Jabesh are our people! I am scared for Jabesh and sad that the people are in this danger! If the Ammonites defeat the people of Jabesh, the Ammonites may come attack us next! or
- I do not know what I can do to help the people of Jabesh. The Ammonites will probably defeat Jabesh and then attack other towns in Israel. I do not know who will stop them! or
- The Ammonites are humiliating all of us Israelites, because we do not have an army ready to fight against the Ammonites. I feel shame and sorrow because other nations think we are weak and divided.

Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Just a few minutes before this, I was thinking about my farm work. Now I feel completely different. I feel God's Spirit with me, and I know what I need to do; or
- The Ammonites have threatened my people, the people I am supposed to protect as king! I am angry that my people are afraid! I am also angry that the Ammonites think that we will not be able to stop them! or

1 Samuel 11:1–15

- I was surprised when I saw all the people crying. I knew something terrible must have happened, but I did not expect this news. It is good that the messengers came here, since I am the leader of Israel and can help gather the people together.

Continue the drama. So Saul took two oxen and cut them into pieces. Saul gave the pieces to messengers, who traveled around the whole land of Israel. The messengers showed the pieces to the people and said, "This is what will happen to the oxen of anyone who refuses to follow Saul and Samuel into battle!"

When the people heard these words, Yahweh caused the people to be terrified when they saw Yahweh's power in Saul. All of the people came together to join Saul's army. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I was just doing my work as usual when suddenly these messengers came with the pieces of meat and this message about Ammonites attacking and war and everything! I was so shocked! How quickly my day has changed! or
- All of us men must leave right now! It is very urgent that we do not waste any time. I almost feel afraid to stop and do anything else but prepare for battle; or
- I am amazed at the power of God in our new king. I was impressed when I saw Saul at the last gathering because Saul is so tall. But now there is something different about Saul. I want to follow Saul and do whatever Saul says.

Continue the drama. Then Saul gathered the army together at Bezek. There were 300,000 men of Israel and 30,000 men of Judah. Saul and his men gave this message to the messengers from Jabesh Gilead: "Tell the other people in your town that we will rescue them before noon tomorrow."

The messengers from Jabesh returned home and gave the message to the people of the town. Then the people rejoiced at this news. The people of Jabesh said to the Ammonites, "Tomorrow we will come out of the city to you. Then you can do whatever you like to us." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Jabesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have not been able to eat or sleep because I have been so worried about the army that is right outside our town. I can hear the army no matter what I do! But now, the messengers have told us this news, and I feel so relieved. I have hope that this will end soon! or
- I am amazed that the other Israelites have gathered to help us so quickly! The messengers told us about what Saul was like and how everyone obeys Saul immediately. I am so glad we have a good leader! or
- We must be careful not to let the Ammonites know that we are expecting an army to help us. We should send a message to trick the Ammonites. That way, we can help the other Israelites who are helping us!

Continue the drama. That night, Saul divided his soldiers into three groups. In the early morning, the men attacked the Ammonite camp and began killing the Ammonites there. The men continued to fight till noon. The Ammonite soldiers who survived ran away in all different directions so that not even two of the Ammonites remained together.

After the battle, the Israelite people said to Samuel, "We remember that certain men did not want Saul to reign over Israel. Bring those men to us and we will kill them!"

But Saul said to the people, "No! You will not kill any Israelites today because this is the day that Yahweh rescued us."

Then Samuel said to the people, "Come, let us go to Gilgal and once more proclaim that Saul is our king."

So all the people went to Gilgal. There before Yahweh, the people confirmed that Saul was king. There, the people gave fellowship offerings to Yahweh. And so Saul and all the Israelites had a very joyful celebration. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These people keep making the wrong decisions. Even when the people are excited and celebrating a victory, they want to hurt others! It is hard to lead these people sometimes! or
- I am glad that Saul led the people so well and then calmed the people down after the battle. I hope that Saul leads the people well his whole life, even when I am not there to help Saul; or

1 Samuel 11:1–15

- I know that Yahweh is really the one who gives us victory when we fight, so I want to celebrate and honor Yahweh at Gilgal. I want to finish the ceremonies to make Saul king, which we should also do in Gilgal, in Yahweh's presence. This way, we can show that Yahweh is our God and that we respect him.

Ask the person playing the Israelite people, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I remember those people who said that Saul could not save us. I am angry that those people were rude and disrespectful to the man who has just saved our people! We should punish those people for what they said! or
- I am so excited about our new king! Look at what a good leader he is! Everyone should be just as excited as I am! or
- I am excited about our future. Now the other nations will know that we have a king who is mighty in battle. Those other nations will not bother us anymore!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 11:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Nahash is an **Ammonite**. Nahash comes and attacks Jabesh Gilead with his army. The Ammonites were a people group who lived to the east of Israel.

The people of Jabesh ask Nahash to make a treaty or covenant with them. When people make a covenant, they make a solemn promise to each other that they cannot break. A king or ruler could also make a covenant with another ruler or kingdom that was weaker than he was. The king could say to these other people, "I will protect you, but you will have to pay me," or "You have to work for me." These other people had to promise to do what the king wanted.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **treaty** or **covenant**. Look up covenant in the Master Glossary for more information. Look at how you have already translated this word before. Pause this audio here.

The **elders** of Jabesh ask for time to send out messengers to ask for help. In this time, an elder was usually the head of a family or clan who had authority in the community. For more information on elder, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for elder as you used in previous passages.

When the messengers arrive in Gibeah, Saul is in the fields with his **oxen**. An ox is a large animal that people used to pull plows and help with farming. Saul is working with two oxen, which people sometimes call a **yoke** of oxen. A yoke is a wooden collar with two openings that people used to tie two oxen or two other animals together so that the animals walk together to pull a plow or vehicle. You can just say "two oxen" instead of yoke.

Stop here and look at a picture of an ox again as a group as needed. Pause this audio here.

When Saul hears about the Ammonite army, the **Spirit of God** comes to Saul again. The Spirit of God, or the Spirit of Yahweh, is the power that comes from God. When the Spirit of God comes over a person, that person receives a special power or ability. This can mean physical strength, special wisdom, or a clear understanding of what God wants. For more information on Spirit of God, refer to Holy Spirit in the Master Glossary. Though these are the same power, you should not translate "Spirit of God" as Holy Spirit. Use the same word or phrase for Spirit of God as you used in previous passages.

Here, the storyteller uses the more general word for **God**, not God's personal name, Yahweh. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

Then the storyteller says that **Yahweh** causes the people to fear Saul and gather together quickly. Yahweh is God's proper name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

When the men gather together as an army, 300,000 men come from **Israel** and 30,000 men come from **Judah**. Sometimes the word Israel means only the northern part of the country of Israel, while Judah means the southern

part of the country. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for Israel and Judah as you used in previous passages.

Saul and his army attack the Ammonites during the morning watch or the last watch. A watch is a period of time during which someone looks out for danger or trouble, usually during the night. In this time, the night had three watches, and the last watch was from about 2 a.m. to 6 a.m., right before sunrise.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **watch**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel tells the people that they should go to Gilgal to declare or reaffirm that Saul is their **king**. A king was someone who ruled over a city or territory. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

While at Gilgal, the people give **peace or fellowship offerings** to Yahweh. A fellowship offering, which people also called a peace offering, is an offering that people brought to God to restore peace with someone and to celebrate fellowship with God and people. For more information on offerings, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for peace or fellowship offering as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 11:1–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (775 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (7.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 12:1–17

1 Samuel 12:1–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 12:1–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:1–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Samuel speaks to the people at the end of his role as their leader, since Saul is now king. Samuel reminds the people of how Samuel has led them. Then Samuel reminds the people of their history and how they failed to follow Yahweh as they should. Samuel urges the people to act differently now, to follow Yahweh. Then Samuel asks Yahweh to give a sign of Yahweh's power, to show that Yahweh is listening and confirming Samuel's words.

In this passage, Samuel begins his speech by reminding the people of how Samuel acted during his long time as leader. Samuel listened to the people's request for a king and did what the people asked. Samuel points out the people's king, Saul, who will now lead Israel. Samuel next points out Samuel's age. Samuel is old, his hair is gray, and people can see Samuel's adult sons, who are among the people and have also served the people or led them. Samuel started leading when he was young and has led up until this day, or this time. Samuel emphasizes his age to show how long Samuel has been leading Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how would you show or describe that someone has lived a long time? What things would you point out about how the person looks or what they have done? Pause this audio here.

Now Samuel asks the people to look at his actions as their leader and agree that Samuel has not mistreated the people in any way. "Here I am," Samuel says. Samuel will not hide from the results of his actions. Samuel tells the people to testify or judge Samuel and bring any complaints against him while Yahweh and Yahweh's anointed one, the chosen king, are listening.

Samuel asks five questions. First, Samuel asks the people if they know of anyone's ox or donkey that Samuel has taken or stolen. An ox is a farm animal similar to a cow, and a donkey is like a small horse. Samuel asks if he has cheated or tricked someone so that Samuel could take something from that person. Samuel asks if he has mistreated anyone. Samuel asks if he has taken any bribes or gifts to make an unfair judgment. Samuel says that if the Israelites can point out anyone whom Samuel has mistreated, Samuel will give back what he has taken and make things fair.

Stop here and look at the pictures of the donkey and ox as a group. Pause this audio here.

Samuel is not expecting the people to name someone whose ox or donkey Samuel had taken. Rather, Samuel is pointing out that the people cannot name anyone. Samuel does this to emphasize that he has never acted unjustly toward anybody in any way. And the people agree. The people say that Samuel has acted fairly as their leader.

Samuel then says that Yahweh and Yahweh's chosen king are witnesses to what the people have agreed to. A witness is a person who sees or hears what happens and is able to testify to the fact that the thing happened. Again, the people agree. Samuel reminds the people of how reliable and trustworthy Yahweh is, since it was

1 Samuel 12:1–17

Yahweh who appointed Moses and Aaron to be the leaders of their ancestors. It was Yahweh who brought the people's ancestors out of Egypt.

Samuel is speaking like they are in front of a judge in a trial to decide a legal problem. Samuel tells the Israelites to stand here, referring to the way an accused person stands in front of a judge. First, Samuel is going to remind the people of all of Yahweh's righteous acts or the good things that Yahweh has done for the people in the past. Then Samuel will show how the people were wrong to ask for a king, because the people were acting like Yahweh and Yahweh's righteous acts were not good enough.

Samuel begins by reminding the people how Yahweh brought the Israelites out of Egypt. When Samuel says Jacob went to Egypt, Samuel means Jacob and Jacob's family, whose descendants became the people of Israel. When the Israelites were slaves and cried out to Yahweh for help, Yahweh sent Moses and Aaron to lead the Israelites out of Egypt and into the land where the people live now.

Again and again, the Israelites forgot Yahweh their God. This means the Israelites ignored Yahweh or stopped worshiping Yahweh alone. So Yahweh allowed Israel's enemies to conquer or oppress the Israelites. One of these enemies was Sisera, the commander of the soldiers from the town of Hazor. Other people groups, like the Philistines and the people of Moab, with their king, also defeated the Israelites' ancestors. Each time, the Israelites admitted that they had sinned by worshiping idols of false gods like Baal and Ashtoreth instead of Yahweh. When the people asked Yahweh for help, Yahweh sent the people leaders like Jerub-Baal, whose name is also Gideon. Yahweh also sent Barak, Jephthah, and Samuel. Some versions say "Bedan" instead of Barak, but Samuel is probably referring to Barak. Each time, Yahweh saved the people so they could live in safety.

But when the people heard that Nahash, king of the Ammonites, was preparing to attack, the Israelites did not trust Yahweh to help. The Israelites asked for a human king, even though Yahweh was their king. But Yahweh still listened to the Israelites' request and gave them a king, who is now here in front of the people. Samuel emphasizes that Yahweh was the one who chose the Israelites' king.

The Israelites' future will depend on how the Israelites act from now on. The people can fear Yahweh, and honor and respect Yahweh by serving him, obeying him, and not rejecting his authority. If both the people and the king follow Yahweh and allow Yahweh to lead them, then the people's future will be good. However, if the people do not obey Yahweh and instead rebel against his commands, Yahweh will treat the people like he treated their ancestors who rebelled. Yahweh will allow the Israelites' enemies to defeat the Israelites.

Again, Samuel tells the Israelites to stand still and pay attention, this time to see Yahweh do something amazing. Samuel points out that this is the time for harvesting wheat, which is during the dry season when it does not rain. Samuel will pray and ask Yahweh to send rain and thunder. When Yahweh does, it would show the people that Yahweh agreed with what Samuel had told them: that the people had done something evil or wrong when they asked for a king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when a leader scolded his people, or told them how they had done something wrong. How did the leader show that it was important for the people to understand what they had done?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel speaks to the people and says that his time as their leader is over. Samuel asks the people to tell Samuel if he has ever acted unjustly. The people declare that Samuel has not mistreated them in any way. Samuel says that Yahweh and Yahweh's anointed one are witnesses to all that Samuel is saying. The people agree.

1 Samuel 12:1–17

In the second scene: Samuel reminds the people of all the good things that Yahweh has done for them in the past. Samuel says that the people rejected Yahweh when they asked for a king, which was wrong.

In the third scene: Samuel explains how the Israelites' future depends on whether they follow Yahweh from that time forward, or whether the Israelites rebel against Yahweh again.

In the fourth scene: Samuel declares that he will pray to Yahweh to send rain to show the people that Yahweh agrees with what Samuel has told the people.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- The people of Israel
- Yahweh
- Yahweh's anointed king, Saul
- Samuel's sons
- Moses
- Aaron
- The Israelites' enemies: Sisera, the Philistines, the king of Moab and his people
- Leaders of Israel: Gideon, Barak, and Jephthah
- And Nahash, king of the Ammonites

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Samuel speaks to the Israelite people who are gathered together. This may be at Gilgal, right after the last passage when the people affirmed Saul as king, or this may be at another gathering. Samuel speaks like he and the people are in a trial in front of a judge. Samuel first invites the people to bring any accusations or complaints against Samuel if he has done anything wrong. The people do not, which shows that Samuel is a trustworthy person whose words are reliable. Next, Samuel points out the witnesses, Yahweh and Saul. Then Samuel accuses the Israelites of acting in a wrong way. Samuel presents two options for the people to do, then asks Yahweh to confirm everything Samuel has said.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when you have a complaint or problem with another person, and must go in front of a judge, what are the steps for that process? What kind of people must be there? What evidence or proof must you give? Pause this audio here.

In the first scene, Samuel begins his speech by mentioning the length and end of Samuel's time as a leader. While Samuel led, he listened to the people's request for a new king, then followed Yahweh's instructions to appoint a king. Samuel points out this king, who is here listening. Samuel has led the Israelites for many years, starting from when Samuel was young until this day, or this time. Samuel is now old, with gray hair and grown sons, who are also listening here.

Samuel then asks the people to judge Samuel's actions and character. Samuel says that he is here in front of the people, ready to listen. Samuel invites the people to testify, or bring evidence against Samuel, while Yahweh and Yahweh's chosen king are listening. Samuel asks if he has done various wrong actions, like stealing, cheating, mistreating, or accepting bribes to make unfair judgments. If the people accuse Samuel of doing any of these things, then Samuel will repay what he has taken and make things right. Although Samuel asks the people if he has done these things in the form of a question, Samuel is not expecting the people to name someone whom Samuel has mistreated. Rather, Samuel is pointing out that the people cannot name anyone because Samuel has been a reliable and trustworthy leader.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss how you will show that Samuel is pointing these things out. Discuss if you want to keep the questions or phrase them differently. Pause this audio here.

The people agree and declare that Samuel has not done any of those things. Samuel points out that Yahweh and Yahweh's anointed one are witnesses. They have heard and can repeat that the people have declared Samuel to be a good leader. Yahweh and Saul can also confirm that what Samuel says is true, both about Samuel's good character and about what Samuel will next say about the people. The people agree that Yahweh is a witness.

1 Samuel 12:1–17

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When you are in front of a judge, what kind of witnesses or people to support your story do you need? How do you show that these people are good witnesses? Why do you need these people? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Samuel accuses the Israelites. Since Yahweh has saved the Israelites many times, the Israelites have done wrong by rejecting Yahweh for a human king. Samuel tells the people to stand still here as Samuel confronts the people with evidence. Samuel does not mean that the people were moving around. Rather, Samuel means that the people should stand like a person stands in front of a judge while another person accuses that person. Samuel reminds the people of the righteous or good acts that Yahweh has done for the people. These acts are Samuel's evidence or proof that the people had sinned.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When you go to a judge, where do the different groups of people stand or sit? Why do the people stand in different locations? What does this show, or how does this help the process? Pause this audio here.

Samuel quickly summarizes how Yahweh saved the Israelites from Egypt, since the people would already know the story. Samuel mentions how Jacob and Jacob's family moved to Egypt, and how, later, when the Egyptians made the Israelites serve as slaves, the Israelites cried out to Yahweh for help. Yahweh sent Moses and Aaron to lead the Israelites out of Egypt into the land they are in now.

Then Samuel summarizes the next several hundred years of Israel's history to point out a pattern. The Israelites stopped serving Yahweh, so Yahweh allowed the Israelites' enemies to defeat the Israelites. Then, when the Israelites admitted they had sinned by serving other gods, and they asked Yahweh to help, Yahweh sent leaders to save the Israelites, so they could again live safely. Samuel lists some of the Israelites' enemies during those times, like Sisera from the town of Hazor, the Philistine people group, and the king of Moab and his people.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the town of Hazor, the Philistines' land, and Moab's land. Pause this audio here.

Then Samuel lists some of the leaders Yahweh has sent: Jerub-Baal or Gideon, Barak, Jephthah, and finally himself, Samuel, whom the people have declared to be a good leader. Yahweh chose military leaders to show that Yahweh was the one who was the king who gave the people a victory.

Even when they heard about Nahash, who was preparing to attack, both Yahweh and Samuel led the Israelites. Samuel was a good leader, and Yahweh was an even better leader, so the people had no reason to ask for a king. But the people rejected Samuel and Yahweh and asked for a king.

Yahweh, however, gave the people what they wanted. Samuel again points out Saul, the king that the people asked for. Samuel also points out that Yahweh is the one who chose the king to emphasize that Yahweh is still the top ruler.

In the third scene, Samuel describes two sets of actions. The first action will bring a good relationship between the people and Yahweh. The people must fear Yahweh by honoring him. The people must serve and obey Yahweh, and not rebel against his commands. Both the people and the king must follow Yahweh, their God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Samuel tells the people to fear Yahweh, or to have a deep respect for and awe of Yahweh. Talk about someone you respect so much that you are almost afraid of that person. What kind of descriptions do you use? Discuss what words or phrases you will use to show this deep respect. Pause this audio here.

However, if the people disobey Yahweh and rebel against his commands, then there will be consequences. Yahweh will treat the Israelites like he treated their ancestors, and Yahweh will allow the Israelites' enemies to defeat them.

In the fourth scene, Samuel declares that he will ask Yahweh to do an amazing thing. Samuel tells the people to pay attention. Samuel reminds the people that it is the dry season, when it does not rain. The people's crops of grain are fully grown in the fields and are ready for people to harvest.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a ripe wheat field. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 12:1–17

Samuel will ask Yahweh to make thunder and rain to show that Yahweh is listening and to confirm that what Samuel has said is true. Samuel does this so that the people will realize and understand that the way the people have been acting is evil. This rain will damage the grain, so this rain could also be a punishment for the people's wrong actions.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- The people of Israel
- Yahweh
- Yahweh's anointed king, Saul
- Samuel's sons
- Moses
- Aaron
- The Israelites' enemies: Sisera, the Philistines, the king of Moab and his people
- Leaders of Israel: Gideon, Barak, and Jephthah
- And Nahash, king of the Ammonites

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Samuel said to all the Israelites, "I have agreed to all you were asking and have appointed a king over you. Here he is, ready to lead. As for me, I have been your leader from my youth until today. Now I am old and have gray hair. You also know my sons; they are here with you.

"Here I am in front of you. You know my character. Yahweh and his anointed king are listening, so speak up if you have seen me doing anything wrong. I have never taken anyone's ox. I have never taken anyone's donkey. I have never cheated anyone. I have never mistreated anyone. I have never accepted a bribe from anyone in order to judge unfairly. If I have, I will repay it." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have been careful to lead in the way that Yahweh has told me. I am not worried about any accusations or complaints; or
- I know that one way to be a good leader is to let the people bring any complaints or issues. The people can trust the leader and help the leader do what is right. I hope Saul sees and understands this; or
- I am growing old and tired now. It is getting harder to lead the people into battle and make so many decisions for the people. I hope Saul will be able to do these things well.

1 Samuel 12:1–17

Continue the drama. The people who stood there listening responded, “You did not cheat any of us, and you did not mistreat us. You did not take anything that belonged to any of us.”

Then Samuel said to the people, “Yahweh and his chosen king are witnesses today. They have heard and can testify against you that you have just said that I have not taken anything from you.”

“Yes,” the people said, “Yahweh is witness.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Of course, Samuel has been a good leader! I wonder why Samuel is saying all of this; or
- Samuel is speaking in such a formal way. Samuel must be about to tell us something important; or
- Yahweh, the king, and Samuel are all here speaking and listening to everything we say! This is an important gathering, and I am impressed that I get to be here too!

Continue the drama. Then Samuel said to the people, “It was Yahweh who appointed Moses and Aaron to be the leaders of your ancestors. It was Yahweh who brought our ancestors out of Egypt. Now pay attention. While Yahweh is listening, I will accuse you. Since Yahweh has saved you and your ancestors many times, I accuse you of doing wrong to reject Yahweh as king.

“After Jacob and his family went to live in Egypt, Jacob’s descendants cried out to Yahweh for help. Yahweh answered by sending Moses and Aaron, who led our ancestors out of Egypt and to this land where they could live. But your ancestors ignored Yahweh their God, so Yahweh allowed your ancestors’ enemies to defeat them. One of these enemies was Sisera, the commander of the soldiers from the town of Hazor. Other enemies who defeated your ancestors were the Philistines, as well as the king of Moab and his soldiers.

“Each time, the people of Israel prayed to Yahweh to save them, and they confessed that they had sinned. The people admitted that they had stopped worshiping Yahweh and had started worshiping Baal and Ashtoreth idols. The people asked Yahweh to rescue them from the power of their enemies and promised to worship only Yahweh. Each time Yahweh sent someone to rescue the people. Yahweh sent Gideon, Barak, Jephthah, and me, Samuel. Yahweh saved the people of Israel from all their enemies, who were attacking from every direction, and then you lived in safety.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Even though my people do not listen to me, I still care for my people and want to save them; or
- It makes me sad when my people worship other gods. When the Israelites’ enemies attack, those false gods cannot save the people. When the Israelites ask for help, I will show them that only I can save them; or
- I warned the Israelites that their enemies would defeat them if the Israelites did not follow my instructions, as they had promised.

Continue the drama. Samuel then said, “But when you heard that Nahash the Ammonite king and his soldiers were preparing to attack, you demanded a human king to rule over you, even though Yahweh your God was your king. See now, here is the king you demanded and chose. Here he is, the one Yahweh has appointed as king over you.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Since it was wrong for the people to ask for a king, I wonder if it is bad that I am the king. Maybe I should stop being king; or
- I am worried about our future now. Will other nations defeat us, just like they defeated our ancestors when they disobeyed Yahweh? or
- Since Yahweh chose me to be his king, maybe there is a way for me to lead the people in the way Yahweh wants me to lead.

Continue the drama. Samuel said, “If you honor Yahweh, serve and obey him, and do not disobey Yahweh’s command but follow Yahweh your God, you and your king, then things will go well for you. But if you refuse to obey Yahweh and refuse to do what he commands, then Yahweh will punish you like he punished your ancestors.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

1 Samuel 12:1–17

- Wow, I did not realize we were rejecting Yahweh like that! I am ashamed that I did not think through my actions; or
- I had forgotten how many good things Yahweh had done for us, and how many times we sinned against Yahweh. I am thankful that Yahweh is giving us another chance to obey; or
- I do not want our enemies to defeat us again! We must remind each other, and our king, to follow Yahweh's commands!

Continue the drama. Then Samuel said, "So pay attention and see the amazing thing Yahweh is going to do. You know that this is the time when we harvest wheat. Although this is the dry season, I will ask Yahweh to make it thunder and rain. Then you will realize how great an evil thing you have done against Yahweh by asking him to appoint a king for you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I need the people to understand how bad and dangerous it is to rebel against Yahweh's instructions. This sign will surprise and scare the people, but Yahweh will be able to show this to the people even better than I can; or
- I know Yahweh is here listening to what we are saying, and I want the people to be aware of Yahweh's presence. I am thankful that Yahweh shows us that he is near; or
- I trust that Yahweh hears me when I ask for things. We have a good relationship as I serve Yahweh and Yahweh teaches me.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel points out that the Israelites' **king** is here with them. A king was someone who ruled over a city or territory. Saul is the king of Israel. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

Samuel tells the people to testify against Samuel while Yahweh and Yahweh's anointed one listen. To testify means to declare the truth about something from one's own experience.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **testify**. Look up testimony in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh is God's proper name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Anointed or anointed one means a person whom God has chosen for a special task. God had Samuel anoint or pour oil over Saul's head to show that God had anointed Saul. For more information on anointed one, refer to anoint in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for anointed or anointed one as you used in previous passages.

Samuel says that Yahweh and Yahweh's anointed one are witnesses. A witness is someone who declares the truth about something that person has seen.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **witness**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh **appointed** Moses and Aaron to bring the Israelites out of Egypt. To appoint means to assign a job or role to someone and give them authority to act in a certain way. Use the same word or phrase for appoint as you used in previous passages.

Samuel reminds the people of Yahweh's righteous acts. Someone who is righteous is behaving in the right way. Yahweh is righteous because everything that God does is right and good. Here, "righteous acts" refers to how Yahweh acted to save the people of Israel from their enemies.

1 Samuel 12:1–17

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **righteous**. Look up righteous in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel says that **Jacob** moved to Egypt and then "they" cried out to Yahweh. Jacob is the Israelites' ancestor. Jacob's name is also "Israel," which is why people call Jacob's descendants "Israelites." The names "Jacob" and "Israel" sometimes refer to the person and sometimes to the people group. Jacob and his family moved to Egypt and became the people group of Israel, so Samuel probably uses this name to refer to Jacob and his family, while "they" refers to the Israelite people group.

When the Israelites' enemies defeat them, the Israelites admit that they have **sinned**. Sin is an act of rebellion against God. Anytime that a person disobeys God's laws, that person sins. For more information on sin, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you used in previous passages.

The people admit that they were wrong to worship the **Baals** and **Ashtoreths**. Baal and Ashtoreth were false gods that the nations around Israel worshiped. People made idols or statues of these gods in order to worship them. People then called these idols "Baals and Ashtoreths." For more information on Baal, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Baals and Ashtoreths as you used in previous passages.

Samuel says if the people fear Yahweh, it will go well for the people. Here, fear means to have reverence, honor, and respect for Yahweh. People show this fear by obeying Yahweh because of the respect they have for Yahweh, not because the people are afraid that Yahweh will treat the people cruelly.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **fear**. Look up "fear of God" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When Yahweh sends rain to confirm Samuel's words, then the people will see how they have done an evil thing by asking for a king. Evil is the opposite of good. When people do evil things, they do things God has told the people not to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **evil**. Look up evil in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 12:1–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (750 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 12:18–25

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 12:18–25 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:18–25 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:18–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Samuel pointed out how the Israelites had sinned against Yahweh. Samuel declared that he would ask Yahweh to send thunder and rain to show that Yahweh agreed with what Samuel had said. This story begins when Samuel prays to Yahweh. Yahweh sends thunder and rain, and the people of Israel are afraid because they realize they have sinned against a very powerful God. The people are afraid that God might kill the people to punish them. Samuel agrees that the people have sinned, but also reassures them that God will not punish the people by killing them. Samuel urges the people to follow Yahweh and promises that Samuel will continue to teach the people and pray for them.

Just like Samuel said he would, Samuel calls out to Yahweh and asks Yahweh to send rain and thunder to prove to the Israelites that they had sinned against Yahweh. Yahweh listens and sends thunder and rain that same day. Everyone is frightened of both Samuel and Yahweh. The people are afraid because Yahweh has so quickly responded to Samuel.

The people of Israel say to Samuel, “Pray to Yahweh your God for your servants.” The people are afraid that God might kill them to punish the people for asking for a king. The people call themselves “your servants,” which is a humble way to talk about yourself. The people ask Samuel to “pray to Yahweh your God,” because the people realize that they do not have the same standing with God that Samuel does because of their sin. Now the people understand that they have sinned in the past and have sinned again with this evil or bad request for a king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone had to apologize to someone important. How did that person show that they were sorry for what they had done? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 12:18–25

Samuel is honest but compassionate when he responds to the people. Samuel tells the people not to be afraid, and he reassures the people that God is not going to punish the people with death. Samuel agrees that the people have sinned, but says they should not continue to sin by turning away from Yahweh or leaving Yahweh in order to follow other things. Instead, the people should acknowledge that their true king is Yahweh. Samuel urges the people to serve Yahweh with all their heart. In the original language, people used the word "heart" to describe the deepest part of a person, where people thought, felt, and understood things. To do something with all your heart means to do it sincerely and completely, not halfway or distractedly.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone did something with "all their heart." Tell how the person focused all of their attention on something or someone they cared for. For example, tell about an athlete who practiced their sport or a person who loved another person. How did that person show that they were determined to show their care for this thing or person? Pause this audio here.

Samuel tells the people not to turn to worthless or empty things. In this story, these worthless things are idols or statues of false gods. These idols cannot do anything to help or save the people. The gods these idols represent are not true gods at all. These gods have no power to do anything for the people who worship them. These gods and their idols are useless.

The people should not reject Yahweh because Yahweh will not reject the people. Yahweh will not reject the people because of his great name or reputation. Yahweh chose to make Israel his people because Yahweh loved the people. Yahweh will continue to care for his people because Yahweh does what he says he will do. Yahweh will not dishonor his name or reputation by giving up on the Israelites. Yahweh wants people to see that he is a great God who is true to his promises, so that the people will honor Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people show their loyalty to their gods? Why are the people loyal to their gods? How do the gods show loyalty to the people? Why are the gods loyal to the people? Pause this audio here.

Samuel then promises to continue to help the Israelites, even though they have a king now. Samuel says, "Far be it from me to stop praying for you!" Samuel was saying here in a very strong way that he would always pray for the people so that the people would follow Yahweh. If Samuel did not pray for the people, Samuel would be sinning against Yahweh. Samuel also says that he will show the Israelites what is right and good for them to do.

Again, Samuel tells the people what they should do. The people should fear Yahweh and treat Yahweh with deep awe and respect. The people should serve Yahweh faithfully with all their hearts. The people should remember all the great things Yahweh has done, to remind themselves that Yahweh is a good God that the people can trust.

However, if the people continue to do evil or wrong things, then Yahweh will punish both the people and their king. Samuel says Yahweh will sweep the people away, like a broom sweeps dirt from a floor. We know from the rest of the Israelites' history that Samuel is saying that if the people continue to do evil things, Yahweh will send the people out of the land that Yahweh had given to the people. Although the people do not know it yet, Yahweh will cause their enemies to take the Israelites away as captives.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:18–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel asks Yahweh to send rain and thunder, and Yahweh does. The people are terrified and ask Samuel to pray to Yahweh for them so that Yahweh does not kill the people.

In the second scene: Samuel reassures the Israelites that Yahweh is their God. Samuel also reassures the Israelites that Samuel will continue to pray for the people and teach them. Samuel urges the people to serve Yahweh, then warns them what will happen if they do not.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Yahweh
- The Israelite people
- And the Israelite king, Saul

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The first scene begins right after the end of the last story. While Samuel is in front of all the people, Samuel asks Yahweh to send rain and thunder. Samuel probably speaks loudly so that the people can hear Samuel talking to Yahweh. That same day, Yahweh sends rain and thunder. When the people see how quickly the rain and thunder came in the dry season, the people are terrified of both Yahweh, who sent the rain, and Samuel, who has such a good relationship with Yahweh that Yahweh would listen to Samuel like this.

The people ask Samuel to pray for them because the people have sinned and because they have seen that Yahweh listens to Samuel. Perhaps the people are not sure they can call Yahweh their God anymore since they have sinned again and again. So the people call Yahweh Samuel's God, and the people humbly call themselves Samuel's servants. The people were afraid because they realized they had sinned against a very powerful God, who might kill the people to punish them. The people admit that they have sinned before and have sinned again by asking for a king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is a humble way to refer to yourself? Think of the story you told earlier about when someone apologized to an important person. What words or phrases did the person use when they apologized? Discuss why people choose these words or phrases. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Samuel reassures the people, but also reminds them of what they need to do in response. Samuel tells the people not to be afraid, because Yahweh is not going to punish them with death. Samuel agrees that the people have sinned, but urges them not to give up or stop serving Yahweh. The Israelites should serve Yahweh with all their heart! Yahweh is still the people's God, too!

Stop here and discuss as a group: Remember the story you told in the previous step about when someone did something with all their heart. Pay attention to the way you described how that person was enthusiastic and sincere when they did that action. Discuss how you want to translate the way Samuel says the Israelites should serve Yahweh with all their heart. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites should not serve other idols because they think that Yahweh will not help them anymore. Those idols cannot help the Israelites, but Yahweh can and will! It was Yahweh who decided to make the Israelites his people, not because of what the people did, but because Yahweh wanted to. And Yahweh continues to be the people's God because he keeps his promises, so that Yahweh does not dishonor his name or reputation. That way, everyone can see that Yahweh is a great God and can honor Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, discuss how you refer to someone's reputation. As an activity, pretend you are picking people to work on a project together, such as building a house or preparing a party. You can pick anyone you know or know of. As you list each person, describe why you picked that person. Pay attention to the way you describe that person's reputation, or how you know that person will act. Pause this audio here.

Samuel also reassures the people that they do not need to worry that Samuel will give up and stop praying for them. Samuel says it would be a sin if Samuel stopped praying, so of course, Samuel will keep praying! Samuel will also teach the people about the right and good way to act. Then the people can learn how not to sin against Yahweh again.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, suggest impossible or crazy actions to each other, things that you would never do. Think of both serious and funny things, such as doing something that scares you or cheering for a rival sports team. Pay attention to how you respond to these suggestions and what words and phrases you use to show that you would never do this thing. Pause this audio here.

To show how important this instruction is, Samuel repeats it and gives a warning. The Israelites must fear Yahweh and serve him completely and sincerely. If the people need a reminder of why they should serve Yahweh, the

1 Samuel 12:18–25

people should just think about all the good things Yahweh has done for them! If the people do not serve Yahweh, but instead continue to sin and do evil, then Yahweh will punish the people. Yahweh will sweep the people away.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss how you will translate the phrase “sweep away” to show that Yahweh will banish or cause the Israelites to leave their land. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When the people are very afraid in the beginning, Samuel tells the people not to be afraid that God will be cruel to them. Later, Samuel tells the people to fear God or have deep respect for and awe of Yahweh. Discuss what words you will use to describe these different kinds of fear. As an activity, think of great leaders who were so good, powerful, and impressive that you were almost a little afraid of them. Then think of powerful leaders who were bad and hurt people. Discuss the difference between how you fear or respect the good leaders and the bad ones. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:18–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Yahweh
- The Israelite people
- And Saul, the Israelite king

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Then Samuel asked Yahweh to send thunder and rain, and on that day Yahweh did cause thunder and rain. Then all the people were very frightened of Yahweh and of Samuel. The people pleaded with Samuel and said, “Ask Yahweh your God to forgive us, your servants. Ask Yahweh not to kill us, for we sinned many times before, and now we have sinned again by asking for a king.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I have never seen a storm like this at this time of the year! It must really be Yahweh who has sent it. Yahweh really is here, listening to what we say! or
- Look at the heavy rain and the loud thunder! It is so loud and windy! Yahweh must really be powerful to control the rain and thunder! I am afraid because I have sinned against Yahweh. Yahweh may be angry and kill me with this storm! or
- Yahweh listened to Samuel’s request for rain! Samuel must have a close relationship with Yahweh, who is a powerful God! I am now afraid of both of them.

Continue the drama. But Samuel replied, “Do not be afraid. It is true that you did all these evil things, but you must not turn away from Yahweh. Instead, serve Yahweh sincerely. Do not abandon Yahweh to serve useless

1 Samuel 12:18–25

idols. These idols cannot help you, and they cannot rescue you, for these idols are completely useless. Yahweh will not stop helping his people because Yahweh is very happy to make you his own people and because everyone will honor Yahweh as the great God." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love the people of Israel so much that I chose them to be my people, even before they started serving me. I also will continue to help the people, even when they sin or turn away from me; or
- I am sad when my people ask false gods for help instead of me. Those gods cannot help them! The people are wasting their time. Instead, the people should ask me for help and rejoice as they worship me; or
- I want all people to see how I treat the Israelites so they can understand that I am a good God. I care about other people groups as well, and want them to honor me.

Continue the drama. Then Samuel said, "As for me, I will certainly always pray for you. If I did not, I would be sinning against Yahweh. I will also teach you how to live in a way that is good and right. But you must fear Yahweh and be sincere as you serve him wholeheartedly. Remember all the wonderful things Yahweh has done for you. However, if you still continue to do evil, Yahweh will allow your enemies to defeat all of you, including your king, and your enemies will take you away from this land as captives." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I care for these people that I lead, and I want to reassure them that Yahweh is not a cruel God. I want the people to have a good relationship with Yahweh, as they learn to fear and respect Yahweh in the right way; or
- I worry about the Israelites. If the Israelites do not serve Yahweh, there will be consequences. I do not want the Israelites to keep making the same mistakes, so I will remind them what to do; or
- I want the Israelites to see how good it is to serve Yahweh! Yahweh is a good God who cares for us, even though we do not deserve it!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 12:18–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel asks **Yahweh** to send rain and thunder. Yahweh is God's proper name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

The people ask Samuel to **pray** to Yahweh for the people. To pray means to speak to God. For more information on pray, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for pray as you used in previous passages.

The people call Yahweh "Samuel's **God**." This is the more general word for God, not God's personal name, Yahweh. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

The people also call themselves Samuel's **servants**. A servant is a man or a woman who works for another person. Here, servant is a humble way to refer to yourself. The people do not actually work for Samuel. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages.

The people admit that they have **sinned**. Any time that a person disobeys God's laws, they sin. For more information on sin, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you used in previous passages.

The people also admit that their request for a king was **evil**. Evil is the opposite of good. When people do evil things, they do things God has told the people not to do. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for evil as you used in previous passages.

A **king** was someone who ruled over a city or territory. Saul is the king of the Israelites. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

1 Samuel 12:18–25

Samuel urges the people to serve Yahweh, not worthless things. Here, Samuel is probably talking about idols or false gods. An idol is an object that people make in order to worship a god. The object reminds the people of some characteristics of the god.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **worthless things**, **idols**, or **false gods**. If you decide to use idol or god for worthless things, look up idol and gods in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Samuel tells the people to **fear** Yahweh. Here, fear means to have reverence, honor and respect for Yahweh. People show this fear by obeying Yahweh because of the respect they have for Yahweh, not because they are afraid that Yahweh will treat the people cruelly. For more information on fear of Yahweh, refer to “fear of God” in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for fear of Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

The people should serve Yahweh **faithfully** and wholeheartedly. To do something faithfully means to do something sincerely and loyally. Use the same word or phrase for faithfully as you used in previous passages.

When a person does something **wholeheartedly**, or with their whole heart, it means that they are sincere and committed. The person really wants to do that thing. Use the same word or phrase for wholeheartedly or with all your heart as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 12:18–25

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (767 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 13:1–14

1 Samuel 13:1–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 13:1–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:1–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This section gives a short summary of Saul's time as king and tells a story that happens during this time. In the story, Saul prepares his army to fight against the Philistines, Israel's enemies. Saul's army is afraid of the huge Philistine army. To keep his soldiers from running away, Saul offers sacrifices to Yahweh without waiting for Samuel. When Samuel arrives, Samuel tells Saul that Saul has disobeyed Yahweh, so Yahweh will not let Saul's sons be king after Saul.

This section begins with a statement that introduces kings of Israel. This special statement usually includes how old a king is when the king begins to rule and how many years the king ruled. Here, in the original language, the numbers for Saul's age and the length of his rule are perhaps incomplete or confusing. Some translations use information from other reliable sources and say that Saul was 30 when he became king and ruled for 42 years.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, tell a story about a leader or king who ruled a long time ago. Begin by introducing the leader, so everyone will know who you are talking about. Then tell the story of something that happened while that person ruled. Pay attention to the phrases or information you use to introduce the leader. Pause this audio here.

The story begins when Saul chooses 3,000 men for his active army. This army will always be ready to defend Israel and the king. Saul keeps 2,000 men with him at Mikmash, which is a town in the hill country of Bethel. Then Saul sends 1,000 men with his son, Jonathan, to the town of Gibeah. Gibeah is in the territory of the tribe of Benjamin. Saul sends the men he did not choose to their homes. If Saul needs more men to fight in the army, Saul can gather those men together later.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the town of Gibeah in Benjamin's territory. Pause this audio here.

While at Gibeah, Jonathan and his men attack and defeat the Philistine outpost or army camp nearby. An outpost is a place where soldiers stay to guard or watch over an area. The Philistines are the Israelites' enemies. The outpost is at Geba, which may be another name for the town of Gibeah.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: When people in your culture go to battle, how do they decide when they need to attack the enemy or when to just wait until the enemy attacks and then defend themselves? What makes these actions different? When might you attack as a way to defend? Pause this audio here.

Someone tells the other Philistines that Jonathan and Jonathan's men have defeated the Philistines at the outpost. Saul knows the Philistines will be angry, so Saul sends messengers around Israel to tell the Israelites what has happened. To get everyone's attention, messengers blow on instruments called trumpets, which people made out of ram's horns. People would often use trumpets to gather the people for war.

Stop here and look at a picture of a trumpet as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people pass messages or tell others about news of big events? How do people know how or when to gather together for war? Pause this audio here.

The messengers also say, "You Hebrews, listen to us!" Hebrews is another word for the people group of Israel, including Israelites who lived in other lands. Usually, other people groups, like the Philistines, used this title. The messengers may have said "Hebrews" to include the Israelites who did not live in Israel.

Then the messengers say that Saul has attacked the Philistines. Even though Jonathan led the attack, the messengers probably said Saul did this, since Saul is the king and is responsible for what his army did.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: List some things that your leaders or nearby leaders have done or decisions that they have made. Discuss whether the leader was able to do those things by themselves or if they had other people help the leader. Pause this audio here.

The messengers also say that the Philistines hate the people of Israel, just like they hate a bad smell! The Israelites understand that the Philistines will attack, so the men travel to Gilgal to join Saul's army. Saul has moved from Mikmash to the town of Gilgal, which is a normal gathering place for the Israelites.

Meanwhile, the Philistines prepare to fight as well. The Philistines have 3,000 chariots, which are wagon-like vehicles with two wheels that horses pull. Soldiers would ride on chariots into battle. It was very difficult to defeat a chariot, but the soldiers on a chariot could often kill a lot of men. The Philistines have 6,000 men to ride the chariots and horses. The Philistines also have so many soldiers that no one can count the men, just like no one can count how many grains of sand are on the seashore!

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a chariot and of a seashore. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines go to Mikmash and set up their camp to the east of Beth Aven. The Israelites see the Philistine army and are afraid! The Israelites realize that they are hard pressed, or in great danger. There are so many Philistine soldiers that they could easily defeat and kill the Israelites. So the Israelites run away and hide. The Israelites hide in caves or holes in the sides of mountains and hills, and in thickets or thorn bushes. The Israelites hide in areas of rocky ground and in pits or holes in the ground. The Israelites hide in cisterns or holes that people had dug out of rock for storing water. Some even cross the Jordan River and go to the territory of the tribe of Gad and the region of Gilead.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cistern and of the Jordan River as a group. Pause this audio here.

Saul is still at Gilgal, and the soldiers who have not run away are so afraid that they are shaking or trembling. Samuel has told Saul to wait seven days at Gilgal. This may be the time of year when Samuel normally comes to Gilgal. Saul could also be waiting as a way to prepare himself spiritually for the sacrifices. In Israel and in other countries at that time, the king and his army would sacrifice to their god to ask for help before starting a battle or war. On the seventh day, Samuel has not arrived yet, and Saul's men are running away in fear, so Saul decides to begin offering sacrifices without Samuel.

Saul asks his men to bring to Saul the animals and supplies for the burnt offerings and the fellowship or peace offerings. People would often offer burnt offerings to Yahweh when they had a request. People offer peace offerings to celebrate that God is with them. Just as Saul finishes giving the burnt offering, Samuel arrives. Saul goes to Samuel to welcome him, but Samuel asks Saul what Saul has done. Samuel can see that Saul has offered the burnt offering already, so Samuel is not asking what has happened. Samuel is accusing Saul of doing wrong and asking why Saul has done it.

Saul says that he was running out of time because his men were scattering, Samuel was late, and the Philistines were already gathered and ready to fight. Saul thinks that the Philistines will come to attack the Israelites at Gilgal, and Saul does not want to fight without asking Yahweh's favor or help. It was Samuel's job to offer the sacrifice and speak to Yahweh to ask for favor and direction in battle, but since Samuel was not there, Saul decided to do Samuel's job himself.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people ask for help from their gods before a battle? Who asks for help or speaks to the gods? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 13:1–14

Samuel replies that Saul has done a foolish thing. Saul has not kept the command that Yahweh, Saul's God, has given him. Yahweh is Samuel's God, too, but Samuel is emphasizing that because Yahweh is Saul's God, Saul should have obeyed Yahweh. Samuel does not say which command Saul did not follow, but Saul would know which command it was. Because Saul has disobeyed, Yahweh will not establish Saul's kingdom or let Saul's kingdom continue. This means that even though Saul is still king, Saul's descendants will not be kings after Saul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a king or leader whose children and grandchildren became king after that king died. Pretend you are a teacher who is telling your class about this family of kings. How would you describe the way this king or leader's descendants also ruled as a king or leader? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh has decided to find someone else to appoint or choose as Yahweh's ruler. It is so certain that Yahweh will do this that Samuel says it is already done. Yahweh has found a man after Yahweh's heart. In the original language, people used the word "heart" to describe the deepest part of a person, where people thought, felt, and made decisions. This means that this man is loyal to Yahweh and wants to serve Yahweh. Yahweh has decided to appoint or choose this man to rule Yahweh's people instead of Saul's descendants, because Saul did not keep or follow Yahweh's command.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The writer formally introduces Saul as king and then begins a story that happened while Saul was king. In the story, Saul chooses some of the men for his army and sends the rest home.

In the second scene: Jonathan and his soldiers defeat the soldiers at the Philistine outpost. Because the Philistines are angry at the Israelites for defeating their men at the outpost, Saul sends messengers to gather the Israelite men at Gilgal to fight.

In the third scene: The Philistines gather their army and camp at Mikmash. The Israelites are afraid and many run away.

In the fourth scene: Saul waits seven days at Gilgal for Samuel. When Saul sees how his men are afraid and how Samuel has not yet arrived, Saul decides to offer the burnt offering.

In the fifth scene: Samuel arrives and asks Saul why Saul has done this. Saul says he was afraid to wait any longer for Samuel. Samuel replies that Saul has disobeyed Yahweh, so Yahweh will not let Saul's family continue to rule Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The men of Israel, or the Hebrews
- Jonathan, Saul's son
- The Philistine army
- Samuel
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The first scene begins with a common statement about the age of the king when he began to rule, and how long the king ruled. In this time, this was a normal way to begin a history or story about a king. This statement gives the setting for the story that the writer will tell next. While the numbers of Saul's age and the length of Saul's rule are not clear here, Saul was a grown man when he became king and probably ruled for about 40 years. You can use the numbers of the translation you are listening to.

Stop here and discuss which numbers you will use here. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember the story you told in step two about introducing a leader. How will you introduce Saul in this story? Pause this audio here.

The story begins when Saul chooses men for his army. It is not clear if this happened at the beginning of Saul's time as king or at a later time. All the fighting men of Israel are together, ready for Saul to pick from. Saul chooses 3,000 men to be his active army. These men's job will be to protect the king and the people from any attack. Saul keeps 2,000 men with Saul at, or "in," a camp just outside the town of Mikmash. Mikmash was a town in the hilly country around the town of Bethel.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the towns of Mikmash and Bethel. Pause this audio here.

Saul puts his son Jonathan in charge of 1,000 men and sends Jonathan and Jonathan's men to the town of Gibeah. Gibeah is in the tribe of Benjamin's territory. Gibeah is across from Mikmash on the south side of a valley. These two towns are good places to defend the area. Saul sends the rest of the men to their tents, which is another way of saying Saul sends them home. If Saul needs a big army for a battle, Saul can gather these men together again.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the town of Gibeah in Benjamin's territory. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Jonathan decides to attack the Philistines. The Philistines had an outpost or camp of soldiers outside the town of Giba, which is probably another name for Gibeah. The Philistine soldiers there would be a threat or danger to the town. It is not clear how long Jonathan has been at Gibeah before he attacks the outpost with his soldiers and defeats the Philistines there.

Someone tells the other Philistines about the attack, and the Philistines are angry. Saul knows that the Philistines will probably try to attack the Israelites, so Saul sends messengers around Israel to gather all the fighting men. These messengers would go to towns and blow trumpets that people had made from rams' horns. The Israelite men would understand that this was a signal that they should gather together for war.

As an activity, have everyone in the group talk to each other. Have one person call out to the others to listen to what the person has to say. Pay attention to the words or phrases you use to get everyone's attention. Pause this audio here.

The messengers also explain why they must gather. Because of the attack on the outpost, the Philistines hate the Israelites like people hate a bad smell.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what words or phrases do you use for things that you hate? What do you compare these things to? Pause this audio here.

When the Israelite men hear this, the men understand that the Philistines will attack soon. Any Israelite man who can fight goes to Saul to join the army. Saul has left Mikmash and gone to Gilgal, probably because this was where the Israelites often gathered.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the town of Gilgal. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the Philistines also gather their army. Some versions say the Philistines have 30,000 chariots, but others say 3,000, which is the more likely number. Two men can ride each chariot, and the Philistines have 6,000 men to ride the chariots and horses. The Philistine soldiers who walk are too many to count. The storyteller says the Philistines are like the grains of sand on the shore of a river or the sea, which no one can count!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe a large group of things, too many to count, like stars in the sky, wheat or rice grains in a field, or a big crowd of people. Pay attention to what words or phrases you use to describe how there are lots of items or people. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines camp outside the town of Mikmash, just east of the town of Beth Aven. The Israelites see how many soldiers the Philistines have and realize that they are in great danger. The Israelites believe that the Philistines will defeat the Israelites and kill them, so many of the Israelite soldiers run away and hide. The Israelites hide in caves, in any kind of hole or pit, among rocks and bushes, and in places to store water. The Israelites even cross the Jordan River to the east and go to the land of the tribe of Gad, and the region of Gilead, just to be further away from the Philistines.

1 Samuel 13:1–14

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the Jordan River and the regions of Gad and Gilead. Pause this audio here.

The fourth scene takes place in Gilgal, where Saul is, along with the soldiers who have not run away. These soldiers are still afraid. The soldiers are so afraid that they are shaking with fear. Saul waits for seven days for Samuel to arrive at the appointed time or the time Samuel said he would. On the seventh day, Samuel has not yet arrived, so Saul decides he cannot wait any longer. Saul's men are scattering or running away, and Saul thinks that he has to do something to stop the men from leaving.

Saul tells people to bring Saul supplies for the burnt offerings and the peace or fellowship offerings. For a burnt offering, a priest would kill an animal and burn the whole animal on an altar. For a fellowship offering, a priest would kill an animal and burn part of it on the altar, and then the people would cook and eat the rest of the animal. Saul offers the burnt offering. Saul may do this by himself, or someone may help Saul, but either way, Saul does not wait for Samuel.

In the fifth scene, Samuel arrives, just after Saul finishes the burnt offering. Samuel has come on the day Samuel said he would come, probably later in the day than Saul expected. Samuel sees the burnt offering and asks Saul why Saul has done this wrong thing.

Saul replies with reasons or excuses for what Saul did. Saul's men were leaving him, so Saul wanted to do something that would cause the men to stay. If Saul's men left, Saul thought he would lose to the Philistines, who may attack at any time. Saul wanted to make sure that the Israelites asked Yahweh for help before they started fighting. Samuel was not there to ask Yahweh for help or instructions, so Saul says he forced himself to offer the burnt offering to ask Yahweh for help, even though that was not Saul's job.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Saul says he forced himself or took the risk of offering the burnt offering, because Saul knew he was not supposed to do that thing. In your language, what words or phrases would you use to describe when someone does something dangerous or something they know they should not do? Pause this audio here.

However, Samuel tells Saul that what Saul did was a very foolish thing to do! This was not what Yahweh told Saul to do. If Saul had done what Yahweh said, then Yahweh would have allowed Saul and his descendants to rule Israel forever. Now this will not happen. Yahweh has already decided to replace Saul with a man whom Yahweh has chosen himself. Samuel says this man will be the ruler over Israel. Again, Samuel uses a different word than king, because Yahweh is really Israel's true king or top ruler. This man is loyal to Yahweh and wants to serve Yahweh. This will happen because Saul did not obey what Yahweh commanded Saul to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the new ruler as a "man after Yahweh's own heart." Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The men of Israel, or the Hebrews
- Jonathan, Saul's son
- The Philistine army
- Samuel
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

1 Samuel 13:1–14

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

When Saul became king, Saul was 30 years old, and he ruled over Israel for 42 years. Saul chose 3,000 Israelite men to be in Saul's army. Saul ordered 2,000 of these men to stay with Saul at Mikmash, which is in the hills around Bethel. The other 1,000 went with Jonathan to Gibeah in the territory of Benjamin. Saul sent the rest of the men back to their homes.

One day, Jonathan and Jonathan's men defeated the Philistine soldiers at the outpost at Geba. Someone told the rest of the Philistine soldiers what had happened. So Saul ordered some of Saul's soldiers to blow trumpets throughout the land of Israel to signal the Hebrews to gather for war. Throughout all Israel, the people heard that Saul's army had attacked the Philistine garrison and that the Philistine people hated the Israelites now. The Israelite men joined Saul at Gilgal as the messengers told the men to do. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad we are finally going to fight back against the Philistines. Maybe, now that we have a king, we can completely defeat the Philistines, so the Philistines will stop bothering us! or
- One moment I am working in my fields, then I hear the messengers blowing trumpets, and now I am going to go join the army! This is all happening very fast. I hope my family will be safe while I am gone; or
- I am a little scared to fight the Philistines! I want to defend my people, but I have not trained to be a warrior.

Continue the drama. At the same time, the Philistines gathered together to fight against the Israelites. The Philistines had 3,000 chariots, 6,000 horsemen, and many other Philistine soldiers on foot. There were so many Philistines that no one could count them. Then the entire Philistine army went up to Mikmash and camped there, east of the town of Beth Aven. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The Israelites are too proud and think that they are better than us! We will defeat the Israelites and show them that we are stronger than them; or
- I am so angry that the Israelites killed some of our people! I want to hurt the Israelites back! or
- I am excited to go fight. I think we definitely will defeat these people and take their land and all their possessions.

Continue the drama. The Israelite soldiers realized that they were in great danger because the Philistine army was much stronger than their army. So the Israelites hid in caves or in thick brush. Others hid behind rocks or in pits and wells. Some of the Hebrews even fled across the Jordan River to the regions of Gad and Gilead. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I saw how many Philistines there are! There is no way we will be able to win! I do not want to die! or
- If I die, my family will not have anyone to provide for them! Maybe if I hide, I can return home after the Philistines win; or
- No one can defeat the Philistines. I am upset that Saul started a war that we cannot win! I am not going to stay and follow Saul.

Continue the drama. Saul stayed at Gilgal, and all the soldiers who had not already run away were shaking with fear. Saul waited for a week, as Samuel had told Saul to do. However, Samuel did not come to Gilgal during that time. Then Saul's soldiers began to leave Saul. So Saul said, "Bring me the animals for a burnt offering and fellowship offerings." Then Saul offered the burnt offerings himself.

1 Samuel 13:1–14

As soon as Saul had sacrificed the burnt offering, Samuel came. Saul went out to welcome Samuel. But Samuel asked Saul, “Why have you done this wrong thing?”

Saul answered, “I had to do it! I saw my soldiers leaving me, and you did not come when you told me you would. Not only that, but the Philistine army was gathering at Mikmash. I realized that the Philistines were coming to attack me here in Gilgal and that I had not done anything to ask Yahweh to help me. So I thought that I had to offer the burnt offering myself.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I did wait for Samuel, but Samuel did not come! Samuel is not Israel’s only leader. Since I am the king, I am the next best person to offer the sacrifices; or
- I do not want to fight the Philistines without Yahweh’s help. I will do anything to get Yahweh’s help, even if it is in a different way than he told me to; or
- My army is scared because they have had nothing to do but wait for seven days. I know we have to sacrifice before battle, so I want to go ahead and offer the sacrifices so we can start fighting. Then my men will not have time to think about how scared they are.

Continue the drama. Samuel said, “That was a very foolish thing you have done! You did not do what Yahweh your God told you to do. If you had, Yahweh would have allowed you and your descendants to rule over Israel forever. But now that will not happen. You and your offspring will not continue to rule as Israel’s kings. Yahweh has decided that he will replace you with a man whom Yahweh has chosen himself. Yahweh has appointed this other man to be the leader of Yahweh’s people, because you did not obey what Yahweh commanded you to do.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- These sacrifices are not payment for my help. I help the Israelites because I care about them, and they honor me by doing what I tell them to do. Saul did not do what I told him to, but instead did the job that I gave to Samuel; or
- I will not refuse to help the Israelites because of Saul’s mistake, because I have chosen to make them my people. However, there will be consequences because of what Saul did; or
- I want to give my people good things and good leaders. I am already prepared to choose another leader, one who will do what is best for the people by following my commands.

Ask the person playing Samuel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am disappointed that Saul did not trust me or Yahweh and did not wait for me. I did what I said I was going to do and came on the day I said I would! or
- I am pointing out what Saul did wrong so that Saul can learn and not do it again. It is important that a leader makes wise decisions, or that leader could hurt his people! or
- I am sad that Saul did not do what Yahweh asked Saul to. Yahweh only asks us to do what is best for us!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

This story begins by describing how old Saul was when he became **king** of Israel. A king was someone who ruled over a city or territory. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

Israel is the name of the country where the Israelites lived. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

Jonathan attacks the Philistine **outpost** at Geba. Use the same word or phrase for outpost or army camp that you have used in previous passages.

After Jonathan attacks the Philistines, Saul sends messengers with trumpets around Israel. People made trumpets out of a ram’s horn, with a hole at the narrow tip. When someone blew through the hole, the trumpet

1 Samuel 13:1–14

would make two or three notes. People used trumpets to signal messages, especially messages for gathering the people for war.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a trumpet again, as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **trumpet**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The messengers say, "You **Hebrews**! Listen to what we have to say!" The word Hebrew can refer to the descendants of Abraham. People call the descendants of Abraham Israelites, Jews, and sometimes Hebrews. For more information on Hebrew, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Hebrew as you used in previous passages.

The Philistine army has **chariots**. Chariots were wagon-like vehicles with two wheels. Horses pulled a chariot, and two men, one driver and one warrior, rode the chariot into battle. The warrior would fight the enemy while standing in the chariot. Use the same word or phrase for chariot as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a chariot again as a group as needed. Pause this audio here.

When the Israelites see the Philistines, the Israelites are afraid and hide in all sorts of holes, such as cisterns. Cisterns are holes that people dig out of rock to store water.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cistern again as a group, as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **cistern**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Some Israelites cross the Jordan River to hide from the Philistines. The Jordan River is a long river that runs through Israel from north to south. At some times of the year, the river is smaller, and a person can get across the river by wading or swimming through the water.

Stop here and look at a picture of the Jordan River again as a group as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **Jordan River**. Look up Jordan River in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul waits seven days, which is the length of time Samuel **appointed**. Later, Samuel says that Yahweh has already decided to appoint someone else as ruler of Israel. To appoint means to choose something. An appointed time is a time that someone chose. To appoint someone means to assign a job or role to that person. Use the same word or phrase for appoint as you used in previous passages.

When Samuel does not arrive when Saul thinks Samuel should, Saul tells people to bring him the supplies for the **burnt offerings** and fellowship offerings. A burnt offering is a kind of sacrifice that people bring to God. When a person brings God a burnt offering, he kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar, which is a special table or platform that people put gifts to God on. For more information on burnt offering, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for burnt offering as you used in previous passages.

A **fellowship offering**, also called a peace offering, is an offering that people brought to God to restore peace with someone and to celebrate fellowship with God and people. For more information on peace or fellowship offerings, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for peace or fellowship offering as you used in previous passages.

Samuel says that Saul did not obey the commandment that Yahweh gave to Saul. A commandment refers to the rules that God gave his people. This can be the general rules of God or a rule that God gave to Saul specifically. Samuel does not specifically say which commandment Saul did not obey.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **commandment**. Look up commandment in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh is God's personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

1 Samuel 13:1–14

Samuel says, "your **God**," or the God Saul worships. Here, Samuel uses the more general word for God. This is still Yahweh, the God that both Samuel and Saul worship. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

Because Saul disobeyed Yahweh, Yahweh will not let Saul's kingdom continue. Here, kingdom means the role or position of a king. Yahweh is saying that Saul's family would not continue to have the role of king after Saul died.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kingdom** when it refers to someone's descendants having the role of king. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh has decided to choose someone else to be the **ruler** of Israel. In the original language, this word for ruler or chosen leader is not the same word as king. Use the same word or phrase for ruler as you used in previous passages.

This new ruler will be "a man after God's own **heart**." In the original language, people used the word "heart" to describe the deepest part of a person, where people thought, felt, and made decisions. This means that this man is loyal to Yahweh and wants to serve Yahweh. See the Master Glossary for more information about heart. If you use the word for heart in your translation, use the same word that you have used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 13:1–14

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (974 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 13:15–23

1 Samuel 13:15–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 13:15–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:15–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story explains why the Philistine army was such a danger to the Israelites. Samuel leaves the Israelite army, and the Philistines send out groups of soldiers to attack the Israelite people. The Philistines have stopped the Israelite craftsmen from making weapons. When it is time to fight, only Saul and Jonathan have swords and spears. This shows how great Yahweh's victory will be in the later stories, since the Israelites had no swords or spears with which to save themselves.

This story begins when Samuel leaves Saul and the army. Some translations say that Samuel left Gilgal and went to the town of Geba, which is probably another name for Gibeah. Other translations say that Samuel went on his way while Saul and Saul's army went to Gibeah. This second option better matches information from later in the story.

Gibeah is in the territory of the tribe of Benjamin. When Saul arrives there, Saul counts all his soldiers, but there are only about 600 who did not run away in the last story. While the Israelites camp at Gibeah, the Philistines are still at the town of Mikmash, which is not far away. The Philistines send out raiding parties, or groups of soldiers who attack any Israelites they meet. These Philistine soldiers steal or destroy the Israelites' belongings and food supplies.

There are three groups of these Philistine soldiers. The first group goes north, toward the town of Ophrah in the region of Shual. The next group goes west toward the town of Beth Horon. The third group goes east to a range of hills near the valley of Zeboyim. These hills are on the edge of a wilderness, or a place where no one lives.

The storyteller gives us the extra information that it is hard for the Israelites to defend themselves because the Philistines have stopped any blacksmith from working in Israel. Blacksmiths are people who can make tools and weapons from iron. Iron swords and spears were the strongest weapons at that time, and only a blacksmith could make them. The Philistines said they did not want the Hebrews making swords and spears. Hebrew is another word for Israelite. Other nations used the word Hebrew to insult the Israelites.

Stop here and look at a picture of swords and spears as a group. Pause the audio here.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your culture, what materials do people make weapons out of? What are the best or strongest materials for these weapons? What do you call the people who make these weapons? Pause this audio here.

So if any Israelite needed to have their iron farm tools sharpened or repaired, that person had to pay a Philistine blacksmith to do it. The Israelites had iron plowshares to break up the dirt to prepare to plant seeds. The Israelites also had mattocks or hoes, which are metal tools for digging in the dirt. The Israelites had axes, which people used to cut down trees, and sickles, which people used for harvesting grain.

Stop here and look at a picture of plowshares, mattocks or hoes, axes, and sickles as a group. What tools do you have in your culture that look similar to these? Who usually repairs these tools? Pause this audio here.

The Philistines made the Israelites pay very high prices. The Israelites had to pay two-thirds of a shekel or piece of silver to sharpen or repair a plow, a mattock or hoe, a pitchfork, an ax, or a goad. A pitchfork was a three-pronged metal tool that people used to lift grass or hay. A goad is a long stick with a sharp metal point. If a farmer wanted an animal to move or go forward, the farmer would jab the animal with the goad. Some translations say the Israelites paid one-third of a shekel for the last three tools. Either way, these were high prices.

Stop here and look at a picture of pitchforks and goads as a group. Pause this audio here.

Tell a story about a time when something important broke and there was no one nearby who could repair that thing. What did you do? Pause this audio here.

So whenever there was a battle, none of the Israelite soldiers who were with Saul and Jonathan had a sword or spear to fight with. Only Saul and Jonathan had swords and spears. The Israelites are in danger, since they have only a small army, with no swords or spears, and the Philistine army is not far away.

And the Philistines move even closer. The Philistines send the main group of their army to the pass of Mikmash. Remember from the last story that the two armies are on opposite sides of the valley. The valley is hard to cross, except at the pass. Now the Philistines are at the pass, ready to defend themselves or attack Saul's army.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel leaves Gilgal and goes away. Saul and the army also leave Gilgal and go to Gibeah, where Saul counts his men. The Philistines send groups of soldiers north, west, and east to attack the Israelites.

In the second scene: The Israelites have no swords and spears to defend against these attacks because the Philistines had stopped any blacksmiths from working in Israel. When the Israelites needed someone to repair their tools for farming, the Israelites had to take the tools to Philistine blacksmiths.

In the Third scene: A large group of Philistines move from their main camp to the pass at Mikmash.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Saul
- Jonathan, Saul's son
- The Israelite army
- The Philistine army, including their raiding parties
- The Israelite farmers
- And the Philistine blacksmiths

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

At the end of the last passage, Saul and Samuel were at Gilgal with the Israelite soldiers who had not run away. This story begins by describing where everyone goes next. In the first scene, Samuel leaves the Israelite army. Saul and the army also leave Gilgal and travel to Gibeah, which is in the territory of Benjamin.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the towns of Gilgal and Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan and his group of soldiers have probably been at Geba, or Gibeah, this whole time. When Saul arrives there too, Saul counts the men he brought with him and those who are already at Gibeah. There are about 600 men. All the other men who had gathered together in the last story have run away.

Meanwhile, the Philistines are still camped at the town of Mikmash, which is north of Gibeah. The towns of Mikmash and Gibeah are only a few miles away from each other, separated by a deep valley. The valley was hard to cross except at the pass, or safe crossing, of Mikmash.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the towns of Mikmash and Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines send out three raiding groups of soldiers north, west, and east to attack the Israelites. One group of Philistines goes north towards the town of Ophrah, which is in the region of Shual. Ophrah is about eight kilometers north of Mikmash. One group goes west toward the town of Beth Horon, which is about 16 kilometers from Mikmash. The last group goes east towards the ridge of hills and the Valley of Zeboyim. A wilderness is just beyond these hills. The Israelite army cannot stop these raiding groups because the Philistine army is blocking the way north. It would be too difficult to pass by or through the Philistines' main army camped at Mikmash and the soldiers the Philistines sent to guard the pass.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the towns of Ophrah and Beth Horon, as well as the Valley of Zeboyim. Pause this audio here.

The second scene explains why the Israelites could not protect themselves well from these attacks. The storyteller pauses the story to explain something that had been happening in the past. The Philistines wanted to keep the Israelites from making iron swords and spears, so the Philistines stopped any blacksmiths from working in the land of Israel. The Philistines may have sent other raiding parties in the past to kill, capture, or attack any blacksmith in Israel. When Israelite farmers' tools broke, the farmers had to travel to the Philistines' land and pay Philistine blacksmiths for a repair. And the Philistines probably would not make or repair any weapons for the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, tell a story about something that happened during a dangerous time in your people's history. At some point in the story, explain why it was a dangerous time. Pay attention to how and when you choose to explain this. Pause this audio here.

So now, when the Israelites are gathered together with Saul at Gibeah, none of the Israelites have swords or spears except for Saul and his son Jonathan. The army may have had other weapons which they made out of wood, stone, and other metals, but nothing as strong as the iron weapons that the Philistines had.

In the third scene, a garrison, or large group of the Philistine army, moves from the Philistines' main camp by the town to the pass in order to defend it.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Saul
- Jonathan, Saul's son
- The Israelite army
- The Philistine army, including their raiding parties
- The Israelite farmers
- And the Philistine blacksmiths

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Then Samuel left Gilgal and went on his way. The rest of the men followed Saul as Saul went to join his other soldiers. The men went from Gilgal to Gibeah in the territory of Benjamin. There Saul counted the soldiers who were still with Saul. There were only about 600 men.

Saul and his son Jonathan and their soldiers were camping at Gibeah in Benjamin. As for the Philistine army, they were camped at Mikmash. The Philistine soldiers went out from their camp in three groups to go on raids. The first group went north toward the town of Ophrah in the region of Shual. The next group went west toward the town of Beth Horon. The third group went east to the bordering hills that overlook the Valley of Zeboyim toward the wilderness. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- It will be easy to take anything we want from the Israelites. The Israelites’ army would have to fight our army to stop our raiding groups, but they are not strong enough to do so; or
- We hate the Israelites because they attacked our outpost. We want to steal from the Israelites to punish and humiliate them; or
- Since there are so many soldiers in our army, we need lots of food and supplies. We can just take these supplies from the Israelites around us!

Continue the drama. Before this story happened, the Philistines wanted to keep the Israelites from making iron swords and spears, so they prevented blacksmiths from working in any part of the land of Israel. When the Israelites needed to have their plows, hoes, axes, and sickles sharpened, the Israelites had to take them to Philistine blacksmiths. The Israelites had to pay a lot of money for the repairs: two-thirds of a shekel to sharpen plows, hoes, pitchforks, axes, and to repair cow goads. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite people, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I do not feel safe, since no one in our army has iron weapons. The Philistines could attack any time, and I do not think we could stop them! or
- I am angry that the Philistines have stopped the blacksmiths from working here. The Philistines do what they want in our land, and we cannot stop them! or
- I cannot afford the time and money to travel to a Philistine blacksmith. If my tools break, I am worried that I will not be able to repair them. Then I cannot work on my farm and grow food for my family!

Continue the drama. So when the Israelites went into battle against the Philistines, only Saul and his son Jonathan had swords and spears. A large group of Philistine soldiers had gone to the pass at Mikmash. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite soldiers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am scared to fight the Philistine soldiers! The Philistines have more soldiers, and when we fight, their weapons are so strong that they can break our weapons! We are going to die! or
- I am determined to stay with Saul and the army to defend my people, even though the Philistines are stronger than we are. I hope our God saves us! or
- I feel ashamed that we do not have the strongest weapons and that we cannot stop the Philistines from attacking our people.

Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I do not know what to do. Samuel has just scolded me and left. I am not sure if Yahweh will help us, since I disobeyed Yahweh’s command. My army does not even have enough weapons! or
- I am sad that I cannot defend my people from the Philistine raiding groups. Maybe I am not a good king or leader! or

- I wish Jonathan and I could use our swords and spears to defend my people, but I know it will not be enough. I feel useless!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 13:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

One group of Philistine soldiers goes south towards the **wilderness**. A wilderness is an empty place without water. There are almost no trees or bushes growing in a wilderness. The ground is dry and rocky, and there are wild animals roaming around. For more information on wilderness, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for wilderness as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines have stopped any blacksmiths or craftsmen from working in the land of Israel. A blacksmith is a person who can make and repair tools and weapons from iron.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **blacksmith**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines say that they do not want the **Hebrews** to make swords or spears. Foreigners often referred to the Israelites as Hebrews. For more information on Hebrew, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Hebrew as you used in previous passages. Use the same word or phrase for swords and spears as you used in previous passages.

The Israelites had to pay Philistine blacksmiths to repair their plows, hoes, axes, sickles, pitchforks, and goads. Most of these tools had a wooden handle and a metal blade or sharp end. A plow is a farm tool with a metal blade called a plowshare. People used plows to break up the dirt for planting seeds. Animals often pulled the plow. People also used hoes or mattocks for digging in the dirt. An ax had a shorter handle. People used axes to cut down bushes or trees. A sickle had a curved blade. People used sickles for harvesting grain. A pitchfork or a three-pronged fork had a long handle and three sharp metal prongs. People used pitchforks to lift hay or grass. A goad is a long stick with a sharp metal point. If a farmer wanted an animal to move or go forward, the farmer would jab the animal with the goad.

Stop here and look at the pictures of a plow, mattock or hoe, ax, sickle, pitchfork, and goad as a group again as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **plow**, **mattock** or **hoe**, **ax**, **sickle**, **pitchfork**, and **goad**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites had to pay two-thirds of a **shekel** for these repairs. A shekel is a unit of weight. One shekel is 11.4 grams, so two-thirds of a shekel is about 9 grams of silver. For more information on shekel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for shekel or piece of silver as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines moved the main group of their army to the pass. A pass is a safe route through rough or dangerous ground.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **pass**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 13:15–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (946 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 14:1–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 14:1–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:1–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

At the end of the last section, the Philistines sent a group of their soldiers to the pass or the valley's safe crossing. In this story, Saul's son Jonathan goes to look at the Philistine camp with another soldier. Jonathan trusts that God will show Jonathan whether he should attack the Philistines. When God does give Jonathan a sign, Jonathan and the other soldier attack. The Philistines are terrified because God is helping the Israelites.

This section begins by introducing the main characters in the story and what those characters will do. Jonathan, Saul's son, speaks to the young man who is Jonathan's armor-bearer. In that time, a soldier would often go into

1 Samuel 14:1–15

battle with another man who carried the soldier's shield and sometimes his other weapons, such as a sword, spear, bow, and arrows. The two men would fight together as a team, with the armor-bearer giving the soldier weapons as the soldier needed them. The armor-bearer would also protect the soldier from attacks from behind.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do soldiers work together when they fight? What role or responsibility does each person have? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan suggests that he and his armor-bearer go towards the Philistine outpost or army camp on the other side of the valley, probably to see what the Philistines are doing. Jonathan does not tell Saul, perhaps because Jonathan does not want to worry Saul or because Jonathan thinks that Saul will tell Jonathan not to go.

Then the storyteller gives some background information about Saul and the rest of the army. Saul is staying, or temporarily living, outside of the town of Gibeah. Saul is staying near a tree that grows fruit called pomegranates. Pomegranate trees can grow up to 10 meters tall, and leaders often sat and made decisions by trees. This tree was near a place called Migron, which may have been a threshing floor, a large flat space where people would prepare grain.

Stop here and look at a picture of a pomegranate tree and a threshing floor as a group. Pause this audio here.

The 600 soldiers in the Israelite army are near Saul, as is the priest, Ahijah. Yahweh's priests all come from the same family, so the writer lists Ahijah's family line or ancestry to show that Ahijah is really a priest. Ahijah's grandfather, Eli, served Yahweh as a priest at Shiloh, where Yahweh's place of worship was. Ahijah has the ephod. In the original language, this word can mean a sacred garment which only the high priest wore, and which possibly looked like a vest with a pocket. It can also mean the objects that priests used to determine God's will, which priests probably kept in or near the sacred garment. We are not sure which object Ahijah has here.

Stop here and look at a picture of the high priest's ephod as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when would you announce or remind people of someone's family line? Why is it important to know a person's family line? Pause this audio here.

None of these people knows that Jonathan leaves the camp with his armor-bearer. Jonathan plans to cross at a pass or safe place to cross the valley. This valley separates the Israelite army at Gibeah from the Philistines at the town of Mikmash. There are cliffs or rocks on the north and south sides of the pass. People named the cliff on one side Bozez, which means shining or slippery, and they called the cliff on the other side Seneh, which means thorny. It would be hard to cross the valley by going over these cliffs instead of the pass!

Stop here and look at the drawing of the pass as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Where are some areas of land that are rough or dangerous near you? What makes these places dangerous? What do you call these places? Pause this audio here.

Now that the storyteller has described the area and people around Jonathan, he then returns to Jonathan's suggestion to look at the Philistine camp. Jonathan insults the Philistines by calling them uncircumcised. The Israelites were all circumcised as a sign of God's promise with the Israelites. The Israelites considered uncircumcised men to be very bad since those men were not part of God's promise.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do you call people who are not a part of your people group? What are some nice names? What are some names that can be insults? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan says that perhaps Yahweh will help them. Jonathan does not doubt Yahweh, but understands that Yahweh does not have to act. Perhaps Yahweh will help Jonathan and his armor-bearer now, or maybe Yahweh will help the Israelites later. Jonathan is confident that Yahweh will fight for Israel and that nothing can stop Yahweh from saving Yahweh's people. Jonathan knows that with Yahweh on their side, even a small number of men can win a victory.

Jonathan's armor-bearer shows how loyal he is in his response. Jonathan's armor-bearer agrees with whatever plan Jonathan has and is willing to do anything to help Jonathan succeed. Jonathan's armor-bearer says that his heart and soul, or all of him, is completely loyal to Jonathan.

Jonathan then explains Jonathan's plan. Jonathan says that he and his armor-bearer should come out of hiding so that the Philistines can see them. If the Philistines tell them to wait, then Jonathan and his armor-bearer will

not go near the Philistines. But if the Philistines tell the two men to come to the outpost, then this will be a sign from Yahweh. Jonathan says this sign will show that Yahweh has given the Philistines into their hands, or that Yahweh is going to help them defeat the Philistines. Jonathan trusts that Yahweh will cause the Philistines to speak these words in order to show Jonathan what to do.

Jonathan and his armor-bearer come out of hiding so the Philistine soldiers at the outpost can see them. The Philistines say, “Look! The Hebrews are crawling out of the holes they have been hiding in!” Other people groups used the word Hebrews for the Israelites. The Philistines are insulting the two Israelites by comparing them to animals crawling out of the holes they live in.

The Philistines urge Jonathan and his armor-bearer to come up to the outpost so the Philistines can teach the men a lesson. This was a way of challenging the men to fight. The Philistines want to show that they know more about fighting than the Israelites.

Since the Philistines say to come up, Jonathan knows that God will cause Jonathan to be victorious, so he and his armor-bearer go up the hill towards the outpost. The hillside is steep and difficult to climb, so Jonathan has to use his hands as well as his feet. When the two men reach the Philistines, Jonathan starts to knock down the Philistine soldiers. Then Jonathan’s armor-bearer comes along behind to where the Philistines have fallen and kills these men. The Philistines start to run away, but the two Israelites follow their enemies and kill 20 Philistines over an area of about one-quarter of a hectare. This storyteller compares this area to a field small enough to be plowed by a pair of oxen in half a day to show how small this area is.

Then the entire Philistine army begins to panic, including those who are at their camp and in the countryside. The soldiers in the outpost and raiding parties shake because they are so afraid. There is also an earthquake. In that time, people understood that an earthquake showed that God was involved in whatever was happening. This panic was from God. In the original language, people said that something was from God to mean either that God caused something to happen, or to show how big and bad something is.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Jonathan plans to go and look at the Philistine camp with his armor-bearer. Jonathan does not tell his plans to Saul, Ahijah, or the 600 Israelite soldiers who are outside Gibeah.

In the second scene: The storyteller describes the pass that Jonathan plans to cross.

In the third scene: Jonathan speaks to his armor-bearer and suggests crossing the valley. The armor-bearer agrees to do what Jonathan says. Jonathan then explains how Jonathan will know if Yahweh will help them or not.

In the fourth scene: Jonathan and his armor-bearer go towards the Philistine soldiers, who see them. The Philistines tell Jonathan and his armor-bearer to come to the outpost. Jonathan tells his armor-bearer that Yahweh will help the men defeat the Philistines.

In the fifth scene: Jonathan and his armor-bearer climb up to the outpost and kill 20 Philistines. The whole Philistine army begins to panic.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jonathan
- Jonathan’s armor-bearer
- The Philistine soldiers in the outpost, main army, and raiding groups
- Saul
- Six hundred Israelite soldiers

1 Samuel 14:1–15

- Ahijah
- Ahijah's family: Ichabod, Ahitub, Phinehas, and Eli
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story begins in the same place as the last story. The Israelite army is camped near the town of Gibeah. To the north, across a steep valley with cliffs on either side, the Philistine army is camped near the town of Mikmash. There is a safe crossing place across this valley called the Mikmash pass, and the Philistines have sent a group of soldiers to block the pass. Mikmash and Gibeah are about six kilometers apart. Jonathan and his armor-bearer are with Saul's army at Gibeah.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the towns of Mikmash and Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

In the first scene, the storyteller introduces what the story will be about. Then the storyteller gives the context and setting for the story. The storyteller says, "This story will be about the time when Jonathan shared his plan to spy on the Philistine outpost with his armor-bearer, but did not tell anyone else."

The people Jonathan did not tell his plans to are nearby. Saul, Jonathan's father, is staying or temporarily living near a pomegranate tree. This tree is near a place called Migron. It is not clear what this place is, but it may be a threshing floor, which was a flat, open space that was a good place to gather.

The 600 soldiers in the Israelite army are staying near Saul. These soldiers are near enough to protect their king, but also probably spread out so that everyone can have room. Ahijah, the priest, is near Saul as well. Though Ahijah does not do much in this story, the storyteller introduces Ahijah here so Ahijah will not be a surprise when he does act in the later stories.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story with several characters that you have to introduce to your listeners. Pay attention to when you introduce these characters. After you finish the story, discuss why you chose to introduce each character when and how you did. Pause this audio here.

Ahijah's grandfather, Eli, served as Yahweh's priest in the town of Shiloh. Ahijah is either carrying or wearing an ephod, the special clothing for the high priest. Jonathan is probably staying near Saul, too, but none of these people sees Jonathan leave the Israelite camp with his armor-bearer.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the town of Shiloh. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In what order do you list a person's family line in your language? Listen again to how your translation lists Ahijah's family line. Discuss how you will list Ahijah's family line. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the writer describes the pass that Jonathan and his armor-bearer must cross to get to the outpost. There are two cliffs or sharp rocks, one on either side of the pass. One cliff is located on the north, near Mikmash, and the other on the south, near Geba, which is probably another name for the town of Gibeah. People call the first cliff Bozez, which means slippery, and the second cliff Senah, which means thorny. This valley is rough and hard to cross, so people have to cross at the pass.

In the third scene, the storyteller has finished explaining the people and the land around Jonathan, so the storyteller now returns to Jonathan's conversation with Jonathan's armor-bearer. The storyteller repeats Jonathan's words from the beginning of the section, but now he shows the rest of the conversation.

Stop here and discuss as a group: As an activity, tell a story about something funny or interesting that happened recently. To begin, announce what the story is about, like the storyteller does here. Then explain the setting, such as the date or where you were when it happened. Next, you can explain what happened. Discuss how this is similar or different from ways that you normally tell stories. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan is speaking to his armor-bearer, and the men are somewhere where no one else can hear them. Jonathan suggests that they go over to the Philistine outpost. The two men may just see what the Philistine soldiers are doing, but if Yahweh helps the men, they may be able to do more. Jonathan knows that nothing is more powerful than Yahweh and that Yahweh will help the Israelites. Yahweh can act through a large group of soldiers, or just a few, like Jonathan and Jonathan's armor-bearer.

1 Samuel 14:1–15

Jonathan has not yet finished explaining his plan, but Jonathan's armor-bearer is so loyal that the man does not even need to hear the plan before he agrees. The armor-bearer says that Jonathan should go ahead and do what Jonathan thinks is best. The armor-bearer declares that he is ready to follow and support Jonathan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The armor-bearer says that his heart and his soul are with Jonathan. This means that the armor-bearer is completely loyal and ready to follow Jonathan. Describe a person who is completely loyal to someone else. Pay attention to the words or phrases in your language that mean someone is completely devoted or loyal to someone else. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan then explains how the men can learn if Yahweh will help them defeat the Philistines. Jonathan and his armor-bearer should go towards the Philistine outpost until the Philistine soldiers can see the two men. If the Philistines say "Wait," Jonathan and his armor-bearer will not continue climbing up to the outpost. But if Yahweh causes the Philistines to say, "Come to the outpost," then the two men will climb up. This will be how Yahweh will show that Yahweh has given the Philistines "into Jonathan's hands," or into Jonathan's power. Then Jonathan will know what to do.

In the fourth scene, Jonathan and his armor-bearer cross the pass and walk towards the outpost until the Philistines see the two men. The Philistine outpost was on the edge of the pass or on a hill nearby. The Philistines would be higher than the pass and probably could see if anyone was trying to cross it.

The Philistines point out Jonathan and his armor-bearer and speak to one another. The Philistines make fun of the Israelites and then yell out to Jonathan and his companion to come up. The Philistines are challenging Jonathan and his armor-bearer to fight, because the Philistines think they can easily beat two men. Jonathan, however, knows that this means Yahweh will help them, so Jonathan tells his armor-bearer to follow him up to the outpost.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what words or phrases do people use to challenge someone else to fight? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, Jonathan and his armor-bearer climb up to the outpost. Even though this is the safe crossing, it is still steep, and the two men have to use both their hands and feet to climb safely. When they reach the soldiers at the top of the hill, Jonathan begins to knock down the Philistine soldiers, probably using his sword. The armor-bearer follows behind Jonathan and kills the Philistines who had fallen. The armor-bearer may have his own weapon, or he may be using Jonathan's iron spear. The two men kill 20 Philistine men in the space of a quarter of a hectare. To help people understand the size of this area, the storyteller compares it to a field that a person and their ox can plow or prepare for planting in one day.

After Jonathan and the armor-bearer kill 20 men, the ground shakes in an earthquake, and the whole Philistine army begins to panic. The soldiers in the outpost nearby, as well as in the camp or out in the fields, are terrified. Even the soldiers who are far away in the raiding groups and cannot see Jonathan begin to panic and shake with fear. God has made the Philistines all afraid.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jonathan
- Jonathan's armor-bearer
- The Philistine soldiers in the outpost, main army, and raiding groups
- Saul
- Six hundred Israelite soldiers
- Ahijah

1 Samuel 14:1–15

- Ahijah's family: Ichabod, Ahitub, Phinehas, and Eli
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

One day, Saul's son Jonathan said to the soldier who carried Jonathan's weapons, "Let us cross over the pass to the Philistine camp to observe our enemy there." But Jonathan did not tell his father, Saul, what Jonathan planned to do.

At this time, Saul was camping under the pomegranate tree at Migron on the edge of Gibeah. There were about 600 men with Saul. Ahijah the priest, who was wearing the ephod, was also there. Ahijah was the son of Ichabod's brother Ahitub. Ahitub was the son of Phinehas, who was the son of Eli, who had been Yahweh's priest in the city of Shiloh. No one was aware that Jonathan and Jonathan's armor-bearer had left the Israelite camp. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am thankful that 600 of my soldiers are still with me, but I do not know how we will be able to defeat the Philistines. The Philistines have many more soldiers than we do! or
- I am not sure what to do now. Maybe God will speak to Ahijah and give me a message about how to defeat the Philistines; or
- There are so many things that I have to pay attention to. I have to make sure my soldiers can eat, make sure that more do not run away, and plan what we are going to do! I do not have time to pay attention to everything, not even where my son is right now!

Continue the drama. Jonathan and his armor-bearer planned to go through the pass at Mikmash in order to reach the Philistine outpost. On each side of the pass was a steep cliff. People called one cliff Bozez and the other cliff Seneh. The first cliff was on the north side of the pass facing Mikmash, and the other cliff was on the south side of the pass facing Geba.

Jonathan said to the young man carrying Jonathan's weapons, "Come with me across to the camp of those Philistines who do not know God. Perhaps Yahweh will help us to defeat them. Nothing can stop Yahweh from saving his people. It does not matter whether there are many soldiers fighting on our side or only a few."

Jonathan's helper replied, "Do whatever you think best. Lead the way. I will certainly support you." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the armor-bearer, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know that Jonathan is a smart man, so I trust that Jonathan will have a good plan; or
- Jonathan's trust in Yahweh encourages me to trust in Yahweh too! Yahweh will certainly help us Israelites, and Yahweh surely will protect Jonathan and me too; or
- It is my responsibility to protect and support Jonathan, and I am determined to do so, whatever Jonathan decides to do.

Continue the drama. Jonathan said to the armor-bearer, "All right, here is my plan. We will cross the valley and go toward the Philistines so that they can see us. If the Philistines tell us to stop and wait until they come to us, then we will stay right there and not continue climbing up to them. But if the Philistines tell us to go on up to where they are, then we will climb up to them. That will be how Yahweh tells us that he will help us defeat the

Philistines." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I trust that Yahweh will help the Israelites. I also trust that Yahweh will guide me to do what he wants me to do. I know that Yahweh's plans are the best plans! or
- My armor-bearer's loyalty and trust encourage me. I feel braver and safer since my armor-bearer is with me; or
- I am glad that we serve such a powerful God. By ourselves, our 600 soldiers would certainly lose against the thousands of Philistines! But Yahweh can give us victory even if it is just me and my armor-bearer.

Continue the drama. The two men walked towards the outpost so that the Philistine soldiers at the outpost could see the men. The Philistines said, "Look! The Hebrews are crawling out of the holes they have been hiding in!"

Then the outpost soldiers shouted to Jonathan and his helper, "Climb up here and we will teach you a lesson!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have seen how the Hebrews run away when they see the size of our army. I am not worried about these two men coming towards us. We will easily beat these men! or
- I am bored of sitting and guarding this pass. An easy fight will make the day more interesting; or
- Perhaps these Hebrews are giving up and will give us information about what the other Hebrews are doing. If they do, maybe we can defeat the Hebrew army faster.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I see how Jonathan is trusting in my strength to save him, instead of Jonathan's own strength. Because Jonathan trusts me, I will listen to Jonathan's request to show him what to do and help him defeat the Philistines; or
- I want to save and protect my chosen people, even if many of them are running away or their king, Saul, does not do what I tell him to; or
- I rule over everyone on earth, even the people like the Philistines who do not serve me. I will cause the Philistines to speak in a certain way.

Continue the drama. So Jonathan said to his companion, "Follow me up the hill. Yahweh is going to enable us, the Israelites, to defeat the Philistines."

Jonathan climbed up on his hands and feet, and Jonathan's companion climbed up after him. Jonathan started to knock down the Philistine soldiers. Then Jonathan's companion came along behind to where the Philistines had fallen and killed each man. In this first attack, Jonathan and his companion killed about 20 Philistine soldiers. This happened over an area of about one-quarter of a hectare.

Then the entire Philistine army began to panic, including those at the camp and those in the countryside. The soldiers in the outpost and raiding parties trembled with fear. There was an earthquake. It was God who caused all the Philistines to be terrified. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not understand how two Hebrews have killed so many of our men! If two of their soldiers fight this well, the Hebrews will not need many soldiers to defeat us! or
- Two Hebrews are defeating our larger group of soldiers, and the ground is shaking. This is not normal. A god must be helping the Hebrews! We cannot defeat a god! or
- I am more afraid than I have ever been in my life! I am so afraid that I am shaking, and I cannot think of what I should do!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jonathan explains his plan to the young man who is Jonathan's armor-bearer. An armor-bearer carries the large shield of his commanding officer and sometimes that man's other weapons, such as a sword, spear, bow, and

1 Samuel 14:1–15

arrows. An armor-bearer is responsible for protecting the commanding officer during a battle, and the two men fight together as a team.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **armor-bearer**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan wants to go towards the Philistine **outpost**. An outpost is an army camp where soldiers stay so they can guard or watch over an area. Use the same word or phrase for outpost as you used in previous passages.

Saul is staying by a pomegranate tree. These plants are large shrubs, and some may grow as tall as 10 meters. Pomegranate trees have bright green leaves and bright scarlet blossoms that grow into round red fruits people call pomegranates.

Stop here as a group and look again at a picture of a pomegranate tree as needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **pomegranate**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ahijah has the **ephod**. The ephod is a piece of clothing for priests. The ephod has lots of beautiful decorations and designs. For more information on ephod, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for ephod as you used in previous passages.

Ahijah is Eli's grandson. Eli had been **Yahweh's** priest. Yahweh is God's personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

A **priest** is a person who serves God, presenting offerings and prayers on behalf of the people. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used in previous passages.

The Mikmash **pass** has sharp cliffs on either side. A pass is a safe route through rough or dangerous ground. Use the same word or phrase for pass as you used in previous passages.

Jonathan refers to the Philistines as uncircumcised men, or men who are not circumcised. Circumcision is the Jewish custom where people cut off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis. The circumcision was a sign that the person was included in the covenant that God had made with Abraham. Jonathan is insulting the Philistines by saying that the Philistines are not included in this special covenant.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **uncircumcised**. Look up circumcision in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan trusts that Yahweh will give him a **sign**. A sign is something unusual that happens for a special reason. God can give a sign to tell people that something God tells them is true. For more information on sign, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sign as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines say, "Look at the **Hebrews**!" The word Hebrew can refer to the Israelites. People from other groups or nations often used this word. For more information on Hebrew, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Hebrew as you used in previous passages.

Jonathan says that Yahweh has let **Israel** defeat the Philistines. Israel can refer to the Israelite people as well as the country where the Israelites lived. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

The panic the Philistines feel is of **God**. This is the general word for God, or Yahweh, and can mean that God sent the panic or that it is very large and bad. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

There is also an earthquake. An earthquake is when huge groups of rocks under the ground shift and cause the ground to shake.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **earthquake**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 14:1–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (912 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 14:16–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 14:16–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:16–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

1 Samuel 14:16–23

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, King Saul's son, Jonathan, attacked the Philistine soldiers, who began to panic. In this story, the Israelite army sees the confusion in the Philistine camp. Saul begins the process to ask Yahweh for guidance, but then decides to lead the army to fight the Philistines, who had started to kill each other in their panic. Yahweh causes the Israelites to defeat the much larger group of Philistines.

This story begins when Saul's lookouts see the Philistine soldiers who are panicking. Lookouts are soldiers who guard a place by watching out for the enemy. These lookouts are at Gibeah or Geba, which may be different names for the same town in the territory of Benjamin. The lookouts can see the Philistines scattering in all directions. The storyteller compares the way the army scatters with the way ice or wax melts and spreads in the heat.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when soldiers camp somewhere, how do the soldiers keep the camp safe? Who has the role of looking out for danger? Where do these people watch from? Pause this audio here.

When Saul hears that the Philistine soldiers are scattering, Saul realizes that someone from the Israelite army must have left their camp to attack the Philistines. So Saul commands his men to gather the soldiers in order to find out who is missing. The men discover that Jonathan and the man who carries Jonathan's armor are missing.

Then Saul instructs Ahijah the priest to bring the ark of God to Saul. Saul probably wants to ask God about what is happening. The ark of God, or the ark of the covenant, is a box that people covered in gold. This box symbolizes God's presence. Some translations say that Saul instructs Ahijah to bring the ephod, or the priest's vest. However, since Ahijah is already wearing or carrying the ephod, Saul probably asks for the ark. While the ark is normally at the town of Kiriath Jearim, the ark is probably with the army during this time. The Israelites believed that if they took the ark with them into battle, then Yahweh would also go with the Israelites and give them victory.

Stop here and look at a picture of the ark of God as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when soldiers go out to fight, what kind of religious items or symbols do the soldiers bring with them? Why do the soldiers bring these items? Pause this audio here.

At the same time that Saul is speaking to Ahijah, the noisy chaos among the Philistine soldiers is getting louder. Saul then tells Ahijah to withdraw his hand. Here, "withdraw your hand" probably means something like "Stop! There is no time to do that now." It is not clear exactly what the priest is about to do. The priest may be about to use the ark and maybe the ephod to find out God's will or ask for God's favor. But the confusion has become so great that Saul believes there is no time to do this.

Saul calls all of his soldiers together and attacks the Philistine army. By this time, the Philistines are so confused that they are killing each other with their swords. In the Philistine camp, there are Hebrews who joined the Philistines before this battle, perhaps as hired soldiers. But when the Hebrews see the Philistine army scattering, the Hebrews join their fellow Israelites. The storyteller calls them "Hebrews" instead of Israelites, perhaps to show that they are different than the Israelites who normally live in the land of Israel. We also know from previous stories that there are other Israelite soldiers who had run away earlier from the Israelite army and hidden. These soldiers hear that the Philistines are scattering, so these soldiers also join the battle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how would you describe people from your people group who no longer live in your native land? How would you describe people from your people group who live with another people group that is your enemy? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller finishes the story by saying that this is how Yahweh saves the Israelites. Yahweh enables Jonathan to defeat the soldiers at the outpost, causes the Philistines to panic, and brings more soldiers to fight for the Israelites. The Philistines run away, and the Israelites continue to attack their enemies all the way to the town of Beth Aven.

1 Samuel 14:16–23

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The soldiers on guard see the chaos in the Philistine camp and they tell Saul about it. Saul gathers the soldiers to see who is missing. The men find that Jonathan and his armor-bearer are missing.

In the second scene: Saul instructs Ahijah to bring the ark of God to Saul. However, noise in the Philistine camp is getting worse, so Saul tells Ahijah to stop.

In the third scene: Saul and his soldiers go to attack the Philistines. The Hebrews who are living with the Philistines help Saul's army. The Israelites who had run away earlier also help Saul and his army. The Israelite soldiers continue to attack while the Philistine soldiers run away.

The characters in this passage are:

- The lookouts, or Israelite soldiers on guard
- The Philistine soldiers
- Saul
- Jonathan
- Jonathan's armor-bearer
- Ahijah
- The Israelite army with Saul
- The Hebrews in the Philistine camp
- The Israelite soldiers who had run away
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Saul is still camping near the town of Gibeah in Benjamin's territory with Saul's army of 600 soldiers. Saul has ordered some soldiers to stand some distance away from the camp to guard the camp and watch for any attacks.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the town of Gibeah, as well as the town of Mikmash, where the Philistines are. Pause this audio here.

These Israelite soldiers, or lookouts, are close enough to the Philistine camp to see when the Philistine soldiers start running away in terror. The Philistine soldiers look like something that is melting in warm sunlight.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you saw a large group of people or animals run away in different directions. Pay attention to the words or phrases you use to describe how the people or animals move. Pause this audio here.

The lookouts return to the Israelite camp and tell Saul what they have seen. Saul tells his soldiers to gather together so the men can check and see who has left to go and fight the enemy. The soldiers may line up in fighting groups while their leaders check to make sure everyone in the group is present. The men discover that Jonathan and Jonathan's armor-bearer are missing.

In the second scene, Saul instructs Ahijah the priest to bring the ark of God to Saul. The ark was a rectangular wooden box that people had covered in gold. The ark was normally in the town of Kiriath Jearim, but the Israelites sometimes brought the ark with them when they went out to fight. The ark was probably nearby in a safe and honorable spot in the Israelite camp.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the town of Kiriath Jearim. Pause this audio here.

However, while Saul is still talking to Ahijah, the noise and chaos of the Philistines is becoming worse and worse. The Israelites may have been able to hear the noise from their camp. Saul tells Ahijah to stop. Ahijah may have still been bringing the ark to Saul, or Ahijah may have been using the ark to ask Yahweh for guidance.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some phrases you use to tell someone to stop what they are doing because it is no longer useful or needed? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Saul and his soldiers gather together, probably in their fighting groups, and march off to fight the Philistines. When the men arrive, the Israelites see how the Philistines are so confused that they are killing other Philistines with their swords. Saul joins with Jonathan and Jonathan's armor-bearer, who are already attacking the Philistines, and they all fight the Philistines together.

There are some Hebrews who had joined the Philistines and lived in the Philistine camp. These Hebrews now join Saul and Saul's army to fight against the Philistines. There were also some Israelites who were hiding nearby in the hills of Ephraim. These Israelites are the men who had earlier run away from Saul's army. These men may have heard the noise and chaos from the camp, or someone may have told the men about the battle. These Israelites also join Saul to chase and fight the Philistines. Though the Philistine soldiers are quickly running away, the Israelite soldiers are close behind and are killing the Philistines as the Philistines run.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you chased and caught an animal or a person, such as for a game or while you were hunting. What words or phrases do you use to describe when you were close behind whatever you were chasing? Pause this audio here.

It was Yahweh who caused the Israelites to win, even though the Israelites had fewer soldiers and weapons than the Philistines. The Israelites are able to chase and kill the Philistines all the way to the town of Beth Aven, and the Israelites continue fighting throughout the hill country beyond Beth Aven. It is not clear where Beth Aven was, but it may have been a few kilometers north of Mikmash.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The lookouts, or the Israelite soldiers on guard
- The Philistine soldiers
- Saul
- Jonathan
- Jonathan's armor-bearer
- Ahijah
- The Israelite army with Saul
- The Hebrews in the Philistine camp
- The Israelite soldiers who had run away
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Back at Gibeah, in Benjamin’s territory, where Saul and Saul’s soldiers were camping, the soldiers on guard saw the Philistine soldiers running back and forth or scattering in confusion. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing lookouts, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I do not understand what is happening in the Philistine camp, so I am a little nervous. I should hurry and tell my king about what I see. Then the king can decide what to do; or
- It looks like the Philistines are running away! Maybe this is how Yahweh will save our people! or
- I know that my job as a lookout is serious because I protect my fellow soldiers in the camp. If I see anything strange or unusual, I will quickly tell the others.

Continue the drama. Then Saul said to his soldiers, “Gather our soldiers and check to see who has left us to go and fight the enemy.” The soldiers obeyed and found out that Jonathan and his armor-bearer were missing.

Then Saul instructed Ahijah the priest to bring the ark of God to Saul so that Saul could inquire of God about what was happening. The ark of God was with the Israelite army at that time. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- After Samuel left and so many of my soldiers ran away, I felt unsure what I should do. I have been waiting for some sort of sign or opportunity that will help us; or
- Maybe this is Yahweh giving us a sign. I will have Ahijah ask Yahweh, just to make sure; or
- There may be something dangerous happening in the Philistine camp, such as another people group joining the battle. I do not want to lead my soldiers into more danger.

Continue the drama. As Saul was talking to Ahijah the priest, the noise and chaos in the Philistine camp were becoming worse and worse. So Saul said to Ahijah, “Stop, there is no time to do that now.”

Saul and all his soldiers gathered for battle and marched off to fight the Philistines. The men were amazed to see that the Philistines were completely confused. The Philistine soldiers were even killing each other. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite soldiers with Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am surprised that the Philistines are killing each other like this! This is not normal! This must be our God helping us! or
- Look at how the Philistines are no longer a threat! I have been afraid of the Philistines’ big army for so long, but now I am relieved because I think we can win! or
- I am ready to attack the Philistines and get them off our land so that I can go home to my family!

Continue the drama. Earlier, some Hebrews had joined the Philistines and lived among the Philistines in their camp. Now, however, these Hebrews returned to the side of their fellow Israelites and joined Saul and Jonathan. The Israelites who had been hiding in the hills of Ephraim heard that the Philistines were running from their fellow Israelites, and they too all joined in the battle. In this way, Yahweh rescued the Israelites on that day. The Israelites continued to attack the Philistines even after they had traveled farther than Beth Aven. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hebrews in the Philistine camp, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- When the Philistines came to our land, they were so strong and had so many soldiers! I was afraid the Philistines would kill me, so I offered to serve the Philistines if they let me live; or
- I am relieved that my fellow Israelites are here to fight the Philistines! I do not want to work for the Philistines anymore! or
- I am ashamed that the other Israelites can see that I was working for the Philistines. Maybe if I fight the Philistines, the other Israelites will forgive me.

Ask the person playing the Israelite soldiers hiding in the hills of Ephraim, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- When we first saw the Philistine army, I was so afraid that I ran away and hid. There was no reason for me to fight and die if we were going to lose anyway! or
- When I heard how the Israelite army was defeating the Philistine soldiers, I was ashamed of how I ran away. I must go back and fight to make up for how I ran away; or
- I want to be a part of the battle now that we are winning! I want to be a part of the winning army, since they get honor and treasures after they win.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The Israelite lookouts see the confusion in the Philistine camp. The lookouts were soldiers in Saul’s army who had the task of watching the enemy.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **lookouts**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul and his soldiers discover that Saul’s son Jonathan and Jonathan’s **armor-bearer** are missing. An armor-bearer carries his commanding officer’s shield and weapons. An armor-bearer protects and fights alongside his commanding officer. Use the same word or phrase for armor-bearer as you used in previous passages.

Saul asks Ahijah to bring the **ark of God** or the **ark of the covenant** to Saul. This is the wooden box covered in gold that God asked the Israelites to make when they were in the desert. The box symbolized God’s presence, and the Israelites sometimes carried the ark with them when they went to fight. For more information on the ark of the covenant, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for “ark of the covenant” or “ark of God” as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the ark of God as needed. Pause this audio here.

The word **God** in “the ark of God” is the general word for God. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

Ahijah is a **priest**. A priest is a person who serves God, presenting offerings and prayers on behalf of the people. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines are killing each other with their **swords**. Use the same word or phrase for swords as you used in previous passages.

There were some **Hebrews** in the Philistine camp. The word Hebrew can refer to the descendants of Abraham. Sometimes, people used this word for Israelites who did not live in the land of Israel. For more information on Hebrew, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Hebrew as you used in previous passages. Be sure to use different terms for Hebrews and **Israelites** throughout this passage. For more information about Israelites, see the Master Glossary.

Yahweh caused the Israelites to defeat the Philistines. Yahweh is God’s personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 14:16–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (955 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 14:24–35

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 14:24–35 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:24–35 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story takes place during the battle from the last story. At the beginning of the battle, Saul makes all his soldiers promise not to eat anything until the end of the day, when the soldiers have defeated the Philistines. Jonathan does not know about the promise and eats some honey. At the end of the day, the Israelite soldiers

are so hungry that they begin to eat meat in a way that Yahweh had told them not to. Saul stops the soldiers who are disobeying Yahweh and builds an altar.

In this story, the storyteller explains why the Israelite soldiers were hard-pressed or exhausted during the battle. Before the battle, Saul made his soldiers swear an oath or a very solemn promise that they would not eat any food. Saul wanted to get revenge on the Philistines by sunset. Saul cursed, or wished bad things to happen, to any soldier who ate before sunset.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time someone cursed someone else. How do people curse each other? What are the effects of these curses? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller does not include why Saul cursed the soldiers. Probably Saul hoped to get God's help to make sure the Israelites defeated the Philistines. In this time, people often fasted, or did not eat, in order to prepare themselves before they asked God for something. People often did this before a battle, but not often during the battle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when are some times when people choose to stop doing normal actions, like eating, before doing something important or special? Why do people do this? Pause this audio here.

So during the day of the battle, none of the Israelite soldiers ate any food. Some time during the battle, the Israelite army is in a forest or an area with trees. There, the soldiers find some honey on the ground. Bees make honey, a sweet liquid, and store it in honeycombs, which are the nests the bees make out of wax. Bees usually make their nests in a high place, like on a tree branch. Apparently, there was so much honey in this bee's nest that it was dropping out of the honeycomb onto the ground.

Stop here and look at a picture of honey, a honeycomb, or a bee's nest, as a group. Pause this audio here.

Because the Israelite soldiers fear the curse of Saul's oath, the soldiers do not eat any of the honey. However, Jonathan has not heard about the oath. Jonathan dips his staff, or wooden stick, into the honey and eats some of the honey. The storyteller says Jonathan's eyes brightened, which means that Jonathan feels stronger and more alert.

Then one of the Israelite soldiers tells Jonathan about the strict oath. The soldier says that because of the oath, none of the soldiers has eaten, so the soldiers feel weak. Jonathan says that his father, Saul, has made trouble for their country. Jonathan means that Saul has made it more difficult for the Israelite army to defeat the Philistines. Jonathan says it would have been better if the soldiers had eaten some of the spoils or plunder. Spoil is anything that people take from an enemy they defeat, and in this case, Jonathan means food. Jonathan asks if eating some food would have caused the Israelites to kill more Philistines. This is not a question that Jonathan expects anyone to answer. Jonathan is emphasizing that Israelite soldiers would have been able to kill more Philistines if the soldiers had eaten something, which would have made the Israelites feel stronger.

The Israelites chase the Philistines from the town of Mikmash to the town of Aijalon, and strike down or kill many of the Philistines by the end of the day. The Israelites take sheep, cattle, and calves as spoil from the Philistines. These are all farm animals that are good for eating. Because the men have not eaten all day, the Israelites are exhausted. Now that it is evening time and they have defeated the Philistines, the Israelite soldiers are in a hurry to eat quickly, and the soldiers do not prepare the meat properly. The Israelite soldiers kill the animals immediately at the spot where they took the animals. However, the soldiers do not drain the blood out of the meat like Yahweh told them to. The soldiers eat the meat together with the blood.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sheep, cow, and calf as a group. Pause this audio here.

Someone tells Saul that the soldiers are sinning against Yahweh, or disobeying Yahweh's law by eating meat with the blood still in it. So Saul calls the soldiers unfaithful or traitors against Yahweh. Saul orders some soldiers to roll a big stone over to Saul immediately. Saul tells his officers to order their soldiers to kill the animals on the stone. Then the blood will drain from the animals and flow onto the stone and down to the ground. The men can then eat their meat. Saul says that the men must not sin against Yahweh by eating meat with blood still in the meat.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people think or believe about eating meat with blood in it? What are some foods or ways of eating foods that are wrong or not acceptable in your culture? Why should people not eat those foods in that way? Pause this audio here.

So everyone does as Saul instructs and brings the animals to the stone. Though the storyteller just mentions the cattle, the storyteller means both the cattle and the sheep. The men kill their animals on the stone. In this way, Saul makes an altar to Yahweh, or to honor Yahweh. The animals that the people kill there might be like a sacrifice to Yahweh. In any case, this altar is a place where people honor Yahweh by following Yahweh's laws. This is the first time Saul has made an altar.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do altars look like? Who usually makes the altars? What are some special or important times when people would make an altar? Why do people make altars at those times?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Before the battle, Saul commands the Israelite soldiers to swear that they will eat nothing during the daytime until Saul gets his revenge on the Philistines. So throughout the day, the Israelite soldiers are very weak and exhausted because no one eats anything.

In the second scene: During the battle, the Israelite army enters a forest. When the men find honey on the ground, the men do not eat the honey. Jonathan does not know about the promise Saul made the soldiers swear, so Jonathan eats some honey and feels stronger. When the soldiers tell Jonathan about the serious oath, Jonathan says that Saul has caused trouble for the Israelite soldiers.

In the third scene: All day, the Israelite soldiers continue to chase the Philistines, from the town of Mikmash to the town of Aijalon.

In the fourth scene: The Israelites have defeated the Philistines by the end of the day. The soldiers are so hungry that they begin to kill and eat the animals without preparing the animals in the way Yahweh said to do.

In the fifth scene: Someone tells Saul what the soldiers are doing. Saul instructs the soldiers to set up a stone where they can properly kill and prepare the meat. This way, the men do not sin against Yahweh.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelite soldiers
- Saul
- The Philistine soldiers
- Jonathan
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the last story, the storyteller said that Yahweh caused the Israelites to defeat the Philistines. Now, in this story, the storyteller will describe some events that happened during the day of the battle.

Scene one probably begins before the Israelite soldiers attack the Philistine soldiers. The Israelite army may still be at their camp, or the soldiers may be outside the Philistine camp. Jonathan is probably not with the main group of soldiers. Saul orders the Israelite soldiers to swear an oath that they will not eat any food before the evening. No one is allowed to eat any food until Saul has taken revenge on his enemies. If anyone does eat, then those people will be under a curse. This is why the soldiers are weak from hunger during the day of the battle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people swear oaths? What do people say or do to show that this is a very serious promise? Pause this audio here.

Scene two happens during the battle. While the Israelites are chasing and killing the Philistines, the Israelites enter a forest or an area with many trees. The Israelites see honey on the ground. There is probably a bees' nest in a nearby tree, and there is so much honey inside that the honey is dripping out. Though the soldiers see the honey, no Israelite soldier eats any of the honey, because of the oath that the men swore.

However, Jonathan has not heard about the oath, so he dips the end of his staff or walking stick into the honey. Jonathan then scoops the honey off the end and eats it. Because Jonathan eats some sweet honey, Jonathan's eyes brighten, and Jonathan feels stronger and more alert.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you had not eaten for a long time, then had some good food. Think about how each part of your body felt after you ate. What are some words or phrases you would use in your language to describe how the food made your body feel stronger or better? Discuss what phrase you want to use in your translation to describe how Jonathan felt stronger and more alert. Pause this audio here.

One of the soldiers says to Jonathan, "Your father made us swear a very solemn oath not to eat, which is why we are all weak with hunger." Jonathan replies that his father has made it more difficult for the Israelite army to defeat the Philistine army.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss how in your culture a soldier would refer to the king when speaking to the king's son. Discuss how the son of a king would speak of his father when talking with one of the king's soldiers. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Imagine a situation where you have not eaten for a long time, and you are very hungry. How do you talk about being weak from hunger? How will you translate that the Israelite soldiers were weak from hunger? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan wishes that the soldiers had eaten the food left behind by the Philistines. The Israelites had probably already chased the Philistines out of their camp, so everything in the Philistine camp now belonged to the Israelites. This included food supplies, and Jonathan wishes that the Israelites had stopped and eaten some of the food. Jonathan says that if the Israelite soldiers had done that, then the soldiers would have been able to kill many more of the Philistines.

In the third scene, the Israelites continue to chase and kill the Philistines all the way from Mikmash to the town of Aijalon, which is 25 kilometers away. Since no one has eaten any food, the soldiers are very exhausted and weary.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel as a group. Find the towns of Mikmash and Aijalon. Pause this audio here.

The fourth scene begins at the end of the day. Now it is evening, and the Israelites have defeated the Philistines. The oath is completed, so the Israelites can eat again. The Israelites probably have returned to the Philistine camp to gather the spoil or plunder. The men are so hungry that they rush towards the sheep, cattle, and calves, and the men immediately kill the animals. However, the men do not drain the blood out of the meat. The men probably cook the meat and begin to eat it.

The fifth scene begins when someone, probably one of the soldiers, tells Saul to look at the soldiers. Saul is probably not near the soldiers who are eating, so Saul cannot see what the men are doing. This person says that because the men are eating the meat with blood, the soldiers are sinning against Yahweh. Saul agrees and calls out to those soldiers who are eating. Saul says, "You are unfaithful to Yahweh!" Saul is telling the men that their actions are wrong because the men have not faithfully followed Yahweh's laws.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, pretend you are talking to someone you work with who has not followed your boss or leader's instructions. What words or phrases would you use to tell that person that they are doing something wrong or against the rules? Pause this audio here.

Saul orders some of his soldiers to roll a large stone over towards Saul. Once the men do this, Saul speaks to his officers, or the leaders of the smaller groups of men. Saul instructs these officers to go among their soldiers and order their soldiers to kill their animals on the large stone. When the men do, the blood will drain off the

meat onto the stone. Then the soldiers can eat the meat because there will be no more blood in the animals. Saul commands the soldiers not to sin against Yahweh by eating the meat with blood in it.

So, that night, all the soldiers bring their animals over to the stone and kill the animals there. This stone is an altar. Because Saul instructed his soldiers to set up the stone, the storyteller says that Saul built this altar. This is the first time that Saul has done this.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelite soldiers
- Saul
- The Philistine soldiers
- Jonathan
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

During the battle, the Israelite soldiers were weak from hunger because Saul had made the men swear an oath. Saul said, “May God curse any of you who eats anything at all before evening. No one is allowed to eat any food until I have taken revenge on my enemies.” So none of the soldiers ate anything that day. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so determined to get revenge on the Philistines. I want my soldiers to be just as determined. I do not want the soldiers to think about anything else, even food! or
- I am worried that my soldiers will see the food and other supplies in the Philistine camp and become distracted. The soldiers may leave the battle to go and eat. I will order the men to swear this oath so that they will not stop fighting; or
- I have heard that people sometimes do not eat to honor Yahweh, and then Yahweh helps them. I will make sure no one in my army eats, then Yahweh will definitely help us.

Ask the person playing the Israelite soldiers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am worried. I know that when I fight, I will become exhausted. If the battle lasts all day, I do not know if I will be strong enough to keep fighting if I do not eat! Someone may kill me if I am not strong enough! or
- I do not like this oath, but I must obey my king, so I will swear just like the others are doing; or
- I do not understand how this oath will help us win the battle. Why would our king want us not to eat?

Continue the drama. All the Israelite soldiers went into an area with trees where there was honey lying on the ground. As the soldiers went by the trees, the men saw the honey dripping down from the honeycomb. However, none of the men ate any of the honey because they were all afraid of Saul's curse.

But Jonathan was not there when his father made the soldiers swear an oath not to eat, so Jonathan did not know about it. So when Jonathan saw the honey, Jonathan reached out the end of the staff that he was carrying and dipped it into the honeycomb. Jonathan ate some honey, and he felt stronger and more alert.

Then one of the men in the army said, "Your father, Saul, made us swear a severe oath not to eat anything. Saul cursed anyone who ate anything today, so we have not eaten anything today, which is why we are weak." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite soldier who speaks to Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am scared for Jonathan! I do not want Saul's curse to come to Jonathan! or
- Oh no! Jonathan was not with us when we swore the oath, so Jonathan does not know about the curse! I wonder if the curse will affect Jonathan, since he did not swear with us; or
- I can see how Jonathan looks stronger after eating. I wish we could eat too. I am so hungry and tired!

Continue the drama. Jonathan replied, "My father has caused trouble for the people of Israel. You can easily see how I regained strength when I ate just a little honey. It would have been much better if you had eaten some of the food we took from our enemies, the Philistines! Then you would have had the strength to kill even more of the Philistines." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not understand why my father would make the people swear this oath. Everyone knows that people need food to stay strong! or
- I am angry that my father would order the people to swear this oath so that he can get revenge. If our soldiers are weak, the men may die in battle. Saul's oath is harming our soldiers! or
- I feel so much stronger and more alert after eating. I feel ready to chase the Philistines all day. I wish everyone in the army could feel this way!

Continue the drama. That day, the Israelites defeated the Philistines and pursued them from Mikmash all the way to Aijalon. Afterwards, the Israelites were weak from hunger since they had not eaten that day. So the men rushed to the animals they had taken away from the Philistines, and killed the animals right there on the ground. The men began to eat the meat with the blood still in it. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so hungry and exhausted that I cannot think about anything but eating food right now! I do not want to move much or do much work before I eat; or
- Look at all the good things the Philistines left in their camp! Here are all the animals and possessions that the Philistines stole from the Israelites, as well as all the supplies they brought with them. I will have many good things to take back to my family!

Continue the drama. Then one of Saul's men said to Saul, "Look! The men are sinning against Yahweh because they are eating meat that still has blood in it."

Saul cried out to his soldiers, "You have been unfaithful to Yahweh! Roll a large stone over here at once."

Then Saul said to his officers, "Go and tell the men to bring their cattle and sheep here to kill them properly. Then the men can eat the meat. The men must not sin against Yahweh by eating the meat that still has blood in it." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am worried that my men were not following Yahweh's law. I do not understand why the men forgot to drain the blood, since they would normally do that at home; or
- I do not want Yahweh to be angry with us. I already disobeyed Yahweh earlier, so I cannot allow anyone to do anything that would cause Yahweh to stop helping us; or
- There are so many things that I must focus on as a king, so I did not even notice what my soldiers were doing!

1 Samuel 14:24–35

Continue the drama. So the men all did as Saul instructed them to do. In this way, Saul made an altar to honor Yahweh. This was the first time that Saul did this.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Saul makes his soldiers swear an oath. When people make a promise to each other, they can swear an oath to make the promise more serious. When someone swears an oath, the person says, "I will absolutely keep my promise. If I do not, God may punish me."

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **oath**. Look up oath in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul **curses** anyone who does not keep the oath. When you curse someone, you wish that something bad will happen to that person. People believed that a curse would come true. For more information on curse, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for curse as you used in previous passages.

Saul says that no one may eat until Saul avenges himself or takes revenge on his enemy. To avenge yourself means to harm someone because of the way that person first harmed you. Saul wants the Israelite soldiers to harm the Philistines because the Philistines harmed the Israelites as their enemies.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **avenge**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **Israelites** are very weak from hunger. Use the same word or phrase for Israelites as you have used previously. See the Master Glossary for more information about Israelites.

The soldiers find honey in a forest. Honey is a sweet liquid that small, flying insects called bees make. Bees make a nest called a honeycomb out of wax, where the bees make and store honey. Honey was a precious and valuable food to the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **honey** and **honeycomb**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan wishes the soldiers had eaten some of the spoil or plunder. Spoil is anything that a winning army takes from its defeated enemy after the battle. Here, Jonathan is specifically referring to the food that the Israelites took from the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **spoil** or **plunder**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Someone tells Saul that the soldiers are sinning against Yahweh. **Sin** is an act of rebellion against Yahweh. Anytime that a person disobeys Yahweh's laws, that person sins. Here, the Israelite soldiers are disobeying Yahweh's command not to eat meat with blood in it. For more information on sin, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh is God's personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Saul tells his men to set up a stone as an **altar**. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. An altar is like a table or a platform that people make of earth or large stones. This altar seems to be a place where people can drain blood from meat so they can honor Yahweh by following Yahweh's law. For more information on altar, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for altar as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word
Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 14:24–35

Audio Content
- Hear and Heart (956 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 14:36–46

Hear and Heart
In this step, hear 1 Samuel 14:36–46 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:36–46 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage
Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:36–46 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Saul made his soldiers promise not to eat anything during the day while they fought the Philistines. In this story, it is now evening, and Saul wants to keep chasing the Philistines. However, when God does not respond to Saul's questions about whether he should chase the Philistines, Saul thinks this must be because one of the Israelites has sinned. Saul discovers that Jonathan broke the promise by eating, but the other Israelite soldiers rescue Jonathan from Saul's punishment.

This story probably begins right after the last story finishes. Now that the Israelites have eaten, Saul wants to continue to chase after the Philistine soldiers. Saul says that the Israelites should all plunder the Philistines. Normally, this means that the men should take the Philistines' belongings, but here, Saul also means to keep fighting the Philistines. Saul wants to chase the Philistines all night until sunrise and kill everyone in the Philistine army. This way, the Philistines will not be able to attack the Israelites again for a very long time.

The soldiers agree to Saul's instructions, but the priest, probably Ahijah, insists that the men should ask God before doing anything. So Saul asks God if the Israelites should chase after the Philistines. Saul asks if God will give the Philistines into the Israelites' hands. In the original language, people used the word "hand" to mean power or control. Saul is asking if the Israelites will continue to win against the Philistines. Saul is probably not praying directly to God, but asking through another method, such as using the Urim and Thummim in the priest's ephod.

Stop here and look at a photo of the ephod with its pouch as a group. Pause this audio here.

When God does not respond, Saul assumes that this is because someone has sinned. The Israelites knew that their sin always separated them from God. So when God was silent, the Israelites knew it was probably because someone had sinned. However, Saul does not know who that person is or what the person has done. Saul tells all the leaders in his army to gather together so they can find out who sinned or disobeyed God. Saul says that the men must kill whoever has sinned. Saul gives a strong promise to do this. Certainly, Yahweh, who rescues Israel, lives, and just as certainly, Saul will do what Saul promises.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone knew they had upset or offended someone else, not because the other person said so, but because the other person was silent. Talk about what the first person did to try to fix the situation so that the other person would talk to the first person again. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Saul promises very strongly that he will do what he says. In your culture, how do people show that they will absolutely do what they say they will? Pause this audio here.

Some of Saul's soldiers know that Jonathan has broken the solemn oath from the last story by eating the honey, but none of the soldiers wants to tell Saul. Saul tells his soldiers to stand in one group while Saul and his son, Jonathan, stand separate from them. Saul's soldiers agree and do so. Then Saul prays to Yahweh and respectfully asks Yahweh why he has not answered Saul. Since Saul believes Yahweh has not answered because someone has sinned, Saul asks Yahweh to show the men who has sinned.

Saul asks Yahweh to show the men through casting lots, which was a way people asked what Yahweh wanted. There were several ways to do this, so it is not clear exactly what the men did here. People often shook stones with symbols in a small container in such a way as to cast or shake out a stone. This stone could have either the word "Yes" or "No" on it as an answer to their question. Yahweh would cause the stone with Yahweh's answer to come out.

The priests of Israel had two stones, one they called Urim and one called Thummim. These two stones may have been different in color, one white and one black. A priest may have pulled these stones out of the ephod pouch in order to determine by lot Yahweh's choice between two different options.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people ask a god for guidance? Who can speak to the god? Pause this audio here.

Saul asks Yahweh to choose the Urim stone if Saul or Jonathan is guilty or has sinned. If the other Israelites have sinned, then Saul asks Yahweh to choose the Thummim stone. Yahweh chooses the Urim, showing that Jonathan or Saul is guilty of doing this sin and that the other Israelites are not guilty. Saul then asks Yahweh to show the

men if it was Jonathan or Saul who was guilty. Saul probably assigns one stone to Jonathan and one to himself. Yahweh chooses the stone that shows that Jonathan has sinned.

When Saul asks Jonathan what Jonathan has done, Jonathan explains that he ate some honey off his staff. Though eating honey was not a sin, Jonathan sinned because he ate food even though Saul had ordered the men to swear an oath not to eat. Breaking a solemn oath with Yahweh's name is a sin, even if Jonathan did not know about the oath. Jonathan accepts Saul's punishment of death. Since Saul promised earlier that Saul would order his men to kill whoever sinned, Saul swears another oath, or strong promise, that Jonathan will die. Saul calls on God to punish Saul with death or worse if Saul does not keep his oath.

The soldiers do not think that this is a fair punishment. The soldiers ask if Jonathan, the man who saved Israel, should die. The soldiers are not expecting Saul to reply to their question. The soldiers are saying that it does not make sense to kill the man who saved them. The soldiers say, "This must never happen!" which means that the soldiers will not agree to kill Jonathan. The soldiers also swear an oath and say that Yahweh certainly lives and, just as certainly, the soldiers will not let a hair fall off Jonathan. The soldiers mean that the soldiers will not let Saul punish Jonathan in any way, because God helped Jonathan save the Israelites.

So the Israelite soldiers ransom Jonathan, and no one kills Jonathan. To ransom someone means to make a substitute payment for someone or something. The people offered something else to Yahweh in place of Jonathan. Perhaps the men gave money, or perhaps the men provided an animal to die instead.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The soldiers save Jonathan, but the soldiers must pay the price or punishment for the sin. Tell a story about a time when someone did something wrong. Tell how another person gave that person a punishment, such as to pay back the money or do extra work. Then tell how someone else helped the person who did wrong by paying the money or doing the work instead. Pause this audio here.

Saul stops chasing after the rest of the Philistine soldiers, who are able to escape back to their own land. Because of his oath, Saul had to stop chasing the Philistine soldiers to see who broke the oath. Then Saul could not chase the Philistines and kill as many of them, just like Jonathan said in the last section. The human King Saul, even though he spoke a curse, could not keep the curse because Saul's own soldiers would not allow it. This shows how Saul sometimes acted unwisely as a leader when Saul made strong promises to God. Saul made these promises to try to make God like Saul more. But Saul could not keep these promises.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:36–46 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Saul says that the Israelites should continue to chase after the Philistines. The soldiers agree, but the priest says that the men should ask God first.

In the second scene: Saul asks God if the men should chase the Philistines, but God does not answer Saul.

In the third scene: Saul gathers his officers and says that whoever has sinned must die. Saul orders his soldiers to stand apart from Saul and Jonathan. Saul asks Yahweh to show the men who has sinned. Yahweh shows through the lot that Jonathan has sinned.

In the fourth scene: Saul asks Jonathan what Jonathan did, and Jonathan explains that Jonathan ate some honey. Saul declares that Jonathan must die. The Israelite soldiers say that they will not let anyone hurt Jonathan, and so the soldiers rescue Jonathan.

In the fifth scene: Saul does not continue to chase the Philistine soldiers, who return to their homes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The Philistine soldiers

- The Israelite soldiers
- The priest, probably Ahijah
- God, whose personal name is Yahweh
- The Israelite officers
- And Jonathan

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The first scene probably begins right after the end of the last story. It is evening time, and the Israelites have stopped chasing the Philistine soldiers to eat. Now that the Israelites have finished eating, Saul speaks to his soldiers. Saul orders his soldiers to go with Saul to attack the Philistines all night long and kill all of the Philistine soldiers. Saul's soldiers agree to do what Saul says. But the priest insists that the men should ask God before the men do anything. This priest is probably Ahijah, since the storyteller said earlier that Ahijah was with the Israelite army.

So in the second scene, Saul asks God what to do. The storyteller does not describe how Saul does this, but Saul may have asked the priest to use the ephod or the Urim and Thummim in the ephod pouch to speak to God. Saul asks if Saul, along with Saul's soldiers, should chase the Philistines. Saul wants to know if God will cause the Israelites to win. Saul may wait some time for a reply, but God does not respond to Saul that day. This shows that someone has sinned against God.

In the third scene, Saul tells his officers to come together and that together the men all must discover who has sinned. Saul swears an oath that whoever has sinned will definitely die. This means that Saul will order someone to kill that person. Saul will do this even if the person is Saul's son, Jonathan. At least some of the men know that Jonathan has sinned because Jonathan ate that day, even though Saul had threatened that anyone who ate that day should die. However, none of the men tells Saul what Jonathan did.

Then Saul tells his soldiers to stand in a group together, while Saul and Jonathan stand apart as a second group. The soldiers agree, and the men all do what Saul said. Then Saul prays to Yahweh respectfully. Saul says God's name and emphasizes that Yahweh is the God of Israel. Saul asks Yahweh why Yahweh has not answered Saul's question. Saul asks Yahweh to show the men who is guilty by choosing a stone when the men cast the lots. If Saul and Jonathan are guilty, Saul asks Yahweh to show this by choosing the Urim stone. If the other soldiers are guilty, Saul asks Yahweh to show this by choosing the Thummim stone.

The priest probably casts the lots by reaching into a pouch for a stone or by shaking the pouch in such a way that only one stone falls out. Yahweh causes the priest to get the Urim stone, which shows that the guilty person is in Saul and Jonathan's group. Then Saul says to choose the lot again between Saul and Jonathan, so the priest casts the lots. The storyteller shortens this part and does not explain which stone represented which man, since the listeners would know how this process works. The priest casts the lots again and gets the stone that shows it was Jonathan who sinned.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story where you do the same action with several steps many times. Pay attention to when you describe all the steps of the action and when you choose to shorten your description and leave out steps of the action. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, Saul asks Jonathan what happened, and Jonathan explains how he ate the honey. Jonathan then says that Jonathan must die, but we are not sure how Jonathan says this. It is possible that Jonathan protests the punishment or asks a question. Most likely, Jonathan accepts Saul's punishment of death for what Jonathan did. Saul then swears another oath, this time that Saul will kill Jonathan. Saul calls on God to punish Saul with death if Saul does not keep the oath.

However, Saul's soldiers strongly say that Jonathan must not die for Jonathan's sin. Jonathan rescued the Israelites from their enemies because God helped Jonathan do so. The Israelites could see that God was with Jonathan that day. So the soldiers also swear by Yahweh that they will not let anyone punish or harm Jonathan in the smallest way. No one will even cut or cause a piece of hair on Jonathan's head to fall to the ground.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who completely protects someone else, such as the way a parent protects a child. Pay attention to the words or phrases you use to describe the

1 Samuel 14:36–46

way that this person is completely safe. How will you talk about the way the people say that not even a piece of Jonathan's hair will fall to the ground? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Both the soldiers and Saul say that Yahweh surely lives, and just as surely, the men will do something too. What are some words or phrases in your language that people say to promise or show that they will definitely do a certain thing? Pause this audio here.

So the men ransom or redeem Jonathan. The men may pay some money or give an animal to die instead of Jonathan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about the story you told in the last step, where someone gave something like money to save someone else from punishment. What words or phrases would you use to describe how that person helped? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, Saul does not order the Israelites to continue chasing like Saul had planned. The Philistine soldiers who are still alive return to their home country.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:36–46 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The Philistine soldiers
- The Israelite soldiers
- The priest, probably Ahijah
- God, whose personal name is Yahweh
- The Israelite officers
- And Jonathan

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Then Saul said, "Let us chase the Philistines tonight, take their belongings all night long, and kill every one of the Philistines!"

"Yes," the Israelite soldiers replied, "that is a great plan!"

But the priest said, "First, we must ask God and see if this is what God wants us to do." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Even though we have a king, God is still our top leader. I must remind the people of that; or

- I am worried because Saul does not remember to ask God before he makes his plans. The last time that Saul did not do what God wanted, Samuel left our army; or
- I want the Israelites to be safe. If God does not want us to continue to chase the Philistines, the Philistines may defeat and kill our soldiers. We should ask God before we do this.

Continue the drama. So Saul asked God, "Shall I lead my army to chase the Philistines? Will you allow us to destroy the Philistines?"

But God did not answer Saul's question that day.

So Saul said to Saul's army officers, "Someone must have sinned, and that is why God is not answering. Come here. We need to discover how one of us has sinned today. As surely as Yahweh who delivers Israel lives, so surely do I promise that the person who has committed this sin must die, even if that person is my son Jonathan!"

But no one at all told Saul what Jonathan had done. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I thought that we killed so many Philistines because God wants us to and is helping us. I do not understand why God would not answer my question; or
- I am angry that someone has sinned. Now we have to stop and discover who has sinned, while the Philistines are escaping; or
- I want to be a fair king, so I will punish whoever sinned, even if it is my son Jonathan.

Ask the person playing Saul's officers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know that Jonathan broke the oath, but I did not say anything, because I am worried the king will be angry with me for not telling him earlier; or
- I do not want Jonathan to die. Perhaps Jonathan did not really break the oath, because Jonathan did not know about the oath. Maybe someone else has sinned; or
- I wish Saul had not sworn all these oaths, because I do not think that was wise. First, we were hungry during the battle, and now Saul's son is in danger of death. I am not sure what the right thing to do is now, so I will not say anything.

Continue the drama. Then Saul gave this command to the Israelite soldiers: "You all stand over there, and Jonathan and I will stand here."

And the men replied, "We will do whatever you say."

Then Saul prayed, "Yahweh, God of our people Israel, why have you not answered me today? Yahweh, God whom we worship, if Jonathan or I are guilty, then answer by the Urim stone, but if your people Israel have sinned, then answer by the Thummim stone."

The priest chose the Urim, showing that Jonathan or Saul was guilty and the soldiers were innocent.

Then Saul said, "Now decide by drawing lots whether my son Jonathan is the guilty one or if I am."

The priest did so, and it was Jonathan who was at fault.

Then Saul said to Jonathan, "What have you done?"

So Jonathan said to Saul, "Indeed, I did taste a little honey which I dipped with the end of my staff. I stand before you willing to die."

Saul answered, "If I do not have you put to death, Jonathan, then may God strike me dead!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I think my father's oath was not a good one, but I understand that I disobeyed it. I will not try to make excuses; or
- I wish that my father had not made his soldiers promise this oath. I am frustrated that our soldiers were weak yesterday, and now we have to stop chasing the Philistines; or
- I am surprised that my father swore another oath that I must die. My father looks like he is not even sad that I am going to die!

1 Samuel 14:36–46

Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am embarrassed that it is my own son who has caused us to stop chasing the Philistines. I do not even know what my son is doing most of the time! or
- I am very sad that it is my son who has sinned! I do not want to order my soldiers to kill my son, but I cannot break my promise; or
- I must show that I am a fair king, or the people will not trust me. I will swear another oath to show that I will not break the rules for some people, even people I care about.

Continue the drama. But the soldiers said to Saul, “No one shall kill Jonathan. Jonathan is the one who has rescued us, the Israelites, from our enemies. We swear by the living Yahweh that we will not allow anyone to punish Jonathan in the slightest way, for Jonathan was able to save Israel from the Philistines today because God helped Jonathan.”

So no one killed Jonathan because the men redeemed Jonathan’s life. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelite soldiers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Jonathan just saved our people! It is not fair if Jonathan must die now! or
- I understand that we cannot break promises, but our God has shown us ways to ransom or pay a substitute in some situations. Maybe we can do the same here to save Jonathan; or
- God helped Jonathan but did not speak to Saul. Maybe Saul should not have commanded us to promise the oath that Jonathan accidentally broke.

Continue the drama. After that, Saul and Saul’s soldiers stopped chasing the Philistines, and the Philistine soldiers returned to their own country.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:36–46 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Saul says that the Israelites should chase after and plunder the Philistines. To plunder means to take belongings like food and weapons from a defeated enemy. Here, Saul probably means to kill the Philistines and take the Philistines’ belongings.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **plunder**, the action people do when they take the belongings of the enemies they conquer. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **priest** instructs Saul to ask God for guidance first. A priest is a person who serves God and presents offerings and prayers on behalf of the people. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used in previous passages.

The priest says to ask **God** first. This is the general word for God, or Yahweh. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

Saul asks if God will cause **Israel** to continue to win the battle with the Philistines. Israel can refer to the Israelite people as well as the country where the Israelites lived. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

Because God does not answer Saul, Saul tries to figure out who has sinned against God. **Sin** is an act of rebellion against Yahweh. Anytime a person disobeys Yahweh’s laws, that person sins. For more information on sin, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you used in previous passages.

Saul swears a solemn **oath** with **Yahweh’s** name. Yahweh is God’s personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. Although the word “oath” does not appear in the original language in this story, you may use oath if needed for clarity in your translation. If needed, look up oath in the Master Glossary and use the same word or phrase that you used in the previous passages.

1 Samuel 14:36–46

Saul **prays** to Yahweh and asks Yahweh to show who has sinned. When someone prays, that person is communicating with God. For more information on pray, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for pray as you used in previous passages.

Saul calls himself Yahweh's **servant**. A servant is a man or a woman who works for another person. Here, servant is a humble way to refer to yourself. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages.

Saul asks God to choose the Urim if the Israelites have sinned and the Thummim if Saul or Jonathan has sinned. We are not exactly sure what these looked like, but the Urim and Thummim were probably two special stones. The Urim and Thummim may have been different colors, one white and one black. Priests may have picked one out of the ephod by lot to determine God's choice of two different options.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Urim and Thummim** and for **casting lots**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan says that he ate a little **honey** off his staff. Honey is a sweet liquid that small flying insects, called bees, make. Use the same word or phrase for honey as you used in previous passages.

The soldiers ransom Jonathan. When someone is a prisoner, another person can buy that person free or ransom the person. The soldiers may have paid money or given animals to kill instead of Jonathan.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **ransom**. Look up ransom in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 14:36–46

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (961 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.6 MB)

- Embodying the Text (4.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 14:47–52

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 14:47–52 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:47–52 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:47–52 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story is a summary of Saul's time as king. While Saul is king, Saul fights bravely and defeats many of the Israelites' enemies. The storyteller gives the names and relationships of some important members of Saul's family. Because the Israelites and the Philistines often fought during Saul's life, Saul often added more soldiers to his army.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are some important things that a king or leader does? What do people choose to remember or talk about when a leader dies or finishes ruling? Pause this audio here.

This story begins after the battle with the Philistines. Even though the people had earlier declared Saul to be king, it was through the battle with the Philistines that Saul secured his authority as king. People were not challenging Saul or saying that Saul should not be king.

Then Saul leads the Israelite soldiers to fight against the Israelites' enemies, who live in the lands around Israel. Saul and his army fight against the people of Moab, Ammon, and Edom. The Israelites also fight the kings of Zobah and their people, as well as the Philistines. Saul leads the Israelites to win these battles against these nations.

Saul fights valiantly or bravely and leads the Israelite army to defeat the Amalekites as well. Before this, the Amalekite people, as well as others, had plundered the Israelites, which means they attacked the Israelites to take the Israelites' possessions. But now Saul saves the Israelites from the hand of their enemies. In the original language, people used the word hand to mean power or control, so Saul saves the Israelites from the power of the enemies.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time in your people's history when an enemy invaded and stole your people's belongings. How did your people eventually stop or defeat that enemy? Who led the people to defeat the enemy? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller lists some of Saul's family members. Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malki-Shua are Saul's sons. Ishvi is probably another name for Ishbosheth, who shows up in a later story. Merab and Michal are Saul's daughters. Merab is older than Michal. Saul's wife's name is Ahinoam, and Ahinoam's father's name is Ahimaaz.

The commander or leader of Saul's army is Saul's cousin, Abner. Saul's father, Kish and Abner's father, Ner, are brothers. Kish and Ner are Abiel's sons.

Even though Saul helps the Israelites defeat many of their enemies, Saul cannot fully defeat the Philistines. As long as Saul lives, the Israelites and the Philistines fight bitterly or fiercely. Since these two groups are often fighting, Saul is always ready to find more men to add to Saul's army. Whenever Saul sees an Israelite man who is strong and brave, Saul takes that man into Saul's service or commands that man to join his army.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do leaders or rulers convince or order people to join their army? What kind of men do those leaders look for? How often do those leaders add more soldiers?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:47–52 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: During his time as king, Saul leads his soldiers to fight the people who live in the land around the Israelites. Saul defeats the Israelites' enemies, who had plundered the Israelites.

In the second scene: Saul's wife's name is Ahinoam. Saul has sons named Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malki-Shua as well as daughters named Merab and Michal. Saul's cousin Abner is the commander of the Israelite army.

In the third scene: Because the Israelites are often fighting the Philistines, Saul adds any brave men he sees to Saul's army.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The Israelites, including the strong and brave men
- The Israelites' enemies, who include the Moabites, Ammonites, Edomites, the kings and people of Zobah, the Philistines, and the Amalekites
- Saul's sons, Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malki-Shua
- Saul's daughters, Merab and Michal
- Ahinoam, Saul's wife, who is Ahimaaz's daughter
- Abner, Saul's cousin, who is Ner's son
- Kish, Saul's father
- Ner, Abner's father
- And Abiel, Kish and Ner's father

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In this story, the storyteller gives a short overview of Saul's time as king after the victory in the last section. The storyteller describes Saul's military victories, Saul's family, and the ongoing fight with the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, pretend you are a teacher and you are about to tell your students about a king or leader in your history. Quickly give a little overview or summary of what that leader did during their lifetime. Pay attention to which information you include and how you choose to organize that information. Pause this audio here.

Scene one begins after the last story and covers all of Saul's time as king. Because Saul defeated the Philistines, the Israelites trusted Saul as their king because Saul could protect the Israelites. At different times during Saul's reign, Saul led the Israelites to fight their enemies, who lived in the lands all around the Israelites.

The people groups of Moab, Ammon, and Edom live to the east and south of Israel. The Philistines and Amalekites are in the southwest, while Zobah is a city or a kingdom of cities located north of Israel. Some of these people groups had been attacking the Israelites and taking the Israelites' possessions. However, Saul is a brave warrior and leads the Israelites to win battles against these nations. Saul stops these other people groups from

plundering or attacking the Israelites. Saul and his army probably fight several battles against each nation, like the Philistines, whom the Israelites often fight during Saul's time as king.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Israel and the surrounding lands. Find the territory of the Moabites, Ammonites, Edomites, Zobah, the Philistines, and the Amalekites. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller lists the names of some of Saul's family members. Saul's wife's name is Ahinoam, and Ahinoam's father is Ahimaaz. Saul has sons named Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malki-Shua. The storyteller probably listed these sons in age order, like their sisters Merab and Michal. Saul's cousin Abner is the commander of Saul's army. Abner's father is Ner, who was Saul's uncle. Saul's father, Kish, and Abner's father, Ner, are both Abiel's sons. Saul does have more family members, but the storyteller does not list those family members here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you describe your father's brother and your father's brother's son? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you list or describe someone's family members? Why do you do it in this order? Discuss how you will list Saul's family members. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the storyteller explains that because the Israelites and the Philistines often fought during Saul's time as king, Saul often needed more soldiers. So whenever Saul saw any Israelite man who was strong and brave, Saul either asked or commanded that man to join the army. In the original language, the storyteller says that Saul attached these men to himself, which means these men came into Saul's army.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In the original language, the storyteller says that the Israelites and Philistines fought all the days of Saul. This means the Israelites and Philistines fought throughout Saul's lifetime. Discuss how you would talk about something that happens throughout or during someone's entire life. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:47–52 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The Israelites, including the strong and brave men
- The Israelites' enemies, who include the Moabites, Ammonites, Edomites, the kings and people of Zobah, the Philistines, and the Amalekites
- Saul's sons, Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malki-Shua
- Saul's daughters, Merab and Michal
- Ahinoam, Saul's wife, who is Ahimaaz's daughter
- Abner, Saul's cousin, who is Ner's son
- Kish, Saul's father
- Ner, Abner's father
- And Abiel, Kish and Ner's father

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

1 Samuel 14:47–52

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After Saul had secured his position as king, Saul led his army to fight against the Israelites' enemies all around them. The Israelites fought against the people of Moab, of Ammon, and of Edom; the kings of Zobah and their people; and the Philistines. Saul defeated all the nations he fought. Saul was a very brave fighter and led his army to defeat the Amalekites. In this way, Saul rescued the people of Israel from all who had been attacking them and taking the Israelites' possessions. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so proud of our king, who is a strong warrior. Now we can defeat anyone who attacks us, and the other nations will respect us! or
- I have been afraid for a long time, since the other nations attacked and stole from us. I am relieved that Saul has defeated our enemies. Now we can live in peace; or
- I am glad we have such a good king. I want to support the king and follow his commands because I know the king will protect us.

Continue the drama. Saul had sons named Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malki-Shua. Saul's daughters were Merab and Michal. Merab was older than Michal. Saul's wife was Ahinoam, the daughter of Ahimaaz. The commander of Saul's army was Abner, Saul's cousin. Abner's father was Ner, who was Saul's uncle. Saul's father, Kish, and Abner's father, Ner, were both sons of Abiel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am thankful that God has given me both sons and daughters; or
- I want someone I can trust to lead my army, so I will put my cousin in command. I know my cousin, and I know he will be loyal to me.

Continue the drama. As long as Saul lived, the Israelites were always fighting their enemy, the Philistines. So whenever Saul saw a strong and brave Israelite, Saul took that man into his army. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the strong and brave men of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad to fight for Saul, since Saul keeps leading our people to defeat our enemies; or
- While I would rather do another job, I do want to protect my people, so I will obey my king's orders; or
- I wish we were not fighting the Philistines all the time, but I am thankful that Saul often brings more soldiers to help us fight.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 14:47–52 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Saul secures his **kingship** over Israel. A kingship is the role or position of a king. For more information, refer to king in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for kingship as you used in previous passages.

Israel can refer to the Israelite people as well as the country where the Israelites lived. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

Saul defeats the people groups who had **plundered** Israel. To plunder means to take belongings like food and weapons from a defeated enemy. Use the same word or phrase for plunder as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 14:47–52

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (970 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (788 KB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 15:1–9

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 15:1–9 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:1–9 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 15:1–9

In a previous story, Saul had failed to obey Yahweh's command. Samuel, the prophet, told Saul that because of what Saul had done, Yahweh would not allow Saul's children to continue to be kings after Saul. In the meantime, Saul continued to make Saul's army stronger and bigger. In this passage, Samuel gives Saul Yahweh's instructions to attack and kill all of the Amalekite people and all of their animals and to destroy the Amalekites' belongings. Many years before, when the Israelites left Egypt to go to the Promised Land, the Amalekites had attacked the Israelites. Now it was time for Yahweh to punish the Amalekites for this.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about people groups that your people have been enemies with for many years. How did those people become your enemies? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do your people expect of warriors when those warriors go to war? What are the warriors supposed to carry or not carry back home, and what are the warriors supposed to completely destroy? What is the reason for this? Pause this audio here.

Samuel has been silent since Samuel accused Saul of disobeying Yahweh's commands. Now Samuel appears again in the story to give Yahweh's message to Saul. When Samuel says that Samuel is the one who Yahweh sent to anoint Saul as king, Samuel is remembering how Samuel anointed Saul in the past. Yahweh appointed Samuel as Yahweh's prophet and as the one who anointed Saul as king. Therefore, the king must obey Samuel's instructions.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If someone in your culture gives a message from a deity, how should the people respond? How do people in your culture know whether or not to trust the person who brings the message? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh, who is the commander of the angel armies, or heavenly beings, says that Yahweh will punish the Amalekites, who are the descendants of Amalek. The Amalekites attacked Israel when Yahweh brought the Israelites out of Egypt many years ago. So now Yahweh commands Saul to completely destroy the Amalekites and all that belongs to the Amalekites. Yahweh wants the Israelites to totally destroy everything the Israelites capture in war, including men, women, children, babies, and livestock or different animals that belong to the Amalekites.

Stop here and look at pictures of what people considered livestock: camels, donkeys, sheep, cows, and oxen, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture show their loyalty to their deity or deities? Pause this audio here.

Saul listens to Yahweh's order to totally destroy the Amalekites and their belongings, and Saul does what Yahweh says to do. Saul calls, inspects, and counts the soldiers at Telaim. Telaim was a city in the territory of Judah. The 200,000 men on foot, or foot soldiers, are from the northern tribes of Israel and not Judah, since Judah is listed separately. There are 10,000 men from Judah. We are not sure if the men from Judah are also foot soldiers, or men who ride in chariots or on horses.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when your leaders gathered and assigned people from your community to go to war. How did the leaders do this? Pause this audio here

Saul and Saul's soldiers waited in the valley, or dry riverbed, outside of the city of Amalek. A wall may have surrounded this city to protect the people in the city. While the army was waiting in the valley, Saul sent a message to the Kenites who lived with the Amalekites. The Kenites were kind to the Israelites when the Israelites came out of Egypt because the Kenites guided the Israelites in the desert. Saul chose to warn the Kenites to leave before the battle began so the Kenites would be safe from fighting. The Kenites listened to the warning and left the Amalekites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Saul showed loyalty to the Kenites because of what the Kenites had done many years ago for the Israelites. When is it important to show loyalty to a person or group of people in your culture? How does your culture show loyalty to people in your culture as well as people outside of your culture? Pause this audio here.

Saul and his army then defeated the Amalekites from the city of Havilah to the city of Shur. We do not know the location of Havilah, but it is perhaps in the territory of the Ishmaelites, descendants of Abraham's first son. We think Shur is east of Egypt, in the wilderness region in the Sinai Peninsula.

1 Samuel 15:1–9

Though Saul and his army won the battle against the Amalekites, Saul did not obey Yahweh's command to destroy everyone and everything that belonged to the Amalekites. Saul took Agag, the king, captive as a prisoner of war. Saul also spared the best of the livestock and did not completely destroy the animals. But, everything that was not good, Saul and his army destroyed.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Share stories where the Israelites or people in your communities failed to obey instructions from a deity. Why do you think Saul may have chosen to disobey?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel tells Saul to listen to Yahweh's words. Yahweh tells Saul that Yahweh knows that the Amalekites fought against Israel when the Israelites came out of Egypt. Yahweh instructs Saul and Saul's army to completely destroy the Amalekites and everything that belongs to the Amalekites. Yahweh tells Saul to kill everyone, including men, women, children, and infants, plus all of the livestock animals.

In the second scene: Saul prepares Saul's army to fight against the Amalekites. Saul calls Saul's army to meet Saul in Telaim, and then Saul inspects and numbers the soldiers. There are 200,000 foot soldiers from Israel, plus 10,000 men from the tribe of Judah.

In the third scene: Saul and Saul's army come to the valley outside of the city of Amalek and wait there. Saul sends a warning to the Kenites who live with the Amalekites to leave the area. Saul says that the Kenites showed kindness to the Israelites when the Israelites left Egypt, so Yahweh will not harm the Kenites. So the Kenites leave the Amalekites.

In the fourth scene: Saul and Saul's army defeat the Amalekites from Havilah as far as Shur, which is next to Egypt. Saul takes Agag, Amalek's king, alive. But Saul destroys all of the people by the sword of Saul's armies. However, Saul spares, or keeps alive, Agag and all of the best sheep, oxen, the fattest calves, and the lambs. Saul does not destroy these animals. But everything that Saul thinks is worthless, the Israelites destroy.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- Samuel
- Yahweh
- The Israelite foot soldiers
- The soldiers from Judah
- The Kenites
- The Amalekites
- And Agag

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

We do not know how long after the previous passage this passage happens. It seems as if Saul has had time to build up his army, so it may have been quite a bit of time. We are also not sure exactly where the conversation between Samuel and Saul takes place.

When Samuel talks to Saul, Samuel identifies himself as the person Yahweh had previously sent to anoint Saul as king of the Israelites, Yahweh's chosen people. Saul has to obey Samuel since Samuel is a prophet of Yahweh. Samuel tells Saul to listen to the words of Yahweh as Samuel tells the words to Saul.

Samuel identifies Yahweh as "Yahweh of hosts." This title shows that Yahweh is the leader of both the armies of the Israelite people and the armies of spiritual beings in heaven.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about Yahweh as "Yahweh of hosts"? Pause this audio here.

Amalek was a grandson of Esau, Jacob's older twin brother. Amalek's descendants, the Amalekites, had attacked the Israelites at Rephidim in the Sinai wilderness. Yahweh tells Saul, through Samuel, to go and utterly, or completely, destroy the Amalekites and all of the Amalekites' belongings and animals.

In the second scene, Saul calls his men to the area of Telaim, and then Saul counts and inspects the men.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Count as many of one specific object as you can see. For example, count all of the rocks in the area. Discuss how you would count large numbers in the thousands and tens of thousands. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the story talks about both Saul and Saul's army by only saying Saul's name. In your translation, you could say that Saul and Saul's soldiers go to the city of Amalek and wait in the valley. It is not only Saul who goes, but Saul and all of Saul's men. The valley is a dry riverbed, or lower part of land, where water only flows in the rainy season. Saul and his army wait in the valley so that they can attack the Amalekites in the city at the right time.

Stop here and have one person in the group give instructions directly to a leader about what the leader should do, together with the leader's people. Pay attention to how you talk about the leader and all of the leader's people. Do you only use the leader's name, or do you say the leader and all of the leader's people? Pause this audio here.

The story then says that Saul told the Kenites to leave the Amalekites. More than likely, Saul did not say this directly to the Kenites. Saul probably sent a message to the Kenite leaders to tell their people to leave the area so the Kenites would not be destroyed. The Kenites had acted as a guide to the Israelites when the Israelites had left Egypt. Because the Kenites were kind, Saul spared the Kenites. Saul told the Kenites that the Kenites were kind to, or steadfastly loved, the Israelites. Saul meant that the Kenites were loyal and faithful to the Israelites by doing something to help the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group stories about people or groups of people who are very kind and very loyal. What kinds of words do you use to describe this type of person? When someone is kind like this, others trust that person and think that person is very loyal. Pause this audio here.

In scene four, Saul destroyed the Amalekites but did not obey Yahweh's command. Saul took Agag, the Amalekites' king, prisoner and kept Agag alive. Saul did destroy the rest of the Amalekites. However, Saul kept the best of the livestock alive and was not willing to destroy these animals. Saul's army did destroy everything that no one wanted or that was weak or unworthy.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- Samuel
- Yahweh
- The Israelite foot soldiers
- The soldiers from Judah
- The Kenites
- The Amalekites
- And Agag

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Samuel tells Saul to listen to Yahweh's words. Yahweh tells Saul that Yahweh knows that the Amalekites fought against Israel when the Israelites came out of Egypt. Yahweh instructs Saul and Saul's army to completely destroy the Amalekites and everything that belongs to the Amalekites. Yahweh tells Saul to kill everyone, including men, women, children, and infants, plus all of the livestock animals. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Killing women, children, and babies seems so cruel! or
- I had better do this just right because Yahweh is already upset that I did not obey last time; or
- I can kill everything, maybe. But what if the Amalekites have some good animals?

Continue the drama. Saul prepared his army to fight against the Amalekites. Saul called his army to meet Saul in Telaim, and then Saul inspected and numbered the men. There were 200,000 foot soldiers from Israel, plus 10,000 men from Judah's tribe.

Saul and his army came to the valley outside the city of Amalek and waited there. Saul sent a warning to the Kenites who lived with the Amalekites to leave the area. Saul said that the Kenites showed kindness to the Israelites when the Israelites left Egypt, so the Kenites would be spared. So the Kenites left the Amalekites. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Kenites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Thank the god of the Israelites that our ancestors were kind to the Israelites! Now the Israelites are kind to us! or
- Praise be to Yahweh, that Yahweh is letting us live! or
- I never liked those Amalekites!

Continue the drama. Saul and his army defeated the Amalekites from the city of Havilah as far as the city of Shur, which is next to Egypt. Saul took Agag, the Amalek king, but destroyed all of the people by the sword of Saul's armies. However, Saul spared or kept alive Agag and all of the best sheep, oxen, the fattest calves, and the lambs, and did not destroy them. But everything that Saul thought was worthless, the Israelites destroyed. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh could not have really meant all of the sheep. Look, these sheep are perfect for sacrificing to Yahweh! or
- I am sure it will not hurt for us to keep the animals. The animals are not worshiping foreign gods, and the animals are in good condition.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Why will Saul not just listen to me? Does Saul not know that what I tell Saul to do is best for Saul? or
- I am so angry at Saul, but I still love my people. I will bring another person to rule over Israel who loves me.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

1 Samuel 15:1–9

Samuel told Saul that Samuel was the one whom **Yahweh** had sent to **anoint** Saul as **king** over the **Israelites**. So Samuel told Saul to listen to the word or voice of Yahweh, or the message that Yahweh had given for Saul. Yahweh is God's personal and proper name. To anoint is to set someone or something apart for special service by pouring a sweet-smelling oil over that person. A king is someone who rules over a region or country. The people of Israel were God's chosen people who were Jacob's descendants. Use the same words for Yahweh, anoint, king, and Israelites that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, anoint, king, and Israelite, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh of hosts tells Saul to attack the Amalekites as punishment for the way they treated the Israelites when the Israelites left Egypt. Saul is to attack the Amalekites and destroy all of the people and all that belongs to the Amalekites. Saul should completely destroy, not spare, or not keep alive the Amalekites. Saul must put to death all of the men, women, children, and babies, as well as the **cattle and sheep**, **camels**, and **donkeys**. Remember that cattle can be cows or oxen. Yahweh of hosts means that God is in charge of Israel's armies and the armies of the spiritual beings in heaven. Camels are large, strong animals that can walk for a long time in the desert. Donkeys are animals that are big enough to carry a heavy load or a person. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh of hosts, cattle and sheep, camels, and donkeys that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh of hosts, camels, and donkeys, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about someone **completely destroying** something. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, translate it in a similar way here. Pause this audio here.

Saul called all of Saul's army together from Israel and Judah. Saul and Saul's army waited in the **valley**, or **dry riverbed**, outside of the **city** of Amalek. A valley, sometimes called a wadi, is a dry riverbed that only flows with water during the rainy season. A city is a large area where people live, and it has a wall around it to protect it. Use the same words for valley or dry riverbed and city that you have used in previous passages.

Saul warned the Kenites who were living with the Amalekites to leave the city so Yahweh would not destroy them. Saul did this because the Kenites had shown kindness, or steadfast love, to the Israelites. So the Kenites left.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kindness** or **steadfast love**. Look up "steadfast love" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul's army destroyed the Amalekites with **swords**. In other words, Saul's army used swords to kill the Amalekites in battle. Talk about killing people with swords in battle in the same way as you have in previous passages.

Then Saul attacked the Amalekites and took Agag, the king, and all of the best animals and kept them alive. But everyone else and all of the unworthy animals Saul and Saul's army completely destroyed.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 15:1–9

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (543 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (754 KB)

1 Samuel 15:10–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 15:10–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:10–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:10–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Yahweh gave a command to Saul through the prophet Samuel. Samuel told Saul that Yahweh was going to punish the Amalekites for their sins against the Israelites. Yahweh told Saul to totally destroy the Amalekites and everything that belonged to the Amalekites. Saul went to battle with Saul's army and destroyed all of the Amalekites except for the king, Agag. Then the soldiers in Saul's army kept the best of the sheep and cattle in order to sacrifice those animals to Yahweh.

In this passage, the scene shifts from Saul's actions to Yahweh's response. Yahweh speaks to Samuel and tells Samuel that Yahweh is sad because he made Saul king, since Saul has not followed Yahweh. Therefore, Yahweh will remove Saul from the position that Yahweh gave Saul as king. Samuel is angry and cries out to Yahweh all night. More than likely, Samuel is feeling the sadness of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group a story about a time when your culture's god felt an emotion such as sadness or anger. What happened to make your god feel that way, and what did that god do? Pause this audio here.

At Carmel, Saul put up a monument, probably to celebrate Saul's victory over Amalek. Kings often did this in the ancient Near East. Gilgal was in the Jordan Valley and was the main town where people made sacrifices to Yahweh. Gilgal was also the place where Samuel had anointed Saul as king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What places in your culture are religiously or politically significant to the people in your culture? Why are those places significant? Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Carmel and Gilgal. Pause this audio here.

The prophet arrived, probably when King Saul was getting ready to offer burnt offerings from the best animals that Saul took from Amalek. Saul greeted Samuel enthusiastically, and Saul blessed Samuel and assured Samuel that Saul had carried out Yahweh's command successfully. Saul told Samuel that Saul had kept the best sheep and cattle for sacrifice to Yahweh. Saul had directly disobeyed Yahweh! Samuel shows that Samuel does not believe Saul's claim to have obeyed Yahweh's commandment and to have killed all of the people and animals of the Amalekites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories of people who have rebelled against deities in your culture. What are the consequences for people in your culture who rebel against their deities? Pause this audio here.

Samuel asks Saul about the cries or sounds of the sheep and oxen.

Saul blames Saul's soldiers for failing to completely destroy everything. Then Saul says the soldiers spared the animals for a good reason: to make sacrifices to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some of the reasons that people might give for disobeying their deities? Why do you think people might disobey deities? Pause this audio here.

When Yahweh commanded Saul to totally destroy the Amalekites and their belongings, Yahweh placed the Amalekites and their possessions under a ban. In other words, these people and their property were completely off limits to the Israelites and were inappropriate or unclean to sacrifice to Yahweh. When Saul decided to sacrifice these animals to Yahweh, Saul showed that Saul was making an idol of himself and Saul rejected Yahweh's message.

Samuel says that Yahweh is more pleased when people obey Yahweh than when people make sacrifices to Yahweh. Then Samuel says that to rebel against God and to be stubborn are as sinful as witchcraft and worshiping idols. Samuel ends his statement by telling Saul that because Saul has rejected Yahweh's command, Yahweh now rejects Saul as king. Samuel is not saying that people are doing the wrong thing when they give sacrifices, but Samuel is saying that to obey God is always the most important thing that people should do.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:10–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh speaks to Samuel and tells Samuel that Yahweh regrets making Saul king of Israel. Samuel is distressed and angry and cries out to Yahweh through the night.

In the second scene: Someone tells Samuel where to find Saul. They say that Saul has built a monument of himself in Carmel and then gone down to Gilgal.

In the third scene: Samuel finds Saul. Saul says that Yahweh has blessed Samuel, and Saul tells Samuel that Saul has carried out Yahweh's commands. Samuel confronts Saul and says that Saul has disobeyed Yahweh. Saul makes excuses that the soldiers brought the best sheep and oxen from the Amalekites in order to sacrifice to Yahweh. Saul says that Saul and his men totally destroyed the rest of the Amalekites.

In the fourth scene: Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh said that Saul was once small in his own sight, but that Yahweh had anointed Saul as king and sent Saul to destroy the Amalekites completely. Samuel again confronts Saul for disobeying and calls what Saul did evil in Yahweh's sight.

1 Samuel 15:10–23

In the fifth scene: Saul again makes excuses that he did obey Yahweh. Yet Saul brought back King Agag, and the soldiers took some of the sheep and oxen from the Amalekites to sacrifice to Yahweh. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh is not as happy when people make sacrifices as much as Yahweh is happy when people obey Yahweh. Samuel says that rebellion is like the sin of divination, or calling upon other spirits. Samuel also says that when someone is arrogant or thinks that they are better than everyone else, it is the same as idolatry. Now, because Saul has rejected Yahweh's commands, Yahweh has rejected Saul as king.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- Saul
- Agag
- Amalekites
- And soldiers

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

It is likely that the action starts outside of the battle in which Samuel had told Saul to destroy the Amalekites. This scene shifts from the battle to the conversation between Yahweh and Samuel. Then Samuel goes to find Saul in Gilgal.

In the first scene, when the word of Yahweh comes to Samuel, this means that Yahweh speaks to Samuel. This is the normal way that Yahweh spoke to a prophet. Yahweh says that Yahweh regrets that Yahweh made Saul king. Yahweh is not saying that Yahweh made a mistake. Yahweh is explaining that Yahweh is sad that Saul rebelled against Yahweh. Samuel is so distressed and angry that Samuel cries out to Yahweh all night long.

Stop here as a group and talk about different ways that God speaks. What words do you use when God speaks to you or to others? Notice the way you describe God speaking. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and talk about a time when you were both sad and angry at the same time. How will you talk about how Samuel felt when he cried out to Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

The second scene starts early in the morning when Samuel goes to meet Saul. Someone tells Samuel that Saul has set up a monument, or some sort of structure, to himself in Carmel, a town in Judah. Then Samuel goes to Gilgal.

In the third scene, when Saul sees Samuel in Gilgal, Saul says that Yahweh has blessed Samuel. Saul then boasts that Saul obeyed Yahweh. However, Samuel asks Saul why Samuel hears the sounds of the sheep and oxen in the distance. Samuel is not asking Saul a question that Samuel expects Saul to answer. Samuel is reminding Saul that Samuel knows Saul did not obey Yahweh. You may want to use the words here for the specific sounds these animals make, or you can use a general word for the cries of the animals. Samuel uses the phrases "in my ears" and "I hear," both of which mean that Samuel hears the noises the animals make.

Saul says that it was the people, or the soldiers, who brought the sheep and oxen from the Amalekites to sacrifice to Yahweh, Samuel's God. The original language simply says that someone brought the sheep and oxen to Saul, but we know that it was the soldiers. It is also important to notice that Saul calls Yahweh "Samuel's God," not Saul's own God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you describe the sounds that animals make? What sounds do you use for sheep and cows, or oxen? Make those sounds. How will you talk about the way the animals in this story make these sounds? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, Samuel starts with the exclamation, "Enough!" Samuel is telling Saul to stop talking. Samuel tells Saul what Yahweh had said to Samuel the previous evening. Samuel says that Saul might have thought of himself as small in his own eyes, which means that Saul thought of himself as unimportant.

Stop here and discuss as a group: If you feel like you are not important, how do you describe yourself? How will you talk about how Saul used to feel like Saul was not important? Pause this audio here.

Then Samuel asks Saul again why Saul did not obey Yahweh. Note that Samuel is saying that Saul is the one who disobeyed by taking the spoils of the war. Samuel asks Saul directly why Saul did not obey Yahweh to help Saul understand that Saul did not obey. Samuel asks Saul why Saul did something that was evil in the eyes of Yahweh, which means that Yahweh thinks what Saul did was evil.

In the fifth scene, Saul still says that Saul obeyed the voice of Yahweh, or Yahweh's instructions to Saul. Saul admits that Saul brought back Agag, the Amalekites' king. Then Saul tries to say that it was the people, not Saul, who were the ones who took the spoils of war to sacrifice to Yahweh, but that the people destroyed everything else. Samuel passes Yahweh's judgment on Saul and declares that it is better to obey Yahweh than to sacrifice to Yahweh. Samuel says that when someone rebels or disobeys against Yahweh, it is like that person sins by asking other spirits to help them. Samuel says that when someone thinks they know better than Yahweh, that person is making themself an idol. That person is really worshipping something other than Yahweh. Samuel ends by telling Saul that Yahweh has rejected Saul as king of Israel.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:10–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- Saul
- Agag
- Amalekites
- And soldiers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Yahweh speaks to Samuel and tells Samuel that Yahweh regrets making Saul king of Israel. Samuel is distressed and angry and cries out to Yahweh through the night. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so angry at Saul for his disobedience! Now Yahweh will reject Saul as king! or
- Why did Yahweh make Saul king in the first place? or
- Yahweh, please give Saul another chance!

Continue the drama. Someone tells Samuel that Saul built a monument of himself in Carmel and then went to Gilgal. Samuel finds Saul in Gilgal. Saul calls Samuel "blessed of Yahweh" and tells Samuel that Saul has carried out Yahweh's commands. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so awesome! I built a monument to myself. This was a great victory! or
- I feel panic. I need to justify why I did not keep all of Yahweh's commands; or
- Samuel is here, so we can go make these sacrifices to Yahweh!

Continue the drama. Samuel confronts Saul for not obeying Yahweh. Saul makes excuses that the sheep and oxen were the best that the soldiers brought back from the Amalekites in order to sacrifice to Yahweh. Saul says that the soldiers totally destroyed the rest of the animals. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I destroyed everyone but Agag! Is that not good enough? I was obedient! or
- I do not understand why Samuel is so upset. I was not the one who brought the sheep and oxen back. That was my army, not me. or
- I do not understand! We kept these so we could sacrifice them to Yahweh. Is that not what Yahweh would want from us?

Continue the drama. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh said Saul was once small in Saul's own sight, but that Yahweh had anointed Saul as king and sent him to destroy the Amalekites completely. Samuel again confronts Saul about Saul's disobedience and calls that obedience evil in the sight of Yahweh.

Saul again makes excuses that Saul did obey Yahweh. Yet Saul had brought back Agag, and the soldiers had taken some of the sheep and oxen from the Amalekites to sacrifice to Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am getting more and more angry as I talk to Saul. Saul just does not understand; or
- I cannot believe how prideful Saul is. Saul does not actually realize that it was Saul who was disobedient to Yahweh. Yahweh gave Saul clear instructions, and Saul did not follow the commands or make his soldiers follow them!

Continue the drama. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh does not delight in sacrifices as much as Yahweh does obedience. Samuel says that rebellion is like the sin of divination, or calling upon other spirits, and that being proud is the same as worshipping other gods.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:10–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The word of **Yahweh** came to Samuel. In other words, Yahweh gave Samuel a message. Yahweh said that Yahweh regretted making Saul the king of Israel. Saul had disobeyed Yahweh. Saul did not fulfill the commands that Yahweh had given Saul. Samuel was angry or distressed and cried out all night to Yahweh. Yahweh is God's personal and proper name. Use the same word for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on word and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel got up early in the morning to meet Saul. Someone told Samuel that Saul had gone to Carmel to set up a monument to himself because of Saul's victory over the Amalekites. Then Saul had gone down to Gilgal. When Samuel found Saul, Saul said that Yahweh had **blessed**, or done good to, Samuel. Saul declared that Saul had obeyed the word or command of Yahweh. Use the same word for blessed as you have used in previous passages. For more information on blessed, refer to the Master Glossary.

But Samuel asked Saul, "What then is the bleating of the **sheep** and lowing of **oxen** that I hear?" Bleating and lowing are the sounds that sheep and oxen make. Use the same words for sheep and oxen that you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss together as a group what you will call these sounds that the animals make. Pause this audio here.

Saul confesses that the army brought the best sheep and oxen from the Amalekites to **sacrifice** to Yahweh, whom Saul calls Samuel's **God**. But Saul says that his army destroyed everything else. A sacrifice is a gift that

people give to Yahweh. God is the one true creator God. Use the same words for sacrifice and God that you have used in previous passages. For more information on sacrifice and God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel tells Saul to stop talking so that Samuel can tell Saul what Yahweh has said. Samuel talks about when Saul still felt unimportant, but Yahweh **anointed** Saul as **king** over Israel. When someone anoints someone or something else, they set that person or thing apart by pouring a sweet-smelling oil over the person or thing. A king is a ruler over a territory or region, like a nation or country. Use the same words for anoint and king that you have used in previous passages. For more information on anoint and king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel confronts Saul because Saul disobeyed Yahweh. Saul kept some of the spoil, or good things, from the Amalekites. Yahweh saw this as **evil**. Evil is the opposite of good. In this case, evil is disobedience to Yahweh. Use the same word for evil that you have used in previous passages. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul then defends himself and says that Saul did what Yahweh told Saul to do. But Saul says that it was the people, or the soldiers, who disobeyed and took the spoil, the sheep and oxen, to sacrifice to Yahweh.

Then Samuel corrects Saul by telling Saul that Yahweh is happy when people obey more than when people make sacrifices. Samuel says that when people rebel, it is like the people are looking to other things than Yahweh for their answers, much like a person who **sins** when they use **divination**. Divination is when someone calls on spirits that are not Yahweh. Samuel also says that disobedience is the same as wickedness and **idolatry**, or worshiping other gods. Therefore, since Saul rejected the word or command of Yahweh, Yahweh has rejected Saul from being the king. Use the same words for sin, divination, and idolatry that you have used in previous passages. For more information on sin, divination, and idols, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 15:10–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (551 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.4 MB)

- Embodying the Text (2.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (750 KB)

1 Samuel 15:24–35

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 15:24–35 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:24–35 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passages, Samuel gave Saul instructions from Yahweh to totally destroy the Amalekites. Saul won the battle against the Amalakites, but allowed King Agag and the best sheep and cows to live. When Saul saw Samuel, Saul greeted Samuel and said that Saul had obeyed Yahweh's commandments. Samuel told Saul that because Saul had rejected the word or instructions of Yahweh, Yahweh had rejected Saul as king of Israel.

In this passage, Saul admits that Saul did sin by listening to the desires of Saul's soldiers, instead of listening to the word of Yahweh. Saul confesses his sin and provides a weak excuse. Saul says he was "afraid of the men," so Saul "listened to their voice." Samuel had commanded Saul to listen to the voice of Yahweh, but Saul disobeyed by listening to other voices instead.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who are some of the people that you are tempted to listen to instead of God? Who do people in your culture listen to for advice? Why do they listen to those people? Pause this audio here.

The conversation between Samuel and Saul has apparently been in secret, away from people. Now Saul asks Samuel to return with Saul to worship Yahweh because Saul wants the Israelites to feel like Samuel still honors Saul as king. Samuel refuses to go with Saul because Yahweh no longer blesses Saul as king, and Yahweh has rejected Saul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do the actions of one person give honor to another person in your culture? Who do people in your community want to be friends with because it makes them famous? Pause this audio here.

When Samuel turns to leave the area, Saul grabs the hem or end of Samuel's long robe, and it tears. Usually, when someone tears their own clothing in this culture, that person is sad about bad news or about a sin that the person has done. In this case, Saul means something very different. Regardless of what Saul may have intended, Samuel explains the real meaning. Just as Saul separated a piece of cloth from Samuel, so Yahweh has taken the kingdom of Israel from Saul.

Stop here and look at a picture of a robe. Pause this audio here.

Samuel says that Yahweh will give Saul's kingdom to another person, or a neighbor, who is better than Saul. This does not necessarily mean that Yahweh will give the kingdom to someone who lives in the same town, but perhaps to a friend, or to someone Saul knows.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about a time when a good leader came in place of a bad leader. How did this change happen? What did people know about the leadership change before it happened? Pause this audio here.

Samuel goes on to say that Yahweh, whom Samuel calls the "Glory of Israel," will not lie or change his mind. Samuel calls Yahweh the "Glory of Israel" to show that Yahweh lasts forever, and therefore Yahweh does not change. Samuel wants to show Saul what Yahweh is like, and Samuel wants to remind Saul that Yahweh has made a decision that is final.

Saul confesses his sin again to Samuel. However, instead of honoring Yahweh, Saul is concerned with honoring himself. Saul is unwilling to be ashamed in front of the Israelites, and especially the elders or older leaders of Israel.

Although Samuel had said that he would not return with Saul, Samuel changes his mind and turns back after all to go with Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about a time when you or someone else wanted to cover up a shameful action. What did you do? Who did you ask to help you? Pause this audio here.

You will remember that Saul had not killed the king of the Amalekites. Now, Samuel asks his guards to bring King Agag into Samuel's presence. King Agag goes calmly because Agag thinks that no one wants to kill Agag anymore. Instead, Samuel speaks to Agag. Samuel tells Agag that Agag has killed people with swords, and many mothers no longer have children because of Agag. Therefore, Samuel will make Agag's mother childless. Then Samuel kills and cuts Agag to pieces in front of Yahweh, much like a priest cuts up an animal to sacrifice to Yahweh. In this way, Samuel completes the work that Saul did not do. Samuel makes sure that the Israelites destroy everything they took from the Amalekites.

In summary, both Samuel and Saul go back to their own hometowns. The distance between their towns is about 16 kilometers. Samuel does not see Saul ever again, though Samuel feels sad because Saul disobeyed Yahweh. Yahweh also regrets, or is sorry, that Yahweh had made Saul king over Israel. This does not mean that Yahweh himself has changed. This simply means that when Saul disobeyed Yahweh, Yahweh was sad that Saul had made that choice to disobey Yahweh.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Saul confesses to disobeying Yahweh's word and Samuel's instruction because Saul was afraid of his men, or soldiers. Saul asks for forgiveness from Samuel and asks Samuel to go back to Gilgal with Saul. Samuel refuses to go back to Gilgal with Saul. Samuel tells Saul that since Saul has rejected Yahweh's command, Yahweh has rejected Saul as Israel's king. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh will not lie or change his mind because Yahweh is not like a human who changes his mind.

In the second scene: Saul begs Samuel again to honor Saul by going back to Gilgal with Saul so that Saul may worship Yahweh, Samuel's God. So Samuel goes back to Gilgal with Saul, and Saul worships Yahweh.

In the third scene: Samuel asks for someone to bring Agag, the Amalekites' king, to Samuel. Agag goes to Samuel gladly because Agag thinks that the time for Agag to die has passed. Samuel tells Agag that the same way Agag made many women childlessso will Agag's mother be childless. Samuel cuts Agag to pieces with a sword in front of Yahweh.

In the fourth scene: Samuel returns to Samuel's home in Ramah, and Saul returns to Saul's house at Gibeah. Samuel never meets with Saul again, but Samuel mourns for Saul. Yahweh is sorry that Yahweh made Saul king of Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- Samuel
- Yahweh
- King Agag
- Saul's soldiers
- And the Israelite elders

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first and second scenes, Saul and Samuel's conversation takes place somewhere in or near Gilgal. However, Saul and Samuel are not at the place where they sacrifice the offerings to Yahweh. Saul says that he has sinned against Yahweh's command and against Samuel's instructions. In this case, Saul actually says that Saul has sinned against the "mouth of Yahweh," which means that Saul has disobeyed what Yahweh told Saul to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about how Saul describes what Saul did? Saul says that Saul did not do what Yahweh told Saul to do. Pause this audio here.

But Saul gives an excuse. Saul says that Saul was afraid of his men, Saul's soldiers. Saul begs Samuel to forgive Saul and to come back with Saul to worship Yahweh, or so that Saul can sacrifice the animals that Saul brought back to worship Yahweh. Samuel refuses to go with Saul. Samuel says that Saul has rejected "the word of Yahweh," which means that Saul has not obeyed what Yahweh told Saul to do. Because Saul rejected Yahweh's commands, Yahweh rejected Saul himself as king over Yahweh's people, Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say that Yahweh rejects Saul because Saul did not obey Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

Samuel turns around to leave. As Samuel turns, Saul reaches down and pulls on the bottom of Samuel's long robe. Some of the cloth tears off. Saul is begging Samuel to stay with Saul. But Samuel uses this action to tell Saul what Yahweh will do. Samuel says that Yahweh will tear away, or take away, Saul's kingdom and give it to another person who is better than Saul. Some Bible translations say that Yahweh will give the kingdom to a neighbor. This does not necessarily mean that Yahweh will give the kingdom to someone who lives in the same town, but that Yahweh might give the kingdom to a friend, or to someone Saul knows.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Samuel uses Saul's action of tearing Samuel's robe as a way to show Saul what will happen to Saul's kingdom. How will you talk about this in your translation? Pause this audio here.

Samuel says that "The Glory of Israel does not lie or change his mind." The Glory of Israel refers to Yahweh. The word glory is not the normal word for glory. It is a word that usually means "something that continues forever." Some Bible translations translate this title for Yahweh as something like "the eternal God of Israel." The fact that Yahweh will not lie or change Yahweh's mind is something that is always true about Yahweh. Samuel wants Saul to know that Yahweh has decided to reject Saul as king, and there is nothing Saul can do to change Yahweh's mind.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate the title "The Glory of Israel" so that it refers to Yahweh as a God who is always the same? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Saul confesses his sin again. However, Saul immediately changes from talking about Saul's own sin to begging Samuel again to come with Saul so that Saul will not be ashamed in front of the elders of Israel. Saul needs Samuel, as Israel's religious leader, to be with Saul when Saul sacrifices the animals. It is important to remember that Saul again calls Yahweh Samuel's God. Saul says that Saul will worship "Yahweh, your God." Samuel finally agrees and goes back to Gilgal with Saul. Saul worships Yahweh there, probably by sacrificing the animals Saul has brought back from the Amalekites.

In the third scene, Samuel asks for someone to bring King Agag to Samuel. King Agag comes. Although we do not fully understand the language here, it is possible that King Agag was hopeful or cheerful because he thought

“the bitterness of death was past.” In other words, King Agag thought that it was too late for the Israelites to kill him and that Agag would not experience the horrible shame and pain of death. However, Samuel reminds King Agag of what Agag has done to others. Samuel says that King Agag has made many women no longer have children because Agag has killed those women’s children with swords. Because of this, Samuel will make King Agag’s mother no longer have children by killing King Agag with a sword.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Samuel uses special language to talk about how King Agag killed many people with swords, and that is why Samuel will kill King Agag with a sword. How will you talk about this in your translation? Pause this audio here.

Samuel cuts Agag into many pieces with a sword, probably in the same way he would cut up an animal before Samuel sacrifices it to Yahweh. This is why the story tells us that Samuel kills Agag “in front of Yahweh.”

In the fourth scene, Samuel returns to Samuel’s hometown of Ramah, and Saul returns to Gibeah. Samuel never again sees Saul, but Samuel is very sad that Saul has disobeyed Yahweh. Yahweh is sorry that Yahweh made Saul king of Israel.

Stop here and look together at the map of Gilgal, Ramah, and Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- Samuel
- Yahweh
- King Agag
- Saul’s soldiers
- And the Israelite elders

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Saul confesses to disobeying Yahweh’s word and Samuel’s instruction because Saul was afraid of his men, the soldiers. Saul did what the people wanted, not what Yahweh told Saul to do. Saul asks for forgiveness from Samuel and asks Samuel to go back to Gilgal with Saul. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I was really hoping it would be ok to bring sheep back to sacrifice; or
- I should have known better than to be disobedient again! or
- Maybe Yahweh will change his mind.

1 Samuel 15:24–35

Continue the drama. Samuel refuses to go back to Gilgal with Saul. Samuel tells Saul that since Saul has rejected Yahweh's command, Yahweh has rejected Saul as Israel's king. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- How could Saul do this? or
- Does Saul not understand that he had to obey what Yahweh said? Now, who will rule over the Israelites? or
- My heart is so sad at Saul's disobedience.

Continue the drama. Samuel turns to leave, and Saul grabs Samuel's robe. Saul tears Samuel's robe. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh has torn the kingdom of Israel from Saul and has given it to Saul's neighbor, who is better than Saul. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh, who is the Glory of Israel, will not lie or change his mind because Yahweh is not like a human who changes his mind. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My anger against Saul is great! Saul has not obeyed me, so Saul will not be king; or
- My heart delights in Samuel, and I know Samuel will deliver my word; or
- I have already chosen another person to be king. I am done with Saul!

Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I am devastated that Yahweh will not change his mind; or
- I want to do anything to make Yahweh allow me to keep the kingdom; or
- I do not believe Samuel! I will keep the kingdom, because I will look good to the Israelites! I will convince Samuel to come back with me and honor me!

Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I am devastated that Saul would do this; or
- I am angry now. Saul is showing that he does not repent.

Continue the drama. Saul begs Samuel again to honor Saul by going back to Gilgal with Saul so that Saul may worship Yahweh, Samuel's God. So Samuel goes back to Gilgal with Saul, and Saul worships Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- At least Samuel will come back with me to show the elders that I am still honored!

Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I will go back with Saul in order to kill Agag and finish the job; or
- I still love Saul. I want to help Saul as much as I can.

Continue the drama. Samuel asks people to bring Agag, the Amalekites' king, to Samuel. Agag goes to Samuel gladly because Agag thinks that the time for Agag to die has passed. Samuel tells Agag that the same way Agag made many women childless, so will Agag's mother be childless. Samuel cuts Agag to pieces with a sword in front of Yahweh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Agag, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel panic. I really thought I was safe!

Continue the drama. Samuel returns to Samuel's home in Ramah, and Saul returns to Saul's house at Gibeah. Samuel never meets with Saul again, but Samuel mourns for Saul. Yahweh is sorry that Yahweh made Saul king of Israel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 15:24–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this passage, Saul confesses that he disobeyed **Yahweh's** command and Samuel's instruction. Saul confesses that Saul was afraid of his soldiers, so Saul gave in to the soldiers' wishes instead of obeying Yahweh. Saul begs for Samuel to forgive Saul's **sin** and asks Samuel to go back with Saul so that Saul may **worship** Yahweh. Yahweh

1 Samuel 15:24–35

is God's personal, proper name. To worship is to give honor to God. Use the same words that you have used for Yahweh, sin, and worship in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, sin and worship, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **forgive**. Use the same word you have used in other books of the Bible, and see the Master Glossary for more information on forgiveness. Pause this audio here.

Samuel tells Saul that Samuel will not go with Saul to worship Yahweh. Samuel says that Saul has rejected the **word of Yahweh** and so Yahweh has **rejected** Saul as **Israel's king**. The "word of Yahweh" is the command or instruction that Yahweh gave. To reject someone or something is to dismiss that person or thing. A king is a ruler over a region or country. Israel is the country of people who belong to Yahweh, who people call the Israelites. Use the same words or phrases for the "word of Yahweh," reject, king, and Israel as you have used in previous passages. For more information on word, king, and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel turns to leave, and Saul tries to grab Samuel's **robe** to stop Samuel from leaving. Saul tears Samuel's robe. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh has torn or taken the **kingdom** of Israel from Saul and given it to someone else—one of Saul's **neighbors** who is better than Saul. A robe is a piece of clothing that people would usually wear as an outer garment. A kingdom is a territory or a people that a king rules. A neighbor is someone who lives in the same area or near the same region as another person. Use the same words for robe, kingdom, and neighbor that you have used in previous passages. For more information on robe, kingdom, and neighbor, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh, who is the **glory** of Israel, does not lie or change Yahweh's mind because Yahweh is not a human. Glory is usually the fame that people receive for doing something wonderful. In this case, this word reminds the people that Yahweh's fame and Yahweh's character never change.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **glory** in this setting. Pause this audio here.

Saul confesses his sin again to Samuel. Saul also requests that Samuel honor Saul before the **elders** of Saul's people and Israel by going back with Saul to worship Yahweh, Samuel's **God**. So Samuel goes back with Saul, and Saul worships Yahweh. Use the same words for God and for elders that you have used in previous passages. For more information on God and elders, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then Samuel asks for Agag, the Amalekites' king. Agag comes to Samuel gladly because Agag thinks the possibility of Agag's death has passed. But Samuel tells Agag that since Agag's sword has made many women childless, Agag's mother will also be childless. Then Samuel cuts Agag to pieces with a sword before Yahweh, at Gilgal.

Samuel then returns to Samuel's home in Ramah, and Saul returns to Saul's home in Gibeah. Samuel never meets with Saul again. Samuel mourns a lot for Saul. Yahweh is sorry that Yahweh made Saul king of Israel.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 15:24–35

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (563 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (749 KB)

1 Samuel 16:1–13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 16:1–13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:1–13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage takes place some time after Yahweh has rejected Saul as king. Samuel and Saul have both returned to their hometowns. Samuel is grieving over Saul's rebellion. Yahweh asks Samuel why Samuel is still grieving.

Yahweh tells Samuel to fill Samuel's horn with oil and leave. These horns were from rams, and leaders often filled these horns with olive oil to anoint people for special tasks. A leader would anoint a person by pouring the olive oil over the person's head. Samuel would have used this oil to anoint the new king.

Stop here and look at a picture of a ram's horn. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you choose leaders in your culture? What kinds of rituals do people do to show that someone is the new leader? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh tells Samuel to go to Jesse's household in the town of Bethlehem because Yahweh has chosen one of Jesse's sons to be king. Jesse was from the tribe of Judah. Jesse lived in Bethlehem just south of Ramah.

Stop here and look at a map of Bethlehem in relation to Ramah. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 16:1–13

Samuel is afraid. Samuel knows that Saul will be angry if Saul hears that Samuel is anointing a new king in Saul's place. So Samuel asks Yahweh why Yahweh thinks this is a good idea. Yahweh tells Samuel to take a heifer, which is a female cow. People used heifers specifically for peace offerings, which are offerings to show good relationships between people and God, and between people and other people. Samuel does all that Yahweh has told Samuel to do, which means that Samuel fills his horn with olive oil, takes a heifer, and goes to Bethlehem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture communicate their peaceful intentions to one another? Pause this audio here.

The elders of Bethlehem tremble in fear when they see Samuel enter their town. We do not know why the elders tremble in fear. Samuel tells the elders that Samuel has come in peace. Samuel invites the elders to consecrate themselves, or clean themselves and make themselves holy, and come to the sacrifice. Then Samuel consecrates Jesse and Jesse's sons and invites them to the sacrifice. Yahweh required that people prepare themselves for all kinds of sacrifices by performing certain kinds of washing to symbolize that the people were ready to worship Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of things do you do to prepare yourselves for special religious ceremonies in your culture? Why are these rituals important to your people? Pause this audio here.

Jesse's sons come before Samuel one at a time. Samuel thinks to himself that the oldest, Eliab, must be the one Yahweh will choose to be king because in that culture, the oldest son was usually the most important son. However, Yahweh tells Samuel not to look at outward appearances because Yahweh knows people's hearts. In other words, Yahweh knows if someone is really good or bad.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of outward appearances do people use to help them decide if someone will be a good leader? What kinds of status in the community or family are important to consider when you choose new leaders? Pause this audio here.

Samuel probably asks Jesse to call each of Jesse's sons to walk in front of Samuel, although Jesse probably does not know why Samuel wants to look at Jesse's sons. As each passes by, Yahweh tells Samuel that Yahweh has rejected each son. Samuel asks if there are any more sons, and Jesse calls Jesse's youngest son to come. This son is out in the fields watching the family's sheep. Because this son is the youngest member of the family, Jesse had probably not considered David important enough for Samuel to look at. Jesse sends a messenger to get David. But when David comes in, Yahweh tells Samuel to stand up and anoint David. David has beautiful eyes, which means David is really handsome. So Samuel takes the horn of oil and anoints David in front of all of David's brothers. Yahweh's Spirit is with David from that time forward, and Samuel goes back to Samuel's home in Ramah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel is sad that Saul disobeyed Yahweh. Yahweh tells Samuel to stop grieving because Yahweh has rejected Saul. Yahweh tells Samuel to go to Bethlehem and anoint one of Jesse's sons as the one Yahweh had chosen to be king over the people of Israel.

In the second scene: Samuel goes to Bethlehem with a heifer and tells the elders, as well as Jesse, to consecrate themselves and come to a sacrifice.

In the third scene: Jesse and Jesse's sons arrive at the sacrifice. When they enter, Samuel assumes that he is going to anoint Eliab, Jesse's oldest son. However, Yahweh tells Samuel not to look at Eliab's outward appearance because Yahweh looks at the heart of people to understand who those people really are. Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah all pass before Samuel. However, Samuel tells Jesse that Yahweh has not chosen these. Four more of Jesse's sons pass before Samuel, but they are not the ones Yahweh has chosen. Samuel asks Jesse if Jesse has

1 Samuel 16:1–13

any other sons. Jesse tells Samuel that the youngest is out in the fields watching sheep. So Samuel tells Jesse to bring the youngest son in.

In the fourth scene: Jesse brought in his youngest son, David. David was handsome with beautiful eyes. Yahweh told Samuel to get up and anoint David. Samuel took the horn of oil and anointed David where all of David's brothers could see. Then the Yahweh's Spirit came on David powerfully from that day forward. Samuel got up, left, and went back to Ramah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- Jesse
- The elders
- Eliab
- Abinadab
- Shammah
- The rest of Jesse's sons
- A messenger who calls David from the fields
- David
- And the Spirit of Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story happens sometime after Yahweh rejects Saul as king, but we do not know how long after.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you start this passage to show that this happened some time after Yahweh rejected Saul? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh's conversation with Samuel probably happens while Samuel is in Ramah, where Samuel lives. Yahweh asks Samuel a question that Yahweh does not expect Samuel to answer: "How long will you grieve over Saul?" This question could also be worded as a gentle command like, "Do not keep grieving for Saul," or "You have grieved long enough for Saul."

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about how Yahweh gives Samuel the gentle command to stop grieving for Saul? Pause this audio here.

Samuel answers with another question that Samuel does not expect Yahweh to answer. Samuel asks, "How can I go? Saul will kill me if he finds out that I am anointing someone else as king." Samuel is saying that Samuel thinks it is a bad idea to go. Perhaps Samuel is afraid that Saul will kill Samuel. Yahweh tells Samuel that it will be fine, and Yahweh asks Samuel to take a heifer, or female cow, with Samuel to Bethlehem. Samuel will tell the people in Bethlehem that Samuel is sacrificing this heifer as a way to worship Yahweh and to cover any sins that the people in the area have done. In this way, the people will perhaps not know the other reason that Samuel is coming to Bethlehem.

Samuel gathers the things Samuel needs, and the setting changes to Bethlehem, a town about seven kilometers south of Jerusalem. When Samuel arrives in Bethlehem, the elders, who are the older men of the community, tremble in fear when they see Samuel. We do not know why the elders are afraid, but perhaps the men understand that Samuel is visiting Bethlehem for a serious reason. The elders ask Samuel if Samuel is coming in peace.

Samuel has the elders consecrate themselves, or make themselves "holy" or ritually pure, so that the elders can participate in the sacrifice to Yahweh. Samuel also consecrates Jesse and Jesse's sons. Although the storyteller does not include this information, the elders and Jesse probably have to wash themselves in a special way in order to become holy and able to participate.

Each one of Jesse's sons stands before Samuel. Yahweh has not yet told Samuel which son Yahweh has chosen as king. When Samuel sees the eldest son Eliab, Samuel assumes that Eliab is the one that Yahweh has chosen to be king. Yahweh tells Samuel not to look at the outward appearance, or the way a man looks, because Yahweh sees all that is in a man's heart. The Israelites would talk about their emotions and decisions coming from their

heart. This conversation between Samuel and Yahweh is likely taking place in Samuel's thoughts, and not out loud for others to hear.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about Yahweh seeing what is in a person's heart. In other words, how will you talk about the fact that Yahweh does not just look at what a person looks like on the outside? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh has not chosen any of Jesse's seven sons whom Jesse brought before Samuel. Samuel asks Jesse if Jesse has any other sons. David, Jesse's youngest son, is in the fields taking care of the sheep. Samuel tells Jesse to call for David and that they will not sit down until David arrives. Samuel does not mean that the men will remain standing, but that the men will not do anything else important until David arrives.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do you talk about someone waiting for an event to happen before that person continues doing something important? Pause this audio here.

Jesse sends a messenger to call David back from the fields to the town of Bethlehem, where everyone has gathered. When David arrives, Samuel sees that David is very handsome. In the original language, the story says that David is red and that David has beautiful eyes. When someone says that a person is red, this means that the person looks healthy. When someone says that a man has beautiful eyes, this means that the man is handsome.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do you talk about a man who looks healthy and handsome? How will you talk about how David looks in this story? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh tells Samuel to rise and anoint David, for David is the one Yahweh has chosen. This does not mean that Samuel has been sitting down, but that Yahweh wants Samuel to act. Samuel anoints David with Samuel's horn of oil, which means that Samuel pours the oil on David's head from Samuel's ram's horn. Yahweh's Spirit comes on David. This means that Yahweh gives David everything David needs to do the things Yahweh asks him to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about Yahweh's Spirit giving David everything he needs from that time onwards? Pause this audio here.

Samuel then goes back to Ramah.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Samuel
- Jesse
- The elders
- Eliab
- Abinadab
- Shammah
- The rest of Jesse's sons
- A messenger who calls David from the fields
- David
- And the Spirit of Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Samuel is sad because Saul disobeyed Yahweh. Yahweh tells Samuel to stop grieving because Yahweh has rejected Saul. Yahweh tells Samuel to take Samuel's horn of oil and go to Bethlehem to Jesse, and to anoint one of Jesse's sons. Yahweh had chosen one of Jesse's sons as Yahweh's king. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I will do what Yahweh says, but I am still sad about Saul; or
- I hope this next king is better than Saul; or
- How do I know this problem will not happen again?

Continue the drama. Samuel asks Yahweh how Samuel can go to Bethlehem because Saul will try to kill Samuel. Yahweh tells Samuel to take a heifer, or a female cow, with Samuel in order to sacrifice the heifer. Yahweh tells Samuel to invite Jesse and Jesse's sons to the sacrifice and to anoint the son that Yahweh tells Samuel to anoint. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I trust Yahweh, so I am sure this will work and Saul will not try to kill me; or
- Jesse has a lot of sons. I wonder which one Yahweh has chosen.

Continue the drama. Samuel goes to Bethlehem with a heifer and tells the elders, as well as Jesse, to consecrate themselves and come to the sacrifice. Jesse and Jesse's sons arrive at the sacrifice. When Jesse and Jesse's son enter, Samuel assumes that Samuel is going to anoint Eliab, Jesse's oldest son. However, Yahweh tells Samuel not to look at the outward appearance because Yahweh looks at the heart. Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah all walk in front of Samuel. However, Samuel tells Jesse that Yahweh has not chosen these sons. Seven of Jesse's sons pass before Samuel, but none of these is the son Yahweh has chosen. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the elders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so afraid! Why is Samuel coming to our town? What have we done wrong?

Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh, what is wrong with these boys? Surely they are good enough; or
- I have looked at each of Jesse's sons. Maybe I heard Yahweh wrong; or
- I wonder what kind of person Yahweh is looking for in a new king.

Ask the person playing Eliab, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What is it that Yahweh is choosing? I do not understand, but this must be an important task!

Continue the drama.
- I know Yahweh is going to pick me since I am the oldest; or

- Surely I am good enough! or
- There is no way that Samuel will pick one of my younger brothers!

Samuel asks Jesse if Jesse has any other sons. Jesse tells Samuel that the youngest son is out taking care of sheep. So Samuel tells Jesse to bring the youngest son in. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jesse, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Why would Samuel want to see my youngest? David is just a shepherd, not a warrior; or
- David's a great kid, but he is not very strong. What was wrong with Eliab or the others? or
- I wonder what Yahweh is looking for.

Continue the drama. So Jesse brings in his youngest son, David. David is handsome and healthy. Yahweh tells Samuel to get up and anoint David. So Samuel takes the horn of oil and anoints David where all of David's brothers can see. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What just happened? How did I get to be anointed and not my brothers? or
- What an honor that Yahweh chose me. Yahweh, help me serve you well; or
- I wonder what Yahweh wants me to do for Yahweh? or
- I feel Yahweh's power! How wonderful! or
- I feel Yahweh's power! I am afraid of what Yahweh will ask me to do!

Ask the person playing Eliab, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- How did Yahweh choose David, the youngest son? I am so angry! or
- What is wrong with me? I am the strongest, the oldest, and the best fighter; or
- This is so unfair. I cannot follow my youngest brother!

Continue the drama. Then the Spirit of Yahweh came upon David powerfully from that day forward. Samuel got up, left, and went to Ramah.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel is sad that Saul disobeyed **Yahweh**. Yahweh tells Samuel to stop grieving because Yahweh has rejected Saul as **king** over **Israel**. Yahweh is God's personal and proper name. A king is a ruler over a region. Israel is the land that Yahweh gave to Jacob's descendants and the people who live in that land. Use the same words for Yahweh, king, and Israel that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, king, and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh tells Samuel to take Samuel's **horn** of **oil**, go to **Bethlehem** to Jesse, and anoint one of Jesse's sons. Yahweh had chosen one of Jesse's sons as Yahweh's king. Samuel asks Yahweh how Samuel can go to Bethlehem because Saul will try to put Samuel to death. Yahweh tells Samuel to take a heifer, or a female cow, with Samuel in order to **sacrifice** the heifer. Yahweh tells Samuel to invite Jesse and Jesse's sons to the sacrifice and to anoint the son that Yahweh tells Samuel to **anoint**. A horn of oil was a ram's horn that held oil that people used to anoint a person. Bethlehem is the birthplace of David, a town not far from Jerusalem. A sacrifice is a gift, usually an animal, that people offered to Yahweh. To anoint is to pour a sweet-smelling oil over someone or something, usually to appoint that person or thing for a special task. Use the same words for horn, oil, Bethlehem, sacrifice, and anoint that you have used in previous passages. For more information on horn, Bethlehem, sacrifice, and anoint, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel goes to Bethlehem with a heifer and tells the **elders**, as well as Jesse, to **consecrate** themselves and come to the sacrifice. Elders are older men who have authority in a community. To consecrate is to set something or someone apart for God and to make the person or thing clean. Use the same words for elders and consecrate that you have used in previous passages. For more information on elders and consecrate, refer to the Master Glossary.

The elders ask Samuel if Samuel has come in **peace**. Use the same word or phrase for peace that you have used previously, and see the Master Glossary for more information about peace.

Jesse and Jesse's sons arrive at the sacrifice. When they enter, Samuel assumes that Samuel is going to anoint Eliab, Jesse's oldest son. However, Yahweh tells Samuel not to look at the outward appearance because Yahweh looks at the **heart**. The Israelites spoke about the heart as the place where a person's emotions and decisions

came from. Use the same word for heart that you have used in previous passages where heart means the same thing. For more information on heart, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel asks Jesse if Jesse has any other sons. So Jesse has someone bring in Jesse's youngest son, David. Samuel takes the horn of oil and anoints David. Then the **Spirit of Yahweh** comes upon David powerfully from that day forward. Use the same word or phrase for "Spirit of Yahweh" that you have used in previous passages. Although this story talks specifically about the Spirit of Yahweh, you can listen to more information about God's Spirit by referring to Holy Spirit in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what name you will use for **David**. Look up David in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this name in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 16:1–13

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (543 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (749 KB)

1 Samuel 16:14–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 16:14–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:14–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:14–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story follows when Samuel anointed David to become the new king in place of Saul. We see in the previous story that Yahweh's spirit has come with power to David. In this story, we hear that Yahweh's Spirit departed from Saul, and Yahweh sent a spirit that does evil to terrify and torment Saul. We see that Yahweh's favor, or Yahweh's Spirit, had left Saul and had come to David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture know that God, or their deity, is present with their leaders? Pause this audio here.

In ancient cultures, people often played music to help relieve people's sadness. Some cultures believed that the lyre instrument could chase away demons. Saul's servants told Saul that God had sent a spirit that does evil to torment Saul. The servants called Saul their master, and the servants asked Saul to command the servants to search for someone who plays the lyre. That person could play when the spirit of evil bothered Saul, and then Saul could feel better.

Stop here and look as a group at a picture of a lyre. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your culture use music? When do you use music, and what kinds of musical instruments do you use for different types of events? Pause this audio here.

Saul told his servants to find someone who plays the lyre well and to bring that person to Saul. One of the servants told Saul that a son of Jesse from the town of Bethlehem knows how to play the lyre. Jesse was an important man in Bethlehem, and the servant says that David plays the lyre skillfully. The servant also says that David is a man of valor, or a courageous man. David is a warrior. This is the first time we hear of David being a courageous warrior, but it is possible that David fought wild animals as a shepherd when David was protecting his sheep. Most importantly, the servant tells Saul that Yahweh is with David. This means that Yahweh helps David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, what kinds of servants or helpers do your rulers have? What kinds of things do those servants do to help the ruler? When a leader is looking for a helper, what qualities does the leader look for in a helper? Pause this audio here.

So Saul sent messengers to Jesse to send Jesse's son David, who was a shepherd, to Saul. Jesse sent David to Saul along with a young goat, a donkey loaded with bread, and a wineskin full of wine. Wine and bread were traditional food and drink, and in this case Jesse was giving these things as a gift to king Saul. People often carried wine in an animal's skin.

Stop here and look at a photo of a donkey, a young goat, and a wineskin. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of food, drink, crops, or livestock would you give as a gift to a ruler in your culture? Pause this audio here.

David served Saul, and Saul loved David very much. Sometimes, a king and a servant would be loyal to each other like friends. David was so special to Saul that David even became one of the men who carried Saul's armor and weapons during a battle. Saul sent a messenger to ask Jesse to let David stay in Saul's service because Saul liked

1 Samuel 16:14–23

David so much. And whenever the spirit from God tormented Saul, David would play the lyre. Then Saul would feel better, and the spirit would go away.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:14–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh's Spirit had left Saul, and Yahweh sent a spirit that did evil to torment Saul.

In the second scene: Saul's servants told Saul that an evil spirit from God was tormenting Saul. Saul told his officers to find someone who plays the lyre well and to bring that person to Saul. One of the servants told Saul that one of Jesse's sons from Bethlehem knows how to play. So Saul sent messengers to Jesse to send Jesse's son David, who was a shepherd, to Saul.

In the third scene: Jesse sent David to Saul along with a young goat, a donkey loaded with bread, and a wineskin full of wine.

In the fourth scene: David served Saul, and Saul loved David very much. David became Saul's armor bearer. Saul asked Jesse to let David stay in Saul's service because Saul liked David so much. And whenever the spirit from God tormented Saul, David would play the lyre. Then Saul would feel better, and the spirit would go away.

The characters in this passage are:

- Spirit of Yahweh, or Spirit of God
- King Saul
- Spirit that does evil things
- Saul's servants
- Yahweh
- Messengers who take messages to Saul and Jesse
- Jesse
- And David, Jesse's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story happens sometime after Samuel anoints David as the next king. Saul is likely still at Saul's home in Gibeah when this story happens.

Yahweh's spirit had left Saul, and instead, Yahweh sent a spirit that did evil things and tormented Saul. This spirit probably made Saul very afraid. It seems as though this spirit torments Saul often and is not a one-time event.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about Yahweh's spirit leaving Saul and then Yahweh sending another spirit that does evil things to Saul? In your culture, what kinds of things do evil spirits do to people? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about this evil spirit from Yahweh? We know that Yahweh sent this spirit and that this spirit did evil things to Saul. Pause this audio here.

Saul's servants want Saul to pay attention to what they say to Saul. The servants tell Saul that it is an evil spirit that is causing Saul this trouble. When the servants come to Saul, the servants refer to Saul as "our lord" or "our master," even though the servants are talking to Saul. The servants refer to themselves as "your servants," or "his servants," even though they are talking about themselves.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do servants respectfully come to talk to a leader? How do the servants get the leader's attention? How do the servants address the leader, and how do the servants talk about themselves to the leader? Pause this audio here.

The servants politely ask Saul to tell the servants to find someone who plays the lyre, or small harp, well. Then, whenever the evil spirit torments Saul, the person can play the lyre and Saul will feel better.

Saul tells the servants to find someone who plays the lyre well. One of the servants suggests Jesse's son because this son is brave and a good fighter. The servant describes Jesse's son as someone who speaks well or wisely. The son is also handsome, and Yahweh is with the son.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say that Yahweh is with Jesse's son? Remember that this means that everyone can see that Yahweh favors and does good things for David. Pause this audio here.

Saul sends messengers to Jesse to bring David from watching the sheep to serve Saul. So Jesse sends David with a donkey, a lot of bread, a wineskin of wine, and a young goat.

David comes to serve Saul. Saul likes David. David becomes one of Saul's armor-bearers, or a person who carries the armor and the weapons into battle. After this, Saul sends a message to Jesse to allow David to remain in Saul's service. Notice that messengers are going back and forth between Saul and Jesse. Saul and Jesse are speaking directly with each other. Saul asks Jesse for David to continue to "stand before" Saul. This means that Saul wants David to continue to serve Saul. Saul says that David has found favor in "his sight." This means that Saul likes David very much.

Whenever the evil spirit from Yahweh comes on Saul, David plays the lyre. Then the evil spirit leaves Saul, and Saul feels relieved.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:14–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Spirit of Yahweh, or Spirit of God
- King Saul
- Spirit that does evil things
- Saul's servants
- Yahweh
- Messengers who take messages to Saul and Jesse
- Jesse
- And David, Jesse's son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Yahweh's Spirit had left Saul, and Yahweh sent an evil spirit to torment Saul. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel tormented; or
- I feel scared; or
- I am terrified!

Continue the drama. Saul's servants told Saul that an evil spirit from God was tormenting Saul. The servants said to Saul, "Let our master command us to search for someone who plays the lyre. He will play when the evil spirit from God comes upon you, and you will feel better." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the servants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have heard that music will help with evil spirits, so I hope this works; or
- I hope we can find someone quickly. I feel bad for Saul; or
- I am very afraid of Saul when the evil spirit torments Saul; or
- I never want this to happen to me!

Continue the drama. Saul told his officers to find someone who plays the lyre well and to bring that person to Saul. One of the servants told Saul that a son of Jesse of Bethlehem knows how to play. This servant describes the son as brave and a warrior. The son speaks well and is fine-looking. Yahweh is with the son. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope this works! or
- I should have listened to Yahweh and Samuel! or
- Why would Yahweh allow this to happen?

Continue the drama. So Saul sent messengers to Jesse to send Jesse's son David, who was a shepherd, to Saul. Jesse sent David to Saul along with a young goat, a donkey loaded with bread, and a wineskin full of wine. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jesse, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very afraid for my son David! or
- I am happy to help Yahweh's king.

Continue the drama. David served Saul, and Saul loved David very much. David became Saul's armor-bearer. Saul asked Jesse to let David continue to serve Saul because Saul liked David so much. And whenever the spirit from God tormented Saul, David would play the lyre. Then Saul would feel better, and the spirit would go away. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What an honor to serve the king; or
- I am glad I can help the king feel better when the king is unwell; or
- Samuel just anointed me. What if King Saul gets jealous of me? Does King Saul know that Samuel anointed me?

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 16:14–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Yahweh's Spirit had left Saul, and Yahweh sent an evil spirit to torment or make Saul afraid. Yahweh is God's personal and proper name. Yahweh's Spirit is the power of God. Use the same word for Yahweh and Yahweh's Spirit that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh and Yahweh's Spirit, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **torment**. When someone torments someone else, that person does evil things to the other person to make the other person afraid. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate an **evil spirit** from Yahweh. This is a spirit that Yahweh has sent to torment Saul. Because Yahweh created all spirits, Yahweh can tell any spirit what to do. Although we do not fully understand what this evil spirit does, you may refer to the Master Glossary for evil spirit, and use the same words or phrases for evil spirit that you have used in other books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

Saul's **servants** told Saul that an evil spirit from **God** was tormenting Saul. These servants were probably officials in Saul's government. You may translate servant as "official" if you would like. See servant and God in the Master Glossary for more information.

The servants said to Saul, "Let our **lord** command us to search for someone who plays the **lyre**." A lord is someone who is a master over another person. A lyre is a stringed musical instrument similar to a small harp. Use the same words for lord and lyre that you have used in previous passages. For more information on lord, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look at a picture of a lyre as a group again if necessary. What word will you use for this musical instrument? Pause this audio here.

Saul told his officers to find someone who plays the lyre well and to bring that person to Saul. One of the servants told Saul that a son of Jesse of **Bethlehem** knows how to play. Bethlehem is in the Master Glossary.

So Saul sent messengers to Jesse to send Jesse's son **David**, who was a **shepherd**, to Saul. Jesse sent David to Saul along with a young goat, a **donkey** loaded with bread, and a wineskin full of **wine**. David was Jesse's youngest son and became the second king of Israel. A shepherd is a person who takes care of sheep and goats. Use the same words for David, shepherd, donkey, and wine that you have used in previous passages. For more information on David, shepherd, donkey, and wine, refer to the Master Glossary.

So David served Saul, and Saul loved David very much. David became Saul's armor-bearer. Use the same word for armor-bearer that you have used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 16:14–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (554 KB)
- Setting the Stage (1.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (1.9 MB)

- Filling the Gaps (1.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (754 KB)

1 Samuel 17:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 17:1–11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:1–11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, the prophet Samuel anointed David as the next king of Israel. Then, David served King Saul in Saul's court by playing soothing music when Saul felt upset because the evil spirit came on Saul.

In this passage, the Philistines attack the Israelites again. You will remember from previous passages that the Philistines were enemies of Israel who worshiped idols. The Philistines gather their armies for war against Israel. This means that the whole Philistine army gets ready to fight against the Israelite army.

The Philistine army gathers at the town of Sokoh, which is in Judah, to the west of Bethlehem, in the direction of the Philistine territory. The Philistines camp at the town of Ephes Dammim, which is between Sokoh and Azekah. The people in this city allow travelers to use the main road through the Valley of Elah. We do not know exactly where Ephes Dammim is located, but it was probably on the southern slope of the Valley of Elah. The Valley of Elah runs from Bethlehem west towards the Philistine cities of Gath and Ekron.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Sokoh, Ephes Dammim, Azekah, Elah, Gath, and Ekron. Pause this audio here.

Saul and the Israelite army gather together and probably camp on the northern slope of the Valley of Elah. The Philistines may attack Israel at this place because it is the easiest place for the Philistines to get into Israelite territory.

The Philistine army and the Israelite army draw up their battle lines. This means that each army stands in a line to prepare for battle. The armies face each other on opposite hills, and the Valley of Elah is between the armies. A valley is a narrow gorge or ravine that water has created as it flows through the land between two hills.

Stop here and look at a picture of a valley in between two hills as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do you prepare soldiers for battle? What kinds of formations do your soldiers use when they fight? How do soldiers choose where to do battle with an enemy? Pause this audio here.

From the battle line of the Philistine army, a champion comes out. A champion is someone who steps out to fight between two battle lines of opposing armies. This champion's name is Goliath. Goliath is from Gath, which is an important Philistine city on the southern border.

Goliath is extremely tall. Goliath is six cubits and a span tall. A cubit measures the space between the tip of a man's middle finger and that man's elbow. A span measures the space between a man's thumb and the tip of the man's little finger when the man stretches them as far apart as he can. A cubit is about 45 centimeters, and a span is about 22 centimeters. This means that Goliath is nearly three meters tall.

Goliath wears armor. Armor is a metal covering that soldiers wear to protect their bodies. The armor covers almost all of Goliath's body except for his face. The armor Goliath wears is made of bronze and weighs 5,000 shekels, which is about 57 kilograms. Goliath wears a bronze helmet and scale armor covering his chest, back, and stomach. People made the scale armor from scales that overlapped one another. Goliath has bronze greaves or coverings that fit over his shins to protect Goliath's legs. Goliath carries a javelin made of bronze on his back. A javelin could have been a light, short spear that warriors could throw at an enemy, or it could have been more like a scimitar, which is a short sword with a curved blade that is sharp on the outside of the blade. The shaft or long wooden handle of Goliath's weapon is very big, like the crossbar of a weaver's beam in that culture. The tip or metal point of the spear or scimitar, which people made from iron, weighs 600 shekels or about 7 kilograms. Goliath also has a large shield that covers his entire body. A man walks in front of Goliath to carry the large shield.

Stop here and look at a picture of a man wearing armor, including a helmet, scale armor over his chest, and greaves over his shins. Look at a picture of a javelin, a picture of a scimitar, and a picture of a weaver's beam to see how big the shaft of Goliath's weapon was. Look at a picture of a man carrying a large shield. Pause this audio here.

Goliath comes out of the battle line of the Philistines and begins to shout insults to the Israelite army. Goliath begins to ask the Israelite army questions. Goliath does not want answers to these questions. Goliath uses his questions to insult the Israelite army. Goliath asks why the Israelites have lined up for battle because Goliath is a champion of the Philistines, but the Israelite army are only servants. Goliath wants to make a point that the Israelites are servants of Saul. Goliath demands that Israel send one man down into the valley to fight Goliath to decide the ending of the entire war. In ancient times, it was common for two armies to each send a champion to fight one another. This fight between two individuals would determine which army won the battle. If the Israelite champion won, then the Philistine soldiers would be slaves to the Israelites. But if Goliath won, then the Israelite soldiers would be slaves to the Philistines.

Goliath challenges the Israelite army and demands again that Israel send one man to fight Goliath. Goliath taunts the Israelite army and shows that he hates the Israelites and does not respect them. When Saul and all the Israelite army hear Goliath's shout, the men do not see any way to defeat Goliath and become dismayed and terrified.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The Philistine and Israelite armies gather on opposite sides of the Valley of Elah. The armies stand in their battle lines and face one another.

In the second scene: The Philistine champion Goliath steps into the valley between the two armies. Goliath is very tall and wears heavy armor that protects his entire body except his face. Goliath also carries a large sword and follows behind a man who carries a shield that protects Goliath.

In the third scene: Goliath shouts at the Israelite army. Goliath makes fun of the Israelites for even trying to fight the Philistines and demands that the Israelites send a champion to fight Goliath. This fight will decide who wins the battle between the Philistines and Israelites. If the Israelites win, then the Philistines will be the Israelites' servants, but if the Philistines win, then the Israelites will have to serve the Philistines. Saul and the Israelite soldiers are dismayed and afraid.

The characters in this passage are:

- Philistine army
- Israelite army
- King Saul
- And Goliath

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the Philistine army approaches Israel's territory to fight the Israelite army. The Philistines gather their armies for war. To gather armies for war means to gather soldiers together and prepare to fight. The Philistines draw up battle lines. This means the Philistines line up in battle formation on one side of the Valley of Elah. Saul and the Israelite army line up on the opposite side of the Valley of Elah. The armies face one another.

Stop here and look at a picture of a valley between two hills. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you describe the valley between the hills and the two armies that have gathered for war? Why do you think the Philistine army may have chosen this spot to prepare to fight the Israelites? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, Goliath moves from the Philistine battle line into the valley between the armies. Goliath is almost three meters tall and wears bronze armor that covers his entire body. Goliath has a helmet, scale armor covering his stomach and back, and greaves that cover Goliath's legs from his knees to his feet. The only part of Goliath without armor is Goliath's face. Goliath's armor is very heavy. Altogether, the armor weighs about 57 kilograms.

Goliath also carries a huge javelin or scimitar on Goliath's back. The shaft of the javelin is so thick that it looks like a weaver's beam. A weaver's beam was a strong, long, rounded wooden pole that people used at the top of a loom to hold all the threads. A weaver's beam would have been very thick and sturdy. This comparison helps us to understand just how big Goliath's weapon is. The iron point of the javelin weighs close to 7 kilograms. Along with all of Goliath's protective armor, Goliath has a man in front of Goliath whose job is to carry a shield that protects Goliath's entire body.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you describe the size of things in your culture? If you do not have weaver's beams, what kinds of objects do you have that would be a good comparison here? How will you describe how tall Goliath was and how heavy his armor and weapons were? Pause this audio here.

Look at a picture of a man wearing armor like Goliath. Look at a picture of a javelin, a picture of a scimitar, and a picture of a large shield. Tell a story about a soldier who is so large that it looks like no one could defeat that soldier. What language do you use to describe this very strong soldier? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, Goliath begins to shout at Saul and the Israelite soldiers. Goliath says, "Why have you bothered to line up for battle?" Goliath is saying, "I am a soldier and a champion, but all of you are only servants. I am a Philistine, and I am ready to fight you, servants of Saul. So choose a soldier to represent you and send that soldier to fight me. If that soldier wins and kills me, then my people will be your slaves. But if I win and kill your soldier, then you will become our slaves and serve us."

Goliath continues to shout at the Israelites, "Today I challenge you, Israelite soldiers! Choose one of your soldiers and send him to fight me!" When the Israelites hear Goliath's taunts, Saul and the Israelite soldiers are greatly afraid and do not believe they can defeat Goliath.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone made fun of an enemy. How do you describe one person taunting another? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

1 Samuel 17:1–11

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Philistine army
- Israelite army
- King Saul
- And Goliath

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The Philistines gather their army for battle and camp at Ephes Dammim between Sokoh and Azekah. King Saul and the Israelite army gather and camp in the Valley of Elah. The Philistine and Israelite armies face each other on opposite hills with the Valley of Elah in the middle. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Philistine army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are confident that our army is greater and we can attack Israel and win; or
- We take pride in knowing our champion is bigger and stronger than the men in Israel.

Continue the drama. The Philistine champion Goliath of Gath steps forward from the Philistine soldiers' battle line. Goliath is close to three meters tall and wears bronze armor from the helmet on Goliath's head to the chain mail around Goliath's stomach and back to the greaves that cover Goliath's legs from his knees to his feet. Goliath's armor weighs almost 57 kilograms. Goliath also has a huge javelin on Goliath's back. The javelin's shaft is so thick it looks like a weaver's beam, and the javelin's point is made of iron and weighs about seven kilograms. Goliath has a man in front of him who carries a large shield that protects Goliath almost completely. The only part of Goliath that is not covered by armor is Goliath's face. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Goliath, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am confident that my armor will protect me from any weapon the Israelites might have; or
- I take pride in knowing I am a great champion and am not afraid to fight the Israelites.

Ask the people playing the Israelite army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Goliath is so intimidating in his big, heavy armor and with his huge shield! We could never defeat Goliath! or
- We do not know how to respond to a great champion like Goliath and just want to stay silent; or
- We are not sure Yahweh can protect us from this great champion; or
- We are angry and disappointed that Yahweh has not yet saved us!

Continue the drama. Goliath begins to shout at the Israelite army. Goliath taunts the Israelites and asks, "Why did you bother to line up for battle? I am a Philistine, but you only serve Saul. Send me a soldier who can fight me! If that soldier wins and kills me, my people will be your slaves. But if I win and kill that soldier, then you will be our slaves and serve us." Goliath continues to taunt the Israelites and shout, "I challenge the armies of Israel today! Send me a man to fight me!" When Saul and the Israelites hear Goliath, they are dismayed and terrified. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I would like to send someone to fight Goliath, but I have no soldiers who can do that. We would become slaves to the Philistines! or

- I am afraid that we will never be able to defeat the Philistines as long as the Philistines have champions like Goliath.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The Philistines gathered their armies for war and camped at Ephes Dammim. The **Philistines** were a group of people who were enemies of Israel and worshiped idols. Use the same word for Philistines as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines camped on one **hill** of the **Valley** of Elah, and the Israelites camped on the opposite hill. A hill is a naturally raised area of land that is not as tall as a mountain. A valley is a narrow ravine that water created as the water flowed through the land between two hills. Use the same words or phrases for hill and valley as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and again look at a picture of a valley between two hills as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

A champion named Goliath stepped out from the Philistine army. A champion was someone who stepped out to fight between two battle lines of opposing armies. A champion represented an entire army. Champions would often fight to determine the outcome of battles instead of having entire armies fight each other.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **champion**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Goliath tells the Israelites that whoever wins in battle against Goliath will become the **servant** of the other army. If the Israelites won, the Philistines would be the Israelites' servants, but if the Philistines won, then the Israelites would have to be servants to the Philistines. A servant is a man or woman who works for another man or woman. A servant usually has a low position in the community. Use the same word for servant as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Goliath was six cubits and a span tall. A cubit was a measure of the distance between the tip of a man's middle finger and that man's elbow. A span was a measure of the distance between a man's thumb and the tip of that man's little finger when the man stretched them as far apart as he could. A cubit measured about 45 centimeters, and a span measured about 22 centimeters.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for **cubit** and **span**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words you have used there. For more information on cubit and span, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Goliath wore armor. Armor was a metal covering to protect a soldier in battle. Goliath wore a helmet, scale armor, and greaves that people had made of bronze. A man also carried a shield in front of Goliath. A helmet was a covering that protected a soldier's head. Scale armor was metal plates that people tied together with leather straps. Scale armor covered a soldier's chest and back. Greaves were metal coverings over a soldier's calf that may have been lined inside with leather for comfort. A shield was a large plate of metal that the soldier or another person carried in front of the soldier to protect almost all of the soldier's body.

Stop here and look at a picture of armor, including a helmet, scale armor, and greaves. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **helmet**, **scale armor**, **greaves**, and **shield**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Goliath's armor was very heavy. The armor weighed 5,000 shekels or 57 kilograms. The tip of Goliath's weapon weighed 600 shekels or about 7 kilograms. A **shekel** is a unit of measurement. One shekel is about 11.4 grams. Use the same word for shekel as you used in previous passages. For more information on shekel, refer to the Master Glossary.

1 Samuel 17:1–11

Goliath carried a javelin on Goliath's back. A javelin may have been a light, short spear that someone could throw at an enemy, or it could have been more like a scimitar, which is a short sword with a curved blade that is sharp on the outside of the blade.

Stop here and look at a picture of a javelin and a picture of a scimitar as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **javelin**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Goliath walked behind Goliath's shield-bearer. A person who was a shield-bearer carried a large shield in front of another soldier.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **shield-bearer**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When King Saul and the Israelite army heard Goliath's taunts, the Israelites shook and were very afraid.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 17:1–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (470 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (688 KB)

1 Samuel 17:12–19

1 Samuel 17:12–19

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 17:12–19 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:12–19 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:12–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, the Israelite army and the Philistine army lined up to face each other to prepare for battle in the Valley of Elah. A champion named Goliath stepped out from the Philistine army to challenge the Israelite army to send their own champion to fight Goliath. Goliath was tall and wore heavy armor to protect Goliath. Saul and the Israelite army were terrified.

In this passage, the storyteller begins by interrupting the story about Goliath to talk about David. Even though we learned about David in a previous passage, here the storyteller talks about David again and gives more information. You will remember David from previous passages. Earlier in 1 Samuel, the prophet Samuel anointed David to be the next king after Saul. David then served King Saul by playing the harp to calm Saul.

David's father was Jesse, who was an Ephrathite. This means that Jesse was from Bethlehem in Judah. People sometimes called Bethlehem, and the area around Bethlehem, Ephrathah, and people living in that area Ephrathites. This also means that Jesse was from the ancestral tribe of Judah. Jesse was already an old man when Saul was king, and Jesse had eight sons. Jesse's oldest three sons were Eliab, the oldest, Abinadab, the second-born, and Shammah, the third-born. These three sons followed King Saul into war against the Philistine army.

David, however, was Jesse's youngest son. David also served King Saul, but instead of remaining with King Saul and Saul's army at their camp, David traveled back and forth between Saul's army and Bethlehem, where David took care of David's father's sheep.

Stop here and look at a map that shows both Bethlehem and the Valley of Elah as a group. Look at a picture of sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do younger brothers usually do in families in your culture? What are those younger brothers' responsibilities? Pause this audio here.

Now, the author very briefly goes back to the story about Goliath. At the same time that David was traveling back and forth between the battle lines and Bethlehem, Goliath continued to challenge the Israelites. For about 40 days, the Philistine champion Goliath stepped in front of the Philistine army in the morning and in the evening, and Goliath challenged and laughed at the Israelite soldiers. Goliath may not have done this for exactly 40 days, but at least for many days.

The author then goes back to telling about David. One day, while the Israelite and Philistine armies still faced one another, Jesse told David to hurry and take an ephah of roasted grain and 10 loaves of bread to David's brothers in the army camp. An ephah was a way to measure dry substances like grain. An ephah was between 13 and 23 kilograms. This roasted grain was probably wheat or barley. Roasted grain and loaves of bread were common foods for the Israelite people to eat at that time. Jesse also told David to take 10 pieces of cheese to

the commanders of David's brothers' unit. Cheese is a solid food that people make from milk. The commander of the unit was probably the brothers' commanding officer, the person in charge of their group of soldiers.

Stop here and look at a picture of roasted grain, a picture of a loaf of bread, and a picture of a piece of cheese as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss as a group: Why do you think it was important for David to bring this type of food to the commanding officer? What kinds of food do people in your culture eat during a battle or when they are in the army? Pause this audio here.

Jesse told David to hurry and see how David's brothers were doing, and to bring back news about the brothers. Jesse wanted to know that Jesse's sons were well. Jesse either wanted David to bring back good news about David's brothers, or Jesse may have wanted David to bring Jesse a token or physical sign that the brothers had received the food and were safe and well. David's brothers were in the Valley of Elah with King Saul and Saul's soldiers fighting against the Philistine army.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture receive news about their families during a battle or war?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:12–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Jesse, an Ephrathite man from Bethlehem, had eight sons. Jesse's three oldest sons, Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah, followed King Saul to war with the Philistines. Jesse's youngest son was David. While Jesse's oldest sons stayed with King Saul, David traveled back and forth from the battle lines to Bethlehem to take care of David's father's sheep.

In the second scene: Meanwhile, the Philistine champion Goliath comes out from the battle line every morning and evening for about 40 days. When Goliath steps forward, Goliath challenges the Israelite army to send a man to fight against Goliath.

In the third scene: One day, Jesse tells David to quickly take an ephah of roasted grain along with 10 loaves of bread to David's brothers. Jesse also sends 10 pieces of cheese for David to give to the commander of David's brothers' unit. Jesse wants David to deliver the food, find out if David's brothers are well, and bring back a confirmation or token to prove that the brothers are well. David's brothers are with King Saul and Saul's army in the Valley of Elah, fighting against the Philistines.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jesse
- Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah
- David
- Goliath
- The Israelite army
- And the commander of the brothers' unit

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the storyteller interrupts the story about Goliath that began in a previous passage. Now the storyteller will tell more about Jesse and David. Jesse is an Ephrathite from Bethlehem. Jesse is already an old man when Saul is king, and Jesse has eight sons. Jesse's oldest three sons, Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah, fight in King Saul's army. These three sons have followed King Saul into battle against the Philistines. Jesse's youngest son is David. Although David serves King Saul, David travels back and forth between the battle lines and Bethlehem, where David takes care of Jesse's sheep.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where the action moves between different characters but happens all at the same time. How do you make sure your audience understands that, even though each character is acting in a different place, everything is happening at the same time and is all part of the same story? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, at the same time that David travels back and forth from the battle lines to Bethlehem, the Philistine champion Goliath continues to challenge the Israelite army on a regular basis. Goliath steps out from the battle line and challenges the Israelites to send someone to fight against Goliath every morning and evening for about 40 days.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story in which there seems to be no solution to a problem. How do you show how it feels not to know the solution to the problem? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, Jesse gives David an ephah, or between 13 and 23 kilograms, of roasted or parched grain. If you would like, you can just say that Jesse gave David a bag of roasted grain. Jesse also gave David 10 loaves of bread and 10 pieces of cheese to take to the commander of David's brothers' unit. Jesse tells David, "Go quickly and take this food to your brothers. Find out if your brothers are well and bring back a token to prove to me that they received the food and are alright." Jesse may want David just to bring back good news, or Jesse may want a physical sign that David's brothers are well. The brothers are with King Saul and Saul's army in the Valley of Elah, fighting against the Philistines. We do not know if Jesse actually tells David where David's brothers are, or if this is a summary the storyteller gives to let the audience know where the brothers are located.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people who are far apart communicate with one another in your culture? How do you carry messages and bring back news? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:12–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jesse
- Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah
- David
- Goliath
- The Israelite army
- And the commander of the brothers' unit

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Jesse is an Ephrathite from Bethlehem. Jesse is already an old man when King Saul begins to rule. Jesse has eight sons. Jesse's three oldest sons, Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah, fight in King Saul's army. These sons followed

1 Samuel 17:12–19

King Saul to the Valley of Elah to fight against the Philistines. Jesse's youngest son is David. While Jesse's oldest sons stay with King Saul to fight, David travels back and forth from the battle lines to Bethlehem, where David takes care of Jesse's sheep. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are proud to fight for King Saul! or
- We know being a soldier is an important job; or
- We are more important than our little brother, who just takes care of sheep.

Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know I am too young to fight, but I will keep serving King Saul; or
- I get tired of going back and forth, but I know that both serving King Saul and taking care of my father's sheep are important jobs.

Continue the drama. While David travels back and forth, the Philistine champion Goliath continues to taunt the Israelite army. Every morning and evening for about 40 days, Goliath steps in front of the Philistine battle line and demands that the Israelite army send someone to fight Goliath. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Goliath, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know the Israelites are terrified of me and will never fight me; or
- I believe defeating the Israelites will be easy because the Philistine army and I are so strong and mighty.

Ask the people playing the Israelite army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are losing hope that Yahweh will intervene and defeat this champion; or
- We are terrified of Goliath and do not know what to do.

Continue the drama. One day, Jesse gives David an ephah of roasted grain and 10 loaves of bread. Jesse wants David to hurry to the battle line and give the food to David's brothers. Jesse also gives David 10 pieces of cheese for David to deliver to the commander of David's brothers' unit. Jesse tells David, "Take these to your brothers and bring back news about them. Bring me a token so I know your brothers received the food and are well." David's brothers were with King Saul and Saul's army in the Valley of Elah, fighting against the Philistines. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jesse, "What are you feeling and thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am concerned about my sons and want to make sure their needs are met; or
- I want to make sure the commander of my sons' unit takes good care of my sons.

Ask the person playing the commander of the unit, "What are you feeling and thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am terrified of Goliath and glad to get some food; or
- I will take special care of these men because I know David will visit again.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:12–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jesse had eight sons, and **David** was Jesse's youngest son. David would become the second king of Israel. For more information on David, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for David as you used in previous passages.

David's father, Jesse, was an Ephrathite. An Ephrathite was a person from Bethlehem or the towns right around Bethlehem. Ephrathites came from the tribe of Judah in Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Ephrathite**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jesse was from **Bethlehem**, a small village in Judah. For more information on Bethlehem, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for Bethlehem as you used in previous passages.

1 Samuel 17:12–19

Jesse's three oldest sons fought with King Saul against the Philistines, but Jesse's youngest son, David, traveled back and forth between the battle line and the place where David cared for his father's sheep in Bethlehem.

The **Philistine** Goliath stepped out every morning and evening to challenge and laugh at the Israelites and to demand that the Israelites send someone to fight against Goliath. The Philistines are a people group who were constantly at war against the Israelites. The Philistines lived in the southwest part of Israel by the Mediterranean Sea. Use the same word for Philistine as you used in previous passages.

Jesse told David to take an **ephah** of roasted grain and 10 loaves of bread to David's brothers. An ephah is a dry measure equal to approximately 13 to 23 kilograms. Use the same word or phrase for ephah as you used in previous passages. For more information on ephah, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jesse also sent 10 pieces of cheese with David to give to the **commander** of David's brothers' unit. The commander of a unit was a military officer in charge of a particular group of soldiers. Use the same word for commander as you used in previous passages.

Cheese is a food that people make from milk.

Stop here and look at a picture of pieces of cheese. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cheese**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jesse told David to take the food to David's brothers and to bring back news or a token from the brothers. A token was a physical sign that the brothers were well. A token would give Jesse assurance or confirmation that Jesse's sons were alive and well.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **token** or assurance. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 17:12–19

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (451 KB)

- Setting the Stage (2.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (697 KB)

1 Samuel 17:20–30

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 17:20–30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:20–30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, David traveled back and forth between the Israelite army camp and the town of Bethlehem to take care of his father Jesse's sheep. One day, Jesse told David to quickly go to the camp and take some food to David's brothers. Jesse wanted David to find out if David's brothers were doing well.

Early the next morning, David left another shepherd in charge of the sheep and hurried toward the camp with the food, just as Jesse had instructed David. David arrived at the camp as the soldiers were leaving to line up in their battle positions. The Israelite army shouted the war cry to show that the battle was about to begin as they lined up in battle formation. The Israelite and Philistine armies lined up to face each other in preparation for battle.

Stop here and look at a map that includes Bethlehem and the army camp at the Valley of Elah. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture know when a battle is about to begin? Pause this audio here.

David left the food David had brought with the man who took care of the supplies for the army. Then David ran to greet his brothers in the battle line. While David spoke with his brothers, suddenly the Philistine champion Goliath from Gath stepped out in front of the Philistine battle line. Goliath made fun of the Israelites and made his usual challenge as he had been doing day after day. This time, David heard what Goliath said. When all the other Israelite soldiers heard Goliath, they ran from Goliath because the soldiers were so afraid.

The Israelite soldiers talked among themselves about how Goliath kept coming up the hill towards the Israelite army to challenge them. The Israelites discussed how King Saul had promised to give any man who killed Goliath great riches as a reward. The king had also promised to give the king's daughter as a wife to any Israelite who killed Goliath. The family of the man who killed Goliath would be free in Israel. This means that man's descendants and servants would not have to pay taxes or fulfill any other obligations to serve the king.

1 Samuel 17:20–30

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of rewards do people receive for defeating enemies in your culture? Pause this audio here.

David turned to the men who were next to David and asked what would be done for the man who killed Goliath and removed the disgrace from Israel. Goliath brought disgrace, or shame, to Israel because Goliath dared to go against God and God's people. David asked, "Who does this uncircumcised Philistine think he is to mock or defy the army of the living God?" Circumcision was a sign that a man was included in the covenant God made with Abraham. Goliath was uncircumcised because Goliath was not one of God's people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where someone brings shame on a person or group of people. Pause this audio here.

The soldiers around David repeated the information about what the king had promised to the man who would kill Goliath. When Eliab, David's oldest brother, overheard David talking with the soldiers, Eliab's anger burned against David. This means that Eliab was very angry with David. Eliab asked David why David came to the camp and who was taking care of the few sheep that were David's responsibility. Eliab called David proud and devious and accused David of coming to the camp only so David could watch the battle.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone was very angry with someone else because they thought that person was irresponsible or proud. Pause this audio here.

But David replied to Eliab, "I have not done anything wrong. Can I not even speak?" David turned away from Eliab and continued to ask other soldiers what people might do for the man who was brave enough to kill Goliath. Every soldier David asked confirmed the information David had already heard.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Early in the morning, David leaves another shepherd in charge of David's sheep and hurries to the army camp with the food. David arrives just as the Israelite and Philistine armies are lining up to face each other for battle. David leaves the food with the man who keeps supplies and runs to greet David's brothers in the battle line.

In the second scene: Suddenly, Goliath, the Philistine champion from Gath, steps out of the line of the Philistine army. Goliath taunts the Israelite army as he has been doing day after day. This time, David hears Goliath's challenge. The Israelite soldiers are so afraid of Goliath that the soldiers flee in terror.

In the third scene: The Israelite soldiers talk amongst themselves about Goliath and what King Saul has promised to give the man who kills Goliath. The king has promised to give great wealth, a daughter in marriage, and freedom to the man's family.

In the fourth scene: David turns to the soldiers next to David and asks what people will do for the man who kills Goliath and removes Goliath's disgrace from Israel. David asks how Goliath, a man who is not one of God's people, could dare to defy the armies of the living God. The soldiers tell David what King Saul has promised.

In the fifth scene: David's oldest brother Eliab overhears David asking about rewards for killing Goliath, and Eliab's anger burns against David. Eliab calls David proud and devious and accuses David of coming to the camp only to watch the battle. David replies, "I have done nothing wrong. Can I not even ask a question?" David turns away from Eliab to ask again about rewards for killing Goliath. The soldiers confirm what David has already heard.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- The other shepherd who cares for David's sheep
- The Israelite soldiers

- The Philistine soldiers
- Goliath
- Eliab
- And David's other brothers

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, early in the morning, David leaves his sheep with another shepherd and travels to the army camp with the food, as Jesse instructed David. David arrives at the camp right at the time when the Israelite army is taking their battle positions and shouting their war cry. David gives the food from Jesse to the man in charge of supplies for the Israelite army. Then David hurries to the battle line to find out if David's brothers are well.

In the second scene, at the same time that David reaches his brothers in the battle line, the Philistine champion Goliath of Gath steps away from the Philistine army and moves up towards the Israelite army. The Philistine army has lined up on one side of the valley, and the Israelite army has lined up on the other side of the valley. Goliath probably walks down from the Philistine army into the valley and then up towards the Israelite army on the other side. Goliath challenges the Israelite army to find a champion to defeat Goliath as he has done day after day. This time, David hears Goliath's shouting towards the Israelite army. The Israelite soldiers flee from Goliath in fear when they hear Goliath's insults.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where the order of events is clear even though the setting of the story changes. In this story, two things happen at almost the same time when David greets his brothers and hears Goliath speak. How will you make this clear to your audience? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the Israelite soldiers have been talking among themselves. The soldiers talk about Goliath and how Goliath constantly challenges and makes fun of the Israelite army. The soldiers also discuss what King Saul has promised to give to the champion who would defeat Goliath. The king promised to give great riches, to give the king's daughter to the man in marriage, and to give freedom for the man's whole family in Israel. To marry a king's daughter was a great reward for faithful service in Israel. A free family in Israel did not have to pay taxes or fulfill other obligations to the king.

In scene four, David turns to the Israelite soldiers next to David and asks what reward the man who kills Goliath would receive. Even though the soldiers have been discussing the rewards among themselves, we are not sure if David has heard what King Saul has promised to give the man who kills Goliath. David asks, "What will be done for the man who kills this Philistine and takes away the disgrace of Goliath from Israel? Who is this uncircumcised man who dares to challenge the army of the living God?" David may have asked this question because he did not know what King Saul promised, or David may have wanted to make sure that what David had heard was true. David may also have asked the question to show David's disrespect for Goliath. By challenging the Israelite army, Goliath spoke wrongly about Israel's God. Goliath is a disgrace because Goliath has dared to challenge the army of the living God. The term "living God" reminds the Israelites that God is active and working on behalf of the Israelites. This contrasts with the gods from other cultures, who are not alive and do not act. When David questions the soldiers, the soldiers repeat what they have been discussing among themselves.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people describe gods in your culture? How will you describe the living God in this passage? Pause this audio here.

In scene five, David's oldest brother Eliab overhears David's questions, and Eliab's anger burns against David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you show how angry Eliab is at David? Remember the story you told in the previous step about someone being angry. Pay attention to what words you used to describe that person's anger. Pause this audio here.

Eliab demands to know why David has come to the battle line and what David did with the few sheep that were David's responsibility. Because David's family only has a few sheep, it would have been a great loss if they had lost even one sheep. Eliab believes David has been irresponsible in leaving the sheep. Eliab declares that David is full of pride and has an evil heart. Eliab accuses David of coming to the camp only so David could witness the battle.

1 Samuel 17:20–30

But David knows David has obeyed his father Jesse. David asks Eliab, “What have I done wrong? I only asked a question.” David turns away from Eliab to another soldier and asks again about the reward for the man who kills Goliath. Again, the soldiers repeat the same information David has already heard.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- The other shepherd who cares for David’s sheep
- The Israelite soldiers
- The Philistine soldiers
- Goliath
- Eliab
- And David’s other brothers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Early in the morning, David leaves his sheep with another shepherd and travels to the Israelite army camp at the Valley of Elah with the gifts of food as Jesse had instructed. David arrives at the battlefield just as the armies are lining up for battle and shouting war cries. The armies stand facing each other. David leaves the food with the keeper of supplies and runs to greet David’s brothers in the battle line. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am excited to travel to the army camp to see my brothers; or
- I am happy to obey my father so that we can make sure my brothers are doing well.

Ask the people playing Eliab and David’s other brothers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people may answer things like:

- We are glad to see our brother and to know he brought food; or
- We do not know why David is here. We are not happy to see David.

Continue the drama. Just as David begins to speak with his brothers, Goliath, the Philistine champion from Gath, comes out from the Philistine army and walks up the hill towards the Israelite army. David hears Goliath shout the challenge Goliath has made towards the Israelite army day after day. The other Israelite soldiers are so afraid of Goliath that they flee from Goliath in terror. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Goliath, “What are you feeling and thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I know I am more powerful than these Israelite soldiers. The Israelite soldiers are still terrified of me, even after almost 40 days! or
- I am proud of my might and wish these Israelites would just let us defeat them already.

Ask the people playing the Israelite soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- We are still terrified of Goliath! God has not done anything for us in the time Goliath has been insulting us, and we do not know if God will ever help us; or
- We are not sure God can defeat Goliath.

Continue the drama. The Israelite soldiers talk amongst themselves about Goliath. "Have you seen that giant?" the soldiers ask each other. "Goliath comes out every day to challenge Israel. But King Saul has promised great rewards for the man who kills Goliath." The king had promised to give the man who defeated Goliath great riches and the king's daughter in marriage, and to allow the man's family to be free from taxes in Israel.

David turned to the soldiers next to David and asked what reward people might give to the man who defeated Goliath. "What reward will the man receive who defeats Goliath and ends his disgrace against Israel? Who is this uncircumcised Philistine who dares to defy the army of the living God of Israel?" The soldiers confirm the rewards that King Saul has promised to give to the man who defeats Goliath. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know the living God of Israel will not accept this Philistine who is not one of God's people and who does not respect the God of Israel; or
- I know the living God of Israel can defeat any giant; or
- I know God could use me to fight this giant even though I am small and young.

Continue the drama. When David's oldest brother, Eliab, hears David asking about the rewards for killing Goliath, Eliab is very angry with David. Eliab accuses David of being irresponsible for leaving the sheep that are David's responsibility. Eliab says, "I know you are prideful and deceitful! You probably came here only to watch the battle!" David replies to Eliab, "I have done nothing wrong. I was only asking a question!" David then turns to another soldier and again asks what people might do for the man who defeats Goliath. The soldier confirms what other soldiers had told David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Eliab, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I think my little brother is just here to cause trouble. David cannot possibly be useful here on the battlefield; or
- I do not think David could defeat Goliath. David is just being nosy.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Early in the morning, David left his **sheep** with another **shepherd**. David was Jesse's youngest son, and David took care of his father's sheep. A shepherd is someone who takes care of sheep or goats. Sheep are gentle animals that people keep to use the animals' milk, to eat the animals' meat, and to use the animals' hair for clothing. Use the same words or phrases for shepherd and for sheep as you used in previous passages. For more information on David and shepherd, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sheep as a group, if it is helpful. Pause this audio here.

David reached the army **camp** right as the Israelite and Philistine soldiers lined up for battle and began to shout war cries. A camp is a place where a group of people stop for a limited period. In this case, it was a place where the Israelite army stopped and stayed to fight the Philistines. Use the same word or phrase for camp as you used in previous passages.

Israelites refer to the people who are descended from Jacob. The Israelites lived in **Israel**. Use the same words or phrases for Israelite and Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israelite and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary

A war cry or battle cry is when an army shouts a word or phrase, or makes a noise, right before the soldiers fight in a battle.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **war cry**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David left his things with the keeper of supplies and ran to greet David's brothers. The keeper of supplies took care of the baggage and provisions that the Israelite army needed.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **keeper of supplies**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Just as David greeted his brothers, Goliath, the Philistine **champion** from Gath, came up from the Philistine army. A champion was someone who was willing to fight against someone else on behalf of that champion's country. Use the same word or phrase for champion as you used in previous passages.

The Israelite soldiers ran from Goliath in terror. The soldiers talked amongst themselves about the rewards King Saul had promised to give the man who defeated Goliath. The king would give that man great riches and the king's daughter in marriage. The king would also make that man and the man's family free in Israel. To be free in Israel meant that a man and his family would no longer have to pay taxes in Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **free in Israel**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word as you used there. Pause this audio here.

David asked the soldiers around David what reward a man would receive if that man defeated Goliath and took the disgrace away from Israel. To bring disgrace on someone or something means to bring shame or make that person ashamed. Goliath brought disgrace on Israel because Goliath defied the army of the living God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **disgrace**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word as you used there. Pause this audio here.

David asked, "Who is this uncircumcised Philistine who dares to defy the armies of the living God?" Circumcision is the Jewish practice of cutting off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis. Circumcision was a sign that the person was included in the covenant God made with Abraham. Goliath was uncircumcised, or not circumcised, which means that Goliath was not part of the covenant and was not one of God's people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **uncircumcised**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word as you used there. For more information on circumcision, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

David called God "the living God." **God** refers to the God who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being. This is the God who made a covenant, or special promise, to Abraham and Abraham's descendants, the Israelites. Use the same word for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

When David's brother Eliab heard David's questions, Eliab was very angry and accused David of being irresponsible, prideful, and deceitful. Eliab asked David who was watching the sheep in the **wilderness**. Eliab said that David had a **wicked heart.** Use the same words or phrases for wilderness, wicked, and heart as you have used before, and see the Master Glossary for more information about wilderness, wicked, and heart.

David said to Eliab, "I have done nothing wrong. All I did was ask a question." David then turned to some other soldiers and asked more about the man who would kill Goliath. Those soldiers repeated the same information to David that David had already heard.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 17:20–30

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (405 KB)
- Setting the Stage (1.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (662 KB)

1 Samuel 17:31–40

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 17:31–40 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:31–40 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:31–40 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, David took some food from his father Jesse to David's brothers at the army camp at Elah. When Goliath came out from the Philistine army and challenged the Israelite army, David asked the men around David what the king would do for the man who could defeat Goliath and remove the disgrace from Israel. David asked why Goliath continued to go against the armies of the living God.

In this passage, we learn how some men heard David asking those questions, and the men repeated David's questions to Saul, Israel's king. Now, Saul asks the men to bring David to Saul. When David arrives, David tells Saul that no man should lose heart because of that Philistine. To lose heart means to be afraid, so David is telling Saul that no one should be afraid of the Philistine. David says David will fight the Philistine Goliath.

King Saul says that David cannot fight against the Philistine because David is just a young boy. David is probably between 15 and 20 years old, and men would not think of David as an adult. Saul also might mean that David does not have any military training or experience. Saul goes on to tell David that the Philistine Goliath has been a warrior and expert in war since Goliath was a young man.

Stop here and discuss as a group: When do you consider young men adults in your culture? How do you know when a young man is ready to fight in battle? Pause this audio here.

David calls himself King Saul's servant and responds to Saul in a polite and respectful way, even though David does not agree with King Saul. David says that David has been taking care of David's father's sheep. David has experience with fighting because David has protected the sheep from dangerous animals. David tells Saul that when a lion or bear tried to steal a sheep from the flock, David chased the lion or bear, hit it with David's staff, and rescued the sheep from the animal's mouth. A shepherd like David would use a staff to help defend themselves and their animals from dangerous animals. When the lion or bear turned to attack David, David grabbed the lion or bear by the fur on its throat and hit that animal until it died. We can see from David's experiences that David was strong and brave.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sheep, a lion, and a bear as a group. Look at a picture of a shepherd's staff. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of tools do you use when you take care of animals in your culture? Pause this audio here.

David continues to tell Saul that David has killed a lion and a bear, and David will kill the uncircumcised Philistine just like David killed the lion and bear. David is insulting the Philistine Goliath by calling Goliath uncircumcised. The Israelites were proud that their circumcision was a sign of their special covenant with Yahweh. The Philistine did not respect the armies of the living God. "The living God" is another name for Yahweh. Yahweh rescued David from the paw of the lion and the bear, and Yahweh will also rescue David from the hand of the Philistine. To rescue someone from the paw or hand of something means to rescue that person from the power of something. God will rescue David from the Philistine, even though Goliath is more powerful than David.

King Saul replies, "Go, and may Yahweh be with you." This was a common way to say goodbye, but King Saul is also asking Yahweh to be with David on David's mission to fight against the Philistine. King Saul gives his armor to David. This armor includes a tunic, or shirt that people wore under armor, and a bronze helmet. People made this kind of armor from small metal rings, which they tied together with leather straps. People wore this kind of armor over their chest for protection. A helmet is a metal covering for a person's head. Saul's helmet was bronze, which is a type of metal. David put on King Saul's sword over the armor and tried to walk around. David had never worn armor before and could not move freely because the armor was very heavy.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of armor, including a tunic, a helmet, and a sword. Pause this audio here.

David told King Saul that David could not wear the armor because David had not worn it before. So, David took off King Saul's armor.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kind of clothing or armor do people in your culture wear in battle in order to protect themselves? Pause this audio here.

David picked up his shepherd's staff or stick and started to walk down the hill and into the valley towards Goliath. At the streambed in the valley, David stopped and picked up five small smooth stones. A streambed is where water sometimes flows in a valley between hills. Sometimes streambeds are dry when there has not been much rain. The stones would have been smooth because water had flowed over the stones. David put the stones in the pocket of David's shepherd's bag. With David's sling in his hand and David's staff in his hand, David came closer to Goliath the Philistine. A sling was a weapon that people made of leather that could hold a small stone.

A person would swing the leather of the sling around his head and then release the stone to hit that person's enemy. Because David carried his sling in his hand, we know David was ready for the action of battle.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a valley with a streambed in the valley. Look at a picture of a smooth stone and a shepherd's bag. Look at a picture of a sling. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you think about David going to fight a warrior like Goliath with only a sling?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:31–40 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Some men from the army overhear David when David asks questions about what the king would do for the man who would defeat Goliath. These army men tell King Saul, and King Saul asks the men to bring David to Saul.

In the second scene: David tells King Saul that no one should be afraid of that Philistine Goliath, and David will fight Goliath. King Saul responds to David and says that David is too young and inexperienced to fight a warrior like Goliath.

In the third scene: David responds to King Saul and says that David has experience because David protected his sheep from dangerous animals. David chased and killed lions and bears that attacked David's sheep and rescued the sheep from those animals. David killed the lion and the bear, and David will kill the uncircumcised Philistine Goliath like David killed the lion and bear. Yahweh rescued David from the animals, and Yahweh will rescue David from Goliath.

In the fourth scene: King Saul tells David to go, and may Yahweh go with David. King Saul tries to give David some armor, but after David tries the armor on, David decides not to wear it because David is not used to the armor. David picks up five small smooth stones from the streambed and walks closer to Goliath. David carries his shepherd's staff in one hand, and David carries his sling in his other hand.

The characters in this passage are:

- Men from the Israelite army
- King Saul
- David
- Lion and bear
- Sheep
- And the Philistine, Goliath

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, David had spoken to some men in King Saul's army. David had asked those men what people would do for the Israelite man who defeated the Philistine Goliath. Now, some of the men from the Israelite army tell King Saul about David's questions. King Saul sends someone to bring David to Saul. The Israelite army is in a battle line on one side of the valley, and the Philistine army is in a battle line on the other side of the valley. The Philistine Goliath stands in front of the Philistine army battle line and continues to challenge the Israelite army while David speaks to King Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where the focus is on action in one place, and then the focus switches to action in another place, even though the first action is still happening. How will you help your audience understand that several things are happening all at the same time? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, David comes to King Saul and tells Saul that no man should lose heart because of Goliath. To lose heart means to be afraid. No one should be afraid of the Philistine. David is talking about the Philistine Goliath,

but David does not say Goliath's name because David did not like or respect Goliath. David says David will fight against the Philistine. King Saul replies, "You cannot fight against this Philistine and win! You are only a young boy, but that man has been a warrior for his entire life."

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about people who lose heart, or who become very afraid and discouraged. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about an enemy that you really do not respect. Notice that what you call your enemy shows how you feel about that person. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, David disagrees with King Saul. Even though David does not agree with King Saul, David speaks respectfully and calls himself King Saul's servant. David says David has experience in battle because, while David took care of his father's sheep, David protected the sheep. When a lion or bear came and stole a sheep from the flock, David chased after the animal, hit it, and took the sheep out of the animal's mouth. When the lion or bear tried to attack David, David grabbed the animal by the fur on its throat, beat the animal, and killed it. "I have killed any lion or any bear who tried to steal my sheep," David tells King Saul, "and I will kill this uncircumcised Philistine too because he challenged the armies of the living God. Yahweh rescued me from the lion and the bear, and Yahweh will rescue me from this Philistine."

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where someone disagrees with someone else in a polite and respectful way. How will your audience understand that David respected King Saul even though David disagreed with King Saul? Pause this audio here.

In scene four, King Saul tells David, "Go, and may Yahweh go with you." King Saul wants David to defeat the Philistine. King Saul gives David King Saul's armor to protect David in the battle. King Saul gives David a tunic to go under the armor. King Saul also gives David a helmet that people made of bronze and King Saul's own sword. David puts on the armor and the sword and tries to walk around. However, David has never worn armor before, and David cannot move easily because the armor is so heavy.

"I cannot fight in this armor because I have never worn it before," David says. David takes the armor off and, with his staff in his hand, David stops and picks up five small smooth stones from the streambed. David puts the stones in the pocket of David's shepherd's bag. David has a sling in his other hand. David walks towards the Philistine.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture prepare for a battle? How will you describe David's preparation for battle? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:31–40 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Men from the Israelite army
- King Saul
- David
- Lion and bear
- Sheep
- And the Philistine, Goliath

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

David has been talking to some men from the Israelite army. David asks the men about what the king might do for the Israelite who defeats the Philistine Goliath. Some men go to King Saul and tell Saul about David’s questions. King Saul sends someone to bring David to Saul. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the men from the Israelite army, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We think this boy, David, wants to fight against Goliath; or
- We are tired of David’s questions and hope King Saul tells David to go home; or
- We hope David is the answer to the problem of Goliath! or
- We are angry with David because David is bragging about defeating Goliath.

Continue the drama. David comes to King Saul and says, “No one should be afraid of this Philistine. I will fight him!” King Saul replies, “There is no way you could ever defeat this Philistine! You are only a young boy, and you have no experience with fighting. But this Philistine has been a warrior from the time he was young!” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I like David’s courage, but I see no way David could win against Goliath; or
- I am afraid that David has too much confidence in himself; or
- I think this young man is too prideful and will cause even more trouble for us with the Philistines.

Continue the drama. David does not agree with what King Saul says. David tells King Saul, “I have plenty of fighting experience! I have been watching my father’s sheep, and whenever a lion or a bear came to steal a sheep, I chased after it, hit it, and took the sheep out of its mouth. When that lion or bear turned and tried to attack me, I grabbed it by the fur on its throat and hit it until it was dead. I have killed lions and bears, and just like I killed them, I will kill this Philistine because he has challenged the armies of the living God. Yahweh rescued me from the lion and the bear, and Yahweh will rescue me from the Philistine Goliath.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Even though no one seems to believe me, I know Yahweh will fight for me; or
- I know King Saul does not have confidence in me, but I have confidence in Yahweh. I hope King Saul allows me to fight!

Continue the drama. King Saul tells David to go, and may Yahweh go with David to fight. Then King Saul offers David Saul’s tunic and armor. Saul also gives David a helmet that people made of bronze and King Saul’s own sword. David tries on the armor and tries to walk around, but David has never worn armor before. The armor is heavy and makes it hard for David to move easily. “I cannot wear this,” David tells King Saul. “I cannot move easily.” David takes off King Saul’s armor and picks up five small smooth stones. David puts the stones in the pocket of David’s shepherd’s bag and walks towards Goliath. David has his shepherd’s staff in one hand and David’s sling in the other hand. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel a little afraid, but I know Yahweh is with me, like King Saul said; or
- I am confident Yahweh will use what I have to defeat Goliath.

Ask the person playing the Philistine Goliath, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I see a young boy walking towards me and wonder what the Israelites are thinking; or
- I can kill this boy easily, and then we can finally defeat all these Israelites! or
- Israel must have a very weak God to send a young boy to fight against me!

1 Samuel 17:31–40

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:31–40 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Someone brings **David** to Saul because David has been asking questions about the man who would defeat Goliath. David was Jesse's son who took care of Jesse's sheep and served King Saul. Use the same word for David as you used in previous passages. For more information on David, refer to the Master Glossary.

David continues talking to Saul and says, "Your **servant** will fight Goliath." A servant is a man or woman who works for another person. David was Saul's servant. David showed respect for Saul when David called himself Saul's servant. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul tells David that David cannot defeat Goliath because David is only a **youth** or a boy. A youth could be an infant or a growing boy, or a youth could just mean that David was a young soldier whom people did not yet accept as an adult soldier. Use the same word for youth as you used in previous passages.

Saul tells David that Goliath has been a **warrior** since Goliath was a youth. A warrior is a brave or experienced soldier. Use the same word for warrior as you used in previous passages.

David tells Saul that David fought a lion and a bear when those animals came to attack David's father's sheep. A lion is a large brownish-yellow cat. Male lions have a large mane, or a lot of fur, around their heads. Lions are excellent hunters. A bear is a large, hairy animal with thick hair and a short tail. Both lions and bears have sharp claws that they use to grab and hurt other animals or people. Lions and bears will eat other animals like sheep.

Stop here and look at pictures of a lion, a bear, and a sheep. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **lion**, **bear**, and **sheep**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David tells Saul that David killed the lion and the bear, and David will kill the **uncircumcised** Philistine Goliath. Circumcision is the practice of cutting off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis. Circumcision was a sign that a person was included in the covenant God made with Abraham. Goliath was uncircumcised, so Goliath was not one of God's people. Use the same word for uncircumcised as you used in previous passages. For more information on circumcised and uncircumcised, refer to circumcision in the Master Glossary.

David tells Saul he will defeat Goliath because Goliath challenged the armies of the living **God**. God is the one who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being. Use the same word for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

David says that **Yahweh** rescued David from the lion and the bear, and Yahweh will rescue David from Goliath. Yahweh is God's personal name. This name showed the close relationship between God and the people of Israel. David also uses the name "living God" when David talks about Yahweh. Use the same word for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul agrees to let David go with Yahweh to fight Goliath. Then Saul gives David Saul's **tunic**, breastplate of **scale armor**, **bronze helmet**, and **sword**. A tunic is an item of clothing that reaches to the knees or the ankles. People made tunics from wool or linen, and sometimes a man would put his sword in the waist of his tunic. People wore armor over the chest and back. People made armor out of many small metal rings that they tied together with leather straps. Because all the rings were connected, the armor would be flexible like fabric, but the metal would make the armor difficult for weapons to pierce. The helmet Saul gave was made of bronze. Bronze is a metal that people make by combining copper and tin. Use the same words for tunic, armor, bronze helmet, and sword as you used in previous passages. For more information on tunic and bronze, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look at pictures of a tunic, armor, helmet, and sword, if needed. Pause this audio here.

David tries on Saul's armor, but the armor is too heavy and does not allow David to move easily. David takes off the armor and picks up five small smooth stones in the streambed. A streambed is where water sometimes flows in a valley between hills. In dry seasons, when there is not much rain, streambeds do not have much water. But during rainy seasons, streambeds can be full of flowing water. The stones would have been smooth because water had flowed over the stones for a long time.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **streambed**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you used there. Pause this audio here.

David puts the stones in the pocket of David's shepherd's bag. A shepherd would use a shepherd's bag to carry belongings as the shepherd walked alongside their sheep each day. David also carried a shepherd's staff. This was a stick shepherds could use to help them walk and to help defend the sheep against other animals. David carried a sling in David's other hand. A sling is a simple weapon that people made of a strap in a loop that people could spin over their head to fling small stones.

Stop here and look at a picture of a shepherd's bag, a shepherd's staff, and a sling. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **shepherd's bag**, **shepherd's staff**, and **sling**. See the Master Glossary for more information about shepherds, if needed. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 17:31–40

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (390 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (659 KB)

1 Samuel 17:41–54

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 17:41–54 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:41–54 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:41–54 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, David told King Saul that David would fight Goliath. King Saul disagreed, but David insisted that Yahweh would rescue David from Goliath. David walked towards Goliath carrying a shepherd's staff and a sling with five small rocks in David's bag.

Now, Goliath begins to walk towards David. The man who carries Goliath's shield walks in front of Goliath. The shield is big enough to protect most of Goliath's body. The two men walk closer and closer to David. Goliath looks at David and realizes that David is a youth. David's face is ruddy, or healthy with reddish cheeks, and David is handsome. David carries his shepherd's staff or stick and a sling, which is a weapon people use to throw rocks. Goliath is not impressed with David's appearance or with the staff David carries. Goliath probably thinks that Goliath is much stronger and better equipped to fight than David, so Goliath despises David. Goliath does not believe it is worth the effort to fight against David.

Stop here and look at a picture of a shield-bearer with a shield, a picture of a staff, and a picture of a sling. Pause this audio here.

Goliath asks David if David thinks Goliath is like a dog that David can chase away with a stick. A dog is a four-legged animal that the Israelite people considered unclean. To call someone a dog was an insult. Goliath thinks David does not respect Goliath. Because David only carries a staff and a sling, David looks like he is about to fight a dog instead of a warrior like Goliath. Goliath curses David in the name of Goliath's gods. Goliath probably worships the gods of the Philistines. To curse someone means to wish something bad would happen to that person. Goliath hopes that the Philistine gods Goliath worships will use their power to destroy David.

Stop here and look at a picture of a dog as a group. Pause this audio here.

Goliath shouts for David to come closer so Goliath can kill David and give David's body to the birds of the air and the beasts of the field, or the wild animals. For the Israelite people, the idea of leaving bodies out for the birds and wild animals to eat was worse than death because people highly valued giving dead bodies a proper burial. Goliath threatens and challenges David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do people in your culture usually do to show respect to dead bodies? Pause this audio here.

David replies that Goliath attacks with a sword, spear, and javelin, but David comes in the power of Yahweh Almighty, who is the God of Israel's armies. Because Goliath has defied or challenged the God of Israel, David says Yahweh will give David victory over Goliath. David will hit Goliath and cut off Goliath's head. David says that today the Israelites will slaughter or kill the entire Philistine army, and the Israelites will give the dead bodies of the Philistine army to the birds and the beasts. Then the entire world will know that Israel has a God who really does things for God's people. David says that everyone who is gathered to fight will know that Yahweh does not

use weapons or spears to save Yahweh's people. Yahweh always decides who wins battles, and Yahweh will give the Philistines into the Israelite army's hands. This means Yahweh will help the Israelites defeat the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about the gods in your culture. What kind of power do those gods have, and how do those gods use that power to help people in battle against their enemies? Pause this audio here.

Goliath moves closer to David as Goliath gets ready to attack David. Goliath probably cannot move quickly because Goliath has so much armor on his body and so many weapons to carry. But David quickly runs forward to the battle line to meet Goliath. David reaches into David's shepherd's bag and takes out a stone. David puts the stone in David's sling, swings the sling around David's head, and slings the rock straight into Goliath's forehead. This is one of the few places on Goliath's body that armor does not protect. The stone goes deep into Goliath's forehead, and Goliath falls facedown on the ground.

So with only a sling and a stone, David defeats Goliath the Philistine. David does not have a sword when David strikes the Philistine and kills him.

As soon as Goliath falls, David runs to Goliath and stands over him as Goliath lies on the ground. David grabs Goliath's sword from its sheath or holder. People had probably made this sheath from leather. Even though the earlier description of Goliath and Goliath's armor did not include Goliath's sword, this is probably the javelin or scimitar Goliath wore on his back. David uses the sword to kill Goliath by cutting off Goliath's head, just like David had promised to do earlier.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a javelin next to its sheath and a scimitar next to its sheath. Pause this audio here.

When the Philistine army sees that their champion Goliath is dead, the Philistines turn away from the Israelite army and run away. The Israelite men, who are from Israel and Judah, run forward and shout a battle cry as they chase the Philistine army. The army chases the Philistine soldiers all the way to the entrance of the city of Gath and to the gates of the city of Ekron. All along the road that leads from Shaaraim to Gath and Ekron, the dead and wounded bodies of the Philistine soldiers lay.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about an important military victory in your culture. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a map that contains the Valley of Elah and the cities of Gath, Ekron, and Shaaraim. Pause this audio here.

When the Israelites finished chasing the Philistines, the Israelites returned and plundered the Philistine army camp. This means the Israelites took all the equipment and supplies out of the camp. David kept Goliath's head and took it to Jerusalem. We are not certain if David left Goliath's head outside Jerusalem right away, or if David took the head to Jerusalem much later. Because Jerusalem belonged to the Philistines at this time, David may have placed Goliath's head outside Jerusalem as a warning to the people who lived there, or David may have placed the head in Jerusalem much later when the city belonged to Israel. David kept Goliath's armor and weapons in David's tent or dwelling-place. The army may have given David his own tent at the army camp right away because David had won a big victory. Or, David might have put Goliath's weapons in the tent of meeting or the tent of Yahweh. This was the place where Yahweh's presence lived, and later on, David found Goliath's sword in the tent of meeting.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:41–54 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Goliath walks behind his shield-bearer towards David and sees that David is a young boy who is ruddy and handsome. Goliath despises David and accuses David of thinking Goliath is only as intimidating as

a dog. Goliath curses David by Goliath's gods and shouts for David to come closer so Goliath can give David's body to the birds and wild animals to eat.

In the second scene: David replies to Goliath that Goliath comes with weapons, but David comes in the name of Yahweh Almighty. Because Goliath defied the army of Israel, Yahweh will give David victory over Goliath so that the whole world will know that Israel has a God who really does things for his people. Yahweh always wins Yahweh's battles, and Yahweh will give victory over the Philistines to Israel.

In the third scene: Goliath slowly moves closer to David, and David runs quickly towards Goliath as David pulls a stone out of David's bag. David puts the stone into David's sling and throws the rock into the middle of Goliath's forehead, where the stone sinks in. Goliath falls facedown on the ground. David takes Goliath's sword out of its sheath and uses the sword to kill Goliath and to cut off Goliath's head.

In the fourth scene: When the Philistines see that Goliath is dead, the Philistines run away. The men in the Israelite army shout a battle cry and quickly chase the Philistine army all the way to Gath and Ekron. Dead bodies of Philistines lie on the road. When the Israelites finish chasing the Philistines, the Israelites return to plunder the Philistine camp. David takes Goliath's head to Jerusalem, but keeps Goliath's weapons in David's tent.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Philistine Goliath
- Goliath's shield-bearer
- David
- The Philistine army
- And the Israelite army

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, David had already walked toward Goliath, and now, Goliath begins to follow Goliath's shield-bearer towards David. Goliath watches David walk towards Goliath, and Goliath sees that David is young, healthy, and handsome. But Goliath is not impressed with David. Goliath sees that David carries only a staff, and Goliath believes David insults Goliath by only carrying such inferior weapons. Goliath accuses David of treating Goliath like a dog because David comes towards Goliath holding a staff or stick in David's hand while Goliath walks behind a shield that almost covers Goliath's entire body. Goliath makes fun of David and begins to curse David by the Philistine gods. Goliath wants his gods to destroy David. Goliath yells, "Come closer so I can kill you and feed your body to the birds and wild animals!"

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story in which one person insults another. What kinds of insults do people use in your culture? What actions do people use to show that they are cursing or making fun of someone else? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, David shouts back to the Philistine. In this passage, David is talking to the Philistine Goliath, but David does not say Goliath's name because David hates and does not respect Goliath.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone you really do not respect. Notice that what you call that person shows how you feel about that person. Pause this audio here.

David yells, "You are coming towards me with a sword, a spear, and a javelin. But you have challenged the God of the army of Israel. So I am coming to you in the name of our God, Yahweh the Almighty." To come "in the name of" Yahweh means that David comes to Goliath with the power and strength of Yahweh the Almighty. To say that Yahweh is almighty means that Yahweh is all-powerful because Yahweh is the God of heaven's armies or hosts. You may translate this as "Yahweh, the God who is all-powerful" if you believe that works better in your language. David also says, "Today, Yahweh will defeat you, and I will cut off your head. Then I will give the dead bodies of your Philistine army to the birds of the air and beasts of the field to eat!"

Stop here and discuss as a group: Goliath and David both threaten to give the dead bodies of their enemy to the birds of the air and the beasts of the field. Goliath and David would not really give the dead bodies to the birds and the animals, but this was a way to show that they were cursing their enemy. How will you say this so that people understand that this was a way to show disrespect to a person's enemy? Pause this audio here.

David says, “Then the whole world will know that Israel has a God who really does things for his people. And everyone here will know that Yahweh always wins his battles, and he does not have to use weapons. This battle belongs to Yahweh, and Yahweh will give us victory over you!”

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where someone has great confidence over an enemy even though that person looks weaker than their enemy. How will you help your audience understand David’s confidence and trust in Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, as Goliath walks even closer to David, David runs towards Goliath. David grabs a stone out of David’s bag and puts the stone into David’s sling. David swings the sling over David’s head and throws the rock at Goliath. The rock hits Goliath right in the forehead and sinks in. Goliath stumbles and falls facedown on the ground. So David defeats the Philistine warrior Goliath with only a sling and a stone. David does not have a sword when David strikes and kills the Philistine Goliath. The storyteller repeats this information to show that what David said would happen comes true. David runs over and pulls Goliath’s sword out of its sheath. David uses Goliath’s sword to kill Goliath by cutting off Goliath’s head.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In this scene, David throws the rock and hits Goliath, and Goliath falls down. Then the storyteller summarizes what David did by saying that David defeated Goliath with only a sling and a stone. After the storyteller summarizes what happened, the action continues, and David kills Goliath. Tell a story where people do a lot of things, then the storyteller gives a brief summary of what happened, and then the action continues. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, when the Philistine army sees that Goliath is dead, the Philistines turn away from Goliath and run. The Israelite army, which is made up of men from Israel and Judah, shouts a battle cry and quickly runs after the Philistine army. The Israelites chase the Philistines all the way down the Shaaraim road that also led towards the cities of Gath and Ekron. Bodies of dead and wounded Philistine soldiers lay along the entire road. When the Israelite army finishes chasing the Philistines, the Israelite army goes back to their camp and plunders the Philistine army camp. The Israelites take anything that is valuable. David eventually takes Goliath’s head to Jerusalem, but David keeps Goliath’s weapons in David’s own tent.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:41–54 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Philistine Goliath
- Goliath’s shield-bearer
- David
- The Philistine army
- And the Israelite army

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Goliath walked towards David. Goliath walked behind a man who carried a shield that was big enough to protect almost all of Goliath's body. Goliath's forehead was the only part of his body that was not covered by the shield or armor. As Goliath walked, Goliath looked at David and saw that David was young, healthy-looking, and handsome. Goliath also saw that David carried only a staff and a sling. Goliath hated David and asked him, "Do you think I am no more than a dog that you can chase away with a stick?" Then Goliath called out to his gods and asked the gods to harm David. Goliath yelled to David, "Come closer, so I can kill you and leave your body for the birds and wild animals to eat!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Goliath, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am insulted that the Israelite army would send a young boy with only a stick and a sling to fight someone as important and powerful as me! or
- This battle should be easy because this youth cannot possibly defeat me.

Continue the drama. David responded to Goliath by shouting, "You come to fight me with a sword, spear, and javelin, but I come to you depending on Yahweh Almighty, the God of the armies of Israel. You have defied Yahweh, but today Yahweh will give me the strength to defeat you. I will kill you and cut off your head! And today we will kill all the Philistine soldiers and leave their bodies for the birds and wild animals to eat! Then people everywhere will know that Israel has a God who really does things for his people. Everyone here will know that Yahweh does not rescue his people with a sword or a spear because Yahweh decides who wins every battle. Yahweh will give us victory over you!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I have no doubt that Yahweh will defeat Goliath and the Philistines! or
- I am offended by Goliath because he challenged Yahweh. I am excited to see Yahweh defeat this army of Philistines, who do not respect Yahweh.

Continue the drama. Goliath comes closer and closer to David, and David runs to meet Goliath at the battle line. David quickly grabs a stone out of David's bag and places it in his sling. David slings the stone directly at Goliath and strikes Goliath in the forehead. The stone sinks deeply into Goliath's head, and Goliath stumbles and falls on his face on the ground. So with a sling and a stone, David defeated Goliath. David did not have a sword when he defeated Goliath. David ran to Goliath and grabbed Goliath's sword out of its sheath as David stood over Goliath. David used Goliath's sword to kill Goliath by cutting off Goliath's head, just as David had promised he would do. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Goliath's shield-bearer, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very surprised that this young boy has killed Goliath! or
- I am terrified that this young boy will now kill the rest of us just as he said he would!

Continue the drama. When the Philistine army realizes that their champion is dead, the Philistines all turn and run away from the Israelite army. The Israelite army, men from Israel and Judah, shout their battle cry and chase the Philistine army. The Israelites chase the Philistines along the road that goes from Shaaraim all the way to Gath and Ekron. The Israelites kill the Philistines as they run, so the bodies of dead and dying Philistine soldiers lie all along the road. When the Israelites finish chasing the Philistines, the Israelites return to the Philistine camp to plunder it. David takes Goliath's head to Jerusalem, and David keeps Goliath's weapons in David's tent. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Philistine soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are terrified of the Israelites and their God! or
- We do not care about the promise we made to serve the Israelites if they defeated our champion. We are going to run away as fast as we can so we might live!

Ask the people playing the Israelite soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are so happy that Yahweh defeated Goliath! We celebrate Yahweh's power and our victory! or
- We are determined to kill the Philistines who disrespected and made fun of us and our God; or

- We are shocked that God used a shepherd boy to defeat Goliath instead of having King Saul defeat the Philistine!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:41–54 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Goliath walked behind Goliath's shield-bearer. A person who was a shield-bearer carried a large shield in front of another soldier.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a man carrying a shield. Translate this word in the same way you have in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

Goliath walked towards **David**. David was Jesse's youngest son, and David kept his father's sheep in Bethlehem. David also served King Saul. For more information on David, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for David as you used in previous passages.

Goliath looked at David and saw that David was **ruddy** and handsome. To be ruddy means that someone is healthy and has rosy or reddish cheeks. Use the same word or phrase for ruddy or healthy as you used in previous passages.

Goliath accused David of coming towards Goliath as if David were trying to scare a dog away. A dog is a four-legged animal that people in Israel considered unclean. It was a common insult to call someone a dog.

Stop here and look at a picture of a dog as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **dog**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Philistine cursed David by the Philistine's **gods**. Use the same word or phrase for gods as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information.

To curse someone is to wish that something bad would happen to that person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **curse**. Look up curse in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David said Goliath came against David with a sword, spear, and javelin or scimitar. These were all weapons people used in war. Remember from the last passage that Goliath also wore heavy armor that covered almost all of Goliath's body, and a man walked in front of Goliath carrying a large shield. David had no armor, and David did not carry any weapons. Use the same words or phrases for sword, spear, and javelin or scimitar as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sword, a spear, and a javelin or scimitar as a group. Pause this audio here.

David came against Goliath in the power of **Yahweh Almighty**, or **Yahweh of hosts**. Yahweh of hosts is the **God of Israel**. Yahweh is God's personal name that shows the close relationship that God had with Israel. To describe Yahweh as "almighty" or "Yahweh of hosts" means that Yahweh is in charge of all of the armies, or hosts, of Israel. This name reminds us that Yahweh has power over all things in the universe. For more information on Yahweh, Yahweh of hosts, God, and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for these ideas as you used in previous passages.

David knew that Yahweh would defeat Goliath. David ran towards Goliath, put a stone in David's sling, and slung the stone into Goliath's forehead. A sling is a weapon people make by connecting leather straps to a pouch. Use the same word for sling as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sling as a group. Pause this audio here.

David knocked Goliath down with a sling and a stone. Then David ran to Goliath, took Goliath's sword out of its sheath, and used the sword to kill Goliath. A sheath is a cover for a knife or sword. People had probably made Goliath's sheath out of leather.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sheath as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sheath**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David used Goliath's sword to kill Goliath, and then the Israelite soldiers chased the Philistine soldiers. The Israelites shouted their **battle cry** as they chased the Philistines. A battle cry is a word or noise that an army shouts as they begin a battle. Use the same word or phrase for "battle cry" as you used in previous passages.

When the Israelite soldiers finished chasing and killing the Philistine soldiers, the Israelites returned to **plunder** the Philistine camp. To plunder means to steal goods. Use the same word or phrase for plunder as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 17:41–54

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (398 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (605 KB)

1 Samuel 17:55–18:5

1 Samuel 17:55–18:5

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 17:55–18:5 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:55–18:5 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:55–18:5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, David fought against Goliath the Philistine. Yahweh gave David victory over Goliath, and the Israelite soldiers chased and killed the Philistine soldiers and plundered their camp.

As this passage begins, we learn about something else that happened in the last story while David was walking toward Goliath. This event has already happened, but the storyteller is giving us more information about what else happened at the same time. As David went out to meet Goliath, King Saul watched. Saul asked Abner, the commander of Saul's army, who David's father was. Saul knew who David was because David served King Saul, but Saul may not have known much about David's family or background. Saul wanted to know more about David's family and the family's reputation in Israel. Saul may have wanted to know who David's father was so Saul could have David serve Saul permanently. You will remember that David had been going back and forth between Bethlehem, where David cared for his father's sheep, and the army camp, where David served King Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about what happens when you introduce new people to each other, especially someone you want to work with. In your culture, what kind of information is important to know about each other? What kind of information do you want to know about someone's family or ancestors? Pause this audio here.

Abner, however, did not know anything about David's family or status within Israel. Abner told the king, "As surely as you live, O king, I do not know." With this phrase, Abner wanted King Saul to know that Abner was telling the truth about Abner's lack of knowledge about David. Saul told Abner to go and learn more about David's family.

As soon as David finished killing Goliath by cutting off Goliath's head, Abner brought David to Saul. Abner brought David so quickly that David still held Goliath's head in David's hand. Saul asked David who David's father was, and David replied that David was the son of Saul's servant Jesse from Bethlehem.

David and Saul finished talking. Afterwards, the soul of Jonathan became bound to the soul of David, and Jonathan loved David as much as Jonathan loved himself. Jonathan was King Saul's oldest son. For one soul to be bound to another means that these men had great affection for one another and were best friends. From that day forward, King Saul had David stay with Saul to live at Saul's court so David could serve Saul. Saul did not send David back to David's father's house.

Jonathan made a covenant with David because Jonathan loved David deeply. When people make a covenant, they make a solemn promise to one another that they cannot break. The people say they want to have a good relationship with each other. Jonathan and David promised to always be loyal friends to one another.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about two people who have a relationship as close as David and Jonathan. How do people show promises of friendship and love in your culture? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 17:55–18:5

To show Jonathan's friendship, Jonathan took off his robe or tunic and gave it to David. Jonathan's robe or tunic was an outer garment that would have covered Jonathan's other clothing. Jonathan also gave his own armor to David, along with Jonathan's sword, bow, and belt. People wore armor to protect themselves in battle. People used swords and bows as weapons in battle. Jonathan's belt may have been where Jonathan held his dagger, or a short sword. By giving David his robe, armor, and weapons, Jonathan showed his covenant friendship with David. Jonathan also showed how unselfish Jonathan was. We do not know if Jonathan already knew that David would be the next king, but we see that Jonathan did not feel threatened by David like Saul did.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a robe, armor, sword, bow, and belt. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how might someone show that they are very close friends with someone else? Pause this audio here.

Whatever military tasks Saul commanded David to do, David did them well. Therefore, Saul made David a high-ranking officer in Saul's army. David was probably in charge of a large group of soldiers. All the soldiers and officers in Saul's army were happy about this.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:55–18:5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Earlier, when David was walking towards Goliath to fight against Goliath, King Saul watched. Saul asked his army commander, Abner, who David's father was. Abner did not know, so Saul asked Abner to find out. As soon as David killed Goliath, Abner brought David to Saul, and David told Saul that David's father was Jesse from Bethlehem.

In the second scene: After David and Saul finished talking, David and Jonathan became best friends. Jonathan was King Saul's oldest son. King Saul had David stay and serve Saul at Saul's court. Jonathan and David made a covenant to always be loyal friends, and as a sign of friendship, Jonathan gave David Jonathan's robe, armor, sword, bow, and belt.

In the third scene: Whatever King Saul asked David to do, David did it well. So, Saul made David a high-ranking officer in Saul's army. All the soldiers and officers in Saul's army approved of David's position.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- King Saul
- Abner
- Jonathan
- And soldiers and officers in Saul's army

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the storyteller helps us understand something that already happened in our last story. While David walked towards the Philistine Goliath, King Saul watched. Saul turned to his army commander, Abner, and asked, "Who is the father of that young man?" Abner responded to the king, "As surely as you live, my king, I do not know." Abner used an expression in which Abner swore on the king's life. This expression was part of an oath or a promise that Abner used to make sure Saul knew Abner was telling the truth. By swearing on the king's life, Abner was saying that the king could kill Abner if Abner was not telling the truth.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What phrases or expressions do you use in your culture to make sure people know you are telling the truth? Pause this audio here.

Saul told Abner to find out who David's father was. As soon as David finished killing Goliath by cutting off Goliath's head, Abner brought David to King Saul. David had not even set down Goliath's head. David was still holding

1 Samuel 17:55–18:5

Goliath's head in David's hand. Saul asked David who his father was, and David replied that his father was Saul's servant Jesse from Bethlehem. By calling Jesse Saul's servant, David did not mean that his father served King Saul. David meant that Jesse was loyal to Saul as Israel's king.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where the action goes from something that is happening right now to something that has already happened. How do you help your audience understand when the action is happening? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, David and King Saul finished talking. Afterwards, David and Saul's oldest son, Jonathan, became best friends. Jonathan's soul was bound to David's soul, and Jonathan loved David as much as Jonathan loved himself. God created humans with souls, which are a person's thoughts, feelings, and desires. We cannot see a person's soul, but we know it is there. In the original language, the word used for "bound" means to bind or to tie something to something else. David's soul was bound to or tied to Jonathan's soul, and Jonathan and David cared deeply for one another. From that day on, King Saul had David live at Saul's court so David could serve Saul. Saul did not send David back to David's father in Bethlehem. Because Jonathan loved David so much, Jonathan and David made a covenant together. Jonathan and David promised to always be loyal friends to each other. To show Jonathan's friendship, Jonathan took off his robe and gave it to David. Jonathan also gave David Jonathan's armor, sword, bow, and belt. By giving David all these things, Jonathan showed that Jonathan deeply respected and loved David. Jonathan also showed his unselfish covenant friendship with David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Remember the story you told about two friends in the previous script. Pay attention to the words you use to describe this kind of friendship and loyalty. Discuss how you might translate this. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, whatever military tasks Saul gave to David, David did well. So, Saul promoted David to be a high-ranking officer in Saul's army. All of the soldiers and other officers in Saul's army were happy about David's position.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a leader that everyone likes. How do you describe that leader? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:55–18:5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- King Saul
- Abner
- Jonathan
- And soldiers and officers in Saul's army

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

1 Samuel 17:55–18:5

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Even though the action has moved forward from the last story, the author helps us to understand something that has already happened. Earlier, while David walked towards the Philistine Goliath, King Saul watched David. Saul asked his army commander, Abner, "Whose son is that young man?" Abner replied, "I swear, my king, I do not know." Saul ordered Abner to find out who David's father was. As soon as David had killed Goliath by cutting off Goliath's head, Abner brought David to King Saul. David had not even had a chance to set down Goliath's head, and still held the head in David's hand. Saul asked David about David's father, and David told Saul, "My father is your servant Jesse from Bethlehem." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am impressed with this young man and want to know more about him; or
- I see that God uses David, and I want David's help to fight other battles.

Ask the person playing Abner, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I see that this young man has impressed the king, and I want to please the king by getting the king what he wants; or
- I am curious about this young man's family, too, because this young man serves in my army.

Continue the drama. David and Saul finished talking. Later, David and Saul's son, Jonathan, became best friends. David and Jonathan's souls were bound together, and they loved each other very much. Jonathan loved David as much as Jonathan loved himself. From that time on, King Saul kept David in Saul's court so David could serve Saul. Saul did not send David back to David's father's home in Bethlehem. Because Jonathan loved David so much, Jonathan and David made a covenant together. Jonathan and David promised to always be faithful and loyal friends. As a sign of Jonathan's friendship, Jonathan took off his robe and gave it to David. Jonathan also gave David Jonathan's armor, sword, bow, and belt. By doing this, Jonathan showed his deep respect and love for David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am grateful to be David's close friend and want David to know that; or
- David is more famous than I am because of what David did to Goliath, but I do not feel threatened by David. I trust God and support David.

Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love Jonathan and am so grateful for Jonathan's friendship; or
- I am humbled that my friend supports me and gave me his armor and weapons.

Continue the drama. Whatever tasks King Saul gave David to do, David did them successfully. Because David did everything so well, Saul promoted David to be a high-ranking officer in Saul's army. All the other soldiers and officers in Saul's army were happy about David's position. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the soldiers and officers in Saul's army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We approve of David because we see that David trusts God; or
- We know David is a good leader and are happy to follow David.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 17:55–18:5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

As Saul watches David walk towards Goliath, Saul asks Abner, his army **commander**, about David's father. The commander of an army leads a large group of soldiers into battles. Use the same word or phrase for commander as you used in previous passages.

Saul asks Abner whose **son** David is. A son is the male child of his parents. Use the same word or phrase for son as you used in previous passages. For more information on son, refer to the Master Glossary.

1 Samuel 17:55–18:5

David tells Saul that David's father is Jesse, Saul's **servant**. A servant is a man or woman who works for another person. A servant may live in the same house as his master. Jesse did not live in King Saul's house, but Jesse was loyal to Saul as a king. Use the same word for servant as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul wants to know more about **David**. David was the youngest son of a man named Jesse. David took care of his father's sheep, but later, David became a commander in King Saul's army. For more information on David, refer to the Master Glossary.

Some time after Saul and David finished talking, Saul's son Jonathan and David became best friends. Jonathan and David's souls were bound together. God created people with thoughts, feelings, and desires. We cannot see this part of a person, but we know it is there. In the Bible, people usually call this invisible part of a person a soul.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **soul**. Look up soul in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

From this time forward, Saul kept David at Saul's court and did not send David to David's father's home in Bethlehem. Jonathan made a **covenant** with David because Jonathan loved David as much as Jonathan loved himself. A covenant is a solemn promise people make to each other that they cannot break. When people make a covenant together, they say they want to have a good relationship with each other. Use the same word or phrase for covenant as you used in previous passages. For more information on covenant, refer to the Master Glossary.

As a sign of their deep friendship, Jonathan gave David Jonathan's robe, armor, sword, bow, and belt. A robe was an outer garment that people wore over other clothing. Armor was a metal covering people wore to protect themselves in battle. A sword had a long, pointed metal end that people used as a weapon in battle. People made bows out of a curved piece of wood held tight by a string. People used bows to shoot arrows. Jonathan's belt probably tied his robe over Jonathan's armor and may have held a dagger or a short sword. Use the same words or phrases for robe, armor, sword, bow, and belt as you used in previous passages and see the Master Glossary for more information about robe, if needed.

Stop here and look at a picture of a man wearing a robe, armor, and a belt. Look at a picture of a sword and a bow. Pause this audio here.

Whatever Saul gave David to do, David did it well. Saul promoted David to a high rank or position of authority within Saul's army, and all of Saul's soldiers and officers were pleased.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 17:55–18:5

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (417 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (637 KB)

1 Samuel 18:6–16

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 18:6–16 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:6–16 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:6–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Saul asked David who David's father was. Later, David and Saul's son Jonathan became best friends and swore a covenant with one another. Saul promoted David to be a high-ranking official in Saul's army, and all the other soldiers and officers approved.

This passage begins with another look back at something that already happened. This is what happened after David had killed the Philistine Goliath. David and the other soldiers, including King Saul, were returning home. When the men passed through each town in Israel, women came out to greet King Saul. The women wanted to honor King Saul for his victory over the Philistines. The women celebrated with joyful songs and danced. The women played music on their tambourines and stringed instruments. People often used a tambourine, which is a small, round drum, in celebrations. We are not sure what kind of stringed instrument this was, but it was probably a lute or sistrum. It may have been an instrument with three strings or an instrument like a triangle with three sides that would make a jingling sound when someone shook it.

Stop here and look at a picture of a tambourine and a picture of a lute or sistrum. Pause this audio here.

The women celebrated Saul's victory and sang a song which said, "Saul has killed thousands of the enemy, and David has killed tens of thousands of them." This does not mean that Saul and David killed this exact number of people. The women wanted to celebrate that their leaders had been victorious over a great number of enemies.

1 Samuel 18:6–16

The women probably were not trying to say that David was better than King Saul because David had killed more men. The women were celebrating the victory of both men.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture celebrate a military victory? Pause this audio here.

King Saul did not like the words of the song the women sang, so Saul became very angry. Saul thought, "The people say that David has killed tens of thousands of the enemy, and I have killed only thousands. If the people keep honoring David this way, soon the people will want to make David king instead of me!" So from that time on, Saul watched David suspiciously because Saul was jealous of David.

The next day, an evil spirit from God came forcefully on Saul. We do not know if God himself sent the evil spirit or allowed the evil spirit to control Saul, but we know that the spirit of God had left Saul. The evil spirit overwhelmed, harmed, and distressed Saul. Saul was acting wildly or was not in Saul's right mind. Saul did not act like Saul was in control of his behavior or speech. As Saul acted wildly, David played the lyre. A lyre is a musical instrument with strings like a harp. We know from a previous passage that David regularly played the lyre to comfort King Saul when Saul was upset.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where someone acts like they are not in control of their behavior. How does the person look and act? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a lyre as a group. Pause this audio here.

Saul had Saul's spear in Saul's hand. This spear was probably a special spear that was a sign of Saul's authority as king. Suddenly, Saul threw Saul's spear at David. Saul thought Saul would kill David by pinning David to the wall with Saul's spear. To pin someone to a wall means to throw a spear so hard that the spear goes through the person and sticks into the wall, so the person cannot move. Saul tried this twice, but each time David jumped away.

Stop here and look at a picture of a spear as a group. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh was with David, but Yahweh had left Saul. Therefore, Saul began to be afraid of David. So Saul sent David away from Saul and made David the commander over 1,000 soldiers. David led the soldiers into their battles and returned victoriously to his people. David was successful and won every battle because Yahweh was with David. When Saul saw how successful David was, Saul was even more afraid of David. But everyone else in Israel and Judah loved David because David led their soldiers into battle so well.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:6–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: When the Israelite army was returning home after David defeated Goliath, the Israelite women came out from every town to honor King Saul and rejoiced with singing, dancing, and musical instruments. The women's song said, "Saul has killed his thousands, and David has killed his tens of thousands." Saul did not like the words of this song, so Saul was angry. Saul thought the people might try to make David king instead of Saul, so Saul watched David suspiciously from then on.

In the second scene: The next day, God sent an evil spirit that came forcefully on Saul. Saul was acting wildly in Saul's house while David tried to comfort Saul by playing the lyre, as David often did. Saul tried twice to kill David by throwing his spear at David to pin David to the wall, but David jumped away both times.

In the third scene: Because Yahweh was with David but had left Saul, Saul was afraid of David. So Saul sent David away and made David a commander of 1,000 soldiers. David led the soldiers and won every battle because Yahweh was with David. When Saul saw all of David's success, Saul became even more afraid of David, but all of Israel and Judah loved David because he led the soldiers victoriously.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- David
- The Israelite army
- The Israelite women
- The evil spirit from God
- David's unit of 1,000 soldiers
- And the people of Israel and Judah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, we have a flashback to an earlier passage. When David had defeated Goliath and all the Israelite soldiers were returning to their homes, the women came out of every town the men passed through to greet King Saul. The women wanted to honor Saul for Saul's victory over the Philistines. When the women came out, the women celebrated with joyful songs and dancing and played tambourines and stringed instruments. The women sang a song that said, "Saul has killed thousands of enemies, but David has killed tens of thousands." People used phrases like these as a kind of special way to talk about how both men killed many enemies. The women probably did not want to compare David and Saul, but we can understand how Saul might have thought the women were saying David was more successful at killing enemies than Saul.

The women were happy that the Israelite army had defeated the Philistines and that their soldiers were returning home. The women celebrated both Saul's and David's victory. But King Saul did not like the words to the song, so Saul became very angry. "The people believe David has killed tens of thousands of enemies, and I have only killed thousands," Saul thought. "Soon the people will want David to be king instead of me!" From then on, Saul did not trust David and watched David closely.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where someone says something good about someone else, but the other person thinks that the first person is saying something bad even though they use the same words. How can you explain how people can hear the same words but understand those words differently? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the next day, an evil spirit came upon Saul forcefully. This means that the spirit overwhelmed Saul and distressed Saul greatly. Saul was raving or acting wildly in Saul's house. Saul's words and actions were so wild that Saul did not look or sound like Saul was in control of himself. David was with Saul and was playing the lyre. You will remember from an earlier passage that David often played the lyre to comfort King Saul when Saul was distressed.

Saul had his spear in his hand, and suddenly, Saul threw this spear at David. Saul wanted to kill David by pinning David to the wall, which means to throw a spear so hard that it goes through a person and sticks the person to the wall. Saul threw his spear at David two times, but each time David jumped away.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who lost control of himself or behaved in a wild way. Act out your story and think about what words you use to describe that person's actions. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, Saul became afraid of David because Yahweh was with David, but Yahweh had left Saul. So, Saul sent David away and made David the commander of 1,000 soldiers. David led the soldiers in their battles. David won every battle because Yahweh was with David. When Saul saw all of David's victories, Saul was even more afraid of David. But all of Israel and Judah loved David because David went out and came in before the soldiers. This is a way to say that David led the soldiers victoriously.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where someone is successful in everything that person does. What words do you use to describe someone who always seems to succeed? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:6–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

1 Samuel 18:6–16

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- David
- The Israelite army
- The Israelite women
- The evil spirit from God
- David's unit of 1,000 soldiers
- And the people of Israel and Judah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

When David had killed Goliath, the Israelite soldiers were returning to their homes. When the soldiers passed through the towns in Israel, the women came out to honor King Saul. The women sang joyful songs, danced, and played musical instruments. The women sang a song that said, "Saul has killed thousands of enemies, and David has killed tens of thousands of enemies!" King Saul did not like the words to this song, so Saul became very angry. Saul thought to himself, "The people believe David has killed ten times the number of enemies that I have killed. Soon, the people will want David to be king instead of me!" So from then on, Saul watched David closely because Saul did not trust David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I deserve more honor than David because I am king and David is not! or
- I had better be watching in case David or the people decide they do not want me to be king anymore. I cannot trust David.

Ask the people playing the Israelite women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- We celebrate both Saul and David because they both led our soldiers to be victorious in the battle; or
- We are impressed with David's bravery. We trust in Yahweh, and we notice that David is a good leader.

Continue the drama. The next day, God sent an evil spirit to King Saul, and this spirit came on Saul forcefully. Saul was in Saul's house. Saul was acting wildly and did not seem to have control over his own thoughts or actions. David was with Saul, and David was playing the lyre to comfort Saul, as David often did. Saul had his spear in his hand, and suddenly, Saul threw the spear at David. Saul wanted to kill David by pinning David against the wall with Saul's spear. Saul threw his spear at David twice, but both times David jumped away and was safe. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the evil spirit from God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want Saul to be angry and afraid because God is no longer with Saul; or
- I am determined to make Saul try to kill the next king Yahweh has chosen.

Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not understand why Saul is so angry with me when I have obeyed and served Saul well; or
- I am afraid that the king of Israel will kill me; or

1 Samuel 18:6–16

- I am afraid, but I will trust Yahweh no matter what Saul does because I know Yahweh is with me.

Continue the drama. Yahweh was with David, but Yahweh was not with Saul anymore, so Saul was afraid of David. Therefore, Saul sent David away and made David commander over 1,000 soldiers. David led the soldiers in their military campaigns and won every battle. David was victorious because Yahweh was with David. When Saul saw all of David's victories, Saul was even more afraid of David. But all the people of Israel and Judah loved David, because David faithfully led the soldiers into battle and won every time. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing David's 1,000 soldiers, "What are you feeling and thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We trust David with our lives because we can tell Yahweh is with David; or
- We love David because David is with us and leads us well.

Ask the people playing the people of Israel and Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are beginning to trust David more and more because David is a great leader; or
- We believe David would make a good king.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:6–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

When the soldiers were returning home after David defeated Goliath, the women of **Israel** came out to greet King Saul. Use the same word for Israel that you have used in previous passages, and remember that Israel is in the Master Glossary.

The women sang with joy, danced, and played the **tambourine** and stringed instruments. A tambourine is a small, round drum that people often used in celebrations. Use the same word for tambourine as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a tambourine as a group. Pause this audio here.

We are not sure exactly what the stringed instrument was, but it was probably a lute or sistrum. These had three strings or a triangle with three sides that made a jingling sound when people moved it.

Stop here and look at a picture of a lute or sistrum as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for these stringed instruments. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The women of Israel sang a song about Saul and **David** and how those men had killed their enemies. Saul did not like the song, so Saul was angry. Saul believed the people might want to make David king instead of Saul. David was Jesse's son, and Samuel anointed David to be king after Saul. David became a commander in King Saul's army. Use the same word for David as you used in previous passages. For more information on David, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul is afraid that David will become **king** or take over the **kingdom**. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory. A kingdom is the territory or people that a king rules. You may want to translate this so that people understand that Saul is afraid that the people will make David their king. Use the same words for king and kingdom as you used in previous passages. For more information on king and kingdom, refer to the Master Glossary.

The next day, an **evil spirit** from God overwhelmed Saul. Evil spirits are spirits that God created, but that chose to rebel against God. Because God created the spirit, God can still use the spirit to do what God wants. Evil spirits can take control of people and make those people act in strange ways. Use the same word or phrase for evil spirit as you used in previous passages. For more information on evil spirit, refer to the Master Glossary.

1 Samuel 18:6–16

Saul was raving in Saul's house. To rave means to act wildly or ecstatically. Saul did not appear to be in control of Saul's thoughts or actions. Saul was speaking messages, but those messages were not coherent or true. The word the storyteller uses means "to prophesy," but this does not mean that Saul was speaking the words of God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **rave**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

While Saul raved, David played the lyre as David often did to comfort King Saul. A **lyre** was a musical instrument like a harp with strings. Use the same word or phrase for lyre as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a lyre as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Saul held a spear in his hand that Saul used to try and pin David to the wall. A **spear** is a weapon with a pointed tip and a long shaft. Saul's spear may have been a symbol of his authority as king. Use the same word for spear as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a spear as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Saul was afraid of David because **Yahwe**h was with David, but Yahweh was not with Saul anymore. Yahweh is the name God gives himself. This name reminds people of the close relationship God had with the people of Israel. Use the same word for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul made David **commander** over 1,000 men. A commander was an officer in the army who led a group of soldiers. Use the same word for commander as you used in previous passages.

Because Yahweh was with David, David never lost a battle. When Saul saw David's success, Saul was even more afraid of David, but the people of Israel and Judah loved David because David led the soldiers well.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 18:6–16

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (391 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.1 MB)

- Defining the Scenes (2.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (633 KB)

1 Samuel 18:17–30

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 18:17–30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:17–30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:17–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Saul was angry with David and watched David carefully because Saul was jealous. When an evil spirit came upon Saul, Saul tried to kill David. Saul feared David and sent David away to be a commander in the army. But all of Israel and Judah loved David because David led the soldiers well and won many battles.

One day, Saul says to David, “You know my older daughter Merab. I will give you permission to marry Merab if you will serve me by being brave and fighting Yahweh’s battles.” The people in Israel believed the battles they fought against other nations were Yahweh’s wars against nations that did not worship Yahweh. You will remember from a previous passage that, before David fought against Goliath, Saul had promised to give Saul’s daughter to be the wife of the man who defeated Goliath. But Saul has not yet kept that promise to David.

Saul is still jealous and afraid of David, so Saul is secretly thinking that the Philistines will kill David, and Saul will not have to do it himself. David answers Saul, “How am I worthy of such an honor? Who am I, and who is my father’s clan?” A clan is a group of families from the same ancestor. David does not expect Saul to answer David’s questions. David is telling Saul that it is a great honor to have a chance to marry Saul’s daughter, but David is not from an important family. David does not believe he is worthy or important enough to marry Saul’s daughter.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time in your culture where an important person treated an unimportant person in a surprising and honorable way. How did the unimportant person respond? How did other people in the community respond to what happened? Pause this audio here.

When the time comes for David to marry Merab, however, Saul allows another man to marry Merab. This man’s name is Adriel, and Adriel is from the town of Meholah. We do not know exactly how much time passes between the time Saul tells David that David can marry Merab and the time when David and Merab are supposed to be married. We also do not know exactly why Saul chooses to allow Adriel to marry Merab instead of David. Saul may have thought the Philistines would kill David before the time when Saul had to allow David to marry Merab.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, what happens when someone changes their mind after they make a promise? Pause this audio here.

However, Saul's other daughter, Michal, had fallen in love with David. When someone tells Saul, Saul is happy to hear the news. Saul wants David to desire to marry Michal so much that David will be willing to fight the Philistines. In this way, Saul will use Michal as a snare, or a trap, to try to get David killed in battle with the Philistines.

Stop here and look at a picture of a snare as a group. Pause this audio here.

So Saul says to David a second time, "I will give you permission to marry my daughter, and you will become my son-in-law." A son-in-law is the husband of a father's daughter. Then Saul orders his servants to speak privately with David and say to David, "Listen, the king is very pleased with you, and all of us and the officials are loyal to you. So accept the king's offer, and marry the king's daughter."

Saul's servants obey Saul. We do not know if the servants speak directly to David or just speak so that David can hear what the servants say. When David hears the servants' words, David says, "How could I ever hope to get such an honor to marry the king's daughter? It seems impossible for someone who is poor and unknown like me." David knows that, to marry a woman, a man has to pay a bride price. A bride price is a sum of money that the groom has to pay the bride's father. David knows that the price to marry a king's daughter would be very high, and David cannot pay the king much money. David says he is not rich or famous enough to be a part of Saul's royal family.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time a man wanted to marry a woman. What did the man or woman have to do in order for the woman's family to allow the man to marry the woman? Pause this audio here.

Saul's servants tell Saul what David said. Saul understands that David wants to marry Michal, but David does not believe David will be able to pay the bride price. Saul commands Saul's servants to go back to David and to tell David that Saul does not want money for the bride price. Instead, Saul wants the foreskins of 100 Philistine men. Saul wants David to kill 100 Philistine soldiers and bring the soldiers' foreskins to Saul to prove that David killed the soldiers. When someone circumcised a man, that person removed the foreskin from the man's penis. The Israelite men were all circumcised, but the Philistine men were not. Saul knows this will be good proof that David has killed that many Philistines. Saul is actually plotting to have the Philistines kill David. Saul does not believe David can kill and circumcise that many Philistines.

Saul's servants tell David what Saul said, and David is happy that he can marry Saul's daughter, Michal. So David and David's men quickly go to fight the Philistines. Together, David and his men kill more Philistine soldiers than Saul had required. David may kill as many as 200 Philistines, or David may just kill more Philistines than necessary. David cuts off the Philistine men's foreskins and brings the foreskins to King Saul even sooner than Saul had asked. David shows the king that David brings the full number of foreskins that Saul required so that David can marry Saul's daughter. Then Saul allows David to marry Michal.

When Saul realizes that Yahweh is with David and that Saul's daughter Michal loves David, Saul grows even more afraid of David. Saul hates David and remains David's enemy for the rest of Saul's life.

The commanders of the Philistine army continue to lead the Philistines into battle against the Israelites. Whenever the Philistines do this, David defeats the Philistines more completely than any of Saul's other officers. Therefore, David becomes very well known. Everyone knows who David is and honors David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a young man in your culture who becomes famous because he did something good.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:17–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Saul tells David that Saul will allow David to marry Saul's older daughter, Merab, if David will be brave and fight in all of Yahweh's battles. Saul secretly wants the Philistines to kill David. David tells Saul that

David is not important or worthy enough to marry Saul's daughter. Saul eventually allows another man, Adriel, from the town of Meholah, to marry Merab.

In the second scene: Saul's other daughter, Michal, had already fallen in love with David. Saul is pleased and thinks that this time, Saul might be able to use Michal as a snare for David so that the Philistines might kill David. A second time, Saul tells David that Saul will allow David to marry one of Saul's daughters.

In the third scene: Saul tells his servants to go to David privately and say that Saul is pleased with David, that all the servants and officials are loyal to David, and that David should marry Saul's daughter. Saul's servants obey. When David hears what the servants say, David says he would feel honored to marry Saul's daughter, but David is poor and unimportant in Israel. David really means that David would be unable to pay the bride price to marry Saul's daughter.

In the fourth scene: Saul's servants report David's words back to Saul, and Saul says the only bride price Saul wants David to pay is 100 Philistine foreskins. Saul secretly hopes David will not be able to kill that many Philistines, and the Philistines will kill David. However, David kills more Philistines than Saul requested and brings Saul the full number of foreskins that Saul wanted. Saul allows David to marry Michal.

In the fifth scene: Saul realizes Yahweh is with David, and even Saul's daughter loves David. Saul feels even more fear and hatred towards David. Saul continues to feel this way for the rest of Saul's life. David continues to defeat the Philistines each time the Philistines attack, and David becomes famous and honored throughout Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- David
- Merab
- Adriel
- Michal
- Philistines
- And Saul's servants

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, one day, Saul comes to David and says, "You know my older daughter Merab. If you serve me as a courageous and faithful soldier and fight Yahweh's battles, I will allow you to marry her." However, Saul does not speak truthfully to David. Saul is thinking that if David fights in battles and if the Philistines kill David in those battles, Saul will not have to kill David himself. Saul does not want to raise a hand against David, which means that Saul does not want to harm David himself. David answers, "How am I worthy of such an honor? How could you think my family and clan are so important?" David answers Saul politely, but David does not believe that his family is worthy of the honor of marrying into the king's family. David's clan includes David's extended family, which is a group of families descended from the same ancestor.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In the previous step, you told a story about an important person and an unimportant person in your culture. What words do you use to describe someone who is important and someone who is unimportant? Pause this audio here.

Instead of giving Saul's daughter to David as David's wife, Saul had caused Saul's daughter to marry a man named Adriel, who was from the town of Meholah. We do not know why Saul changed his decision. However, we know Saul hated David, and Saul may have thought the Philistines would kill David before David could marry Merab.

In the second scene, Saul's other daughter, Michal, had fallen in love with David. To fall in love means that someone develops romantic feelings for someone else. Michal felt great affection for David. When someone tells Saul, Saul is pleased. Saul thinks to himself, "I will allow David to marry Michal. Maybe I can use Michal as a snare for David so the Philistines will kill David." Saul thinks that David might be so happy to marry Michal that David will be willing to fight the Philistines more, and the Philistines will kill David. Saul promises David for the second time that David can marry one of Saul's daughters.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story in which someone says he wants something good to happen, but this person really wants something bad to happen. What words communicate that the person's intention is not what the person says? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Saul tells his servants to go to David privately and say, "Listen, the king is pleased with you, and all of us and the officials are loyal to you. You should marry the king's daughter." The servants obey Saul and either speak to David or speak so that David can hear them. But David responds, "How could I ever receive the honor of marrying a king's daughter? It seems impossible that someone as poor and unimportant as I could receive such an honor." David knows that to marry a king's daughter will require a high bride price. David is concerned that David will be unable to pay the bride price.

In the fourth scene, Saul's servants report back to Saul what David said. Saul tells the servants to go back to David and tell David, "The king is not asking for money. The only bride price King Saul wants is the foreskins of 100 Philistines. This is how the king will have revenge on his enemies." The Israelites were circumcised, but the Philistines were not circumcised. Saul wants David to circumcise the dead Philistines and bring the foreskins to Saul to prove the Philistines are dead. But Saul actually has a secret plan. Saul hopes that David will not be successful and that the Philistines will kill David.

Saul's servants take the message to David, and David accepts the bride price because David is happy to marry Saul's daughter, Michal. So, earlier than the time Saul set for David to bring the bride price, David and David's men go and fight with the Philistines and kill more men than Saul had asked for. David brings the Philistines' foreskins to Saul and counts the foreskins out completely in front of Saul. So Saul agrees to let David marry his daughter, Michal.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who completes a task that seems impossible, and that person does the task much better than anyone expected. Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, when Saul sees and knows that Yahweh is with David, and that even Saul's daughter Michal loves David, Saul fears David even more. As long as Saul lives, Saul hates David.

The Philistine commanders often lead the Philistines into battle against the Israelites. Each time they fight, David defeats the Philistines more completely than any of the other officers in the Israelite army. So David becomes famous, and everyone knows David's name.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:17–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- David
- Merab
- Adriel
- Michal
- Philistines
- And Saul's servants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

One day, Saul said to David, “You know my older daughter Merab. If you will serve me by being a brave and faithful soldier and fight in all of Yahweh’s battles, I will allow you to marry my daughter.” Saul secretly thought that the Philistines would kill David, so Saul would not have to kill David. David responded politely, “How am I worthy of the honor of marrying the king’s daughter? How could you consider my family and my clan to be so important in Israel that you would invite me to marry the daughter of the king?” But when the time came for David to marry Merab, Saul did not keep his promise. Instead, Saul allowed a man named Adriel from Meholah to marry Merab. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking? The person might answer things like:

- I feel honored that King Saul wants me to marry Saul’s daughter, but I feel so unworthy; or
- I am suspicious that King Saul might have plans that Saul is not telling me; or
- Sometimes I feel unworthy to marry a king’s daughter. Other times, I feel upset that King Saul promised to let me marry Saul’s daughter, but then allowed someone else to marry her.

Ask the person playing Merab, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy that I could marry a man as famous and great as David; or
- I feel confused that my father allowed another man to marry me and did not keep his promise to David.

Continue the drama. However, Saul’s other daughter, Michal, had fallen in love with David. When someone tells Saul, Saul is pleased and thinks to himself, “I will allow David to marry Michal. I hope I can use Michal as a snare for David, and the Philistines will kill David.” A second time, Saul tells David that David can marry one of Saul’s daughters. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that I have another chance to get the Philistines to kill David; or
- I want David to believe I am pleased with him, but I really want David to die because I am afraid of David and how much the people love David.“

Continue the drama. Saul tells his servants to go to David privately and tell David, “Listen, the king is pleased with you, and all of us are loyal to you. You should marry the king’s daughter.” David responds and says, “How could I ever receive the honor of marrying the king’s daughter? I am poor and unimportant in Israel. This seems impossible.” Although David did not say it, David knew that he would probably be unable to pay the bride price to marry Saul’s daughter. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Saul’s servants, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We trust David and want to follow David; or
- We want to obey Saul, but we also want David to marry Saul’s daughter because we love David.

Continue the drama. Saul’s servants report back to Saul what David said. When the servants tell Saul that David does not believe David can pay the bride price to marry Saul’s daughter, Saul tells the servants to return to David. The servants should tell David, “The king does not want money for the bride price. All the king wants are the foreskins of 100 Philistines, and you will be able to marry his daughter.” When the servants tell David what Saul said, David is happy to agree to pay that price. David is happy to marry Saul’s daughter Michal.

So, earlier than the time Saul set for David to pay the bride price, David and David’s men quickly go to the Philistines and kill more men than King Saul had requested. David brings the full number of foreskins to Saul to prove that David has killed more men than Saul had asked. So Saul allows David to marry Michal. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Philistines, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We keep fighting against David, but we keep losing the battles! or
- We cannot believe that this one man has so much power to keep defeating us.

Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel joyful that I was able to give Saul what he wanted and to marry Michal; or
- I celebrate that I defeated the Philistines and proved I am worthy to marry the king’s daughter.

Continue the drama. When Saul realized that Yahweh was with David and that even Saul’s daughter Michal loved David, Saul was even more afraid of David. Saul hated David for the rest of Saul’s life.

The Philistines continued to attack the Israelites in battle. Every time they did, David defeated the Philistines more completely than any of Saul’s other officers, so David became very famous in Israel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 18:17–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Saul tells **David** that Saul will allow David to marry Saul’s older daughter, Merab, if David serves Saul bravely and fights **Yahweh’s** battles. David was a commander in Saul’s army, and Yahweh helped David to win many battles. Yahweh is God’s personal name. This name showed the close relationship that God had with the people of Israel. Use the same words or phrases for David and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on David and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul offers to let David marry Saul’s daughter. David says that David’s family and **clan** are not important in **Israel**. A clan is a group of families descended from the same ancestor. Use the same words or phrases for clan and Israel as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information about Israel.

David says he is not important enough to marry Saul’s daughter and to become Saul’s son-in-law. A son-in-law is the husband of a man’s daughter.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **son-in-law**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When the time comes for David to marry Merab, Saul allows another man to marry Merab. However, Saul’s other daughter, Michal, had fallen in love with David. Saul is pleased and wants David to marry Michal. Saul hopes that Michal will be a snare for David so that David will fight the Philistines more, and that the Philistines will kill David. A snare is a trap that people use to catch animals. Saul wants David’s marriage to Michal to trap David into fighting the Philistines.

Stop here and look at a picture of a snare as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **snare**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul sends Saul’s **servants** to speak to David privately and to encourage David to marry Michal. A servant is a man or woman who works for another person. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

David says to the servants that David would be honored to marry the king’s daughter, but David is poor and unknown in Israel. David does not believe David can pay the bride price to marry Michal. A bride price is a sum of money or goods that the man who wants to marry the bride gives to the bride’s family.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bride price**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul tells his servants to let David know that the only bride price Saul wants is 100 Philistine foreskins. The foreskin is the skin at the tip of a penis that someone removes to circumcise the man. The Israelite men were circumcised, but the Philistine men were not circumcised. Saul wanted David to show that David had killed the number of Philistine men that Saul requested by circumcising those men and bringing the foreskins to Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foreskin**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David is happy to agree to do what Saul asks so that David can marry Michal. David and his men kill more Philistines than Saul requested and bring the full number of foreskins to Saul. Saul allows David to marry Michal.

When Saul realizes that Yahweh is with David and Michal loves David, Saul is even more afraid of David and remains David's enemy for the rest of Saul's life. The Philistines continue to attack the Israelites, but David defeats the Philistines more completely than any other of Saul's officers. So David becomes very famous in Israel. Everyone knows who David is.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 18:17–30

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (392 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (603 KB)

1 Samuel 19:1–10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 19:1–10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:1–10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 19:1–10

3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passages, King Saul realized that his son-in-law, David, had become more famous and that the people of Israel respected David. At the beginning of this story, King Saul orders his son, Jonathan, and Saul's household servants to kill David. Some translations refer to King Saul's household as servants, but most people believe that the people King Saul spoke to were not servants who cooked or cleaned, but were instead Saul's close advisors and companions in the royal court. This was an important command because a king may punish people if those people do not obey the king's commands.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Israel and the land of the Philistines. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who in your culture has the most power to order people to do a task? What happens if a person refuses or fails to do the task? How does a leader punish a person if the person does not obey the leader's command? Pause this audio here.

It is likely that Jonathan found this order difficult because Jonathan was King Saul's son and heir, but Jonathan was also David's close friend. The storyteller says that Jonathan "delighted much in David" or "was greatly fond of David." Jonathan does not want to harm David, so Jonathan tells David that King Saul wants to kill David. Jonathan gives David directions on the same day that King Saul gives the command. Jonathan knows that Jonathan needs to warn David quickly.

Jonathan urges David to be "on guard" or to be aware, because King Saul could attack David at any time. Jonathan seems to be the only person who warns David of the plan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time you helped a friend in a difficult situation. How did you help that friend get out of trouble? Has a friend ever given you help when you were in trouble? If so, share your experience with the group. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan tells David to go out into a field and hide. While this could be a field for planting and growing crops, it is more likely that this is an open field in the countryside where David can hide. The location is not as important as the reason. Jonathan tells David to hide because Jonathan will bring his father, King Saul, to the field to convince Saul not to kill David or have anyone else kill David. This may seem like an odd or risky decision. However, Jonathan might have done this so that David could trust that Jonathan was doing what Jonathan said he would do. Jonathan vowed to "speak well" of David. This means that Jonathan would help King Saul see why King Saul should not have his servants kill David. Jonathan also promised to tell David if Jonathan learned anything new about King Saul's plans or intentions.

Stop here and look at a photo of an open field in the countryside. Pause this audio here.

The next morning, David does what Jonathan told him to do. David hides and listens for Jonathan and King Saul. Jonathan and Saul come into the field, and Jonathan acts as a mediator, or someone who tries to bring peace and understanding between two or more people. Jonathan honors his father's role as king by addressing Saul as king first before speaking to Saul as Jonathan's father. Jonathan asks the king not to kill the king's servant, David. Jonathan calls David a servant because David honors the king by serving Saul. Jonathan gives King Saul reasons why Saul should not kill David when Jonathan says that David has not sinned against the king and that everything David has done has actually brought good things to King Saul. David is a strong fighter. David's fame also gives King Saul a good reputation as someone who is strong and powerful.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you show honor in your culture? How do a hero's actions make the leaders of your community look good or become famous? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan also reminds Saul that, as a king, Saul should avoid killing an innocent person. Saul agrees and makes a promise not to kill David. Again, Yahweh uses Jonathan to bring peace between King Saul and David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do people make promises or vows in your culture? Think of a time you made an important promise and kept it. Share this story with the group. Pause this audio here.

After King Saul makes his oath not to kill David, Jonathan calls out for David to come to Jonathan. It is likely that some time passed between Saul's vow and Jonathan calling for David. It is also likely that Saul was not present when Jonathan and David spoke. Jonathan does not assume that David heard the conversation, even though David was in the same field as Jonathan and Saul. Instead, Jonathan tells David what happened during the conversation. Again, this shows David that David can trust Jonathan to keep Jonathan's promises and that Jonathan is a close friend and protector. Because of King Saul's vow, Jonathan brings David back to serve King Saul. David seems to trust King Saul enough to return to serve Saul.

After Jonathan speaks to David, people begin to go to war again, but we do not know how long after the conversation this happens. We find out who David, and likely the army, fights against when we learn that David defeats the Philistine army. The Philistine army flees, so it seems that the defeat is so great that the Philistines have no choice but to run away from the war. Once again, Israel and their enemies, the Philistines, recognize David's victory. It is likely that King Saul feels jealous of David, which may explain why King Saul becomes angry. David receives Yahweh's favor, and Yahweh's spirit rests on David. But an evil spirit from Yahweh comes and torments Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group: When you are angry or proud, how do you act towards other people or situations? How have you seen other people act when they are angry or proud? Pause this audio here.

As the evil spirit comes to King Saul, David is near Saul playing a stringed instrument called a lyre. At the same time, King Saul is holding a weapon called a spear. King Saul forgets the vow that Saul made not to kill David, and King Saul either lunges with or throws the spear at David. However, because Yahweh is protecting David, David is able to see and know what King Saul is doing. David avoids the spear, and that night, David runs away again to escape King Saul.

Stop here and look at a photo of a spear. Also, look at a photo of a lyre.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has eight scenes.

In the first scene: King Saul speaks to his son, Jonathan, as well as Saul's close advisors and officials. King Saul orders the men to kill David.

In the second scene: Jonathan tells David that King Saul is trying to kill David. Jonathan tells David to hide in a secret place for protection from King Saul.

In the third scene: David hides in an open field and waits for Jonathan and King Saul to speak.

In the fourth scene: Jonathan meets with King Saul in the open field where David is hiding. Jonathan asks King Saul to spare David's life, and Jonathan reminds King Saul of all the good David has done. King Saul agrees with Jonathan and vows not to kill David.

In the fifth scene: Jonathan calls out for David and tells David about the conversation with King Saul.

In the sixth scene: Jonathan takes David back to serve King Saul.

In the seventh scene: David goes to war with the Philistines, conquers the Philistine army, and causes the Philistines to run away.

1 Samuel 19:1–10

In the eighth scene: After David returns from war, David is back in the royal court and plays the lyre for King Saul. An evil spirit comes upon King Saul, and Saul lunges with or throws his spear at David to try to kill David. David escapes and does not return.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- Jonathan
- David
- King Saul's officials and advisors
- The Philistine army
- And the evil spirit from Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

As the story begins, King Saul speaks to Jonathan and Saul's officials and advisors and orders them to kill David. It is likely that this conversation takes place in the place where King Saul rules. This means that King Saul may be seated on his throne with Jonathan and the officials and advisors standing or kneeling in front of the throne to show respect to King Saul. It is possible that Jonathan feels confused between obeying his father, King Saul, and saving the life of Jonathan's closest friend, David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you feel if you were in charge of something and people praised someone else for the success? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan finds David in another place and tells David what King Saul is planning to do. Jonathan tells David to stay in a secret place and to hide near the field where Jonathan says he will talk to King Saul the next morning.

Jonathan tells David to be on his guard in the morning. Jonathan will speak to King Saul the morning after King Saul orders David's death, because Jonathan feels it is urgent to protect David.

As Jonathan speaks to King Saul in the open field, Jonathan reminds King Saul of all the good David has done for the people of Israel. It is possible that David hears and sees part of this conversation, since David is hiding in the same field. It is important to remember that David's good deeds have strengthened King Saul's reputation with other nations. In other words, when David is successful, it makes King Saul successful. Jonathan gives King Saul examples of how David has helped King Saul, including how David killed the Philistine Goliath. Jonathan tells King Saul that David "took his life in his own hands," or risked being killed, when David fought the Philistine. King Saul remembers these actions and seems to lose the desire to kill David. King Saul then makes an oath not to kill David and says, "As Yahweh lives, David will not be put to death." By saying "as Yahweh lives," King Saul makes a strong oath that King Saul must keep as long as Yahweh lives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what special words or phrases do you use to make a vow? How would you translate King Saul's vow? Pause this audio here.

When Jonathan shares with David that David is now safe, it is likely that David trusts Jonathan completely. That is probably why David agrees to go back to the royal court and be with King Saul.

The scene changes as David then goes to fight in a war. We do not know how long David had been back serving Saul before David left for war again. David successfully fights the Philistine army and returns more famous than before. David and the army fought so hard and so well that the Philistine army was frightened and ran away to save their lives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how would you translate the fact that David struck the Philistine army with such force that the army ran away? Pause this audio here.

Once again, King Saul is jealous to hear how famous David is and how successful David has been. Yahweh showed that Yahweh gave David "favor" or approval by giving David success in battle. King Saul seems to fear that Yahweh has taken Yahweh's approval from Saul and has given Yahweh's approval to David. An evil spirit from Yahweh comes and torments Saul. Yahweh has a bigger plan, and Yahweh knows that this must happen to Saul. King Saul then likely lunges with or throws his spear at David while David is playing the lyre in the royal court. Yahweh protects David, and David manages to move away quickly enough that Saul does not hurt David. The

spear remains stuck in the wall. That night, David runs away. David may have thought that King Saul would not give up trying to kill David until Saul succeeded.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has eight scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- Jonathan
- David
- King Saul's officials and advisors
- The Philistine army
- And the evil spirit from Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

This is a story about how King Saul tried to kill David. King Saul was frustrated and angry because David was very successful fighting in the war, and people praised David for all David did. King Saul decided to kill David. King Saul ordered Jonathan and Saul's advisors and officials to find and kill David. Jonathan was King Saul's son and David's close friend. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Saul, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that people are not honoring me! or
- I am jealous of David's successes; or
- How dare the people praise David more than me!

Continue the drama. Jonathan found David and told David that King Saul wanted Jonathan and the king's officials and advisors to find David and kill David. Jonathan told David to be on guard in the morning and to find a secret place and hide. Jonathan told David to hide in an open field because Jonathan planned to take King Saul to the same field to tell King Saul why Saul should not kill David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I am scared! or
- Can I trust what Jonathan is saying? or
- Why does Saul want to kill me?

Continue the drama. The next morning, David secretly hid in the field and waited for Jonathan and King Saul to come to the field to talk. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like, Continue the drama.

- I am afraid that King Saul will see me; or

- I feel lonely. I have no more friends; or
- Will Jonathan be able to convince King Saul not to kill me?

When David was hiding in the morning, King Saul and Jonathan came to the field to talk. Jonathan shared all of the good things David did for King Saul and the people of Israel, and Jonathan reminded King Saul why Saul should not kill David. Jonathan also helped King Saul remember what King Saul had seen with his own eyes. King Saul remembered watching David kill Goliath, and King Saul remembered rejoicing at all David had done. King Saul listened to Jonathan and agreed that David should not be killed. King Saul made an oath not to kill David for as long as Yahweh lived. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Saul, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- David has been good to me; or
- How could I forget those things that David did?

Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you thinking or feeling? The person might answer things like:

- I hope this works! or
- What should I say to convince my father not to kill David?

Continue the drama. After King Saul left, Jonathan called out for David, and Jonathan told David about the conversation with King Saul. David listened to what Jonathan said to King Saul about David's good deeds. Jonathan also told David that King Saul promised not to kill David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so relieved! or
- I still have a friend! or
- I am so grateful for Jonathan's help!

Continue the drama. David trusted Jonathan, so David went with Jonathan back to the royal court and stayed with King Saul again.

After some time, David went to war to fight against the Philistine army. David did very well. David did so well that the Philistine army fled in order to save their lives. This made David even more famous, and people praised David for all David had done.

When David returned from war, David returned to the royal court and played the lyre for King Saul. God showed favor to David, and King Saul could see this. An evil spirit came upon King Saul, and King Saul forgot his vow not to kill David. King Saul likely lunged with or threw his spear at David and missed. David was able to escape from King Saul's attempt to kill David. David fled that night. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so jealous of David! or
- I will feel better once I kill David!

Also, ask the person playing David, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I am scared that Saul will kill me! or
- I do not know who to trust!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

At the beginning of this story, King Saul speaks to his son, Jonathan, and to Saul's servants or officials and advisors. Saul orders the men to kill David. King Saul was the first king of Israel. Saul had a son named Jonathan who was a soldier and a close friend of David. David was also married to King Saul's daughter. The king told the king's servants and Jonathan to kill David. In this passage, the servants are probably really officials and advisors who served in the royal court near the king and helped the king make decisions by providing information and

1 Samuel 19:1–10

advice. You may translate this either as the king's officials or the king's servants. For more information about the word servant, see the Master Glossary. If you choose to use the word for servant, use the same word you have used in previous passages for servant.

If you choose to use the words **officials** and **advisors**, stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use. If you have already translated these words or phrases in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan meets with David and tells David that King Saul wants to kill David. Jonathan tells David to find a secret place to hide from King Saul. Jonathan tells David to hide in a field, and Jonathan says that Jonathan will bring King Saul to the field so Jonathan can speak with King Saul. Remember, an open field is not the same as a field where people grow crops. This type of field usually has high grass or overgrown plants.

Stop here and look at a picture of an open field as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss the best word to use for an **open field**, and use this word in future passages. Pause this audio here.

The next morning, Jonathan talks to King Saul in the open field where David is hiding. Jonathan reminds King Saul of all the good things David has done. Jonathan helps King Saul remember how David killed the **Philistine** and how David saved **Israel** from the **Philistines**. Look up Israel in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there.

Jonathan asks King Saul not to kill David, and Jonathan helps King Saul remember the moments that King Saul saw with his own eyes. King Saul remembers and is happy about all the things David has done. King Saul swears an **oath** not to kill David for as long as **Yahweh** lives. An oath is a promise that a person makes to another person. When a person makes an oath, Yahweh expects that person to keep the oath. Jonathan speaks to David about what King Saul promised to do, and David returns to be with King Saul. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh and oath as you used in previous passages. Look up oath and Yahweh in the Master Glossary for more information.

As people tell stories of David's victory, King Saul seems to become jealous and afraid of David's popularity and success. An evil spirit from Yahweh comes on King Saul, and Saul forgets the vow he made not to kill David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Based on what you have learned about Yahweh, how will you translate this part of the story? Look up evil spirit in the Master Glossary for more information. Discuss how you will translate "evil spirit." You may say something like "spirit from Yahweh that torments Saul," or "evil spirit from Yahweh."Pause this audio here.

As David is playing a stringed instrument, likely a lyre, King Saul lunges with or throws a **spear** at David and tries to kill David. A lyre was a small instrument with strings that a person could play with their hands. A spear was a weapon a person could use in battle. A spear had a sharp blade that people attached to the end of a stick. A person could use a spear to kill someone near them, or a person could throw the spear in order to kill someone farther away. David moves quickly out of the way of the spear. That night, David runs away. Use the same words for lyre and spear as you have used before.

Stop here and look at a picture of a lyre as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a spear as a group.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 19:1–10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (962 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

1 Samuel 19:11–24

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 19:11–24 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:11–24 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:11–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, King Saul attempted to kill David with a spear, but David escaped. Then David ran away and returned to his home. King Saul now sends messengers to watch or spy on David and make sure that David does not escape, so that they can kill David the next morning. However, David's wife, who is King Saul's daughter, Michal, warns David that King Saul wants to kill David. Michal urges David to leave immediately and not to wait until the morning. Remember, Michal and Jonathan are both working against King Saul's plan and are helping David escape.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do you think that both Jonathan and Michal were willing to help save David, even though their father, King Saul, wanted to kill David? Pause this audio here.

Michal creates a plan to help David escape, and Michal lowers David from the window. It is possible that David's house was part of the city wall, and David may have been able to leave the city by climbing out the window. Michal also places a household idol in David's bed with goat hair on it to try to trick King Saul's men into thinking David is asleep. Although Michal has an idol, there is no indication that David himself worshipped idols. People often made household idols in different sizes, and it is likely that this idol was a larger idol in the home, because Michal thought the size would trick people into thinking it was David himself.

Stop here and look at examples of household gods or idols. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at goat hair. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, is it acceptable for a person to go against their parents' wishes in order to protect or defend their husband or wife? What happens to someone if that person lies to their parents? Pause this audio here.

When King Saul's messengers arrive at David's house, the messengers demand to see David. Michal tells the men that David is sick. King Saul's men tell King Saul that David is sick, and King Saul orders his men to go back to the house, get David, and carry David on David's bed back to Saul so that King Saul can kill David. David's bed likely has a wooden frame and a wool mattress with blankets and pillows. However, when the men try to bring David to King Saul, the men realize that Michal has lied and that David has escaped. King Saul asks Michal why Michal lied to King Saul. Michal lies to King Saul and says that David forced Michal to help or that David said David would kill Michal. It is likely that Michal lied to King Saul in order to save Michal's own life and to hide her involvement in helping David escape.

Stop here and look at a picture of a bed from ancient times. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time when you told a lie to avoid getting into trouble. Share the details and the reason you lied. Tell how you felt when you lied. Pause this audio here.

After David escapes, David goes to a place called Ramah to see the prophet Samuel. David tells Samuel everything that King Saul did to David. It is important to remember that Samuel knows David well and is the prophet who anointed David as the future king of Israel. Samuel takes David with Samuel to live in Naioth. King Saul receives information that David is in Naioth, and King Saul sends men to capture David. However, when King Saul's men find Samuel in Naioth, the men see Samuel with other prophets who are prophesying. King Saul's men begin to prophesy also! In this case, the men were probably in a trance-like state and receiving messages from God. The men were probably not able to harm David.

Stop here and look at a map of David's route from David's home to Ramah and then David's route from Ramah to Naioth with Samuel. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: David runs to Samuel because David trusts Samuel. Think of a person you trust the most. If you were in trouble, who would you ask for help? Share with the group about your trusted person and why you would ask for that person's help. Pause this audio here.

When King Saul hears that Saul's men are prophesying, King Saul sends more men to capture David. But when the second group of men finds Samuel in Naioth, the Spirit of God comes on these men, and these men also start to prophesy. The Spirit of God takes control of the men and causes the men not to find and harm David. King Saul then sends a third group of men to capture David, but these men also begin to prophesy when they find Samuel. It is likely that King Saul feels very frustrated at this point, and Saul decides to go to Naoith himself to find Samuel and David.

Stop here and look again at a map of the route that David took and that King Saul and his men took. Pause this audio here.

When King Saul arrives at the great well in Seku, King Saul demands to see Samuel and David. Someone tells King Saul that Samuel and David are in Naoith in Ramah. King Saul journeys to find Samuel and David, but the Spirit of God falls on King Saul in the middle of the journey. When King Saul arrives where Samuel is, King Saul begins to prophesy in front of Samuel like Saul's men did before. King Saul takes his clothes off and lies on the

ground continuously during the day and night as Saul prophesies. The people around King Saul are surprised and ask if even King Saul is a prophet! In previous stories, King Saul prophesied to help show God's presence. But this time, it seems that King Saul is prophesying because the Spirit of God is protecting David and preventing King Saul from killing an innocent man.

Stop here and look at a photo of a well or cistern that people used to store water. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about the highest position in your culture. You may be thinking of a king, president, or leader. Picture that leader behaving like King Saul did when Saul prophesied. How would you react if you saw your leader behave like Saul?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:11–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has 12 scenes.

In the first scene: King Saul sends messengers or spies to watch David and to make sure David does not leave David's home.

In the second scene: Michal tells David that King Saul is trying to kill David. Michal urges David to leave immediately. Michal helps to lower David out of the house's window, and David escapes. Michal then places a household idol in David's bed to trick King Saul's men into believing that David is ill.

In the third scene: King Saul sends messengers or spies to take David to King Saul. Michal then says to the messengers that David is ill.

In the fourth scene: Messengers likely report to King Saul that David is ill. King Saul sends messengers once again, and King Saul tells the messengers to bring David on his bed to King Saul so that King Saul can kill David.

In the fifth scene: The messengers enter David and Michal's house to take David, and the messengers realize that David is not there. The men find the household idol that Michal has used as a disguise for David. The men then report back to King Saul.

In the sixth scene: King Saul likely calls for Michal, because King Saul and Michal talk about where David has gone. King Saul asks Michal why Michal lied to Saul and why Michal let Saul's enemy, David, go. Michal responds with a lie and says that David forced Michal to let David go or that David said he would kill Michal.

In the seventh scene: David has escaped and decides to travel to Ramah to find Samuel. David finds Samuel and tells Samuel all that King Saul has done to David. Samuel takes David to stay with Samuel in Naioth.

In the eighth scene: King Saul finds out where David is hiding, and King Saul sends men to find David and bring David back. When the men find Samuel, the Spirit of Yahweh falls on the men, and the men begin to prophesy and are unable to harm David.

In the ninth scene: King Saul hears about the men and decides to send more men to find and bring David back. Again, the men see Samuel and immediately begin to prophesy. These men are also unable to harm David.

In the tenth scene: A third time, King Saul sends men to find David. These men also begin to prophesy as soon as the men see Samuel and the other prophets.

In the eleventh scene: After sending three groups of men, King Saul is likely frustrated and decides to go himself to find David. King Saul stops at the great well of Seku to ask where David and Samuel are, and people tell Saul that David and Samuel are in Naioth. As King Saul continues on his journey, the Spirit of Yahweh falls on King Saul, and King Saul begins to prophesy like the other men did!

In the twelfth scene: King Saul arrives at Naoith. King Saul continues to prophesy when Saul sees Samuel and the other prophets. King Saul strips off his clothing and lies naked through the day and night as Saul continues to prophesy. All of the people watching are amazed and ask if King Saul is also a prophet.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- David
- Michal
- Messengers or spies
- Household idol
- Samuel
- Prophets
- Spirit of Yahweh
- Three separate groups of King Saul's men
- People near the great well of Seku
- And people who watch Samuel, King Saul, and the prophets

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

After King Saul tries to kill David with a spear, David runs home to David's wife, Michal. King Saul sends messengers to spy on David at David's house and to make sure David does not leave so that they can kill David in the morning.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What phrases do you use in your language for "spies" or people who secretly observe and report information back to a person in charge? Pause this audio here.

Michal warns David that Michal's father, King Saul, is going to kill David. Michal urges David to leave immediately, and Michal helps to lower David out the window so that David can escape in the night. Michal knows that King Saul will want proof that David is in the house, so Michal decides to put a household idol in David's bed. Michal covers the idol with clothes and goat hair to make the idol look like David. This idol is big enough that people could think the idol is a person when the idol is in a bed and blankets are on top of it.

Stop here and look at examples of household gods or idols. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at goat hair. Remember that a goat is a small animal like a sheep. Look at a photo of a goat. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words or phrases will you use to describe the household idol that Michal used? Pause the audio here.

When King Saul sends messengers to get David, Michal tells the messengers that David is ill. The messengers must then go back to give King Saul the news that Michal said David was ill. King Saul then demands that the messengers bring David on David's bed so that King Saul can kill David. The messengers then go back to David's house. When the messengers realize that Michal has tricked them, the messengers report back to King Saul. King Saul calls Michal and asks Michal why she has lied to Saul and why Michal has let Saul's enemy, David, escape. Michal lies to King Saul and says that David forced Michal to let David go, or that David said David would kill Michal.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the lie that Michal tells King Saul in order to protect herself? Pause this audio here.

After David escapes, David decides to go to Ramah and finds Samuel because David trusts Samuel. David tells Samuel everything that King Saul has done, and Samuel takes David to live with Samuel in Naioth. We are not sure where Naioth is, but it is possibly a camp where prophets lived together close to Ramah.

Stop here and look at a map of David's route from David's home to Ramah and then David's route from Ramah to Naioth with Samuel. Pause this audio here.

When someone tells King Saul where David is hiding, King Saul sends men to bring David back. However, when the men see Samuel and the group of prophets with Samuel prophesying and playing music, the Spirit of God falls on or controls King Saul's men. The men begin to prophesy and are unable to harm David. These men probably do not prophesy in the same way as other prophets. The Spirit of God controls the men, and the men are almost in a trance. The Spirit of God prevents the men from harming David. When Saul finds out, Saul sends more men. Once again, the men see Samuel, the Spirit of God falls on the men, and the men begin to prophesy. A third time,

1 Samuel 19:11–24

King Saul finds out and sends more men to bring David back. Again, the Spirit of God falls on the men, and the men prophesy when they see Samuel.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you describe the "Spirit of God" and how the Spirit falls on, or controls, King Saul's men? Pause this audio here.

Finally, King Saul decides to go himself to bring David back. King Saul travels to Ramah and stops at the great well of Seku to ask the people where David is. King Saul likely stops at the well because many people would often travel to wells to get water for their homes and to speak to other people. Wells were good places for people to stop and get information. When the people tell King Saul that David is in Naoith, King Saul continues on to find David. While King Saul is traveling, the Spirit of God falls on Saul, and Saul begins to prophesy like the men before him as Saul continues to travel along the road to find Samuel.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the route King Saul's men and King Saul would have taken to get to Naioth. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a photo of a well or cistern used for storing water. Pause this audio here.

When King Saul arrives in Naoith, Saul sees Samuel with a group of prophets that Samuel is teaching and training, and Saul continues to prophesy like before. King Saul strips his royal clothes off and lies on the ground during the day and night, while Saul continues to prophesy. It is possible that the other prophets were also naked. In this case, each man may have taken off his outer clothes but still worn his inner tunic. The Spirit of God controls both King Saul and Saul's men by causing the men to be in a trance-like state and naked. The people who are watching are amazed, and the people ask if King Saul is also a prophet!

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how would you describe a king removing his clothing like King Saul did? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:11–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has 12 scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- David
- Michal
- Messengers or spies
- Household idol
- Samuel
- Prophets
- Spirit of Yahweh
- Three separate groups of King Saul's men
- People near the Great Well of Secu
- And people who watch Samuel, King Saul, and the prophets

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After King Saul tries to kill David with a Spear, David escapes and runs home. King Saul sends messengers to David’s house to spy on David and to make sure that David does not leave the house. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the messengers or spies, “What are you thinking or feeling?” The person might answer things like:

- I do not want to disappoint King Saul! or
- We had better find David, or King Saul might kill us instead!

Continue the drama. Michal, David’s wife, warns David that King Saul is still trying to kill David. Michal urges David to leave the house immediately. Michal helps lower David from the window, and David escapes into the night. Meanwhile, Michal knows that she needs to make it look like David is asleep in the bed. So, Michal places a household god in the bed and covers it with clothing and goat hair to look like David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Michal, “What are you thinking or feeling?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so scared that my father is going to kill my husband! or
- I know I should not lie, but I am protecting my husband.

Continue the drama. King Saul sends messengers to get David and bring David to King Saul. Michal tells the men that David is ill and asleep in bed. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Saul, “What are you thinking or feeling?” The person might answer things like:

- I am finally going to get David! or
- Surely, my daughter, Michal, will understand and help me.

Continue the drama. After the men tell King Saul, King Saul tells the men to go and get David on David’s bed and bring David to King Saul so that Saul can kill David.

However, when the men go to see David, the men realize that Michal has lied and tricked the men into believing that David is ill. Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the messengers, “ What are you thinking or feeling?” The person might answer things like:

- Surely King Saul will be furious and kill us! or
- We should blame Michal for lying to us so that we do not get into trouble!

Continue the drama. When King Saul finds out, Saul calls his daughter, Michal, to come and see Saul. Saul asks Michal why she lied to Saul and why Michal let Saul’s enemy, David, escape. Michal lies again and says that David forced Michal to let David go, otherwise David would kill Michal. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Michal, “What are you thinking or feeling?” The person might answer things like:

- I am frightened for my life! or
- How can I convince my father that I am not to blame?

Continue the drama. After David escapes, David decides to go to Ramah to find Samuel. David trusts Samuel as a friend and as the person who anointed David as the future king. David finds Samuel and tells Samuel everything that King Saul has done. Samuel takes David to stay with Samuel in Naioth. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you thinking or feeling?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so tired and just need someone I can trust! or
- I am so thankful that Samuel is here to help and protect me! Or
- I really miss my wife!

Continue the drama. When King Saul finds out where David is hiding, King Saul sends men to find David in Naoith and to bring David back to King Saul. However, when the men arrive and see Samuel, the Spirit of Yahweh falls on the men, and the men begin to prophesy. The men are unable to harm David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, “What are you thinking or feeling?” The person might answer things like:

- I did not expect this to happen! or
- I am so grateful for how Yahweh is protecting David and all of us!

Continue the drama. When King Saul hears what has happened to Saul's men, Saul sends another group of men to Naioth to get David. When the men arrive and see Samuel, the same thing happens again! The men begin to prophesy and are unable to harm David.

King Saul then sends another group of men to Naoith to get David. However, the same thing happens again! The men see Samuel, and the Spirit of Yahweh falls on them. The men are unable to harm David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Spirit of Yahweh, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I will not let these men hurt David! or
- Everyone will experience my spirit!

Continue the drama. Finally, King Saul decides to go to Ramah and find David. King Saul stops at the great well of Seku and asks people if they know where David is. The people tell King Saul that David is in Naioth, and King Saul continues on Saul's journey. As King Saul is on his way to Naioth, the Spirit of Yahweh falls on King Saul, and King Saul begins to prophesy! Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Saul, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- Nothing will stop me from finding David! or
- I am so frustrated that David keeps getting away from me!

Continue the drama. As King Saul arrives in Naioth, King Saul sees Samuel and the prophets with Samuel. King Saul continues to prophesy, and King Saul strips his clothes off and lies on the ground during the day and night as Saul continues to prophesy. The people watching the prophets are amazed and ask if even King Saul is a prophet too! Pause the drama. Ask the people observing King Saul, "What are you thinking or feeling?" They might answer things like:

- What is the king doing?! or
- Should I be looking at King Saul when he is not clothed?

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 19:11–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

When David ran away from **King** Saul, David went home. King Saul sent messengers to make sure that David did not leave his home. These messengers are spies that Saul sent to watch and to report back to King Saul. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. For more information on king and David, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss what word you will use for messengers or **spies.** If you have used "spies" before, use the same word or phrase for spies as you used in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

Michal warned David that King Saul wanted to kill David, and Michal urged David to leave immediately. After Michal lowered David from the house window, Michal knew she needed to make it look like David was asleep in bed. Michal took a large household **idol**, also known as a teraphim, and placed it in the bed with clothing and goat hair to make it look like David. Use the same word or phrase for idol as you used in previous passages. For more information on idol, refer to the Master Glossary. For more information on idol, refer to the Master Glossary.

When King Saul sent men to bring David back, Michal told the men that David was ill. King Saul then demanded that the men carry David on his bed to King Saul so that King Saul could kill David. This means King Saul literally wanted the men to carry David on David's bed to Saul.

Stop here and discuss the word or phrase you will use for **carry David on his bed**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 19:11–24

When King Saul realized David was gone, Saul called Michal, and King Saul asked Michal to explain why she let Saul's **enemy**, David, go. Use the same word for "enemy" as you have used in previous 1 Samuel passages.

David escapes and finds Samuel. When Saul sends men to find David, the men find Samuel with a group of **prophets**. Saul's men begin to **prophesy**, or give messages from God. In this case, the men were probably in a trance-like state. The men may have been dancing and shouting as they gave these messages. You may use the same words or phrases to describe these actions as you used in previous passages when Saul began to prophesy. If you use the words for prophesy or prophets, see the Master Glossary for more information on prophesy or prophets.

After King Saul sends men three different times, King Saul decides to go and find David. When King Saul finds Samuel, Saul begins to prophesy and strips his clothes off. King Saul and his men prophesied because the **Spirit of God** fell on them and controlled the men's actions. Use the same words for "Spirit of God" as you have used in previous passages. Even though God's Spirit is not called the Holy Spirit here, you may refer to God and to the Holy Spirit in the Master Glossary for more information about the Spirit of God.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe King Saul's act of **stripping his clothes off** as Saul is prophesying. How will you say that King Saul is naked in an appropriate way?

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 19:11–24

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (925 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

1 Samuel 20:1–17

1 Samuel 20:1–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 20:1–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:1–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Saul tried to kill David, but David's wife, Michal, helped David escape. David went to live with Samuel. When Saul sent messengers to Samuel to capture David, the men instead began to prophesy or speak a message from God before Samuel. Twice more, Saul sent messengers to Samuel, but these men also prophesied instead of capturing David. Finally, Saul himself went to Samuel, but God's Spirit made Saul prophesy as well.

In this story, David now runs away from where Samuel is in Naioth near the town of Ramah and goes to see Jonathan, Saul's son. We are not sure what Naioth is, but it may have been a small village where prophets lived inside or just outside the town of Ramah. The story also does not tell us where Jonathan is staying, but Jonathan is probably in Gibeah, the town where Saul was living before Saul went to look for David in Ramah.

Stop here as a group and find Ramah and Gibeah on the map of Israel. Pause this audio here.

David asks Jonathan what crime or wrong thing David did that Saul is now trying to kill David. But Jonathan does not believe what David says. Jonathan says that surely Saul is not trying to kill David. Jonathan tells David that David is not going to die. Jonathan says Saul does nothing without telling Jonathan, so if Saul wanted to kill David, Saul would have told Jonathan. Jonathan is so sure of this that again, Jonathan tells David it cannot be true.

David promises Jonathan that David is telling the truth. David says Saul knows how much Jonathan likes David, so Saul must have decided not to tell Jonathan so that Jonathan would not be upset. But David makes a strong oath, or promise, again that David is telling Jonathan the truth. David says that just as surely as Yahweh lives and Jonathan lives, David is in great danger.

This time, Jonathan says he will do whatever David wants Jonathan to do. So David gives Jonathan instructions. First, David reminds Jonathan that tomorrow is the New Moon festival. In Old Testament times, the people of Israel celebrated this festival at the beginning of each month, when the people could see the new moon rise in the sky. During this festival, the Israelites stopped their work, offered special sacrifices, and blew trumpets to celebrate. David knows David is supposed to come eat a meal with the king during this festival, but David asks Jonathan's permission not to come. Instead, David says he will go to a field outside of the town and hide until the evening of the day after tomorrow. At that time, the festival will be finished.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What special festivals or celebrations does your community celebrate? Who attends these festivals, and what are some traditions or things you always do during these celebrations? Pause this audio here.

David tells Jonathan what to say if Saul notices that David is not at the festival. We know that this thing David tells Jonathan to say is a lie, and Jonathan knows it too. Jonathan will say that David strongly asked Jonathan

for permission to quickly travel to David's hometown of Bethlehem and then quickly travel back again. Jonathan will say this is because David wanted to attend the annual sacrifice for David's clan, or all of David's relatives. This was a special sacrifice that David's clan made together each year before Yahweh, so it would be important for David to be there. David says that if Saul says "Very well," or "Good," to Jonathan, this means that David will be safe from harm. But if Saul becomes very angry, then Jonathan will know that Saul wants to kill David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were uncertain if a person was angry or not. What did you do or ask that person to find out if the person was angry? What did that person do or say that helped you to know if they were angry? Pause this audio here.

David now reminds Jonathan of the covenant that Jonathan made earlier with David before Yahweh. You will remember that a covenant is a solemn agreement. Jonathan made this covenant with David that Jonathan and David would always be loyal friends. So David now asks Jonathan to do David a favor as his friend. David says that if Jonathan thinks David is guilty of being disloyal to Saul, Jonathan must kill David himself. David does not want Jonathan to take David to Saul if Jonathan thinks David is guilty. David would rather that Jonathan kill David than for Saul to kill David. But Jonathan strongly says that Jonathan would never harm David. Then Jonathan asks David a question that Jonathan does not expect David to answer. Jonathan says, "If I really knew that my father wanted to kill you, would I not tell you?" By asking this question, Jonathan tells David that Jonathan would certainly warn David if he knew David was in danger.

David now asks Jonathan who will come to tell David if Saul does become angry when Jonathan speaks with Saul. Before Jonathan answers David's question directly, Jonathan tells David to come with Jonathan out into a field or an open piece of land outside the city. Although the passage does not say why Jonathan does this, Jonathan probably wants to make sure no one can hear what Jonathan and David say to each other. Then Jonathan answers David's question. First, Jonathan promises David with an oath before Yahweh that Jonathan will find out what Saul is thinking and planning about David. Jonathan says that if Saul has a friendly attitude toward David, Jonathan will tell David this. But if Jonathan discovers that Saul truly is planning to kill David, Jonathan says Yahweh must punish Jonathan severely if Jonathan does not tell David this and help David escape to safety.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you made a very strong promise to someone else. What happens in your culture if someone breaks a strong promise to someone else? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan speaks a blessing over David and asks Yahweh to be good to David just as Yahweh has been with Jonathan's father, King Saul. Then Jonathan asks David to keep showing kindness toward Jonathan in the same way that Yahweh shows kindness. Jonathan asks David to do this for as long as Jonathan lives, so that Jonathan will not be killed. Jonathan would normally become the next king as Saul's heir, or the oldest son. So Jonathan is probably thinking that if David becomes the next king after Saul, people may think that Jonathan is a threat to David. Jonathan asks David to show this kindness not only to Jonathan himself, but also to Jonathan's whole family. Jonathan asks David to keep showing kindness to Jonathan's family even when Yahweh cuts off, or kills, every one of David's enemies from the face of the earth. This is special language that means Yahweh will completely destroy all of David's enemies so that there will be none left in the whole world.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, when a new person becomes a leader, what happens to the family or officials of the old leader? Pause this audio here.

So Jonathan makes a covenant, or solemn promise, with the house of David, or between David's descendants and Jonathan's descendants. Then Jonathan calls on Yahweh to bring punishment. However, the original language is not clear about who Jonathan wants Yahweh to punish. Jonathan may ask Yahweh to destroy David's enemies, or Jonathan may ask Yahweh to punish David's descendants if those descendants ever break this covenant with Jonathan's descendants.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Jonathan blesses David and promises to be loyal to David even though Jonathan's own father, Saul, wants to kill David. In your culture, when might it be okay to be loyal to someone even more than to your own family? Pause this audio here.

Finally, Jonathan asks David to repeat David's promise to Jonathan once more because of their strong friendship and Jonathan's love for David.

1 Samuel 20:1–17

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: David runs from Ramah to the place where Jonathan is staying. David asks Jonathan why Saul is trying to kill David. Jonathan says David must be mistaken about Saul, but David swears that what David says is true.

In the second scene: Jonathan promises to help David, and David gives Jonathan a lie to tell Saul. David says this lie will help Jonathan know if Saul wants to kill David or not. But David says that if Jonathan thinks David is guilty, Jonathan should kill David himself. Jonathan says he would never kill David, and that if Jonathan knew Saul wanted to harm David, Jonathan would surely tell David. So David asks how Jonathan will get this information about Saul back to David.

In the third scene: Jonathan takes David to a field outside the city. Here, Jonathan promises to carry out the plan to find out what Saul is thinking. If Saul is feeling peace toward David, Jonathan promises to tell David. But if Saul does want to kill David, Jonathan will not only tell David but also help David escape.

In the fourth scene: Jonathan asks that Yahweh be with David just as Yahweh has been with Saul. Jonathan also asks David to be kind to Jonathan so that Jonathan will not be killed. And Jonathan asks David's descendants to show kindness to Jonathan's descendants when Yahweh destroys all of David's enemies. Finally, Jonathan asks David to swear this again because of their friendship and Jonathan's love for David.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Jonathan
- Saul
- Yahweh
- David's clan, or all of the people David is related to
- David's descendants
- And Jonathan's descendants

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, David flees, or runs away from, Naioth in Ramah to the place where Jonathan is staying. David comes to Jonathan and asks Jonathan three questions: "What have I done? What is my guilt? What have I done wrong to your father? Your father is trying to take my life!" All three of David's questions are different ways of asking the same thing. David is asking Jonathan what David did to make Saul so angry that Saul would try to kill David. However, David already knows that David has done nothing wrong to Saul, so David does not expect Jonathan to answer these questions. Instead, David uses these questions as a way to tell Jonathan in a strong way that David is not guilty.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, if someone accuses you of something that you know is not true, how do you strongly deny that you are guilty of that thing? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan says very strongly to David, "Surely not! You are not going to die!" Jonathan seems very confident that David is not in any danger. Jonathan explains why he thinks this when Jonathan says, "Listen, my father does not do anything without telling me, whether it is important or not." Jonathan means that Saul tells Jonathan even about small, unimportant things, so surely Saul would tell Jonathan if Saul was planning to kill David.

Then Jonathan asks David a question that Jonathan does not expect David to answer. Jonathan asks why Jonathan's father would hide or keep this secret from Jonathan. Jonathan asks this question as a way to say that if Jonathan does not know about Saul's plan, then that plan must not be true. Jonathan is so confident about this that Jonathan says again that this thing cannot be true.

1 Samuel 20:1–17

We cannot be sure, but some people believe this story happened before the last story because of how David and Jonathan still have different ideas of what Saul is thinking and feeling.

David swears an oath again, or makes a strong promise, before Yahweh that what David says is true. We are not sure why the story says that David swore again, because the passage does not say clearly when David swore the first time. However, David's three questions to Jonathan at the beginning of the passage could be like a kind of oath.

David reminds Jonathan that Saul knows very well how much David has found favor in Jonathan's eyes. This is special language that means Jonathan likes David very much. David says that Saul knew Jonathan would be very grieved or upset if Jonathan knew Saul wanted to kill David, so Saul did not tell Jonathan. But David swears another oath that what David says is true. David says, "As sure as Yahweh lives and you live, there is only a step between me and death." This is special language that means David is in great and immediate danger.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were in great danger. Pay attention to the words you use to describe this danger. Then discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use where David says there is only "a step between me and death." Pause this audio here.

Jonathan asks David what David wants Jonathan to do, so David gives Jonathan instructions. David says that people will celebrate the festival of the new moon tomorrow night, and the king expects David to come eat a meal with the king. But David asks Jonathan's permission not to come. Instead, David will go and hide in a field, or an open place outside, until the third evening. You will remember that for the Israelites, each new day began at sunset, so when David says tomorrow, David means after the sun sets on the same day he talks with Jonathan. The New Moon festival sometimes lasted for two nights, because people could not yet see the new moon in the evening of the first day of the festival in certain months. So in the months when that happened, the phrase "until the third evening" would mean when the festival day is over.

David says that if Saul misses David, or notices that David is not at the meal, Jonathan must tell Saul that David asked Jonathan's permission to run to Bethlehem, David's hometown, because David wanted to attend the annual sacrifice there. Although the original language uses the word "run," it probably does not mean that David literally ran, but only that David wanted to quickly travel to Bethlehem and then quickly travel back. You will remember that David and Jonathan both know that this is a lie. David wants Jonathan to say this to deceive Saul. David says that if Saul says "Very well," or "Good," then David is not in immediate danger. But David says that if Saul loses his temper or becomes very angry, then Jonathan will know for sure that Saul is determined to harm David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you know if someone feels anger about something? For example, maybe the person communicates these feelings directly with their words or actions, or maybe the person shows their feelings more indirectly, such as by not talking anymore or by how they move their body. If needed, remember the story you told in step two about a person who you thought was angry. Pause this audio here.

David asks Jonathan to show kindness to David because of the covenant, or solemn agreement, that Jonathan and David made with each other. In the original language, the word David uses means "steadfast love," or a special type of kindness that does not end, no matter what happens. Throughout this story, both David and Jonathan ask for this kindness from each other and promise it to each other because of their covenant.

David says that if Jonathan thinks David is guilty of harming Saul, David wants Jonathan to kill David himself. But Jonathan says, "Far be it from you!" or "Never!" Then Jonathan asks David a question that Jonathan does not expect David to answer. Jonathan asks, "If I knew that my father was determined to harm you, would I not tell you?" Jonathan says this to show that Jonathan would certainly tell David. So David asks Jonathan who will tell David if Saul gets angry when Saul learns that David will not come. Jonathan responds, "Come, let us go out into the field." We do not know for sure what kind of field this is. It may be land where people grow crops for food, or it may refer more generally to open land.

When Jonathan and David get to the field, Jonathan makes an oath using Yahweh's name that Jonathan will "sound out," or find out, what Saul is thinking and planning by this time, the day after tomorrow. Jonathan says that if Saul is favorably disposed or has a friendly attitude toward David, will Jonathan not tell it to David? This

is a question that Jonathan does not expect David to answer. Jonathan uses this question to make a statement. But Jonathan says that if Jonathan's father is inclined, or wants, to hurt David, Yahweh should severely punish Jonathan if he does not tell David and send David away to a safe place. Jonathan says this to show that Jonathan's promise to protect David is very serious.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you make a strong promise in your culture? What special things do you say or do to show that you very much mean what you say? How will you talk about Jonathan making this strong promise to David? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan asks that Yahweh be with David just as Yahweh has been with Saul. Then Jonathan asks David to be kind and faithful to Jonathan just as Yahweh is kind and faithful, so that no one will kill Jonathan. Jonathan also asks David not to cut off or stop his kindness to Jonathan's family when Yahweh cuts off every one of David's enemies from the face of the earth. This is special language that means that Jonathan wants David and David's descendants to always be friendly with Jonathan and Jonathan's descendants, and never to fight against them as enemies.

So Jonathan makes a covenant or solemn agreement with David's house, or with David and David's descendants. Jonathan uses the words, "May Yahweh call David's enemies to account." This is special language that means Jonathan is calling on Yahweh to punish David's descendants if David's descendants ever break this covenant by harming Jonathan's descendants. It is as if Jonathan is saying, "If anyone breaks this covenant, Yahweh will punish that person."

Finally, Jonathan makes David swear this oath again because of their loyal friendship and Jonathan's love for David—the strong kind of love where a friend is willing to die for his friend.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Jonathan
- Saul
- Yahweh
- David's clan, or all of the people David is related to
- David's descendants
- And Jonathan's descendants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

1 Samuel 20:1–17

David runs from Ramah to the place where Jonathan is staying. David asks Jonathan, “What have I done wrong to your father? Your father is trying to kill me!”

But Jonathan says, “You must be mistaken! My father does not do anything without telling me about it. Surely I would know if my father wanted to kill you. This cannot be true!”

But David says, “I promise this is true. Your father knows how much you like me, so your father must have hidden this from you because he knew you would be upset. But just as true as Yahweh lives and you live, I am in danger of being killed!” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel shocked that Saul would want to kill me! I have always served Saul faithfully; or
- I feel afraid and unsure who I can trust, but Jonathan has always been a loyal friend.

Ask the person playing Jonathan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel very confused. Why would my father want to kill David? That does not make any sense; or
- My father always tells me about the decisions he makes as king. I am sure if my father were angry with David, my father would tell me about it; or
- There is no way my father could want to kill David. David has always loved our family and faithfully served my father, the king. David must have misunderstood.

Continue the drama. Jonathan says, “I will do whatever you want me to do.”

So David gives Jonathan some instructions. David says, “You know that the New Moon festival begins tomorrow. I am supposed to be there to eat the meal with your father. But give me your permission not to come to the meal. Instead, I will hide in the field until the evening of the day after tomorrow, when the festival is finished. But if your father notices that I am not there and asks where I am, tell your father I asked your permission not to come, and instead I ran home to Bethlehem to be there for the annual sacrifice with all of my family. If your father says ‘Good,’ that means I am not in danger, but if he becomes angry, you will know he wants to harm me. But if you think I am guilty, be kind to me and kill me yourself.”

But Jonathan says, “I would never kill you!”

So David asks, “Who will come to tell me if your father becomes angry?” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am sure Saul still wants to kill me, but I know that Jonathan does not believe it; or
- I do not like to deceive Saul, but there is no other way to help Jonathan know the truth; or
- If I am hiding out in the field, how will Jonathan let me know if Saul is angry and still wants to kill me?

Ask the person playing Jonathan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I still cannot believe that my father would want to kill David. But I trust David, so I will follow David’s plan; or
- I do not like to lie to my father, but I will do anything to help my friend David.

Continue the drama. Jonathan takes David to a field outside the city. Then Jonathan says, “Yahweh, the God of Israel, be my witness! I will surely find out what my father is thinking about you by this time, the day after tomorrow. If my father is feeling friendly toward you, I will let you know. But if my father wants to harm you, may Yahweh punish me if I do not tell you and help you escape to safety. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I love my father, but I would never let my father do anything bad to David; or
- I know David is afraid, and I want David to know that he can trust me to do what I promise.

Continue the drama. Jonathan says to David, “May Yahweh be with you as he has been with my father Saul. But be kind and faithful to me just as Yahweh is kind and faithful. Keep on showing kindness to my family when Yahweh kills every one of David’s enemies in the world.”

So Jonathan makes a covenant with David and David’s descendants. Jonathan says, “If anyone breaks this covenant, Yahweh will punish them.” Finally, Jonathan asks David to repeat the promise David has just made.

1 Samuel 20:1–17

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I love David; or
- I do not want David or David’s descendants to ever become my family’s enemies; or
- I know Yahweh’s power is with David.

Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel like Jonathan is afraid of me, but I am not sure why; or
- I already promised Jonathan these things, so why is he asking me to promise them again? or
- I am starting to feel annoyed because Jonathan has asked this again!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy with Jonathan. Although Jonathan could expect to become the next king, instead, Jonathan has asked me to be with David just as I have been with Saul; or
- Jonathan can see that I have given David my power and protection. Although Jonathan does not know for sure, he seems to understand that I will make David the next king.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

David asks Jonathan what David’s **guilt** is. Guilt is a person’s responsibility for the wrong thing they have done. A person who is guilty deserves to be punished for doing that wrong thing. Use the same word or phrase for guilt that you have used in previous passages.

David also asks Jonathan what David’s **sin** is that makes Saul want to kill David. Sin is an act of rebellion against God. Anytime that a person disobeys God’s laws, that person sins. Use the same word or phrase for sin that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up sin in the Master Glossary.

Jonathan says that Jonathan’s father, Saul, never does anything, either great or small, without **disclosing** it to Jonathan. Saul would always tell Jonathan what Saul was going to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about Saul telling Jonathan everything Saul was about to do. Pause this audio here.

David vowed, or **swore an oath**, to Jonathan. An oath is a special sort of promise. When someone swears an oath, that person says, “I will absolutely keep my promise. If I do not, God may punish me.” If someone did not keep his promise after swearing an oath, we say that the person broke his oath. It was an utterly disgraceful and dangerous thing to break an oath. Use the same word or phrase for “swore an oath” that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up oath in the Master Glossary.

David says that Saul knows that David has **found favor in Jonathan’s eyes**. To “find favor in someone’s eyes” means to make that person happy with you or pleased by what you do so that they like or approve of you. Use the same word or phrase “finding favor in someone’s eyes” that you have used in previous passages.

David calls himself Jonathan’s **servant**. A servant is a person who does work for someone else. To call himself Jonathan’s servant showed David’s respect for Jonathan as the king’s son. Use the same word or phrase for servant that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up servant in the Master Glossary.

David says that if Saul is angry, they will know that Saul intends to harm or do **evil** to David. Use the same word or phrase for harm or evil that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up evil in the Master Glossary.

David asks Jonathan to show David kindness. This is the kind of kindness or love that people promise to show to each other forever.

1 Samuel 20:1–17

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kindness** or **steadfast love**. Look up steadfast love in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David says that just as **Yahweh** lives and Jonathan's soul lives, there is but a step between David and death. The name Yahweh is God's personal name that shows the close relationship that God had with the people of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up Yahweh in the Master Glossary.

The **soul** is the invisible part of a person where that person's thoughts, feelings, and emotions are. But the Bible often uses the word soul to mean a person's life, because without the inner part of the person, the person is not complete. Use the same word or phrase for soul that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up soul in the Master Glossary.

Although the next day was the festival of the New Moon, David tells Jonathan to tell Saul that David went to Bethlehem for the yearly sacrifice for all of David's clan. The festival of the New Moon celebrates the time of the month when the new moon rises in the sky.

Stop here and discuss as a group what you will call the **festival of the New Moon** in this story. See the Master Glossary for more information about the festival of the New Moon, but also use the same title for this festival that you used in Numbers 10:10, if you have already translated it there. Pause this audio here.

A **sacrifice** is a gift to God. People often placed the gift on a platform that people made of earth or large stones, which people called an altar. The purpose of a sacrifice could be that people wanted to thank God for something, worship God, confirm their relationship with God, or ask forgiveness for something they had done wrong. A sacrifice could involve the killing of an animal, which people would then burn on the altar. But the gift could also be food items, oil, or sweet-smelling spices. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifice that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up sacrifice in the Master Glossary.

David's **clan** means a group of families who were descended from the same ancestor. This would be a very large group of people. Use the same word or phrase for clan that you have used in previous passages.

Jonathan swears by Yahweh, the **God** of **Israel**, that Jonathan will find out what Saul intends to do. Use the same words for God and Israel as you did in previous passages, and remember that God and Israel are in the Master Glossary.

Jonathan promises to send David away with **peace.** In this case, two people live in peace when they live in a good relationship with each other. Translate peace in the same way you have previously, and see the Master Glossary for more information about peace.

Jonathan made a **covenant** with the house of David. When people make a covenant, they make a solemn promise to each other that they cannot break. Individual people or whole families could make a covenant with each other. By making a covenant with each other, the people were saying that they wanted to have a good relationship with each other. For instance, people might promise that they would not fight with each other and that they would help the other group if that group had a problem. Use the same word or phrase for covenant that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up covenant in the Master Glossary.

The house of David means not only David himself, but also all of David's family and David's descendants.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **house of David**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. For more information, look up descendants in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 20:1–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (966 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 20:18–34

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 20:18–34 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:18–34 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:18–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, David told Jonathan how Saul tried to kill David. Jonathan promised to help David, and David came up with a plan for how Jonathan could trick Saul to find out what Saul is thinking about David. Finally, Jonathan asked Yahweh to be with David, and David renewed his promise to show kindness, or steadfast love, to Jonathan and Jonathan's descendants forever.

In this story, Jonathan now gives David instructions. Jonathan says that tomorrow is the New Moon festival and that people will notice when David is not at the feast. You will remember from the last story that the people of Israel celebrated this festival at the beginning of each month, when people could see the new moon rise in the sky. During this festival, the Israelites stopped their work, offered special sacrifices, and blew trumpets to celebrate. As David said in the last passage, David would normally eat at Saul's table during this festival, so Jonathan is concerned that Saul will notice when David does not come to the feast.

Jonathan tells David that toward evening on the third day, or the day after tomorrow, David must go down quickly to the place where David hid when the trouble with Saul began and wait there by the stone, or pile of stones. Jonathan tells David that at that time, Jonathan will come and use Jonathan's bow to shoot three arrows to the side of the rock, or pile of rocks, where David is hiding. Jonathan will do this as if Jonathan were shooting at a target.

Stop here and look at a picture of a bow and arrow. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what kinds of weapons do people use to hunt or fight from a distance? How do people practice with these weapons so that people can use the weapons well? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan says that Jonathan will then send a young male servant to go find the arrows Jonathan has shot. Jonathan says that if Jonathan tells the servant that the arrows are between the servant and Jonathan, which means that the servant has gone too far, then David is to come to Jonathan because this means that David will be safe. Here, Jonathan swears an oath that David will be safe, which means Jonathan promises that David can trust Jonathan. But Jonathan also says that if Jonathan tells the servant that the arrows are beyond the servant, or farther away from Jonathan, then David must go away, because this means David is in danger and Yahweh wants David to leave.

Jonathan ends by reminding David that this thing Jonathan and David have discussed is a secret between Jonathan and David, and that Yahweh will watch Jonathan and David to make sure they keep their promise to each other.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some things that people in your community keep secret between two people? When is it right to keep a secret to protect someone from harm? When does it harm other people to keep a secret? Pause this audio here.

So David goes and hides in the field just as Jonathan said to do. And on the day of the New Moon feast, King Saul comes and sits down at the table to eat. The king sits in his usual place at the table, with his back to the wall, and Jonathan sits opposite, or on the other side of the table. Abner, Saul's army commander, sits beside Saul, but David does not come to sit in David's seat.

Although David does not come to the feast, Saul does not say anything about David. Saul thinks to himself, "David must have done something that accidentally made David unclean." You will remember that the law of Moses said that certain things, like touching a dead body, would make a person unclean, and that while a person was unclean, that person could not participate in a religious celebration such as the New Moon festival. So Saul thinks this is why David did not come.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some celebrations in your community where people expect to come together? What are some reasons you might not allow someone to come who you would normally allow to come? Pause this audio here.

But the next day, which is the second day of the new month, David is still not at his place at the table. So Saul now asks Jonathan why David has not come, and Jonathan tells Saul what David told Jonathan to say. Jonathan says, "David earnestly asked me if he could go to Bethlehem. David said, 'Our family is having a sacrifice in the town, and my brother has demanded that I come. If you are my friend, please give me permission to go see my relatives.' That is why David has not come to the king's table."

Saul becomes very angry with Jonathan. Saul says, "You are as perverse and rebellious as your mother!" Then Saul asks a question he does not expect Jonathan to answer. Saul says, "Don't I know that you have sided with the son of Jesse to your own shame and the shame of the mother who gave you birth?" Saul means that

Jonathan's friendship with David, whom Saul refers to as the son of Jesse, will bring shame upon Jonathan and upon Jonathan's mother.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are some wrong actions that a person might do that would bring shame to their family? Now tell a story about a person who did something that was right and good, but that thing still caused their family to feel shame. Pause this audio here.

Saul continues, "As long as the son of Jesse is alive, you will never be king. Now send someone to bring David to me, because David deserves to die, and I am going to kill David!"

Jonathan responds, "David should not be killed! David has done nothing wrong!"

Saul throws his spear at Jonathan to try to kill Jonathan. So Jonathan now knows that Saul plans to kill David, just as David said.

Jonathan feels very angry as Jonathan leaves the festival. Jonathan does not eat anything because Jonathan feels grieved or sad by the way Saul had disgraced and dishonored David.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:18–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Jonathan gives David instructions on where to hide in the field and how Jonathan will communicate with David to let David know if Saul wants to kill David or not. Then David goes and hides in the field.

In the second scene: When the New Moon festival begins, Saul sees that David does not come to Saul's table. However, Saul does not say anything, because Saul thinks David accidentally became unclean and cannot come.

In the third scene: When David does not come to the table to eat the next day either, Saul asks Jonathan where David is. Jonathan says David went to David's hometown for the annual sacrifice. Saul becomes very angry with Jonathan. Saul says that Jonathan has brought shame upon Jonathan and upon Jonathan's mother. Saul says that Jonathan will not become king as long as David is alive. Finally, Saul tells Jonathan to bring David to Saul so that Saul can kill David. Jonathan says that Saul should not kill David, because David has done nothing wrong. So Saul throws Saul's spear at Jonathan to try to kill Jonathan.

In the fourth scene: Jonathan leaves the festival without eating anything because Jonathan feels grieved by the shameful way Saul has treated David.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jonathan
- David
- Yahweh
- King Saul
- The young male servant
- And Abner

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Jonathan continues to talk with David. Jonathan says, "Tomorrow is the New Moon festival, and my father will miss you, because your seat will be empty." You will remember that the Israelites celebrated the New Moon festival each month, and King Saul expected David to eat this meal with Saul. We are not sure how many people ate with Saul, but we later learn that both Abner, the commander of Saul's army, and Jonathan were there. And since Abner, Jonathan, and David are all important warriors who fight for Saul, this may be why the king invites David to eat with Saul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are some reasons why a king or important leader might invite certain people to eat a meal with the king or leader? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan now tells David that David must wait until dark on the third day and then go down quickly to the place in the field where David hid when David first experienced this trouble with Saul. You will remember that for the Israelites, the new day began in the evening, so Jonathan means that David must go there on the day after tomorrow.

Jonathan says David must hide there by the stone, or stones. We are not sure what the original language says here. Some translations say "stone Ezel," which means "the Departure Stone," while others say stone heap or pile of stones.

Next, Jonathan says that Jonathan will shoot three arrows toward this pile of stones as if Jonathan were shooting at a target. Although Jonathan does not use the word "bow" here, we know that Jonathan will shoot these arrows using Jonathan's bow. You will remember that a bow is a long, narrow piece of wood. People tie a strong string tightly to either end of this piece of wood so that the wood bends into a curved shape. Arrows are long, thin sticks with a pointed tip on one end. People often tie bird feathers onto the other end to help the arrow fly straight through the air. A person can shoot an arrow from the bow by pulling back the string and then letting go of the string quickly so that it pushes the arrow forward and makes it fly into the air.

Stop here and look at a picture of a bow and arrow as a group. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan says that Jonathan will shoot the three arrows to the side of the pile of stones as if Jonathan were shooting at a target. We are not sure if this means that Jonathan will shoot the arrows so that the arrows hit the side of the rock itself, or if Jonathan means that Jonathan will shoot the arrows so that the arrows fall to a point beside the rock. Jonathan says that Jonathan will then send a young male servant to go get the arrows. If Jonathan says to the servant, "The arrows are on my side," that means the servant has gone farther away from Jonathan than the arrows. This will mean Jonathan is telling David that Saul does not want to kill David. Jonathan says, "Then as surely as Yahweh lives, you are safe." The phrase "as surely as Yahweh lives" is the normal way to say an oath, which means that Jonathan is promising to David before Yahweh that David can trust that Jonathan is telling the truth.

But Jonathan also says that if Jonathan says to the servant, "The arrows are beyond you," that means that the servant has not gone far enough away from Jonathan to reach the arrows. In that case, Jonathan is telling David that Saul still wants to kill David. Jonathan says that if Jonathan says this to the servant, then David must go away, because David will know that David is in danger and Yahweh wants David to leave.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who created a special way of communicating a secret message to someone else. How did that person decide what to use to communicate this message? How did the person keep it a secret from other people? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan ends the conversation with David by reminding David that the thing that Jonathan and David have discussed is a secret between Jonathan and David. Jonathan is talking about the covenant, or strong promise, that Jonathan and David made with each other. Yahweh will act as a witness between Jonathan and David to make sure they keep this promise to each other. After Jonathan and David finish talking, David goes and hides in the field. In the original language, the word for field here means farmland that people use for growing crops or for grazing animals.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when two people make an important promise to each other, how do those people talk about that promise? Who is responsible to make sure each person keeps that promise? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, when the New Moon feast begins, the king comes and sits down at the king's table to eat. The king sits down at his usual place at the table, with the king's back to the wall. In the original language, the storyteller says that Jonathan "stood in his place," which some translations translate as "arose." However, what this probably means is that Jonathan stood in attendance, ready to serve his father, the king. So after Saul sits down first, then Jonathan sits opposite the king, or on the other side of the table. And Abner, the commander of the king's army, sits next to Saul. But David is not there to sit in David's seat.

Saul notices that David is not at the table, but Saul does not say anything. Saul thinks to himself, “Something must have caused David to become unclean.” You will remember that the law of Moses talks about many things that might cause a person to become ceremonially unclean. Some of these things a person might do intentionally, such as bury a family member who has died. Other things might be accidental or unplanned. Here, Saul thinks David must have accidentally become unclean, and so David cannot come to the feast.

In the third scene, when David still does not come to the feast the next day, Saul asks Jonathan, “Why has the son of Jesse not come to the meal either yesterday or today?” You will remember that David’s father is Jesse, so when Saul says “the son of Jesse,” Saul means David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you make it clear in your translation that Saul is talking about David? Pause this audio here.

Now Jonathan says the words David told Jonathan to say. Jonathan says, “David earnestly asked me if he could go to Bethlehem. David said, ‘Our family is having a sacrifice in the town, and my brother has demanded that I come. If you are my friend, please give me permission to go see my relatives.’ That is why David has not come to the king’s table.” You will remember that Jonathan is lying. David did not go to Bethlehem, but is actually hiding nearby. Jonathan tells Saul this lie to see how Saul will respond. If Saul responds that this is okay, Jonathan will know that Saul does not mean to kill David. But if Saul becomes angry, then Jonathan will know that Saul wants to kill David.

When Jonathan says these words, Saul becomes very angry. Saul says, “You are as perverse and rebellious as your mother!” Calling someone a perverse and rebellious son is a strong insult. Saul is saying Jonathan is a lowly traitor or a shameful person who is not loyal. Where Saul calls Jonathan’s mother rebellious, some translations say prostitute. We are not sure if this is correct, but we do know that Saul is speaking in an insulting way about both Jonathan and Jonathan’s mother.

Saul continues, “Do I not know that you are choosing the son of Jesse to your own shame and the shame of your mother’s nakedness?” Here, Saul is asking a question that Saul does not expect Jonathan to answer. What Saul means is that Saul knows Jonathan is very loyal to David. And Saul is saying that because of this, Jonathan’s own mother should be ashamed that she gave birth to Jonathan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If someone in your community acts very shamefully toward their family, what are some insulting things people might say about that person? Also, if a person causes shame to your community, what insults might people say about that person’s parents? Pause this audio here.

Saul says, “As long as the son of Jesse lives on the earth, your kingdom will never be established. Now send someone to bring Jesse’s son to me, because Jesse’s son deserves to die, and I am going to kill him!” As Saul’s oldest son, Jonathan would expect to become the next king when Saul dies. But Saul is saying that as long as David is alive, David will keep Jonathan from being able to become the next king. So Saul wants Jonathan to help Saul kill David by bringing David to Saul.

Jonathan responds by asking two questions that Jonathan does not expect Saul to answer. Jonathan says, “But why should David be killed? What has David done?” Jonathan is strongly disagreeing with Saul. Jonathan is saying that David must not die. This makes Saul very angry, and Saul throws Saul’s spear at Jonathan to try to kill Jonathan.

In the last scene, Jonathan gets up from the table very angry. Jonathan leaves the festival without eating anything, because Jonathan feels very sad about the shameful way Saul has treated David.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:18–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jonathan
- David
- Yahweh
- King Saul
- The young male servant
- And Abner

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, Jonathan continues to talk with David. Jonathan says, "Tomorrow is the New Moon festival, and my father will miss you, because your seat will be empty. On the day after tomorrow, at evening time, go to the place where you hid when this trouble with my father began and wait by the pile of stones there. I will shoot three arrows to the side of the stones like I am shooting at a target. Then I will send a young male servant to get the arrows. If I call to the young man, 'The arrows are on my side,' then come, because as surely as Yahweh lives, you will be safe. But if I call out, 'The arrows are farther away,' then you must go, because Yahweh wants you to leave. And may Yahweh make us keep our promises to each other, because Yahweh has heard what we said." Then, when Jonathan and David finish talking, David goes and hides in the field. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel hopeful that David misunderstood my father's actions and that David will be able to come out of hiding; or
- I do not think that my father, King Saul, wants to kill David, but this is a good plan to keep David safe, just in case David is right; or

Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Jonathan is a good man. Although Jonathan is loyal to me, I know it is important for Jonathan to trust and honor his father, King Saul; or
- This is a good plan. I know that Saul wants to kill me, but this will help Jonathan see the truth, too.

Continue the drama. In scene two, as the New Moon feast begins, the king comes and sits down at the king's table to eat. The king sits down at his usual place at the table, with the king's back to the wall. Jonathan sits opposite the king, or on the other side of the table. And Abner, the commander of the king's army, sits next to Saul. But David is not there to sit in David's seat. Saul thinks in his mind, "Something must have caused David to become unclean." But Saul does not say anything to Jonathan or anyone else about David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Some things that make people unclean accidentally are shameful to talk about, so I will not ask what happened; or
- I am sure David will be ceremonially clean again tomorrow and can come to the feast then.

Continue the drama. In scene three, when David again does not come to the feast, Saul asks Jonathan, "Why has the son of Jesse not come to the meal either yesterday or today?" Jonathan says, "David earnestly asked me if he could go to Bethlehem. David said, 'Our family is having a sacrifice in the town, and my brother has demanded that I come. If you are my friend, please give me permission to go see my relatives.' That is why David has not come to the king's table."

When Saul hears this, Saul is very angry! “You are as bad and rebellious as your mother! Do I not know that you are choosing the son of Jesse to your own shame and the shame of your mother’s nakedness? As long as the son of Jesse lives on the earth, you will never be king! Now send someone to bring Jesse’s son to me, because Jesse’s son deserves to die, and I am going to kill him!”

But Jonathan responds, “But why should you kill David? What has he done?” And in Saul’s great anger, Saul throws his spear at Jonathan to try to kill Jonathan. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am furious that Jonathan is more loyal to his friend David than Jonathan is to me. Not only am I Jonathan’s own father, but I am the king of Israel and must be obeyed! or
- I am shocked that Jonathan would dishonor me like this. This is shameful! or
- I want Jonathan to honor me and our family by becoming the next king. But if Jonathan refuses to obey me and chooses to honor David instead, then I must kill both of them.

Continue the drama. Jonathan feels very angry. Jonathan gets up from the table and leaves the festival without eating anything, because Jonathan feels very sad about the shameful way Saul has treated David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel shocked that my father would want to kill David. David has always been loyal and trustworthy toward my father; or
- I am grieved that my father would be so jealous of David’s success that my father would try to kill David. Does my father not see that Yahweh is blessing David? or
- I know that it is right to show loyalty to my family, and especially to the king. But I must be even more loyal to David, because Yahweh has blessed David.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:18–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jonathan tells David that tomorrow will be the **festival of the New Moon**. “New moon” means the time each month when people can see the new moon rise in the sky. The Israelites celebrated this time each month during the festival of the New Moon. Use the same word or phrase for “festival of the new moon” that you have used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information about the festival of the New Moon.

Jonathan says that Jonathan will shoot three arrows as though Jonathan is shooting at a mark or target. A target is an object or particular place that a person tries to hit with their arrows when they practice shooting with their bow. By aiming at a target, a person can improve how they shoot to become more skilled and accurate with their bow.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **target**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan tells David that as surely as **Yahweh** lives, David will be safe if Jonathan tells David that everything is safe. Use the same word for Yahweh as you have used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for Yahweh for more information.

The **king**, or Saul, comes to eat at the feast. Use the same word for king as you have used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for king for more information.

When David does not come to the feast, Saul thinks that something must have made David unclean. This does not mean dirty from the outside. In the Bible, a clean person means a person who is fit for service to God, while a person who is unclean is unfit for service to God. A person would become unclean either because of sin or by touching an unclean thing.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **unclean**. Look up clean and unclean in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 20:18–34

Jonathan says that David asked for Jonathan's permission to go to Bethlehem, where David's **clan** is making a sacrifice. The word clan means a group of families who are descended from the same ancestor. This would be a very large group of people. Use the same word or phrase for clan that you have used in previous passages.

A **sacrifice** is a gift to God. People often placed the gift on a platform made of earth or large stones, which people called an altar. The purpose of a sacrifice could be that people wanted to thank God for something, worship God, confirm their relationship with God, or ask forgiveness for something they had done wrong. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifice that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up sacrifice in the Master Glossary.

Jonathan says that David had said to Jonathan, "If I have found **favor in your eyes**, let me go." The phrase "favor in your eyes" means that the person likes and approves of you and therefore treats you with kindness. Use the same word or phrase for "favor in your eyes" that you have used in previous passages.

When Jonathan finishes telling these things to Saul about David, Saul's anger is **kindled**. The word kindled means to create a fire, or to arouse and stir up, like someone who stirs up a fire to make it burn hot. Use the same word or phrase for kindled that you have used in previous passages.

Saul calls Jonathan perverse and rebellious. The word perverse means bent, twisted, bad, or distorted, and rebellious means to resist or to refuse to obey orders.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **perverse** and **rebellious**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul says that Jonathan's **kingdom** will never be established. In other words, Jonathan will never rule as king. Use the same word or phrase for kingdom that you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up kingdom in the Master Glossary.

Jonathan is **grieved** by the way Saul has treated David. To be grieved means to be sad or very upset and unhappy. Use the same word or phrase for grieved that you have used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 20:18–34

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (866 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 20:35–42

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 20:35–42 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:35–42 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:35–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last passage, after Jonathan gave David instructions about how Jonathan would communicate secretly with David by shooting arrows, David hid in the field. When the festival of the New Moon began, and David did not come to eat with King Saul, Saul thought David had become unclean, so Saul did not say anything. But when David did not come on the second day of the festival either, Saul asked Jonathan where David was. Jonathan told Saul a lie that David had gone to David's hometown of Bethlehem. Saul became very angry. Saul used some insulting words to call Jonathan disloyal and a traitor. Saul said that Jonathan would never become king as long as David was alive. Saul told Jonathan to bring David to Saul so Saul could kill David. Jonathan responded that David had done nothing wrong. So Saul threw Saul's spear to try to kill Jonathan. Finally, Jonathan left the festival very angry and very sad because of how Saul had treated David.

Now, the very next morning, Jonathan goes out into the field to the place where Jonathan told David to meet Jonathan. Jonathan takes a young servant boy with him, and Jonathan tells the servant in a kind way to run and find the arrows Jonathan will shoot from Jonathan's bow.

Stop here and look at a picture of a bow and arrow as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who gives a command to a servant or a less powerful person who has to obey the command. Tell how that person gives the command in a kind way, even though the other person must obey the command. Pause this audio here.

As the servant boy runs ahead, Jonathan shoots an arrow beyond the boy so that the arrow flies through the air above the boy's head. When the servant gets to the place where the arrow has fallen to the ground, Jonathan shouts to the boy, "Isn't the arrow beyond you?" Jonathan does not expect the boy to answer this question. Jonathan uses the question to say that the arrow is indeed farther away. Jonathan says this to communicate the

secret message to David that Jonathan had planned in the previous passage. This message means that David must leave because Saul wants to kill David.

Then Jonathan shouts again to the servant boy, “Hurry! Go quickly! Do not stop!” Jonathan says this to secretly communicate to David how quickly David must leave because of the danger.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time in your community when someone warned other people that something dangerous was going to happen. Maybe this danger was a wild animal, a storm, enemy soldiers, or something else. Now, act this story out. Pay attention to what the person does to get other people’s attention, and what words the person uses to warn the other people. Pause this audio here.

The servant boy picks up the arrow and brings it back to Jonathan. The servant does not know about Jonathan’s plan. Only Jonathan and David understand what Jonathan’s words mean.

Jonathan gives Jonathan’s weapons to the servant boy and tells the boy to take the weapons back to the city. Then, as soon as the boy leaves the field, David stands up where he has been hiding on the south side of the stone. David bows low in front of Jonathan. In this culture, people would bow to show great respect. David touches David’s forehead all the way to the ground three times. Since this was the lowest David could kneel, it showed the greatest possible honor David could show toward Jonathan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people show respect to other people? If two people are friends, but one of those people is more powerful or respected in the community than the other, how do those people act or speak to each other to show this? Pause this audio here.

Now David stands up, and Jonathan and David kiss each other. In ancient Israel, Jewish men often greeted each other with a kiss to show friendship and honor each other. Jonathan and David also weep together, but David weeps the loudest. We are not sure why David and Jonathan took this risk that someone might see David with Jonathan. This seems surprising after all that Jonathan did to communicate secretly with David. It is possible that David and Jonathan did not plan to meet, but changed their minds at the last minute because the two men felt such strong emotion.

Jonathan blesses David and says to go in peace, because Jonathan and David have sworn to be loyal to each other. Jonathan repeats part of the oath that Jonathan and David swore earlier when Jonathan says, “Yahweh is witness between you and me, and between your descendants and my descendants forever.”

Finally, David goes away, and Jonathan goes back to the city.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:35–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Jonathan takes a servant boy with Jonathan and goes to the field where David has hidden. Jonathan shoots an arrow into the field and tells the servant to find it. Jonathan shouts to the servant that the arrow is farther out and to go quickly. Then, when the servant returns with the arrow, Jonathan sends the boy back to the city.

In the second scene: David comes out from where David hid by the pile of stones and bows before Jonathan. Then David and Jonathan kiss and weep together. Jonathan tells David to go in peace because of the oath the men both swore to be loyal to each other.

In the third scene: David goes away and Jonathan returns to the city.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jonathan
- David

- Young servant boy
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Jonathan goes to the field where Jonathan and David planned to meet and where David is now hiding. The original language says that Jonathan goes to the field for the "appointment," or that Jonathan goes to the "appointed place." However, it may be more natural to say that Jonathan goes to the place where Jonathan and David agreed to meet.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the most natural way to say that Jonathan went to the appointed field so that everyone will understand which field Jonathan goes to? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan takes a young servant boy to the field with Jonathan. The storyteller uses the same word here to describe the servant as in the last story, except that here the storyteller adds one more word to show that the servant is "small." This probably means that the servant is a very young boy who is younger than 13 years old.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you talk about a male child who is not yet a teenager? How will you translate this so that people will understand how young the servant is? Pause this audio here.

When Jonathan and the servant arrive at the field, Jonathan tells the servant, "Run ahead and get the arrows that I am about to shoot." Although this is a command that the servant knows he must obey, Jonathan says it in a way that sounds kind and not harsh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate what Jonathan says so that it sounds like a command and not a request, but also so that it sounds kind? If needed, refer back to the previous step to see how you talked about this there. Pause this audio here.

As the servant runs ahead, Jonathan shoots an arrow so that it flies over the boy's head and out into the field beyond the boy. When the boy arrives at the place where the arrow has fallen to the ground, Jonathan shouts a question that Jonathan does not expect the boy to answer. Jonathan yells, "Isn't the arrow beyond you?" Since Jonathan is actually using this question to make a statement, it may be more natural to say, "But the arrow is in front of you!"

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate where Jonathan tells the boy to find the arrow? Pause this audio here.

You will remember that Jonathan told David that Jonathan would shoot three arrows. However, here the passage only mentions that Jonathan shoots one arrow. We are not sure why this is. Some translations change this part of the passage to say that Jonathan shot "arrows," or more than one arrow. But it is very possible that Jonathan changed his plan and shot only one arrow. So it is best to follow the original language and only mention that Jonathan shoots one arrow.

Now Jonathan shouts again to the servant, "Hurry! Be quick! Do not stay!" You will remember that Jonathan yells this so that David will hear and understand how quickly David must go away. Jonathan gives the command three times, in three different ways, to show how urgent it is. So it is important to do this in your translation too.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases in your language will work best for these commands in your translation? Pause this audio here.

After the servant boy gets the arrow, the servant returns with the arrow to Jonathan. Here, the passage says that the servant "knew nothing." This means that the servant does not know about the plan that Jonathan and David made or the secret meaning of Jonathan's words. Only Jonathan and David know these things.

Now the passage says that Jonathan gives Jonathan's "weapons" to the servant. This probably means Jonathan's bow and arrows, but it could include other weapons as well. Then Jonathan tells the servant to carry the weapons back to the city. The passage does not say which city this is. This may be Saul's hometown, Gibeah, but we are not sure.

As soon as the servant leaves, David stands up from David's hiding place on the south side of the stone. Then David bows down before Jonathan three times "with his face to the ground." This means that David bowed so low to the ground that David touched his forehead to the ground each time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about the way that David gets on his knees and bows so that David's head touches the ground? Pause this audio here.

David and Jonathan kiss each other. David and Jonathan also weep or cry loudly together. But David cries the most, or the loudest. Then Jonathan says, "Go in peace, because we swore to be friends with each other when we said, 'Yahweh will be a witness between us and between our descendants forever.'" The phrase "go in peace" is something that a person with more authority or power would say to someone who has less authority. Since Jonathan is the king's son, Jonathan has more authority than David does. But Jonathan also shows with his words that Jonathan and David are friends.

Finally, David goes away, and Jonathan goes back to the city.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:35–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jonathan
- David
- Young servant boy
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, Jonathan takes a young servant boy with Jonathan and goes to the field where Jonathan told David to hide. Jonathan tells the boy, "Run and find the arrows I shoot with my bow." So as the boy starts to run, Jonathan shoots an arrow into the air so that the arrow flies above the boy, far out into the field. Then, when the boy reaches the place where the arrow has fallen on the ground, Jonathan shouts to the boy, "Isn't the arrow beyond you? Hurry! Go quickly! Do not stop!" So the servant boy picks up the arrow and takes it back to Jonathan. Then Jonathan gives the servant boy Jonathan's weapons and sends the boy back to the city with the weapons. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope David is here like I told David to be. David has hidden so well that I cannot see him! or
- I know my servant may wonder why I only shot one arrow, but I do not want to use up any more time. It is important for my servant to leave quickly so that David can get away without anyone seeing David.

Ask the person playing the servant boy, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am surprised that my master Jonathan came all the way out to this field to only shoot one arrow. Usually, when my master comes to practice shooting arrows, he shoots many more arrows. But my master must have just changed his mind.

Continue the drama. In the second scene, David stands up from David’s hiding place on the south side of the stone. First, David bows before Jonathan. Then David and Jonathan kiss and weep together. David weeps louder than Jonathan does. Then Jonathan says, “Go in peace, because we swore to be friends with each other when we said, ‘Yahweh will be a witness between us and between our descendants forever.’” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am very sad that my good friend David has to go away, but there is no other way to protect David from my father; or
- I will always be loyal to David, not only because David is my friend, but also because of the oath I swore in the presence of Yahweh.

Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I know it may be dangerous to come out of hiding, but I want to see my friend Jonathan one more time before I go; or
- I do not understand why Saul wants to kill me after everything I have done to show my loyalty to Saul and Saul’s family; or
- I love my friend Jonathan, and I do not want to leave Jonathan. But I know that it would be too dangerous to stay here.

Continue the drama. Finally, David goes away, and Jonathan goes back to the city.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 20:35–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In the morning, Jonathan took a young servant boy and went to the **appointed place** in the field. You will remember that an appointed place is a location that people agree on together beforehand. Use the same word or phrase for “appointed place” that you have used in previous passages.

You will remember from the previous passage that this **field** might be a piece of land where people grow crops for food, or it might just be an open plot of land where there are no buildings or people living. Use the same word or phrase for field that you used in previous passages.

Jonathan told the servant to run and get the arrows that Jonathan would shoot. Then, as the boy ran, Jonathan shot an arrow **beyond** the servant. Here, the word beyond means to pass over, so this means that Jonathan shot the arrow so that the arrow flew above the servant’s head, far out into the field. Use the same word or phrase for beyond that you have used in previous passages.

The storyteller in this passage talks about both **arrows** and weapons. Arrows are long, thin sticks with a pointed tip on one end. People can make arrows fly very quickly through the air by shooting the arrows from a bow. Although the storyteller does not mention the bow, we know that Jonathan used a bow to shoot Jonathan’s arrow. Look up bow in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word or phrase for arrows that you have used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look again at a picture of a bow and arrows, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Weapons can mean any kind of tool people use to fight in battle. A bow and arrows are one kind of weapon. Jonathan may have had other weapons with Jonathan, but the passage does not say what these weapons were. Use the same word or phrase for weapons that you have used in previous passages.

After Jonathan sent the servant back to the city, David **rose** or got up from where David was hiding on the south side of the stone. “Rose” means to stand up tall, so David may have been sitting, crouching, or even lying down

flat on the ground so that the servant could not see David. Use the same word or phrase for rose or got up that you have used in previous passages.

David “fell on his face to the ground” in front of Jonathan. This does not mean that David fell down accidentally or hurt himself. This means that David kneeled down and then leaned forward to touch David’s forehead to the ground out of great respect for Jonathan.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **fell on his face to the ground**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

After telling David to go in **peace**, Jonathan repeats some of the words from the oath Jonathan and David made to each other in a previous passage. In that oath, Jonathan and David promised not only to be loyal to each other, but also that their descendants would be loyal to each other in the name or power of **Yahweh**. Use the same words or phrases for peace and Yahweh that you have used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for more information about peace and Yahweh, if needed.

Originally, Jonathan and David used the word “house” to refer to their descendants, or the people in their families who would come after them, like children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren. But here in this story, Jonathan uses a slightly different word in the original language that means seed or offspring to describe these descendants. This is special language that shows how Jonathan and David’s families will grow large and cover the land of Israel, just like the seeds that a farmer spreads across his land grow to become a field of crops.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **seed** or **offspring**. Look up seed in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 20:35–42

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (855 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.9 MB)

- Defining the Scenes (4.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 21:1–9

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 21:1–9 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:1–9 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Jonathan went to meet David in the field where David was hiding from Saul. Jonathan shot arrows and sent his servant boy to collect the arrows. Jonathan gave the boy commands that were a secret, urgent warning to David that Saul wanted to kill David, and that David should run away immediately. When the servant boy left, Jonathan sent David away with a blessing and reminded David of the covenant of friendship that David and Jonathan had made earlier in Yahweh's presence.

Then David traveled from the city where King Saul was, most likely Gibeah, to the city of Nob. Nob was the city where the priests lived. It is likely that the ark of the covenant was in Nob at that time. Nob was eight kilometres southwest of Gibeah and a very short distance north of Jebus, later known as Jerusalem. David went to see Ahimelech the priest, who was the great-grandson of Eli the high priest. The title "priest" here means the chief priest or the high priest. The high priest was the most important priest who, once a year, offered a sacrifice on behalf of all the people of Israel to ask Yahweh's forgiveness for all the sins the people had committed the previous year. Ahimelech was most likely the brother of Ahijah, Saul's priest. Ahimelech trembled in fear when he saw David. Ahimelech asked David why David came alone. Probably other servants of Saul normally came with David, and Ahimelech sensed that something was wrong. Ahimelech did not want to become involved in any trouble.

Stop here and look as a group at a map showing David's journey from Gibeah to Nob. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and tell a story about someone who showed that they were afraid. What kinds of things did that person do? Pause this audio here.

David answered Ahimelech and told Ahimelech a lie. David said that the king had sent David to do something special for the king. David said that the king told David not to tell anyone anything about David's task and the king's instructions. David said that David told David's men where to meet David. David was probably not sure whether he could trust Ahimelech because Ahimelech was the brother of Saul's priest Ahijah. Or David may have wanted to protect Ahimelech from King Saul. Saul might have thought that Ahimelech was involved in David's escape. So David made up a story to explain why David was by himself.

1 Samuel 21:1–9

David asked Ahimelech what Ahimelech "had on hand." If Ahimelech had five loaves of bread, David wanted the five loaves, or David wanted whatever there was. David asked if Ahimelech had any food available that David could take with him on David's mission. David asked for five loaves because David had spoken of several men going with David, and probably wanted to gather provisions for two or three days. David was prepared to accept any food if the five loaves of bread were not available.

Ahimelech said that Ahimelech did not have any common bread available, but there was holy bread. "Common" or ordinary bread is bread that has not been set apart for Yahweh as holy. Common bread was ordinary bread that anyone could eat. Holy bread, also called the "bread of the Presence," was the bread that Yahweh commanded to be always in Yahweh's presence in the tabernacle. The holy bread consisted of 12 large round loaves, which likely symbolized the 12 tribes of Israel. The bread also symbolized God's constant provision for his people. Yahweh only allowed priests and the priests' families to eat this bread. Ahimelech the priest was happy to give David some of the holy bread, as David had said that David was traveling on an important mission from the king. Ahimelech said that Ahimelech would give David the holy bread only if David and David's men had not had sexual relations with women recently. To have sexual relations with women made men ceremonially unclean for a time.

Stop here and look as a group at a picture of the holy bread. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and discuss this question: Who in your culture can handle holy things? What makes someone ritually clean in order to do that? Pause this audio here.

David answered Ahimelech and said that David and David's men had not had sexual relations recently. It was a common practice for men not to have sexual relations with women during military missions because people regarded war as sacred. David then said that the "vessels of the young men" were holy even when they went on common, ordinary missions. David's expression "the vessels of the young men" referred to the body and particularly to the parts of the body involved in sexual relations. David assured Ahimelech, the high priest, that the body parts of the young men remained holy during ordinary or common missions, so the men would certainly stay holy on this special mission for the king. By saying this, David suggested that this mission was holy.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do soldiers in your people group do to make their bodies fit or ready for battle or war? Pause this audio here.

Therefore, since there was no other bread available, Ahimelech gave David the bread of the Presence or the holy bread. The bread of the Presence was 12 large loaves of bread that the priests set in two rows on a table before Yahweh in the tabernacle. The priests put freshly-baked bread on the table each Sabbath, and only the priests were allowed to eat the old bread. Ahimelech gave David and his men the old bread, even though the men were not priests. However, Ahimelech ensured that David and David's men would not treat the bread as ordinary bread by checking that David and David's men were ceremonially clean.

Now, Doeg the Edomite, or a native from the land of Edom, was there that day. Doeg was working for King Saul, probably as Saul's chief shepherd, overseeing the king's herdsmen. Doeg was there because some religious duty he needed to perform kept Doeg before Yahweh at the tabernacle. The storyteller is not clear what that duty was. Doeg may have been there for purification because of a particular sin Doeg committed. Or, perhaps because Doeg was a non-Jew, Doeg wanted to become part of the religious community of Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of people besides priests remain around your places of worship, and why? Pause this audio here.

Then David asked Ahimelech if Ahimelech had a sword or a spear available. David gave a false explanation of why David asked for the weapons. David said that David had not brought with him David's sword or any other weapons because the king had told David to leave immediately, so quickly that David had not had time to get his weapons.

Ahimelech replied that there was only the sword of Goliath the Philistine, whom David killed in the Valley of Elah or the Terebinth Valley. This sword was wrapped up in a cloth and was hanging behind the ephod—the high priest's shoulder-dress. You will remember that David first took Goliath's sword as part of his plunder after David had killed Goliath. David probably later brought this sword to the tent of meeting, where the Israelites sacrificed to Yahweh. The fact that the sword was in the tent of meeting behind the ephod meant that the sword was very important. The high priest's ephod was a highly decorated piece of clothing that the high priest wore in the

1 Samuel 21:1–9

tent of meeting when the priest served Yahweh. On top of the ephod, the high priest wore a breastpiece which held the Urim and Thummim, two objects the high priest used to determine Yahweh's will. Ahimelech said that if David wanted the sword, David could take it, as it was the only sword there. David accepted the sword. David said, "There is no other sword as good." David believed that this sword had greater value to David than any other sword. The sword was so valuable to David because David had cut off Goliath's head with it after David had killed Goliath.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a spear and a sword.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: David travels from Gibeah to Nob and meets Ahimelech the priest. Ahimelech is afraid and asks David why David travelled totally alone. David lies to Ahimelech. David says that he is alone because the king sent David to do a special task for the king, and David's men will meet David later at a certain place.

In the second scene: David asks if Ahimelech has any food available that David can take with David on his mission. David asks for five loaves of bread, or whatever else Ahimelech has. Ahimelech says that he does not have any common bread available, but that there is holy bread. Ahimelech says Ahimelech will give David the holy bread on the condition that David's men have not had sexual relations with women recently.

In the third scene: David says that David and his men do not have sexual relations with women whenever they go on any common mission. Because this mission is special, the men will keep "the vessels of the young men" holy and not have sexual relations before this mission. Ahimelech gives David and his men old bread of the Presence or holy bread, which the priests had taken away from the table in the tent of meeting, or tabernacle.

In the fourth scene: The storyteller gives the audience additional information. The storyteller tells us that Saul's servant, a man called Doeg from Edom who was Saul's chief shepherd, is also there at Nob. Doeg is there because some religious duty Doeg needs to perform keeps him serving Yahweh at the tabernacle.

In the fifth scene: David asks Ahimelech if Ahimelech has a spear or a sword that David can have. Ahimelech says that he only has Goliath's sword, which David can have if David wants it. David accepts the sword as a weapon of greater value to David than any other.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Ahimelech the high priest
- And Saul's servant Doeg the Edomite

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Then David travelled from the city where King Saul was, most likely Gibeah, to the city of Nob. Nob was about eight kilometers southwest of Gibeah and a very short distance north of the city of Jebus, later called Jerusalem. David went to see Ahimelech the high priest. Ahimelech trembled in fear when he saw David. Ahimelech asked David why David was alone and why there was no one with David. Ahimelech asked David two questions that meant the same thing to show Ahimelech's surprise that David came totally alone.

Stop here and look as a group at a map that shows David's journey from Gibeah to Nob, if necessary. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words or phrases do you use in your language to say that someone is trembling? Do you use different words or phrases to show different causes of trembling, for example, fear, cold or shock? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 21:1–9

David answered Ahimelech and said that David was alone because the king had sent David to do a special task for the king. David also said that David's men were not with David because David would meet the men later at a certain place. Note that David told Ahimelech a lie, but we only know it from following the events in the story. The storyteller does not use the word "lie" to explain what David said. David said that David would meet his men "at a certain place." People said this when they either did not know the name of a person or place, or when they deliberately tried to hide the name.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What are the ways, if any, to make it clear in your language that a character in a story is telling a lie? How will you show that David lied to Ahimelech? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What phrases or words do you use in your language to mention a specific place without saying where that place is? Pause this audio here.

Now David introduces a new topic to the conversation. David uses a phrase that makes it clear David is talking about a new thing. David says to Ahimelech, "And now, what do you have on hand? If you have five loaves of bread, give them to me, or whatever there is." "What do you have on hand?" is an expression that means "what food do you have with you at present?" David was probably making a polite request rather than giving Ahimelech a command.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words or phrases do you use in your language to introduce a new topic into a conversation like David does here? Pause this audio here.

Ahimelech answered David and said that Ahimelech did not have any common bread available, but there was holy bread. Ahimelech said he would give David the holy bread on the condition that David's men had not had sexual relations with women recently, as this would make the men ceremonially unclean. Remember that "common" bread means bread that is not holy or set apart for the worship of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about common bread as opposed to holy bread? Pause this audio here.

David answered Ahimelech and said that David and his men did not have sexual relations with women whenever the men went on any common mission. Therefore, much more now, they would keep "the vessels of the young men" holy and not have sexual relations before this mission for the king. David's expression "the vessels of the young men" referred to the body, and probably particularly to the parts of the body involved in sexual relations. David implied that this mission was holy.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about phrases or nicknames in your language that people use to describe body parts that are not proper to talk about politely, and that people might be embarrassed to talk about. Talk about phrases or words you will use to translate the phrase "the vessels of the young men," which refers to the male body parts involved in sexual relations. Pause this audio here.

Therefore, since there was no other bread available, Ahimelech gave David the bread of the Presence or the holy bread. The priests put freshly baked bread on the table before Yahweh in the tabernacle each Sabbath. Ahimelech gave David and his men the old bread, which the priests had taken away from the table in the tent of meeting, or tabernacle. The storyteller does not actually mention the tent of meeting, or tabernacle, but it talks about bread that is "before Yahweh," or "in Yahweh's presence." This implies that the bread was in the tabernacle, near the ark of the covenant.

Now the passage introduces some background information to the story. The passage uses a phrase that makes it clear that this is background information. Doeg the Edomite, or a native from the land of Edom, was there that day. Doeg was working for King Saul, probably as Saul's chief shepherd. Doeg was there because some religious duty Doeg needed to do kept him before Yahweh at the tabernacle. Although we do not hear any more about Doeg in this passage, we hear more about Doeg later. The storyteller introduces Doeg here to set up the later story.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do you show that you are introducing additional or background information to the story? Pause this audio here.

Then David asked Ahimelech, "Don't you have a spear or a sword here?" The way David asked the question implied that David expected that Ahimelech would have a spear or a sword. David gave a false explanation of why David

asked for the weapons. David said that he had not brought with him David's sword or any other weapons because the king had told David to leave immediately, so quickly that David had not had time to get his weapons.

Ahimelech replied that there was only the sword of Goliath the Philistine, whom David killed in the Valley of Elah or the Terebinth Valley. This sword was wrapped up in a cloth and was hanging behind the ephod—the high priest's shoulder-dress. Ahimelech said that if David wanted the sword, David could take it, as it was the only sword there. David accepted it because David said this weapon had more value or was more important than any other weapon.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a spear and a sword.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Ahimelech the high priest
- And Saul's servant Doeg the Edomite

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

David travels from Gibeah to Nob and meets Ahimelech the priest. Ahimelech is trembling and asks David why David travelled alone. David lies to Ahimelech. David says that David is alone because the king sent David to perform a special task for the king. David also says that David's men are not with him because David will meet the men later at a certain place. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Ahimelech looks scared. I will have to lie to Ahimelech because I do not want to get Ahimelech into trouble with the king; or
- But Ahimelech knows me and trusts me, so it will be easy to say something that Ahimelech will believe; or
- I am desperate. I need to get some food and some weapons from Ahimelech.

Continue the drama. David asks if Ahimelech has any food available that David can take with him on David's mission. David asks for five loaves, or whatever else Ahimelech has. Ahimelech answers David and says that Ahimelech does not have any common bread available, but that there is holy bread. Ahimelech says he will give David the holy bread on the condition that David's men have not had sexual relations with women recently. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ahimelech, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am not sure what to do. David wants me to give him food, but we only have the holy bread. Only the priests can eat the holy bread; or

1 Samuel 21:1–9

- But David and his men serve the king of Israel. I am sure Yahweh will be happy if I give David the old holy bread that was in the tent of meeting last week; or
- I just need to make sure that David and his men are pure before Yahweh and have not had sexual relations with women recently.

Continue the drama. David answers Ahimelech and says that David and his men do not have sexual relations with women whenever they go on any common mission. Therefore, much more now, the men would keep "the vessels of the young men" holy and not have sexual relations before this mission. Ahimelech gives David old bread of the Presence or holy bread, which the priests had taken away from the table in the tabernacle.

Saul's servant, a man called Doeg from Edom who was Saul's chief herdsman, is also there at Nob. Doeg is there because some religious duty he needed to perform keeps Doeg before Yahweh at the tabernacle. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Doeg, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel curious and suspicious. What is David doing here without his men? or
- Did King Saul send David on a mission by himself? Why is Ahimelech giving David the holy bread? or
- I will remember what I have seen and perhaps tell the king when I see him.

Continue the drama. David asks Ahimelech if Ahimelech has a spear or a sword David can have. Ahimelech says that he only has Goliath's sword, which David can have if David wants it. David accepts this sword as a weapon of greater value to David than any other. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy! I get to use the precious sword again! I cut Goliath's head off with this sword; or
- This sword reminds me of Yahweh's faithfulness when Yahweh caused me to defeat the giant; or
- I am feeling hopeful that Yahweh is with me now and will keep me safe from Saul.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Then David came to Nob, to Ahimelech the **priest**. The title priest here means the chief priest or the high priest. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

David said to Ahimelech that the **king** had sent David to perform a special mission.

David is talking about King Saul, who is the ruler of an entire nation. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

David said to Ahimelech, "And now, what do you have on hand?" What do you have on hand means, "What food do you have with you right now?"

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **"What do you have on hand?"** If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ahimelech answered that Ahimelech had no common bread, but there was holy, or consecrated bread. Ahimelech checked that David and David's men had not had sexual relationships with women recently. Then Ahimelech gave David some of the bread of the presence, which people removed from before Yahweh and which they replaced with hot bread.

Common bread was ordinary bread that anyone could eat. Holy, or consecrated bread, also called the bread of the presence, refers to the bread which Yahweh commanded to be always in his presence in the tabernacle. The priests consecrated this bread, which means that the priests had made the bread holy. The bread of the presence was 12 large loaves of bread that the priests set in two rows on a table before Yahweh in the tabernacle. The 12 loaves likely symbolized the 12 tribes of Israel and how God always provided for his people, the Israelites. The

1 Samuel 21:1–9

Israelites brought the bread to the table as an act of thanksgiving for God's provision for the people. The priests put freshly baked bread on the table each Sabbath, and only the priests were allowed to eat the old bread.

Stop here and look as a group at a picture of the holy, or consecrated, bread. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **common bread**, **holy** or **consecrated bread**, and **the bread of the presence**. Look up holy or consecrated in the Master Glossary. If you have already translated these phrases in another book of the Bible, use the same phrases that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh is God's personal name that appears throughout this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Now, Doeg the Edomite was there that day. Doeg was working for King Saul as Saul's chief **shepherd**, overseeing the king's herdsmen. Use the same word or phrase for shepherd as you used in previous passages. For more information on shepherd, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then David asked Ahimelech if Ahimelech had a **spear** or a **sword** at hand. Use the same word or phrase for spear and sword as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a spear and a sword. Pause this audio here.

Ahimelech said to David that Ahimelech had the sword of Goliath the Philistine, whom David had killed in the Valley of Elah. This sword was wrapped in a cloth behind the **ephod**. Use the same word or phrase for ephod as you used before. For more information on ephod, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 21:1–9

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (567 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.7 MB)

- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (811 KB)

1 Samuel 21:10–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 21:10–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:10–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:10–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, David ran away from King Saul to Nob, where Ahimelech the high priest was. David lied to Ahimelech and told him that David was on a special mission for the king. David asked Ahimelech for food and weapons. Ahimelech gave David holy bread from the tent of meeting and Goliath's sword.

Then David quickly left Nob that day as he continued to run away from Saul. David went to Achish, the king or ruler of the Philistine city of Gath, which was 37 kilometres southwest of Nob and far away from Saul. Perhaps David went there because the Philistines in Gath were also enemies of Saul, and maybe the people there would accept another of Saul's enemies. Achish was not the king of the land of the Philistines, but as a ruler of a main city, Achish was called the king of that city. Gath was one of five main Philistine cities, and the birthplace of Goliath. David wanted to hide from Saul in Gath and possibly work for Achish as a hired soldier. David was probably hoping that people in Gath would not recognise David because some years had passed since David had killed Goliath.

Stop here and look as a group at a map that shows David's journey from Nob to Gath. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What is the official title for leaders of cities in your people group? Pause this audio here.

But the servants or officials of King Achish recognised David as "the king of the land" and the one whom the Israelite people honoured with dances, singing, "Saul has killed his thousands, and David his ten thousands." The officials called David "king of the land" not because they knew that Yahweh had chosen David to be the next king of Israel, but because the officials remembered David's success when he killed Goliath. The officials also quoted the song that women sang about David's war victories to show Achish how strong David was. David's strength could be a danger to Achish.

And David took these words to heart, or paid attention to what the officials of Achish said about David. David became afraid of Achish because the song about David implied that David was a threat to Achish. Since David was alone, David was afraid that Achish might kill him because Achish would be afraid of David.

So, because of David's fear, David changed his behaviour while Achish and Achish's servants were watching. David pretended to be insane and acted differently than usual when he was in their hands or when the Philistines tried to restrain David. To make the people of Gath think that David was insane, David made marks on the gates to the city or the gates of Achish's palace by either scratching or clawing. David also let his saliva, or water from his mouth, run down into David's beard.

Stop here and discuss as a group how insane people act in your culture. Tell a story of someone who pretended to be insane but who was not really insane. Pause this audio here.

When Achish saw how David was behaving, Achish spoke to his officials, who had first recognised David. Achish said that David was acting insanely and asked why the officials had brought David to Achish. Achish felt there were many crazy or insane people in Gath, and therefore, Achish did not need David there as well. Achish was speaking angrily and in a mocking way. Achish was saying that his officials were fools for being afraid of a crazy man. Achish certainly was not interested and did not care what David the crazy man did, because Achish thought David was crazy. Achish definitely did not want David in his house.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:10–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: David quickly leaves Nob that day as he continues to flee from Saul. David goes to Achish, the king or ruler of Gath.

In the second scene: The servants or officials of Achish recognise David as the "king of the land." The officials even remember the song people sang about David's war victories.

In the third scene: David pays attention to what Achish's officials say about David. David is afraid that King Achish may kill David. David changes his behaviour and pretends to be insane when the men try to restrain David. David makes scratch marks on the city or palace gates and David lets his saliva run down his beard.

In the fourth scene: Achish mocks his officials and asks the officials why they brought David to Achish. Achish feels there are many crazy people in Gath, and therefore, David is unimportant and just another crazy person. Achish does not need David there as well.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Achish, the king or ruler of Gath
- And officials of King Achish

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Then David "rose" and fled Nob that day as David continued to run away from Saul. The word "rose" does not mean that David was sitting, but it shows that David acted quickly and decisively. David went to Achish, the king or ruler of the city of Gath. Gath was 37 kilometers southwest of Nob, and it would have taken David a whole day to walk to Gath.

Stop here and look as a group at a map showing David's journey from Nob to Gath. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How are you going to describe Achish's official title as the ruler of the city of Gath? Pause this audio here.

But the servants or officials of King Achish recognised David. The officials asked, "Is not this David the king of the land? Did they not sing to one another of him in dances, 'Saul has killed thousands of people, and David has killed tens of thousands'?" The officials did not expect anyone to answer these questions. The officials asked these questions to strongly say that they believed the man who came to their city, Gath, was in fact David. The words of the song show that Saul has killed thousands of people in battles. However, David has killed tens of thousands of people.

Stop here and remember how you translated this song in previous stories in 1 Samuel. Pause this audio here.

David took these words to heart, or paid attention to what the officials of Achish said about David. David became afraid that Achish might kill him because David was a danger to Achish. So, because of his fear, David changed his

behaviour while Achish and Achish's servants were watching. David pretended to be insane and acted abnormally when David was in their hands. The phrase "in their hands" has a number of possible meanings. One interpretation is that David acted like a madman when the officials tried to restrain David. The other interpretation is that David acted insane when he was nearby, or in the presence of the officials. David made marks on the gates to the city or the gates of Achish's palace by either scratching or clawing. David also let his saliva run down into David's beard.

When Achish saw how David was behaving, Achish spoke to his officials, who had first recognized David. Achish said that David was acting insanely and asked why the officials had brought David to Achish. Achish said, "Do I lack madmen, that you have brought this fellow to behave as a madman in my presence? Shall this fellow come into my house?" Achish asked questions he did not expect anyone to answer to stress that Achish had madmen, or crazy people, already in his city. Achish said he would not need David there as well since David was unimportant and not dangerous. Achish asked, "Must this man come into my house?" Achish did not want his officials to let David into Achish's house. Achish spoke in an angry and mocking manner.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:10–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Achish, the king or ruler of Gath
- And officials of King Achish

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

David quickly leaves Nob that day as he continues to run away from Saul. David goes to Achish, the king or ruler of Gath. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel relieved! I have food and weapons. I can continue on my way; or
- Where can I go? I am desperate. I will go to the Philistine city of Gath. Surely Saul will not look for me there; or
- I will ask the king of Gath if I can work for him as a soldier. So many years have passed since I killed Goliath. Surely the Philistines will not recognise me.

Continue the drama. The officials of Achish recognise David as the "king of the land," the man about whom people sing songs and dance to celebrate his war victories. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the officials of Achish, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are scared. This is David, who killed Goliath the giant! Women sang a song about David's victories over our people; or

- What is David doing in our city? David is a dangerous man of war! or
- We must warn King Achish.

Continue the drama. David pays attention to what the officials of Achish said about him. David is afraid that King Achish may kill David. David changes his behaviour and pretends to be insane when the men try to restrain him. David makes scratch marks on the city or palace gates, and David lets his saliva run down his beard. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am really worried! The officials recognised me! What do I do now? Achish will want to kill me! or
- Perhaps I should pretend to be insane? Maybe they will not kill me then; or
- I will dribble and act crazy. This is my only hope in this situation.

Continue the drama. Achish mocks his officials and asks the men why they brought David to Achish. Achish feels there are too many crazy people in Gath who are unimportant and not dangerous. Achish thinks David is unimportant and not dangerous. Achish certainly does not want David in Achish's house.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 21:10–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Then David quickly left Nob that day as he continued to run away from Saul. David went to Achish, the **king** or ruler of a Philistine city, Gath. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages when you talked about the king of a city. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Someone who is insane, or crazy, is someone who does not act like a normal person. An insane person may not have control over that person's own actions.

Stop here and discuss as a group the best way to describe David as insane. Remember that David was not really insane, but David acted like he was. Pause this audio here.

But the **servants** or officials of King Achish recognised David as "the king of the land" and the one that people honoured with dances, singing, "Saul has killed his thousands, and David his ten thousands." In this case, the servants are really officials who serve the king. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages, when the servants are officials of a king. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 21:10–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (538 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (872 KB)
- Speaking the Word (809 KB)

1 Samuel 22:1–10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 22:1–10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:1–10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, David continued to run away from Saul. After David left the high priest Ahimelech in the city of Nob, David went to Achish, the king of the Philistine city of Gath. However, the officials of Achish recognised David. David pretended to be insane so that the king would not kill David.

David ran away from the Philistine city of Gath because David was afraid of Achish, the king of Gath. David found refuge in a cave near the city of Adullam in the territory that belonged to the tribe of Judah. Adullam was 16 kilometres southeast of Gath and 16 kilometres southwest of Bethlehem, David's birth town. When David's seven brothers and the rest of his father's household heard where David went, they came from Bethlehem to join David in Adullam, because now they were in danger from Saul. David's father's household included all the living descendants of David's father, plus David's mother and the family slaves. Female descendants who were married were not part of the household anymore.

Stop here and look at the map as a group. Identify David's journey from Gath to the cave of Adullam and David's family's journey from Bethlehem to the cave of Adullam. Pause this audio here.

When people heard that David was in the cave of Adullam hiding from Saul, many people went to David. They were people in any kind of trouble. They were people who owed money to other people. They were people who were bitter in their souls, or discontent, because they had suffered some kind of loss or because they were without something that they wanted or needed. There were about 400 of these men, and David became their military leader. These men wanted a change in their lives, and they were willing to follow David and do anything for David.

1 Samuel 22:1–10

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who or what kind of people usually join a person who rebels against the government to fight alongside that person? Pause this audio here.

David took his elderly parents from the cave to the city of Mizpeh in the country of Moab, east of the Dead Sea. The name Mizpeh means watchtower or mountain height. We do not know where in Moab the city of Mizpeh was, but its name suggests it was probably on top of a mountain. David asked the king of Moab to allow David's parents to stay in Mizpeh with the king. David was afraid that Saul would harm his parents if David's parents remained in Israel. In seeking protection for his parents and looking after them, David was following common ancient custom and obeying the fifth commandment that Yahweh gave to Moses. David's ancestor Ruth was from the land of Moab, so Moab was a good place for David's parents to find refuge. David's parents would not necessarily live in the same house as the king, but they would live in the same city, close enough for the king to protect David's parents. David told the king of Moab that David wanted his parents to stay there until David knew what God would do for David. This way, David showed the Moabite king David's belief that God controlled David's future. David was sure that David's cause was just and that Saul was attacking David unfairly. David confidently hoped that God would give David safety again.

Stop here and look at the map as a group. Identify David's journey from the cave of Adullam to the city of Mizpeh in Moab. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and tell a story of a time when you or someone you know did something to protect their parents. Pause this audio here.

The king of Moab agreed to David's request, and David left his parents with the king. David's parents stayed there all the time David was in the stronghold, but it is not clear how long that was. We are not sure where the stronghold was. A "stronghold" is any place that is difficult to attack or capture. The stronghold may have been the city of Mizpeh or a different place in Moab. We can see from what the prophet Gad says to David next that the "stronghold" was probably not the cave near Adullam in the territory of the tribe of Judah.

There was a prophet named Gad in Israel at that time. The prophet warned David not to remain in the stronghold but to leave the stronghold and go to the land of the tribe of Judah. From then on, Gad would tell David Yahweh's word and advise David, just like Samuel told Yahweh's word to Saul. So David left and went to the forest of Hereth in the land of the tribe of Judah. We do not know exactly where the forest was.

Stop here and look at the map as a group. Identify David's journey from Moab to the forest of Hereth in the land of the tribe of Judah. Pause this audio here.

One day, Saul was in the city of Gibeah, which was where Saul lived. Saul was sitting under a tamarisk tree on a hilltop, with his spear in his hand, and all Saul's officers were standing around Saul. A tamarisk tree is a tree that grows up to eighteen metres in height and has delicate, needle-like leaves and small, pink or white flowers. It is a good shade tree because it rarely loses its leaves. The storyteller says that Saul was sitting under a specific tamarisk tree. Saul held his important meeting with his officers at a well-known place where Saul usually held council. The spear in Saul's hand showed that Saul was the king.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a tamarisk tree. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a king's spear. Pause the audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, what special clothes or items would a king wear or hold during special occasions to show that he is the king of the country? If your country does not have a king, talk about special clothes or items that a leader of your country would have to show their high position. Pause this audio here.

Someone told Saul that some of Saul's men had seen David and David's men. Possibly someone saw David and David's men going to the forest or living in the forest. Saul thought that David was trying to kill Saul and become king himself. Saul also thought that Saul's officials were secretly supporting David. Saul reacted to the news by speaking to Saul's men. Saul called his men the "men of Benjamin." Saul was one of the members of the tribe of Benjamin, and Saul had chosen men from the tribe of Benjamin to serve Saul as his government and military officials. David, however, was from the tribe of Judah. Saul asked his men if the son of Jesse, or David, would give all of his men fields and vineyards. Saul did not expect anyone to answer this question. Saul was being sarcastic.

1 Samuel 22:1–10

Saul used a question to strongly say that David would not give the men of Benjamin fields and vineyards. Saul had chosen men from his own tribe of Benjamin to be Saul's officials, and Saul rewarded the men with land. Saul was assuming that David would also choose men from David's own tribe, Judah, to be David's officials and that David would reward those men with gifts of land. Saul called David "the son of Jesse" instead of using his name to show that Saul despised David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do government leaders in your people group choose their officials? What makes government leaders either favour or not favour people from your tribe or area? Pause this audio here.

Saul also asked if the son of Jesse would make all the men commanders of thousands of soldiers and commanders of hundreds of soldiers. Saul was not expecting anyone to answer this question either. Saul was saying that David would not choose men from the tribe of Benjamin to be his military commanders. If Saul's officials thought David would choose them, the officials were quite wrong.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about what levels of military commanders your people group's army has. Pause this audio here.

Saul asked his men if this was why Saul's men plotted against Saul. Saul did not expect anyone to answer. Saul was being sarcastic again. Saul did not believe that David would give the Benjamite men land and important positions, and Saul thought his Benjamite officials were therefore being foolish to support David.

Saul was not happy that no one told Saul when his son made a covenant with the son of Jesse. Saul was talking about his oldest son, Jonathan, and the agreement that Jonathan had made with David regarding their friendship and the friendship of their families. Someone must have told Saul about the covenant, but apparently, it was not one of Saul's officials who told Saul. Saul accused his men of not feeling sorry for Saul, because the men did not inform Saul that his son Jonathan had stirred up Saul's servant David to wait secretly for an opportunity to kill Saul. Saul thought that David was hiding in the forest at that very moment to make a surprise attack on Saul, but it was not the truth.

Then Doeg the Edomite, one of Saul's servants, spoke. Doeg was a foreigner from the country of Edom, and Doeg was Saul's chief shepherd. Doeg said that he saw the son of Jesse coming to the city of Nob, to Ahimelech the priest, son of Ahitub. Doeg was retelling the events he probably would have witnessed when Doeg was in Nob. Doeg said that Ahimelech asked Yahweh what David should do. Probably Ahimelech would have consulted Yahweh through the ephod, which contains the Urim and Thummim. The Urim and Thummim were two objects the high priest used to determine Yahweh's will. Doeg also told Saul that Ahimelech gave David food provisions and the sword of Goliath the Philistine. Everything that Doeg told Saul sounded to Saul like Ahimelech was helping David in military preparations against Saul.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: David flees Gath and finds refuge in a cave near the city of Adullam. When David's seven brothers and the rest of David's father's household hear where David went, they come from Bethlehem to join David in Adullam.

In the second scene: About 400 men join David in the cave near Adullam, and David becomes these men's military leader. These men are rebels who are unhappy, have suffered losses, or whom others mistreated.

In the third scene: David takes his elderly parents from the cave of Adullam to the city of Mizpeh in the country of Moab. David asks the king of Moab to allow David's parents to stay in Mizpeh with the king until God works out his plans for David. David leaves his parents with the king of Moab, and David's parents stay there all the time David is in the stronghold.

1 Samuel 22:1–10

In the fourth scene: A prophet named Gad warns David not to remain in the stronghold but to leave and go to the land of the tribe of Judah. David leaves and goes to the forest of Hereth in the land of the tribe of Judah.

In the fifth scene: Saul and his officials are on a hilltop where Saul usually holds council. Someone tells Saul that some of Saul's men had seen David and David's men. Saul thinks that David is trying to kill Saul and become king himself, and that Saul's officials are secretly supporting David. Saul mocks his officials and tells the men that they should not expect that the son of Jesse will give them privileges of land and important positions. Saul accuses his officials of not telling Saul about a covenant that his son Jonathan made with David. Saul also accuses his officials of not feeling sorry for Saul and not informing him that, apparently, Jonathan stirred up David to wait for an opportunity to kill Saul.

In the sixth scene: Doeg the Edomite tells Saul that Doeg saw the son of Jessie coming to Nob, to Ahimelech the priest. Doeg says that Ahimelech asked Yahweh what David should do and gave David food provisions and the sword of Goliath the Philistine.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- David's brothers
- The rest of David's father's house, including David's mother, all of David's father's descendants except David's married sisters, plus all the slaves or servants
- About 400 men who joined David to be in his army
- The king of Moab
- The prophet Gad
- King Saul
- Saul's officials who were with Saul
- And Doeg the Edomite

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

David fled the Philistine city of Gath and found refuge in a cave near the city of Adullam in the territory that belonged to the tribe of Judah. Adullam was 16 kilometers southeast of Gath and 16 kilometers southwest of Bethlehem, David's birth town. When David's seven brothers and the rest of David's father's household heard where David went, they came from Bethlehem to join David in the cave of Adullam.

Stop here and look at the map as a group. Identify David's journey from Gath to the cave of Adullam and David's family's journey from Bethlehem to the cave of Adullam. Pause this audio here.

When people heard that David was in the cave of Adullam hiding from Saul, about four hundred men joined David, and David became their military leader. These men were rebels in any kind of trouble, people who owed money to other people, and people who were bitter in their souls because they had suffered some kind of loss or because they were without something that they wanted or needed. These are examples of the problems these men had, but we do not know exactly what problems they actually had. However, these men were bitter of soul, or very discontent and unhappy with their lives.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you describe people like that, who are always bitter and not content? Pause this audio here.

David took his elderly parents from the cave to the city of Mizpeh in the country of Moab, east of the Dead Sea. David made a polite request to the king of Moab to allow David's parents to stay in Mizpeh with the king. David told the king of Moab that David wanted his parents to stay there until David knew what God would do for David. David used the general word for God rather than God's personal name, "Yahweh," because David was talking to a non-Israelite king.

Stop here and look at the map as a group. Identify David's journey from the cave of Adullam to the city of Mizpeh in Moab. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words do you use in your language when you talk about God to a believer and to a non-believer? Pause this audio here.

David left his parents with the king of Moab. David's parents stayed in Moab all the time David was in the stronghold, but it is not clear how long that was. We are not sure where the stronghold was. We can see from what the prophet Gad says to David next that the stronghold was probably not in the territory of the tribe of Judah. If the stronghold was not in the territory of the tribe of Judah, at some point, David's men would have probably left the cave of Adullam and joined David at the stronghold.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What does a stronghold look like in your area? What do you call these places that have strong defenses, like a surrounding wall or barrier, and soldiers guarding it? Pause this audio here.

A prophet named Gad warned David not to remain in the stronghold but to leave and go to the land of the tribe of Judah. We are not sure if Gad was staying with David or if Gad came from somewhere else. So David left and went to the forest of Hereth in the land of the tribe of Judah. We do not know exactly where the forest was. If David's men had joined David at the stronghold, then the men probably would have gone with David.

Stop here and look at the map as a group. Identify David's journey from Moab to the forest of Hereth in the land of the tribe of Judah. Pause this audio here.

As the storyteller tells the story, he uses language that shows the listener that the storyteller is changing scenes. Now the storyteller is talking about Saul in Gibeah. One day, Saul was in Saul's city, Gibeah. Saul was sitting under a tamarisk tree on a hilltop where Saul usually held council. Saul had a spear in his hand, and all Saul's servants or officials were standing around Saul. Although the original language uses the word servants for Saul's officials, these are not servants in the normal way. These are officials, or advisors and leaders, in Saul's government. As leaders, these men serve their king, Saul. Saul was holding an important meeting. Someone told Saul that some of Saul's men had seen David and David's men. Saul thought that David was trying to kill Saul and become king himself. Saul also thought that Saul's officials were secretly supporting David. Saul spoke to Saul's men. Saul addressed his men as "men of Benjamin" and asked them if the son of Jesse would give all of the men fields and vineyards. Saul also asked if the son of Jesse would make all the men commanders of thousands and commanders of hundreds. Saul was not expecting anyone to answer Saul's questions. Saul spoke sarcastically to his men and made a strong point that David, who was from the tribe of Judah, would not give Benjamite men privileges of land and important positions. Saul asked his men if this was why the men plotted against Saul. Saul did not expect anyone to answer. Saul was speaking sarcastically and accusing the men again. Saul did not believe that David would give the Benjamites land and important positions, and Saul thought his Benjamite officials were therefore being foolish to support David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Saul mocked his men by asking questions that did not require an answer but that acted as pointed statements. Saul mocked David by not referring to David by name but by calling David "the son of Jesse." Discuss different ways people mock or insult others in your language. Pause this audio here.

Saul was not happy that no one told Saul when Saul's son made a covenant with the son of Jesse. Someone must have told Saul about the covenant, but apparently it was not one of Saul's officials. Saul accused his men of not feeling sorry for Saul, because they did not inform Saul that, apparently, Saul's son Jonathan stirred up his servant David to wait secretly for an opportunity to kill Saul. Saul thought that David was hiding in the forest at that very moment to make a surprise attack on Saul.

Then Doeg the Edomite, who oversaw Saul's shepherds, said that Doeg saw the son of Jessie coming to Nob, to Ahimelech the priest, son of Ahitub. Doeg said that Ahimelech inquired of Yahweh for David and gave David food provisions and the sword of Goliath the Philistine. However, everything that Doeg told Saul sounded like Ahimelech was helping David in military preparations against Saul.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- David's brothers
- The rest of David's father's house, including David's mother, all of David's father's descendants except David's married sisters, plus all the slaves or servants
- About 400 men who joined David to be his army
- The king of Moab
- The prophet Gad
- King Saul
- Saul's officials who were with Saul
- And Doeg the Edomite

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

David fled the city of Gath and found refuge in a cave near the city of Adullam. When David's brothers and the rest of David's father's household heard where David went, they came to join David in the cave of Adullam.

When other people heard that David was in the cave of Adullam, about 400 men joined David, and David became their military leader. These men were rebels in any kind of trouble. They were people who owed money to other people. The men were people who were bitter in their souls because they had suffered some kind of loss or because they were without something that they wanted or needed. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am not safe near Saul, and I am not safe near King Achish of Gath. The cave of Adullam will be a good hiding place! or
- I am so glad my family has joined me, as Saul will probably try to kill them too! Perhaps I should take my parents to stay with the king of Moab, as their ancestors came from Moab. I need to look after my parents; or
- Look at all the rebels joining me! Maybe Yahweh brought these men to me to be my army, and I will be their leader!

Continue the drama. David took his elderly parents from the cave to the city of Mizpeh in the country of Moab. David asked the king of Moab to allow David's parents to stay in Mizpeh with the king. David told the king of Moab that David wanted his parents to stay there until David knew what God would do for David. David left his parents with the king of Moab, and David's parents stayed there all the time David was in the stronghold. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David's parents, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are happy that David is a good son and that David is looking after us; or
- We are relieved that we will be safe from Saul in Moab. The king of Moab will take care of us; or
- We are worried about David. Saul wants to kill David.

Continue the drama. A prophet named Gad warned David not to remain in the stronghold but to leave and go to the land of the tribe of Judah. So David left and went to the forest of Hereth in the land of the tribe of Judah.

One day, Saul was in Saul's city, Gibeah. Saul was sitting under a tamarisk tree on a hilltop where Saul usually held council. Saul had a spear in his hand, and all Saul's officers were standing around Saul. Saul was holding an

important meeting. Someone told Saul that some of Saul's men had seen David and David's men. Saul thought that David was trying to kill Saul and become king himself. Saul also thought that Saul's officials were secretly supporting David. Saul spoke sarcastically to his men. Saul asked the men if the son of Jesse would give all of the men fields and vineyards. Saul also asked if the son of Jesse would make all the men commanders of thousands and commanders of hundreds. Saul asked his men if this was why they plotted against Saul. Saul did not believe that David would give the Benjamites land and important positions, and Saul thought his Benjamite officials were therefore being stupid to support David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I knew that the son of Jesse wanted to kill me, so he could become king! or
- And even my own officers are helping David! Nobody tells me anything! Even my own son Jonathan made a covenant with David, and none of my officials warned me about it! I feel betrayed by everyone; or
- I am worried now. I must find a way to keep my men from betraying me. Don't these foolish Benjamites realise that they will be unimportant in David's army? David will reward his own men with land and rank, because those men come from the tribe of Judah, like David does.

Continue the drama. Saul was not happy that no one told Saul when Saul's son made a covenant with the son of Jesse. Saul accused his men of not feeling sorry for Saul, because the men did not inform Saul that, apparently, Saul's son Jonathan had stirred up his servant David to wait secretly for an opportunity to kill Saul. Saul thought that David was hiding in the forest at that very moment to make a surprise attack on Saul.

Then Doeg the Edomite said that he saw the son of Jessie coming to Nob, to Ahimelech the priest, son of Ahitub. Doeg said that Ahimelech talked with Yahweh for David and gave David food provisions and the sword of Goliath the Philistine. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Doeg the Edomite, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have some information about David that Saul will like. I was clearly at the right place at the right time when I saw Ahimelech help David; or
- Saul will think highly of me when I tell him what I saw in Nob; or
- I will tell Saul that Ahimelech the priest advised David what to do and gave him food and Goliath's sword. It truly looks like Ahimelech is supporting David.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

David went from the cave of Adullam to Mizpeh in Moab and asked the king of Moab if David's parents could stay with the king until David knew what **God** would do for David.

Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

The king in this story is the **king** of a whole area called Moab. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

After David left his parents with the king of Moab, David stayed in a stronghold. Then the prophet Gad told David not to remain in the stronghold but to go to the land of the tribe of Judah.

A stronghold is a place that is well-protected and difficult to attack or take over. A stronghold can be a building that people make like a fortress or castle, or it can refer to a cave in the wilderness that offers safety and security. Here, stronghold means a man-made fortified building.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **stronghold**, meaning a man-made fortified building. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. For more information on stronghold, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **prophet** as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

1 Samuel 22:1–10

One day, Saul was sitting on a hilltop in Gibeah under a tamarisk tree. Saul had Saul's spear in his hand, and all Saul's servants were standing near Saul. A tamarisk tree is a tree that grows up to 18 metres in height and has delicate needle-like leaves and small, pink or white flowers. A tamarisk is a good shade tree because it rarely loses its leaves.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a tamarisk tree. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **tamarisk tree**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Here, the word **servants** refers to the officials in Saul's government, not to slaves. However, these officials do serve Saul. You may use the word officials in your translation if you would like. Use the same word for servants or officials of the king as you have used in previous passages. If you use the word for servant, see the Master Glossary for more information.

Here, the word **spear** refers to the king's spear. Saul's spear would likely be larger, more ornate, and better crafted than those of ordinary soldiers. People would make Saul's spear from higher-quality materials. The spear might include symbols or markings that represent the tribe of Benjamin, Saul's family, or Saul's authority as the anointed king of Israel. Since this spear belonged to Saul, the makers of the spear could have made it unique in some way, such as having a unique shape, balance, or other features that set it apart from standard spears. Use the same word or phrase for spear that you have used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a king's spear. Pause the audio here.

And Saul said to his servants who stood around Saul, "Hear now, people of Benjamin; will the son of Jesse give every one of you fields and **vineyards**, will he make you all commanders of thousands and commanders of hundreds? Is that why you all conspired against me?"

Use the same word or phrase for vineyards as you used in previous passages. For more information on vineyards, refer to the Master Glossary.

Use the same word or phrase for army **commanders** as you have used before.

Stop here and discuss as a group if you have special words or phrases in your language for commanders of **hundreds of soldiers** and commanders of **thousands of soldiers.** If you do, then you can use them here. If you do not have them in your language, decide what words or phrases you will use. Pause this audio here.

Doeg the Edomite told Saul that Doeg saw David at Nob coming to see Ahimelech the priest and that Ahimelech talked with **Yahweh** for David and gave David food provisions and Goliath's sword. Yahweh is God's personal name, and Yahweh is used throughout this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 22:1–10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (543 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (846 KB)

1 Samuel 22:11–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 22:11–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:11–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:11–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, David continued to flee from Saul and went to a cave near the city of Adullam in the territory of the tribe of Judah. David's family joined David at the cave, as well as 400 rebels. David took his parents to Mizpeh in Moab so that David's parents could stay in safety with the king of Moab. David stayed in a stronghold until the prophet Gad advised David to go to the land of the tribe of Judah. So David went to the forest of Hereth. In the meantime, King Saul accused his officials of plotting with David and not keeping Saul informed of what David was doing. Doeg the Edomite, Saul's chief shepherd, told Saul that Doeg had seen Ahimelech the high priest in the city of Nob talk with Yahweh for David and give David food provisions and Goliath's sword.

After hearing Doeg the Edomite's story of David's time with Ahimelech, King Saul sent a message to Ahimelech, the priest, the son of Ahitub. The title "priest" here means the chief priest or the high priest. Saul told Ahimelech that Saul wanted to see Ahimelech and all his father's house. Ahimelech's "father's house" referred to all the adult male descendants of Ahimelech's father. All of these men were priests in the city of Nob. All the priests in the city of Nob were Ahimelech's brothers or sons. So all the priests obeyed Saul and went to see Saul in Gibeah. Gibeah was eight kilometers northwest of the city of Nob.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows the priests' journey from Nob to Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

Then Saul spoke to Ahimelech in an angry and mocking way and said, “Listen now, son of Ahitub.” Ahimelech replied and said, “Here I am, my lord.” “My lord” was a general term of respect that people used for any ruler or master. Then Saul asked Ahimelech a long question that Saul did not expect anyone to answer. The question was really a series of statements accusing Ahimelech of plotting with David against Saul. Saul said that Ahimelech and the son of Jesse were plotting against Saul. Saul referred to David by David’s father’s name to show that Saul did not respect David at all. Saul accused Ahimelech of helping David to rebel against Saul because Ahimelech gave David bread and a sword and talked with God for David. Saul was convinced that even as he was speaking to Ahimelech, David was waiting for an opportunity to kill Saul.

Ahimelech answered Saul and asked Saul a long question that was really a few small questions that Ahimelech did not expect Saul to answer. Ahimelech used this question to make several statements to prove that Ahimelech had been loyal to Saul. Ahimelech implied that the king’s accusations could not be true. Ahimelech asked Saul, “And who among all your servants is so faithful as David?” Ahimelech considered David to be better than any of the other servants of Saul. Ahimelech could not understand why Saul would think that David was not loyal to Saul. Ahimelech asked Saul if this had been the first time that Ahimelech had talked to God for David. This was another question that did not require an answer. Ahimelech was saying that Ahimelech often talked with God for David, and Saul had not been concerned before. It was normal for Ahimelech to ask questions of Yahweh for David, because David had a high position in Saul’s court. Ahimelech told Saul that Saul should not consider Ahimelech the king’s servant and Ahimelech’s family to be guilty of any wrongdoing. Ahimelech truthfully denied that he knew anything about David’s plot against Saul.

But Saul refused to listen to Ahimelech. Saul said that Ahimelech and all Ahimelech’s father’s family, all the priests at Nob, were certainly going to die. Saul was going to have someone kill these men.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about the history of your people group. Discuss situations from the past when a ruler killed or put innocent people in prison because the ruler feared that other people would overthrow the ruler. Pause this audio here.

The king told his guards, who stood near the king, to surround and kill the priests who served Yahweh. Saul told the guards that the priests had also, like everybody else, supported or helped David. Saul said that although the priests knew that David had run away, the priests had not told Saul. But the king’s guardsmen refused to obey Saul’s order to kill the priests of Yahweh. As the king of Israel, Saul’s responsibility was to encourage people to follow God’s laws and respect the priests, as the priests were responsible for offering sacrifices, teaching the people, and praying to God to help the people of Israel. The guardsmen probably thought that the sentence was unjust, and the guards feared Yahweh more than they feared the king.

Then Saul commanded Doeg the Edomite to go and kill the priests. So Doeg went and attacked the priests. That day, Doeg killed 85 people who wore the linen ephod. The linen ephod was a plain, probably white, linen robe, which only priests wore. The priest’s ephod was very different from the high priest’s ephod, which was a highly decorated piece of clothing. The high priest wore the ephod in the tent of meeting when he served Yahweh. Since the people who Doeg the Edomite killed wore linen ephods, this means that Doeg killed 85 priests. Doeg was a foreigner from a country that people called Edom, which may be why Doeg did not have as much respect for priests and was willing to kill the priests.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a priest wearing an ephod. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about tasks or responsibilities that the authorities in your people group have given to foreigners because people from your people group did not want to do those tasks. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Here, the passage identifies priests as “people who wore the linen ephod.” What kinds of professions in your culture can you clearly identify and name by what the people in that profession wear? Pause this audio here.

And Doeg the Edomite also killed everyone else who lived in the city of Nob, the city of priests. Nob was a central religious centre in Saul’s kingdom. Nob was where the ark of the covenant probably was, at least for a while. Yet Saul treated Nob like some enemy city against which Saul started a holy war. Saul wanted to destroy the city and everything in it. Doeg killed both men and women, children, babies and the livestock, including oxen,

donkeys, and sheep. Doeg did not necessarily slaughter all the townspeople himself. Doeg could have had Doeg's own followers and relatives with Doeg.

Doeg killed everyone in Nob except Abiathar, one of Ahimelech's sons. Abiathar escaped and ran to David to join David's group of supporters. After Abiathar had caught up with David, Abiathar told David that Saul had killed Yahweh's priests. Abiathar would have given David a detailed account of what happened.

David told Abiathar that from the moment David had seen Doeg the Edomite in Nob, David had known that Doeg would tell Saul that David had been to see Ahimelech. David confessed to Abiathar that David himself was ultimately responsible for Saul killing Abiathar's family. Although it was Doeg the Edomite who killed the priests, David felt that, through David's earlier presence at Nob, David was guilty of causing the priests' death.

David told Abiathar not to be afraid and to stay with David. Abiathar and David now had the same enemy, Saul, who wanted to kill them both. David said that David would protect Abiathar, so before Saul could kill Abiathar, Saul would first have to kill David.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:11–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

In the first scene: King Saul summons Ahimelech, the high priest, and Ahimelech's father's house to come and see Saul. So, Ahimelech and all his father's descendants, who are the priests in the city of Nob, travel to Gibeah to see the king.

In the second scene: Saul speaks to Ahimelech and accuses Ahimelech of conspiring with David against Saul.

In the third scene: Ahimelech tells the king that the king should not consider Ahimelech and Ahimelech's family to be guilty of any wrongdoing. Ahimelech truthfully denies that he knew anything about David's plot against Saul.

In the fourth scene: Saul refuses to listen to Ahimelech's defense. Saul says that Ahimelech and all Ahimelech's father's family, all the priests at Nob, were certainly going to die.

In the fifth scene: The king tells the king's guards to surround and kill the priests who served Yahweh. The king's guardsmen refuse to carry out the king's order to kill the priests. Saul commands Doeg the Edomite to go and kill the priests, and Doeg kills 85 priests that day. Doeg also kills all the men, women, children, babies, and livestock in the city of Nob.

In the sixth scene: Abiathar, one of Ahimelech's sons, escapes from Nob and flees to

David to join David's group of supporters. Abiathar tells David that Saul killed Yahweh's priests. David says that David himself is ultimately responsible for the murder of Abiathar's family.

In the seventh scene: David tells Abiathar not to be afraid and to stay with David. Abiathar and David now have the same enemy, Saul, who wants to kill them both. David says that David will protect Abiathar.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- Ahimelech the high priest
- Ahimelech's father's household, which consisted of all Ahimelech's father's male descendants, who were all the priests in the city of Nob
- Saul's guardsmen
- Doeg the Edomite
- Everyone in the city of Nob, including the men, women, children, and babies
- All the livestock in the city of Nob

- Abiathar, one of Ahimelech's sons
- And David

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

After hearing Doeg the Edomite's story of David's time with Ahimelech, King Saul sent a message to Ahimelech, the high priest, in the city of Nob. Saul told Ahimelech that Saul wanted to see Ahimelech and all of Ahimelech's father's house, which means all Ahimelech's relatives who descended from Ahimelech's father, whether or not they lived together. These men were Ahimelech's brothers and their sons, who were all priests from Nob. So all the priests obeyed and went to see Saul in Gibeah. Gibeah was eight kilometers northwest of the city of Nob.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows the priests' journey from Nob to Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words or phrases do people use in your language to describe family members as a group? What words do you use to describe immediate family and extended family? What words do you use to describe family members who live in the same house? Pause this audio here.

Then Saul spoke to Ahimelech, "Listen now, son of Ahitub." The phrase "Listen now" would normally mean, "listen please." However, since Saul was very angry, Saul was probably speaking in a mocking way. Saul was angry when he called Ahimelech "son of Ahitub" rather than by Ahimelech's name. This phrase was an insulting rather than polite way to address someone. Ahimelech replied, "Here I am, my lord." "My lord" was a general term of respect that people used for any ruler or master.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What are the polite ways of referring to a king or an important leader in your people group? How do people in authority talk to their subjects when they are angry with those subjects? Pause this audio here.

Then Saul asked Ahimelech a long question that Saul did not expect anyone to answer. The question was really a series of statements accusing Ahimelech of plotting with David against Saul. Saul said that Ahimelech and the son of Jesse were plotting against Saul. Saul referred to David by David's father's name to show that Saul did not respect David at all. Saul accused Ahimelech of helping David to rebel against Saul because Ahimelech gave David bread and a sword and inquired of God for David. Saul was convinced that even as Saul was speaking to Ahimelech, David was waiting for an opportunity to kill Saul.

Ahimelech asked Saul a long question that was really a few short questions that did not require an answer. Ahimelech used this question to make several statements to affirm that Ahimelech had been loyal to Saul. Ahimelech implied that the king's accusations could not be true. Ahimelech asked Saul, "And who among all your servants is so faithful as David?" Ahimelech considered David to be better than any of the other servants of Saul. Ahimelech referred to David respectfully by David's name, in contrast to Saul, who called David "the son of Jesse." Ahimelech asked the king, "Who is the king's son-in-law?" Ahimelech was stressing that the king had given the king's own daughter to David in marriage. Ahimelech asked Saul, "Who is the captain over the king's bodyguard?" Ahimelech was saying that Saul had put David in charge of the officials who were guarding Saul's life. Ahimelech asked the king, "Who do people highly honour in your house?" Ahimelech was saying that all the members of the king's household highly respected David. Ahimelech asked Saul if this was the first time that Ahimelech had talked with God for David. This was another question that did not require an answer. Ahimelech was saying that it was normal for Ahimelech to talk with God for David, because David had a high position in Saul's court. Ahimelech told Saul that Saul should not consider Ahimelech the king's servant and Ahimelech's family to be guilty of any wrongdoing. By referring to himself as "the king's servant," Ahimelech spoke to the king in a humble and polite way. Ahimelech truthfully denied that Ahimelech knew anything about David's plot against Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Both Saul and Ahimelech used questions that did not require an answer to make important or strong statements. How do you make important or strong statements in your language? Pause this audio here.

But Saul refused to listen to Ahimelech. Saul said that Ahimelech and all Ahimelech's father's family, all the priests at Nob, were certainly going to die.

The king told the guards who stood near the king to surround and kill the priests who served Yahweh. Saul told the guards that the priests had also, like everybody else, supported or helped David. Saul said that although the priests knew that David had run away, the priests had not told Saul. But the king's guardsmen refused to obey Saul's order to kill Yahweh's priests. The storyteller says that the servants of the king "would not raise a hand" to strike Yahweh's priests. The storyteller means that the servants would not attack the priests.

Then Saul commanded Doeg the Edomite to go and strike down, or attack and kill, the priests. This way of talking about killing people is very violent. So Doeg went and attacked the priests. That day, Doeg killed 85 people who wore the linen ephod. Only priests wore a linen ephod, so this means that Doeg killed 85 priests.

And Doeg the Edomite also killed everyone else who lived in Nob, the city of priests. Doeg killed both men and women, children, babies and the livestock, including oxen, donkeys, and sheep. Doeg did not necessarily slaughter all the townspeople alone. Doeg could have had his own followers and relatives with Doeg.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you describe violent scenes in stories in your language? Remember that Doeg probably did not kill everyone himself, but Doeg led the group of people who killed everyone in Nob. Pause this audio here.

Now the storyteller changes the direction of the story and introduces a contrast in the story. One of the high priest's sons escaped and went to see David. Doeg killed everyone in Nob except Abiathar, one of Ahimelech's sons. The word "one" in the original language can mean either "one son" or "the first son." Abiathar escaped and ran to David to join David's group of supporters. After Abiathar had caught up with David, Abiathar told David that Saul had killed the priests of Yahweh. Saul had not personally killed the priests but was responsible for their deaths. Saul was the one who authorized the killing that Doeg the Edomite carried out. Abiathar would have given David a detailed description of what happened.

David told Abiathar that as soon as David saw Doeg the Edomite in Nob, David knew Doeg would tell Saul that David had visited Ahimelech. David confessed to Abiathar that David himself was ultimately responsible for the killing of Abiathar's family.

David told Abiathar not to be afraid and to stay with David. Abiathar and David now had the same enemy, Saul, who wanted to kill them both. David said that David would protect Abiathar, so before Saul could kill Abiathar, Saul would first have to kill David.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:11–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Saul
- Ahimelech the high priest
- Ahimelech's father's household, which consisted of all Ahimelech's father's male descendants, who were all the priests in the city of Nob
- Saul's guardsmen
- Doeg the Edomite
- Everyone in the city of Nob, including the men, women, children, and babies
- All the livestock in the city of Nob
- Abiathar, one of Ahimelech's sons
- And David

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

1 Samuel 22:11–23

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After hearing Doeg the Edomite's account of David's time with Ahimelech, King Saul sent a message to Ahimelech the priest in the city of Nob. Saul told Ahimelech that Saul wanted to see Ahimelech and all Ahimelech's father's house, the priests from Nob. So all the priests obeyed Saul and went to see Saul in Gibeah. Gibeah was eight kilometers northwest of the city of Nob.

Saul said, "Listen now, son of Ahitub." Then Saul accused Ahimelech of plotting with David against Saul. Saul said that Ahimelech and the son of Jesse were plotting against Saul. Saul accused Ahimelech of helping David to rebel against Saul because Ahimelech gave David bread and a sword and inquired of God for David. Saul was convinced that even as Saul was speaking to Ahimelech, David was waiting for an opportunity to kill Saul. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so angry with Ahimelech! Ahimelech is helping David to become a king! I feel panic that I am losing my throne! Who does Ahimelech think he is? or
- Ahimelech is supposed to be my priest, yet he is plotting against me with the son of Jesse! or
- Let's see what Ahimelech has to say for himself. Doeg the Edomite told me how Ahimelech helped the son of Jesse!

Continue the drama. Ahimelech answered Saul and assured Saul that Ahimelech had been loyal to Saul. Ahimelech asked Saul, "And who among all your servants is so faithful as David? Who is the king's son-in-law? Who is the captain over the king's bodyguard? Who do people highly honour in your house?" Ahimelech asked Saul if it was the first time that Ahimelech had inquired of God for David. Ahimelech was saying that it was normal for Ahimelech to talk to God for David, because of David's high position in Saul's court. Ahimelech told Saul that Saul should not consider Ahimelech the king's servant and Ahimelech's family to be guilty of any wrongdoing. Ahimelech truthfully denied that Ahimelech knew anything about David's plot against Saul. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ahimelech, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This must be a misunderstanding. How can Saul accuse me of conspiring against Saul with David? or
- David is a man of very high standing, and the king usually trusts David! David's wife is the king's daughter. Everyone at the king's court trusts David; or
- I cannot believe this! How could I not have helped David? How could I not have talked to Yahweh for David? I have talked with Yahweh for David in the past. The king's accusations against me and my father's house are untrue.

Continue the drama. But Saul refused to listen to Ahimelech. Saul said that Ahimelech and all Ahimelech's father's family, all the priests at Nob, were certainly going to die.

The king told the guards who stood near the king to surround and kill the priests who served Yahweh. Saul told the guards that the priests had also, like everybody else, supported or helped David. Saul said that although the priests knew that David had run away, the priests had not told Saul. But the king's guardsmen refused to carry out the king's order to kill Yahweh's priests. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king's guardsmen, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is the king's duty to obey Yahweh's laws. Yahweh wants the king to look after the priests of Yahweh; or
- Why does the king want us to kill the priests? It is against Yahweh's law! or
- We feel afraid of Yahweh. We would rather obey Yahweh than King Saul. We are not going to kill the priests!

Continue the drama. Then Saul commanded Doeg the Edomite to go and kill the priests. So, Doeg went and attacked the priests. That day, Doeg killed 85 priests.

And Doeg the Edomite also killed everyone else who lived in Nob, the city of priests. Doeg killed both men and women, children, babies, and the livestock, including oxen, donkeys, and sheep. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Doeg the Edomite, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The king wants me to kill the priests. I will do it. I am the king's hired soldier, so I must do what the king tells me to do; or
- The king could kill me if I do not obey the king. I have proof that David and Ahimelech were conspiring against King Saul. I saw Ahimelech help David at Nob; or
- Part of my job is to kill people and livestock in the city of the priests. I will kill them and take all their possessions; or
- If I kill the priests when no one else wants to do it, perhaps King Saul will give me something extra or show me more favour.

Continue the drama. Doeg killed everyone in Nob except Abiathar, one of Ahimelech's sons. Abiathar escaped and ran to David to join David's group of supporters. After Abiathar had found David, Abiathar told David that Saul had killed Yahweh's priests. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Abiathar, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I lost all my family! Doeg killed my father and all my brothers, the priests; or
- The king wants to kill me, too. I was able to escape! or
- I will run away to be with David. David is running away from Saul, too. We will ask Yahweh to save us.

Continue the drama. David told Abiathar that as soon as David saw Doeg the Edomite in Nob, David knew Doeg would tell Saul that David had visited Ahimelech. David confessed to Abiathar that David felt that David himself was ultimately responsible for the killing of Abiathar's family. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so sad. I am responsible for the death of all these innocent priests! I regret going to see Ahimelech! The minute I saw Doeg, the hired soldier from Edom, I knew Doeg would tell Saul about me; or
- I feel ashamed that because of me, Abiathar lost all his family; or
- Now the two of us, Abiathar and I, are fleeing from the king. Abiathar will be safe with me.

Continue the drama. David told Abiathar not to be afraid and to stay with David. Abiathar and David now had the same enemy, Saul, who wanted to kill them both. David said that David would protect Abiathar.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 22:11–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Then King Saul sent a message to summon Ahimelech the **priest**, and all Ahimelech's father's house or household, who were the priests at the city of Nob. The title priest here means the chief priest or the high priest. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

In this case, Ahimelech's **father's house** or **household** refers to all the adult male descendants of Ahimelech's father, even if those descendants did not live in the same house with Ahimelech. Use the same word or phrase for father's house or household as you used in previous passages.

Ahimelech respectfully calls Saul his "**lord**," or master. Use the same word or phrase for lord or master as you have used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for more information about lord.

Saul asked Ahimelech why Ahimelech had conspired against Saul and had given David **bread** and a **sword** and had inquired or talked to God for David. Use the same words or phrases for bread and sword as you used in previous passages. In this case, when a priest inquires of God for someone, the priest talks to God for that person and asks God what God wants that person to do.

1 Samuel 22:11–23

Stop here as a group and discuss how you will say that Ahimelech **inquired of God**, or **talked to God**, for David. If you have already translated this word or phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **God** as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahimelech could not understand why Saul would think that David was not loyal to Saul. Ahimelech told the king that there was no one more loyal among all Saul's **servants** than David and that David was the king's son-in-law. Ahimelech told the king that David was the captain of the king's bodyguard and that everyone in the king's house honoured David.

Here, the word servants refers to the officials in Saul's government, not to slaves. However, these officials do serve Saul. Use the same word for servants or officials as you have used in previous passages, and see the Master Glossary for more information about servants.

A person's **son-in-law** is the husband of that person's daughter. David was Saul's son-in-law because he was the husband of Saul's daughter, Michal. Use the same word or phrase for son-in-law as you used in previous passages.

The king's bodyguards were soldiers whose job was to protect the king. A captain of the king's bodyguard was a high-ranking officer responsible for leading and commanding the group of soldiers who protected the king. This person oversaw the king's safety and security and made sure no one harmed the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bodyguard** or **captain of the king's bodyguard**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

And the king commanded his guardsmen to surround and kill **Yahweh's** priests. Yahweh is God's personal name, and the storyteller uses it three times in this passage when the passage mentions the priests of Yahweh. In other places, the storyteller uses the general word for **God**. Use the same general term for God and the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on God and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then the king commanded Doeg the Edomite to kill the priests. And Doeg went and killed the priests. Doeg killed 85 persons who wore the linen **ephod**. Use the same word or phrase for ephod as you used before. For more information on ephod, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a priest wearing a linen ephod. Pause this audio here.

And Doeg the Edomite killed both men and women, children and babies, as well as **cattle**, **donkeys**, and **sheep**. Use the same words or phrases for cattle, donkeys, and sheep as you used before. For more information on donkey, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 22:11–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (542 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

1 Samuel 23:1–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 23:1–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:1–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, King Saul accused Ahimelech of plotting against Saul with David. Ahimelech assured Saul of Ahimelech's loyalty, but Saul ordered Saul's guards to kill Ahimelech and all of Ahimelech's father's household. When the guards refused to obey Saul, Saul told Doeg the Edomite to kill Ahimelech and Ahimelech's household. Doeg murdered Ahimelech and all the priests of Yahweh, as well as all the other people and livestock in the city of Nob. However, Abiathar, Ahimelech's son, escaped and ran away to David. David said David would protect Abiathar.

One day, someone told David that the Philistines were attacking the city of Keilah and stealing grain from the people's threshing floors. Keilah was a strong city in the territory of the tribe of Judah, near the Philistine border, about eight kilometers south of Adullam. David was likely traveling between the forest of Hereth and Keilah when David heard the news. Threshing floors were outside the city walls, where people separated grain from husks. It was harvest time, and the Philistines attacked because the Philistines could use the grain right away and knew the people would be too busy to defend the city. Losing the crop would cause great hardship for the people of Keilah.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a threshing floor. Pause the audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when other people attacked cities or areas in your land. Why did those people attack? Pause this audio here.

So, David asked Yahweh whether David should go and attack the Philistines. We do not know how David asked Yahweh. If Abiathar the priest was with David at this point, Abiathar would have asked Yahweh for David to use the Urim and Thummim from the high priest's ephod. Otherwise, David could have asked Yahweh through the prophet Gad. David could have also asked Yahweh directly by praying to Yahweh. David wanted to know if Yahweh wanted David to try to defend Keilah against the Philistines. In the ancient Near East, people asked their gods before going out to war. However, it would have been the king's job to fight his enemies. Yahweh told David that David should attack the Philistines in order to save the city of Keilah and its people from the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss the question as a group: How do the military leaders in your country decide whether they should go to war? Pause this audio here.

But David's men responded with fear when they heard about David's plans to attack the Philistines in Keilah. David's men said that they were already afraid of the enemies around them. The men did not want to go into another battle while they were also in the centre of their enemies in the territory of the tribe of Judah. The men were even more afraid of facing the Philistine army in Keilah, so close to the Philistine territory.

Then David asked Yahweh the second time. David probably wanted Yahweh to reassure David because David's men were fearful. Yahweh answered David and told him to go to Keilah. Yahweh said that Yahweh would cause David and David's men to defeat the Philistines. Again, we do not know how David asked Yahweh.

So David obeyed Yahweh's command and trusted Yahweh's promise. David and David's men went to Keilah and attacked the Philistines and led away the Philistines' cattle. The Philistines may have brought their cattle to Keilah to eat what people left on the threshing floor or to transport the grain the Philistines were stealing. David and his men killed many Philistines. In this way, David rescued the people who lived in Keilah from the Philistines.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see David's journey from the forest of Hereth to Keilah. Pause this audio here.

Now we hear background information about Abiathar the priest, Ahimelech's son. Abiathar had already escaped from Saul. We do not know where exactly Abiathar joined David, but most likely it was somewhere before Keilah. When Abiathar came to Keilah, Abiathar brought with him the ephod. This was the high priest's ephod, which was a highly decorated piece of clothing. The high priest wore this ephod in the tent of meeting when he served Yahweh. On top of the ephod, the high priest wore a breastpiece. This breastpiece held the Urim and Thummim, two objects the high priest used to learn Yahweh's will.

Then someone informed Saul that David had gone to Keilah. Instead of being happy that Yahweh freed the people of Keilah from the Philistines, Saul mistakenly believed that God had delivered David into Saul's hands, or into Saul's power. Saul spoke as though it were God's will that Saul capture David. Saul believed that God had made it possible for Saul to catch David because David had put himself in a trap. Saul had not set a trap that David had entered, and David had not deliberately trapped or imprisoned himself. Rather, by entering Keilah, David had put himself in a dangerous position. Keilah was a fortified city. Keilah had a wall around it. David would have no way out of Keilah except through the gates, which people could bar from the inside and watch from the outside.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about cities in your area. In the past, how did people make those cities safe from attack? How do people make those cities safe now? Pause this audio here.

Then Saul called all the people to war. Israel did not have a professional army, so Saul would gather men to come fight as soldiers whenever Saul needed. We do not know how many men responded, but in a previous battle with the Amalekites, 200,000 men and 10,000 from Judah had joined Saul. Since Saul called up everyone, Saul likely planned to use a large army against David's 600 men. Saul wanted to besiege Keilah by surrounding the city to cut off supplies of arms, food, and water, to force the people inside to either fight their way out or surrender.

Someone told David that Saul was plotting evil against David and not against the Philistines. David asked Abiathar the priest to bring the ephod to David. It was the high priest's ephod which Abiathar brought with him from the city of Nob. David wanted to find out Yahweh's will.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your people group find out God's will? Pause this audio here.

Then David prayed to Yahweh. David addressed Yahweh as, "Yahweh, the God of Israel." Yahweh was God's name by which the people of Israel knew God. "The God of Israel" means the God whom the people of Israel worship. David told Yahweh that David had heard for certain that Saul was seeking to come to Keilah to destroy the city because of David.

David asked Yahweh to tell David something that might happen in the future. David asked if the men or the citizens of Keilah would hand David over to Saul in order to try and save their city. The citizens were those men who lived in Keilah and owned property there. The citizens were the city's rich people and were probably the city leaders or authorities. David also wanted Yahweh to tell David if Saul would come and attack Keilah. And Yahweh confirmed that Saul would come to Keilah.

David asked Yahweh again if the men of Keilah would hand David and David's men over to Saul, as David feared might happen. The leaders of Keilah likely knew that Saul had destroyed Nob and could do the same to their city. From the leaders' perspective, David had brought more trouble than help. While the Philistines only stole grain, Saul intended to destroy Keilah. Yahweh told David that the men of Keilah would surrender David to Saul.

David accepted Yahweh's answer and immediately left Keilah with David's 600 men. David had started with 400 men at the cave of Adullam, and more men had joined since then. The men moved from place to place, never staying anywhere permanently, always seeking safety from Saul. When someone told Saul that David had escaped Keilah, Saul chose not to chase David further at that time.

When David left Keilah, David went into the wilderness of the territory of the tribe of Judah. The wilderness was between the mountains of Judah and the Dead Sea. Different parts of this wilderness had different names. The desert or wilderness of Ziph was part of the wilderness of Judah, which was near the city of Ziph. Ziph was about 8 kilometres south-southeast of Hebron, about 19 kilometres southeast of Keilah. David may have lived only in the wilderness strongholds in the hill country of the wilderness of Ziph. Wilderness strongholds were places where people could hide and find refuge or protection in the wilderness. These were probably natural structures like caves, not man-made forts. It is possible that David lived in the wilderness and then went to the mountains in the wilderness of Ziph. And Saul searched for David every day, but God did not permit Saul to catch David. God was keeping David safe from Saul.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see David's journey from the forest of Keilah to the wilderness of Ziph. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a stronghold in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

In the first scene: David finds out that the Philistines have attacked the city of Keilah and are stealing the grain from the threshing floors. David asks Yahweh if David should go and attack the Philistines at Keilah. Yahweh says that David should go and attack the Philistines to save the people of Keilah.

In the second scene: David's men are afraid when they hear about David's plans to attack the Philistines in Keilah. David's men say that they are already afraid of the enemies around them in Judah. So David asks Yahweh again if the men are to go to Keilah, and Yahweh says the men are to go right away because Yahweh will cause David and David's men to defeat the Philistines.

In the third scene: David trusts Yahweh's promise, and David and David's men go to Keilah. The men attack the Philistines and take the cattle that the Philistines brought to Keilah. David and David's men kill the Philistines and save the inhabitants of Keilah.

In the fourth scene: The storyteller gives background information about Abiathar the priest, Ahimelech's son. We find out that when Abiathar came to David at Keilah, Abiathar brought with him the high priest's ephod.

In the fifth scene: Someone tells Saul that David has gone to Keilah. Saul mistakenly believes that God has delivered David into Saul's hands. Saul calls up all the people for war, so Saul and Saul's army can go to Keilah and besiege or surround David and David's men.

In the sixth scene: David finds out that Saul is planning to capture David. David asks Abiathar to bring David the ephod so he can find out Yahweh's will. Yahweh confirms that Saul will come to Keilah. Yahweh tells David that the men from Keilah will surrender David to Saul.

In the seventh scene: David and David's men leave Keilah and go from place to place, wherever the men will be safe from Saul. When Saul hears that David has escaped from Keilah, Saul decides not to go after David at that time. David and David's men now live in the strongholds in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah and reach the hill country in the wilderness of Ziph. Saul searches for David every day, but God does not permit Saul to catch David.

The characters in this passage are:

- People who told David about the Philistine attack on Keilah, probably David's men
- David
- The Philistines
- Yahweh
- People of Keilah
- David's men, or soldiers
- Abiathar the priest
- The person who told David that Saul was coming to Keilah
- King Saul
- And Saul's army

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

One day, someone said to David, "Look! The Philistines are fighting against Keilah and are robbing the threshing floors." Here, the messenger was calling David's attention to a serious problem. The messenger was not telling David to physically see the Philistines. The messenger was alerting David that the Philistines were stealing the grain from the threshing floors. Keilah was a city in the area of the tribe of Judah and was located near the Philistine border, eight kilometres south of the city of Adullam. David was probably traveling between the forest of Hereth and Keilah when David heard the news.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone brought serious news that needed immediate action. What words or phrases did that person use to call people's attention to the problem? Pause this audio here.

So David asked Yahweh, "Shall I go and attack these Philistines?" David referred to the Philistines in a way that showed how much David did not respect the Philistines. Yahweh told David that David should attack the Philistines in order to save the city of Keilah and its people from the Philistines.

The story is clear that the way David's men react is not how Yahweh and David expected the men to react. When the men heard the news, David's men said, "Look, even here in the heart, or middle, of Judah, we are afraid." David's men feared enemies all around them and the thought of battle. The men said, "We will be terrified if we try to fight the Philistines' armies at Keilah!" David's men feared the Philistines. That is why the men refer to the Philistine raiding party as "armies," although the Philistines did not really send an army to Keilah. The Philistines would have sent a raiding party of a smaller group of men.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say in your language to show that somebody's response was not how we would expect that person to respond? Pause this audio here.

Then David asked Yahweh again. It is important to note that this was the second time David asked Yahweh. And Yahweh said to David, "Arise, go down to Keilah." "Arise" did not mean David was to stand up, but that David was to go quickly. The phrase "go down" here probably means that where David and David's men were staying

was perhaps on a hill, and the men would have to travel downhill. Yahweh said that Yahweh would "give the Philistines over into David's hand." This means that Yahweh was going to give David and David's men power over the Philistines. As before, the story does not say what David did to ask Yahweh and by what means Yahweh spoke to David.

Stop here and discuss as a group the best way to translate Yahweh's instructions to David. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller makes it clear that David immediately obeyed what Yahweh had commanded. So, David and David's men went to Keilah and attacked the Philistines. David and his men led away the Philistines' cattle. David and David's men killed many Philistines. In this way, David rescued the people who lived in Keilah from the Philistines. Although the storyteller seems to say that David did these actions by himself, we know that David's men were fighting with David. By using this type of language, the storyteller makes David important and presents David as a brave and successful leader.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see David's journey from the forest of Hereth to Keilah. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and discuss: How will you show that the way a character behaved in a story was because that person obeyed what somebody else told them to do? Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and discuss: How will you talk about a character in a story to show that the person is brave and courageous? How will you show that this person is the most important character among other characters? Pause this audio here.

Now we hear background information about Abiathar, Ahimelech's son. Abiathar the priest had already escaped from Saul. We do not know where exactly Abiathar joined David. It is very likely that Abiathar joined David before the battle in Keilah, and David and Abiathar traveled together to Keilah. Here, the story repeats information about Abiathar joining David and tells us new information about Abiathar bringing the ephod with Abiathar.

Then someone informed Saul that David had gone to Keilah. Saul believed that God had delivered David into Saul's hands, or into Saul's power. Saul believed that God had made it possible for Saul to catch David. Saul was probably speaking to Saul's officials and gave a reason why Saul thought that God wanted Saul to catch David. Saul said, "Because David has shut himself in by entering a city that has gates and bars."

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate the phrase "to deliver someone into someone's hands" so it means giving someone into another person's power? Talk about whether there is a similar phrase in your language, or whether you will need to use another phrase and what that phrase will be. Pause this audio here.

Because Saul knew that David was in a city with gates and bars, Saul decided that Saul should go capture David. Then Saul called up all the people for war. Saul wanted his army to go to Keilah to besiege or surround David and David's men.

Someone told David that Saul was plotting evil against David instead of against the Philistines. David told Abiathar the priest to bring the high priest's ephod to David. David wanted to use the Urim and the Thummim from the ephod to ask Yahweh what to do.

David prayed to Yahweh and called Yahweh by his personal name, which the people of Israel knew. David called Yahweh "Yahweh, God of Israel." David humbly approached God by using the phrase "your servant" when referring to himself. David said, "Your servant has surely heard that Saul seeks to come to Keilah, to destroy the city because of me." David used language that stressed that David had definitely heard beyond any doubt that Saul was coming to Keilah to destroy the city because of David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about a situation in your life when someone trustworthy told you about something scary that was going to happen. Pause this audio here.

David asked Yahweh to tell David something that might happen in the future. David asked Yahweh, "Will the citizens of Keilah surrender me into Saul's hand?" The phrase "surrender into Saul's hand" means to let Saul capture David. David also asked Yahweh, "Will Saul come down, as your servant has heard?" The phrase "come down" means simply to come to a place, not to physically go down. David again called Yahweh "Yahweh, God of Israel." David was humbly asking Yahweh when David referred to himself as "your servant." Yahweh answered David's second question and confirmed that Saul would come to Keilah.

Then David asked Yahweh again if the men of Keilah would hand David and David's men over to Saul. Yahweh answered David and said that the men from Keilah would surrender David to Saul.

Now the storyteller introduces what David did as a result of what Yahweh had told David in the previous passage. The storyteller uses language that makes it clear there is a link between what happened before and what David is doing now. So David and his men left Keilah at once. There were about 600 men with David at that time. The men went wherever they might be safe to avoid Saul capturing the men. When somebody told Saul that David had escaped from Keilah, Saul decided not to go after David at Keilah.

Now we hear about the area that David went to when David left Keilah and was hiding from Saul. When David left Keilah, David went into the wilderness of the territory of the tribe of Judah. The wilderness was between the mountains of Judah and the Dead Sea. Different parts of this wilderness had different names. The desert or wilderness of Ziph was part of the wilderness of Judah, which was near the city of Ziph. Ziph was about 8 kilometres south-southeast of Hebron, about 19 kilometres southeast of Keilah. David may have only lived in the wilderness strongholds in the hill country of the wilderness of Ziph. Wilderness strongholds were places where people could hide and find refuge or protection. These were probably natural structures like caves, not man-made forts. It is possible that David lived in the wilderness and then went to the mountains in the wilderness of Ziph. And Saul searched for David every day, but God did not permit Saul to catch David. God was keeping David safe from Saul.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see David's journey from the forest of Keilah to the wilderness of Ziph. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The word stronghold can mean a wilderness stronghold, like a cave or protected natural area, or a stronghold like a strong city with high walls. In this case, these were natural strongholds, unlike the strongholds in previous stories that people had built. How will you translate this wilderness stronghold? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- People who told David about the Philistine attack on Keilah, probably David's men
- David
- The Philistines
- Yahweh
- People of Keilah
- David's men, or soldiers
- Abiathar the priest
- The person who told David that Saul was coming to Keilah
- King Saul
- And Saul's army

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

One day, someone told David that the Philistines were fighting the people of Keilah and were stealing the grain from the people’s threshing floor. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that the Philistines are attacking Keilah; or
- I am uncertain what to do. If Saul did not think I betrayed him, King Saul and I would be defending Keilah. I do not know if I should still feel responsible for fighting the Philistines; or
- I love my people. I want to help my people. I will ask Yahweh what to do!

Continue the drama. So, David asked Yahweh whether David should go and attack the Philistines. Yahweh told David to go and attack the Philistines in order to save the city of Keilah and its people from the Philistines.

But David’s men responded with fear when they heard about David’s plans to attack the Philistines in Keilah and that Yahweh had said the men should do it. David’s men said that they were already afraid while staying in the centre of the territory of the tribe of Judah. The men would be much more afraid when they had to face the Philistine army in Keilah, a city very close to Philistine territory. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David’s men, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We feel really scared of the Philistines here in the middle of the land of the tribe of Judah. The Philistines have an army much bigger than we are; or
- We cannot go to Keilah. Keilah is close to the Philistines’ land and is full of the Philistine army! The Philistines will kill us! or
- We are not sure we can trust David. Did Yahweh really tell David to go to Keilah?

Continue the drama. Then David asked Yahweh the second time. Yahweh answered David and told David to go to Keilah. Yahweh said that Yahweh would cause David and David’s men to defeat the Philistines.

David and David’s men went to Keilah and attacked the Philistines and led away the Philistines’ cattle. David and his men killed many Philistines. In this way, David rescued the people who lived in Keilah from the Philistines. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel so happy! Yahweh delivered the Philistines into our hands, like Yahweh said he would do; or
- I feel thankful that my men are learning to trust Yahweh. Next time, my men will believe Yahweh the first time; or
- I am relieved that we could free the people of Keilah from the thieving Philistines!

Continue the drama. Abiathar the priest, the son of Ahimelech, had come to David in the wilderness. When Abiathar came to David at Keilah, Abiathar brought with him the ephod.

Someone told Saul that David had gone to Keilah. Saul mistakenly believed that God had delivered David into his hands. Saul thought that by entering Keilah, David had put himself in a dangerous position. Keilah was a fortified city, and David would have no way out of Keilah except through the gates, which people could bar from the inside and watch from the outside. Saul called up all the people for war, so Saul and Saul’s army could go to Keilah and besiege or surround David and David’s men. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- It feels so good to know that God wants to give David into my hand! David is very foolish to shut himself in the city of Keilah like that! or
- I will call my big army, and we shall surround David and David’s men. David and David’s men have no chance of escaping! or
- I do not respect the son of Jesse at all. Does Jesse’s son really think he can run away from me, King Saul?

1 Samuel 23:1–14

Continue the drama. Someone told David that Saul was plotting evil against David. David told Abiathar the priest to bring the ephod to David. Then David prayed to Yahweh. David told Yahweh that David had heard for certain that Saul was seeking to come to Keilah in order to destroy the city because of David. David asked Yahweh if the men of Keilah would hand David over to Saul in order to try and save their city. David also wanted Yahweh to tell David if Saul would come and attack Keilah. And Yahweh confirmed that Saul would come to Keilah. Then David asked Yahweh again if the men of Keilah would hand David and his men over to Saul. Yahweh answered David and said that the men from Keilah would surrender David to Saul. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My spies told me that Saul is planning to catch me in Keilah. I will not be scared. I will ask Yahweh if Saul will really come down and if the men of Keilah will hand me over to Saul; or
- Yahweh confirmed that Saul is coming down to catch me and that the men of Keilah will hand me over to Saul. I am disappointed that the men of Keilah are not grateful for me and my men saving them from the Philistines; or
- I am grateful that Yahweh confirmed what will happen. Now we need to run away at once!

Continue the drama. David and his men left Keilah at once. There were about 600 men with David at that time. David and David's men went wherever they might be safe from Saul capturing them. When somebody told Saul that David had escaped from Keilah, Saul decided not to go to Keilah. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry and disappointed that the son of Jesse has managed to get away from me; or
- There is no point in my army going to Keilah anymore, but we will catch David somewhere else; or
- I am sure God still wants me to chase David and will hand David over to us.

Continue the drama. David and David's men lived in the strongholds in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah and reached the hill country in the wilderness of Ziph. And Saul searched for David every day, but God did not permit Saul to catch David. God was keeping David safe from Saul.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Someone told David that the Philistines were attacking the town of Keilah and were robbing the grain from the threshing floors. Threshing floors were hard, level surfaces in the open air, located outside of towns, where the blowing winds could separate the seeds from the husks. People either walked on the grain or dragged a heavy board over it, and then tossed both grain and husks into the air. The wind blew away the lighter husks, but the heavier grain fell to the ground.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a threshing floor. Pause the audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **threshing floors**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Therefore, David asked **Yahweh** whether David should go and attack the Philistines in Keilah. Yahweh is God's personal name, and the storyteller uses this name throughout most of this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

David and his men went to Keilah and attacked the Philistines. David led away the cattle and killed many Philistines. This term "cattle" is a general term that could include any animals that people use, such as cows, sheep, or goats.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for animals that people use. This is usually a general term for cows, sheep, goats, horses, and camels. However, here, these may have been animals that the Philistines could use to carry away the grain. If you have used a general term like this before, use the same word or phrase for **cattle** as you used before. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 23:1–14

When Abiathar, the son of Ahimelech, had fled to David at Keilah, Abiathar brought with him the **ephod**. This ephod refers to the high priest's ephod, which was a highly decorated piece of clothing. Use the same word or phrase for ephod as you used before. For more information on ephod, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul believed that **God** had delivered David **into his hands**. Saul thought that by entering Keilah, David had put himself in a dangerous position. Talk about delivering people into the hands of others in the same way here as you have done in previous passages. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used before. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Someone told David that Saul was plotting evil against David and not against the Philistines. David asked Abiathar the **priest** to bring the ephod to David. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used before. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then David said, "O Yahweh, the God of Israel, your **servant** has surely heard that Saul seeks to come to Keilah, to destroy the city because of me." Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used before. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

And David remained in the strongholds in the wilderness, in the hill country of the wilderness of Ziph. Wilderness strongholds were places where people could hide and find refuge or protection in the wilderness. The strongholds in this story were probably natural structures like caves, not man-made forts like the storyteller mentioned in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wilderness stronghold**. Look up stronghold in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a stronghold in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **wilderness** as you used before. For more information on wilderness, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 23:1–14

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (563 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (824 KB)

1 Samuel 23:15–29

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 23:15–29 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:15–29 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:15–29 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, David found out that the Philistines attacked the people in the strong city of Keilah. Yahweh told David that Yahweh wanted David to go and fight the Philistines to free the people of Keilah. Yahweh caused David to defeat the Philistines. David and David's men killed the Philistines, but David soon found out that Saul was planning to catch David in Keilah. Yahweh confirmed that Saul was coming to Keilah and that the men of Keilah would surrender David to Saul. David and David's men ran away from Keilah at once and wandered from place to place until the men reached the wilderness of Ziph. Saul searched for David every day, but Yahweh prevented Saul from finding David.

While David was at Horesh in the wilderness of Ziph, David realised that Saul had come out to kill David. The word Horesh means "in the Wood," so we are not certain whether Horesh was a town, a village, or a forested area. Somebody told David that Saul was leading a military raid to kill David.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Find Horesh in the desert of Ziph. Pause this audio here.

Then Jonathan, Saul's son, came to see David at Horesh. Jonathan probably traveled from Gibeah, the city where Jonathan's father, King Saul, ruled from and where Jonathan lived. Gibeah was about 50 kilometres away from Horesh. Jonathan came to "strengthen David's hand in God," which meant that Jonathan came to encourage David to trust God and believe that God would protect David. It was most likely very dangerous for Jonathan to visit David at this time, when Jonathan's father was searching for David. At the same time, it must have been very encouraging for David to see Jonathan at this dangerous time.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see Jonathan's journey from Gibeah to Horesh in the desert of Ziph. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when one friend travelled far in order to encourage another friend. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan reassured David and told David not to be afraid because Saul, Jonathan's father, would not be able to find David to do any harm. Jonathan told David that David would be the future king of Israel and that Jonathan would be the second man in the kingdom, or David's second in command. Jonathan was convinced that Yahweh, whom both Jonathan and David trusted, would protect David from Saul's hand or power. Jonathan spoke about David's future even though Jonathan did not know that the prophet Samuel had anointed or selected David to be king, as Yahweh had instructed Samuel. Even though Jonathan knew nothing about David's anointing, Jonathan could tell from David's actions and Jonathan's father's behaviour that David would become king after Saul's death. Jonathan told David that Saul, Jonathan's father, also knew that David would be king over Israel. Saul must have realized that David would become king because the prophet Samuel had predicted that Yahweh would reject Saul, and David was successful in everything David did. Jonathan realized that Saul, Jonathan's own father, was the enemy of Jonathan's best friend, David.

Then Jonathan and David made a covenant, or an agreement. In the presence of Yahweh, Jonathan and David renewed the strong promise of friendship they had made earlier in Yahweh's name. Jonathan and David promised each other that they would always act as faithful friends to one another. After that, Jonathan returned home, but David stayed in Horesh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What types of relationship covenants or agreements do people in your culture make? How do people renew and remember these covenants? Pause this audio here.

The Ziphites, or the people who lived in the town of Ziph, went up to Saul in the city of Gibeah, which was in the territory of the tribe of Benjamin. The Ziphites brought Saul the news that David was hiding in their land in the strongholds of Horesh on the hill named Hakilah, south of Jeshimon. Jeshimon was the name of a desert region in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Jeshimon meant wasteland or desert.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see the Ziphites' journey from Ziph to Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

The Ziphites invited King Saul to come down to their land, the territory of the tribe of Judah, at once, or at any time Saul wanted. The Ziphites said they would make it possible for the king to capture David.

Saul was very pleased that the Ziphites wanted to give David to Saul. Saul said, "May Yahweh bless you because you had compassion on me." Saul wanted Yahweh to be kind to the Ziphites because the Ziphites helped Saul. By asking Yahweh to bless the Ziphites for helping him, Saul showed that Saul did not understand Yahweh's will and did not respect Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a ruler who mistakenly thought they had authority from God to do something. What happened when the ruler used his authority wrongly? Pause this audio here.

Saul told the Ziphites to go back to their hometown, or to their own territory, and find out exactly where David was. Saul wanted the Ziphites to do that because Saul had heard from someone that David was very cunning or clever. Saul thought that David was smart and careful and planned things out wisely, but Saul also thought that David used tricks and deception when necessary to escape Saul.

Saul urged the Ziphites to look around and carefully discover the different places where David was likely to hide. Then Saul wanted the Ziphites to return to Saul and tell Saul when they were certain exactly where David was. Then Saul would go with the Ziphites to their land, the territory of the tribe of Judah. If David were in the land of the tribe of Judah, Saul would search for or hunt for David among thousands of people from all the clans or families of the tribe of Judah until Saul found David.

So, the men from Ziph set out for home ahead of Saul. In the meantime, David had gone further with his men and was in the wilderness, or desert, near the town of Maon. This town was in the dry valley of the Arabah. Maon was eight kilometres south of Ziph, which was located in the Jeshimon wilderness.

Saul and Saul's soldiers went to Ziph and started to search for David. When someone told David that Saul was looking for him, David went to "the rock" and lived in the wilderness of Maon. The meaning of "the rock" is not clear here. It perhaps refers to a large rough and uneven cliff or rockface, which are common in mountain

regions, or it could refer to a valley at the bottom of the mountain that runs through the Maon wilderness. When Saul heard where David had gone, Saul chased David and David's men in the wilderness of Maon.

Stop here as a group and look at a photo of a rock face from a mountain region in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Pause this audio here.

Saul reached the rock or mountain where David was. Saul and Saul's men went on one side of the mountain, and David and David's men were on the other side. David and David's men were in great hurry to get away from Saul. As Saul and Saul's army were getting close to David and David's men, suddenly a messenger, another Israelite, came to Saul with a message. The messenger told Saul to hurry back home, because the Philistines had attacked the land of Israel.

Then Saul stopped chasing David and returned to Gibeah to fight the Philistines. Therefore, people began to call the place where Saul stopped pursuing David the rock of escape or the rock of separation.

Then David left the wilderness of Maon and went to stay in the strongholds in the wilderness surrounding En Gedi. En Gedi was an oasis, a fertile area with water that allowed plants to grow. En Gedi was located between 19 and 32 kilometres northeast of the wilderness of Maon, on the western shore of the Dead Sea. Caves in that area acted as strongholds or safe places. En Gedi was an ideal hiding place for David and David's men.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see David's journey from the wilderness of Maon to En Gedi. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a photo of the En Gedi oasis.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:15–29 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

In the first scene: While David and David's men are at Horesh in the wilderness of Ziph, someone tells David that Saul is leading a military raid to kill David.

In the second scene: Jonathan, Saul's son, comes to see David at Horesh to encourage David to trust God. Jonathan reassures David and tells David that Saul will not be able to find David to do any harm. Jonathan tells David that David will be the future king of Israel and that Jonathan will be David's second in command. Jonathan tells David that Saul also knows that David will be king over Israel. Jonathan and David renew their covenant of friendship before Yahweh. Jonathan goes home, and David remains in Horesh.

In the third scene: The people from the town of Ziph go up to Saul at Gibeah and tell Saul that David is hiding in the strongholds of Horesh, on the hill of Hakilah, south of the wilderness of Jeshimon. The Ziphites invite King Saul to come down to their territory. The Ziphites say they will make it possible for the king to capture David. Saul asks Yahweh to bless the Ziphites because the Ziphites are kind to Saul.

In the fourth scene: Saul tells the Ziphites to go back to their hometown and find out exactly where David is. Saul urges the Ziphites to go and look around and learn about the different places where David is likely to hide. The Ziphites are to return to Saul and tell Saul David's hiding place when they are certain where David is. Then Saul will go with the Ziphites to their land, the territory of the tribe of Judah. Saul says that if David is in the land of the tribe of Judah, Saul will search for or hunt for David among all the clans of Judah until Saul finds David.

In the fifth scene: So, the men of Ziph set out for their town. David and David's men are in the wilderness of Maon, in the valley of Arabah, to the south of the wilderness of Jeshimon. Saul and Saul's soldiers go to Ziph and start to search for David. When someone tells David that Saul is looking for David, David and his men go to a rocky mountain and live in the wilderness of Maon. When Saul hears where David had gone, Saul chases David with his men in the wilderness of Maon.

In the sixth scene: Saul reaches the rocky mountain where David is. Saul and Saul's men go on one side of the mountain, and David and David's men are on the other side. David and his men are in great hurry to get away from Saul. As Saul and Saul's army are getting close to David and his men, suddenly a messenger comes to Saul with a message to hurry back home, because the Philistines have attacked the land of Israel.

In the seventh scene: Saul stops pursuing David and returns to Gibeah to fight the Philistines. People begin to call the place where Saul stopped pursuing David the rock of escape or the rock of separation. Then David leaves the wilderness of Maon and goes to stay in the strongholds of the wilderness surrounding the oasis of En Gedi.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Saul
- Jonathan
- Yahweh
- The Ziphites, or people from the town of Ziph
- Saul's men
- David's men
- Someone who told David that Saul was searching for David
- And Saul's messenger

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

While David was at Horesh in the wilderness of Ziph, somebody told David that Saul was leading a military raid to kill David.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Find Horesh in the desert of Ziph. Pause this audio here.

Now we learn what happened while David was in Horesh. Jonathan, Saul's son, came to see David at Horesh. Jonathan probably traveled from Gibeah, where Jonathan was staying at his father's, Saul's, court. Gibeah was about 50 kilometres away from Horesh. It probably would have taken Jonathan about one or two days to walk from Gibeah to Horesh. Jonathan came to encourage David to trust God and believe that God would protect David.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see Jonathan's journey from Gibeah to Horesh in the desert of Ziph. Pause this audio here.

Jonathan reassured David and told David not to be afraid because Saul, Jonathan's father, would not be able to find David to do any harm. Jonathan told David that David would be the future king of Israel, and that Jonathan would be the second man in the kingdom, or David's second in command. Jonathan told David that Saul, Jonathan's father, also knew that David would be king over Israel. Jonathan says, "Saul, my father," both at the beginning and the end of Jonathan's statement. This repetition shows Jonathan is genuinely prepared to accept his relationship with Jonathan's father, Saul.

Then Jonathan and David made a covenant or agreement. Jonathan and David renewed in the presence of Yahweh the strong promise of friendship they had made earlier in Yahweh's name. Jonathan and David promised each other that they would always act as faithful friends to one another. After that, Jonathan returned home, but David stayed in Horesh.

Then the Ziphites, or the people who lived in the town of Ziph, went up to Saul at Gibeah. The phrase "went up" here means that Gibeah was located on higher ground than Ziph. The Ziphites asked Saul, "Is not David hiding among us in the strongholds at Horesh, on the hill of Hakilah, which is south of Jeshimon?" The Ziphites were not asking for information about David. Instead, the Ziphites used the question to make a statement to tell Saul where David was.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see the Ziphites' journey from Ziph to Gibeah. Pause this audio here.

The Ziphites invited King Saul to come down to their territory at once, or at any time Saul wanted. The Ziphites said to Saul, "Now come down, O king, according to all your heart's desire to come down." The Ziphites said, "Come down," because the king would be coming down from his hill country to the Ziphites' area, which was on lower ground. "O king" was the polite way to address the king directly. The Ziphites continued and said they would make it possible for the king to capture David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you address a king or a very high-ranking official in your language? Pause this audio here.

Saul responded to the Ziphites and said, “May Yahweh bless you, because you have had compassion on me.” Saul makes it clear that the kindness that the people of Ziph showed Saul is what caused Saul to ask Yahweh to bless the Ziphites.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you talk when you express reasons for actions? What do you say to make it clear that something made you act in a certain way? Pause this audio here.

Saul told the Ziphites to go back to their hometown, or their own territory, and find out exactly where David was. Saul wanted the Ziphites to do that because Saul had heard from someone that David was very cunning or clever. The word cunning means that David was smart and careful, and planned things out wisely. But David also lied when necessary to get his way and escape Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What word or phrase will you use to say that David was cunning? How will you show that David was both careful and wise, but also used tricks and deception? Pause this audio here.

Saul asked the Ziphites to “know about all the hiding places where David hides.” In other words, Saul wanted to persuade the Ziphites to look all around and learn about all the different places where David was likely to hide. Saul told the Ziphites to return to Saul and tell Saul where David’s hiding place was when the Ziphites were certain where David was. Then Saul would go with the Ziphites to their land, in the territory of the tribe of Judah. If David were in the land of the tribe of Judah, Saul would search for or hunt for David among all the clans of Judah until Saul found David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say when you try hard to persuade someone to do something? Pause this audio here.

So, the men of Ziph “arose and went” to their town ahead of Saul. The word “arose” does not mean that the men stood up, but it shows that the men went quickly.

Now the storyteller introduces what is happening to the other characters in the story while Saul is persuading the Ziphites to search for David. The storyteller uses language that makes it clear he is talking about a new thing. Now David and David’s men were in the wilderness of Maon, in the valley of Arabah, to the south of the wilderness of Jeshimon, where the men were trying to escape Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say to make it clear that you are introducing new information to the story? Pause this audio here.

Saul and Saul’s soldiers went to Ziph and started to search for David. When someone told David that Saul was looking for David, David went to a rocky mountain and continued to live in the wilderness of Maon. When Saul heard where David was, Saul chased David with his men in the wilderness of Maon.

Stop here as a group and look at a photo of a rock face from the mountain region in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Pause this audio here.

Saul reached the rocky mountain where David was. Saul and Saul’s men went on one side of the mountain, and David and David’s men were on the other side. Now we learn how David and David’s men were in a great hurry to get away from Saul. As Saul and Saul’s army were getting close to David and David’s men, suddenly a messenger, another Israelite, came to Saul with a message. The messenger told Saul to hurry back home, because the Philistines had attacked the land of Israel. Note that all the action in this part of this story is taking place really fast, and there is a lot of stress.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you describe the events of this part of the story to show the fast speed of things taking place and the stress? What word or phrase will you use to show that Saul needed to both go back to his land and hurry? Pause this audio here.

Then Saul stopped chasing David and returned to Gibeah to fight the Philistines. Therefore, people began to call the place where Saul stopped chasing David the rock of escape or the rock of separation.

When David found out that Saul had stopped chasing David, David left the wilderness of Maon and went to stay in the strongholds of the wilderness surrounding the oasis of En Gedi. En Gedi was located between 19 and 32

1 Samuel 23:15–29

kilometres northeast of the wilderness of Maon, on the western shore of the Dead Sea. It would take David and his men between 8 and 10 hours to walk to En Gedi.

Stop here as a group and look at the map to see David's journey from the wilderness of Maon to En Gedi.

Embodying the Text
Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:15–29 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Saul
- Jonathan
- Yahweh
- The Ziphites, or people from the town of Ziph
- Saul's men
- David's men
- Someone who told David that Saul was searching for David
- And Saul's messenger

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

While David and David's men were at Horesh in the wilderness of Ziph, someone told David that Saul was leading a military raid to kill David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am scared. Saul truly wants to kill me! or
- Saul is even searching for me in the wilderness! or
- Will Yahweh save me this time?

Continue the drama. Jonathan, Saul's son, came to see David at Horesh to encourage David to trust God. Jonathan reassured David and told David that Saul would not be able to find David to do any harm. Jonathan told David that David would be the future king of Israel and that Jonathan would be David's second in command. Jonathan said that Saul also knew that David would be king over Israel. Jonathan and David renewed their covenant of friendship before Yahweh. Jonathan went home, and David remained in Horesh. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jonathan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My friend David is in need. I feel worried for David because my father, Saul, is trying to kill David; or
- I feel scared, but I need to go to the wilderness and encourage David to trust God. David needs to know that God will make David king of Israel and that my father knows it; or
- I feel so happy that we can renew our covenant of friendship before Yahweh. David and I will be friends forever!

1 Samuel 23:15–29

Continue the drama. The people from the town of Ziph went up to Saul at Gibeah and told Saul that David was hiding in the strongholds of Horesh, on the hill of Hakilah, south of the wilderness of Jeshimon. The Ziphites invited King Saul to come down to their territory and said they would make it possible for the king to capture David. Saul asks Yahweh to bless the Ziphites because the Ziphites had shown Saul mercy. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Ziphites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are pleased we can tell King Saul where David and David's men are; or
- Perhaps Saul will give us special privileges for helping Saul find his enemy; or
- It is surprising that Saul felt we were merciful towards Saul. Saul did not sound like a king. We are doing our duty.

Continue the drama. Saul told the Ziphites to go back to their hometown and find out exactly where David was, because people had told Saul that David was very cunning. Saul urged the Ziphites to go and look around and learn about the different places where David was likely to hide. The Ziphites were to return to Saul and tell Saul David's hiding place when they were certain where David was. Then Saul would go with the Ziphites to their land, the territory of the tribe of Judah. Saul said that if David were in the land of the tribe of Judah, Saul would search for David among all the clans of Judah until Saul found David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel hopeful of killing David this time; or
- I need to make sure that the Ziphites know exactly where David is, because David is very clever and can outsmart me. If I know for sure that David is in the land of the tribe of Judah, I will search through all their clans! or
- At last, I have someone who is taking pity on me instead of supporting David.

Continue the drama. So, the men of Ziph set out for their town. David and David's men were in the wilderness of Maon, in the valley of Arabah, to the south of the wilderness of Jeshimon. Saul and his soldiers went to Ziph and started to search for David. When someone told David that Saul was looking for David, David and his men went to a rocky mountain and lived in the wilderness of Maon. When Saul heard where David had gone, Saul chased David with his men in the wilderness of Maon.

Saul reached the rocky mountain where David was. Saul and Saul's men went on one side of the mountain, and David and David's men were on the other side. David and his men were in a great hurry to get away from Saul. As Saul and Saul's army were getting close to David and David's men, suddenly a messenger came to Saul with a message to hurry back home because the Philistines had attacked the land of Israel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so disappointed! We nearly caught up with David and David's men. What a shame we must abandon the chase; or
- But there is no other way. I have to defend our land from the Philistines; or
- I have to wait for another chance to catch David.

Continue the drama. Saul stopped pursuing David and returned to Gibeah to fight the Philistines. People began to call the place where Saul stopped pursuing David the rock of escape or the rock of separation. Then David left the wilderness of Maon and went to stay in the strongholds in the wilderness surrounding the oasis of En Gedi. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I praise Yahweh for saving me again! or
- Hopefully, we can have a rest now that Saul will be fighting the Philistines; or
- I am grateful that we can hide near the oasis of En Gedi, where there is fresh water and plenty of food.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 23:15–29 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

1 Samuel 23:15–29

David was in the **wilderness** of Ziph at Horesh. Use the same word or phrase for wilderness as you used in previous passages. For more information on wilderness, refer to the Master Glossary.

And Jonathan, Saul's son, rose and went to David at Horesh, and strengthened David's hand in **God**. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jonathan told David that David would be **king** over Israel, and Jonathan would be David's second in command. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jonathan and David made a **covenant** of friendship before Yahweh**.** Use the same word or phrase for covenant as you used in previous passages. For more information on covenant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh is God's personal name, and the storyteller uses this name throughout most of this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul says that Saul will find David among all the **clans** of Judah. Clans are groups of families within a larger tribe. Use the same word or phrase for clan, or family group, as you have used in previous passages.

The Ziphites told Saul that David was hiding in their territory in the **strongholds** at Horesh, on the Hill of Hakilah, south of Jeshimon. Here, "strongholds" means wilderness strongholds, which were caves. Use the same word or phrase for wilderness strongholds as you used in previous passages. For more information on stronghold, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 23:15–29

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (575 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.7 MB)

- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (821 KB)

1 Samuel 24:1–7

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 24:1–7 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:1–7 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, while David was at Horesh in the wilderness of Ziph, David found out that Saul was pursuing David to kill him. Jonathan, Saul's son, came to encourage David to trust God. Jonathan and David renewed their covenant of friendship in Yahweh's presence. The Ziphites told Saul that David was hiding in their territory and said they would lead Saul to David. Saul and Saul's men went to Ziph and chased David and David's men in the wilderness of Maon. When Saul found out that the Philistines were attacking Israel, Saul stopped searching for David and went home to Gibeah. David and David's men went to the oasis of En Gedi and stayed there.

Saul and Saul's army were fighting the Philistines and chasing the Philistines away from the land of Israel. When Saul and his army returned home, someone told Saul that David was in the wilderness surrounding the oasis of En Gedi.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Locate the wilderness of En Gedi. Pause this audio here.

On hearing the news about David's location, Saul selected 3,000 of the best soldiers in Israel. Then Saul and his army went to look for David and David's men in a place called the rocks of the wild goats at En Gedi. Gibeah, where Saul lived, was about 65 to 80 kilometres from En Gedi. It would take Saul and Saul's army between 1.5 and 2 days to walk from Gibeah to En Gedi. The name "rocks of the wild goats" probably is not a name for particular rocks, but a general description of a place. People probably called this place "rocks of wild goats" because there were many wild goats in the area.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Locate the journey Saul and Saul's men traveled from Gibeah to En Gedi. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about where the names for different places in your village, town, or region come from. Talk about the reasons why people gave places certain names. Pause this audio here.

When Saul's army arrived at En Gedi, Saul came to some sheepfolds, or sheep pens, which were along the route where people walked. People built sheepfolds to fence in their sheep. People built the fences out of stones. Some sheepfolds were permanent, with stone walls and a roof. Others were temporary buildings that people made from loose stones with thorn bushes on top. There was a cave by the sheepfolds, and David and David's men were sitting in the innermost part of the cave, which was the area farthest away from the entrance. And Saul went into the cave to relieve himself, which means to empty his bowels.

1 Samuel 24:1–7

Stop here and look at a picture of a sheepfold. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a large cave, like the one where David and his men were hiding. Pause this audio here.

When David's men saw Saul, the men told David that this was the day Yahweh had spoken about, the day Yahweh said he would deliver David's enemy into David's hands and allow David to do to the enemy whatever seemed right. By saying this, the men implied that Yahweh brought Saul there so David could kill Saul. However, David's men mistakenly believed that Yahweh had spoken to David about this day. We do not have a record of it anywhere, so we cannot be sure that Yahweh ever told David he would deliver Saul to David. The men saw Saul coming into the cave as a sign from Yahweh that now was the time for David to kill Saul.

Then David quietly moved close enough to touch Saul's robe, which was a long, sleeveless outer garment. Then David secretly cut off the corner of Saul's robe. A corner refers to an edge or border of the robe. It was not necessarily a corner piece. The robe may have been round, without corners. The word "secretly" refers both to the way David moved over to Saul and to the way David cut off the corner of the robe. Saul did not know what David had done.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a robe that Saul was likely to wear. Pause this audio here.

After David cut the corner of Saul's robe, David felt sorry and regretted what he had done because he believed it was wrong. In those days, people viewed cutting off a corner of the hem as a symbol of disloyalty and rebellion. Saul's robe also showed Saul's authority as king. David was disrespecting Saul as king by cutting off part of Saul's robe.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a situation when somebody made a wrong decision because they followed wrong advice. Talk about a time when something seemed like a message from God, but you later realized that it was not from God. What made you think the message was from God in the first place? What made you realize the message was not from God? Pause this audio here.

David said to David's men, "Yahweh forbid that I should do such a thing to my master, Yahweh's anointed." David regretted what David had done and said he would not harm Saul. David would not do "such a thing," to kill Saul as David's men had suggested. David would not kill Saul because Saul was Yahweh's anointed one, which meant that Yahweh had chosen Saul to be king over Israel. David respected Saul because Yahweh had anointed, or appointed, Saul to be king over Israel, and Saul was still king. Saul was still king even though, as you will remember, the Spirit of Yahweh had already left Saul. Because Saul was the person Yahweh had anointed, David would not attack or harm Saul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a situation when somebody wronged you, but you stopped yourself from paying that person back. Talk about the reasons that made you not pay that person back. Pause this audio here.

David stopped or restrained his men by what David said, and David did not allow his men to kill Saul. Saul finished relieving himself, stood, went out of the cave, and started out on his way.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Saul returns home from fighting the Philistines, and someone tells Saul that David is in the wilderness surrounding the oasis of En Gedi. Saul selects 3,000 of the best soldiers in Israel, and Saul and his army go to look for David and David's men in a place called the rocks of the wild goats at En Gedi.

1 Samuel 24:1–7

In the second scene: Saul comes to some sheepfolds along the route where people walked. There is a cave by the sheepfolds, and David and his men are sitting in the innermost part of the cave. Saul goes into the cave to relieve himself.

In the third scene: David's men mistakenly believe that Saul's coming into the cave is a sign from Yahweh that now is the time for David to kill Saul. David moves over to within reach of Saul's robe and secretly cuts off the corner of the robe.

In the fourth scene: After David cuts the corner of Saul's robe, David feels sorry and regrets what he had done because he believes that it was wrong. David speaks to his men and strongly rejects the idea of attacking Saul. David says that David would not attack Saul, because Yahweh had anointed or chosen Saul to be king of Israel.

In the fifth scene: David stops or restrains his men by what David says, and David does not allow the men to kill Saul. Saul gets up, leaves the cave, and starts out on his way.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The Philistines
- Someone who told Saul where David was
- Three thousand soldiers that Saul selected
- David
- And David's men

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Saul and his army were fighting the Philistines and chasing them away from the land of Israel. When Saul and Saul's army returned home, someone told Saul, "Look! David is in the wilderness of En Gedi." The man started talking to Saul in a way that shows that the information the man gave to Saul was important.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Locate the wilderness of En Gedi. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and discuss: What do you say in your language to show that the information you are giving is important? Pause this audio here.

As a result of the news Saul received, Saul selected 3,000 of the best soldiers in Israel. Then Saul and his army went to look for David and David's men in a place people called the rocks of the wild goats at En Gedi. Gibeah, where Saul lived, was about 65 to 80 kilometres from En Gedi. It would take Saul and Saul's army between 1.5 and 2 days to walk from Gibeah to En Gedi.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Locate the journey Saul and his men did from Gibeah to En Gedi. Pause this audio here.

Saul came to some sheepfolds that were along the route where people walked. There was a cave by the sheepfolds, and David and his men were sitting in the innermost part of the cave, which was the area farthest away from the entrance. The cave must have been big enough that Saul was not aware that there were other men in the cave. Saul went into the cave to relieve himself. The original language says that Saul went into the cave to "cover his feet," because when a man squatted to relieve himself, his robe covered his feet.

Stop here as a group and discuss: What do you say in your language when someone has gone to relieve themselves? How do you say it in an appropriate way that all people, men and women and children together, can listen to? What do you say specifically when a person has gone to empty their bowels? Pause this audio here.

Then David's men spoke to David and said, "Here is the day of which Yahweh said to you, 'Behold, I will give your enemy into your hand, and you shall do to him as it shall seem good to you.'" The men did not speak to David altogether. Most likely, one of the men spoke to David in a whisper, and the others agreed. The men were calling David's attention to the fact that this was a good time or opportunity to kill Saul.

Stop here as a group and discuss: How do you speak in your language to say that someone is whispering? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 24:1–7

Then David quietly moved close enough to touch Saul's robe. Then David secretly cut off the robe's edge or border. The word "secretly" refers both to the way David moved over to Saul and to the way David cut off the corner of the robe. Saul did not know what David had done.

As soon as David cut the corner of Saul's robe, "his heart struck him," because he believed that what he had done was wrong. The expression "his heart struck him" means that David suddenly felt sorry and regretted what David had done. You can also say that David felt sad in his heart. It is important to note that David realized that what he did was wrong very soon after David had cut the corner of Saul's robe.

David spoke to his men and strongly rejected the idea of attacking Saul. David said to his men, "Yahweh forbid that I should do such a thing to my master, Yahweh's anointed." "Yahweh forbid" means "Never!" David said that he would never do such a thing to David's master, Yahweh's anointed. David would not attack Saul, because Yahweh had anointed or chosen Saul to be king of Israel. That is why David would not put out his hand against Saul or harm Saul. David was likely very quietly whispering to his men, as Saul was still in the cave.

David stopped or restrained his men by what David said, and David did not allow the men to kill Saul. Then Saul got up, left the cave, and started out on his way or in the direction Saul intended to go.

Stop here as a group and discuss: How will you translate "Yahweh forbid" to mean "Never!"? How will you show that David and his men are speaking so quietly that Saul does not hear the men? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Saul
- The Philistines
- Someone who told Saul where David was
- Three thousand soldiers that Saul selected
- David
- David's men

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Saul returned home from fighting the Philistines, and someone told Saul that David was in the wilderness surrounding the oasis of En Gedi. Saul selected 3,000 of the best soldiers in Israel, and Saul and his army went to look for David and David's men in a place called the rocks of the wild goats at En Gedi. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy that at last we will catch David; or

1 Samuel 24:1–7

- I will not let David get away again! David must die! or
- God is delivering David into my hand again! No one will interrupt my mission this time!

Continue the drama. Saul came to some sheepfolds along the route where people walked. There was a cave by the sheepfolds, and David and his men were sitting in the innermost part of the cave. Saul went into the cave to relieve himself.

David's men spoke to David and told him that this was the day Yahweh had spoken about, the day Yahweh said Yahweh would deliver David's enemy, King Saul, into David's hands and allow David to do to the enemy whatever seemed right. Then David moved over to within reach of Saul's robe and secretly cut off the corner of the robe. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- At long last, the day has come to kill Saul! or
- Saul walked into the cave we are in! Yahweh has delivered Saul into our hands! or
- We need to tell David that this is the day Yahweh has given him to do with Saul as David pleases. Surely David will allow us to kill King Saul!

Continue the drama. After David cut the corner of Saul's robe, David felt sorry and regretted what he had done because David believed that it was wrong. David spoke to his men and strongly rejected the idea of attacking Saul. David said that he would not attack Saul because Yahweh had chosen Saul to be king of Israel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What have I done by cutting off the corner of King Saul's robe? I feel so ashamed! I behaved like a traitor; or
- Saul is still King of Israel. Yahweh anointed Saul to be king. I will not kill Yahweh's anointed! or
- I must speak to my men and stop them from killing Saul. My men spoke like they heard from Yahweh, but Yahweh does not want us to kill Saul.

Continue the drama. David stopped or restrained his men by what David said, and David did not allow the men to kill Saul. Saul stood, left the cave, and started out on his way.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

When Saul and his army returned home, someone told Saul that David was in the **wilderness** surrounding the oasis of En Gedi. Use the same word or phrase for wilderness as you used in previous passages. For more information on wilderness, refer to the Master Glossary.

On hearing the news about David's location, Saul selected 3,000 of the best soldiers in **Israel**, and Saul and his army went to look for David and his men in a place called the rocks of the wild goats at En Gedi. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul came to some sheepfolds, or sheep pens, along the route people walked. A sheepfold refers to a fence-like enclosure that people made of stones. Some sheepfolds were permanent, consisting of stone walls and a roof. Others were temporary constructions of loose stones with thorn bushes on top.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sheepfold. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sheepfolds**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David's men spoke to David. The men told David that this was the day **Yahweh** had spoken about, the day Yahweh said he would deliver David's enemy, King Saul, into David's hands and allow David to do to the enemy whatever seemed right. Yahweh is God's personal name, and the storyteller uses this name throughout this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

David reached out and cut off a corner of Saul's **robe**. Use the same word for robe as you have used in previous passages, and remember that robe is in the Master Glossary.

David spoke to his men and strongly rejected the idea of attacking Saul. David says that David would not attack his lord Saul, because Saul was Yahweh's anointed, or chosen person to be king of Israel. Here, the word lord means master, someone who has full authority. Saul was David's lord because Saul was the king of Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **lord**. Look up lord in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **anointed** as you used in previous passages.

For more information on anointed, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 24:1–7

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (546 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (814 KB)

1 Samuel 24:8–22

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 24:8–22 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:8–22 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:8–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, after hearing that David was in the wilderness of En Gedi, Saul took 3,000 of his best soldiers to find David. Saul went into a cave to relieve himself, not knowing David and David's men were hiding inside. David's men said this was the day Yahweh promised to give David's enemy into David's hands. David quietly cut off a corner of Saul's robe but immediately felt guilty. David stopped his men from attacking Saul because Saul was the king whom Yahweh chose. Then Saul got up and left the cave.

As soon as Saul had left the cave, David quickly goes out of the cave and shouts after Saul, "My lord the king!" to show David's great respect. When Saul looks behind to see who is calling him, David bows down with his face to the ground to honour Saul.

David asks why Saul is listening to people who tell Saul that David wants to harm Saul. David is not really asking a question, but is telling Saul that Saul should not listen when people tell Saul that David is seeking Saul's harm.

David tells Saul that Saul was in the cave and saw what happened with his own eyes. Saul witnessed how Yahweh put Saul into David's hands, or into David's power, and David had a chance to kill Saul in the cave. Some of David's men told David to kill Saul, but David felt sorry for Saul and spared him. David refused to lay a hand on Saul, or harm Saul, because Saul is David's master and Saul is the person Yahweh anointed, or chose to be king.

David tries to convince King Saul that David is innocent. David says, "Look, my father, see the corner of your robe in my hand." David calls Saul his "father" to show respect. David shows Saul the piece of Saul's robe he secretly cut off, which proves that David could have easily killed Saul but chose not to. David tells Saul that this shows David has not sinned against Saul or done anything wrong. David has not rebelled against Saul or encouraged others to disobey Saul. Even though David has not wronged Saul, Saul is still chasing David to kill him.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a situation when someone has accused you wrongly of having done something you did not do. How did you convince that person that you were innocent? Pause this audio here.

David keeps talking to Saul and calls on Yahweh to decide who is right. David believes Saul is wrong, so David calls on Yahweh to avenge David against Saul, or punish Saul for the bad things he has done. However, David promises that David himself will never hurt Saul. David says, "But my hand shall not be against you." These words make it clear that David does not want to use any violence against Saul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when someone treated you unfairly, and you chose not to take revenge. How did you feel, and why did you decide not to take revenge? Pause this audio here.

David now quotes an old proverb, or wise saying, which David, Saul, and the people of that time knew well. The saying says, "Wicked actions come from wicked men!" The meaning of the wise saying is that only evil people do evil deeds. David implies that since David is not an evil person, David would not do evil to Saul. David is likely also implying that since Saul was trying to do evil to David, Saul must be an evil person. David says that he will not hurt Saul because David is not a bad person. David promises that his hand will not be against Saul.

David continues to speak to Saul and asks Saul a question that does not require an answer. David tells Saul that Saul, the king of Israel, should not have come out with an army to chase David in the wilderness. David asks why Saul is wasting time chasing someone who will not hurt Saul. It is like chasing a dead dog or a tiny flea. But a

dead dog is harmless. A flea is a tiny insect that jumps and feeds on the blood of animals or people. A flea is so small that it is hard to see. David speaks humbly, saying that David is not dangerous, not important, and not worth Saul's trouble.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a dog. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a flea. Pause this audio here.

David knows he will not get justice from Saul, so while speaking to Saul, David calls on Yahweh to judge between David and Saul and to decide who is right and who is wrong. David also calls on Yahweh to see, or pay attention to, David's situation and defend David. David wants Yahweh to support David and prove he is right. David is also asking Yahweh to save David from Saul's hand, or power, and stop Saul from trying to harm David.

After David finishes speaking, Saul asks David, "Is this your voice, my son David?" Saul knows who was speaking, because Saul saw David when David called after Saul. When Saul says this, Saul shows that he is surprised that David is there. Saul means, "Am I really hearing you, David, my son?" Saul calls David Saul's son because it was a polite and affectionate way to refer to a younger man. There was no family relationship between Saul and David. Then Saul weeps, or cries loudly, probably because he realises that he wronged David.

Saul says to David, "You are more righteous than I am." Saul admits that David is more righteous, which means that David acted morally and correctly. Saul explains that David treated him well by showing Saul kindness and faithfulness. David was loyal to Saul and did not try to harm Saul. But Saul treated David badly, and Saul admits he acted the opposite of how David acted.

Saul tells David that what David just said shows Saul that David was good to him. Even though Yahweh gave David the chance to kill Saul, David chose not to.

Saul makes a strong point by asking a question that does not need an answer. Saul says people do not let their enemies go free when people can hurt their enemies. Saul admits that David was good to Saul by not killing him when David had the chance. Saul then asks Yahweh to reward David for this kind action.

Then Saul admits that he has no doubt that David will become king, and the kingship of Israel will always remain in David's hands.

Saul now asks David to swear, or make a serious promise in Yahweh's name, that David will not kill Saul's descendants and make Saul's family disappear. Saul wants David to promise that when David becomes king, David will not harm Saul's children or grandchildren. Back then, it was common for new kings to kill the former king's family to stop rebellions. If David killed Saul's descendants, people would forget Saul's name, and Saul's sons would not be there to pass on Saul's name and land. Other members of Saul's clan would take over Saul's land.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Why do you think it was important for Saul that his name and land carry on to Saul's descendants? How do you feel about descendants inheriting the family name or title and land in your culture? Pause this audio here.

So David agrees to Saul's request and swears, or makes a serious promise in Yahweh's name, not to kill Saul's family. Then Saul returns home to Gibeah, but David and his men go up to the stronghold, their hiding place in the mountains in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Locate the journey of Saul from En Gedi to Gibeah and the journey of David from En Gedi to the wilderness in the mountains in the territory of the tribe of Judah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:8–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Shortly after Saul left the cave, David quickly goes out from the cave and shouts after Saul. When Saul looks behind him, David tells Saul that Saul should not listen when people tell Saul that David is seeking to harm Saul.

In the second scene: David speaks to Saul. David tells Saul that Saul saw how Yahweh gave David a chance to kill Saul in the cave, but David chose not to. David says he has not done anything wrong to Saul, even though Saul is chasing David to kill him. David calls on Yahweh to judge between David and Saul and to punish Saul if Saul has done wrong. But David promises he will never hurt Saul. Finally, David asks Yahweh to defend David, protect him, and save him from Saul's power.

In the third scene: After David finishes speaking, Saul admits that David is more righteous than Saul is because David stayed loyal and did not harm Saul, even though Saul treated David badly. Saul asks Yahweh to reward David for David's kindness. Saul also admits that he is sure David will become king and that Israel will do well under David's leadership.

In the fourth scene: Saul asks David to promise in Yahweh's name not to kill Saul's descendants or destroy Saul's family. David agrees and makes the promise.

In the fifth scene: Then Saul returns home to Gibeah, but David and his men go up to the stronghold, their hiding place in the mountains in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- King Saul
- Saul's men—the storyteller does not mention the men, but we know they are somewhere near, and they travel back with Saul to Gibeah
- And David's men—the storyteller does not mention the men, but we know they are in the cave and then travel back with David to the stronghold

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Right after Saul left the cave where David and his men were hiding, David quickly goes out from the cave and shouts after Saul respectfully, "My lord the king!" Even though Saul is close by, enough time passed for Saul to be some distance away, so David shouts or speaks loudly to Saul. When Saul looks behind to see who called him, David bows down with his face to the ground to give respect to Saul.

David asks why Saul is listening to people who tell Saul that David wants to harm Saul. David is not really asking a question, but telling Saul that Saul should not listen when people tell Saul that David is seeking to harm Saul.

David tells Saul that Saul was there and saw what happened with his own eyes. Saul witnessed how Yahweh put Saul into David's hands, or into David's power, and David had a chance to kill Saul in the cave. Some of David's men told David to kill Saul, but David felt sorry for Saul and spared him. David refused to lay a hand on Saul or harm Saul, because Saul is David's master and the one Yahweh anointed or chose to be king.

David wants Saul to look closely at the piece of Saul's robe that David cut off. David says, "Look, my father, see the corner of your robe in my hand." David refers to Saul as "my father" to show respect. David tells Saul that this shows David has not sinned against Saul. David says that "there is no evil in David's hands," which means that David has not done anything wrong. Still, even though David has not hurt Saul, Saul is chasing David to kill him.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say in your language if you want someone to look closely at something? Pause this audio here.

David keeps talking to Saul and calls on God to judge between David and Saul, which means to decide who is right. David believes Saul is wrong, so David asks God to avenge David against Saul, or punish Saul for the wrong things Saul has done. However, David promises that David himself will never hurt Saul. David says, "But my hand shall not be against you." This means that David does not want to use any violence against Saul.

David now quotes an old proverb, or wise saying that everyone knew: "Wicked actions come from wicked men." David suggests that because he is not evil, he will not harm Saul. David also hints that since Saul is trying to

harm David, Saul might be acting like an evil person. However, David speaks very humbly and politely to Saul and does not say this directly. David finishes by saying that David's hand will not be against Saul, which means that David will not hurt Saul because David is not a wicked man.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about wise old sayings in your culture. Talk about what areas of life people mostly use these sayings for, and how people have changed the sayings over time. Is there a special way you use words when you quote wise sayings? Or is there a way you show that you are using a wise saying in a story? Pause this audio here.

David keeps speaking to Saul, and David refers to Saul in a way that shows respect for Saul's high position. David says, "After whom has the king of Israel come out?" By asking a question that does not require an answer, David makes a strong point that the king of Israel should not have come out against David. When David says Saul has "come out," David means that Saul has come to chase David. David asks why Saul is wasting time chasing someone who will not hurt David. It is like chasing a dead dog or a tiny flea. David is speaking humbly, saying that David is not important, not dangerous, and not worth Saul's trouble.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of animals might you compare an unimportant person to? How will you talk about what David says in a way that shows that David is humble? Pause this audio here.

David continues to speak to Saul and calls on Yahweh to judge between David and Saul and decide who is right and who is wrong. David also asks Yahweh to see, or pay attention to, David's situation and to defend David. David wants Yahweh to support David and prove he is right. David also calls on Yahweh to deliver David from Saul's hand, or Saul's power, and to stop Saul from trying to harm David.

After David finishes speaking, Saul asks David, "Is this your voice, my son David?" Saul knows who was speaking, but Saul's question shows surprise at what David has said. Saul calls David his son because it was a polite and affectionate way to refer to a younger man. Saul weeps or cries aloud, probably because Saul thinks he has wronged David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What are the usual ways people refer to each other in your language, depending on their age and position in the community? Pause this audio here.

Saul says to David, "You are more righteous than I am." Here, "righteous" means being in the right. Saul admits that David acted morally and correctly. Saul explains why he believes that David is in the right by comparing David's good behaviour to Saul's own bad actions.

Saul tells David that what David just said shows him that David was good to Saul. Even though Yahweh put Saul into David's hands, or gave David the chance to kill Saul, David chose not to.

Saul asks a question that does not need an answer. Saul says, "For if a man finds his enemy, will he let him go away safe?" Saul makes a strong point that most people do not let their enemies go free when they can harm their enemies. Then, Saul asks Yahweh to reward David for David's kind action.

Then Saul admits that Saul believes that David will become king and the kingship of Israel will remain in David's family.

Saul now asks David to swear, or make a serious promise in Yahweh's name, that David will not kill Saul's descendants and make Saul's family disappear. Saul wants David to promise that when David becomes king, David will not harm Saul's children or grandchildren. In making such a promise, an Israelite probably said something like, "As surely as Yahweh lives."

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do people say in your language when they make solemn promises or vows? Remember how you translated what people say to make serious promises in previous passages in 1 Samuel. Pause this audio here.

So David agrees to Saul's request and swears, or makes an oath, not to kill Saul's family. Then Saul and his men return home to Gibeah, but David and his men go up to the stronghold, their hiding place in the mountains of the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Gibeah was about 65 to 80 kilometres northwest of En Gedi, and it would take Saul and his men about 1.5 to 2 days or more to walk across a mountain area. The stronghold in the mountains in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah was about 20 to 30 kilometres west of En Gedi, and it would take David and his men about 2 to 3 days to walk across the steep mountains.

Stop here as a group and look at the map. Locate the journey of Saul from En Gedi to Gibeah and the journey of David from En Gedi to the wilderness in the mountains in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:8–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- King Saul
- Saul's men—the storyteller does not mention the men, but we know they are somewhere near, and they travel back with Saul to Gibeah
- And David's men—the storyteller does not mention the men, but we know they are in the cave and then travel back with David to the stronghold

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Shortly after Saul left the cave, David quickly goes out from the cave and shouts after Saul, "My lord the king!" When Saul looks behind to see who is calling him, David bows down with his face to the ground to honor Saul. David tells Saul that Saul should not listen when people tell Saul that David is seeking Saul's harm. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel hopeful. King Saul has seen for himself that Yahweh gave Saul into my hands, but I have not hurt Saul; or
- I feel desperate. This is my only chance to convince Saul that I do not want to harm him and have done good to him; or
- I feel a bit scared. What if Saul now sends his men to attack me and my men?

Continue the drama. David tells Saul that Saul saw with his own eyes how Yahweh put Saul into David's hands, or into his power, and David had a chance to kill Saul in the cave. Some of David's men told David to kill Saul, but David spared Saul. David says he refused to lay a hand on Saul, or harm Saul, because Saul is David's master and the one Yahweh anointed, or chose to be king.

David tries to convince King Saul that David is innocent. David shows Saul the piece of Saul's robe he secretly cut off, which proves that David could have easily killed Saul but chose not to. David tells Saul that this shows David has not sinned against Saul or done anything wrong. Even though David has not wronged Saul, Saul is still chasing David to kill him.

David keeps talking to Saul and calls on Yahweh to decide who is right. David also calls on Yahweh to avenge David against Saul, or punish Saul for the bad things Saul has done. However, David promises that David will never hurt Saul. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel desperate for King Saul to see that I am innocent, and I am in the right; or
- I am losing hope that Saul will be just. I need to ask Yahweh to show Saul that I am in the right. Yahweh needs to protect me; or
- Only Yahweh can punish Saul for the bad things Saul has done, because Yahweh chose Saul to be king.

Continue the drama. David now quotes an old wise saying, "Wicked actions come from wicked men!" David says that he is not going to harm Saul because David is not a wicked man. David tells Saul that Saul, the king of Israel, should not have come out with an army to chase David in the wilderness. It is like chasing a dead dog or a tiny flea because David is not important, not dangerous, and not worth Saul's trouble.

While David speaks to Saul, David calls on Yahweh to judge between David and Saul and to decide who is right and who is wrong. David also calls on Yahweh to pay attention to David's situation and defend David. David wants Yahweh to support David and prove he is right. David is also calling on Yahweh to deliver David from Saul's hand, or power, and stop Saul from trying to harm David.

After David finishes speaking, Saul asks David whether he was really hearing David's voice. Then Saul weeps, or cries loudly. Saul admits that David was more righteous than Saul was. David was loyal to Saul and did not harm him, but Saul treated David badly. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am shocked. Is that really David speaking to me right now? Has David really spared my life even though he could kill me in the cave? or
- I am ashamed. I wrongly accused David and chased David to kill him; or
- I feel deep sadness. David is more righteous than I am. I hope Yahweh forgives me for what I have done.

Continue the drama. Saul tells David that what David just said shows Saul that David was good to Saul. Even though Yahweh gave David the chance to kill Saul, David chose not to. Saul makes a strong point that people do not let their enemies go free when people can hurt their enemies. Saul admits that David was good to Saul by not killing Saul when David had the chance. Saul then asks Yahweh to reward David for this kind action.

Saul admits that he has no doubt that David will become king, and the kingship of Israel will prosper and remain in David's family. Saul now asks David to swear, or make a serious promise in Yahweh's name, that Saul will not kill Saul's descendants and make his family disappear. So David agrees to Saul's request and swears, or makes an oath, not to kill Saul's family. Then Saul returns home to Gibeah, but David and his men go up to the stronghold, their hiding place in the mountains in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel relieved that I did not kill Saul, even when my men told me to; or
- I praise Yahweh, for Yahweh is just! Yahweh showed Saul my innocence; or
- I feel grateful that evil people cannot stop Yahweh's plans. Now even Saul says that I will be king over Israel!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 24:8–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Shortly after Saul left the **cave**, David gets up and goes out from the cave and shouts after Saul, "My **lord** the **king**!" David **bows down** to Saul. Use the same words or phrases for cave, lord, king, and bow down as you used in previous passages. For more information on lord, king, and bow, refer to the Master Glossary.

David tells Saul that Saul saw with his own eyes how **Yahweh** put Saul **into David's hands**, or **into David's power**, and David had a chance to kill Saul in the cave. Use similar phrases for the idea of Yahweh putting people into someone's hands, or power, that you have used previously. Yahweh is God's personal name, and

the storyteller uses this name throughout this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

David tries to convince King Saul that David is innocent. David shows Saul the piece of Saul's **robe** that David secretly cut off, which proves that David could have easily killed Saul but chose not to because Yahweh **anointed** Saul. David tells Saul that this shows David has not **sinned** against Saul or done anything wrong. Use the same words or phrases for anointed, robe, and sin as you used in previous passages. For more information on anointed, robe and sin, refer to the Master Glossary.

David asks Yahweh to **judge** between David and Saul to see who has done the right thing. Use the same words or phrases for "judging between people" that you have used previously. Judge is in the Master Glossary.

David now quotes an old **proverb**, or wise saying that David, Saul, and the people of that time knew well. The saying says, "**Wicked**, or evil, actions come from wicked men!" Wicked actions are evil or bad. Use the same words or phrases for wicked and proverb as you used in previous passages. For more information on wicked and proverb, refer to the Master Glossary.

David tells Saul that Saul, the king of **Israel**, should not have come out with an army to chase David in the wilderness. It is like chasing a dead dog or a tiny flea because David is not important and not worth Saul's trouble. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

A **dog** is a furry animal that people often keep as a pet. Dogs are loyal and friendly, and people often train dogs to do things like fetch or protect their owners. But a dead dog is harmless. Use the word for dog that you used before.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a dog. Pause this audio here.

A flea is a tiny insect that jumps and feeds on the blood of animals or people. A flea is so small that it is hard to see.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a flea. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **flea**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

After David finishes speaking, Saul calls David his **son** and asks David whether he was really hearing David's voice. Then Saul weeps, or cries loudly. Saul admits that David was more **righteous** than Saul was. Here, the word righteous means being in the right. Saul admits that David did what was right, and Saul did not. Use the same words or phrases for son and righteous as you used in previous passages. For more information on son and righteous, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul says that Saul knows Yahweh will give David the **kingdom** of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for kingdom that you have used previously. Kingdom is in the Master Glossary.

After David gives an **oath** not to kill Saul's family, Saul returns home to Gibeah, but David and his men go up to the **stronghold**, their hiding place in the mountains in the wilderness in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Here, stronghold means a cave, not a strong fort that people built. Use the same words or phrases for oath and wilderness stronghold as you used in previous passages. For more information on oath and stronghold, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 24:8–22

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (554 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (825 KB)

1 Samuel 25:1–13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 25:1–13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:1–13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This true story happened sometime after David spared Saul's life. In this story, the old prophet, Samuel, dies. The Israelites gather to grieve, or mourn, for Samuel. In Israelite custom, mourning often included loud crying or wailing. Public mourning for someone important like Samuel often lasted for weeks. The Israelites hold Samuel's funeral in Ramah, Samuel's hometown.

Stop here and look at a map that includes Ramah as a group. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 25:1–13

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture mourn for an important person or religious leader? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller mentions that David then goes down to the wilderness of Paran. David may have moved to the wilderness to get further away from Saul. Samuel's presence had helped keep Saul from hurting David. Now that Samuel has died, Saul might come to hurt David. A wilderness does not have many resources, so people have a hard time finding food, water, and shelter in the wilderness. People usually do not choose to live in a wilderness. Though the storyteller does not say it, we know from later in the story that David's army of men also travels with David. The wilderness of Paran lay in the northeastern part of the Sinai Peninsula. The area spanned from northwest of the Gulf of Aqaba into the mountains of Judah.

Stop here and look at a picture of a wilderness as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a map that includes the wilderness of Paran as a group. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller starts talking about a very rich man whom people called Nabal. Nabal lived in Maon, a town in the territory of the tribe of Judah, near Hebron. Nabal had property in Carmel, about a 30-minute walk north of Maon. The fertile land in Carmel provided a good place for Nabal's servants to take care of Nabal's animals. Nabal had many grazing animals. Nabal had 3,000 sheep and 1,000 goats.

Stop here and look at a map that includes Maon and Carmel as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at pictures of goats and sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

Nabal's wife, Abigail, was good, wise, and beautiful. Nabal, however, was a bad man. People knew Nabal as a mean man with selfish habits and who treated people badly. Nabal descended from Caleb. This means that Nabal came from a well-known family in the tribe of Judah.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone important who was also a bad person. Pause this audio here.

In the wilderness, someone tells David that Nabal's servants have started to shear Nabal's sheep and goats. To shear means to pull or cut off the long hair or "wool" from the animals. Since the Israelites did not have iron tools in those days, people may have pulled off loose wool by hand or with a bronze comb. This typically does not hurt the animals. In fact, it helps to keep the sheep healthy. In those days, people usually sheared sheep once a year. The animals then grew more wool until the next year. Then the owner would either sell the wool or use the wool to make cloth. At that time, the owner of the animals used profits from selling the wool to pay the workers.

Stop here and look at an image of workers shearing sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

In the story, David sends 10 young men from David's army as messengers to talk with Nabal in Carmel. We know from previous stories and from later in this story that David's army had hundreds of men. David sends the 10 young men to Nabal as representatives of David and David's army.

David's message includes a respectful greeting and an extremely polite request. David asks Nabal for help to send food for David's army to eat. David knew that during the animal shearing time, Nabal would have prepared a party with lots of food for Nabal's workers. David tells Nabal that David's army had stayed in Carmel near Nabal's workers, or shepherds, who took care of the sheep and goats. The whole time David's army stayed near Nabal's shepherds, the shepherds did not lose anything. In other words, David's army never attacked or stole from the shepherds. In fact, David's army likely even helped to protect Nabal's shepherds and animals from dangerous thieves. David even told Nabal that Nabal could ask Nabal's workers about what David had said. David knew that Nabal's workers would confirm that David told the truth.

Stop here and look at a picture of a shepherd as a group. Pause this audio here.

David was trying to arrange with Nabal to help each other. David and David's men had already protected Nabal's business. So, David was asking Nabal to help give some food to David's army. David does not ask for enough food to feed the whole army. David simply asks for the amount of food Nabal is willing to give.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about when one person politely negotiated with someone else. What did the first person say to start the negotiation? Pause this audio here.

After David told the message to the 10 men, these men went to tell the message to Nabal. David's 10 men then waited to hear Nabal's answer. This likely means that David's young men told David's message to Nabal's servants. Then Nabal's servants would have told Nabal. Nabal then gave a formal, very harsh response. Nabal not only rejected David's request but also insulted David. Nabal then asked who David was. Nabal was implying that David was not important. Nabal even compared David to a slave who has run away from the slave owner. Nabal made it clear that Nabal would not give any help at all to David. Nabal did not want to share the food Nabal had prepared for his shearers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you made a polite request to another person. How would you feel if that person responded like Nabal did? Pause this audio here.

David's young men went back to David to report everything Nabal said to David. David immediately told David's army to attack Nabal. David and 400 men put on their swords and started to go to Nabal. Two hundred of David's men stayed to protect the army's supplies.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sword as a group.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: Samuel dies, and the Israelites mourn for Samuel. David and David's men move to the Desert of Paran.

In the second scene: The storyteller describes Nabal and Nabal's wife, Abigail.

In the third scene: David learns that Nabal is shearing sheep. So, David asks 10 messengers from David's army to give Nabal a message. David tells the messengers the message to give to Nabal. David wants to ask Nabal for food and drink since David's army already protected Nabal's shepherds and sheep.

In the fourth scene: The messengers travel to Nabal and tell David's message to Nabal. David's messengers then wait for Nabal's response.

In the fifth scene: Nabal strongly insults David and rudely refuses to help David.

In the sixth scene: David's messengers return to tell David what Nabal said. David prepares 400 men from David's army to go attack Nabal.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Israelites who mourn for Samuel
- David
- David's army
- Nabal
- Abigail
- Nabal's servants, who include the shepherds and shearers
- And 10 young men from David's army who tell Nabal about David's message

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, we learn that the prophet Samuel has died. Israelites traveled from many places to Ramah to mourn for Samuel. The Israelites buried Samuel in Ramah, Samuel's hometown. The original language says that "all Israel" came together to mourn. Many of the Israelite people likely came to Ramah at different times over several weeks. After this, David and David's army of men went to stay in the wilderness of Paran.

Stop here and review the map that includes Ramah as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the storyteller describes a rich man from Maon but does not give the man's name. Then the storyteller describes this man's business in Carmel. The man owned 3,000 sheep and 1,000 goats. Each year, this man's servants, called shearers, would pull off or cut off the wool or hair of these sheep and goats. The original language says that this man "was shearing the sheep and goats." Actually, this man's servants did the shearing.

Stop here as a group and look at a photo of workers shearing sheep. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Act out pulling out and cutting off the extra hair on sheep and goats. Then act out gathering this hair to sell or so that others can make cloth to sell. After acting this out, describe the actions you did in your language. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller finally tells us the rich man's name, Nabal. Some translations tell Nabal's name first and then describe Nabal.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Describe someone you know. Pay attention to the order of when you tell details about the person and when you tell the person's name. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also briefly tells us that Nabal had a wise and beautiful wife named Abigail. Then the storyteller continues to describe Nabal as a cruel man who was selfish and treated people badly. Nabal came from the clan of Caleb, part of the Israelite tribe of Judah.

In scene three, the storyteller mentions David's name three times. This shifts the focus from Nabal back to David. David learns that Nabal's servants were shearing sheep. David knew that owners celebrated during the shearing time. This means that Nabal would have prepared a lot of food. David's large army had little access to food in the wilderness. We learn later in the story that David already knew about Nabal since David's army had stayed near Nabal's shepherds before the shearing time. David had protected Nabal's business. So, David prepares 10 messengers from David's army to give a polite request for help from Nabal. David tells these messengers to peacefully ask in David's "name." This means that the messengers had David's authority to deliver the message to Nabal for David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about one person. Then, in the same story, change the focus to another person. How does the listener know that you have shifted the focus to the second person? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a true story of when someone with authority sent messengers to deliver a message on behalf of the person in authority. Pay attention to the words you use that show that the messengers had the authority to give the message. Pause this audio here.

Then, David tells the messengers the message to give to Nabal. David wants to ask Nabal for food and drink since David's army already protected Nabal's shepherds and sheep. David gave a very polite request and used the word for "peace" three times. David wished Nabal, everyone in Nabal's home, and Nabal's belongings a good upcoming year and good health. Then David said that David had heard about the animal shearing time. David then informed Nabal that Nabal's servants who cared for Nabal's animals stayed in Carmel, near David's army. David's army never mistreated or stole from these servants. In other words, David's army had the strength and opportunity to mistreat and steal from Nabal, but did not do so. David said that Nabal could ask these servants, and the servants would confirm that David spoke the truth.

David then respectfully asked Nabal to treat David's men with kindness during the shearing celebration. David asked that David's men would "find favor" in Nabal's eyes. Finally, David asked Nabal to give whatever food Nabal could give to the messengers and to David for David's army. David refers to the messengers as "your servants" and to David as "your son David." David is showing respect to Nabal by showing that David knows Nabal has more wealth and power than David does.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Act out a situation with two people. The first person should have more wealth and power than the second. The second person should respectfully and humbly ask for help from the first person. What words did the second person use to show respect? Pause this audio here.

David spoke to the messengers. David's words to the messengers included the message that the messengers would soon say to Nabal. Some translations use David's words as though David spoke all of this directly. The messengers would then quote this to Nabal later. For example, "I have heard that your shearers are shearing the

animals." Other translations use David's words as the messengers would tell the words for David. For example, "David heard that your shearers are shearing the animals."

Stop here and try different ways to say this. Discuss as a group which ways sound more natural. Pause this audio here.

In scene four, David's messengers travel to Nabal. With David's authority, the messengers tell David's message to Nabal. David's messengers then wait for Nabal's response.

In scene five, the story briefly shifts to focus on Nabal. Nabal asks, "Who is this David? Who is this son of Jesse?" "Son of Jesse" refers to David, whose father is named Jesse. Nabal then said that many slaves run away from their owners. Nabal is insulting David and implying that David is no better than a lowly slave. Nabal then says to David's messengers, "I do not even know you or where you come from. Why should I give you bread and water? Why should I let you eat the animals I have killed for my servants who sheared my sheep?" Nabal is not expecting anyone to answer these questions. These questions emphasize that Nabal did not think David had any importance or worth to Nabal. Nabal had no intention of giving up Nabal's food to help feed David and David's men.

Scene six starts with David's men's response. The men "turn around and go back" to David and tell David everything. The storyteller emphasizes this by repeating David's name three times. David's men tell David "all these words." This means the men said everything Nabal said when Nabal arrogantly rejected David's request.

Then the storyteller shows that David immediately responds after David hears that Nabal has rudely rejected David's request. As we see in the next story, David is very upset and acts immediately. David instructs all of David's men to put on their swords. David also puts on his own sword. Then David leads 400 of the men in the army, and they start to go to Nabal in Carmel. Two hundred of David's men stay behind at the camp to protect all the gear.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel
- Israelites who mourn for Samuel
- David
- David's army
- Nabal
- Abigail
- Nabal's servants, who include the shepherds and shearers
- And 10 young men from David's army who tell Nabal about David's message

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

1 Samuel 25:1–13

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, Samuel dies, and the Israelites mourn for Samuel in Ramah. Then David and David's army go to the wilderness of Paran. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We loved and respected Samuel. This is a hard time for us Israelites; or
- God used Samuel to bless and direct our people. We want to honor Samuel at Samuel's funeral.

Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Saul knows that God has chosen me as the next king. Now that Samuel has died, Saul will probably act more harshly toward me; or
- Now that Samuel is not here to stop Saul, Saul may come to hunt me down. My men and I will need to go into hiding.

Continue the drama. In scene two, the storyteller describes Nabal and Nabal's wife, Abigail. Nabal lives in Maon and has a business raising sheep and goats in the nearby town, Carmel. Nabal has a lot of wealth, but people know Nabal's mean and unethical character. Abigail is very different from Nabal. Abigail is intelligent and beautiful.

In scene three, David learns that Nabal's servants are cutting the wool from Nabal's animals. David then prepares 10 young men from David's army to give a message to Nabal. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My army lives in the wilderness. We do not have enough food for all 600 men. We need help from others to give us food; or
- My army has helped Nabal's shepherds. I can ask Nabal to help us in return; or
- I have shown kindness to Nabal, so perhaps Nabal will show kindness to me.

Continue the drama. Then David tells the messengers the message to give to Nabal. David wants to ask Nabal for food and drink since David's army already protected Nabal's shepherds and sheep. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Nabal has a higher position and more wealth than I do. I want to show respect to Nabal; or
- I will only ask Nabal for the amount Nabal wants to give. I do not want to ask for too much. I will feel content with whatever Nabal willingly gives; or
- We treated Nabal's men very well, so I feel like I have a right to ask for food in return. But I do not want to be demanding or disrespectful. I'll just ask nicely for Nabal's leftovers.

Continue the drama. In scene four, the messengers travel to Nabal and tell David's message to Nabal. David's messengers then wait for Nabal's response. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- David has given a very polite, respectful, and humble message to Nabal. Since our army has helped Nabal, we believe Nabal will help us; or
- David is making a wise arrangement with Nabal. Our army can help Nabal, and we will gladly continue to help Nabal.

Continue the drama. In scene five, Nabal strongly insults David and rudely refuses to help David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Nabal, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very angry at this stranger, David; or
- Carmel has a monument of big stones that celebrates Saul's battle victory. Everyone who sees these stones knows King Saul's power. David, Jesse's son, does not have any power; or
- I worked hard to gain my wealth, and this nobody, David, shows disrespect to ask anything from me; or
- I do not care that David helped my servants. I do not owe David anything. I am better than David.

Continue the drama. In scene six, David's messengers return to tell David what Nabal said. David prepares 400 men from David's army to go attack Nabal. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I asked Nabal politely for help in return for helping Nabal. Nabal is acting selfishly; or
- I humbly and respectfully gave a message to Nabal, but Nabal very rudely insulted me; or
- I am very angry at Nabal.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Israel came together to mourn for Samuel. Here, "Israel" refers to the **Israelites**. Israelites refer to the people who are descendants of Abraham. The Israelites lived in the country called Israel. Use the same word or phrase for Israelites as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israelites, refer to the Master Glossary.

David and David's army went to the **wilderness**. A wilderness has almost no plants or animals. People do not usually live in the wilderness. Look up wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information, and translate wilderness in the same way as you have in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

The story talks about Nabal's 3,000 **sheep** and 1,000 **goats**. Rich people in those days often had many sheep and goats. Sheep and goats are both grazing animals. This means that sheep and goats eat grass and other small plants in fields. People use the milk and meat from sheep and goats to make food to eat. People also use the skin and hair from sheep and goats to make clothes. Sheep and goats depend on **shepherds**, people who guide the animals to find food. The shepherds also protect sheep and goats. Shepherds stop thieves from stealing the sheep and goats. Shepherds also stop wild animals from attacking and killing the sheep and goats. Use the same words for "shepherds," "sheep" and "goats" that you used in previous passages. See shepherd in the Master Glossary for more information.

Nabal's servants sheared the sheep and goats. This means that the servants cut off or pulled off the hair or wool of the animals in order to make cloth. In Nabal's time, servants sometimes used a metal comb to help pull off the animals' hair. This usually does not hurt the animal.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **shear** and **wool**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Nabal had **servants** who sheared the sheep. A servant is a man or woman who works for another person, the master. Servants have low status in the community and must obey the master. Look up servant in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word for servants as you have used in previous passages.

People knew Nabal as a harsh or mean man. A harsh person usually acts angrily toward other people. Harsh people often are very selfish. Harsh people often feel happy when other people suffer.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe Nabal as a harsh and mean man. Remember how you described the bad person in step two. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that Nabal comes from the Calebite family. Calebite refers to a descendant of Caleb. Calebites came from the Israelite tribe of Judah.

In this story, David wishes **peace** to Nabal and Nabal's household, or the people who live in Nabal's house. This word for peace shows that David wishes for Nabal to have well-being in life. This also shows that David does not intend to harm Nabal. Instead, David is giving a friendly greeting. Look up peace in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word for peace that you have used in previous passages.

Sometimes the storyteller calls both David's and Nabal's men "young men" or servants. These are probably men who are not married but are old enough to fight or work hard for their master.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **young men**.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 25:1–13

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.1 MB)
- Setting the Stage (7.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (9.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.4 MB)

1 Samuel 25:14–22

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 25:14–22 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:14–22 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:14–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 25:14–22

In the last story, Nabal rudely rejected David's polite request for help. David responded by telling 400 men in David's army to join David to attack Nabal. This story happens at the same time that David's army was coming toward Nabal's land.

In this story, one of Nabal's servants told Nabal's wife, Abigail, how David had sent messengers to Nabal. Nabal's servant explained to Abigail how the messengers came from where David had been staying in the wilderness. Nabal's servant also explained how Nabal shouted at David's messengers when Nabal heard the message from David.

The servant then tells Abigail about how, for many days, David's army had stayed nearby to Nabal's servants. The servant talking to Abigail had personally stayed near David's army. The servant tells Abigail that David's army acted very kindly to Nabal's servants. David's army never stole from Nabal's servants who worked to care for Nabal's animals in the fields. In fact, David's army even protected Nabal's servants and animals all day and all night for a long time.

After telling Abigail how Nabal rudely responded to David's kindness, the servant urgently asked Abigail to carefully think about how to respond. Otherwise, the servant knew that things would end badly for Nabal and everyone in Nabal's household, including the servants. Because of Nabal's bad character, Nabal would not listen to anyone. So, the servant knew that talking to Nabal would not change the situation.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a person who would not listen to anyone. Pause this audio here.

Abigail quickly told the servants to prepare a generous gift of food and drink for David's army. The combination of all the food Abigail brought likely provided enough food for a good meal for at least 400 men, perhaps more. The food included 200 loaves of bread, 2 containers holding wine, the meat from 5 sheep, 5 large bags of dry, roasted grain, 100 handfuls of raisins, and 200 handfuls of ripe figs.

Abigail's servants prepared 200 loaves of bread. Sometimes, the Israelites made flat, round pieces of bread without yeast, which only took a short time. The Israelites called the bread with yeast "leavened" and the bread without yeast "unleavened." Unleavened bread tends to stay fresh longer than leavened bread. The storyteller does not explain the size or shape of each bread that Abigail asked the servants to prepare for David. Abigail either brought larger chunks of bread with yeast, called loaves or smaller, flat, round pieces of bread without yeast. Either way, more than one person could likely share each "bread." Two hundred loaves of bread, along with other food, would likely feed more than 200 men, perhaps even 400 men.

Stop here and look at a picture of loaves of bread and flat, round bread as a group. Discuss what word you might use in your language. Pause this audio here.

Abigail's servants also prepared two containers that held wine. Some translations call these containers "skins," meaning dried animal leather that people made into a container. But the containers could also refer to bottles or jars. In those days, the Israelites often drank a little bit of wine with each meal. The storyteller does not mention the size of these containers. The size depends on the size of the animal that the servants had killed to make the container of skin. However, one typical wineskin could hold enough wine for 126 to 169 people to each have a full drink. So, two wineskins could hold enough wine for 252 to 338 people to each have a full drink.

Stop here and look at a picture of a wineskin as a group. Describe in your own words what the wineskin looks like. Pause this audio here.

Abigail's servants prepared the meat from five sheep by removing the skin and the inside parts of the animal. The storyteller does not say whether the servants had already cooked the meat or not. Most likely, the servants had already cooked the meat. Each sheep could probably feed up to 60 men. So, the meat from all five sheep would likely feed almost 300 men.

Stop here and look at a picture of sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail's servants prepared five large bags of dry, roasted grain, probably either wheat or barley. This amount of grain could feed about 18 people for one meal. People would need to eat most of the other food soon so that it did not spoil, but people could keep the grain longer without spoiling since someone had already roasted it.

Stop here and look at a picture of dry, roasted grain as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail's servants prepared 100 handfuls of raisins, or sun-dried ripe grapes, that people pressed together into one big lump. This kind of dried food lasted longer than fresh fruit.

Stop here and look at a picture of raisins as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail's servants prepared 200 handfuls of ripe, dried figs, a small, sweet fruit pressed together into one big lump. This kind of dried food lasted longer than fresh fruit.

Stop here and look at a picture of dried figs as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail told her servants to load all the food supplies onto donkeys. Then Abigail told the servants to start taking all the supplies to meet David's army. Abigail rode her donkey behind these servants to go greet David. Abigail did not tell her husband, Nabal, about what Abigail was doing. Suddenly, while Abigail rode her donkey down into a valley, David's army came down into the valley from the other direction.

Stop here and look at a picture of a donkey carrying a lot of supplies as a group. Pause this audio here.

Just before Abigail and David met in the valley, David had been talking about Nabal. Most likely, David said this out loud to the men in David's army. David said, "I did not receive any benefit by protecting this man's property in the desert. Because of me, no one stole any of this man's possessions there. I did good things for this man. In return, this man is acting badly towards me."

David then continued to say a very serious promise, or oath. David promises to kill every male in Nabal's household before the next morning. David also says that if David does not complete this oath, God should bring punishment to someone. Some translations say that God should bring punishment to David's enemies. But it is more likely that David means God should punish David if David does not kill every male in Nabal's household before the next morning.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:14–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: One of Nabal's servants tells Abigail about David's kindness to Nabal and Nabal's meanness to David.

In the second scene: Abigail quickly prepares food for David's army. Then Abigail and her servants go to meet David and David's army.

In the third scene: On the way to meet Nabal, David regrets ever helping Nabal. David makes an oath that God should kill David if David does not kill Nabal and all Nabal's male servants on that day.

The characters in this passage are:

- Nabal's servant who talks with Abigail
- Abigail, Nabal's wife
- Nabal and Abigail's servants
- David
- And David's army

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the storyteller starts the story with language that shows that what happens next happened at the same time as the end of the previous story. In other words, this story happens while David and 400 men from David's army are coming with swords to meet Nabal. At this time, back at Nabal's land, one of Nabal's young male servants speaks directly with Nabal's wife, Abigail. The servant uses a word to let Abigail know that the servant is about to say something important.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story of a time when someone wanted to tell an important person an important message. Pay attention to the words the person said to get the attention of the important person. Pause this audio here.

Scene one continues as Nabal's servant explains to Abigail that David had sent messengers to kindly greet Nabal. However, Nabal shouted harshly at David's messengers. Then the servant tells Abigail about something that happened before David sent the messengers to Nabal. In the recent past, Nabal's servants took care of Nabal's animals in the fields. At that same time, David and the men in David's army stayed near Nabal's servants. The servant says that David's army was "a wall" to Nabal's servants. Walls provide protection from bad things. So, the servant was saying that David's army protected the servants. The storyteller does not say how long David's army stayed near Nabal's servants. However, we know that animals eat in fields for weeks or months before shearers cut off the animal's hair. So, David's army likely stayed near Nabal's servants for weeks, possibly months. The servant even says that David's army showed kindness and gave protection to Nabal's servants all day and all night. Also, no one from David's army hurt or stole from Nabal's servants. Then David sent messengers to Nabal. Nabal shouted at the messengers.

Nabal's servant tells Abigail about all these events. Finally, the servant asks Abigail to carefully think about how to respond.

Stop here and discuss as a group: The events of scene one happened in a different order than how the servant told Abigail about the events. First, the servant told Abigail about how Nabal had insulted David's messengers, and then the servant told Abigail what had happened before Nabal insulted David's messengers. Practice telling this part of the story. What order sounds natural in your language? Pause this audio here.

Nabal's servant then says a word to bring Abigail's attention back to the current situation. The servant then tells Abigail to think carefully about how Abigail can respond to this situation. The words the servant uses almost sound like a command. Normally, especially in those days, a servant would not tell a superior what to do. The servant here is still acting respectfully to Abigail. However, the strong words show that the servant is making an urgent request. The servant continues to explain the reason for this request. The servant knows that something bad or "evil" will happen. The servant says the bad thing will happen to "our master," meaning Nabal, and all of the people in Nabal's household. The servant also says that speaking to Nabal will not work. In other words, the servant knows that the foolish and stubborn Nabal will not change or solve the bad situation. The servant actually calls Nabal a "son of worthlessness," which means a useless man. Here, "a son of worthlessness" means more than just useless. It also tells us that Nabal regularly chose to act badly.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story of a time that someone gave a respectful but urgent request to a superior. Pay attention to the words the person uses to show both respect and urgency. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Retell the story you told in step two about a person who would not listen to other people's advice. Now, think about what words you used in the story to describe this "son of worthlessness," or foolish person, who would not listen to anyone. Pause this audio here.

Scene two starts when Abigail responds to what Nabal's servant said. Abigail hurries and asks her young male servants to prepare food and drink to load on donkeys to take to David. This includes 200 breads, 2 large containers of wine, meat from 5 whole sheep, 5 bags of dry, roasted grain, 100 handfuls of pressed raisins, and 200 handfuls of pressed dried figs. We do not know for sure if the servants had already cooked the meat or if the servants had just cut the meat so that people could cook it right away. After the servants finish putting all the food and drink on the backs of the donkeys, Abigail sends the servants with these supplies to meet David. Abigail then rides on a donkey behind the servants to also meet David. The storyteller says that Abigail did not tell what Abigail was doing to her husband, Nabal.

Stop here and look at a picture of a donkey carrying a lot of supplies as a group. Pause this audio here.

At the end of scene two, the storyteller uses words to show that Abigail suddenly met David. This happened suddenly because Abigail rode her donkey down into the valley on the mountain path from Nabal's land. This mountain path was hidden and hard to see from the other side of the valley. At the same time, David and David's army walked down the mountain path on the other side of a valley, going towards Nabal's land. In other words,

Abigail and Abigail's servants arrived in the valley at the same time that David and David's men arrived in the valley from the other direction.

In scene three, the storyteller tells us that David had just been talking while on the way to attack Nabal. In other words, what David said happened before David met Abigail. David makes an oath, or a serious promise to God, to kill every male in Nabal's household before the next morning. David actually says that David will kill everyone who belongs to Nabal who pees against a wall. This refers to how males pee differently from women. It means that David plans to kill every male of every age in Nabal's household.

David also says that if David does not complete this oath that God should punish David. Some translations say, "May God punish David." Since David is speaking, some other translations say, "May God punish me."

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:14–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Nabal's servant who talks with Abigail
- Abigail, Nabal's wife
- Nabal and Abigail's servants
- David
- And David's army

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, one of Nabal's servants tells Abigail about David's kindness to Nabal and Nabal's harshness to David. The servant tells Abigail that Nabal shouted at David's messengers when David asked Nabal for help. Then the servant tells Abigail how David had protected Nabal's servants and animals. Nabal's servant expects that David will react negatively to everyone in Nabal's household because of Nabal's harshness. Nabal's servant knows that Nabal will not change his mind even if someone reasons with Nabal about the dangerous situation. So, Nabal's servant asks Abigail to consider how to respond to fix the situation. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the servant, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- David acted respectfully and peacefully toward Nabal, but Nabal acted harshly toward David. David did not deserve this injustice; or
- I am afraid David will respond in anger to Nabal's harshness toward David; or
- David is a strong military leader. David can easily come and kill all of us because of our foolish master, Nabal; or
- I am afraid that all of us will die; or
- Nabal does not listen to other people's good advice. We should not even bother talking with Nabal; or
- Abigail is our last and only hope to fix this bad situation.

1 Samuel 25:14–22

Continue the drama. In the second scene, Abigail quickly prepares food for David's army. Then Abigail and her servants take all the food and go to meet David and David's army. Abigail chooses not to tell Nabal that Abigail is preparing food to take to David. Then, suddenly, Abigail and all her servants meet David and 400 men from David's army in the mountain valley. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Abigail, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I need to hurry to respond so that David will not harm us after what my foolish husband has done; or
- Nabal refused to give David even a little bread, wine, and meat. I will take all those things plus more food as well. Nabal is very wealthy, and we have a lot of food ready from the animal shearing feast time. We can give a large amount of food to David; or
- If I tell Nabal what I am doing, Nabal will stop me. I will not tell Nabal about this, or Nabal might make even more foolish decisions to make the situation worse; or
- Oh! Here comes David and David's army. I do not know what will happen; or
- I hope that David will accept the gifts I prepared for David. I hope that David will not kill us because of my foolish husband's harshness.

Continue the drama. In the third scene, the storyteller tells us what David said on the way to meet Nabal. David knew that David did not benefit from helping Nabal. David made an oath that God should kill David if David did not kill Nabal and all Nabal's male servants on that day. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My army did not have much food in the wilderness. We helped Nabal's servants and did not steal from the servants. When we needed help, Nabal responded very rudely; or
- Nabal has plenty of food, but Nabal refused to help us. I regret ever helping a very greedy man like Nabal; or
- I wasted my time and energy helping this mean man; or
- I am very angry! Nothing will stop me from killing Nabal and all of the males in Nabal's household; or
- I deserve revenge; or
- God has already chosen me as the next king, and Nabal compared me to a slave. I am important and powerful. I will use my power against Nabal.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:14–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Nabal's **servant** tells Abigail about what happened between Nabal and David. Also, later in the story, Abigail asked her young men, or servants, to prepare food to take to David and David's men. A servant is a man or woman who works for another person, the master. Servants have low status in the community and must obey the master. If needed, look up servant in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word for servant as you have used in previous passages.

Nabal's servant tells Abigail how David had sent messengers from David's army from the **wilderness** to meet Nabal. A wilderness has almost no plants or animals. People do not usually live in the wilderness. Look up wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information, and translate wilderness in the same way as you have in previous passages.

Nabal's servant referred to Nabal as "our **lord**." This means "our master." A lord is a man who is a master over other people, who has full authority, and whom people have to show respect. When you call someone "lord," you are saying that this person has authority over you. Use the same word for lord here that you have used previously when lord means master. The word lord is in the Master Glossary.

Nabal's servant tells Abigail about how David's men protected Nabal's servants while Nabal's servants took care of the **flock**. Here, flock means a group of sheep and goats. Use the same word for flock that you used in previous passages.

Abigail asks her servants to prepare 200 breads. In those days, the Israelites usually shared **bread** with each other at each meal. The Israelites ground up and roasted grain to make flour. Then the Israelites made bread by

1 Samuel 25:14–22

combining flour with oil to make a dough. Then the Israelites would bake this dough. People baked dough by slowly heating food at a high temperature to make it ready to eat. The Israelites made some kinds of bread with yeast, which made the bread grow bigger while baking. Israelites would make this kind of bread as loaves, or bigger chunks of bread to cut or tear apart for smaller pieces later. The process to make bread dough with yeast took a few days. Use the same word for bread that you used in previous passages.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of bread as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail also told her servants to prepare two large bags of wine. People called these kinds of containers "wineskins" since people typically made these out of the dried skin of animals.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of wineskins as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wineskins**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Abigail also told her servants to prepare the meat from five **sheep**. Use the same word for sheep that you used in previous passages.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail also told her servants to prepare two big containers of dry, **roasted grain**. People in those days often prepared the very top part of a type of grain, probably wheat or barley, by roasting this in an iron pan or on a rock over a fire. The top part of each piece of grain contains seeds that people could eat. When people roasted the top part of the grain, they could save the food since it stayed good to eat for a long time without having to cook it more. People in those days often used roasted grain as travel food. Armies of men also used roasted grain for food during fighting times. Use the same word or phrase for roasted grain that you used in previous passages.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of grain as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail also told her servants to prepare 100 handfuls of raisins. People in those days would take grapes, a fruit that makes wine, and dry the grapes in the sun. We call dried grapes "raisins." The Israelites often used this food for travel or for soldiers to eat during battle since it lasts for a while without the need to cook it more. Sometimes the people would soak the raisins in water and mix the raisins with grain to eat.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of raisins as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **raisins**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Abigail also told her servants to prepare 200 handfuls of ripe, dried figs. Figs are similar to raisins. The Israelites often used this food for travel or for soldiers to eat during battle since it lasts for a while without the need to cook it more.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of figs as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **figs**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Abigail told the servants to put all the food on the backs of **donkeys**. For more information on donkey, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for donkeys that you used in previous passages.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of donkeys carrying lots of supplies as a group. Pause this audio here.

David says that David did good things for Nabal, but Nabal did **evil** to David. Use the same word or phrase for evil as you used in previous passages. If needed, look up evil in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word for evil as you have used in previous passages.

David says that he hopes **God** will kill David if David does not kill every man in Nabal's **household** before morning. David uses the general word for God. Use the same words for God and household as you used in previous passages. If needed, look up God and household in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 25:14–22

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.1 MB)
- Setting the Stage (6.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (6.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.5 MB)

1 Samuel 25:23–38

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 25:23–38 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:23–38 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:23–38 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This true story happens after the last story when Nabal's wife, Abigail, sent her servants ahead of Abigail to meet David and David's men with a gift of food supplies. At the end of the last story, David had planned to kill Nabal and all the men in Nabal's household. Abigail rode a donkey behind her servants to go meet David. Suddenly, Abigail sees David.

Stop here and look at a picture of someone riding on the back of a donkey as a group. Pause this audio here.

In this story, as soon as Abigail sees David, Abigail quickly gets down from riding on the donkey's back. Abigail drops her body to the ground with her face towards the ground, in front of David. In those days, people bowed face down like this in front of someone to show respect and honor to the other person.

Abigail is still bowing to David when Abigail begins her long and respectful speech to David. Abigail says, "On me alone be the blame." In other words, Abigail says that Abigail will take the guilt or responsibility. Abigail is probably requesting that David place the blame on Abigail for Nabal's bad behavior. Abigail speaks very politely to David as if David is someone who has authority over Abigail. Abigail even calls herself David's servant.

Stop here and act out a situation as a group when one person asks a more powerful person to listen to something important. How does the person listening act? How does the person asking act? Pause this audio here.

Abigail calls David "my lord" again. Abigail asks David to please not pay attention to the worthless Nabal. Abigail calls Nabal worthless because Nabal has acted foolishly. Abigail also says that Nabal's name means a foolish person and that Nabal regularly acts foolishly.

Abigail then says that she did not meet "my lord's" young men directly. Abigail is calling David master again. Abigail is telling David that Abigail did not meet the messengers or young men whom David had sent to meet Nabal.

Abigail continues to very politely call David "my lord, or master," again. Then Abigail starts to make a very strong promise to Yahweh and to David. Abigail says that Yahweh has prevented David from two things. Yahweh has stopped David from killing innocent people and taking revenge for David's own self. But David has not said that David will not harm Nabal. Abigail is suggesting that Yahweh has caused Abigail to meet David to stop David from killing Nabal and all the men in Nabal's household. Nabal has done something bad to David, but Yahweh is stopping David from doing something bad back to Nabal.

Abigail once again refers to David as "my lord." Abigail says she hopes that anyone who purposefully tries to do bad things to David will "be like Nabal." This means that Abigail hopes that anyone who does bad things to David will, at some point in time, experience bad consequences or punishment. Yahweh has not punished Nabal yet, but Abigail expects that Yahweh will punish Nabal because Nabal acted foolishly or treated David badly.

Abigail then asked David to allow Abigail to give the "blessing," meaning the gift of food supplies, to the young men in David's army.

Abigail asks David to forgive her "rebellion." Another way to say this might be, "Please forgive me if I have done anything wrong." But Abigail had not done anything wrong. Perhaps Abigail is accepting Nabal's guilt for doing something bad to David. However, most likely, Abigail is speaking politely and asks David to forgive Abigail for continuing to speak. In other words, Abigail is humbly asking David's permission for Abigail to continue speaking.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when someone who was not important in the community begged a respected leader to do something. Pause this audio here.

Abigail says that Yahweh will make a house that lasts forever for "my lord." Abigail means that she believes Yahweh will make David's house, or David's descendants, the leaders of Israel for many generations, or for a long time. Abigail thinks that Yahweh will do this because David, whom Abigail again calls "my lord," is fighting Yahweh's battles, and Abigail hopes that David will not do evil things during David's lifetime.

Abigail then talks about her hope that Yahweh will punish anyone who might start to chase David to kill David. Then Abigail talks about Yahweh keeping David in the "bundle" or "pouch" of the living. In those days, people often kept small, valuable items in a pouch or a small bag that someone could carry with them. Abigail hopes Yahweh keeps David alive, just like a person guards a valuable treasure. But, Abigail hopes Yahweh will quickly

kill David's enemies just as fast as a person throws a rock very quickly and very far from out of the pouch of a sling.

Stop here and look at a picture of a rock in a sling as a group. Pause this audio here.

If available: Stop here and look at a video of someone throwing a stone from a sling as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail tells David that she knows that Yahweh will complete all the good things that Yahweh has planned for "my lord," or David. Abigail also says that Yahweh will definitely make David the future leader of Israel. Abigail tells David that she knows David will not have grief or a guilty conscience because David chose not to needlessly kill innocent people or to take revenge for David's own self. Abigail requests that David remember Abigail, "your female servant," when David officially starts to lead Israel. Abigail is asking David to remember what Abigail had done to stop David from killing innocent people for revenge. Abigail is also asking David to show Abigail kindness when David begins to lead Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group. What makes an honest and good leader in your culture? Why do you think it is important that David did not kill innocent people for revenge? Pause this audio here.

Abigail finishes speaking, and David responds to Abigail. David praises Yahweh, God of Israel. David says that Yahweh sent Abigail on that day to meet David. Then David blesses Abigail and thanks her for her wise actions. David says that Abigail's actions stopped David from killing innocent people that day because David no longer plans to take revenge for himself.

David continues to tell Abigail that Yahweh, God of Israel, stopped David from doing evil to Abigail. This means that Yahweh stopped David from killing all the men in Nabal's house, including Abigail's husband, Nabal. David tells Abigail that, if Abigail had not quickly come to meet David, David would have killed Nabal and all the men in Nabal's household before sunrise the next morning.

David accepts the food gifts that Abigail brought for David's men. Abigail has her servants give all the food to the men in David's army. Then David tells Abigail to go back up the hill to Abigail's house in peace. David means that David will not do anything to hurt Abigail or the people in Abigail's household. David tells Abigail, "I have listened to you and I will do what you asked."

Then Abigail returns to her household to go talk to Nabal. Abigail sees that Nabal is hosting a big feast, like a king might host. Abigail sees that Nabal acts very cheerfully because Nabal has been drinking too much wine at the feast. So, Abigail decides not to tell Nabal about what happened with David until the next morning.

In the morning, Nabal has recovered from being drunk. So, Abigail explains to Nabal about what happened with David. Right away, Nabal becomes so sick that Nabal becomes as still as a rock. Ten days later, Yahweh takes away Nabal's life.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:23–38 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Abigail pleads with David on behalf of the people in Abigail's household. Abigail gives a gift of food to David and the men in David's army.

In the second scene: David answers Abigail and agrees not to harm Abigail's household.

In the second scene: Abigail returns to find Nabal drunk at Nabal's own feast. Abigail waits until the morning to tell Nabal what happened with David. When Nabal hears about this, Nabal gets so sick that Nabal is as still as a rock. Then, ten days later, Yahweh takes Nabal's life.

The characters in this passage are:

- Abigail, along with Abigail's servants who helped Abigail deliver the food gifts to David
- David
- David's men
- Yahweh, God of Israel
- Nabal
- And the people who celebrated with Nabal during Nabal's feast

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Abigail gave a very long and respectful speech to David. Abigail used very humble and polite words throughout her speech. When Abigail saw David, Abigail quickly got down from riding on the back of her donkey. Abigail purposefully and humbly fell down with her face to the ground in front of David to show respect to David. Abigail "fell at David's feet." Abigail did not trip and fall. This means that Abigail bowed close, in front of David. Abigail put her head close to David's feet as David looked at Abigail. The storyteller tells us twice, with different words, that Abigail bowed before David. We do not know if Abigail bowed once or twice. Abigail may have bowed down to David a first time and then moved closer to David to bow again. Or, possibly, Abigail may have bowed only once, but the storyteller just said the information twice. We do know that Abigail is still bowing to David the whole time Abigail gives her speech to David. Abigail calls David, "my lord," meaning "master." Abigail is using a title for David that shows Abigail knows David has authority over Abigail and that Abigail is showing respect for David. Abigail even calls herself David's "servant." Then Abigail asks David to please listen to what Abigail has to say. Abigail says that she would take the responsibility or the blame for the evil that Nabal had done to David. Abigail will call David "my lord" and will call herself David's "female servant" many times in this story. Abigail does not say "I" but, instead, calls herself David's female servant.

Abigail politely asks David for permission to speak to David. Abigail asks David if she can speak to David's "ears;" in other words, Abigail asks David to listen to what Abigail will say. This does not mean Abigail is talking directly to David's ear, like a whisper. It just means that Abigail wants David to listen.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about how an unimportant person begs an important person to do something in your culture. Talk about how you will translate Abigail's speech to David as she uses titles like "my lord" to address David and "your servant" to talk about herself. Pause this audio here.

Abigail asks David not to pay attention to, or to ignore, this "worthless man," Nabal. Here, the phrase "worthless man" shows that Abigail knows that Nabal does not tend to make decisions that honor Yahweh. Abigail says that the name Nabal means fool. So, Nabal's name fits Nabal well because Nabal certainly acts like a fool. People who act foolishly do not follow God. When people continue to act foolishly, bad consequences come, and Yahweh punishes those people.

Abigail calls David "my lord" again. Abigail does this when she tells David that Abigail did not see the messengers David had sent to Nabal.

Abigail again calls David "my lord" and changes her speech to show that Abigail is going to say her main point. Abigail says that Yahweh has stopped David from killing innocent people by taking revenge. Abigail then says that she hopes that any of David's enemies who want to do something evil to "my lord," meaning David, will have a fate like Nabal's fate. Abigail knows that Yahweh will somehow punish Nabal for Nabal's foolish actions. Abigail stresses this point by saying an oath, or a strong promise, to Yahweh and to David. Abigail does this by saying, "As Yahweh lives and your soul lives." Abigail is saying, "I will absolutely keep my promise. If I do not, Yahweh may punish me."

Stop here and discuss as a group some ways that someone can make a strong promise in your language. Pause this audio here.

Abigail continues to talk to David. Abigail says that Yahweh has stopped David from killing innocent people by taking revenge. Abigail then says that she hopes that any of David's enemies who want to do something evil to "my lord," meaning David, will have a fate like Nabal's fate. Abigail knows that Yahweh will somehow punish Nabal for Nabal's foolish actions.

Abigail continues to speak politely to David. Abigail asks David to forgive her for continuing to speak. Probably this means that Abigail is asking David for permission to keep speaking to David. Abigail says that she knows

Yahweh will make “my lord,” meaning David, to have a household or family that continues for many generations as leaders. Abigail talks about David having a sure or enduring house. This means that Yahweh will allow David’s descendants to rule Israel. Here, “house” or “household” refers to David and David’s future descendants.

Stop here as a group and talk about people you know who have ruled as leaders for many generations. How is this the same or different from David and David’s descendants leading for generations? Pause this audio here.

Abigail says the reason why she believes Yahweh will make David and David’s descendants leaders. Abigail says this is because “my lord,” meaning David, is fighting the battles of Yahweh. In other words, Abigail is saying that David has fought battles as an Israelite against people in other nations who oppose Yahweh. Also, Abigail says that David will not do evil things during David’s lifetime.

Abigail continues talking and shares her hope that, if anyone tries to kill David, Yahweh, David’s God, will keep David alive. Abigail says this by saying that she hopes Yahweh will tie up the life of “my lord,” meaning David, with the “pouch of the living.” In those days, people often kept a valuable item in a special pouch in order to keep the item safe. So, Abigail is saying that she hopes Yahweh will keep David alive and safe because Yahweh protects David like a valuable treasure.

Stop here and look at a drawing of a pouch for keeping valuable items. Abigail means that Yahweh will watch over or protect David. Discuss as a group how you will describe in your language that Yahweh will watch over or protect David. Pause this audio here.

Abigail also says that she hopes that Yahweh will throw out the lives of David’s enemies like a person throws stones far and fast from the middle of a sling. A sling is a simple weapon that people made of a piece of cloth with two long cord strings on each side of the cloth. In those days, people used a sling as a weapon to throw stones at a person or animal who threatened them when that person or animal was too far to fight by hand.

Stop here and look at a picture of a rock in a sling. Then discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sling**. If you have already translated this word or phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Abigail says that Yahweh will do all the good things that Yahweh had said Yahweh would do for “my lord,” meaning David. Abigail says this includes Yahweh appointing David as the official ruler of Israel. Abigail says that David will not be sad or have a bad conscience as Israel’s leader because David will choose not to kill out of revenge.

Finally, Abigail finishes her speech to David. Abigail asks David to remember Abigail when Yahweh does these good things to “my lord,” meaning David. Abigail is asking David to show “your female servant,” meaning Abigail, kindness when David becomes the ruler of Israel.

In the second scene, David responds to Abigail. First of all, David praises Yahweh, God of Israel, for sending Abigail at that time to meet David. Then David says a blessing about how Abigail’s wisdom stopped David from killing just for revenge. In other words, David is showing thanks to Yahweh and to Abigail.

David starts his next sentence saying, “But, as Yahweh God of Israel lives.” David is saying that what David is about to say is just as true as the fact that Yahweh lives. David continues to say that Yahweh stopped David from causing harm to Abigail. David explains to Abigail that, if Abigail had not quickly come to meet David, David and David’s men would have followed David’s plan to kill every one of the males in Nabal’s household before the next morning.

Then David accepts the food gifts from Abigail’s hand, meaning that David accepts these things from Abigail. David tells Abigail to “Go back up to your house in peace. I have listened to you and I will do what you ask.” David is telling Abigail that David and David’s men would not harm anyone in Abigail’s household.

So, Abigail goes to find Nabal. The storyteller now uses language to show that something important is about to happen as Abigail goes to find Nabal. Nabal is hosting a huge feast, like what a king would host, and Nabal has a “happy heart” from drinking too much wine.

Stop here and act out a scene when someone is very happy and very drunk. Then take turns describing this person in your language. Pause this audio here.

Abigail decides to wait until the morning to talk with Nabal about what happened with David, since Nabal would recover from being drunk by morning.

In the morning, Nabal has recovered from being drunk, so Abigail, Nabal's wife, tells Nabal what happened with David. Right away, Nabal's "heart died," and Nabal's body became as hard as a rock. This does not mean that Nabal dies. It means that Nabal somehow instantly became so ill that Nabal could not even move.

Then, about ten days later, Yahweh "strikes" Nabal dead. This means that Yahweh quickly takes away Nabal's life at that time, and Nabal dies. Often, the word "strike" means to hit someone. Here, the word struck does not mean that Yahweh hit Nabal. In this story, struck means that Yahweh caused Nabal to die. Yahweh did this as a consequence for Nabal's foolish actions.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for this meaning of **strike**. If you have already translated this word or phrase with the same meaning in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:23–38 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Abigail, along with Abigail's servants who helped Abigail deliver the food gifts to David
- David
- David's men
- Yahweh, God of Israel
- Nabal
- And the people who celebrated with Nabal during Nabal's feast

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

As soon as Nabal's wife, Abigail, sees David, Abigail hurries to get down off her donkey so that Abigail can bow face down on the ground in front of David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Abigail, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am terrified to approach David's army of 400 men with swords when I have no way to defend myself. I might even die; or
- I know my husband Nabal acted foolishly and rudely to David. I am sure that David is planning to do something bad back to Nabal. But I think David might listen to me and change his mind; or
- I see David coming with David's army of men. I am afraid that the people I love will die because of what my husband did; or
- I will gladly accept my husband's guilt so that David will not take revenge on our household; or

- I hope that David will accept the gifts I have prepared for David and David's men. Perhaps David will stop being so angry.

Continue the drama. Abigail stays down in a bowing position and pleads with David to listen to what Abigail has to say. Abigail asks David not to pay attention to Nabal because Nabal acted foolishly. Abigail also tells David that Abigail did not see the messengers that David had sent to Nabal. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so angry with Nabal for acting so rudely to me, and I want to kill Nabal and all the men in Nabal's household. I do not plan to kill the women. I will listen to what this woman has to say; or
- This woman is showing a lot of bravery, respect, and humility. Also, the woman told me that she did not participate in acting rudely to my messengers. I want to hear what she will say.

Continue the drama. Abigail tells David that Yahweh is stopping David from killing innocent people through revenge. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Wow, I was not thinking about what Yahweh wanted me to do! I should pay attention to think about what Yahweh wants and not just what I want; or
- This woman is right. I am thinking only about revenge. Revenge is an evil reason to kill people; or
- When I wanted to kill Nabal for revenge, I did not think about the future consequences I would have when I became the ruler of Israel. Leaders should not act in revenge.

Continue the drama. Abigail shares her hope that anyone who tries to do evil to David will have a bad consequence, as Abigail knows Nabal will soon have. Then Abigail asks David to accept the food gifts that Abigail brought for David's army of men. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Abigail, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know that Yahweh punishes foolish people who do evil things. I need to remind David that Yahweh will make sure Nabal will have a bad consequence. David should not take revenge for himself; or
- I want to show honor to David as a future leader by giving these gifts; or
- I hope that David will see that I am paying David back something good in return for the good that David had done before by protecting our shepherds and flocks.

Continue the drama. Abigail says that Yahweh will definitely make David's household rulers for a long time. Abigail says that Yahweh will do this because David is fighting Yahweh's battles and that David will not do evil things during David's life. Abigail also talks about how Yahweh, David's God, will protect David's life and kill David's enemies. Abigail says that, when Yahweh makes David the ruler of Israel, David will not be sad or have a bad conscience because David will not kill innocent people in an act of revenge. Abigail also asks David to remember to show her kindness when Yahweh makes David the King of Israel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh, through Samuel, already chose me as the future king of Israel. I have fought many battles for Yahweh and for Israel. But I have faced so many difficulties, including King Saul trying to kill me many times. Also, the men in my army have had little food to eat in the wilderness. I do not see much evidence that I will start to be king soon. I am so tired, and I struggle to have hope. This woman has reminded me that Yahweh will keep Yahweh's promise; or
- I was planning to do something evil to Nabal and the men in Nabal's household. But, if I want to follow Yahweh, I have to fight Yahweh's battles, not my own battles for revenge; or
- I have to trust that Yahweh will punish the people who do evil things to me. I should not try to do Yahweh's job. I am not Yahweh; or
- This woman is right, as the future leader, I cannot do something evil like killing all the men in Nabal's household for revenge. I would always have a guilty conscience if I did that evil thing; or
- This woman is so wise. Yahweh sent this woman to stop me from doing something very evil.

Continue the drama. David answers Abigail by praising Yahweh for sending Abigail to meet David. David thanks Abigail for her wise actions that kept David from David's plan of murder and revenge. David tells Abigail that David had planned to kill all the men in Nabal's household before the morning. Instead, David chooses not to

kill these men. David accepts the food gift from Abigail. David tells Abigail to return home in peace. David had listened to Abigail and so no longer plans to kill anyone in Nabal's household. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Abigail, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so grateful to Yahweh! I had guessed that David would do something evil back to Nabal. Now I know for sure that David planned to do that. Thank you, Yahweh, that David has changed his mind! or
- I need to tell Nabal that Yahweh spared Nabal's life.

Continue the drama. Abigail goes to find Nabal. Abigail sees Nabal very happily drunk at Nabal's big feast. So, Abigail decides to wait to tell Nabal about what happened with David in the morning. Nabal recovers from drunkenness in the morning. So, Abigail tells Nabal what happened. Nabal instantly gets so sick that Nabal's body is as still as a rock. Around ten days later, Yahweh takes Nabal's life, so that Nabal dies. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Nabal, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy to have this big feast. Look at all I have. I am a very wealthy businessman. I have a great life, and I can do whatever I want to do; or
- I am so angry that my wife gave so much of my food to David! or
- I am scared because David almost came to kill us; or
- I am very sick. I know I will die.

Ask the person playing Abigail, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Nabal has eaten too much and drunk too much wine. David and David's men had little access to food, and they were hungry. Nabal had plenty of food to give to David, but Nabal selfishly kept the food. David is the true, future king, but Nabal acts like Nabal is a king; or
- Nabal already does not listen well. I have to wait until Nabal recovers from drunkenness to talk with Nabal; or
- Yahweh is punishing Nabal for Nabal's foolishness; or
- Now Nabal has the consequences for acting foolishly. Yahweh has taken Nabal's life.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:23–38 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Abigail had been riding her **donkey**. When Abigail sees David, she gets off the back of the donkey. Translate donkey the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on donkey, refer to the Master Glossary.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of a donkey as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abigail **bows** low with her face to the ground in front of David. Abigail bowing down like this shows respect to David and humility from Abigail. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about bow, and use the same word for bow that you have used in previous passages.

Abigail calls David "my **lord**." This means "my master." A lord is a man who is a master over other people, who has full authority, and who deserves for people to give him respect. When you call someone "lord," you are saying that this person has authority over you. When Abigail uses the word lord, Abigail is showing humility for herself and is giving respect to David. Some translations may also say "sir" instead of "you" to show the same meaning as "lord." Use the same word for lord here that you have used previously when lord means master. The word lord is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for lord that you used in previous passages.

Abigail calls herself David's maidservant or female **servant**. Usually, a servant is a man or woman who works for another person, the master. Servants have low status in the community and must obey the master. Abigail was not David's servant. Abigail had married a rich farmer, so Abigail had high status in the community. Abigail humbly calls herself David's servant to show respect to David. Look up servant in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word for servant as you have used in previous passages.

Abigail says that Nabal's name means foolishness or folly. Then Abigail hopes that David's enemies will experience folly, like Nabal. A **fool**, or a person who acts foolishly, eventually experiences folly, meaning bad results or consequences because of bad behavior. A foolish person usually acts selfishly by treating other people badly

and not following God. Abigail hoped that anyone who tried to hurt David would experience bad consequences for their folly.

Abigail and David both talk about **Yahweh**. Yahweh is **God's** proper name, the Israelites' personal name for God. Use the same general word for God and the same name for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on God and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Abigail talks about the people who may plan to act evilly toward David. Abigail also says that David will not do **evil** if David fights for Yahweh instead of fighting for David. Evil means that people decide for themselves what they can and cannot do instead of obeying God. Evil is always bad, the opposite of good. People who act evilly think that they know better than God. Use the same word for evil as you used in previous passages. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary.

Abigail says that Yahweh kept David from unnecessary killing, or bloodshed, and from avenging, or taking revenge for, himself. David also talks about this. From previous stories, we know that Yahweh does not want the Israelites to allow bloodshed because Yahweh is holy. Yahweh is set apart from all evil, and Yahweh lives with the Israelites. Someone who takes revenge for themselves imposes a punishment on another person or group of people as a type of payment for the suffering or loss that this other person caused the first person. Taking revenge for yourself means that you do not trust God to provide justice for you. People who take revenge have not shown grace or forgiveness to others. With forgiveness, the people can restore the relationship between the two groups and remove guilt. With revenge, the person who takes revenge for himself causes more harm and wrongdoing.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **revenge** and **bloodshed**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Abigail gives a blessing or gift to David. Here, Abigail means the food and wine that Abigail had prepared for the men in David's army. Note that Abigail did not try to bribe David with this gift. Abigail was honoring David through the gift.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **blessing** or **gift**. Here, blessing is another way to talk about a gift, because Abigail means for the gift to bless, or do good to, David and David's men. You may either use the same word for blessing that you have used in previous passages, or you may use a word for gift. If needed, refer to the Master Glossary for more information about bless. Pause this audio here.

Abigail asks David to forgive her rebellion or transgression. Rebellion is when someone does something against someone in authority. Similarly, transgression is when someone does something that goes against the rules of someone in authority. Here, Abigail is showing respect by talking with David.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **rebellion**. Pause this audio here.

Later in this story, David tells Abigail to go in **peace** back to her **house**. Here, David means that David will not attack the people in Abigail's household. Look up household and peace in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same words for peace and household that you have used in previous passages.

Abigail says that Yahweh will **appoint** David as ruler over **Israel** in the future. David talks about Yahweh God of Israel. Here, to appoint means God will assign a job or role to David and give David authority through that role as the leader of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for appoint as you used in previous passages. Use the same word for Israel that you have used in previous passages, and remember that Israel is in the Master Glossary.

Abigail prays that David will not have a troubled **heart** because he commits bloodshed and takes revenge on Nabal. Later in the story, the storyteller describes Nabal as having a happy heart because Nabal felt happy when Nabal drank too much wine. Then, after Abigail tells Nabal what happened with David, Nabal's heart died. In these examples, the heart refers to the person's thoughts, feelings, and will. Use the same word for heart as you used in previous passages. For more information on heart, refer to the Master Glossary.

David **blesses** Yahweh, God of Israel. Here, David is thanking and giving praise to Yahweh for stopping David from doing an evil thing. David also blesses Abigail for her wise discernment. Here, David is thanking Abigail and praying that God will do good things for Abigail. Use the same word for bless that you have used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for a full definition of bless.

Nabal hosted a banquet or a feast to celebrate with other people during the animal shearing time for Nabal's business. When someone hosts a feast, the host usually provides a very large meal as a way to celebrate something. Nabal also drinks so much wine at the feast that the word the storyteller used for feast actually refers to drinking lots and lots of wine.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **feast**. If you have already translated this word or phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 25:23–38

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)
- Setting the Stage (7.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (10.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (7.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (7.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.5 MB)

1 Samuel 25:39–44

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 25:39–44 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:39–44 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:39–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This true story happens after Yahweh caused Nabal, Abigail's husband, to die. So Abigail became a widow, or a woman whose husband had died. We know from a previous story that Nabal had a business in the town of Carmel. So, in this story, Abigail was still in Carmel after her husband Nabal died. David and David's men probably had returned to their army camp somewhere in the wilderness nearby.

Stop here and look at the map that includes Carmel as a group. Pause this audio here.

In this story, someone had told David that Nabal had died. So, David praises Yahweh. David says that Yahweh has avenged David for Nabal's insult against David. To avenge is to punish someone for something that person did wrong to someone else. Then David says that Yahweh had stopped David from doing something evil. David says that Yahweh justly punished Nabal for the evil Nabal had done. David understood that it was Yahweh's job to avenge people. Therefore, Yahweh had acted mercifully to David by keeping David from doing something wrong by trying to avenge himself.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone did something bad and then received a punishment for the wrong thing they did. Pause this audio here.

Then David sends messengers to Carmel to talk to Abigail. The messengers tell Abigail that David sent the messengers to ask Abigail to marry David. Abigail quickly bows her face down to the ground in front of David's messengers. Abigail is showing respect for David by showing respect to David's messengers. Abigail speaks to David's messengers as though Abigail were talking to David. Abigail says that Abigail will serve David by washing David's messengers' feet. In those days, people typically wore shoes on their feet that had openings where dirt and dust could easily enter. The person wearing the shoes had very dusty and dirty feet. In those days, a person hosting guests would provide a bowl-like container of water for the guests to wash their own feet. The host would have also provided some kind of cloth to dry the guests' feet. Abigail could have simply offered water for David's messengers to wash their own feet. Or, Abigail could have asked one of Abigail's servants to wash David's messengers' feet. Abigail chose to wash the very dirty feet of these men by herself to show that Abigail wanted to serve David. So, Abigail is showing her willingness to marry David through humbly serving David's messengers.

Stop here as a group and act out someone important doing a job that normally someone with low status would do. Discuss as a group: What would you think if you saw a leader from your community doing this? How is this the same or different from what Abigail did? Pause this audio here.

Then Abigail quickly gets on the back of Abigail's donkey to ride to the place where Abigail will marry David. Five young women, Abigail's female servants, walk behind Abigail to go with Abigail to meet David. In those days, other women often went with a bride to the groom's house, where the bride and groom would get married. Abigail and these young women follow David's messengers back to David. Then Abigail marries David.

Stop here and look at a picture of someone riding on the back of a donkey as a group. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that David also married Ahinoam from the town of Jezreel in Judah's territory. Though we do not know the exact location of Jezreel, we do know that it was in the hill country near the towns of Maon and Carmel.

Stop here and look at the map that includes Jezreel as a group. Pause this audio here.

We do not know for sure when David married Ahinoam, but possibly, David married Ahinoam before marrying Abigail. So, both Ahinoam and Abigail became David's wives. Although David now had more than one wife, David probably treated Ahinoam and Abigail equally, or as having the same rights. In those days, people accepted when

men married more than one woman. Leaders, especially, might marry more than one wife to gain support from the people who lived in the areas where each wife lived. Both Ahinoam and Abigail came from the area of Judah, so David likely gained support from people in Judah by marrying these women. Also, sometimes a man would marry a widow to take care of the widow. In that culture, women did not have the same rights as a man. A new husband would protect and provide for the widow.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, do men have more than one wife? How would you describe wives who have the same rights as other women who are married to the same man? In some cultures, men cannot have more than one wife at a time. If your culture is like this, discuss how you will translate that David had more than one wife. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also tells us what happened with David's first wife, Michal. We know from previous stories that David had married King Saul's daughter, Michal. We also know that Saul hated David. Saul felt jealous of David because Saul knew Yahweh wanted David to become king.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How would a man in your culture feel if someone forced the man's current wife to marry someone else against the first man's will? Pause this audio here.

Michal's second husband, Palti or "Paltiel," whose father was Laish, comes from the town of Gallim. We do not know Gallim's exact location, but Gallim was most likely less than one hour north of Jerusalem and less than one hour south of Gibeah, where Saul lives.

Stop here and look at the map that includes Gallim as a group.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:39–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: David praises Yahweh for avenging David and punishing Nabal for the evil Nabal did.

In the second scene: David sends messengers to Abigail to ask Abigail to marry David.

In the third scene: David marries Abigail. We also learn information about two of David's other wives, Ahinoam and Michal.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Yahweh
- Nabal
- David's messengers
- Abigail
- The five young women who went with Abigail as Abigail went to marry David
- David's wife, Ahinoam
- Saul, who was David's father-in-law and Michal's father
- David's wife, Michal
- And Palti or Paltiel, the man who married Michal

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, someone had told David that Nabal had died. So, David blesses Yahweh. This means that David thanks or praises Yahweh. David says that Yahweh had "pleaded David's case" or spoken in David's favor. The words David uses are like Yahweh acted as a judge in a courtroom who both protects an innocent person's rights and punishes the guilty person. David says that David received disgrace or shame from Nabal's hand, meaning Nabal acted towards David in a very rude, shameful way. David then says that Yahweh had stopped Yahweh's servant, meaning David, before David did an evil thing to Nabal. In those days, sometimes people talked about

1 Samuel 25:39–44

themselves as Yahweh's servant instead of saying, "I am the servant." David then talks about the fact that Yahweh punished Nabal. David says that Yahweh made the evil that Nabal did to David return on Nabal's own "head." This is special language that just means that Nabal now has the consequences of that evil instead of David. In other words, Yahweh had punished Nabal for the wrong that Nabal had done to David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Who in your culture acts like a judge to decide when people are innocent or guilty? Tell a true story about a judge who punished a guilty person in a right, or just, way. What happened? How did the person whom the guilty person harmed respond to the guilty person's punishment? Pay attention to the words you use to describe this. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, David sends messengers to ask Abigail to marry David. David's messengers, or servants, arrive at Carmel, where Abigail is staying. David's messengers tell Abigail, "David sent us to you to take you to him as his wife." This does not mean that David is forcing or kidnapping Abigail to marry David. This is David's way of asking Abigail to marry David.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do people decide marriages? What words or phrases do people use when they want to ask someone else to agree to a marriage? Act out this scene using each of those different words and phrases. Which words or phrases do you think that David or David's messengers may have said? Pause this audio here.

Abigail quickly bows down with her face to the ground in the same way Abigail did in the previous story. Then Abigail uses language that shows she is about to say something important. Abigail talks to the messengers as though Abigail were talking directly to David. Abigail calls herself David's female servant. Abigail says that Abigail will act as a servant by washing the feet of "my lord's servants," meaning David's messengers. When Abigail calls David "my lord," Abigail is calling David her master. Abigail does all these things to show that Abigail is very willing to marry David.

In the third scene, Abigail quickly goes to meet David. Abigail rides on the back of a donkey to go to David. Five young women, likely Abigail's closest servants, walk along with Abigail while Abigail rides on the donkey. Abigail and the five young women follow David's messengers back to the place where David is staying. Then Abigail marries David.

The storyteller tells us that David also married a woman named Ahinoam from the town of Jezreel. So, David had two new wives, Ahinoam and Abigail.

The storyteller uses language that shows that what the storyteller is about to say happened before David married Abigail. Saul had made Saul's daughter, Michal, marry another man named Palti. The storyteller does not say that David is still married to Michal, but we know this is true. The storyteller tells us the name of Palti's father, Laish. Palti comes from the town of Gallim.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:39–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Yahweh
- Nabal
- David's messengers
- Abigail
- The five young women who went with Abigail as Abigail went to marry David
- David's wife, Ahinoam
- Saul, who was David's father-in-law and Michal's father

- David's wife, Michal
- And Palti or Paltiel, the man who married Michal

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, David learns from someone that Nabal died. David praises Yahweh for avenging David, stopping David from doing something evil and for punishing Nabal. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Wow, Yahweh, thank you for doing good things for me! or
- I must praise Yahweh! Yahweh both kept me from doing something evil by taking revenge on Nabal and punished Nabal for the evil Nabal did; or
- Yes, Nabal deserved to die! or
- Yahweh not only saved me from the guilt of doing evil for my own purposes but also did good things for me because I obeyed Yahweh.

Continue the drama. Then, in the second scene, David sends messengers to Carmel to ask Abigail to marry David. The messengers say David's message to Abigail. Abigail responds by bowing and washing the messengers' feet. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Abigail, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Wow! Yahweh is taking care of me by providing a new husband; or
- I cannot wait to marry David. My husband Nabal was a worthless fool, but David has shown wisdom by obeying Yahweh; or
- Before Nabal died, I asked David to show kindness to me when David becomes the ruler of Israel. David is already showing kindness to me. I am so grateful! or
- I will do anything for David!

Ask the person or group playing David's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Abigail has shown a lot of humility. Abigail is a wealthy woman, but Abigail has even chosen to wash our dirty feet like a servant. This beautiful and wise woman will make a great wife for David.

Continue the drama. In the third scene, Abigail marries David. Abigail rides a donkey, and five young women, likely Abigail's female servants, walk behind Abigail to go with David's messengers to meet David. Abigail marries David. The storyteller tells us that David also married Ahinoam from Jezreel, another part of the territory of Judah. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have a wise wife, Abigail; or
- Perhaps the family and friends of Ahinoam and Abigail here in Judah will also support me.

Continue the drama. The storyteller tells us something that happened with David's wife, Michal, sometime before David married Abigail and Ahinoam. Saul, Michal's father, made Michal marry another man while Michal was still married to David. Michal's new husband's name is Palti or Paltiel. Palti, Laish's son, comes from the town of Gallim. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hate David and am afraid that David will take my kingdom from me. As my son-in-law, David might try to say that David has the right to take over my kingdom. So, if I make Michal marry someone else, David will not have any claim to try to become king; or
- This will weaken David's power.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very angry and hurt that Saul would treat me like this! or
- I had the opportunity in the past to kill Saul and take the kingdom, but I did not do it because I obeyed Yahweh; or
- I miss my wife, Michal, and I do not want Michal to marry someone else; or
- I want my wife, Michal, back. Michal and I are still married. Saul cannot legally do this.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Michal, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have to obey my father, King Saul; or
- I am sad that I am still married to David, but my king and father is making me marry another man; or
- Women here do not marry more than one man at a time. This is a very strange thing for me to do. I feel like my father forced me into this second marriage; or
- What will happen between me and David now? or
- What will people think about me for doing this strange thing?

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 25:39–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

David learns that Nabal died. David **blesses Yahweh**, the God of Israel. Yahweh is the personal name for God. David is thanking or giving praise to Yahweh for justly punishing Nabal and for stopping David from doing an **evil** thing. Use the same word for Yahweh and bless that you have used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for a full definition of Yahweh and bless. Evil means that people decide for themselves what they can and cannot do instead of obeying God. Evil is always bad, the opposite of good. People who act in an evil way think that they know better than God. Nabal had done something evil to David. A person who does evil willingly does bad things to hurt other people. Use the same word for evil as you used in previous passages. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary.

David's messengers tell Abigail that David wants to marry Abigail. Abigail responds and calls herself David's maidservant or female **servant**. A servant is someone who works for another person. Here, Abigail is humbly calling herself David's female servant to show respect to David. Abigail offers to wash the feet of David's servants. The word "servants" here is different than the word Abigail uses, which means "female servant." Here, servants refer to David's messengers, men who worked for David whom David trusted to deliver David's message. In fact, at the end of this passage, the storyteller just calls these men David's messengers. Look up servant in the Master Glossary for more information, and if you use the word "servant," use the same word for servant as you have used in previous passages.

Abigail also calls David, "my **lord**." This means "my master." A lord is a man who is a master over other people, who has full authority, and who deserves for people to give that man respect. When you call someone "lord," you are saying that this person has authority over you. When Abigail uses the word lord, Abigail is showing respect to David. Use the same word for lord here that you have used previously when lord means master. The word lord is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for lord that you used in previous passages.

Abigail quickly goes with David's messengers so that Abigail can marry David. Abigail rides on the back of a **donkey** to go to David. Translate donkey the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on donkey, refer to the Master Glossary.

If necessary, stop here and look at a picture of a donkey as a group.

Speaking the Word
Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 25:39–44

Audio Content
- Hear and Heart (977 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.5 MB)

1 Samuel 26:1–12

Hear and Heart
In this step, hear 1 Samuel 26:1–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:1–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage
Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Nabal wronged David and David's men. David went with his men to kill Nabal. But Abigail, Nabal's wife, met David on the road and begged David not to kill Nabal. David agreed not to kill Nabal. But Nabal later died. David married Abigail. David also married Ahinoam of Jezreel. Saul gave Saul's daughter, Michal, to another man to be that man's wife, even though Michal was married to David.

In this passage, Saul decides to chase David again. You will remember that David and David's band of followers have been hiding from Saul because Saul was trying to kill David. When David spared Saul's life in an earlier story, Saul showed that Saul was sad about chasing David. Some time has passed, and now Saul again chases David to try to kill David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Share about a time when someone wronged you and apologized, but then did the same hurtful thing later. How did you feel? Pause this audio here.

The Ziphites go to Saul's hometown of Gibeah to tell Saul where David is hiding. You will remember that the Ziphites had previously come to Saul and told Saul about David's hiding place. The Ziphites are Israelites from the tribe of Judah from the nearby area of Ziph. Probably only some of the Ziphites went to Gibeah to share this information with Saul. The Ziphites told Saul that David was hiding on the hill of Hakilah, which overlooks Jeshimon. Jeshimon means wasteland. Many translations translate the hill of Hakilah as "east of Jeshimon," but it could also mean "facing Jeshimon." Others translate the hill of Hakilah more vaguely as "near Jeshimon."

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Gibeah in relation to Ziph, the hill of Hakilah, and Jeshimon. Pause this audio here.

After hearing what the Ziphites say, Saul takes 3,000 special soldiers to pursue David in the wilderness. Saul chooses these men because they are elite or the most fit. Saul leaves the comforts of his home to go into the wilderness after David. Saul feels that David's presence threatens Saul, so Saul is willing to go into such a harsh location to chase David, and to take 3,000 elite men to fight just a few hundred of David's men. Saul and the 3,000 soldiers camp at the hill of Hakilah, where the Ziphites told Saul that David would be. David is in the wilderness with the group of soldiers who are loyal to David.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a wilderness. Pause this audio here.

David discovers or sees that Saul is chasing David, and David sends scouts or spies to find Saul's camp. David goes to Saul's camp. David is probably hiding with some of David's men in a place where they can see Saul's camp. David sees that Saul and Abner, son of Ner, the commander of Saul's army, are sleeping. Saul is lying in the middle of the camp with Saul's men around Saul. The men are also sleeping. David asks for one volunteer to go with David into Saul's camp, either Ahimelek or Abishai. Ahimelek is silent, but Abishai volunteers to go with David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some dangerous jobs or tasks that people in your culture might have to do? How do you choose people to do these dangerous tasks? Pause this audio here.

This is the only place that Scripture mentions Ahimelek the Hittite. You will remember that the Hittites were one of the Canaanite groups that Yahweh commanded Israel to destroy. Ahimelek is probably a descendant of those Hittites that the Israelites did not destroy.

Abishai is the brother of Joab and the son of Zeruiah. Zeruiah is Abishai's mother. In that time, people in that culture usually identified someone by who the person's father was. But here, the storyteller identifies Abishai by who Abishai's mother was.

David and Abishai sneak past the encampment of soldiers at night to where Saul sleeps, along with Saul's commander, Abner. Saul's spear is stuck in the ground by Saul's head. Saul's spear would have been a royal spear that identified Saul as the king.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a royal spearhead in David's time. Pause this audio here.

An encampment is a place where an army would stop to rest and set up their sleeping places in a circle for protection.

Abishai, who likely whispers, tells David, “Today God has delivered your enemy into your hands.” Abishai is encouraging David that God has given David the opportunity to kill David’s enemy, even this very night. Abishai wants to use a spear, probably Saul’s spear, to kill Saul. Abishai tells David that Abishai will not have to strike Saul twice with Saul’s spear, meaning that Abishai’s first thrust of the spear would be enough to kill Saul.

David will not let Abishai kill Saul. David asks Abishai who could be innocent if they killed Yahweh’s anointed king. David did not mean for Abishai to answer this question. Rather, this question emphasizes that David believes he would be guilty before Yahweh if David or Abishai killed Saul. You will remember from an earlier story that Yahweh directed the prophet Samuel to anoint Saul as king of Israel by pouring oil on Saul’s head. The Israelites called their kings Yahweh’s anointed to show that the Israelites recognized that it is Yahweh himself who chooses kings.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: What are some rituals in your culture that you have to appoint someone as a leader? In what ways do people show respect to their leaders in your culture? Pause this audio here.

David insists that Yahweh will cause Saul to die in some other way than David killing Saul. Then David uses the oath “as Yahweh lives” to make David’s statement even more certain. David says, “Yahweh forbid that I should put out my hand against Yahweh’s anointed.” Here, David again strongly insists that David will not reject Saul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of oaths or strong words do people use in your language to show they will keep their promises? Pause this audio here.

Instead of killing Saul, David takes Saul’s spear and water jug, then leaves the encampment with Abishai. David does this to prove to Saul later that David spared Saul’s life again.

Stop here and look at a picture of an ancient water jug as a group. Pause this audio here.

Neither Saul nor any of Saul’s 3,000 soldiers awake as David and Abishai come and go from the camp because Yahweh causes the soldiers all to fall into a deep sleep.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: The Ziphites come to Saul at Gibeah and tell Saul where David is hiding. Saul takes 3,000 chosen soldiers to the location where the Ziphites said David would be.

In the second scene: David discovers or sees that Saul has come after David in the wilderness. David sends scouts to determine if Saul really has come.

In the third scene: David and some of David’s men go to see Saul’s camp. David asks for a volunteer to go into the camp with David. Abishai says Abishai will go.

In the fourth scene: David and Abishai sneak into Saul’s camp, where everyone is sleeping. David and Abishai find Saul also sleeping. Abishai wants to kill Saul, but David will not let Abishai kill Saul. Instead, David takes Saul’s spear and water jug. Then David and Abishai leave Saul’s camp without anyone waking up.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Ziphites
- Saul
- Saul’s army of 3,000 special men that Saul chose for this task
- Abner
- David
- David’s scouts
- Abishai
- And Ahimelek

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The story starts with Saul in Saul's home city of Gibeah. Saul would be living comfortably as king of Israel in Gibeah. A group of Ziphites travels to Gibeah to tell Saul what these men know about where David is. The Ziphites are Israelites from the tribe of Judah who live near the area where David is hiding. The Ziphites probably tell David's location because the Ziphites want Saul to be kind to the Ziphites since Saul is king.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel that shows Gibeah, Ziph, Jeshimon, and the hill of Hakilah. Pause this audio here.

The Ziphites say to Saul, "Isn't David hiding on the hill of Hakilah near Jeshimon?" Even though the Ziphites ask a question, the Ziphites are telling Saul where David is rather than asking Saul where David is.

Stop here and discuss how you might translate a question like this that is meant to provide information rather than request information. Pause audio here.

Jeshimon is a wilderness. The wilderness is a lonely place with very little water or food. David and David's men know the wilderness well and can survive in it.

Stop here and look at a photo of a wilderness in Israel as a group. Notice places people could hide if they wanted to. Pause audio here.

David sees that Saul is coming and sends spies to confirm Saul's approach. David does not actually "see" Saul coming, but this is a way to say that David knows or discovers that Saul is coming because someone tells David. Then David and some of David's men sneak to a place where they can observe Saul's camp without anyone seeing David's men.

David asks if either Ahimelek or Abishai will go with David into Saul's camp. Abishai is the brother of Joab and the son of Zeruiah. Zeruiah is Abishai's mother. Most of the time, Scripture identifies someone as the son of that person's father. The storyteller probably mentions Zeruiah instead of Abishai's father because Zeruiah is David's sister. Abishai is David's nephew. The storyteller probably mentions Joab as Abishai's brother because Joab becomes important later in David's story.

Stop and discuss as a group: How will you translate that Abishai is the son of Zeruiah? Is it important for your people to know that Zeruiah is Abishai's mother and not Abishai's father? If so, then how will you translate this so people understand? Pause this audio here.

David is asking whoever volunteers to do a very dangerous thing because Saul's men could capture or kill whoever goes into Saul's camp.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a camp formation. Use rocks or other items to form a circular camp. At the center, place a different item to represent King Saul. Pause the audio here.

Abishai volunteers to go. At night, David and Abishai sneak to the center of the encampment where Saul and Saul's commander, Abner, are sleeping. Saul's men had probably set up the camp with their sleeping places in a circle around the most important people, like Saul and Saul's commander, Abner, to protect those people. Later, the storyteller tells us that all of Saul's men are sleeping at this point, too.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the camp where Saul was sleeping with Saul's 3,000 special men who were helping Saul chase David to kill David. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss how to show that everyone was asleep even though the storyteller does not tell us that until later. Pause this audio here.

Abishai, who likely whispers, says to David that today God has given David's enemy to David. Abishai is telling David that tonight David can kill Saul. Abishai says that Abishai will kill Saul with Saul's own spear. David asks Abishai who could be innocent if they killed Yahweh's anointed. David did not mean for Abishai to answer this question. Rather, this question emphasizes that David believes David would be guilty before Yahweh if David or Abishai killed Saul.

David uses two oaths to Yahweh to emphasize that David would never harm Saul. In the first oath, David says, “as surely as Yahweh lives,” which means David is as sure that Yahweh himself will kill Saul as David is sure that Yahweh exists.

Stop and discuss other options for translating the phrase “as surely as Yahweh lives.” You could translate this phrase with the words “by Yahweh who lives.” You could also translate the phrase “I promise you.” Pause this audio here.

David says, “Yahweh forbid that I should put out my hand against Yahweh’s anointed.” Here, David strongly insists with an oath that David will not harm Saul.

David shows mercy to Saul. But David also wants Saul to know that David could have killed Saul. So, David takes Saul’s spear and water jug. The water jug has been next to Saul from the beginning, but this is the first time we hear about it. David and Abishai leave the camp without waking Saul, Abner, or any of the 3,000 soldiers because Yahweh put Saul and Saul’s army in a deep sleep.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Ziphites
- Saul
- Saul’s army of 3,000 special men that Saul chose for this task
- Abner
- David
- David’s scouts
- Abishai
- And Ahimelek

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The Ziphites come to Saul at Gibeah and tell Saul that David is hiding in the wilderness. Pause the drama. Ask the person or people playing the Ziphites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am hoping that Saul will be happy with us for telling Saul where his enemy is; or
- I do not like doing this, but we will be in trouble if we do not tell Saul that David is in our wilderness; or
- We need to kill David and David’s band of rebels. These men will only bring trouble.

Ask the person playing Saul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- These Ziphites are good people. This is the second time the Ziphites told me where to find my enemy, David; or

1 Samuel 26:1–12

- Finally, I can eliminate the only threat to my throne; or
- I know it is wrong to keep going after David. But I must capture David because David is a threat to my throne; or
- God has blessed me with the knowledge of my enemy's whereabouts.

Continue the drama. Saul takes 3,000 soldiers and goes to the place where the Ziphites told Saul David would be. David learns that Saul is coming and sends spies to confirm it. When David knows for sure that Saul has come, David takes some of David's men to a place near Saul's camp. David asks if Ahimelek or Abishai will go with David into Saul's camp. Abishai volunteers to go with David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ahimelek, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is a very foolish thing to do. I am not going down there; or
- I do not know what to say. I do not want to do this, but I do not want to look like a coward either; or
- I feel disappointed. I wanted to go with David, but Abishai spoke up first.

Continue the drama. David and Abishai sneak into Saul's camp while Saul and all of Saul's men are sleeping. When David and Abishai find Saul and Abner, Saul's commander, asleep, Abishai urges David to let Abishai kill Saul. But David will not let Abishai kill Saul and says that David will never kill the one whom Yahweh anointed as king. David and Abishai take Saul's spear and Saul's water jug. Then David and Abishai leave the camp without waking any of Saul's men because God put all of the men in a deep sleep. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Abishai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel frustrated. Why did I risk my life to come into this camp? or
- We have lived as exiles for years because of Saul. What is David thinking? or
- David is weak. If David will not act when it is clearly time to act, David will put us all in danger; or
- Maybe David is right, and we should not kill Saul. Maybe we should let Yahweh punish Saul.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The Ziphites tell Saul where David is hiding by asking, "Is not David hiding on the hill of Hakilah east of Jeshimon?" Then Saul takes 3,000 chosen soldiers to pursue David in the **wilderness** of Ziph. A wilderness is a lonely, barren place without much water where people do not live. David is staying in such an isolated place because David is hiding from Saul. Use the same word for wilderness that you have previously used. Look up wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information.

By sending spies, David discovers where Saul's army camped. These spies were like scouts but moved around secretly.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **spies**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David and Abishai find Saul asleep with Saul's spear stuck in the ground beside Saul's head. This was probably a special spear for Saul since Saul was king. Translate spear in the same way you have translated spear in previous passages. Later, we find out that Saul also has Saul's water jug next to Saul as he sleeps.

Stop here and look at a picture of a royal spear and a water jug as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abishai says, "**God** has given your enemy into your hand this day." Abishai uses the general word for God rather than Yahweh. Use the same word for God as you previously used. For more information on "God," refer to the Master Glossary. Use similar language for giving enemies into David's hands as you have used in previous stories.

David tells Abishai not to destroy Saul. David asks Abishai who could be innocent if they killed **Yahweh's anointed**. David uses Yahweh, God's personal name. You will remember that Samuel anointed Saul as king to show that Yahweh had chosen Saul. Use the same words for Yahweh and anoint that you have previously used. For more information on Yahweh and anoint, refer to the Master Glossary.

David tells Abishai that Saul will die some other way besides David killing Saul. Use the same language that you have used in earlier stories to talk about Yahweh "striking," or killing, Saul. David makes David's words even more insistent by using the **oath**, "as Yahweh lives." Although the storyteller does not use the word oath here, David is swearing an oath. When someone swears an oath, that person says, "I will absolutely keep my promise. If I do not, God may punish me." For more information about what an oath is, you can refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 26:1–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (870 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 26:13–25

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 26:13–25 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:13–25 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.

4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:13–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story follows immediately from the previous story. In that story, David and Abishai went into Saul's camp. All the people in Saul's camp were asleep. Yahweh made all the people in the camp stay asleep while David and Abishai were in the camp. David and Abishai took Saul's spear and water jar from beside Saul. David and Abishai did not hurt or kill anybody in Saul's camp. David and Abishai left Saul's camp. This passage tells us what David does next.

David goes to stand on a hill near Saul's camp. There is a deep space, or valley, between the hill where David stands and Saul's camp. The space between David and Saul's camp makes David feel safe.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Where in your country is there a valley between two hills that you could shout across the valley? If there is no valley like this, talk about what the valley in the passage might have looked like. Pause this audio here.

David shouts across the valley to Saul's army. David calls out and shouts to Abner, Ner's male descendant. You will remember from previous passages that Abner is the commander of Saul's army and is part of Saul's army. Abner leads Saul's soldiers and keeps Saul safe. David calls Abner by Abner's name. David wants Abner to know that David has visited Saul's camp. We do not know if the people in the camp wake up before David calls out to the camp or if David wakes the people in the camp by shouting. David calls out to get Abner's attention. David wants Abner to answer David's call.

Abner replies to David. Abner does not know who is shouting at the camp and at Abner. Abner asks who is shouting. Abner wants to know who dares to disturb Israel's king. Abner speaks angrily to David because David woke the king. David uses questions to show that Abner is doing a bad job of guarding the king.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have someone in the group tell a story about a time when someone scolded a leader for doing a bad job. Pause this audio here.

David knows and tells Abner that Abner did not guard Saul properly that night when David and Abishai went into Saul's camp. David does not say who went into Saul's camp. David did not go to Saul's camp to kill Saul, but Abishai did want to kill Saul. David then talks to all the soldiers in Saul's camp. David uses a common phrase as a promise that what David says afterwards will happen. David knows that Yahweh is alive. With the same confidence, David knows that Abner and the soldiers must die. David tells all the soldiers that the soldiers must die because the soldiers did not guard Saul, the person Yahweh anointed or chose to be king. Saul is the soldier's master.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about situations when people swore or promised that something was going to happen. Pause this audio here.

David asks the soldiers and Abner to look around for the king's spear and water jug. David knows the spear and water jug are gone. David wants Abner to see the evidence that Abner and the soldiers failed to protect the king. David knows where the spear and jug are.

Stop here and look at a picture of a royal spear from the time of David. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a water jug from the time of David. Pause this audio here.

Saul is awake. Saul has heard David and Abner calling to each other across the valley. Saul recognises David's voice and wants David to confirm that David is the one who calls to the soldiers and Abner. Saul calls David Saul's son to show Saul's affection for the younger man.

David shows respect to Saul by calling Saul David's lord and king. David shows Saul that Saul is still David's master and king. David continues to show respect by calling Saul lord and naming himself, David, the servant.

David uses the questions to Saul to ask Saul what David has done wrong. David knows that David has not done anything wrong. David wants Saul to hear what David wants to say to Saul. David talks about why Saul may be hunting David. David knows that Saul has no reason to hunt David. First, David suggests that Yahweh caused Saul to hunt David as a judgment for David's sinning against Yahweh. If David did sin against Yahweh, David would give an offering. David offers this in order to please Yahweh and to ask Yahweh not to punish David.

David suggests a second reason for Saul hunting David. David suggests that men, people of Israel, persuaded Saul to hunt David. If people did this, David wants Yahweh to punish the people. The people who hunt David are making David leave the land of Canaan. Yahweh gave the land to the Israelites as an inheritance from one generation to the next generation for all time. The people who hunt David are making David go into lands where the people serve and worship different gods. It is wrong to stop an Israelite from living in the land Yahweh gave to the Israelites. This is why David calls for Yahweh to curse and punish those people.

David asks Saul not to kill David. David does not want to die and have David's blood go into the ground away from where the Israelites meet with Yahweh. It is important to remember that Yahweh is everywhere and works in all lands. However, Canaan is where the Israelites worshiped Yahweh and where Yahweh appeared to the Israelites. It was important to the Israelites to die in the land where the Israelites met with Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What traditional and important things can you only do when you are in your own land? What does somebody do if they need to live outside of your country or the land that you live in? Pause this audio here.

David tells Saul that David is not important. The king, the most important person in Israel, hunts a flea. A flea is a very small animal that lives on other animals. A flea is the size of a small seed. David says that David is like a flea, an insignificant creature, compared to the king. David then compares Saul hunting David to someone who hunts a partridge in the mountains. A partridge is a wild bird that people hunt, cook and eat. We do not know the exact type of bird that David is talking about.

At David's time, there were many partridges on the fields and lowlands of Israel. Nobody needed to go to the mountains to find a partridge. David means that there is no need to hunt David. Also, a bird calls out just like David is calling out to Saul. David is saying that David is like the partridge.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What animals do you say people are like in your community or language because of similarities between the people and the animals? Pause this audio here.

Saul responds to David. Saul admits that Saul has sinned against Yahweh. Saul sinned by hunting David. Saul calls to David and tells David to return to Saul. Saul knows that David decided not to kill Saul that night, at that time. Because David did not kill Saul, Saul says that Saul will not hurt David again. Saul has been foolish. Saul was not wise or sensible. Saul made wrong choices.

David decides to give back to Saul the spear that David took from Saul. David does not go over to Saul's camp. We do not know why David does not give back the water jug. David wants one of the soldiers in Saul's camp to come to get the spear. David knows that Yahweh blesses people who are faithful, follow Yahweh, and do what Yahweh asks. David tells Saul that, at that time, Yahweh put Saul into David's power. David chose not to harm Saul because Saul was Yahweh's chosen and anointed king for Israel. In the same way as David respected Saul and kept Saul safe, David wants Yahweh to look after David and keep David safe. David puts his trust in Yahweh.

Saul wants Yahweh to bless David so that David receives good things from Yahweh. Saul knows that David will do lots of good things and be successful. We do not know what Saul expects David to succeed in doing. David and Saul stop talking and go away from the hill and the camp in different directions. Even though Saul asks David to come back, David does not go with Saul. Saul goes back to Saul's home, probably to Gibeah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:13–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

1 Samuel 26:13–25

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: David calls out to Saul's army and speaks to Abner. David tells Abner and the other soldiers that Abner and the soldiers have not kept the king safe.

In the second scene: David speaks to Saul. David asks why Saul hunts David. Saul says Saul has done the wrong thing. David decides to give back the king's spear. David tells Saul that David kept Saul safe. Saul blesses David.

In the third scene: David and Saul leave in different directions.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Abishai
- Saul's army
- Abner, son of Ner, commander of Saul's army
- Saul
- And the young man who collects the spear from David.

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage describes what happens immediately after the previous one. David and Abishai leave Saul's camp and cross a valley to reach a hill. David and Abishai go to Saul's camp at night. When David leaves the camp, it is still night, and David crosses to the other side of the valley. David stands far from Saul's camp but close enough to shout across the valley to the camp. David is at the top of a hill. We do not know if it is still night at the beginning of this passage or how long David traveled from the camp to the hill. However, we know that David wakes some people when David shouts to the camp, so it was probably still night.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you shout to get someone's attention? Is there a particular phrase that you use? Pause this audio here.

First, David calls out to talk to Abner. Abner leads Saul's army. The soldiers can also hear David. We do not know if David calls out something else before Abner answers. Abner answers David after David calls out to Abner by name. David responds to Abner with three questions that David does not expect Abner to answer. David uses the questions to tell Abner that Abner failed to guard Saul properly. The first question is an insult. David knows Abner is a fully grown man and one of the best soldiers in Israel. Saul trusts Abner to protect Saul, the king. David refers to Abner's lord. Saul is Abner's lord, the person Abner obeys and serves.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What respectful title do you call a person who is a leader and tells other people what to do? Pause this audio here.

David tells Abner and the soldiers that Abner and the soldiers failed to keep Saul safe. Because Abner and the soldiers failed, David judges Abner and the soldiers. David uses a common phrase as a promise that what David says afterwards will happen.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do people use in your community to show they are really confident that something is true or will happen? Pause this audio here.

The punishment for Abner and the soldiers is death, but these men do not die in this story. David shows Abner and the soldiers the king's spear and water jug. The spear and water jug are not beside Saul. David has the spear and the water jug on the top of the hill.

Saul is awake. We do not know when Saul woke up. Saul talks to David after David talks to Abner. Saul checks that the voice Saul hears belongs to David. Saul calls David Saul's son. David is not one of Saul's sons. Saul calls David Saul's son to show Saul's affection for the younger man.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What affectionate words or names do you use in your community for people you care about? Do you call people son or daughter even if those people are not your own children? Pause this audio here.

David tells Saul that Saul is right. David asks in three different ways why Saul is hunting David. David shows respect to Saul by calling Saul lord and himself Saul's servant. Firstly, David asks why Saul is hunting David.

Then David asks what David has done. Lastly, David asks what evil or guilt is on David's hands. David does not have anything actually on David's hands. If a person has guilt or evil on their hands, it means that the person is responsible for doing something wrong.

David wants Saul to hear that David knows that Saul is doing the wrong thing by chasing and hunting David. David knows that only Saul is responsible for chasing David. David uses two possible reasons for Saul to chase David to show Saul that Saul is responsible for chasing David. First, David suggests to Saul that Yahweh made Saul chase after David. Second, David suggests that people have made Saul chase after David. David says that the people chased David from Israel today. Today means at this time, not the exact 24-hour time period that David is experiencing.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do you use to describe something that happens to you or affects you now? Pause this audio here.

Then David asks Saul not to kill David in foreign lands. David tells Saul that David is not important and that Saul does not need to hunt David.

After David questions Saul, Saul admits to David that Saul has disobeyed God by chasing after David.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about a time when you showed a person what they did wrong, and then the person admitted that they made a mistake. Pause this audio here.

Saul wants David to go back to Saul and to Saul's camp. Saul recognises that David kept Saul safe and showed respect to Saul at that time, on that night. Saul says that Saul will keep David safe because David kept Saul safe. Saul admits to David that Saul was not wise and made wrong choices.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about a time when a leader admitted they had done something wrong. Talk about the leader's tone of voice and manner of speaking. How might Saul have been speaking here? Pause this audio here.

David answers Saul. David wants to give back the king's spear to Saul. David does not go over to Saul's camp. David suggests that a soldier or young man from Saul's camp should come to get the spear from David. Notice that David does not go to Saul himself.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How might you describe the soldier in your translation? Pause this audio here.

David says that Yahweh blesses people who follow Yahweh and do what Yahweh wants. Yahweh let David be in control of Saul's life at that time, on that night. David did what was right and did not hurt the person Yahweh chose to be king. On that day, at that time, David valued and saved Saul's life. David calls on Yahweh to do the same for David as David did for Saul.

Saul replies to David. Saul wants Yahweh to give David good things. Saul shows affection to David by calling David Saul's son. Saul recognises that David will succeed and do great things in life after this meeting.

David then leaves the hill and goes away from that place. Saul goes away as well, but Saul goes in a different direction, back to Saul's home, probably at Gibeah.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:13–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- Abishai

- Saul's army
- Abner, son of Ner, commander of Saul's army
- Saul
- And the young man who collects the spear from David.

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

David calls out to Saul's army and speaks to Abner. David tells Abner and the other soldiers that Abner and the soldiers have not kept the king safe. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Come on, wake up and see what we did while you were sleeping! or
- These soldiers have failed; or
- Look what we managed to do while you slept!

Ask the person playing Saul's army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What is going on? Who is shouting at us? or
- What has happened while we were asleep? or
- I am afraid! We have failed our lord the king!

Ask the person playing Abner, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This man has woken us up! or
- It is David! What has David done? or
- David has my king's spear and jug!" or
- I have failed my lord the king. Yahweh will punish me. I am ashamed and frightened.

Continue the drama. David speaks to Saul. David asks why Saul hunts David. Saul says Saul has done the wrong thing. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to speak to Saul; or
- It is time for Saul to understand that Saul is sinning against Yahweh; or
- I am tired and sad. I do not want Saul to hunt me anymore. I want to live in my family's land.

Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- David knows that I am responsible for hunting David; or
- I am sorry that I have hunted David. I love David like a son; or
- I want David to come back to be with me.

Continue the drama. David decides to give back the king's spear. David tells Saul that David kept Saul safe. Saul blesses David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I will give you back your spear; or
- Yahweh guides me; or
- I respect the king that Yahweh gave to us; or

- I will continue to trust Yahweh.

Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Please Yahweh, bless David; or
- I am sad. I have done bad things as king, and I know that David will be great.

Continue the drama. David and Saul leave in different directions. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I will not go to Saul. I do not trust Saul; or
- It is time to go and find somewhere to rest.

Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want David to come home with me; or
- David will be great. I do not like that. Maybe I can kill David if he comes back with me; or
- It is time to go back to Gibeah.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 26:13–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

David crossed over to the other side of the valley and stood on top of the hill. David called out to the army and to Abner. David asked Abner why Abner did not guard his **lord**, or master, the **king**. Use the same words or phrases for lord and king as you used in previous passages. For more information on lord and king, refer to the Master Glossary.

David makes a promise to Abner and the army. David says that as sure as **Yahweh** lives, Abner and the army will die. Yahweh is God's personal name. In this passage, the storyteller calls God "Yahweh." Be sure to translate Yahweh in the same way as you have in previous passages, and remember that Yahweh is in the Master Glossary.

Yahweh has **anointed** Saul as king. Anointed means that God chooses someone for a special task. Use the same word or phrase for anointed that you have used in previous passages. Anoint is in the Master Glossary.

David told the soldiers to look for the **king's spear** and **water jug**. Use the same words or phrases for king's spear and water jug as you used in previous passages.

Saul spoke to David. Saul called David Saul's **son**. Use the same word or phrase for son when the person uses it as an affectionate title as you used in previous passages. For more information on son, refer to the Master Glossary.

David asked Saul why Saul is chasing David. David suggests to Saul reasons why Saul is chasing David. David will make an **offering** to Yahweh if Yahweh sent Saul. Use the same word or phrase for offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

If people have told Saul to chase David, David wants Yahweh to **curse** those people or punish them. Use the same word or phrase for curse as you used in previous passages. For more information on curse, refer to the Master Glossary.

David cannot live in Yahweh's **inheritance**, which is the land Yahweh gave to the Israelites. Use the same word or phrase for inheritance as you used in previous passages.

Saul and Saul's army are chasing David to lands where the people serve other, false **gods**. Use the same word or phrase for false gods as you used in previous passages. For more information on gods, refer to the Master Glossary.

David says that David is like a **flea**. Use the same word or phrase for flea as you used in previous passages.

David says that Saul is hunting David like a person hunts a partridge in the mountains. A partridge is a wild bird that people hunt, cook and eat.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **partridge**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul admits to David that Saul has **sinned**. Use the same word or phrase for sinned as you used in previous passages. Sin is in the Master Glossary.

David says that Yahweh rewards everyone for their **righteousness** and **faithfulness.** In other words, Yahweh rewards people when people behave rightly, according to Yahweh's will. Yahweh also rewards people who are faithful or who obey Yahweh's laws. Use the same words for righteousness and faithfulness that you have used in previous passages. Both righteousness and faith are in the Master Glossary.

Saul asks David to come back to Saul and tells David that Saul will not harm David again. David decides to give Saul the spear. David prays that Yahweh will take care of David as David took care of Saul. Saul hopes that Yahweh will **bless** David. Use the same word or phrase for bless as you used in previous passages. For more information on bless, refer to the Master Glossary.

David leaves the hill, and Saul goes home.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 26:13–25

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (878 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 Samuel 27:1–28:2

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 27:1–28:2 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 27:1–28:2 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 27:1–28:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story tells us about the time after Saul was hunting David in Israel. In Israel, David and Saul spoke to each other across a valley. Saul said that Saul would not try to hurt David again. David heard Saul but did not trust Saul. David did not believe that Saul would stop hunting David.

This story happens some time after the conversation between David and Saul. We do not know how much time has passed between the events in this story and the conversation between David and Saul across the valley.

David thinks to himself that one day, Saul will kill David. David knows that the best thing for David to do is to leave Israel and go to where the Philistines live. David hopes Saul will give up looking for David in Israel.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Tell a story about a time someone escaped a leader who was trying to kill that person. Where did the person go and what happened? Pause this audio here.

David leaves where David and his followers have been staying in the wilderness of Israel. David goes from the land of the Israelites to the land of the Philistines. David goes over the boundary or the border between the two lands.

David's 600 men go with David. David and his followers go to King Achish in the city of Gath in Philistia. King Achish was the son of Maok. We do not know if this is the same Achish that David stayed with before. All the kings of the Philistines might have used the name Achish, or Achish might be this king's personal name.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about examples of people in your community who use the same name from one generation to the next. Why do these people have the same name? Is the name ceremonial, or does the name have a different meaning? Pause this audio here.

David lives with Achish in the city of Gath. David probably does not share a home with Achish. David lives in Gath, and Achish protects and supports David. David lives in Gath with lots of people. David's men live with their households, which are the men's close family and possibly servants. David's two wives, Ahinoam and Abigail, are with David in Gath. The story reminds us that Ahinoam came from Jezreel. Abigail is the widow of Nabal and lived in Carmel before she married David.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Tell stories of times when large groups of people had to run away from their homeland and live in a different place for a while. Pause this audio here.

Saul hears that David is in Gath. We do not know who tells Saul that David has left Israel. Saul stops looking for David because David has left Israel, the land over which Saul has power.

David hopes that Achish is happy with what David is doing. David asks Achish for a gift, or somewhere for David and all David's men to live. At that time, kings gave land to servants whom they trusted. David calls himself a

servant of Achish. David is saying politely that Achish has power over David, and David will do what Achish wants David to do. David does not serve Achish by doing household jobs or looking after Achish. David asks Achish why David, Achish's servant, should stay in Gath. David is saying that David is not important enough to stay in the royal city. David does not want or need to live in the city where King Achish lives, the royal city. David wants to live away from Gath in the countryside, in a smaller town.

When David asks Achish for a place to live, Achish gives David the town of Ziklag. The storyteller reminds us that Ziklag still belongs to the kings of Judah at the time when the storyteller tells this story. You will remember that Judah became a separate kingdom later in Israel's history. The city of Ziklag belonged to David's family from generation to generation as an inheritance from Achish.

Stop here and look at a map of Philistia showing the city of Gath, the town of Ziklag, and the border with Israel. Pause this audio here.

David stays in Philistia at Gath and then Ziklag for a year and four months.

Next, the storyteller tells us what David did while David was in Philistia. David and his men raided, attacked, and stole from groups of people south and west of Ziklag and Philistia. These groups of people were enemies of Israel who had attacked Israel and now lived on the land Yahweh had given to Israel. The Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites lived in the settlements all the way towards Shur and Egypt. Some translations say that the settlements reached from Telam, a town in Judah, but most translations say that people lived in the lands from ancient times. Telam in the original language means a long time or forever. The Geshurites in this story are a different group of people from the Geshurites who lived near Gilead, northeast of Israel.

Stop here and look at a map of Ziklag in Philistia, the lands of the Geshurites and Girzites and Amalekites, Shur, the eastern border of Egypt, and the lands of Judah and Edom. Pause this audio here.

When David and David's men attacked a settlement, the men killed everybody but took sheep, cattle, donkeys, camels, and clothing.

Stop here and look at a picture of sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of cattle as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a donkey as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a camel as a group. Pause this audio here.

David and David's men took back anything that was valuable. David and his men kept some of the animals and clothing to support David and his men in Ziklag. David probably gave some of the animals and clothing to Achish. David went out many times to attack the Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites. After each raid, Achish asked David what David was doing and who David attacked. David did not tell the truth to Achish. David told Achish that David and his men were raiding in the area of the Israelites and the people who lived with the Israelites in the Negev wilderness. The Negev wilderness is an area of dry land in the south of Israel, in the tribal lands of Judah. The Jerahmeelites were a group of people in the tribe of Judah. The Kenites were friends of Israel and lived between Judah and Edom.

Stop here and look again at a map of Ziklag in Philistia, the lands of the Geshurites and Girzites and Amalekites, Shur, the eastern border of Egypt, and the lands of Judah and Edom, if needed. Pause this audio here.

David and his men killed everyone on a raid so that nobody from a raided town came to Gath and told the truth to Achish. David did this all the time that David lived in Philistia on this occasion. Achish did not learn the truth. Achish trusted David and thought that David had become someone that the Israelites hated and rejected. Achish believed that David would be Achish's servant. Achish believed that David would provide military service to Achish and live under Achish's protection. Achish believed that David would always be Achish's servant, that David would live out the rest of David's life serving Achish.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about a time someone lied to people in order to continue obeying God or in order to help a group of people. Pause this audio here.

At the time that David was living in Philistia, the people in Philistia came together to fight Israel. The leaders of the Philistines called the fighting people together to be ready to attack Israel. Achish wanted David to fight with

1 Samuel 27:1–28:2

the Philistines against Israel. Achish says that David and David's men have to join the Philistine army. David does not say that David and his men will attack Israel. David is careful when David replies to Achish. Achish thinks that David is going to help the Philistines attack Israel. Achish honours David by making David Achish's bodyguard. A bodyguard is someone who provides personal protection to somebody special. A bodyguard may give their life to keep the special person safe. Achish makes David Achish's permanent bodyguard, for all the time from that time onwards.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you protect the leaders in your community in dangerous situations?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 27:1–28:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

In the first scene: David decides to go to Philistia.

In the second scene: David, David's men, and the men's wives go to Gath in Philistia. Saul stops looking for David.

In the third scene: David asks Achish, the king of Gath, for somewhere for David and David's men to live. Achish gives Ziklag to David.

In the fourth scene: David and David's men raid the Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites.

In the fifth scene: Achish asks David where David raided. David tells Achish that David and David's men raided people in Judah.

In the sixth scene: Achish thinks about David and thinks that David will serve Achish from now on and always.

In the seventh scene: The Philistines get ready to fight Israel, and Achish tells David that David and David's men will have to fight with the Philistines against Israel. David replies, and Achish thinks that David will be faithful and protect Achish.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- David's men and their households
- Achish, king of Gath
- David's wives, Ahinoam and Abigail
- Saul
- Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites
- And Philistine leaders

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story starts with David in Israel. David is thinking about what to do. In the previous story, David talked with Saul across the valley, and Saul was friendly. This storyteller tells us that David does not trust Saul. David decides to leave Israel and go to Philistia. The storyteller tells us that David thinks to himself, or says in David's heart, that Saul will one day kill David. David talks to himself without speaking out loud. David thinks about slipping out of Saul's hand. This is a way to say that David would move away from Saul's power and that Saul would not be able to capture David. David is not actually in Saul's hand. David is under Saul's power in Israel, and Saul might capture David. When David leaves, Saul will not be able to catch David, and David will be away from Saul's power.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you say that someone is under the control or in the power of another person? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about someone who left your community without telling people they left. Pay attention to any particular phrases you use to describe this. Pause this audio here.

David and David's men leave Israel and go over the border into Philistia.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you describe the change between the land of your people and the land of the people next to you? Is there a well-understood borderline between you, or is there a wider boundary of change? How do you know when you have moved from your land to other people's land? Pause this audio here.

David and David's men went to Achish, the king of Gath. Gath was a city in Philistia. Each man had his family with that man, and David had his wives with David. The storyteller gives us information about each of David's wives. Ahinoam is from Jezreel, and Abigail is from Carmel. Abigail is the widow of Nabal.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about people and help other people identify who those people are? What features or information about a person do you add to that person's name? Pause this audio here.

After David leaves Israel, someone tells Saul that David is in Gath. Then Saul stops looking for David.

After some time in Gath, David asks Achish if David has found favour in Achish's eyes. David wants to know if David pleases Achish. David wants Achish to give David and David's men somewhere to stay away from Gath and the king. David is very polite when David talks to Achish and tells Achish that David is Achish's servant.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you say that a leader now likes someone, particularly if the person has done something to change the leader's feelings? Pause this audio here.

At that time, after David asks Achish for somewhere to stay, Achish gives David the town of Ziklag. David becomes the leader of the town of Ziklag, and the land belongs to David. The town is David's property, and it passes on to each Israelite king as an inheritance from one generation to the next until the time of the kings of Judah, when the storyteller writes this story. The kings of Judah come to power and rule many years after the time of this story.

David lives in Philistia, in Gath and then Ziklag, for one year and four months. During this time of one year and four months, David and David's men raided people to the southwest of Philistia many times. In a raid, people suddenly attack someone else with weapons that can cause damage. Then, rather than keeping the enemy's land, the raiders usually take the possessions of the people in the land.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about the difference between an attack on people to gain land and an attack on people to hurt the people and take their possessions. Pause this audio here.

David raided the Geshurites, the Girzites, and the Amalekites. These people had lived on their land a long time. These people's lands went all the way to Shur and Egypt, and the people were enemies of Israel. David killed all the people in a settlement but took away anything valuable. David took sheep, cattle, donkeys, camels, and clothing.

After a raid, when David went back to Gath and met with Achish, Achish would ask David where David had raided that time. David did not tell Achish the truth. David told Achish that David and David's men raided people in Israel, in the dry lands of Judah and the Kenites.

Stop here and look again at a map of Ziklag in Philistia, the lands of the Geshurites and Girzites and Amalekites, Shur, the eastern border of Egypt, and the lands of Judah and Edom, if needed. Pause this audio here.

David and David's men killed everybody in the settlement during a raid. David was worried that if David left someone alive, that person would go to Gath and tell Achish the truth. David wanted Achish to believe that David and David's men were raiding their fellow Israelites. All the time that David was in Philistia, living in Gath and Ziklag, David was careful not to let anybody survive a raid who might tell Achish the truth.

Achish trusted David and thought that David had made himself offensive to the Israelite people. If David did kill people in Judah, the people in Judah and their fellow Israelites would hate David and find David unacceptable. David would never be able to go back to Israel. Achish believed that David would always serve Achish.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you describe a person who did something terrible to his people and whom the people hated? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 27:1–28:2

David raided the Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites during the year and four months in Philistia. Towards the end of that time, the Philistine leaders started to gather their fighting men together to fight Israel. Achish gathered his fighting men and talked to David. Achish told David that David and David's men must be part of Achish's army. David replied to Achish politely and said that Achish would see what his servant, David, could do. However, David did not promise to fight against Israel. Achish believed David would fight against Israel, and Achish made David Achish's bodyguard from that time onwards.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 27:1–28:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- David
- David's men and their households
- Achish, king of Gath
- David's wives, Ahinoam and Abigail
- Saul
- Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites
- And Philistine leaders

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

David decides to go to Philistia. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not trust Saul; or
- I do not feel safe in Israel; or
- I think that Philistia might be a good place for me, my men, and my wives.

Continue the drama. David, David's men, and the men's wives go to Gath in Philistia. Saul stops looking for David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope that we will be safe here; or
- I need my wives to have somewhere to live; or
- I hope we have a better time in Philistia this time compared to the last time I came.

Ask the person playing David's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We have left our homeland, our inheritance from Yahweh; or
- Maybe we can make a life here; or

- I hope David knows what David is doing.

Ask the person playing David's wives, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Maybe here we can make a home together and be safe from Saul; or
- Will our children be born in a foreign land?

Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- David is gone! Now I can be king without David making me look bad; or
- The Philistines can maybe harm David, so I do not have to! or
- Now I can concentrate on Israel and stop trying to find David.

Continue the drama. David asks Achish, king of Gath, for somewhere for David and David's men to live. Achish gives Ziklag to David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We need to be away from Achish; or
- My people need a place to live; or
- We need to live in Philistia, so I will pretend to serve Achish.

Ask the person playing Achish, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased with David. David is strong, and maybe David will help me; or
- David can have Ziklag to live in.

Continue the drama David and David's men raid the Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites. Pause the drama.Continue the dramaPause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am going to stop these people from hurting Israel; or
- We must keep this a secret from Achish. Do not let anybody live; or
- Take the animals and clothes so that we can give some to Achish and keep some for ourselves.

Ask the person playing the Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- David and David's men are killing entire villages in their raids; or
- We are all going to die.

Continue the drama Achish asks David where David raided. David tells Achish that David and David's men raided people in Judah. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Achish, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love hearing where David has been raiding; or
- This man, David, is hurting my enemies in Israel. I am pleased with David; or
- David brings me plenty of animals and valuable items. David is a good servant.

Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Achish thinks I am hurting my own people; or
- So far, Achish does not know that I am actually raiding Israel's enemies; or
- I must be careful to make sure nobody survives a raid.

Continue the drama Achish thinks about David and thinks that David will serve Achish from now on and always. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Achish, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- David is making the Israelites hate David; or
- David is my servant now.

Continue the drama Philistia gets ready to fight Israel, and Achish tells David that David and David's men will have to fight with the Philistines. David replies, and Achish thinks that David will be faithful and protect Achish.

1 Samuel 27:1–28:2

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Achish, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I must have David and David’s men in my army; or
- David will be my bodyguard now and always. David is a faithful servant to me.

Ask the person playing David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I must be careful now. Achish must believe that we will fight with Achish against Israel; or
- I cannot fight my brothers in Israel; or
- Achish trusts me completely. My plan is working!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 27:1–28:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

David decided to leave Israel and escape from Saul’s **hand** or power. Use the same word or phrase for when hand means power as you used in previous passages.

David knew that Saul would not look for David inside the borders of **Israel**. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for Israel that you have used in previous passages.

David hopes that David has **found favor** in the eyes of Achish. In other words, David hopes that Achish likes David. Use the same word or phrase for found favor in someone’s eyes as you used in previous passages.

David wants to leave the **royal city**, the city of Gath where the king lives. David asks Achish for a country town or small city for David and David’s men to live in. Cities usually have walls around them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **royal city**. Use the same word for city as you have used in previous passages. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David wants to live in a country **town**. A town is smaller than a city but usually still has walls around it. Use the same word or phrase for town as you used in previous passages.

David and David’s men **raided** the Geshurites, Girzites, and Amalekites. David kills all the people and takes the valuable items from their houses. Use the same word or phrase for raided as you used in previous passages.

David told Achish that he was raiding the **Negev** wilderness of Judah. The Negev wilderness is dry land in the south of Israel and part of the land that Yahweh gave to the tribe of Judah.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Negev**. You may say that the Negev is a wilderness, and you can look up wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Achish believed that David would be Achish’s **servant** always. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Achish believed that David would be Achish’s **servant for life**, for all the time from that time onwards.

Stop here and talk about how you will say that David will be Achish’s **servant for life**. Pause this audio here.

Achish told David to bring David’s men to join Achish’s army. Achish thought David would do everything Achish wanted and that David and David’s men would protect Achish from Achish’s enemies. Achish decided to make David a **bodyguard** of Achish.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bodyguard**.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 27:1–28:2

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (916 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 28:3–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 28:3–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:3–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:3–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 28:3–14

This story describes King Saul's visit to a medium, or witch, in a place called Endor. This story interrupts the story about Achish, the Philistine ruler of Gath, who wanted David to help Achish go to war against the Israelites. The story about David and Achish continues after this story about Saul. Some scholars believe that this story about Saul actually took place after the stories about David and the Philistines. Those scholars think the author probably placed this story between the stories about David and the Philistines to make some comparisons about David and Saul's lives.

The author begins by reminding us that the prophet Samuel had died and that all the people of Israel had mourned or were very sad because Samuel had died. The people of Israel buried Samuel's body in Samuel's hometown, Ramah.

Some of the people who lived in Canaan before the Israelites inherited the land used to try to talk to spirits of the dead. A medium is a person who, people believed, could talk to the spirit of a dead person. People sometimes call mediums "witches." A necromancer is very similar to a medium. People thought a necromancer could talk to the spirit of a dead person to reveal or influence future events, a bit like a "fortune teller." People sometimes call necromancers "spiritists." The spirit, or soul, is the invisible, inner part of a person that continues to exist after a person dies. The law that Yahweh gave to Moses banned the Israelites from consulting the spirits of dead people, as the other nations practised. In a previous story, Yahweh said that to consult the spirits of dead people was a disgusting, terrible thing to do, and that anyone who consults the spirits of dead people must die. So Saul, the king of Israel, had banned or expelled all the mediums and necromancers from the land of Israel.

The events of this story begin when the armies of the Philistine people gather and set up camp in the city of Shunem. The Philistines were enemies of Israel. The Philistines camp at Shunem to prepare for battle against Israel. Shunem was on the southwest side of Mount Moreh, in the Jezreel Valley, within the land that belonged to the Israelite tribe of Issachar.

Then King Saul gathers the army of Israel and sets up camp at Gilboa, a hilly area about eight miles southeast of Shunem. Saul can probably see the Philistine army from Gilboa because Gilboa is a hilly place. The Philistine army is very big. When Saul sees the Philistine army, Saul becomes very afraid.

Because Saul is very afraid, Saul asks Yahweh what to do, but Yahweh does not answer Saul. In those days, Yahweh did not usually speak directly to people. Yahweh would usually speak through a special person, like a prophet, or through a priest who cast lots with the Urim, or sometimes through dreams. A prophet is a person who gives messages from Yahweh to the people. The Urim was an object that Yahweh allowed the priests to use to "throw lots" to discover Yahweh's will on a matter. It is not clear how the priests would use the Urim to throw lots, but the Urim would show the priest what Yahweh wanted Yahweh's people to do. The priest would then give that information to the people. Yahweh does not answer Saul through any of these methods in this story.

Saul then asks Saul's advisors to find a woman who is a medium so that Saul can ask the woman to talk to the spirits of dead people for Saul. Saul probably asks Saul's advisors to find a woman who is a medium because Yahweh is not responding to Saul through dreams, Urim, or prophets. Saul has no other way to find out what Yahweh thinks about the battle with the Philistines. Even though Saul had previously banned mediums from the land of Israel, Saul's advisors know of a woman who is a medium who lives in Endor. Endor is a town a short distance northeast of where the Philistine army is camped, about a 2-hour walk from the Israelite army's camp.

Stop here, and as a group, look at a map of the land of Israel. See the locations of Shunem, Mount Moreh, the Jezreel Valley, Gilboa, and Endor marked on the map. Pause this audio here.

Saul probably does not want anyone to recognise Saul because Saul knows that Yahweh will not be pleased, and because Saul is breaking Saul's own law. Saul disguises himself by wearing normal clothes instead of royal robes. Saul and two of Saul's men wait until night, when it is dark, to go to Endor and find the medium. Mediums and necromancers often performed their rituals at night.

Stop here and, as a group, talk about the different reasons a person might not want other people to recognise that person. If you can, tell a story about a time when someone disguised themself. Did that person disguise themself for a good reason or a bad reason? Pause the audio here.

Now discuss as a group, or tell a story about, some of the ways kings or leaders might try to get good advice that will help them govern wisely. Pause the audio here.

Saul tells the woman to bring up the spirit of a dead man that Saul wants to talk to. When Saul asks the woman to call up or bring up the dead man's spirit, Saul is asking the medium to bring a spirit up from the place where dead people are.

It is not clear if this medium could actually speak to the spirit of a dead person or if she only deceived people into thinking that she could. It is not clear if, or how, a medium could call a dead man's spirit from the underworld, or Sheol. People believed that the spirits of dead people all stayed together in one place after a person died. Some scholars think that the Bible does not explain the practice of calling up the spirits of dead people in more detail because Yahweh hated this practice.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do people in your culture think about trying to call up the spirits of dead people? Why do you think Yahweh hated this practice? Pause this audio here.

The woman does not seem to recognise Saul. The woman seems surprised that Saul asked her to help him, because Saul, in his disguise, speaks as if he did not know that Saul had "cut off" or killed the mediums in the land of Israel. The woman suspects that Saul is trying to set a trap for the woman's life. This is special language to say that the woman thinks this stranger, who is really King Saul, is trying to get her in trouble with the authorities for disobeying Saul's command not to use mediums. The woman's response suggests that people in the land of Israel knew that Saul often killed mediums and necromancers.

Saul makes an oath, or a very solemn promise, in Yahweh's name. By this oath, Saul assures the woman that just as it is completely true that Yahweh is alive, the woman can be equally certain that no one will punish her for helping Saul at this moment. Saul's behaviour does not seem to make sense. At the same time that Saul is making a promise in Yahweh's name, Saul is also rebelling against Yahweh. Saul is insulting Yahweh when Saul makes a promise in Yahweh's name that Yahweh will not punish the woman if she breaks Yahweh's law.

Because Saul promised that no one would punish the woman, the woman agrees to help Saul. The woman asks Saul who he would like her to bring up for him. Saul asks the woman to bring up the prophet Samuel. We do not know what kinds of rituals the woman performs first, or if Samuel just appears unexpectedly.

When the woman sees the spirit of Samuel, the woman is so frightened that she screams in a loud voice! We do not know what caused the woman to become afraid and cry out. It is important to note that the woman actually saw Samuel. It was not a vision or a dream.

The woman then recognises who Saul is, and asks Saul why he deceived or tricked the woman by disguising himself. King Saul tells the woman not to be afraid. Saul asks the woman what she can see. The woman says she can see a god, or ghost-like figure, "coming up" out of the earth, meaning that she could see a spiritual being rising up from the earth. Then Saul asks the woman what the spiritual being looks like.

The woman says she sees an old man coming up, wearing a robe. A robe is a piece of clothing that people wear over other clothing for protection or warmth. In the Bible, outer garments, such as cloaks or robes, often showed a person's status or role. From the woman's description, Saul knew the woman was talking about Samuel, the prophet. Samuel the prophet was an old man who used to wear a robe when Samuel was alive. You will remember a previous story when Saul held on to the bottom of Samuel's robe, and it tore.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do people in your culture wear or decorate themselves with to show they have a position of authority or a particular role in the community? Pause the audio here.

This story ends when Saul understands that the woman can see Samuel, and Saul bows down to the ground to show deep respect to Samuel.

Stop here and, as a group, talk about different ways in your culture people might show deep respect to a person in authority.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:3–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller describes what was happening in the history and culture of Israel at that time. Samuel had died, and the people had buried Samuel's body. Saul had expelled all the mediums and necromancers from Israel.

In the second scene: The Philistine and Israelite armies assemble and set up camp close to each other in the Jezreel Valley. Saul becomes terrified when Saul sees the Philistine army.

In the third scene: Saul asks for guidance from Yahweh, but Yahweh does not respond. So Saul asks Saul's advisors where Saul can find a medium.

In the fourth scene: Saul disguises himself and visits the medium at night. Saul asks the medium to call up the dead prophet Samuel.

In the fifth scene: The medium sees Samuel and is afraid. The medium describes what she sees to Saul. Saul recognises that the medium can see Samuel, and Saul bows down with his face to the ground as a sign of respect to Samuel.

The characters in this passage are:

- The prophet Samuel
- Saul, Israel's king
- The Philistine army
- The Israelite army
- Saul's advisors, or servants
- And the medium of Endor

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The first scene of this story introduces us to the details of what was happening around the time this story took place. Samuel the prophet had died, and the Israelites buried Samuel's body in Ramah. King Saul had expelled all the mediums and necromancers from the land of Israel, as Yahweh had commanded the Israelites through the law Yahweh gave Moses. Yahweh's law did not permit anyone to talk to the spirits of dead people. It is important to make clear in your translation that these things have already happened. These things do not happen in this story, but these things do help us to understand this story better.

The events of this story begin in the second scene when the Philistine soldiers come together and camp at Shunem, and the Israelite soldiers camp nearby at Gilboa. There are so many Philistine soldiers that when Saul sees the soldiers, Saul becomes afraid and his heart trembles. This is special language to show that Saul feels terrified or that fear is overwhelming Saul.

Stop here and try to imagine a very large enemy army ready to attack a much smaller army. What word or phrase in your language might best describe how you would feel if you were the leader of the smaller army? Pause the audio here.

In the third scene, Saul asks Yahweh what he should do, but Yahweh does not answer Saul. Yahweh did not usually speak directly to people. Yahweh would usually speak through someone Yahweh chose. Yahweh might speak through a prophet, a priest who would cast lots with the Urim, or even through dreams. However, this time, Yahweh does not answer Saul through any of these methods.

Saul then speaks to his servants. The Bible says these men were servants who served Saul, but they were not like household servants. These men were more like officers or advisors. Saul previously banned all the mediums from Israel, but now, Saul asks Saul's advisors to look for a woman who is a medium. It is not clear why Saul asks specifically for a woman. What is clear is that Saul wants to ask the woman to talk to the spirits of dead people for Saul.

Saul probably asks Saul's advisors to find a woman medium because Yahweh is not responding to Saul in the ways that Yahweh approved of to speak to Yahweh's people.

Saul's advisors know of a woman medium who lives in a small town called Endor. Endor is a short distance northeast of the Philistine camp in Shunem, about a two-hour walk from the Israelite camp at Gilboa.

1 Samuel 28:3–14

The fourth scene happens at night. Saul puts on different clothes so that people do not recognise Saul as the king. When it is dark, Saul and two of Saul's men go to Endor to find the woman medium. It is likely that Saul and Saul's advisors do this in the evening of the same day that Saul's advisors tell Saul about the medium in Endor.

When Saul and Saul's men find the woman in Endor, Saul tells the woman that Saul needs to talk to a man who has died. Saul asks the woman to "divine by," or talk to a spirit, meaning that Saul wanted to find out Yahweh's will through the spirit of a dead man. Saul asks the woman to call, or bring up, the dead man's spirit for Saul. This means Saul wanted the medium to bring up the dead man's spirit from the place where people believed the spirits of dead people would remain after a person died.

Stop here and, as a group, discuss what word or phrase you will use to say that Saul wanted the woman to "divine by" or consult the spirit of a dead man. If you have translated this phrase in a different book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you used previously. Pause the audio here.

The woman does not seem to recognise Saul. The woman responds to Saul by calling Saul's attention to the fact that King Saul has removed or killed all the mediums in the land of Israel. The woman suspects that Saul is trying to set a trap for the woman's life. This is special language to say that the woman thinks Saul is putting the woman's life in danger, like a man sets a trap to catch an animal when he is hunting. The woman knows that if the authorities find out that she talked to a spirit, the woman's life will be at risk.

Saul makes an oath, or a very solemn promise, in Yahweh's name. By this oath, Saul is saying that in the same way it is completely true that Yahweh is alive, the woman can also be completely sure that no one will punish her for helping Saul in this moment.

The woman does not protest against Saul's request anymore. The woman asks Saul who he wants to bring up. Saul asks the woman to bring up the prophet Samuel.

In the fifth scene, the woman sees Samuel and cries out or screams loudly. The Bible passage does not tell us how the woman was able to see Samuel, but it is important to note that the woman actually saw Samuel. It was not a vision or a dream.

Then the woman asks Saul why he deceived her by not telling her that he was King Saul. The storyteller does not tell us what causes the woman to suddenly recognise Saul as King Saul of Israel.

Saul, who is the king, responds to the woman by telling her not to be afraid. The king asks the woman to tell Saul what she can see. The storyteller specifically uses the title "king" for Saul instead of saying Saul's name. This is important. Make sure you use the word "king" in your translation of this part of the story to show the contrast that the king of Israel, who is supposed to follow Yahweh, has broken Yahweh's commands.

The woman tells Saul that she can see a spiritual being coming up from the earth. Your version of the Bible might say the woman saw a god, or a ghost-like, divine figure. In your translation, it is important to make sure that the words you use to describe what the woman saw show that the woman saw something spiritual. The woman did not see something physical, like a living person.

Stop here and discuss as a group the way the spirit-being that the woman saw came up from the earth. If anyone in the group has seen a spirit-being or the spirit of a dead person, have that person describe what it looked like. Then discuss what words or phrases you will use to describe the spiritual being that the woman saw and how it "came up from the earth." Pause the audio here.

Then Saul asks the woman to describe what the spiritual being looks like. The woman says that she sees an old man wearing a robe coming up. From the woman's description, Saul immediately knows that the woman can see Samuel the prophet.

The story ends when Saul recognizes that Samuel has appeared to the woman. Saul bows himself down to the ground as a sign of deep respect for Samuel.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:3–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The prophet Samuel
- Saul, Israel's king
- The Philistine army
- The Israelite army
- Saul's advisors, or servants
- And the medium of Endor

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The Philistine and Israelite armies camp close to each other. King Saul becomes very afraid when Saul sees how big the Philistine army is. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am terrified by the sight of this great and powerful army! I do not know what to do or how to lead my army against them!

Continue the drama. Saul inquires of, or asks, Yahweh what Saul should do. But Yahweh does not answer Saul. Yahweh does not answer Saul by dreams, or by the Urim, or by prophets. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not know what to do to beat the Philistine army! I am seeking divine guidance from Yahweh, but Yahweh's prophet Samuel is dead and cannot help me! Yahweh sometimes speaks to people through dreams, but Yahweh is not speaking to me through dreams! Yahweh also speaks to his people through the Urim, but Yahweh is not speaking to me through the Urim either! or
- I urgently need an answer from Yahweh, but Yahweh is not responding to me. Why is Yahweh not responding to me? I am the king Yahweh placed over Yahweh's people, the Israelites. I am afraid we will all die!

Continue the drama. Then Saul asks Saul's advisors to find a woman who is a medium so that Saul can ask the woman what to do about the coming battle with the Philistines. Saul's advisors say there is a woman medium in the town of Endor, about a two-hour walk away. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know Yahweh does not permit people to talk to the spirit of a dead person, but Yahweh is not answering me. I am desperate to know what I should do in this battle against the Philistines! or
- I feel like I have no choice but to look for a medium to help me. It seems that Yahweh has abandoned me!

Now ask the people playing Saul's advisors, or servants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We do not understand why Saul wants to talk to a medium. Our job is just to do what Saul tells us to do; or
- Saul is behaving very strangely. We wonder why Yahweh is not answering Saul.

Continue the drama. Saul puts on different clothes so that people will not recognise Saul. Then Saul goes with his advisors to Endor at night to find the woman. Saul and Saul's advisors find the medium, and Saul asks the woman to call up the spirit of a dead person whom Saul wants to speak with. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want this woman, who is a medium, to recognise me. If the woman recognizes me, she will become afraid for her life and may not want to help me; or
- I really hope this woman can help me find out what I should know about the Philistine army. Otherwise, I do not know what I will do.

Continue the drama. The woman responds cautiously to Saul's request. The woman fears that Saul is trying to trap her. The woman says that Saul has already cut off, or killed, all the mediums and necromancers from the land of Israel, and she fears for her own life. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the woman who is a medium, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel afraid. I do not know these men. These men might be trying to deceive me into helping them so that King Saul will force me to leave the land of Israel, or worse still, have King Saul kill me!

Continue the drama. Saul makes an oath in Yahweh's name and promises the woman that she will not receive any punishment for helping Saul speak to the spirit of a dead man. After Saul makes this promise, the woman asks who Saul wants to bring up. Saul asks the woman to bring up the prophet Samuel.

The woman sees Samuel and cries out with a loud voice. Then the woman asks Saul why he deceived her about who Saul really is. Saul, the king, tells the woman not to be afraid. Then Saul asks the woman to describe what she sees. The woman says to Saul that she can see a spirit-figure coming up out of the earth. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the woman who is a medium, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I did not expect to suddenly see this spirit-figure coming up out of the earth. It frightened me! Now I can see that King Saul has deceived me, and I am even more afraid for my life!

Continue the drama. The woman describes to Saul what the spirit-figure looks like. The woman says it is an old man wearing a robe. After hearing this description, Saul knows the woman is seeing Samuel. Saul bows himself down to the ground to show reverence or respect to Samuel. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel relieved! I felt afraid to go to the woman who is a medium because I know it is dangerous to try to communicate with the spirit-world, and I know that Yahweh does not allow any contact with the dead! But I feel happier now because Samuel has appeared. Samuel is Yahweh's prophet, and now that Samuel has appeared, I will finally hear what Yahweh will say to me. I feel honoured that Yahweh would allow me to have this encounter with Samuel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:3–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The storyteller clearly calls Saul the **king** in this story to show the contrast between how Saul was supposed to behave as king and how Saul actually behaved. Use the same word or phrase for king as you have used in previous passages. King is in the Master Glossary.

Samuel the prophet had died, and the Israelites mourned or felt great sorrow because Samuel had died. The Israelites had buried Samuel's dead body in Samuel's hometown, Ramah. In addition, Saul had banned or removed all the mediums and necromancers from the land of Israel. A medium is a person who, people believed, could call up the spirit of a dead person. People sometimes call mediums witches. A necromancer is very similar to a

1 Samuel 28:3–14

medium. People thought a necromancer could communicate with the spirit of a dead person to reveal or influence future events, a bit like a “fortune teller.” People sometimes call necromancers “spiritists.”

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **mediums** and **necromancers**. Look up medium in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Saul asked **Yahweh** what to do about the Philistine army, but Yahweh refused to answer. Yahweh is God’s personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh did not respond to Saul with dreams, or Urim, or by the prophets. The Urim was an object which Yahweh authorized the priests to use as a way to “cast lots” and discover Yahweh’s guidance about a matter. While using the Urim and Thummim was a form of divination, it showed the priest what Yahweh wanted Yahweh’s people to do. The priest could then give that information to the people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Urim**. The word Urim also appears in the books of Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, as well as chapter 14 of 1 Samuel. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A **prophet** is a person who gives messages from Yahweh to the people. For more information, refer to prophet in the Master glossary. Use the same word or phrase for prophet as you used in previous passages.

Saul disguises himself and goes to Endor with two of Saul’s advisors. Saul asks the woman to consult the **spirit** of Samuel the prophet. The spirit, or soul, is the invisible, inner part of a person that continues to exist after a person dies. Refer to spirit in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word or phrase for spirit as you used in previous passages.

Saul vows, or makes an **oath** in Yahweh’s name, that no one will punish the woman for doing what Saul asks. An oath is a very serious promise. Refer to oath in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word for oath as you used in previous passages.

Saul tells the woman not to be afraid and asks what the woman sees. The woman says that she sees a spirit-like being coming up out of the earth. The woman tells Saul that the spirit looks like an old man wearing a **robe**. Saul recognizes that this is Samuel and **bows** down to the ground. Use the same words or phrases for bow down and robe as you have used in previous passages, and see bow and robe in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 28:3–14

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (858 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 28:15–25

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 28:15–25 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:15–25 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:15–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story continues the previous story when Saul, Israel's king, visited a woman who was a medium at Endor. You will remember that a medium is a person who, people believed, could call up the spirit of a dead person. The previous story ended when the medium described the spiritual being that she could see. Saul recognised the description as Samuel the prophet, and Saul bowed to the ground as a sign of deep respect to Samuel. Now, Samuel is about to speak to Saul.

This story shows that Yahweh will sometimes abandon a person who continues to abandon Yahweh. This story reminds us that Yahweh is a just and holy God whom people ought to fear and obey. When people continually disobey or sin, there are serious consequences.

Samuel now speaks directly to Saul without the help of the woman. Samuel asks Saul why Saul disturbed or troubled Samuel. In bringing Samuel's spirit up from the dead, Saul has interfered with the natural process of death. Some Bible scholars believe Samuel's question shows that Samuel was happily resting and did not like it when Saul interrupted Samuel's rest.

Stop here and, as a group, talk about what people in your culture believe happens to a person's soul once a person dies. Pause the audio here.

Saul tells Samuel why Saul called for Samuel to speak with Saul. Saul says Saul feels great distress or worry because the enemies of Israel, the Philistines, are at war with Saul and because God does not answer Saul. Saul says that God has turned away from or abandoned Saul and that God no longer answers Saul by prophets or by

dreams. Notice that Saul says God, and not Yahweh, here. Yahweh is God's personal name that the Israelites use and which Saul has been using until now. You will remember a previous story where Yahweh's spirit "departed from" or left Saul. Now, it seems Saul is recognising that Yahweh has indeed abandoned Saul. This may be why Saul refers to Yahweh as "God."

Samuel responds to Saul with another question. Samuel asks why Saul wants advice from Samuel about what Saul should do if Saul already knows that Yahweh has left Saul. Samuel says that Yahweh has become Saul's enemy. You will remember a previous story when Saul tore the fabric of the robe that Samuel wore. In that story, Samuel prophesied that Yahweh had rejected Saul and taken away Saul's rule as king over the kingdom of Israel, to give the rule to another Israelite man named David. Now, Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh has fulfilled the promise Yahweh made in that previous story.

Samuel reminds Saul of the reasons why Yahweh has given the kingdom to David. Samuel says it is because Saul did not obey Yahweh's voice or do what Yahweh told Saul to do about the Amalekite people. You will remember a previous story where Yahweh instructed Saul to completely destroy the Amalekites and everything the Amalekites owned, but Saul did not obey. Samuel says that Saul did not show Yahweh's fierce wrath or intense anger against the Amalekites. The Amalekites were enemies of Israel.

Then Samuel prophesies, or tells Saul what will soon happen. Samuel says that the very next day, Yahweh will give or deliver the Israelite army into the hand of the Philistines. This is special language to say that Yahweh will cause the Israelites to lose the battle against the Philistines. Samuel also says that the next day, Saul and Saul's sons will be where Samuel is, showing that Saul and Saul's sons will die the next day. Samuel ends his speech by repeating the prophecy or predicting that Yahweh will cause the Israelites to lose the battle against the Philistines.

Saul immediately falls, stretched out on the ground, when Saul hears Samuel's words. Saul probably falls in this way because Samuel said that Saul and Saul's sons would die a tragic death the next day. By now, Saul has probably learnt that Yahweh always does what Yahweh says he will do, so Saul knows with certainty that Saul will die the next day. This bad news fills Saul with fear. Sometimes, when a person hears bad news like this, it can cause the person to suddenly become weak and collapse to the ground. Also, Saul had eaten nothing that whole day and night, so Saul was already feeling weak in his body. Some Bible scholars think Saul probably fasted as a purification ritual to prepare himself to meet Samuel.

Stop here, and if you can, talk about a time when you received very bad news. Talk about how your body reacted at that moment. Pause the audio here.

Then the woman comes over to Saul. Seeing that Saul is terrified, the woman tries to help him. The woman addresses Saul respectfully and calls herself Saul's servant. The woman reminds Saul that she took her life into her own hands to obey Saul. This means that the woman risked Saul severely punishing her or even killing her because she broke the law. The woman now wants Saul to do as she asks. The woman offers to bring Saul a morsel of bread or something to eat so that Saul may regain his strength for the journey back to the Israelite camp.

Saul refuses to eat until Saul's advisors and the woman insist again. Then Saul listens to their words, meaning that Saul does what the advisors and the woman ask Saul to do. Some Bible scholars think this shows that Saul has accepted that this food may be the last thing Saul eats because he will die the next day. Saul gets up from the floor and sits on the bed, or couch, which may have been a mat or a solid piece of furniture for people to sit or sleep on.

The woman owns a fattened calf, so she quickly kills the calf and prepares it for Saul and Saul's advisors to eat. A fattened calf is a young cow whose owners have fed the calf well enough for it to become fat. Fat adds flavour and nutrients to the meat. The meat of cows was an acceptable food to eat amongst the Israelite community.

Then the woman takes some flour and kneads or presses it together to make unleavened bread. Flour is a grain that people grind into a powder and then mix with water to make bread. Unleavened bread is a type of flatbread that does not ferment or rise before people bake it. It was normal in that culture to show hospitality to visitors by providing food for the visitors to eat. The woman probably only had one fattened calf, so this meal would have been very costly for her. The woman honors Saul by giving Saul the best meal she can offer him.

1 Samuel 28:15–25

Stop here and look at a picture of a fattened cow, some flour, and unleavened bread as a group. Then, as a group, talk about the kinds of food people might like to give in your culture when they want to honour a visitor. Pause the audio here.

The woman brings the food to Saul and Saul's advisors, and they all eat. That same night, Saul and Saul's advisors get up and leave the woman's house.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:15–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The prophet Samuel and King Saul speak to each other. Samuel confirms that Yahweh has abandoned, or departed from, Saul. Samuel prophesies that Saul and Saul's sons will die the very next day, and Israel will be defeated by the Philistines.

In the second scene: Saul reacts to Samuel's words by falling to the ground. The woman and Saul's advisors encourage Saul to eat some food.

In the third scene: The woman feeds Saul and Saul's advisors. Then Saul and his advisors get up and leave.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel the prophet
- Saul, Israel's king
- The woman who is a medium
- And two men who are Saul's advisors, or servants

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story is a continuation of the previous story when Saul and two of Saul's advisors went to visit a woman who was a medium in Endor. In that story, Samuel, who was a dead prophet, appeared to the woman.

This whole story takes place at night. In the first scene, Samuel speaks directly to Saul without the help of the medium. Samuel asks why Saul has disturbed Samuel by calling Samuel back up. The word for disturbed makes someone think about someone stirring up a pile of leaves that a gust of wind blows around. The idea of Saul calling Samuel back up suggests that Samuel's spirit was resting somewhere below the earth, in the "underworld." Remember that in the previous story, the woman said she saw a spiritual being "coming up" out of the earth.

Saul says he called or summoned Samuel because Saul is worried about the threat of war with the Philistines. Saul also says he wants to speak to Samuel because God has "turned away" from Saul. This is special language that means that Yahweh has left, or abandoned, Saul. It is significant that Saul, in contrast to Samuel, now refers to Yahweh as God instead of as Yahweh. Make sure you include this detail in your translation.

Samuel asks Saul another question. Samuel asks why Saul expects Samuel to give Saul an answer from Yahweh if Yahweh has already abandoned or left Saul. Samuel's question shows that Samuel thinks Saul should not have asked Samuel what to do. Samuel says that Yahweh is now Saul's enemy.

Then Samuel says that Yahweh has torn the kingdom out of Saul's hands. This is special language to say that Yahweh has removed Saul from being the king over the kingdom or nation of Israel. Samuel says that Yahweh has given the kingship of Israel to a fellow Israelite named David. You will remember when Samuel prophesied or predicted all these things in a previous story.

Samuel says Yahweh took the kingdom away from Saul because Saul did not obey Yahweh's voice, which is special language that means Saul did not do what Yahweh told Saul to do. In a previous story, Yahweh told Saul

to completely destroy the Amalekite people and everything the Amalekites owned, but Saul did not obey. Now, Samuel says that Saul did not show Yahweh's fierce wrath or intense anger against the Amalekites.

Then Samuel tells Saul what will soon happen to Saul and the Israelites. Samuel says that the very next day, Yahweh will give or deliver the Israelite army into the hand of the Philistines. This is special language that means that Yahweh will cause the Israelites to lose the battle against the Philistines. Samuel also says that Saul and Saul's sons will "be where Samuel is." This indicates that Saul and his sons will die the next day. The words Samuel uses to say that Saul will die show us that Saul will die a tragic death. Samuel ends his speech by repeating the prophecy that Yahweh will cause the Israelites to lose the battle against the Philistines. This makes it completely clear to Saul that Yahweh will cause the Israelites to lose the battle against the Philistines.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that Saul and Saul's sons will soon "be where Samuel is." Is there a special word or phrase in your language that you can use to describe the place where people believe the spirit of a person goes once a person dies? Pause the audio here.

Notice that Samuel's spirit appears to leave now, because the storyteller no longer mentions Samuel in this story. In scene two, we hear that Saul immediately falls to the floor after hearing the death sentence that Samuel speaks over Saul's life. The passage says that Saul falls full-length to the ground, meaning Saul is fully stretched out, not that Saul collapses in a heap. It is not clear if Saul falls face down or face up on the ground. What is important to note is that Samuel's words fill Saul with fear or terror.

Then the woman comes to Saul. It is not clear if the woman is in the same place as Saul and just came closer to Saul, or if maybe the woman had previously left the place where Saul was and now comes back to Saul. The woman sees that Saul is terrified and in great distress on the floor, and the woman tries to help Saul. The woman says that because she listened to Saul and risked her own life by bringing up Samuel's spirit, the woman now wants Saul to listen to her and to do what the woman says.

Stop here and, as a group, discuss which words or phrases in your language will show how afraid and distressed Saul was in that moment. Pause the audio here.

The woman asks Saul to allow her to bring Saul a morsel of bread or some food to eat. The woman wants Saul to eat food to regain his strength for the journey back to the camp of the Israelite army, but Saul refuses to eat. Saul's advisors and the woman continue to urge Saul to eat. Finally, Saul agrees to eat. Then Saul gets up from the ground and sits on the bed or couch.

It is important to note how this story shows a contrast in Saul's behaviour. This passage highlights how Saul did not listen to Yahweh's voice or obey Yahweh's instructions, yet now, Saul listens to the voices of the woman and Saul's advisors and obeys them.

In the third scene, the woman quickly kills her fattened calf, or young cow, to prepare a meal for Saul and Saul's advisors. Then the woman mixes and kneads flour and bakes unleavened bread, or flatbread. Shortly after, the woman brings the meal to Saul and Saul's advisors, and they eat. Then Saul and Saul's advisors get up and leave. It is important to note that Saul and Saul's advisors leave that very same night.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:15–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Samuel the prophet
- Saul, Israel's king
- The woman who is a medium
- And two men who are Saul's advisors, or servants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Samuel asks why Saul has disturbed Samuel. Saul says he brought Samuel up because Saul feels great concern about the Philistine army, and because Yahweh does not answer Saul through prophets or dreams. Saul wants Samuel to tell Saul what to do. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so relieved! Finally, Samuel will tell me what I must do to overcome the Philistine army; or
- Yahweh has left me, just as Yahweh said he would. I feel like I can no longer use God's personal name, but I am thankful that God has allowed Samuel to come back up to speak to me!

Continue the drama. Samuel asks why Saul expects to receive an answer from Yahweh if Yahweh has already left Saul and become Saul's enemy. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Samuel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so frustrated by this man, Saul. Saul's behaviour is becoming irrational. I can hardly believe that Saul has failed to follow Yahweh's instructions against contacting the spirits of dead people, when Saul himself even banned the mediums from the land of Israel! or
- I previously told Saul that Yahweh had rejected Saul from being king over Israel. How can Saul be so foolish as to think that Yahweh will bless him because Saul called me back up from the place of the dead?

Continue the drama. Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh's words in a previous story have been fulfilled: Yahweh has taken the kingdom of Israel away from Saul and given it to David, because Saul did not obey Yahweh's instructions about the Amalekites.

Then Samuel tells Saul that the very next day, Saul and Saul's sons will die, and Israel will lose the battle against the Philistines. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel shocked and I am in panic! I did not expect Samuel to say these things! What can I do to stop this from happening?

Continue the drama. Samuel's words fill Saul with fear, and Saul falls to the ground. Saul loses all his strength because Saul has eaten nothing all day and night. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Surely Yahweh will fulfil the word he spoke through Yahweh's prophet Samuel! I feel terrified! What will happen to me? I was foolish not to obey Yahweh's instructions to destroy the Amalekites! I listened to the people and did what they wanted, but I did not listen to Yahweh and obey him. I wish I could go back and change what I did, but it is too late!

Continue the drama. The woman comes to Saul and sees that Saul is terrified. The woman offers to bring Saul some food, but Saul refuses to eat at first. Saul's advisors and the woman continue to urge Saul to eat, and finally, Saul agrees. Then Saul gets up from the floor and sits on the bed. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I think it is useless for me to eat this meal if I am to die tomorrow, but I will do as these people say. I still have a long journey ahead of me, and I need my strength. I will eat, even if it is probably going to be my last meal!

1 Samuel 28:15–25

Continue the drama. The woman quickly kills her fattened calf, bakes unleavened bread, and serves Saul and Saul's advisors a meal. That same night, after they have eaten, Saul and Saul's advisors leave the woman's house. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the woman, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The visit from Saul and the things that have happened tonight are very unusual. I do not know what will happen in the future, but I do know that the king of Israel came to my house tonight. I want to honour the king with the best meal I can give; or
- Saul needs to eat. Saul is in no condition to make the journey back to the Israelite's army camp; or
- I do not want Saul to change his mind again and decide to punish me for bringing up Samuel's spirit, so I will try to keep Saul happy by giving Saul a tasty meal before he leaves.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 28:15–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Samuel asks why Saul has disturbed Samuel by bringing Samuel, or calling Samuel up. Saul says that Saul is very worried because the Philistines are at war with Saul and because **God** has turned away from Saul. In the Bible, "God" refers to God who created everything and is the most powerful spiritual being. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Saul says that God does not answer Saul through the **prophets** or **dreams**. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Use the same word for prophet as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet and dreams, refer to the Master Glossary.

Samuel says Saul cannot expect an answer from **Yahweh** because Yahweh has already left Saul and become Saul's enemy. Yahweh is God's personal name. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

Samuel says Yahweh has taken the **kingdom** away out of Saul's **hands**, or **power**, and given it to Saul's **neighbour**, or fellow Israelite, David. A kingdom is the territory or the people that a king rules. Use the same word or phrase for kingdom as you used in previous passages. A neighbour can mean a person from your community or area. Use the same word for neighbour as you used in previous passages. For more information on kingdom and neighbour, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for taking something out of someone else's hands, or power, that you used in previous passages.

Samuel says Yahweh has left Saul because Saul did not obey Yahweh's instructions to destroy the Amalekite people. Then Samuel tells Saul that Yahweh will cause the Israelite army to lose the battle against the Philistine army the following day. Samuel also says that Saul and Saul's sons will all die the following day.

Saul falls to the ground, full of fear, because of Samuel's words and because Saul is weak since he has not eaten for many hours. Then the woman comes to Saul and respectfully tells Saul to eat. The woman calls herself Saul's **servant** as a sign of respect for Saul. At first, Saul refuses to eat, but after Saul's advisors and the woman insist, Saul gets up from the ground and sits on the bed or couch.

The woman kills and prepares a fattened calf for Saul and Saul's advisors to eat. A calf is a young cow. The woman also kneads flour and bakes unleavened **bread** for Saul and Saul's advisors to eat. After Saul and Saul's advisors eat, the men get up and leave. Use the same word for bread as you used in previous stories.

Stop here and, as a group, talk about what word or phrase you will use to say **a fattened calf**. If needed, look again at the picture of a fattened cow.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 28:15–25

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (866 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 29:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 29:1–11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 29:1–11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 29:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

When the Philistines gathered at Shunem to attack Israel, Saul became afraid and asked Yahweh what to do, but Yahweh did not answer. So, Saul asked a woman who speaks to the dead to bring up the spirit of the dead prophet Samuel, as Saul wanted to ask Samuel what Saul should do. In the previous story, Samuel's spirit told Saul that God took the kingdom of Israel from Saul and gave it to David, and that Saul and Saul's sons would die

in battle the next day, with the Philistines winning. Saul became scared and weak, so the woman gave Saul a meal to strengthen him, and then Saul and Saul's men left.

This story returns to the story of David and the Philistines, which the narrator interrupted to tell us about Saul speaking to Samuel's spirit. You will remember that all the Philistines were preparing to fight against the Israelites. The Philistine king, Achish, had told David that David and David's men would have to fight with the Philistine army against the men's own people, the Israelites. And Achish made David Achish's bodyguard forever.

At the start of the story, we learn that the Philistines gather all their forces at the town of Aphek. The last time we heard about the Philistines, they were in Shunem in the Jezreel Valley in Israel, about to fight the Israelites. But before the Philistines march to Shunem to fight Israel, the soldiers of the different Philistine lords or kings gather at Aphek in Philistine territory, 60 to 70 kilometres southwest of Shunem. The Israelite army had already camped by a spring of water in the Jezreel Valley. This spring, probably the En Harod spring, comes out from a rock at the foot of Mount Gilboa, making a pool and then a brook through the valley. The spring is about 10 to 15 kilometers southeast of Shunem.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Locate the Philistine town of Aphek and the Israelite camp by Mount Gilboa. Pause this audio here.

The five Philistine lords, or kings, gather their troops and march out for battle against the Israelites in traditional military units—in groups of a hundred and a thousand soldiers. Each king from the five main Philistine cities has his own army. The fact that the kings are going to battle shows that the kings think it is an important battle. Achish, the king of Gath, is at the back with his soldiers. David and David's men march with Achish and Achish's troops at the rear.

The Philistine commanders ask King Achish, "What are these Hebrews doing here?" The commanders are probably the army leaders of units of thousands and hundreds, not the city lords or kings. The commanders want to know why there are Hebrew soldiers with the Philistine army. The Philistines used the word "Hebrews" in a negative way to describe the Israelites as weak or unimportant. Only non-Israelites, like the Philistines, called the Israelites Hebrews.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about the organisation of the army in your people group. How big are the army units, and what are the positions of those who oversee the units? What is the most senior position in the whole army in your people group? Pause this audio here.

Achish replies to the commanders by asking a question that does not need an answer but makes a strong point. Achish explains who David is and why the commanders can trust David. Achish says he trusts David, the servant of Saul, the king of Israel, because David and David's men have been with Achish for over a year. Since David left Saul and joined Achish's army, Achish has not seen David do anything disloyal.

The Philistine commanders are angry with King Achish because they fear that David and David's men will turn against the Philistines during the battle. The commanders tell Achish to send David back to the place Achish gave David instead of letting David fight. The commanders are talking about Ziklag, a city on the border between the Philistines' land and the territory of the tribe of Judah, which Achish gave to David. The commanders do not want David to join the battle, because the commanders worry that David might switch sides and become their enemy. The commanders may remember how some Hebrew soldiers who had previously joined the Philistines turned against the commanders during a battle.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What are the terms under which foreigners can join the army of your people group? What do the foreigners need to do to prove that they will be loyal during a military campaign? Pause this audio here.

The Philistine commanders point out to Achish that a good way for David to get Saul to like David again would be to kill some Philistine soldiers. Victorious soldiers sometimes cut off the heads of defeated enemies and their commanders. The commanders ask Achish, "How could this fellow make peace with his lord? Would it not be with the heads of the men here?"

The Philistine commanders remind Achish that David is the same person people celebrated with songs and dances, singing, "Saul has killed his thousands, and David his ten thousands." The commanders quote the song

that women sang about David's victories over the Philistines to show how strong David is. The commanders point out that David's strength could be a danger to the Philistines.

Stop here and, as a group, tell a story of how foreigners came to help your people group in battle. Pause this audio here.

Achish does not want to go against the other leaders, so Achish calls David and tells David about the commanders' concerns. But Achish does not share all the details. To show David Achish is telling the truth, Achish swears solemnly in the name of David's God, saying, "As Yahweh lives, you have been upright." Achish believes David has been trustworthy. Achish says to David that Achish would be pleased to have David serve in the army. Achish says he has not seen David do anything disloyal since joining, but the other kings do not trust David. This is probably because the military commanders warned the kings that David might not stay loyal during the battle. So, Achish asks David to go back to Ziklag peacefully and avoid upsetting the Philistine kings. "Go in peace" could be a kind way of saying goodbye, but here it probably also means that Achish wants David and David's men to leave without causing trouble. Achish mentions this so that David will not do anything to anger the kings.

David asks King Achish what David has done wrong. David probably wants to prove David has not done anything bad and see if Achish is being honest. Achish replies to David and assures David even more strongly that Achish believes David is completely loyal and upright. Achish says David is like an angel of God, or a messenger from heaven to Achish. Achish means David is completely good or faultless, like an angel. But the Philistine army commanders do not want David to fight in the battle against Israel.

Achish tells David to go back to Ziklag right away. Achish tells David to get up early the next morning and leave with the servants of David's lord who came with David. Achish calls David's men servants of King Saul because the men served Saul before they came to serve Achish in Gath. David and David's men are supposed to leave as soon as it is light enough to see.

David and David's men do what Achish tells them. Early the next morning, the men get up, leave the camp, and start their journey back to Philistine territory. Meanwhile, the Philistine army marches from Aphek toward Jezreel.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Find the journey David and David's men took from Aphek to Ziklag and the journey the Philistine army took from Aphek to Jezreel.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 29:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The Philistine army gathers at Aphek, and the Israelites camp near Mount Gilboa by a spring in the Jezreel Valley. The Philistines march out for battle in groups of hundreds and thousands, while David and David's men march at the back with King Achish.

In the second scene: The Philistine commanders ask Achish why Hebrew soldiers are in their army. Achish defends David, saying David has been loyal for over a year since leaving Saul, Israel's king. Achish explains that Achish has never seen David do anything untrustworthy.

In the third scene: The Philistine commanders become angry and demand that Achish send David back to Ziklag. The commanders worry David might switch sides during the battle to win back Saul's favor. The commanders remind Achish about the songs people sang about David defeating the Philistines.

In the fourth scene: Achish tells David that Achish believes David has been trustworthy and that he would gladly have David fight in his army. However, the other kings do not trust David, so Achish asks David to return peacefully to Ziklag and avoid causing trouble.

In the fifth scene: David respectfully asks Achish what David has done wrong and why Achish does not allow David to fight the king's enemies.

In the sixth scene: Achish tells David to leave early the next morning with David's men. The men leave the camp at dawn and head back to Philistine territory, while the Philistine army marches from Aphek toward Jezreel.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Philistine army
- The Israelite army
- The lords or kings of the Philistine cities
- David
- David's men
- King Achish
- And Philistine army commanders

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story starts from before Saul talked to the woman who speaks to the dead and shifts focus back to the Philistines. In this story, the Philistines have gathered all their forces at the town of Aphek. The Philistines are preparing to fight against the Israelites. Remember, this takes place before the Philistines marched to Shunem in the valley of Jezreel. At the same time, the Israelite army camped by a spring in the Jezreel valley, which was most likely the En Harod spring at the foot of Mount Gilboa.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Locate the Philistine town of Aphek and the Israelite camp by Mount Gilboa. Pause this audio here.

The five Philistine lords, or kings, gather their troops and march out for battle in groups of a hundred and a thousand men. King Achish and his soldiers are at the back. David and David's men march with Achish and Achish's troops at the rear.

The Philistine commanders ask King Achish why there are Hebrew soldiers with their army. The Philistines used the word "Hebrews" in a negative way to describe the Israelites as weak or unimportant. Only non-Israelites like the Philistines use this word to talk about the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about negative words that people use in your language to refer to other people groups in a negative way. Pause this audio here.

Achish replies to the commanders by asking a question that does not need an answer, but makes a strong statement. Achish asks, "Is this not David, the servant of Saul, the king of Israel? David has been with me for a long time, and since he came to me, I have not found anything wrong with him until now." Achish explains who David is and why the commanders can trust David. Achish says he trusts David, the servant of Saul, Israel's king, because David and David's men have been with Achish "for days and years," which means for over a year. Since David left Saul and joined Achish's army, Achish has not seen David do anything disloyal.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Achish says "for days and years" to show that David has been with Achish for more than a year. What words or phrases do you use in your language to talk about different amounts of time, like a year or longer? Pause this audio here.

The Philistine commanders are angry with King Achish. The commanders tell Achish to send David back to Ziklag, the city Achish gave David, instead of letting David fight. The commanders do not want David to join the battle, because the commanders worry that David might switch sides and become their enemy. The commanders say to Achish, "David shall not go down with us to the battle." The commanders probably say "go down to the battle" because armies fought battles in valleys and not on hillsides, and the armies would be going down into the valley of Jezreel.

The Philistine commanders point out to Achish that a good way for David to get Saul to like David again would be to kill some Philistine soldiers. The commanders ask Achish, "How could this fellow make peace with his lord? Would it not be with the heads of the men here?" The commanders call David "this fellow" to insult David because the commanders are angry.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do people call someone in your language to insult that person because they are angry with the person? Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 29:1–11

The Philistine commanders ask Achish a question that does not need an answer. The commanders make a strong point that David is the same person whom people celebrated with songs and dances. People were singing, “Saul has killed his thousands, and David his ten thousands.” The commanders quote the song that women sang about David’s victories over the Philistines to point out how strong David is and that David could be a danger to the Philistines. Please note that you translated this song before in 1 Samuel 18:7 and 1 Samuel 21:11.

So Achish calls David and tells Achish about the commanders’ concerns. But Achish does not share all the details. To show David that Achish is telling the truth, Achish swears an oath in the name of David’s God and says, “As Yahweh lives, you have been upright.” Achish says to David that Achish would be pleased to have David serve or “go forth and come back” in the army. Achish says Achish has not seen David do anything disloyal since joining, but the other kings do not trust David. So, Achish asks David to go back to Ziklag peacefully, without causing trouble and to avoid upsetting the Philistine kings.

David asks King Achish what David has done wrong. Then David asks Achish again what David has done during David’s time serving Achish that would make Achish not allow David to fight against the king’s enemies. David speaks to Achish very respectfully. First, David refers to himself as Achish’s servant, and then David politely calls Achish “my lord the king.”

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say in your language to show respect when you speak to someone older or in authority? Pause this audio here.

Achish replies to David and assures David even more strongly that Achish believes David is completely loyal and upright. Achish says David is like an angel of God to Achish, meaning David is completely good or faultless, like an angel. Achish tells David that, despite that, the Philistine army commanders do not want David to fight in the battle against Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Achish compares David to God’s angel to show that Achish thinks of David as faultless. What do you say in your language when you want to say someone is perfect or faultless? Pause this audio here.

Achish tells David to go back to Ziklag right away. Achish uses language that shows Achish wants David and David’s men to be urgent about leaving the camp. Achish starts by saying, “Now then, rise early in the morning,” and Achish tells David to leave with David’s men as soon as it is light enough to see.

David and David’s men follow Achish’s orders. Early the next morning, the men get up, leave the camp, and head back to Philistine territory. At the same time, the Philistine army marches to Jezreel from Aphek.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Find the journey David and his men took from Aphek to Ziklag and the journey the Philistine army took from Aphek to Jezreel.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 29:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Philistine army
- The Israelite army
- The lords or kings of the Philistine cities
- David
- David’s men
- King Achish
- And Philistine army commanders

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The Philistine army gathers at a town called Aphek, and the Israelite army is camped by a spring in the Jezreel valley near Mount Gilboa. The Philistine kings and their army march out from Aphek for battle against the Israelites in groups of a hundred and a thousand men. David and David's men march with Achish and Achish's troops at the rear. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel awful. I will have to attack my own people, the Israelites! or
- I feel scared about what will happen to me and my men when we refuse to fight the men of Israel, or if Achish makes us fight the men of Israel!
- I feel hopeful that Yahweh will help us in this situation. Yahweh is faithful.

Continue the drama.

The army commanders ask Achish why there are Hebrew soldiers with Achish's army. Achish replies to the commanders and explains who David is and why they can trust David. Achish says he trusts David, the servant of the king of Israel, because David and David's men have been with Achish for over a year. Since David left Saul and joined Achish's army, Achish has not seen David do anything disloyal.

The Philistine commanders are angry with King Achish. The commanders tell Achish to send David back to the place Achish gave David instead of letting David fight. The commanders do not want David to join the battle, and worry that David might switch sides and become their enemy. The commanders point out to Achish that a good way for David to get Saul to like David again would be to kill some Philistine soldiers. The Philistine commanders remind Achish that David is the same person people celebrated with songs and dances, and the commanders quote a song women sang about David after David won a battle against the Philistines: "Saul has killed his thousands, and David his ten thousands." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing a Philistine army commander, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry! How are we to go to battle alongside the Hebrews? These men could betray us to King Saul! or
- I am surprised that King Achish does not realise that David is so strong. Has Achish not heard the song women sang about David killing thousands of our men? or
- I strongly feel that Achish must send David and David's men back to Ziklag.

Continue the drama. Achish calls David and swears solemnly in the name of David's God, Yahweh, and Achish tells David he believes David has been trustworthy. Achish says that Achish would be pleased to have David serve in the army, because Achish has not seen David do anything disloyal since joining, but the other kings do not trust David. So, Achish asks David to go back to Ziklag peacefully without causing trouble and to avoid upsetting the Philistine kings. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Achish, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so sad that the army commanders and the other kings do not trust David; or
- I feel I have to be loyal to the other kings and tell David to go back to Ziklag, even though David is an honest soldier, and I cannot fault David; or
- I feel embarrassed that I have to tell David he cannot come to battle with my army. I will make sure David knows I have found nothing wrong with David.

Continue the drama. David replies and asks King Achish what David has done wrong. Then David respectfully asks Achish again what David has done during his time serving Achish that would make Achish not allow David

to fight against the king's enemies. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel relieved that I will not have to fight against Israel's army; or
- I feel suspicious. Why does King Achish want me to go back to Ziklag? Achish said he was happy with my service and even made me his bodyguard forever; or
- I feel grateful to Yahweh for taking me and my men out of this difficult situation. I do not want to betray King Saul.

Continue the drama. Achish tells David to get up early the next morning and leave with David's men as soon as it is light enough to see. So early the next morning, the men get up, leave the camp, and start their journey back to Philistine territory. Meanwhile, the Philistine army marches from Aphek toward Jezreel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 29:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The Philistine army gathers at a town called Aphek, and the Israelite army is camped by a spring in the Jezreel valley near Mount Gilboa. The Philistine **lords**, or kings and their army march out for battle against the Israelites in groups of a hundred and a thousand men. Use the same word or phrase for lords as you used in previous passages. For more information on lord, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Philistine army **commanders** ask **King** Achish why there are **Hebrews**, or Hebrew soldiers, with their army. Achish says he trusts David, the **servant** of Saul, the king of **Israel**, because David and David's men have been with Achish for over a year. Since David left Saul and joined Achish's army, Achish has not seen David do anything disloyal. Use the same words or phrases for commanders, Hebrews, servant, king, and Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Hebrews, servant, king, and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then Achish calls David and says to David, "As Yahweh lives, you have been honest." Achish says to David that he would be pleased to have David serve in the army because Achish has not seen David do anything disloyal since joining, but the other kings do not trust David. Remember previous times when you have translated people giving a strong promise that includes the words "as Yahweh lives," and translate this in a similar way.

Yahweh is God's personal name, and this story uses this name throughout this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Achish asks David to go back "in **peace**," or without fighting or causing trouble. This was either a normal way to say goodbye, or Achish was asking David specifically not to cause trouble. Use the same word for peace that you have used before. For more information on peace, refer to the Master Glossary.

Achish answers David and says that David is as blameless in Achish's sight as an angel of God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **angel**. Look up angel in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **God** as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 29:1–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (925 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 30:1–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 30:1–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:1–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, the Philistine army gathered at Aphek to attack the Israelites near Mount Gilboa. The Philistine commanders did not want David and his men to fight with the Philistines, because the commanders were afraid David might betray them and help Saul. Though King Achish trusted David, Achish sent David and his men back to Ziklag to please the Philistine commanders.

While David and David's men are away, the Amalekites attack the city of Ziklag and the Negev wilderness in the southern part of the territory of the tribe of Judah. The Amalekites had fought the Israelites many times

before. Ziklag is a city God promised to give to the tribes of Judah and Simeon, but now Ziklag is part of Philistine territory. King Achish gave Ziklag to David and David's men. The Amalekites conquer and burn down Ziklag, probably without a fight, since the men are away with David. The Amalekites likely do this to get revenge because David had raided the Amalekites' towns before.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Identify Ziklag and the Negev wilderness

in the territory of the tribe of Judah. Identify the area south of Beersheba where the Amalekites lived. Pause this audio here.

The Amalekites take the women and everyone in the city, whether young or old, important or not, but they do not kill anyone. Instead, they force the people from Ziklag to go with them, probably to the countryside where no one lives.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about the last time an enemy attacked your territory. What happened? Talk about the last time your army attacked another people group. What happened? Pause this audio here.

After leaving King Achish near Aphek, David and his men reach Ziklag on the third day. When David and his men arrive, they find that the Amalekites had destroyed their city by fire and taken their wives, sons, and daughters captive. Among those the Amalekites captured are David's two wives, Ahinoam from Jezreel and Abigail, who was once married to Nabal from the village of Carmel in the territory of Judah's tribe. In that culture, it was common for men to have more than one wife.

Stop here and look at the map. Identify the journey that David and David's men took from Aphek to Ziklag. Pause this audio here.

David and his men saw that the Amalekites took their entire families. The men mourn and cry loudly until they are too weak to cry anymore.

Stop here and, as a group, tell a story about a time when you saw people weep like this. Pause this audio here.

Now David is in big trouble because the men in David's army talk about stoning David. Yahweh sometimes commanded stoning to punish people who broke certain laws. An angry crowd could also use stoning to kill someone. David's men do not just want to hurt David—they want to kill David. The men feel bitter in their souls, or in the inner part of themselves. Usually, "bitter" describes something that tastes bad, but here it means the men feel deeply upset. David's men's souls are filled with anger and sadness because the Amalekites have taken their sons and daughters. The men blame David for losing their families. But David makes himself strong by trusting Yahweh, David's God. In this dangerous and confusing time, David turns to Yahweh, who gives David strength. This kind of strength means peace, confidence, and courage, not physical strength.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do the people in your people group talk about the part of a person that has emotions, thoughts, and feelings? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your people group show their unhappiness to the leaders when they blame the leaders when something bad or tragic happens? Could you tell a story of when this happened? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you become strong again by trusting Yahweh when something hard or difficult happens in your life? What do you do to turn to Yahweh, and how does Yahweh give you peace? What do people who follow other gods do to receive peace and encouragement from these gods? Pause this audio here.

David asks Abiathar the priest, Ahimelech's son, to bring David the ephod so Abiathar can ask Yahweh what to do. Abiathar has been with David since he fled from Nob. Abiathar is now the rightful high priest, and Abiathar brings the ephod. The ephod is a piece of priestly clothing that contains the Urim and Thummim, two objects the high priest uses to ask Yahweh for guidance. David asks Yahweh through the ephod, "Should I chase the group of raiders? Will I catch them?" David wants to know if David can catch the raiders if David goes after the raiders. Yahweh answers and tells David to chase the raiders. Yahweh promises that David will catch the raiders and rescue the women and children.

David leads his 600 men to Besor Brook, a large stream in the wilderness of western Negev. In the rainy season, the brook is 100 to 150 meters wide and carries water to the Mediterranean Sea. But in the dry season, the

1 Samuel 30:1–15

brook has no water and its sides are steep, so people sometimes call the brook Besor Valley or Besor Gorge. Two hundred of David's men are too tired to cross the valley, so the men stay behind on the other side. David and the other 400 men cross Besor Valley and keep chasing the Amalekites.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Locate Brook Besor. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: We do not know if there was water in this valley at this time. In any case, it would have been difficult to cross. How do you cross a steep valley, a brook, or a river in your area? Pause this audio here.

David's men find an Egyptian man in a field while they are traveling through the wilderness. David's men bring the Egyptian man to David and give the man some bread to eat and water to drink. Here, "bread" may just mean food in general. The men also give the Egyptian man a piece of fig cake and two cakes of raisins. Figs and raisins are common for travellers to carry because they are filling and nutritious. A fig cake is dried figs that people press into a round shape, and cakes of raisins are chunks of dried grapes. The Egyptian man eats the food, and it makes the man feel better. The man had not eaten or drunk anything for three days.

Stop here and, as a group, look at pictures of figs and raisins, fig cakes and raisin cakes. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kind of food do people in your people group carry with them when travelling? What food do people consider to be nutritious and long-lasting? Talk about a time when you ate food like that and felt better. Pause this audio here.

David asks the Egyptian man who his master is and where the man comes from. David likely guesses from the man's clothes that the man is a slave. The man says he is a young Egyptian and a servant, or slave, to an Amalekite master. Most servants had no choice and were like slaves, unable to leave or get paid. Instead, the servants' masters gave them food, clothes, and shelter. It is unclear if the Egyptian became a slave through war, if someone bought the Egyptian, or if the Egyptian was born a slave. The Egyptian tells David that three days ago, the Egyptian got sick, and his Amalekite master left the Egyptian to die in the countryside because the Egyptian was too weak to travel. That is why the Egyptian had not eaten or drunk anything for three days.

The young Egyptian tells David that before his Amalekite master abandoned the Egyptian, the Amalekites raided four places: the Negev of the Kerethites, the territory of Judah, the Negev of Caleb, and the city of Ziklag, which they burned down. All four places were in the Negev wilderness, a big dry wilderness that mostly belonged to the tribe of Judah. Yahweh promised the Negev Wilderness to Israel, but other people groups still lived there. The Negev of the Kerethites was where the Kerethites lived. The territory of Judah refers to the part of the Negev Wilderness where people from the tribe of Judah lived, close to the Negev of the Kerethites. The Amalekites probably raided the Negev of the Kerethites and then went into the land where people from the tribe of Judah lived. This does not mean the Amalekites took over all of Judah's land or raided every town, just certain areas. The Negev of Caleb was where Caleb's family lived. Caleb was one of the 12 spies Moses sent to explore Canaan. Yahweh gave Caleb Hebron in southern Judah. Caleb's family stayed near Hebron after Caleb died. The Amalekites raided both Israelite and non-Israelite lands. Ziklag was probably the farthest west the Amalekites went, and the Amalekites set Ziklag on fire.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Identify the areas the Amalekites raided. Pause this audio here.

David asks the Egyptian if the Egyptian can guide David to the raiders. David says, "Will you take me down to this band of raiders?" Since the wilderness is mountainous, David likely wants the Egyptian to lead David from the hills down to the valley where the Amalekites are staying. David calls the Amalekites "a band of raiders," meaning the Amalekites are thieves, not an army. The Egyptian agrees to help but only if David promises not to kill the Egyptian or send the Egyptian back to his Amalekite master. The Egyptian asks David to swear before God to keep David's promise. Swearing before God means to make a serious promise, an oath, with God as a witness. People swear like this to convince others that they are not lying.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 30:1–15

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has eight scenes.

In the first scene: While David and his men are away, the Amalekites attack the city of Ziklag and other parts of the Negev wilderness. The Amalekites conquer and burn down the city of Ziklag. The Amalekites take the women and children from the city of Ziklag and make the people go with the Amalekites.

In the second scene: David and his men leave King Achish near Aphek, and the men reach Ziklag on the third day. David and David's men find that the Amalekites destroyed the men's city by fire and took their wives, sons, and daughters captive.

In the third scene: When David and David's men see that the Amalekites took their families, the men mourn and cry loudly until they are too weak to cry anymore.

In the fourth scene: David is in big trouble because the men in David's army talk about stoning David to kill him. David's men feel deeply upset, and they blame David for losing their families. But David makes himself strong by trusting Yahweh, David's God.

In the fifth scene: David asks Abiathar the priest to bring David the ephod so he can ask Yahweh what to do. Abiathar brings the ephod, and David asks Yahweh if he can catch the raiders if David goes after the raiders. Yahweh answers and tells David to chase the raiders and promises that David will catch the raiders and rescue the women and children.

In the sixth scene: David leads his 600 men to Besor Brook, a large stream in the wilderness of western Negev. Two hundred of David's men are too tired to cross, so they stay behind by the brook. David and the other 400 men cross Besor Brook and keep chasing the Amalekites.

In the seventh scene: David's men find an Egyptian man in a field. The men bring the Egyptian to David and give the man some food, which strengthens the man. The man had not eaten or drunk anything for three days. David finds out that the young Egyptian is a servant or slave to an Amalekite master. Three days before, the Egyptian had gotten sick, and the Egyptian's Amalekite master left him alone in the countryside to die.

In the eighth scene: The young Egyptian tells David that before his Amalekite master abandoned him, the Amalekites raided four places: the Negev of the Kerethites, the Negev of Judah, the Negev of Caleb, and the city of Ziklag, which the Amalekites burned down. David asks the Egyptian if he can guide David to the raiders. The Egyptian agrees to take David to the raiders but only if David promises not to kill the Egyptian or send him back to his Amalekite master. The Egyptian asks David to swear before God that David will keep David's promise.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Amalekite raiders
- Women and children from Ziklag who are the wives and children of David and David's men
- David
- David's men
- David's wife, Ahinoam, of Jezreel
- David's wife, Abigail, the widow of Nabal
- And the young Egyptian

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage begins when David and his men come back to Ziklag and find that the Amalekites have raided Ziklag. Here we are retelling the story chronologically as it happened.

While David and his men are away, the Amalekites attack the city of Ziklag and the Negev wilderness in the southern part of the territory of the tribe of Judah. The Amalekites conquer and burn down the city of Ziklag, probably without a fight, since David and David's men are away.

The Amalekites take the women and everyone in the city, "both small and great," as prisoners. "Both small and great" probably means people of all ages and importance. The Amalekites capture everyone, whether young or

old, important or not, but they do not kill anyone. Instead, they force the people from Ziklag to go with them, probably to the countryside where no one lives.

After David and David's men leave King Achish near Aphek, they reach Ziklag on the third day. The storyteller counted the day they left as the first day. The men arrived two full days later, on the third day. The men would have walked between 125 and 145 kilometres. When David and his men arrive, the men find that the Amalekites destroyed their city by fire and took their wives, sons, and daughters captive. Among those the Amalekites captured are David's two wives, Ahinoam from Jezreel and Abigail, who was once married to Nabal from the village of Carmel in the territory of the tribe of Judah.

Stop here and look at the map. Identify the journey that David and his men took from Aphek to Ziklag. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you count days in your culture? Pause this audio here.

When David and his men see that the Amalekites took their families, the men mourn and cry loudly until they are too weak to cry anymore.

Now David is in big trouble because the men in David's army talk about stoning David to kill David. The men feel bitter in their souls, which means that the men feel deeply upset. The men blame David for losing their families. But David makes himself strong by trusting Yahweh, David's God. In this dangerous and confusing time, David turns to Yahweh, who gives David strength, which here means peace, confidence, and courage, not physical strength.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you talk in your language about crying so much? What do you say when someone is deeply upset or feels bitter in their spirit? Pause this audio here.

David asks Abiathar the priest, the son of Ahimelech, to bring David the ephod so David can ask Yahweh what to do. Abiathar brings the ephod. The ephod was a piece of the high priest's clothing. The storyteller may not mean that Abiathar brought the piece of clothing. Instead, the ephod symbolises the Urim and the Thummim, the two objects the priest used to discover Yahweh's will, which were inside the ephod. David asks Yahweh if David can catch the raiders if David goes after them. Yahweh tells David to chase the raiders and promises that David will catch the raiders and rescue the women and children.

David leads his 600 men to Besor Brook or valley, a large stream in the wilderness of western Negev. Besor Brook is about 19 to 21 kilometers from Ziklag, and in the rainy season, the brook is 100 to 150 meters wide. In the dry season, this brook has no water, but the sides are very steep. Two hundred of David's men are too tired to cross the brook, so these men stay behind by the valley. It is likely that the brook had at least some water in it and was a good place to rest and recover. David and the other 400 men cross Besor Brook and keep chasing the Amalekites.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Locate Besor Brook. Pause this audio here.

David's men find an Egyptian man in a field while they are traveling through the wilderness. The men bring the Egyptian to David and give the man some bread to eat and water to drink. The word bread may mean food in general. The men also give the Egyptian a piece of fig cake and two cakes of raisins. The Egyptian man eats the food, and the food makes the man feel better. The story says the man's spirit returns to him, which means the Egyptian feels stronger, not that he died and came back to life. The Egyptian man had not eaten or drunk anything for three days.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words do you have in your language that mean food in general? Decide which word will work best here. Will you use a word for bread or a word for food in general? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say to show that someone who was very weak has regained their strength? Pause this audio here.

David asks the Egyptian man who the man's master is and where the Egyptian comes from. The man says that he is a young Egyptian and a servant, or slave, to an Amalekite master. The Egyptian tells David that three days ago, the Egyptian got sick, and his Amalekite master left him alone in the countryside to die because the Egyptian was not strong enough to travel. That is why the man had not eaten or drunk anything for three days.

1 Samuel 30:1–15

The young Egyptian tells David that before his Amalekite master abandoned him, the Amalekites raided four places: the Negev of the Kerethites, the Negev of Judah, the Negev of Caleb, and the city of Ziklag, which the Amalekites burned down. All four places were in the Negev, a big dry wilderness that mostly belonged to the tribe of Judah.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map. Identify the areas that the Amalekites raided. Pause this audio here.

David asks the Egyptian if the man can guide David to the raiders. David calls the Amalekites "a band of raiders," meaning they are people who steal, not an army. The Egyptian agrees to take David to the raiders but only if David promises not to kill the Egyptian or send him back to his Amalekite master. The Egyptian asks David to swear before God that David will keep his promise.

Stop here and, as a group, talk about what word or phrase you will use to describe the band or raiders to show that they are not an army but people who steal.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has eight scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Amalekite raiders
- Women and children from Ziklag who are the wives and children of David and David's men
- David
- David's men
- David's wife, Ahinoam, of Jezreel
- David's wife, Abigail, the widow of Nabal
- And the young Egyptian

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

While David and his men are away, the Amalekites attack the city of Ziklag and other parts of the Negev wilderness. The Amalekites conquer and burn down the city of Ziklag. The Amalekites take the women and children from the city of Ziklag and make the people go with the Amalekites. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel very scared! The raiders burned our city and are taking us and our children away; or
- We feel angry and disappointed that our husbands are not here to protect us; or
- We are hoping and trusting that Yahweh will save us and keep us safe.

Continue the drama. After leaving King Achish near Aphek, David and his men reach Ziklag on the third day. The men find that the Amalekites destroyed their city by fire and took their wives, sons, and daughters captive.

Having seen that the Amalekites took their families, David and his men mourn and cry loudly until they are too weak to cry anymore. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel heartbroken that the Amalekites have kidnapped our wives and our children; or
- We feel hopeless. What can we now do? Our wives and children are probably very far away now; or
- We feel so scared. Will the Amalekite raiders keep our wives and children alive? or
- We regret following David! It is because of David that the Amalekites stole our wives and children.

Continue the drama. David is in big trouble because the men in his army talk about stoning David to kill him. David's men feel deeply upset, and they blame David for losing their families. But David makes himself strong by trusting Yahweh, David's God. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am scared. The men blame me for the loss of their families, and the men want to stone me! or
- I feel so sad that I let my men down. What can we do? I do not know where the women and children are; or
- I feel hopeful. I can and I will trust Yahweh. That is the only solution I have. I will ask Yahweh what to do.

Continue the drama. David asks Abiathar the priest to bring David the ephod so David can ask Yahweh what to do. Abiathar brings the ephod and David asks Yahweh if David can catch the raiders if David goes after them. Yahweh answers and tells David to chase the raiders and promises that David will catch them and rescue the women and children.

David leads his 600 men to Besor Brook, a large stream in the wilderness of western Negev. Two hundred of David's men are too tired to cross, so they stay behind by the brook. David and the other 400 men cross Besor Brook and keep chasing the Amalekites. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We trust David again. Yahweh told David that we will catch up with the raiding party! or
- We are desperate to free our wives and children. We must leave behind two hundred of our men who are too tired to cross the brook; or
- We have renewed hope in seeing our families again.

Continue the drama. David's men find an Egyptian man in a field while they are traveling through the wilderness. The men bring the Egyptian to David and give the man some bread to eat and water to drink. The men also give the Egyptian a piece of fig cake and two cakes of raisins. The Egyptian man eats the food, and it makes him feel better. The Egyptian had not eaten or drunk anything for three days. David finds out that the young Egyptian is a slave to an Amalekite master. Three days before, the Egyptian had gotten sick, and the Egyptian's Amalekite master had left the Egyptian alone in the countryside to die.

The young Egyptian tells David that before his Amalekite master abandoned him, the Amalekites raided four places: the Negev of the Kerethites, the Negev of Judah, the Negev of Caleb, and the city of Ziklag, which the Amalekites burned down. David asks the Egyptian if he can guide David to the raiders. The Egyptian agrees to take David to the raiders but only if David promises not to kill the Egyptian or send him back to his Amalekite master. The Egyptian asks David to swear before God that David will keep his promise. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the young Egyptian, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am grateful that David and his men saved me from dying in the wilderness; or
- I am interested to know why David has saved me and did not leave me to die; or
- I am happy to take these men to the Amalekite band or raiders, but I am worried that they will kill me or return me to my master; or
- I will only help these men if David swears by his God that he will not return me to my master or kill me.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

1 Samuel 30:1–15

David is in big trouble because the men in David's army talk about stoning David to kill him. David's men feel bitter in their souls, or very upset. The men blame David for losing their families. But David makes himself strong by trusting Yahweh, David's God.

God created people with bodies, and we can touch and see each other's bodies. But God also created people with thoughts and feelings and desires. We cannot see this part of a person, but we know it is there. This invisible part of a person is in the Bible usually called a soul. Even when our body dies, our soul may live on. David's men were bitter in their soul, which means that they were deeply upset.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **soul**. Look up soul in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh is **God's** personal name, and the story uses this name throughout this passage. David found strength in Yahweh, David's God. Use the same name for Yahweh and God that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh and God, refer to the Master Glossary.

David asks Abiathar the **priest** to bring David the **ephod**. Abiathar brings the ephod, and David asks Yahweh if David can catch the raiders if David goes after the raiders. The ephod is a piece of priestly clothing that contains the Urim and Thummim, two objects the high priest uses to ask Yahweh for guidance. In this story, the ephod probably symbolizes the way that the priest asks Yahweh for guidance. Use the same words or phrases for priest and ephod as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest and ephod, refer to the Master Glossary.

David and 400 of David's men cross the Besor Brook, valley, or gorge. This valley is full of water in the rainy season but dry at other times of the year. In any case, the brook is difficult to cross.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What will you call a steep valley like this that is full of water in the rainy season and dry at other times of the year? If you have already translated this kind of valley or gorge in another book of the Bible, use the same word here that you used there. Pause this audio here.

David's men find an Egyptian man in a field. The men bring this man to David and give the man a piece of fig cake and two cakes of raisins. This strengthens the man, as the man had not eaten or drunk anything for three days.

Stop here and, as a group, look at pictures of figs and raisins, fig cakes and raisin cakes. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for fig cake and raisin cake. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David finds out that the young Egyptian is a **servant**, or slave, to an Amalekite **master**.

Use the same word or phrase for servant and master as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant and master, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Egyptian slave asks David to swear, or promise with an **oath**, that David will not kill the slave or give him back to his master. Although the storyteller does not use the word oath, you should talk about this strong promise in a similar way to how you have talked about people giving oaths before. See the Master Glossary for more information about oaths.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 30:1–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (910 KB)
- Setting the Stage (7.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 30:16–31

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 30:16–31 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:16–31 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:16–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, David and his men return to Ziklag and find the Amalekites have burned their city and taken the men's families. David and his men are very sad, but the men blame David. After Yahweh promises that David will catch the raiders, David and his men chase the Amalekites. David and his men meet a young Egyptian slave whose Amalekite master left the Egyptian behind. The Egyptian agrees to lead David to the raiders.

The young Egyptian leads David and David's men to the Amalekites. David sees that the Amalekites are not a strong, organized army. The Amalekites are spread out all over the land in a disorganised way. The Amalekites

cannot protect themselves and are unable to move or escape quickly. The Amalekites have likely been there for days, and celebrated with food, strong drinks, and dancing. The Amalekites are having a big festival because they stole a large amount from the Philistines and from the descendants of Judah. The Amalekites may even be holding a ceremony to thank their god for their success during the raid.

David and his men attack the Amalekites. The men fight from twilight until the evening of the next day. “Twilight” is either the dim light before sunrise or after sunset, but most scholars believe that here twilight refers to the time just before sunrise. For the Israelites, a new day began at sunset, so “evening of the next day” refers to the evening after the battle. This means the Israelites likely fight throughout the daylight hours of that day and finish in the evening after sunset. David’s army defeats the Amalekites, and no man escapes except 400 young men. These men manage to escape on camels, which are large desert animals with a hump on their backs. David and his men either kill or capture the rest of the Amalekite raiders.

Stop here and look at a picture of a camel as a group. Pause this audio here.

David gets back everyone and everything the Amalekites took, including David’s two wives. Nothing is missing. The Amalekites did not kill or take anyone away. David and his men save everyone, both small and great, as well as the sons and daughters of David’s men. David also gets back all the things the Amalekites stole. David brings everything back. David’s mission is a complete success.

David also takes back all the flocks and herds from the Amalekites. The Amalekites likely stole these animals from the Kerethites and Philistines. Flocks include groups of smaller animals like sheep and goats, while herds include groups of larger animals like oxen and cattle. These animals are different from the ones David’s men already owned and recovered. David’s men drive the flocks and herds in front of their own cattle and declare that these animals now belong to David. David’s men want to thank and reward David for leading the men to victory.

Stop here and look at a picture of a flock of sheep as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a flock of goats as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of a herd of oxen and cattle as a group. Pause this audio here.

On the way back to Ziklag, David stops at Besor Brook. David is traveling with his men, the men’s families, their cattle, and the plunder. At Besor Brook, David meets the 200 men David had left behind because those men were too weak and tired to march to the battle. The men go out to welcome David and the people with David. As David gets closer to the 200 men, David greets the men warmly. David speaks to the men in a friendly way and shows David is not angry with the men.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture say hello to each other? Share some formal and informal ways to greet someone. Also, explain how you would greet someone if you were happy with that person and how you would greet someone if you were not happy with them. Pause this audio here.

Some of the 400 men who fought the Amalekites with David are selfish troublemakers. These men complain to David and the others who went to battle. The men say the 200 men who stayed behind at Besor Brook did not help fight, so the troublemakers do not want to share the valuable plunder with those men. The plunder includes animals, and probably items like clothing, jewels, and precious metals. The troublemakers say the men at Besor Brook should only get their wives and children back and leave. The troublemakers want the 200 men to go away while the fighters divide the plunder and celebrate the victory.

But David answers the troublemakers, “No, you will not do that, my brothers, with what Yahweh has given us.” David says it would be wrong to act selfishly when Yahweh has been so generous to the men. David calls the troublemakers “brothers” to show that even though David disagrees, David is still their friend and on their side. David insists the men must include the 200 men when they divide the plunder. David reminds the troublemakers that it was Yahweh who gave David and the men the victory over the Amalekites, and gave the plunder and the men’s families back. David wants his men to be compassionate and generous, just as Yahweh has been compassionate and generous to the men.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Make up a story about someone who wants to behave in a way that is selfish and not honourable to others. What will you say to that person if you are someone in authority? What will you say to that person if you are just that person's friend? Pause this audio here.

David asks the troublemakers a question that does not require an answer: "Who would listen to you in this matter?" David makes a strong point that no one would agree with the men's idea because the idea is wrong. David tells the men that no good person would support the men's idea and to stop talking this way. Then, David makes a new rule for dividing plunder. David compares the men who fought with those who stayed behind to guard supplies. Since the 200 men at Besor Brook helped with the victory because they guarded the supplies, David says everyone will get the same share. The fighters will not get more, and the guards of supplies will not get less. This rule will apply in the future, so guards of supplies will always get a share. Each man's portion will be equal, even if the items are different, like cattle, valuables, clothing, and metals.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about times in life when someone shares things, like goods or rewards, equally among people who do different jobs. Can you think of examples where people work as a team, but not everyone does the same task? Should everyone get the same amount, or should some people get more? Why? Pause this audio here.

The writer of 1 Samuel now shares some background information. David made what he had just told his men into a general law or rule for everyone. This rule began after David's victory over the Amalekites and continued until the time the storyteller told this story.

Then David, his men, and their families return to Ziklag, the city the Philistines gave to David. David takes some of the plunder and sends it as gifts to the elders of the tribe of Judah. These elders were friendly with David, and David wants to show the elders kindness and strengthen their friendship. David probably visited these elders in the past and wants to thank them. David possibly knows that one day, David will need these elders as allies. David only sends the gifts to a specific group of people, who are important elders who are also David's friends. David likely gives the gifts to David's men to deliver, along with a message that says, "Look! Here is a gift for you from the plunder we took from the enemies of Yahweh." David calls the Amalekites the enemies of Yahweh because the Amalekites were enemies of the Israelites, who were God's people. David believes that anyone who fights against Yahweh's people is also an enemy of Yahweh.

Now David distributes the plunder among a number of large and small cities near Hebron. David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the cities of Bethel, Ramoth in the Negev, and Jattir. The Bethel here is a different Bethel from the one in the territory of the tribe of Benjamin. This Bethel is near the cities of Hormah and Ziklag. The city Ramoth was in the Negev, which was a wilderness in the south. Both Bethel and Ramoth of the Negev are in the territory of the tribe of Simeon, whose land originally belonged to the tribe of Judah. Jattir was a city for the priests of Israel, and the tribe of Levi lived here.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the cities of Aroer, Siphmoth, and Eshtemoa. Eshtemoa was a city for the priests of Israel, and the tribe of Levi lived here.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the city of Rakal, and cities belonging to the Jerahmeelite clan and the cities belonging to the Kenite clan. The elders of Racal and the Jerahmeelites were Israelites, but the Kenite elders were not. However, since some Kenites lived among the Israelites, the Kenites may have been allies of the Israelites.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the cities of Hormah, Bor Ashan, and Athak. Bor Ashan means "Well of Ashan." Hormah and Bor Ashan were in the territory of the tribe of Simeon, whose land originally belonged to the tribe of Judah.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the city of Hebron, and to the elders in all the other places David and David's men visited. Hebron was a very important city. Abraham built an altar to Yahweh in Hebron. Hebron was a city of refuge and a city for the priests of Israel, and the tribe of Levi lived there. Hebron was 30 kilometres southeast of Jerusalem.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map and locate the cities near Hebron where David sent gifts of the plunder. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 30:16–31

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about situations when the leaders of your people group sent gifts to the neighbouring countries. Why did your leaders send gifts? What kind of gifts were there?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:16–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has ten scenes.

In the first scene: The young Egyptian takes David and his men down to where the Amalekites are. The Amalekites are celebrating because the Amalekites stole a large amount of goods from the Philistines' land and from the descendants of Judah.

In the second scene: David and his men attack the Amalekites. David's army defeats the Amalekites, with no man escaping except 400 young men who rode on camels to escape.

In the third scene: David gets back everyone and everything the Amalekites took, including David's two wives. David also gets back all the things the Amalekites stole and takes as plunder all the flocks and herds that the Amalekites likely stole from others earlier.

In the fourth scene: On the way back to Ziklag, David stops at Besor Brook and meets the 200 men he had left behind. The men go out to welcome David and the people with David, and David greets the men warmly.

In the fifth scene: Some fighters who went to battle with David are selfish troublemakers. These men complain to David and say that the men who stayed behind should not get any plunder because they did not help fight the Amalekites. The troublemakers say those men should only get their wives and children back and then leave.

In the sixth scene: David says it would be wrong to act selfishly when Yahweh has been so generous to all the men, and David insists they must share plunder with the 200 men at Besor Brook.

In the seventh scene: David makes a strong point that what the troublemakers are suggesting is wrong. David makes a new general rule about dividing the plunder. Those who stay with the supplies will get the same share of the plunder as those who fight in the battle.

In the eighth scene: The writer of 1 Samuel now shares some background information. David made what David had just told his men into a general law or rule for everyone. This rule began after David's victory over the Amalekites and stayed in place until the time of the writing of this story.

In the ninth scene: David, David's men, and their families all return to Ziklag. David takes some of the plunder and sends it as gifts to the elders of the tribe of Judah, but only to those who were also David's friends.

In the tenth scene: The passage lists the large and small cities near Hebron to which David sends the plunder as gifts.

The characters in this passage are:

- The young Egyptian
- David
- The Amalekites
- David's men—the story does not mention the men at this point, but we know they are with David
- Families of David and David's men, including David's two wives
- Two hundred of David's men who stayed at Besor Brook
- The troublemakers—some of David's men who went to battle against the Amalekites
- The rest of David's men who went to battle against the Amalekites
- And the elders of cities in Judah who were also David's friends

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

After David talks with the young Egyptian, the Egyptian leads David and David's men down to where the Amalekites are. The storyteller now uses a phrase that shows that David and his men finally see the men they have been searching for. The storyteller says, "Look! There they are." The men are spread out all over the land in a disorganized way. The Amalekites have probably been there for a few days and have set up camp. The Amalekites are celebrating, eating good food, drinking strong drinks, and dancing together. The Amalekites are having a big festival because they stole a large amount of goods from the Philistines' land and from the people of Judah.

David and his men attack the Amalekites. We do not know if David and his men attack right away or if the men wait in hiding to attack later. When David and his men do attack, the men rush in and defeat the Amalekites. The men fight from twilight until the evening of the next day. "Twilight" in the original language can mean either the dim light before sunrise or after sunset, but most scholars believe that here twilight refers to the time just before sunrise. Therefore, the men likely fight throughout the daylight hours of that day and finish the battle after sunset, since for the Israelites a new day began at sunset. David's army defeats the Amalekites, and no man escapes except 400 young men who manage to get away on camels. David and his men either kill or capture the rest of the Amalekite raiders.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Some words can mean more than one thing, like the word "twilight" in this story. Talk about words in your language that have more than one meaning. How do you make sure people understand what you mean when you use those words? Pause this audio here.

David, with the help of David's men, recovers everything the Amalekites have taken, including David's two wives. The word "everything" refers to both people and things. Nothing is missing. David and his men save everyone, both small and great, as well as the sons and daughters of the men. "Small and great" likely means people of all ages and importance. David also gets back all the things the Amalekites stole. David brings everything back. David's mission is a complete success.

Now the storyteller introduces a different group of things that David and his men take back from the Amalekites. The passage mentions David alone to focus on what David achieves as a leader, but we know David's men are with David. David also takes back all the flocks and herds that the Amalekites had stolen earlier from the Kerethites and Philistines. David now keeps those flocks and herds for David's own people. David's men drive the flocks and herds that David takes as plunder in front of the other livestock or cattle that belonged to David and his men. David's men place the flocks and herds at the front, leading their cattle behind them. The men say that the flocks and herds now belong to David. The men want to thank and reward David for leading the men to victory.

On the way back to Ziklag, David returns the way he came and stops at Besor Brook.

David is traveling with his men, their families, their cattle, and the plunder. At Besor Brook, David meets the 200 men he had left behind because they were too weak and tired to march to the battle. The 200 men see David, his men, and the women and children coming, and they go out to welcome David and the people with David. As David gets closer to the 200 men, David greets the men warmly.

This next part is very different from what just happened. David greets the 200 men at Besor Brook in a friendly way, but some evil men, or selfish troublemakers from among those who went to battle, now act unkindly toward these men. The word "evil" here does not mean these men are dangerous criminals or always bad, but that these men are acting selfishly and without kindness. These men are causing problems. These men insist that the 200 men do not deserve any of the plunder because they did not join the raid. The troublemakers say the 200 men can only take their wives and children and then leave.

But David answers the troublemakers, "No, you will not do that, my brothers, with what Yahweh has given us." David says it would be wrong to act selfishly when Yahweh has been so generous to all the men. David calls the troublemakers "brothers" to show that even though David disagrees, David is still their friend and on their side. David insists they must include the 200 men and not divide the plunder only among the 400 fighters. David reminds the troublemakers that it was Yahweh who gave David and the men the plunder and their families back. It was Yahweh who delivered into the fighters' hand, or handed over to them, the band of Amalekite raiders.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say in your language when you want to show you are supporting someone, or want to show kindness? What words do you use when you are upset with someone or want to show

you do not agree with them? Talk about how the words you choose can show how you feel about a person. How do you decide which words to use?

Pause this audio here.

David asks the troublemakers a question that does not need an answer: "Who would listen to you in this matter?" David makes a strong point that no one would agree to do what the troublemakers are suggesting because it is wrong. The word "listen" here means both hearing what the troublemakers are saying and agreeing to do it. Now David makes a new rule about dividing the plunder. David says, "The share of the man who stayed with the supplies is to be the same as that of him who went down to the battle." This is a general rule or principle that will apply to all similar situations. It does not refer to one man. All the soldiers will get fair and equal portions of the plunder.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you say when you want everyone to know that a rule is not just for one time but for every time something similar happens? Can you think of examples of when someone made a general rule, like at school, at home, or in your community? How did the person explain that the rule was for more than just one time? Pause this audio here.

David is not speaking anymore. The storyteller of 1 Samuel now shares some background information. David made what David had just told his men into a general law or rule for everyone. This rule began after David's victory over the Amalekites and stayed in place until the storyteller wrote this story.

The story now shows that this part happens later. David, David's men, and their families all return to Ziklag. David is not the only one to return, but since David is the leader, the story mentions David by name. When they arrive, David takes some of the plunder and sends it as gifts to the elders of the tribe of Judah, but only to those who are also David's friends. David likely gives the gifts to his men to deliver, along with a message, saying, "Look! Here is a gift for you from the plunder we took from the enemies of Yahweh." The message draws attention to the gifts David is sending to each elder. The word that many people translate as "gift" in the original language means blessing. David distributes the plunder among a number of large and small cities near Hebron. David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the cities of Bethel, Ramoth in the Negev, and Jattir.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the cities of Aroer, Siphmoth, and Eshtemoa.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the city of Rakal, and cities belonging to the Jerahmeelite clan and cities belonging to the Kenite clan.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the cities of Hormah, Bor Ashan, and Athak.

David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the city of Hebron, and elders in all the other places David and David's men visited.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map and locate the cities near Hebron where David sent gifts of the plunder. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:16–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has ten scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The young Egyptian
- David
- The Amalekites
- David's men—the story does not mention the men at this point, but we know they are with David

- Families of David and David's men, including David's two wives
- Two hundred of David's men who stayed at Besor Brook
- The troublemakers—some of David's men who went to battle against the Amalekites
- The rest of David's men who went to battle against the Amalekites
- And the elders of cities in Judah who were also David's friends

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The young Egyptian takes David and David's men down to where the Amalekites are. David sees that the Amalekites are spread out all over the land and are celebrating—eating good food, drinking strong drinks, and dancing together. The Amalekites are having a big festival because they stole a huge amount of goods from the Philistines' land and from the descendants of Judah. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel grateful that Yahweh helped us to find the Amalekites; or
- We will now be able to rescue our wives and children! or
- I expect to conquer the Amalekites because Yahweh told us we will succeed.

Continue the drama. David and his men attack the Amalekites. The men fight from twilight throughout the daylight hours of that day. David's army defeats the Amalekites, with no man escaping except 400 young men who ride away on camels to escape.

David gets back everyone and everything the Amalekites took, including David's two wives. David also gets back all the things the Amalekites stole. David also takes as plunder all the flocks and herds that the Amalekites stole from others earlier. David's men drive the flocks and herds in front of the other livestock that belonged to David and his men. The men say that the flocks and herds now belong to David. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are so happy! We have our wives and children back! or
- We recovered everything! or
- David is a good and brave leader.

Continue the drama. On the way back to Ziklag, David stops at Besor Brook and meets the 200 men he had left behind because they were too weak and tired to march to the battle. The men go out to welcome David and the people with David. As David gets closer to the 200 men, David greets the men warmly.

Some of the men who went to battle with David are selfish troublemakers. These men complain to David and say that the 200 men who stayed behind at Besor Brook should not get any plunder because they did not help fight the Amalekites. The troublemakers say the men at Besor should only get their wives and children back and then leave. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the troublemakers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are bitter. We have worked hard and stayed loyal to David. We feel like we should get more than the weak men who stayed behind; or
- We will not be happy if the lazy men who did not go to battle share in our spoils; or
- Surely David and the other fighters will agree with us. The men from Besor Brook should just take their wives and children and go.

Continue the drama. David replies to the troublemakers and says it would be wrong to act selfishly when Yahweh has been so generous to the men. David insists they must include the 200 men and not divide the loot only among the 400 fighters. David reminds the troublemakers that it was Yahweh who gave David and the men the plunder and their families back, and the victory over the Amalekites. David makes a strong point that no one would agree to do what the troublemakers are suggesting because it is wrong. Now David makes a new rule about dividing the plunder. The share of those who stay with the supplies is to be the same as those who go down to the battle. This is a general rule or principle that will apply to all similar situations. All the soldiers will get fair and equal portions of the plunder. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the 200 men who stayed at Besor Brook, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are relieved. David decided that we will share in the plunder the fighters brought from the Amalekites; or
- We are happy the troublemakers did not get their way.

Continue the drama. The storyteller of 1 Samuel now shares some background information. David made what he had just told his men into a general law or rule for everyone. This rule began after David's victory over the Amalekites and stayed in place until the time the storyteller told this story.

David, David's men, and their families all return to Ziklag. David takes some of the plunder and sends it as gifts to the elders of the tribe of Judah, but only to those who were also David's friends. David sends the gifts with a message, saying, "Look! Here is a blessing for you from the plunder we took from the enemies of Yahweh." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing David, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel glad that we have all this plunder. I will send it as gifts to the elders who are my friends in some of the cities of the tribe of Judah; or
- The Amalekites robbed those people, too; or
- I will need the elders to be my allies when I am king of Israel. The gifts will help the elders remember me.

Continue the drama. David distributes the plunder among a number of large and small cities near Hebron. David sends some of the plunder to the elders or leaders who live in the cities of Bethel, Ramoth in the Negev, and Jattir; the cities of Aroer, Siphmoth, and Eshtemoam; the city of Rakal, and cities belonging to the Jerahmeelite clan and the cities belonging to the Kenite clan; and the cities of Hormah, Bor Ashan, and Athak. David sends some of the plunder to the elders who live in the city of Hebron and elders in all the other places David and his men visited.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 30:16–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

David's army defeats the Amalekites. No man escapes except 400 young men who ride away on **camels** to escape. Use the same word or phrase for camel that you have used in previous passages.

After defeating the Amalekites, David also takes back all the **flocks** and herds from the Amalekites. Flocks include groups of smaller animals like sheep and goats, while herds include groups of larger animals like oxen and cattle. Use the same word or phrase for flocks that you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **herds**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

David's men drive the flocks and herds that David takes as plunder in front of the other **livestock** or cattle that belonged to David and his men. Use the same word or phrase for livestock that you have used in previous passages.

The **evil** men, or selfish troublemakers, complain to David and the others who went to battle. The troublemakers say the 200 men who stayed behind at Besor Brook did not help fight, so the troublemakers do not want to share the valuable **plunder** with those men. Use the same words or phrases for evil and plunder that you have used in previous passages. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary.

1 Samuel 30:16–31

David replies to the troublemakers and says it would be wrong to act selfishly when **Yahweh** has been so generous to them. Yahweh is God's personal name, and the storyteller uses this name throughout this passage. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

David reminds the troublemakers that it was Yahweh who gave David and the men the plunder and their families back. It was Yahweh who delivered into their hand, or handed over to them, the **band** of Amalekite **raiders**. Use the same word or phrase for band of raiders, band, or raiding party that you have used in previous passages. Use the same word or phrase for "delivered into their hand" that you have used in previous passages.

David makes a rule that will continue for a long time in **Israel**. Use the same word for Israel that you have used previously, and remember that Israel is in the Master Glossary.

The storyteller calls this rule a statute and an ordinance. Both of these terms refer to special rules about how to live well together in the Israelite community. These words have similar meanings to each other, and you may choose to use just one term if you only have one term that would refer to a rule like this.

Stop here and discuss as a group what you will call this **statute** and **ordinance**. See the Master Glossary for statute and ordinance. Pause this audio here.

David likely gives the gifts to his men to deliver to several small and large **cities**, along with a message that says, "Look! Here is a gift for you from the plunder we took from the enemies of Yahweh." Use the same word for city that you have used in previous passages. Cities were usually larger settlements that people built a wall around for protection.

The word that many people translate as **gift** or present in the original language means **blessing**. You may call this a gift if you have a word or phrase for a good gift in your language. Or you may use the term for blessing, which also can mean a good gift. For more information on blessing, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 30:16–31

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (917 KB)

- Setting the Stage (7.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

1 Samuel 31:1–13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 Samuel 31:1–13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 31:1–13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 31:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, David and David's men defeated the Amalekites and recovered everything the Amalekites stole from Ziklag. On the way back, some selfish men refused to share the plunder with those who stayed at brook Besor. David created a rule that everyone would receive an equal share, whether they fought or guarded the supplies. When David and his men returned to Ziklag, David sent plunder gifts to those elders of Judah near Hebron who were David's friends.

The story now goes back to when the Philistine army set up camp in Shunem and Saul gathered the Israelite army at Mount Gilboa, about 10 to 15 kilometres south of Shunem in the valley of Jezreel. This part of the story talks about the war between the Philistines and Israel, which the storyteller mentioned earlier. The storyteller had paused that battle story to tell us about David and David's men leaving the Philistine army, returning to Ziklag, and chasing the Amalekites to get back everything the Amalekites had stolen from them. The events in this story happen at the same time that David and his men are chasing the Amalekites.

Back in Jezreel, the Philistines fight against the Israelites on Mount Gilboa. The Philistines kill many Israelite soldiers, and the Israelite army starts to lose the battle. The Israelites must retreat. The Israelites, including King Saul and Saul's sons, run away quickly to save their lives. But the Philistines catch up to Saul and his sons and kill three of Saul's sons: Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malki-Shua. We know that Saul has another son, Ish-Bosheth, who survives, but we do not know if Ish-Bosheth was in the battle. The word "kill" here means to use a weapon, like a sword or spear, to strike someone and cause that person to die.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel. Locate Mount Gilboa, the place where the Israelites and the Philistines fought the battle. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines fight fiercely against Saul. After killing Saul's sons, the Philistines get close to where Saul is. The Philistines attack hard, fighting the men who are still with Saul, including Saul's bodyguard. Then the arrows from the archers hit Saul. The arrows wound Saul very badly. Saul is in severe pain from the arrows, and Saul cannot move easily. Saul's wounds are so bad that Saul's life is in danger, and Saul has no chance of escape.

Stop here and look as a group at a picture of an archer shooting arrows with a bow. Pause this audio here.

1 Samuel 31:1–13

Then Saul asks Saul's armor-bearer to pull out the armor-bearer's sword and kill Saul by stabbing him. An armor-bearer is a young man who helps an older soldier or leader by carrying extra weapons and equipment. Saul wants his armor-bearer to kill Saul because Saul is afraid the Philistines will kill Saul slowly and painfully. Saul thinks it would be more shameful and painful if the Philistines killed Saul. Saul also worries the Philistines will mock Saul and hurt him for their own entertainment. Saul calls the Philistines "uncircumcised fellows," a negative term the Israelites used. The Israelites circumcised their sons as a sign of the Israelites' special agreement with God, and the Israelites looked down on uncircumcised men. The armor-bearer refuses to kill Saul because the armor-bearer is afraid to harm the king of Israel, whom God appointed. Since Saul's armor-bearer will not kill Saul, Saul pulls out his own sword and kills himself by falling on its point.

When the man who carried Saul's armour sees that Saul is dead—either by watching Saul kill himself or seeing Saul's dead body—the armor-bearer throws himself on the point of his own sword and kills himself. The armour-bearer dies with Saul. This means the armor-bearer dies at about the same time, in the same place, and in the same way as Saul.

In that way, Saul, three of Saul's sons, the young man who carried Saul's armour, and all of Saul's men die on that same day. "All of Saul's men" may refer to the men closest to Saul who surround Saul. It may also refer to Saul's household or to Saul's most loyal leaders who were protecting Saul. Saul and these people all died in the same battle on the same day.

The storyteller pauses the story about the battle between Israel and the Philistines to explain what happened after the Philistines won. The Israelite people who lived on the other side of the Jezreel Valley, and those who lived beyond the Jordan River, realised that the Israelite army had run away and that Saul and three of Saul's sons had died. The other side of the Jezreel Valley means the north side, which is also called the Plain of Jezreel. The "area beyond the Jordan" could mean either the east side of the Jordan River or the cities near the river on the west side.

When the Israelites in these areas saw or became aware of what had happened, they ran away from their cities quickly to live somewhere else. The Israelites did not destroy their homes or buildings, but just abandoned them. Then the Philistine soldiers and their families moved into the empty cities and lived there, and took control of the area.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of Israel and locate the area from where the Israelites ran away and which the Philistines took over. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller now goes back to the story of the battle. The day after the people fought, the Philistine soldiers go back to Mount Gilboa to take valuable things from the dead Israelite soldiers. The Philistines "strip the slain," which means the Philistines take weapons and armour from the Israelite soldiers they killed with swords. While doing this, the Philistines find Saul and Saul's three sons lying dead.

The Philistine soldiers cut off Saul's head and take off Saul's armour, including Saul's weapons. So the Philistines remove Saul's military clothes and the weapons Saul carried, like Saul's sword, shield, and spear. After this, the Philistines send men all over the land of Philistia to share the good news that Saul is dead and that the Philistines won the battle. These men possibly carry Saul's weapons and armour as proof of victory. The Philistine messengers announce the good news in the temples, which are houses where Philistines worship their idols. An idol is an object that people make in order to worship a god. The Philistine men also share the news with the Philistine people, possibly in public places like markets or smaller worship areas. The news spreads quickly from person to person and from town to town throughout the land of Philistia.

Stop here and look as a group at pictures of the kinds of armour and weapons that Saul may have had. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how people in your community in the past shared news that affected the whole nation, whether good or bad news. Then, discuss how people share important news now. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines put Saul's armour and weapons in the temple of their goddess that people called Ashtoreth. The temple of the Ashtoreths was a building where people worshipped the Ashtoreth idols, or representations of the goddess Ashtoreth. Ashtoreth was the Philistines' most important goddess, and Ashtoreth was the goddess of love and war. The Philistines place Saul's armor and weapons in the temple to try to show their goddess' power.

The Philistines also hang Saul's dead body on the outer wall of one of their cities called Beth Shan, but we do not know how the Philistines hang the body. The Philistines hang Saul's body to insult both Saul and the Israelites. In those times, it was very important to bury a person's body with respect. When someone did not have a proper burial, people saw it as very shameful. Beth Shan was about 11 miles from Mount Gilboa, where people fought the battle. Beth Shan was an important city where roads from the Jordan Valley and the Jezreel Valley came together. The city had a large stone wall for protection.

Stop here and, as a group, talk about burial customs in your people group. What would people consider to be a respectful burial? What practices would people consider as shameful? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of Israel and locate the city of Beth Shan. Pause this audio here.

But when the people in the city of Jabesh Gilead hear the news about how the Philistines insulted Saul's dead body, all the brave warriors from Jabesh Gilead decide to leave their city and travel all night to the city of Beth Shan. Jabesh is in the region of Gilead, on the east side of the Jordan River, about 32 kilometers from Beth Shan. The people of Jabesh are Israelites. The people feel thankful to Saul because Saul saved them from the Ammonites in the past. The brave warriors take Saul's dead body and the bodies of Saul's sons down from the wall of Beth Shan. The warriors carry the bodies back to Jabesh and burn the bodies. Burning bodies was not something the Israelites usually did, and no one knows why the people burned the bodies this time.

Afterwards, the warriors gather the burned bones and bury them under a tamarisk tree in Jabesh. A tamarisk tree is tall, growing up to 18 meters, with needle-like leaves and small pink or white flowers. This tree was likely famous in Jabesh. The people bury the bones there to honour Saul and Saul's sons. Then the people of Jabesh fast, or stop eating, for seven days. Fasting was a traditional way to mourn someone's death. The people fast to honour Saul and show their sadness because Saul had died.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of Israel and locate the city of Jabesh in Gilead. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a tamarisk tree. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are the burial customs in your people group? What do people do to honour the dead person? Talk about the burial of a special person in your people group who people honoured after their death. What did the person do to earn the honour? How did people honour that person?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 31:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: Back in Jezreel, the Philistines fight the Israelites on Mount Gilboa and kill many Israelite soldiers. The Israelites, including King Saul and three of Saul's sons, run away, but the Philistines catch up to the men and kill them.

In the second scene: The Philistines fight fiercely against Saul and get close to where Saul is. Then the archers' arrows hit Saul and wound Saul very badly. Saul asks his armor-bearer to kill Saul, but the armor-bearer refuses because the armor-bearer is scared. Saul kills himself by falling on the point of Saul's sword. When the armor-bearer sees this, Saul's armor-bearer throws himself on his own sword and kills himself.

In the third scene: Now, the storyteller summarises what happened that day. Saul, three of Saul's sons, and Saul's armor-bearer all die on the same day, along with all of Saul's soldiers who do not run away or the men closest to Saul who are surrounding Saul.

In the fourth scene: The storyteller pauses the story about the battle between Israel and the Philistines to tell what happens after the Philistines won. The Israelite people who lived on the other side of the Jezreel Valley, and those who lived beyond the Jordan River, realised that the Israelite army had run away and that Saul and three

of Saul's sons died. The Israelites flee or run away from their cities to live somewhere else. Then the Philistine soldiers and their families come into the empty cities and live there.

In the fifth scene: The storyteller now returns to the story of the battle. The day after people fought, the Philistine soldiers go back to Mount Gilboa to take valuable things like weapons and armour from the dead Israelite soldiers. The Philistines find Saul and Saul's three sons lying dead, and they cut off Saul's head and remove Saul's military clothes and the weapons he carried. The Philistines send men all over the land of Philistia to share the good news that Saul is dead and that the Philistines won the battle.

In the sixth scene: The Philistines put Saul's armour and weapons in the temple of their goddess, Ashtoreth, and the Philistines hang Saul's dead body on the outside wall of one of their cities called Beth Shan. The Israelites from the city of Jabesh Gilead hear how the Philistines insult Saul's dead body, so the Israelites come and take the dead bodies of Saul and Saul's sons down from the wall of Beth Shan, carry the bodies back to Jabesh Gilead, and burn the bodies. The Israelites bury the burned bones under a tamarisk tree in Jabesh. Then the people of Jabesh fast, or stop eating, for seven days.

The characters in this passage are:

- Philistine army
- Israelite army
- King Saul
- Three of Saul's sons: Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malchi Shua
- Philistine archers
- Saul's armor-bearer
- Saul's men who died with Saul
- Israelites, or Israelite people who lived on the other side of the Jezreel Valley and beyond the Jordan River, who ran away from their homes
- Israelite soldiers who ran away from the Philistines
- Philistine soldiers who moved into the homes that the Israelites had run away from
- Philistines, or Philistine people
- Israelite people who lived in the city of Jabesh in the region of Gilead
- And brave Israelite warriors from the city of Jabesh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The storyteller starts with language that introduces a new event, but shows that this story continues from where the storyteller paused it before. The story goes back to when the Philistine army set up camp in Shunem and Saul gathered the Israelite army at Mount Gilboa, about 10 to 15 kilometres south of Shunem in the valley of Jezreel. The events take place at the same time that David and David's men are chasing the Amalekites.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will start this passage to show that this is a new event, but at the same time, that this story continues from where the storyteller paused before. Pause this audio here.

Back in Jezreel, the Philistines fight the Israelites on Mount Gilboa. The Philistines kill many Israelite soldiers. The Israelites, including King Saul and Saul's sons, run away quickly to save their lives. But the Philistines catch up to Saul and his sons and kill three of Saul's sons: Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malki Shua. Here, the storyteller repeats the word "Philistines" several times to stress that it is the Philistines who kill the Israelites.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel. Locate Mount Gilboa, where the Israelites and the Philistines fought the battle. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are the natural ways in your language to stress that it was the Philistines who killed the Israelites? Pause this audio here.

The Philistines fight fiercely against Saul and Saul's men. The Philistines get close to where Saul is. The Philistines attack hard, fighting the men who are still with Saul, including Saul's bodyguard. Then the archers find Saul. In the original language, "archers" means men with bows. The word "find" here means that the archers' arrows find their target, Saul, and hit Saul. The arrows wound Saul very badly. Saul is in severe pain from the arrows, and Saul cannot move easily.

Then Saul asks his armor-bearer to pull out the armor-bearer's sword and kill Saul by stabbing Saul. Saul wants his armor-bearer to kill him because Saul is afraid the Philistines will kill Saul slowly and painfully. Saul also worries the Philistines will mock Saul and hurt him for their own entertainment. Saul calls the Philistines "uncircumcised fellows," a negative term the Israelites used for the Philistines. The armor-bearer is very scared and refuses to kill Saul. Since Saul's armor-bearer will not kill him, Saul pulls out his own sword and kills himself by falling on the sword's point.

Stop here and talk as a group about the negative words or nicknames that people in your community use to describe people from enemy nations or people groups. Pause this audio here.

When the man who carried Saul's armour sees that Saul is dead, the man throws himself on the point of his own sword and kills himself. The armour-bearer dies at about the same time, in the same place, and in the same way as Saul.

Now the storyteller summarises what happened that day. Saul, three of Saul's sons, and the young man who carried Saul's armour all die. These people die on the same day, along with all of Saul's men. Please note that the phrase "all of Saul's men" does not mean the Philistines kill every single Israelite soldier, but all of Saul's soldiers who do not run away or the men closest to Saul who are surrounding Saul. Saul and these people all die in the same battle on the same day.

The storyteller pauses the story about the battle between Israel and the Philistines to tell what happens after the Philistines won. The Israelite people who lived on the other side of the Jezreel Valley, and those who lived beyond the Jordan River, saw and realised that the Israelite army ran away and that Saul and three of Saul's sons died. In this case, "men of Israel" refers both to the Israelite people and the Israelite army. The other side of the Jezreel Valley means the north side, which is also called the Plain of Jezreel. The "area beyond the Jordan" could mean either the east side of the Jordan River or the cities near the river on the west side. When the Israelites in these areas realised that the Philistines had defeated Saul's army and Saul's army ran away, these Israelites ran away from their cities to live somewhere else. The idea of running away appears twice in the story because the storyteller wants to show that the Israelite army ran away quickly, and the Israelite people also ran away in a similar way. Then the Philistine soldiers and their families come into the empty cities, live there and take control of the area.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of Israel and locate the area from where the Israelites ran away and which the Philistines took over. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller now goes back to the story of the battle. The day after the people fought, the Philistine soldiers go back to Mount Gilboa to take valuable things like weapons and armour from the dead Israelite soldiers. While doing this, the Philistines find Saul and Saul's three sons lying dead.

The Philistine soldiers cut off Saul's head and take off Saul's armour. Saul's "armour" also refers to Saul's weapons. So the Philistines remove Saul's military clothes and the weapons Saul carried, like his sword, shield, and spear. After this, the Philistines send men all over the land of Philistia to share the good news that Saul is dead and that the Philistines won the battle. These men announce the good news in the temples of their idols and to the Philistine people, possibly in public places like markets or smaller worship areas.

Stop here and look as a group at pictures of the kinds of armour and weapons that Saul may have had. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words you have in your language for armour and weapons. What do soldiers in your people group wear for battle? Pause this audio here.

The Philistines put Saul's armour and weapons in the temple of their goddess, Ashtoreth, to show Ashtoreth's power. Please note that the word "armour" means "armour and weapons" as in the previous passage. The Philistines called the goddess "Astarte" in their language. The name Ashtoreth was the Hebrew version and had a negative meaning of shame. Because people had many idols of the goddess in the temple, the storyteller talks about the temple of the Ashtoreths—the many idols of Ashtoreth. The Philistines hang Saul's dead body on the outside wall of Beth Shan, one of their cities, to insult Saul and the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What are the ways you can make a name sound shameful in your language? How are you going to translate the name Ashtoreth or Astarte into your language? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel and locate the city of Beth Shan. Pause this audio here.

But when the people in the city of Jabesh Gilead hear the news about how the Philistines have insulted Saul's dead body, all the brave warriors from Jabesh Gilead leave their city and travel all night to the city of Beth Shan. Jabesh is in the region of Gilead, on the east side of the Jordan River, about 32 kilometers from Beth Shan. The brave warriors take Saul's dead body and the bodies of Saul's sons down from the wall of Beth Shan. The men carry the bodies back to Jabesh and burn the bodies. Afterward, the warriors gather the burned bones and bury the bones under a tamarisk tree in Jabesh. Then the people of Jabesh fast, or stop eating, for seven days to honour Saul and show their sadness because Saul had died.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: "Brave warriors" means "the most courageous warriors." How would you describe someone like that in your language? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The city of Jabesh is called Jabesh Gilead in this story to show that it was Jabesh in the region of Gilead. If your country has cities or towns with the same name but in different regions, how do you tell them apart? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 31:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Philistine army
- Israelite army
- King Saul
- Three of Saul's sons: Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malchi Shua
- Philistine archers
- Saul's armor-bearer
- Saul's men who died with Saul
- Israelites, or Israelite people who lived on the other side of the Jezreel Valley and beyond the Jordan River, who ran away from their homes
- Israelite soldiers who ran away from the Philistines
- Philistine soldiers who moved into the homes that the Israelites had run away from
- Philistines, or Philistine people
- Israelite people who lived in the city of Jabesh in the region of Gilead
- And brave Israelite warriors from the city of Jabesh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Back in Jezreel, the Philistines fight the Israelites on Mount Gilboa. The Philistines kill many Israelite soldiers. The Israelites, including King Saul and Saul's sons, run away quickly. The Philistines catch up to Saul and Saul's sons and kill three of Saul's sons: Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malki Shua. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are so happy that we are winning against the Israelites at last; or
- We are grateful to our goddess Astarte, who is helping us; or
- We are so happy that we killed Saul's three sons. Now we need to kill Saul.

Continue the drama. The Philistines fight fiercely against Saul, and the Philistines get close to where Saul is. Then the archers' arrows find their target, Saul, and hit Saul. The arrows wound Saul very badly. Saul asks Saul's armor-bearer to kill Saul by stabbing him. The armor-bearer is very scared and refuses to kill Saul. Saul pulls out his own sword and kills himself by falling on the sword's point. When Saul's armor-bearer sees that Saul is dead, the armor-bearer throws himself on the point of his own sword and kills himself. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Saul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am desperate. My sons are dead, and now I am badly wounded; or
- I am afraid that the Philistines will treat me badly; or
- My only hope is in death.

Ask the person playing Saul's armor-bearer, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am scared. King Saul asked me to kill him, but I am here to save Saul's life; or
- I failed at my job—King Saul killed himself; or
- My only hope is in death.

Continue the drama. Now the storyteller summarises what happened that day. Saul, three of Saul's sons, and the young man who carried Saul's armour all die. The men die on the same day, along with all of Saul's soldiers who do not run away, or the men closest to Saul who are surrounding Saul.

The narrator pauses the story about the battle between Israel and the Philistines to tell what happens after the Philistines won. The Israelite people living on the other side of the Jezreel Valley, and those living beyond the Jordan River, saw and realised that the Israelite army fled or ran away and that Saul and three of Saul's sons died. When this happened, the Israelites fled or ran away from their cities to live somewhere else. Then the Philistine soldiers and their families came into the empty cities and lived there. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites on the other side of the Jezreel Valley and those living beyond the Jordan River, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are scared because Saul's army has fled, and King Saul is dead; or
- We are in a state of panic! Who is going to protect us from the Philistines now? The Philistines will kill us," or
- We must run away as soon as we can. Yahweh will provide another place for us to live.

Continue the drama. The narrator now goes back to the story of the battle. The day after the fighting, the Philistine soldiers go back to Mount Gilboa to take valuable things like weapons and armour from the dead Israelite soldiers. The Philistines find Saul and Saul's three sons lying dead. The Philistines cut off Saul's head and remove Saul's military clothes and the weapons Saul carried. After this, the Philistines send men all over the land of Philistia to share the good news that Saul is dead and that the Philistines won the battle. These men announce the good news in the temples of their idols and to the Philistine people, possibly in public places like markets or smaller worship areas.

The Philistines put Saul's armour and weapons in the temple of the Philistines' goddess, Ashtoreth. The Philistines hang Saul's dead body on the outside wall of one of their cities called Beth Shan. When the Israelites from the city of Jabesh in the region of Gilead hear the news about how the Philistines have insulted Saul's dead body, all the brave warriors leave the city and travel all night to the city of Beth Shan. The warriors take Saul's dead body and the bodies of Saul's sons down from the wall of Beth Shan, carry the bodies back to Jabesh, and burn the bodies. The warriors gather the burned bones and bury the bones under a tamarisk tree in Jabesh. Then the

people of Jabesh fast, or stop eating, for seven days. Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of the city of Jabesh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are so sad and angry that the Philistines killed Saul and treated Saul's dead body so disrespectfully; or
- Saul was kind to us and saved us from the Ammonites. We are now going to get Saul's body and bring it back to our city and bury it in an honourable way; or
- We are so happy that we went to Beth Shan and were able to rescue the bodies of Saul and his sons. We will honour Saul and Saul's sons by burying their bones under the tamarisk tree, and we will fast for seven days.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 Samuel 31:1–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The Philistines fight against **Israel** on Mount Gilboa, and the men of Israel run away from the Philistines. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Philistines fight fiercely against Saul. Then the archers find Saul, or their arrows find their target, Saul, and hit Saul.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **archer**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look as a group at a picture of an archer shooting arrows with a bow. Pause this audio here.

Then Saul asks his **armor-bearer** to pull out the armor-bearer's sword and kill Saul by stabbing Saul, so that the uncircumcised fellows do not kill Saul slowly and painfully. The Israelites circumcised their sons as a sign of the Israelites' special agreement with God, and the Israelites looked down on uncircumcised men. Use the same words or phrases for sword, armour-bearer, and uncircumcised as you used in previous passages. For more information on circumcision, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Israelites on the other side of the Jezreel Valley and beyond the **Jordan River** also ran away. Use the same word or phrase for Jordan River as you have used previously. Jordan River is in the Master Glossary.

The Philistines send men all over the land of Philistia to share the good news that Saul is dead and that the Philistines won the battle. These men announce the good news in the houses, or **temples**, of their idols and to the Philistine people. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

An idol is an object that people make in order to worship a god. The object reminds the people about some characteristics of this god. People make an object or an image of a god and worship that object as if it were that god. God forbade the Israelites in God's commandments to ever make such an idol, or image, or to worship anything else besides God himself.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **idol**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. For more information on idol, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Afterward, the warriors gather the burned bones and bury the bones under a tamarisk tree in Jabesh.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a tamarisk tree. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **tamarisk tree**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 Samuel 31:1–13

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (920 KB)
- Setting the Stage (7.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)